CIVIL SERVICES EXAMINATION

UPSC • GENERAL STUDIES — PAPER 2

International Relations and Polity & Governance (Lecture 1 to 38)

Governance, Institutions, Health and India’s Foreign Relations

Compiled 2026

Contents

1 Policies of the Developed World and Their Impact on India . . . 23

1.1 Exam Framing: IR Paper and the Four Analytical Keywords . . . 23

1.2 Post-Cold War Transition: Unipolarity, Rules-Based Order and the Supply Chain . . . 24

1.3 The Present Era: Deglobalization and Economic Nationalism . . . 25

1.4 Technology Superiority and Technology Sovereignty . . . 26

1.5 Global Trade under Deglobalization: Climate Barriers, Critical Minerals and Coercive Diplomacy . . . 28

1.6 Restrictive Immigration Policies and the End of Free Movement of Labour . . . 29

1.7 Supply Chain Constraints and the New Trade Vocabulary . . . 30

1.8 The Effect of Developed Policies on India: US and China . . . 31

1.9 Choke Point Vulnerability and Why Deglobalization Is the Overarching Theme . . . 32

1.10 US-Led Developments: The Return of Transactional Foreign Policy . . . 33

1.11 China as India's Strategic Challenge . . . 34

1.11.1 US Outreach in South Asia . . . 35

1.12 Present Times: Competitive Multipolarity and the Position of the Great Powers . . . 36

1.13 Geopolitical, Geoeconomic and Geostrategic Developments . . . 37

1.14 Global Powers Reshaping the Order and the Parallel Systems . . . 38

1.15 The Iran War: Lessons for India and Nuclear Governance . . . 38

1.16 India's Response: Uncertainty, Shifting Alliances and Strategic Autonomy . . . 40

1.16.1 Challenges . . . 40

1.17 Global South Leadership: Opportunity and Challenge . . . 41

1.18 Challenges of Leading the Global South and of the Multilateral Order . . . 43

1.18.1 Challenges . . . 43

1.19 Geoeconomic Challenges: Trade Growth, Supply Chains and Choke Points . . . 43

1.19.1 Challenges . . . 43

1.20 Geostrategic and Security Challenges . . . 44

1.20.1 Challenges . . . 44

1.21 Way Forward: India's Diplomatic Strategy . . . 45

1.22 Official MEA Keywords for Answers . . . 48

2 Various Diplomacies in India's Foreign Policy . . . 51

2.1 Various Diplomacies: A New Framework for India's Foreign Policy . . . 51

2.2 Energy Diplomacy . . . 52

2.2.1 Definition and Core Idea . . . 52
2.2.2 Challenges . . . 53
2.2.3 Way Forward . . . 56
2.3 Integrating Energy Security with India's Foreign Policy: The 2025 Question . . . 58
2.4 Critical Mineral Diplomacy . . . 59
2.4.1 Challenges . . . 59
2.4.2 Way Forward . . . 61
2.5 Semiconductor and AI Diplomacy: The Same Framework . . . 62

3 South Asian Diplomacy and India's Neighbourhood First Policy: Nepal . . . 65
3.1 Setting the Frame: Bilateral Relations and the Primacy of Neighbourhood First . . . 65
3.2 Nepal: Location, the Madhesh Question and the Political Backdrop . . . 66
3.3 Why Nepal Matters to India: Importance in Every Dimension . . . 68
3.3.1 Geopolitical Importance . . . 68
3.3.2 Civilizational and Cultural Importance . . . 68
3.3.3 Geoeconomic Importance . . . 69
3.3.4 Connectivity . . . 69
3.3.5 Geostrategic and Security Importance . . . 70
3.4 The Recent Protests in Nepal: Causes . . . 71
3.5 Impact and Significance of the Recent Developments on India . . . 73
3.5.1 Geopolitical Impact . . . 73
3.5.2 Geoeconomic Impact . . . 73
3.5.3 Geostrategic Impact: Border Diplomacy and Security . . . 74
3.5.4 Geocultural Impact . . . 74
3.6 Post-Election Strengths and Opportunities for India . . . 76
3.7 Challenges and the Way Forward for India . . . 77
3.7.1 Challenges . . . 77
3.7.2 Way Forward . . . 77

4 Supreme Court on Child Rights, Abortion, Online Blocking and Bail . . . 79
4.1 Supreme Court and Child Welfare: Constitutional Jurisprudence . . . 79
4.2 Statutory and Legal Framework for Child Rights . . . 80
4.3 Abortion and the POCSO Overlap (MTP Act 1971) . . . 81
4.3.1 The Consensual-Adolescent Puzzle . . . 81
4.4 Historically Important Supreme Court Judgments on Child Rights . . . 82
4.5 Recent Supreme Court Judgments on Child Rights . . . 85
4.6 Recent Supreme Court Decisions Upholding Fundamental Rights . . . 86
4.7 Answer Framework: The Constitution as a Living Document . . . 88
4.7.1 Introduction . . . 88
4.7.2 Part 1: Constitutional Provisions Ensuring Social Justice . . . 88
4.7.3 Part 2: Role of the Judiciary . . . 88
4.8 Online Takedowns and Blocking versus Fundamental Rights (Article 19) . . . 89

4.8.1 Procedure under Section 69A . . . 90
4.8.2 Grounds and Scope of Blocking . . . 90
4.8.3 The Telegram Blocking . . . 91
4.8.4 Section 79(3B) and the Shreya Singhal Case . . . 91
4.8.5 Reasons for Takedown . . . 92
4.8.6 Issues Concerning Blocking or Takedown Orders . . . 92
4.8.7 Criticism of the Increasing Use of Blocking Powers . . . 93
4.8.8 Way Forward . . . 94
4.9 Bail Jurisprudence: Bail as the Rule, Jail as the Exception . . . 95
4.9.1 Framework . . . 95
4.9.2 Constitutional Basis of Bail . . . 96
4.9.3 Important Case Laws . . . 96

5 Right to Bail, Abortion Jurisprudence and the Anti-Defection Law . . . 97
5.1 Bail as the Rule, Jail as the Exception: Issues and Concerns . . . 97
5.2 Bail Rights versus Anti-Bail Legislations . . . 98
5.2.1 Way Forward . . . 100
5.3 Abortion and Reproductive Autonomy: The Core Debate . . . 100
5.4 Evolution of Abortion Law: Pre-1971 to the Present . . . 101
5.5 MTP Act: Legal Provisions by Gestational Period . . . 103
5.6 Arguments in Support of the MTP Act 1971 Framework . . . 104
5.7 Issues with the MTP Act Framework . . . 105
5.8 Way Forward on Abortion Law . . . 108
5.9 Parliament and Associated Current Affairs: Preparation Framework . . . 109
5.10 Anti-Defection Law: Resignation versus Defection . . . 110
5.11 Anti-Defection Law: Mergers and the Tenth Schedule . . . 112
5.12 Anti-Defection Law: Presiding Officer and Way Forward . . . 114
5.12.1 Way Forward . . . 114

6 Local Self-Government: Democratic Decentralization, Devolution and Functionality (GS Paper 2 Current Affairs) . . . 115
6.1 Local Self-Government: Exam Relevance and the Nature of PYQs . . . 115
6.1.1 Two Traditional Strands of Questions . . . 115
6.1.2 Sarpanchpati Syndrome — A Long-Standing, Not the Latest, Concern . . . 116
6.1.3 Second Latest Strand — Merger of Rural Local Bodies with Urban Local Bodies . . . 116
6.2 Structure of the Topic: The Legs of the Answer . . . 117
6.2.1 The Legs the Topic Will Be Written In . . . 118
6.2.2 How the Issues Are Divided: First Generation vs Second Generation . . . 118
6.2.3 Steps Taken by India — Asked in the Form of Schemes . . . 118
6.3 Way Forward: How to Write Recommendations in Polity . . . 119
6.4 Introduction: The Third Tier and the Numbers to Quote . . . 120
6.5 Constitutional Framework: What to Write on the 73rd and 74th Amendments . . . 122

6.6 Importance of Local Bodies: The Role in Good Governance . . . 124
6.6.1 1. Democratic Decentralization . . . 124
6.6.2 2. Efficiency . . . 125
6.6.3 3. Participatory Governance . . . 125
6.6.4 4. Last-Mile Delivery . . . 125
6.6.5 5. Better Identification of Beneficiaries and Better Targeting . . . 125
6.6.6 6. Promotion of Social Justice . . . 125
6.6.7 7. Promotion of Gender Justice and Women Empowerment . . . 126
6.7 Organizing the Issues: Broad Heads and Substantiation . . . 127
6.7.1 Broad Heads of the Issues . . . 128
6.7.2 An Example of a ULB-Specific Concern . . . 128
6.7.3 Substantiation = Data Plus Data Sources . . . 129
6.8 Issues Related to Elections: Delay, Delimitation, Formation of Councils and Defection . . . 129
6.8.1 Delay in Elections . . . 129
6.8.2 The CAG 2024 Audit and the Worst Delay . . . 130
6.8.3 Delimitation-Related Concerns . . . 130
6.8.4 Delay in the Formation of Councils . . . 132
6.8.5 Defection and Floor-Shifting at the Third Tier . . . 133
6.9 F-Cube: The Problem of Functions (Devolution) . . . 134
6.9.1 What Fully Devolved Means . . . 135
6.9.2 The Challenge . . . 135
6.9.3 Specific Functions or Subjects . . . 135
6.9.4 Devolution Case Studies . . . 136
6.10 The Devolution Index: Parameters and Rankings . . . 137

7 Local Self-Government: Functions, Functionaries and Funds — Devolution Problems and the Way Forward . . . 139
7.1 Devolution of Functions: Direct Cash Transfers and the Shrinking Role of the Gram Sabha . . . 139
7.2 The Office of the Mayor: Structural Constraints . . . 140
7.3 Parallel Administrative Agencies and the Erosion of Local Bodies . . . 141
7.4 No Activity Mapping: Why Merely Devolving Subjects Is Not Enough . . . 143
7.5 Devolution Without Officials and Revenue: Scheme Implementers, Not Formulators . . . 144
7.6 Functionaries: Staffing and District Control . . . 146
7.7 Functionaries: Training, Capacity and Financial Dependence . . . 148
7.8 Funds: Own Source Revenue and the Property Tax Problem . . . 149
7.9 Funds: Grants, Intergovernmental Transfers and State Finance Commissions . . . 154
7.9.1 Delay in the Constitution of State Finance Commissions . . . 155
7.9.2 Why the State Finance Commissions Fail . . . 155
7.10 Other Concerns Limiting the Functionality of RLBs and ULBs . . . 158
7.11 PRI-Specific Concerns . . . 159
7.11.1 Gram Sabha: Size and Timeliness . . . 159

7.11.2 Meetings Held in Secrecy . . . 160
7.11.3 Societal Constraints . . . 160
7.11.4 Digital Constraints . . . 160
7.11.5 Declining Importance of the PRIs . . . 161
7.12 Urban-Specific Challenges of ULBs . . . 161
7.13 Way Forward . . . 163
7.13.1 For Elections . . . 163
7.13.2 For Functions . . . 163
7.13.3 For Functionaries . . . 164
7.13.4 For Funds . . . 164
7.13.5 For the Working of Local Bodies . . . 165

8 GS Paper 2 Current Affairs: Local Self-Government and Malnutrition . . . 167
8.1 Exam Trends and PYQ Insights . . . 167
8.2 Local Self-Government: Funds, Functions, Functionaries and Functionality . . . 168
8.2.1 The Classic Problem: Funds, Functions and Functionaries . . . 168
8.2.2 Questioning Functionality: Is the Third Tier Performing? . . . 168
8.2.3 Way Forward . . . 169
8.3 Steps Taken by the Government of India to Strengthen Local Self-Government . . . 169
8.3.1 Constitutional and Legal Steps . . . 169
8.3.2 The Central Government's Role in Creating the Third Tier . . . 170
8.3.3 Fiscal Devolution and the Finance Commission . . . 170
8.3.4 Rashtriya Gram Swaraj Abhiyan: Capacity Building . . . 171
8.3.5 Leadership and Management Programmes, and Women in PRIs . . . 172
8.3.6 A Separate Ministry, and Urban Governance . . . 173
8.3.7 Development of Indexes . . . 174
8.3.8 Youth Unemployment, NEET and the Human Capital Chain . . . 176
8.3.9 Own Source Revenue Push and the Samarth App . . . 176
8.3.10 SVAMITVA: Property Records and Local Revenue . . . 177
8.3.11 Digital Panchayats: e-Gram Swaraj and PFMS . . . 177
8.3.12 Other Recent Steps: Bhashini and Sabha Saar . . . 178
8.3.13 Accountability Tools and the Overall Picture . . . 179
8.4 Answer-Writing Exercise: Role of Local Bodies and Merging RLBs with ULBs . . . 180
8.4.1 Introduction . . . 180
8.4.2 Role of Local Bodies in Good Governance . . . 180
8.4.3 Pros of Merging RLBs with ULBs . . . 181
8.4.4 Cons of Merging RLBs with ULBs . . . 182
8.4.5 Way Forward . . . 183
8.5 Malnutrition: Concept, Framework and Answer Structure . . . 184
8.5.1 The Human Capital Chain and the Demographic Dividend . . . 184
8.5.2 Framework of Malnutrition . . . 184
8.5.3 Why Malnutrition Is a Different Ball Game . . . 185
8.5.4 Structure for Answering Malnutrition . . . 186

9 Malnutrition in India — Part 1 . . . 187
9.1 PYQs and Exam Weighting of This Topic . . . 187
9.2 Introduction: Definition and Dimensions of Malnutrition . . . 188
9.2.1 Anthropometric Measurement: Stunting, Wasting and Underweight . . . 188
9.2.2 Why the Anganwadi Worker Is Central . . . 188
9.2.3 The Three Dimensions of Malnutrition . . . 189
9.3 NFHS Round 6: Undernutrition Data and the Anganwadi–PHC Connect . . . 190
9.3.1 The Anganwadi Worker and the Primary Health Centre . . . 192
9.4 NFHS Round 6: Obesity, Anaemia and the Nutrition Transition . . . 193
9.4.1 Anaemia: the Data Gap in NFHS Round 6 . . . 194
9.5 Nutritional Security and Its Pillars: Beyond Food Security . . . 195
9.5.1 Broad Pillars of Nutrition Security . . . 196
9.5.2 Governance: The Most Important Part . . . 197
9.5.3 Way Forward Flowing From the Pillars . . . 198
9.6 Causes of Malnutrition: The Economic Dimension . . . 200
9.7 Causes of Malnutrition: Agriculture and Food-System Causes . . . 202
9.8 Causes of Malnutrition: Social Causes . . . 204
9.8.1 The Intergenerational Cycle of Malnutrition . . . 204
9.8.2 Poor Sanitation and Lack of Focus on WASH . . . 205
9.9 Causes of Malnutrition: Governance Concerns . . . 206
9.10 Causes of Malnutrition: Cultural Causes . . . 207
9.11 Causes of Malnutrition: Environmental Causes and Climate-Induced Migration . . . 208
9.11.1 Climate Change Induced Insecurity . . . 208
9.11.2 Environmental Degradation . . . 208
9.11.3 Climate-Induced Migration and Ration Access . . . 208
9.12 Practice Questions to Attempt . . . 209

10 Malnutrition in India — Part 2: Consequences, Government Steps and Way Forward . . . 211
10.1 Consequences of Malnutrition: The Organising Structure . . . 211
10.2 Health Consequences . . . 212
10.3 Economic and Educational Consequences . . . 212
10.3.1 Individual Level . . . 213
10.3.2 Household Level . . . 213
10.3.3 National Level . . . 214
10.4 Social Consequences . . . 215
10.5 Political Consequences . . . 216
10.6 Geographical Consequences . . . 217
10.7 International and Strategic Consequences . . . 219
10.8 Steps Taken by the Government of India . . . 221
10.8.1 Women's Empowerment and the Judiciary — the Lecture's Digression . . . 223
10.8.2 Mission Poshan 2.0 — the Framework . . . 223
10.8.3 Technology Governance, Grievance Redressal and Community Engagement . . . 224

10.8.4 Schemes, Ministry by Ministry . . . 225
10.9 Way Forward . . . 227
10.10 Answer Framework: Malnutrition as a Public Health, Social Equity, Human Development and Welfare Governance Challenge . . . 230
10.10.1 Introduction — About 20 Words . . . 230
10.10.2 Body — The Four Heads . . . 230
10.10.3 Conclusion . . . 231
10.10.4 If It Is Written as a 10-Marker . . . 231
10.11 Additional Governance Challenge to Record . . . 232

11 Malnutrition in India — Part 3: Challenges of Malnutrition . . . 233
11.1 Framing the Challenges of Malnutrition . . . 233
11.2 Economic Challenges . . . 234
11.2.1 The Poverty Trap . . . 234
11.2.2 Migration-Induced Malnutrition . . . 235
11.2.3 Regional and Intra-State Disparities . . . 235
11.3 Agriculture and Food-System Challenges . . . 237
11.4 Maternal and Intergenerational Challenge . . . 238
11.4.1 The Intergenerational Cycle of Malnutrition . . . 238
11.4.2 Poor Maternal Nutrition . . . 239
11.4.3 Postnatal Care and the First 1000 Days . . . 239
11.4.4 Other Gender-Related Concerns . . . 240
11.5 WASH-Related Challenges . . . 241
11.6 Socio-Cultural Challenges . . . 242
11.6.1 Societal Divide . . . 243
11.6.2 Intersection of Vulnerabilities . . . 243
11.6.3 Cultural or Behavioural Challenges . . . 243
11.7 Governance and Institutional Challenges . . . 244
11.7.1 Fragmented and Non-Integrated Governance . . . 244
11.7.2 Aanganwadi-Related Concerns . . . 245
11.7.3 Digital Divide in Aanganwadi Functioning . . . 246
11.7.4 Limited Targeting . . . 246
11.8 Urbanisation and Globalisation-Induced Challenges . . . 247
11.9 Climate Change Challenge and the Nutritional Transition . . . 247
11.10 Integrated Governance and the Way Forward . . . 248

12 Obesity in India — Part 1 . . . 251
12.1 Obesity as Part of the Malnutrition Discussion . . . 251
12.2 The Fixed Structure of an Obesity Answer . . . 252
12.2.1 The Example Head — Food Safety Warning versus Nutritional Labelling . . . 253
12.3 Introduction — 2025 as a Turning Point . . . 255
12.4 Defining Obesity — Over-Nutrition and BMI . . . 257
12.4.1 BMI — the Body Mass Index . . . 257

12.5 Statistics — The Rising Trend . . . 258
12.5.1 The Numbers — NFHS Round 5 to NFHS Round 6 . . . 259
12.5.2 Women — Mobility, Cultural Restrictions and the Double Burden . . . 259
12.5.3 Time Use Survey — the Source of These Facts . . . 260
12.5.4 What the Statistics Tell You . . . 260
12.5.5 The Wrong Metric and the Vicious Cycle . . . 261
12.6 Reasons — Building the Framework . . . 262
12.7 Economic Factors . . . 264
12.8 Food Systems and Agriculture-Related Reasons . . . 265
12.9 Social and Cultural Factors . . . 267
12.9.1 The Cultural Shift in the Perception of Food . . . 267
12.10 Governance, Legal and Administrative Factors . . . 268
12.10.1 Lack of a Stringent Law and of an Innovative Levy . . . 268
12.10.2 Limited Regulation by FSSAI . . . 269
12.10.3 Capacity Building of Food Inspectors and Testing . . . 269
12.10.4 No Front-of-the-Pack Health Labelling . . . 269
12.10.5 Fragmented Policy Making and Limited Integrated Governance . . . 270
12.10.6 Stakeholder and Community Engagement . . . 270
12.11 Other Factors — Media and the Food Processing Industry . . . 271
12.11.1 Increase in Food Processing Industries . . . 271
12.12 Environmental Factors . . . 272
12.13 Role of Globalization in Promoting Over-Nutrition and Obesity . . . 273
12.13.1 Economic Impact . . . 274
12.13.2 Social and Cultural Impact . . . 276
12.13.3 Political Impact . . . 277
12.13.4 Technological Impact . . . 277

13 Obesity in India — Part 2 . . . 281
13.1 Consequences of Obesity — the Organising Structure . . . 281
13.1.1 Political Impact . . . 282
13.1.2 Child Obesity . . . 282
13.2 Health Consequences . . . 283
13.2.1 Women's Reproductive and Maternal Health . . . 283
13.2.2 Child and Adolescent Health . . . 284
13.3 Economic Consequences . . . 285
13.3.1 National-Level Economic Impact . . . 286
13.4 Social Consequences . . . 286
13.4.1 Obesity as an Equity Issue . . . 287
13.4.2 Gender Divide . . . 287
13.5 Nutritional Governance Challenge . . . 288
13.5.1 Challenges . . . 288
13.6 International Consequences . . . 290

13.7 Steps Taken by the Government of India (Ministry-wise) . . . 291
13.7.1 Ministry of Health and Family Welfare . . . 291
13.7.2 Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports . . . 292
13.7.3 Ministry of Ayush . . . 293
13.7.4 Ministry of Women and Child Development . . . 293
13.7.5 Recent Current-Affairs Steps . . . 293
13.8 Way Forward . . . 294
13.8.1 Front-of-the-Pack Labelling — Why It Works . . . 295
13.8.2 Example: The Saudi Arabian Model . . . 295

14 Framework of IR: India's Diaspora . . . 299
14.1 Framework for IR in the Examination . . . 299
14.2 IR Answer-Writing: Keywords, Strategic Framing and Decoding Questions . . . 300
14.3 Great Powers, Global Developments and Their Impact on India . . . 301
14.4 Regional Organisations in the IR Syllabus . . . 304
14.5 Bilateral Relations and the 'Other Nations' Basket . . . 306
14.5.1 Nepal: a Changing Framework . . . 306
14.5.2 Afghanistan: Dealing with the Taliban . . . 306
14.5.3 The 'Other Nations' Basket . . . 307
14.6 Abstract Topics: UNSC, WTO, Central Asia and the EU . . . 308
14.7 Role of Diaspora: The Static Entry Topic . . . 309
14.8 Opening the Answer: Structure and the Prime Minister's Framing . . . 310
14.9 Benefits of the Diaspora: For India and for the Host Nation . . . 311
14.10 Issues Faced by the Diaspora and Issues Caused by It . . . 313
14.10.1 Challenges . . . 313
14.11 India's Approach: From Nehru's Scepticism to the Way Forward . . . 315
14.11.1 Steps Taken by India . . . 315
14.11.2 Way Forward . . . 315
14.12 The PYQ Pattern on the Diaspora . . . 316
14.13 Diaspora: Definition, Numbers and Categories . . . 316
14.14 Country-wise Distribution of the Indian Diaspora . . . 319
14.15 Girmityas, the Indo-Pacific and the Quad: India's Civilisational Claim . . . 321
14.15.1 Girmityas: Who They Are . . . 321
14.15.2 India's Civilisational Claim in the Indo-Pacific . . . 321
14.15.3 ASEAN Centrality and the Two Audiences . . . 321
14.15.4 China in the Indian Ocean Region . . . 322
14.16 Brand Ambassadors and the Living Bridge . . . 323
14.17 The Diaspora as Ambassadors, Pride and a Mini India . . . 324
14.18 India's Engagement with the Diaspora: The 4C Approach and the Keywords . . . 325
14.19 Economic Importance I: Remittances, Forex Reserves and Household Income . . . 326
14.20 Economic Importance II: Investment, Entrepreneurship and Employment . . . 328
14.21 Economic Importance III: Brain Circulation and Company Building in India . . . 329

14.22 Economic Importance IV: Stable External Finance and FDI . . . 330
14.22.1 The Investor-Confidence Story . . . 331
14.23 Economic Importance V: Market Access, Knowledge Networks and Transaction Costs . . . 332
14.24 Economic Importance VI: Innovation, Venture Creation and the Indian-American Record . . . 335
14.25 Tourism, the Service Sector and Religious Diplomacy . . . 337
14.26 Cultural and Societal Impact of the Diaspora . . . 338
14.27 The Living Bridge: Two-Way Interaction and Diaspora as a Policy Pillar . . . 341

15 India's Diaspora — Part 2 . . . 343
15.1 Importance for Indian Foreign Policy and Diplomacy . . . 343
15.1.1 Structural Interdependence . . . 345
15.2 Importance for the Host Nation . . . 346
15.2.1 Political Influence, Representation and Elections . . . 346
15.2.2 Shaping Trade Agreements and Policies . . . 347
15.2.3 Economic Asset and Human Capital . . . 348
15.2.4 Diaspora as a Transaction-Cost Reducer . . . 349
15.3 Effect on the Host Society and Culture . . . 350
15.4 Issues Faced by the Indian Diaspora . . . 352
15.5 Issues Caused by the Indian Diaspora . . . 355
15.6 Steps Taken: Protection, Welfare and Engagement . . . 357
15.6.1 Protection and Welfare . . . 357
15.6.2 Engagement . . . 359
15.7 Way Forward and Overall Policy Shift . . . 359

16 India's Diaspora — Part 4: Answer-Writing on the Diaspora as Living Bridge, Economic Factor and Knowledge Network . . . 361
16.1 The 2020 Question and Its Demand . . . 361
16.2 Introduction and the Opening Line . . . 363
16.3 Role 1 — The Diaspora as a Living Bridge . . . 363
16.4 Role 2 — The Diaspora as a Critical Economic Factor . . . 364
16.5 Role 3 — The Diaspora as a Knowledge Network . . . 365
16.6 The Fourth Head — Political Positions and Strategic Influence . . . 366
16.7 Answer-Writing Craft: Keywords, Structure and Practice . . . 366
16.8 Directive Words, the Counter-View and the Conclusion . . . 368
16.9 Practice Questions to Structure . . . 369
16.10 Shifts in the Nature of the Indian Diaspora . . . 370

17 India's Diaspora — Part 3 . . . 373
17.1 SCO in the News and the Roadmap for this Class . . . 373
17.2 Recap: The Diaspora's Role and the Protection–Welfare Framework . . . 373

17.3 Protection Steps: Pravasi Bharatiya Sahayata Kendra (PBSK) . . . 374
17.3.1 The Skilling Problem . . . 375
17.4 Protection Steps: Pravasi Bharatiya Bima Yojana (PBBY) . . . 375
17.5 Protection Steps: Pre-Departure Orientation Training (PDOT) . . . 376
17.5.1 Example: Religion and Work Culture in the Gulf . . . 376
17.6 Protection Steps: Bilateral Protection of Workers . . . 377
17.7 Protection Steps: Social Security Agreements (SSA) . . . 378
17.7.1 What Social Security Means — The Four Components . . . 378
17.7.2 Healthcare Abroad: The US Contrast . . . 378
17.7.3 Where SSAs Have Been Signed, and the Gulf's Contribution . . . 379
17.7.4 The Shift from London to Dubai . . . 379
17.8 Emergency Evacuation and Crisis Response . . . 379
17.8.1 Operation Kaveri and Why Sudan Matters . . . 380
17.9 Welfare Steps: Scholarships for Diaspora Children . . . 381
17.10 Afghanistan, Central Asia and Regional Presence . . . 382
17.11 Connecting the Diaspora to its Roots: Know India Programme . . . 383
17.11.1 Know India Programme (KIP) . . . 383
17.11.2 Why Roots Matter — The Cultural Argument . . . 383
17.11.3 Multi-Vectored Foreign Policy . . . 383
17.11.4 The BRI Question — Connectivity and Sovereignty . . . 384
17.11.5 Diaspora as a Bridge . . . 384
17.12 Pravasi Teerth Darshan Yojana and the Girmitiya Diaspora . . . 384
17.13 Pravasi Bharatiya Divas and Pravasi Bharatiya Samman . . . 385
17.14 Overseas Mobility (Facilitation and Welfare) Bill, 2025 . . . 386
17.15 Other Steps: Bharat Ko Janiye Quiz and the OCI Framework . . . 386
17.16 Expanding India's Diplomatic Footprint: Embassies and Consulates . . . 387
17.17 Return to the SCO: Institutions and India's Engagement . . . 388
17.18 Way Forward: 4C Approach, Consular Access and Digitisation . . . 389
17.19 Parliamentary Committee Recommendations and Additional Measures . . . 390
17.19.1 Why the Anti-Fraud Recommendation Matters . . . 391
17.20 Contribution of the Diaspora in Southeast Asia . . . 393
17.20.1 Contribution in the Economy . . . 393
17.20.2 Case Study: Singapore . . . 393
17.20.3 Contribution in Society . . . 394
17.20.4 Contribution in Politics . . . 395
17.21 Contribution of the Diaspora in West Asia . . . 396
17.21.1 Contribution in the Economy . . . 396
17.21.2 Contribution in Education and Society . . . 397
17.21.3 Politics in West Asia — Why the Political Capital is Zero . . . 397
17.21.4 The Bigger Player: Saudi Arabia and India's Hard-Power Gap . . . 398

18 The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) . . . 401

18.1 SCO in the Examination: Placement and the Perspective to Build . . . 401
18.2 Previous Year Questions and the Structure of the Topic . . . 402
18.3 SCO for India: The S-C-O Framework . . . 403
18.4 Introduction: Formation of SCO (1991 to 2001) . . . 404
18.4.1 The Shanghai Five . . . 404
18.4.2 Formation of SCO in 2001 . . . 405
18.5 Expansion, the 'Association of Autocrats' Criticism and India's Dilemmas . . . 405
18.6 What SCO Is: Focus Areas, Global Weight and the Shanghai Spirit . . . 406
18.6.1 The Shanghai Spirit . . . 407
18.6.2 Summits and the Shift in Focus . . . 407
18.7 Importance of SCO for India: The Four Dimensions . . . 408
18.8 Importance of SCO for India: The Points . . . 409

19 The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) — Part 2 . . . 413
19.1 Geoeconomic Importance of SCO for India . . . 413
19.1.1 The Geoeconomic Template . . . 413
19.1.2 Energy Security and Structural Dependence . . . 414
19.2 Connectivity and the Map: Pakistan's Denial and the INSTC Route . . . 415
19.2.1 The Map as an Eagle's View . . . 415
19.2.2 Gilgit-Baltistan and the Frontier of Colonial India . . . 415
19.3 The Belt and Road Initiative and Why India Does Not Join It . . . 417
19.3.1 What Connectivity Really Means . . . 418
19.4 Geocultural Importance of SCO . . . 419
19.4.1 India's Projection of Civilizational Diplomacy . . . 419
19.4.2 India's Soft Power . . . 420
19.5 Geostrategic Importance of SCO . . . 421
19.5.1 The Changing Nature of Security . . . 423
19.6 Importance of India for SCO: The Geopolitical Dimension . . . 424
19.7 Importance of India for SCO: Geoeconomic and Geostrategic . . . 426
19.7.1 The Geostrategic Dimension . . . 426
19.7.2 The Geoeconomic Dimension . . . 427
19.8 Importance of India for SCO: The Geocultural Dimension . . . 429
19.9 Strengths of the India–SCO Relationship and the Weaknesses to Follow . . . 430
19.9.1 The Strengths . . . 431

20 The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) — Part 3 . . . 433
20.1 Issues in the SCO: The Overall Frame . . . 433
20.2 Domination by Russia and China . . . 434
20.3 Bilateral Disputes Hampering Cooperation . . . 435
20.4 Lack of Consensus on Afghanistan . . . 436
20.4.1 How to Engage with the Taliban . . . 436
20.4.2 Recognition, Ripple Effects and the Afghan Neighbourhood . . . 437

20.4.3 Taliban Representation at SCO Summits . . . 437
20.4.4 Tajikistan and the Limits of Consensus . . . 438
20.5 Lack of Consensus over the Belt and Road Initiative . . . 438
20.6 Lack of Consensus over English as a Formal Language . . . 439
20.7 Expansion and the Consensus-Building Problem . . . 439
20.8 Shift in Primary Focus: From Geo-Security to Geo-Economy . . . 441
20.9 Expansion and Consensus Formation on Security and Geopolitical Issues . . . 442
20.10 Effect of the Russia–Ukraine War . . . 443
20.10.1 The Discounted Oil Windfall — and India's Import Dependence . . . 443
20.10.2 Where the Advantage Finally Went . . . 443
20.10.3 The West Asia Laboratory . . . 444
20.11 Lack of Tangible Enforcement of Counter-Terrorism . . . 445
20.12 Divergent Interests on Connectivity . . . 446
20.12.1 The Chabahar Trilateral Grouping and the INSTC Eastern Route . . . 446
20.12.2 Pakistan's Geography and the Caspian Sea . . . 447
20.12.3 India's Proposal: Chabahar Port in the INSTC and the Shahid Beheshti Terminal . . . 447
20.13 Recent Issues . . . 448
20.14 Afghanistan, Observers and Points Noted for Later . . . 449
20.15 Way Forward: Strategies for Improving the India–SCO Relationship . . . 450
20.15.1 Points Developed in Class . . . 450
20.15.2 Eight Points to Write in the Answer . . . 451

21 Central Asian Republics . . . 453
21.1 Exam Relevance and PYQ Analysis . . . 453
21.2 Framework of Heads for Central Asia's Importance . . . 454
21.3 Nation Profiles of the Five Central Asian Republics . . . 455
21.3.1 Reading the Region on a Map . . . 455
21.4 Common Features of the Central Asian Republics . . . 456
21.5 Importance of the Central Asian Republics for India . . . 458
21.6 Economic Importance — Geoeconomics, Energy and Complementarity . . . 460
21.6.1 Energy Security . . . 460
21.6.2 Market for India's Goods and Services . . . 461
21.7 Adjacent Regions and Groupings — Caspian, Caucasus, EAEU and the Road to Europe . . . 462
21.8 The Great Game — Heartland and Rimland . . . 463
21.9 Connectivity — Bypassing Pakistan Through Iran . . . 463

22 India–Nepal Relations . . . 465
22.1 Bilateral Relations in the IR Exam: Framework and PYQ Pattern . . . 465
22.2 Note-Making Structure for Every Neighbour and the Nepal Polygon . . . 466
22.3 History of Nepal and India–Nepal Relations . . . 468
22.3.1 Unification and the Yam Between Two Boulders (1768) . . . 468

22.3.2 The Anglo-Nepal War and the Treaty of Sugauli (1814–1816) 469
22.3.3 The Shah Monarchy, the Ranas and the 1923 Treaty of Friendship 469
22.3.4 1950 to 1960: Independence, the Three Pillars and the Fall of the Ranas 470
22.3.5 Monarchy and the Party-less Panchayat System (1960–1990) 470
22.3.6 Jan Andolan, the Maoist People's War and the Republic (1990–2008) 471
22.4 Recent Developments: From the Modi Reset to the Gen Z Protests (2014–2026) 473
22.5 Importance of Nepal for India 478
22.5.1 Geopolitical Importance 478
22.5.2 Geocultural Importance 478
22.5.3 Geoeconomic Importance 480
22.5.4 Geostrategic Importance 481
22.6 Concerns, Challenges and Way Forward 482
22.6.1 Challenges 482
22.6.2 Way Forward 483

23 India–Nepal Relations — Part 2 485
23.1 Recap: From South Asian Diplomacy to China's Role in Nepal 485
23.2 Why Nepal Is Important for China 486
23.2.1 Immediate Neighbourhood and Tibetan Security 486
23.2.2 The Routes into South Asia and the Buffer Logic 486
23.2.3 Geo-Economic Importance: BRI Membership and Connectivity Projects 487
23.2.4 Concerns Against BRI 488
23.2.5 Political Influence, the Maoist–RSP Question and China's Cautious Approach 488
23.2.6 Geostrategic and Geocultural Importance 489
23.3 Implications of China's Growing Engagement for India 490
23.4 Challenges in India–Nepal Relations 493
23.4.1 Challenge 1 — Engaging with a New Government 493
23.4.2 Challenge 2 — The Treaty of Peace and Friendship 494
23.4.3 Challenge 3 — The Boundary Dispute: The Susta Region 494
23.4.4 The Boundary Dispute: Kalapani, Limpiyadhura and Lipulekh 495
23.4.5 Lipulekh's Importance for India 497
23.4.6 Challenge 4 — Big Brother Syndrome and Interference in Domestic Affairs 498
23.4.7 Challenge 5 — The Challenge of Open Borders 498
23.4.8 Challenge 6 — Expanding Chinese Presence and Trade Asymmetry 498
23.4.9 Challenge 7 — Water Resources 498
23.5 Strengths of the India–Nepal Relationship 500
23.5.1 India's Developmental Footprint in Nepal 500
23.5.2 Student Doubt — Why a Stable Government Is a Strength 501
23.6 Implications of Recent Events 502
23.6.1 UPI and Digital Connectivity 503
23.6.2 Impact of the Floods 503
23.6.3 The Recent Elections in Nepal 503
23.7 Way Forward 504

24 India–Afghanistan Relations . . . 507
24.1 Reading the Nepal Question: The Implications Framework . . . 507
24.2 Geopolitical Implications of Nepal's Leadership Change . . . 508
24.3 Geoeconomic Implications of Nepal's Leadership Change . . . 509
24.4 Geocultural Implications of Nepal's Leadership Change . . . 511
24.5 Geostrategic and Security Implications of Nepal's Leadership Change . . . 511
24.6 Afghanistan: Engagement Without Recognition — Introduction and Plan . . . 513
24.7 Afghanistan: Historical Background . . . 514
24.8 Taliban 1.0 and Taliban 2.0: A Structured Comparison . . . 517
24.9 India's Response: From Isolation to Calibrated Engagement . . . 519
24.10 Recent Developments in India–Afghanistan Engagement . . . 521
24.11 Importance of Afghanistan: Immediate Neighbourhood, Buffer and Strategic Theatre . . . 522
24.12 Importance of Afghanistan: Geoeconomic . . . 523
24.13 Importance of Afghanistan: Geocultural and Soft Power . . . 524
24.14 Importance of Afghanistan: Geostrategic, Counter-Terrorism and Internal Security . . . 525
24.15 Why India Engages the Taliban: Challenges and Way Forward . . . 526
24.15.1 Challenges . . . 526
24.15.2 Way Forward . . . 526

25 India–Afghanistan Relations — Part 2 . . . 529
25.1 Why India Chose to Engage with the Taliban . . . 529
25.2 Challenges of Recognition of Taliban 2.0 . . . 530
25.2.1 Why Pakistan Gains from Instability in Afghanistan . . . 532
25.3 China's Engagement with Taliban-Ruled Afghanistan . . . 534
25.3.1 China's Wider Design: Encircling India . . . 534
25.4 Strengths of the India–Afghanistan Relationship under Taliban 2.0 . . . 535
25.4.1 From Taliban 1.0 to Taliban 2.0: Why Engagement Is Now Possible . . . 536
25.5 Weaknesses of the India–Afghanistan Relationship under Taliban 2.0 . . . 539
25.6 Way Forward: Engagement Without Recognition . . . 541
25.7 Overall Assessment: Recognition Is Not an Option . . . 542

26 The National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) . . . 545
26.1 NHRC in the Examination: Placement and PYQ Trends . . . 545
26.1.1 Where It Sits in General Studies Paper 2 . . . 545
26.1.2 The PYQ Record of the Regulatory Bodies . . . 545
26.1.3 The Kinds of Questions Asked . . . 546
26.1.4 The Merger Question: Positives and Negatives . . . 546
26.2 How the Discussion Is Structured . . . 547
26.2.1 The Four-Part Structure . . . 547
26.3 Introduction: Legal Mandate and Constitutional Roots . . . 548
26.3.1 Why the Law Was Amended . . . 548
26.3.2 Rooted in the Constitution: The Letter and the Spirit . . . 549

26.4 The Paris Principles and the Six-Point Test . . . 550
26.4.1 The Six Principles . . . 550
26.4.2 Challenges . . . 551
26.4.3 Way Forward . . . 551
26.5 Definition of Human Rights under the PHRA, 1993 . . . 552
26.5.1 The Four Pillars, Explained . . . 552
26.5.2 The Three-Part Test of a Human Right . . . 553
26.6 International Covenants: The Normative Base . . . 553
26.7 Composition of the Commission . . . 554
26.7.1 The Judicial Members . . . 555
26.7.2 The Ex-Officio Chairpersons . . . 555
26.7.3 The Arithmetic: Three versus Three . . . 555
26.8 Appointment and the Selection Committee . . . 556
26.9 Statutory Functions of the Commission . . . 557
26.9.1 What the Transgender Example Shows . . . 558
26.10 Role of the NHRC: Watchdog, Monitor, Adviser, Educator, Collaborator . . . 558

27 Central Asian Republics — Part 2 . . . 561
27.1 Geocultural Importance of Central Asia . . . 561
27.1.1 Civilizational and Silk Road Linkages . . . 561
27.1.2 Buddhism and Soft Power Diplomacy . . . 561
27.1.3 Sufism and the Islamic Connection . . . 562
27.1.4 Cinema, Culture and Goodwill . . . 562
27.2 Geostrategic Importance of Central Asia . . . 563
27.3 Major Powers Active in Central Asia . . . 565
27.3.1 Student Doubt: The Withdrawal of the Ayni Base . . . 565
27.3.2 Russia . . . 565
27.3.3 China . . . 566
27.3.4 European Union . . . 566
27.3.5 United States . . . 566
27.3.6 Turkey . . . 566
27.4 Implications of Great Power Competition for India . . . 567
27.4.1 Negative Implications . . . 567
27.4.2 Positive Implications . . . 568
27.5 India's Strengths in Central Asia . . . 568
27.5.1 Writing Tip: Strengths in Four Folds . . . 569
27.6 Weaknesses and Issues in India–Central Asia Relations . . . 570
27.6.1 Divergences Among the Five CARs . . . 571
27.7 Steps Taken by India . . . 571
27.8 Way Forward . . . 572
27.9 Answer-Writing Framework: 2024 PYQ on India–Central Asia . . . 574
27.9.1 Deconstructing the Question . . . 574

27.9.2 Model Structure . . . 574
27.9.3 Practice Questions (frame them, do not write answers) . . . 575

28 The National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) — Part 2 . . . 577
28.1 Recap and Framing: The Role of the NHRC . . . 577
28.2 Institutionalisation of Human Rights . . . 578
28.3 Role in Prevention: Custodial Violence and the 24-Hour Reporting Rule . . . 579
28.4 Compensatory Justice . . . 580
28.5 Upholding Fundamental Rights and Social Justice . . . 581
28.5.1 Bonded Labour . . . 581
28.5.2 Manual Scavengers and Sanitation Workers . . . 582
28.6 Enlarging the Ambit of Human Rights: Health Rights . . . 583
28.7 Upholding Women's and Children's Rights . . . 584
28.8 Upholding Migrant Rights . . . 585
28.9 Addressing the Emerging Framework of Human Rights . . . 586
28.10 Improved Access . . . 588
28.11 Issues and Challenges: Why the NHRC is Called a 'Toothless Tiger' . . . 588
28.11.1 Legal Issues and Constraints . . . 589
28.11.2 Institutional Concerns . . . 590
28.11.3 Functional Problems . . . 591
28.11.4 Federal Issues . . . 593
28.11.5 International Issues and GANHRI Accreditation . . . 593
28.11.6 Way Forward . . . 594

29 The National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) — Part 3 . . . 597
29.1 PYQ-Based Approach to the Merger Debate . . . 597
29.2 Benefits of Merging the Commissions into the NHRC . . . 598
29.3 Drawbacks of Merging the Commissions into the NHRC . . . 599
29.4 The Common Public-Administration Logic Behind Merger Debates . . . 602
29.5 Second ARC's Stand and Its Recommendations . . . 602
29.6 2021 PYQ: Structural and Practical Limitations of Human Rights Commissions . . . 603
29.7 Remedial Measures Suggested for the NHRC . . . 604
29.8 PYQ: NHRC as an Effective Complement to the Judiciary and Other Institutions . . . 606
29.9 NHRC vs SHRC: Statutory Framework to Compare . . . 608
29.10 Preparation and Study Approach . . . 609

30 Various Commissions . . . 611
30.1 Topic Overview, PYQs and Answer Framework . . . 611
30.2 Introduction — Details of the Commissions . . . 612
30.2.1 Composition . . . 613
30.3 Functions of the Commissions . . . 614
30.3.1 Function 1 — Investigation and Monitoring of Safeguards . . . 615

30.3.2 Function 2 — Inquiry into Specific Complaints . . . 616
30.3.3 Function 3 — Participation and Advice in Socio-Economic Development . . . 617
30.3.4 Function 4 — Evaluation of Progress . . . 617
30.4 Exam Relevance and the Social Justice Linkage . . . 618

31 Health — Governance, Universal Health Coverage and Challenges . . . 621
31.1 Health in the Syllabus and the Underlying Thought . . . 621
31.2 PYQs and the Exam Relevance of Health . . . 622
31.3 The Structure of the Topic and the Approach to Answers . . . 624
31.4 Defining Health — A State of Complete Well-Being . . . 625
31.5 Constitutional Dimensions of Health . . . 626
31.6 Administrative Perspective — Health in the Three Lists and the Schedules . . . 629
31.7 Health for All and Universal Health Coverage . . . 631
31.8 India's Three-Tier Health Delivery Framework . . . 633
31.9 Issues in Health — Building the Framework . . . 635
31.10 Focus of Healthcare — Curative Rather Than Preventive . . . 636
31.11 Poor Health Financing and High Out-of-Pocket Expenditure . . . 636
31.12 The Missing Middle in Health Insurance . . . 638
31.13 Limited Human Resources and Infrastructure . . . 639
31.14 Equity Concerns . . . 640

32 Health — Part 2 . . . 643
32.1 Infrastructure Deficit in Health . . . 643
32.2 Double Burden of Disease . . . 643
32.3 Climate Change-Related Health Concerns . . . 644
32.3.1 Infrastructural Concern . . . 644
32.3.2 Increase in Extreme Weather Events . . . 645
32.3.3 Rising Chance of Pandemics . . . 645
32.4 Health Governance Issues . . . 646
32.4.1 Weak Integration of Health Services . . . 646
32.4.2 Weak Horizontal Coordination Between Ministries . . . 647
32.4.3 Limited Vertical Coordination . . . 647
32.4.4 Lack of Decentralisation . . . 648
32.4.5 Focus on Outputs Rather Than Outcomes . . . 648
32.4.6 Accountability and Quality Deficit . . . 649
32.4.7 The Dual Problem: Public versus Private Healthcare . . . 649
32.4.8 Parliamentary Standing Committee, 176th Report . . . 650
32.5 Technology-Related Health Challenges . . . 651
32.5.1 Concerns Related to AI . . . 651
32.5.2 Gender Bias in AI . . . 652
32.6 Role of the Private Sector, Market Forces and PPP . . . 653
32.6.1 Merits of Private Sector Participation . . . 653

32.6.2 Challenges . . . 655
32.6.3 Way Forward . . . 657
32.7 Steps (Schemes) . . . 658
32.8 Consequences in Health . . . 658
32.9 Importance of Local-Level Community Healthcare in Universal Health Coverage . . . 659
32.9.1 Challenges . . . 660

33 Various Commissions — Part 2 . . . 663
33.1 Functions of the Commissions . . . 663
33.1.1 Functions Specific to NCPCR . . . 664
33.1.2 Why NCPCR Is Highlighted — and the Same Framework for NCW . . . 664
33.2 Role of the Commissions: Positive Contributions . . . 665
33.2.1 Positive Role . . . 665
33.3 Limitations of the Commissions — Challenges and Way Forward . . . 669
33.3.1 Challenges . . . 669
33.3.2 Way Forward . . . 671

34 Health in India — Part 3: Government Steps, Way Forward and AI in Health . . . 675
34.1 Framing: How Health Questions Are Asked . . . 675
34.2 Budget Steps Taken by the Government of India in Health . . . 676
34.2.1 1. Bio-Pharma Shakti: Indigenous Production of Biologics and Biosimilars . . . 676
34.2.2 2. Expansion of Allied Health Professionals . . . 677
34.2.3 3. Care Economy and Geriatric Care . . . 677
34.2.4 4. Emergency and Trauma Care in District Hospitals . . . 678
34.2.5 5. NIMHANS 2 in North India . . . 678
34.2.6 6. Five Regional Medical Hubs on a Hub-and-Spoke Model . . . 679
34.2.7 7. Cancer Care: Basic Customs Duty Exemption . . . 679
34.2.8 8. Rare Diseases: Customs Duty Exemption . . . 680
34.2.9 9. Strengthening Drug Regulation: CDSCO and the DCGI . . . 680
34.2.10 10. Ayurveda: New Institutes and the WHO Traditional Medicine Centre . . . 680
34.3 Traditional Steps Taken by the Government of India in Health . . . 681
34.3.1 1. Ayushman Bharat: Arogya Mandir, PMJAY and Vay Vandana . . . 681
34.3.2 2. National Health Mission . . . 682
34.3.3 3. Maternal Health . . . 682
34.3.4 4. Preventive Health Care: Immunisation . . . 683
34.3.5 5. Non-Communicable Diseases: National Programme for Prevention and Control . . . 684
34.3.6 6. PM National Dialysis Programme . . . 684
34.3.7 7. The Cancer Care Spectrum . . . 684
34.3.8 8. Other Disease Programmes . . . 684
34.3.9 9. PM-ABHIM: PM Ayushman Bharat Health Infrastructure Mission . . . 684
34.3.10 10. Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission: Digital Health . . . 684
34.3.11 Medicines: Amrit Pharmacy and Jan Aushadhi Kendras . . . 685
34.3.12 National Ayush Mission . . . 685

34.4 Way Forward: Steps Recommended to Fulfil Health for All . . . 686
34.5 AI in Health . . . 688
34.5.1 Applications of AI in Health . . . 688
34.5.2 Challenges Concerning AI in Health . . . 690
34.5.3 The Thought Framework for the Answer . . . 691

35 Health — Part 4 . . . 693
35.1 AI in Health: Framework of Challenges . . . 693
35.2 Technical Challenges . . . 694
35.2.1 Clinical Accuracy and Patient Safety . . . 694
35.2.2 Data Diversity and Generalisability . . . 694
35.2.3 Algorithmic Bias . . . 694
35.2.4 The Black Box Problem . . . 695
35.3 Data Challenges: Poor and Fragmented Data . . . 695
35.4 Ethical Challenges . . . 696
35.4.1 Informed Consent . . . 696
35.4.2 Patient Autonomy . . . 696
35.4.3 Doctor–Patient Relationship . . . 697
35.5 Data Governance Challenges . . . 697
35.5.1 Privacy . . . 697
35.5.2 Cybersecurity . . . 698
35.5.3 Data Ownership . . . 698
35.6 Legal and Regulatory Challenges . . . 698
35.6.1 Medical Liability . . . 698
35.6.2 Regulatory Gaps . . . 698
35.6.3 Post-Deployment Monitoring . . . 699
35.7 Equity Challenges . . . 699
35.8 Other Challenges . . . 700
35.9 Way Forward and Government Steps . . . 700

36 Regulatory Bodies . . . 703
36.1 Regulatory Bodies: Syllabus Placement, Context and PYQ Trends . . . 703
36.1.1 Where It Sits . . . 703
36.2 Structure of the Discussion . . . 704
36.3 What Is a Regulator? Definition and Examples . . . 705
36.3.1 The Coaching-Institute Illustration . . . 705
36.3.2 The Regulators: The Illustrative List . . . 706
36.4 The Framework: State, Service Providers and the Regulator . . . 707
36.5 The Three Functions of a Regulator . . . 708
36.5.1 1. The Quasi-Legislative Function . . . 709
36.5.2 2. The Quasi-Executive Function . . . 709
36.5.3 3. The Quasi-Judicial Function . . . 709
36.6 How Independence Is Established . . . 710

36.7 Evolution of Regulators: Pre-1991 to Post-LPG Reforms . . . 711
36.8 Why Regulators Are Needed (The Need for Regulators) . . . 712
36.8.1 The Illustrations, Point by Point . . . 713
36.8.2 What to Write at the End: Consumer Interest and Information Asymmetry . . . 715
36.9 Independence and Autonomy: Meaning and the PYQ . . . 716
36.9.1 Independence and Autonomy: The Two Words . . . 716
36.9.2 How to Structure This Answer . . . 717
36.9.3 The Body: The Numbered Points . . . 717
36.10 The Second PYQ: Post-LPG Sectoral Regulators and Their Concerns . . . 718
36.11 Student Doubt: Are Commissions Such as the NHRC Regulatory Bodies? . . . 719
36.12 What Remains and How the Topic Connects . . . 719

37 India–Bangladesh Relations . . . 721
37.1 Leftover from the Previous Topic: Nepal and Overflight Rights . . . 721
37.2 Roadmap Ahead . . . 721
37.3 PYQ Pattern and Exam Framing . . . 722
37.4 The March 2026 Turning Point and the Framework of the Discussion . . . 722
37.5 Structure of the Topic . . . 723
37.6 The Relationship Diagram: India's Stakes in Bangladesh . . . 724
37.7 History of Indo-Bangladesh Relations . . . 725
37.7.1 Phase 1 (1971–1975): The Foundation Based on Blood and Sacrifice . . . 725
37.7.2 Phase 2 (1975–1990): Military Rule, Islamization and Strategic Diversification 725
37.7.3 Phase 3 (1991–1996): BNP Rule and Bilateral Mistrust . . . 726
37.7.4 Phase 4 (1996–2001): Awami League, Major Reset and the Ganga Water Treaty . . . 726
37.7.5 Phase 5 (2001–2006): BNP, the Four-Party Alliance and the Chittagong Arms Haul . . . 727
37.7.6 Phase 6 (2009–August 2024): The Era of Model Relationship . . . 727
37.7.7 Phase 7 (August 2024–March 2026): Interim Government under Muhammad Yunus . . . 728
37.7.8 Phase 8 (March 2026 onwards): The Present Phase . . . 729
37.7.9 Timeline for the Diagram and the Phases That Matter . . . 729
37.8 Student Doubt Answered: Was the Sheikh Hasina Regime Dictatorial? . . . 731

Answer-Writing Toolkit . . . 733
Policies of the Developed World and Their Impact on India . . . 733
Various Diplomacies in India's Foreign Policy . . . 733
South Asian Diplomacy and India's Neighbourhood First Policy: Nepal . . . 734
Supreme Court on Child Rights, Abortion, Online Blocking and Bail . . . 735
37.8.1 Dissecting the Question . . . 735
37.8.2 Structure and Presentation . . . 735
37.8.3 Handwriting and Practice . . . 735
37.8.4 Reading Habit . . . 736

37.8.5 Paper-wise Spread . . . 736
37.8.6 Writing for the Service . . . 736
37.8.7 Answer Strategy . . . 736
Right to Bail, Abortion Jurisprudence and the Anti-Defection Law . . . 736
Local Self-Government: Democratic Decentralization, Devolution and Functionality (GS Paper 2 Current Affairs) . . . 737
Local Self-Government: Functions, Functionaries and Funds — Devolution Problems and the Way Forward . . . 738
GS Paper 2 Current Affairs: Local Self-Government and Malnutrition . . . 738
Malnutrition in India — Part 1 . . . 739
Malnutrition in India — Part 2: Consequences, Government Steps and Way Forward . . . 740
Malnutrition in India — Part 3: Challenges of Malnutrition . . . 740
Obesity in India — Part 1 . . . 741
Obesity in India — Part 2 . . . 742
Framework of IR: India's Diaspora . . . 742
India's Diaspora — Part 2 . . . 744
India's Diaspora — Part 4: Answer-Writing on the Diaspora as Living Bridge, Economic Factor and Knowledge Network . . . 745
India's Diaspora — Part 3 . . . 745
The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) . . . 746
The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) — Part 2 . . . 747
The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) — Part 3 . . . 748
Central Asian Republics . . . 748
37.8.8 How to Present the Answer . . . 748
India–Nepal Relations . . . 749
India–Nepal Relations — Part 2 . . . 750
India–Afghanistan Relations . . . 750
India–Afghanistan Relations — Part 2 . . . 751
The National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) . . . 751
Central Asian Republics — Part 2 . . . 752
The National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) — Part 2 . . . 752
The National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) — Part 3 . . . 753
Various Commissions . . . 754
Health — Governance, Universal Health Coverage and Challenges . . . 754
Health — Part 2 . . . 755
Various Commissions — Part 2 . . . 757
Health in India — Part 3: Government Steps, Way Forward and AI in Health . . . 757
Health — Part 4 . . . 758
Regulatory Bodies . . . 758
India–Bangladesh Relations . . . 759

CHAPTER 1

Policies of the Developed World and Their Impact on India

1.1 Exam Framing: IR Paper and the Four Analytical Keywords

This topic flows from the syllabus point that requires knowledge of the **effect of policies of the developed world on India**, and it is taken from the global perspective because every global development is led by the great powers.

- In IR, **4 questions** are set; **2 of them test broad knowledge**, in which a single global development is given and has to be analysed.
  - One question is **abstract**; together these carry roughly **20 to 25 marks** in Paper II [as stated in lecture].
- IR answers are built on four analytical heads: **geopolitical, geostrategic, geocultural and geoeconomic**.
  - These four key words supply the finesse in terms and terminologies that the examination demands.
- The **major powers** are the US, China and Russia and, to some extent, Pakistan, India's competitor; how these powers respond to one another is what the answer must track.
- Today's first task is to write down the **key words and diplomacies** that the Indian government has to practise.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Core idea.**
>
> - All global developments are always led by the great powers.
> - Therefore the effect of the policies of the developed world on India is nothing but the **US and China**.

- Terms such as **bipolarity with multipolarity** are writing material: the same development can be described differently, and the argument is what earns marks.
- Thinkers' names are not to be mentioned unless a minister, whether in the PMO or the Foreign Minister, has himself used the term.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Syllabus point: the **effect of policies of the developed world on India**.

- In IR, **4 questions** are set, **2 of them present a global development** for broad analysis, plus one abstract question (about 20 to 25 marks in Paper II).
- Four analytical heads: **geopolitical, geostrategic, geocultural, geoeconomic**.
- Major powers: US, China, Russia and, to some extent, Pakistan.
- Because great powers lead all global developments, the effect on India is essentially **US and China**.
- Thinkers' names only if a minister has used the term; **bipolarity with multipolarity** is writing material.

1.2 Post-Cold War Transition: Unipolarity, Rules-Based Order and the Supply Chain

The transition to be traced is from the post-Cold War era to the present. **Post-Cold War means post-1991**, a period of **unipolarity**: after the USSR broke up there was clearly one major power, the US.

- The **international rules-based order** was laid in this period: everything had to be carried by the rules.
- One major change of the period was the **changing perspective on global trade**, promoted by the **establishment of the WTO**.
- With the WTO's establishment came the **free flow of labour, capital, technology and ideas**.
- This is also when the **emergence of supply chain formation** took place.
  - Trade had been happening long before; what was new was that post-1991 globalization, India's adoption of **neoliberal policies** and the rise of the US produced the supply chain as a concept.

KEY CONCEPT

Cost effectiveness — the key term of the era.

- **Cost effectiveness** means that it no longer mattered whether a country was a friend, an ally or an enemy — what mattered was which source could sustain the requirement most cheaply.
- Every country began to ask what its own advantage was.
- Post-Cold War all enemies had been eliminated and the world had one country, the US; countries therefore shifted their policies towards **geoeconomics**.
- Developed nations, post-Second World War, have always based their geopolitics on geoeconomics; from India's own perspective, this shift dates from 1991.

- Post-1991 India looked east, lost the USSR, looked for new markets and turned towards West Asia; **economic diplomacy** became important and cost effectiveness became the key.
- Whatever sustains is sourced from wherever it is available — China, Vietnam, India or Dubai.
  - This was the substance of the rules-based, cost-driven world order.

CRITICAL POINT

Criticism of the rules-based order.

- The order claimed that everything was carried by the rules, yet there was 2001, there was 2003, there are still disputes in the South China Sea, and there was Russian aggression — the **Crimean Peninsula was annexed in 2014**.
- Great powers have always believed they could do as they wished; a rules-based order did not change that.

QUICK REVISION

- Post-Cold War = **post-1991** = **unipolarity**, with the US as the one major power.
- The **international rules-based order** was laid in this period.
- The **WTO's establishment** promoted a changing perspective on global trade.
- Consequence: free flow of labour, capital, technology and ideas, and the **emergence of supply chains**.
- **Cost effectiveness** became the key: friend, ally or enemy did not matter, only the cheapest sustainable source did.
- Developed nations' geopolitics has always rested on **geoeconomics**; India turned to economic diplomacy after 1991.
- Criticism of the order: 2001, 2003, South China Sea disputes, Russian aggression, the **2014 annexation of the Crimean Peninsula**.

1.3 The Present Era: Deglobalization and Economic Nationalism

The present era is the era of deglobalization — deglobalization implies the exact opposite of globalization. This was asked in last year's Civil Services Mains.

- The developments are the same and the idea is simple; only the word given to them has changed.
  - Saying 'we have moved from unipolarity to bipolarity' is one way of putting it; others will say the world is still unipolar — both sets of arguments are the writing material.
- Deglobalization is the overarching theme of every development discussed in this lecture.

KEY CONCEPT

Why deglobalization is happening.

- **Make America Great Again**; **Bangladesh First for Bangladeshis**; **Make India Great Again**; **Generation Z protests**; and **Nepal for Nepalis**, as articulated by Balendra Shah.
- This is the exact opposite of the earlier position, when in Nepal the first meetings were with China and India.
- The upcoming world order is therefore described as **economic nationalism** — nationalism derived from economic status.

- **Geo-economics has become more important than geopolitics.**

  - **Geopolitics** means managing relations with the great powers; it still exists, but its importance has shifted to geo-economics.
- Geo-economics today means carrying out **domestic reforms** and engaging with those countries from which there is a benefit.

EXAMPLE

Trade has become selective.

- India has signed **FTAs with the EU and the UK** (the signing and status were discussed in the prelims).
- India is **re-negotiating** with the **European Free Trade Association** and is diplomatically engaged in plurilateral arrangements.
- **RCEP** would have been a strong example, but India left it in **2018–19**.
- Earlier the rule was trade with everyone; now it is trade with those with whom India has a geopolitical interest — engagement restricted to **LMCs, that is like-minded countries**.

QUICK REVISION

- Present era = **era of deglobalization**, the opposite of globalization; asked in last year's Mains.
- Drivers: **Make America Great Again, Bangladesh First for Bangladeshis, Make India Great Again, Generation Z protests, Nepal for Nepalis (Balendra Shah)**.
- New order = **economic nationalism**: nationalism derived from economic status.
- **Geo-economics has become more important than geopolitics**; geopolitics = managing relations with the great powers.
- Trade examples: **India–EU and India–UK FTAs**, re-negotiation with **EFTA**, plurilateral engagement, **RCEP left in 2018–19**.
- Trade is now restricted to **like-minded countries (LMCs)** with geopolitical interest.

1.4 Technology Superiority and Technology Sovereignty

Under deglobalization there is a **dominance of technology**: the focus of every country is technology and **technology superiority**.

- **Semiconductor diplomacy** is being pursued by India, for example with the US under trust, and India has also developed **Shakti Fab**.
- Recent visits to **South Korea** and **Singapore** also focused on semiconductor diplomacy; Singapore's Prime Minister visited India last year.
- Apart from semiconductors, the frontier areas are **quantum, biotechnology, battery storage and renewable power**.

EXAMPLE

The biggest semiconductor-diplomacy example.

- The **Netherlands**, where India is vying for close cooperation with **ASML** — the only company

of its kind in the world.

- The ASML CEO visited India, and the Prime Minister met him in the Netherlands.

- The **space race** is now better called the **moon race**.
- The US **Artemis mission** is the reference point; **Artemis 2** carried out a recent lunar flyby.
- China's missions are the **Chang'e series** — **Chang'e 6** and **Chang'e 4** are the recent ones.
- The **International Space Station** involves the US **NASA** and the **European Space Agency**, while China has its own station, **Tiangong**; Pakistan's astronaut would fly on a Chinese launch vehicle.

KEY CONCEPT

Technology sovereignty.

- **Technology sovereignty** is the new focus of nations: the best example is defence, where India is exploring co-development that finally leads to **Aatmanirbharta**.
- Technology cooperation was limited among nations earlier, and now its interaction has become even more limited.

- **South Korea**: the **K-9 Vajra** gun is being developed with South Korea by **Hanwha**, and there is an India–Korea **defence accelerator**.
- **Germany**: air-independent-propulsion, diesel-electric **HDW class** submarines are to be developed with Germany; the company is **ThyssenKrupp**; Spain was out of the race; the German Chancellor visited India.
- **Pakistan and China**: the defence-diplomacy example is the **JF-17** fighter plane.

CRITICAL POINT

Why this matters now.

- Technology cooperation always existed, but **technology sovereignty** and **technology diplomacy** were nowhere near as important as they are today.
- Every country today wants to focus on technology superiority — in semiconductors, quantum, biotechnology, batteries, space and renewable power.

QUICK REVISION

- Deglobalization is accompanied by the **dominance of technology** and the pursuit of **technology superiority**.
- **Semiconductor diplomacy**: India with the US, **Shakti Fab**, visits to **South Korea and Singapore**, cooperation with **ASML of the Netherlands**.
- Other frontier areas: **quantum, biotechnology, battery storage, renewable power** and the **moon race** (Artemis mission, Artemis 2 lunar flyby).
- China's space push: **Chang'e series (Chang'e 6, Chang'e 4)** and its own station **Tiangong**, versus the ISS of NASA and the European Space Agency.
- **Technology sovereignty** in defence: **Aatmanirbharta**, **K-9 Vajra with Hanwha**, an India–

Korea defence accelerator, **Germany's HDW class AIP submarines with ThyssenKrupp**.

- **Technology sovereignty and technology diplomacy** matter far more today than at any earlier point.

1.5 Global Trade under Deglobalization: Climate Barriers, Critical Minerals and Coercive Diplomacy

Because deglobalization is the overarching theme, the geoeconomic dimension cannot be left out — and within geo-economics, global trade itself has changed.

- **Climate barriers** have been added to trade.
- The **EU** is levying the **Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM)**, also called a carbon tax, on **steel and aluminium**.
  - This will have an effect on the exports of developing nations.
- The **UK** is introducing the same measure as CBAM, and the UK also has a **deforestation regulation**.

CRITICAL POINT

Non-tariff barriers in the name of climate.

- Under the guise of **climate change mitigation**, developed nations are imposing **non-tariff barriers** on developing nations.
- This has led to **distortion in global trade**.

- There is now a focus on **critical minerals**, because of their restricted extent and their role in the energy transition and in upcoming technologies such as **robots, space and EVs**.
- There is also the issue of **unilateral sanctions**: in recent times the US has applied sanctions on allies as well as non-allies, and tariffs as well, on nations such as **Russia** and **Iran**.
- **India faces sanctions over the import of Iranian oil and over the development of Chabahar.**

KEY CONCEPT

Coercive diplomacy.

- A **reduced role of the WTO** has led to **coercive diplomacy**.
- **Coercion means forcing**: coercive diplomacy is professing not to follow the rules of global trade while forcing another country to do, or not to do, something.
- Great powers have practised coercive diplomacy for long, but in today's deglobalizing setting the **geoeconomic perspective has to be discussed first**.

QUICK REVISION

- **Climate barriers**: the EU's **CBAM** — a carbon tax on **steel and aluminium** — will affect developing-nation exports; the **UK** is introducing the same, plus a **deforestation regulation**.
- Effect: **non-tariff barriers** under the guise of climate mitigation, leading to **distortion in**

global trade.

- **Critical minerals** matter because of their restricted extent and their role in the energy transition and in **robots, space and EVs**.
- **Unilateral sanctions and tariffs** by the US on allies and non-allies, including **Russia and Iran**; **India faces sanctions over Iranian oil and Chabahar**.
- **Reduced role of the WTO → coercive diplomacy**, where coercion means forcing.
- Coercive diplomacy is old, but today it must be read through the **geoeconomic** lens first.

1.6 Restrictive Immigration Policies and the End of Free Movement of Labour

Free movement of labour was a feature of the globalization phase. It has now become exactly the opposite: immigration policies that are restrictive and prevent the free movement of labour.

- **H-1B restrictions** in the US.
- The **UK deportation policy** — deporting illegal immigrants to **Rwanda**.
- China's coercive diplomacy with India through immigration policies: the **journalist visa** issue, and, in the broader territorial sense, **Arunachal Pradesh** and the **North East Frontier Agency (NEFA)** — a boundary concern.
- China has restricted its own workforce from working in certain **highly skilled sectors**; it has stopped engineers from going to highly skilled sectors.
- Restrictions on **top AI talent** are the least recent example; in India the sector affected is **mobile manufacturing** — an example only about a week old.

EXAMPLE

The AI-talent precedent.

- Top AI talent is like **Alan Turing** in the **1950s**, when the framework for computers was being developed.
- The US wanted the best of the best engineers and scientists from all over the world; this began with the **Second World War, from 1938 onwards**, when the US planned to take the best scientists and coercively tell them that they could not leave the country.
- Germany restricted its businesses and the US did the same — **now China is doing the same**, because cutting-edge technology is today the most important thing.

Immigration is about who enters legally; the broader reading of the same restriction is about who is allowed to move at all. This is why restrictions on labour and restrictions on technology talent are treated as one perspective.

COMPARISON

AI governance approaches.

- **US: innovation centric.**

- **Europe: rights centric.**
- **India: promotes inclusive AI.**

- There are also **supply chain restrictions**: the US did not allow **Nvidia** to export **H200 chips**, the fastest chips, to China.
- Reports from the latest deal say this is now allowed.

QUICK REVISION

- Free movement of labour has flipped to **restrictive immigration policies**.
- Examples: **US H-1B restrictions**; **UK deportation to Rwanda**; China's **journalist visa** and **Arunachal Pradesh/NEFA** boundary concern.
- China's curbs on its own workforce in **highly skilled sectors** and on engineers; restrictions on **top AI talent**; in India, **mobile manufacturing**.
- The precedent: **Alan Turing (1950s)**, US recruitment of the best scientists from **1938**, Germany's and the US's own restrictions — **China is doing the same today**.
- **AI governance**: US innovation centric, Europe rights centric, India promotes inclusive AI.
- **Supply chain restriction**: the US blocked **Nvidia's H200 chips** to China; now reportedly allowed.

1.7 Supply Chain Constraints and the New Trade Vocabulary

All of these developments have led to **supply chain constraints or restrictions**.

- The movement is from **cost effectiveness to geopolitics**, with **security considerations** as the new indicator.
- Every country would want competition, but fair competition. The US, as the unipolar power, realised that the arrangement was not playing to its tunes and was not helping it, so it began imposing constraints and restrictions.
  - Every country now follows these strategies, and India too wants to move away from the language of globalized trade towards trade with **like-minded nations**.

EXAMPLE

China plus one.

- The best example of the new trade is the **China plus one strategy**: besides China, a country that is the best and cheapest in a particular field becomes the best option for the world.
- There is no 'you plus one' — one has to be the best and cheapest option to be chosen.

Near-shoring	Relocation of industry to a nearby nation — for example, putting the factory in India, or in a Central American country where the labour cost is less.
Friend-shoring	Shifting production to friendly countries; the countries that have benefited are **Vietnam** and **Thailand**, and it can also be seen as part of the China plus one strategy.
Re-shoring	The US wants its factories relocated to its own borders or to its own neighbourhood.

- These concepts emerged in the **economic surveys**.
- **ASEAN nations** are the countries in this frame: **Vietnam, Thailand and Malaysia**.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Answer framing.

- This is a debate and a question of answer framing — the accumulation of knowledge in which **one year's keywords** have to be shown.
- The examples keep changing; the structure of the argument does not.

QUICK REVISION

- Result of all the above: **supply chain constraints and restrictions**.
- Shift from **cost effectiveness to geopolitics**, with **security considerations** as the new indicator.
- The US began imposing constraints because the arrangement stopped playing to its tunes; every country now follows, and India prefers **like-minded nations**.
- **China plus one strategy**: besides China, the best and cheapest in a field becomes the world's best option.
- **Near-shoring** (relocation to a nearby nation), **friend-shoring** (Vietnam, Thailand), **re-shoring** (factories to the US's own borders).
- **ASEAN** — Vietnam, Thailand, Malaysia — explains the frame; the concepts came from the **economic surveys**.

1.8 The Effect of Developed Policies on India: US and China

The effect of developed policies on India is nothing but the US and China. In the light of a rising China, the US is trying to engage India.

- The engagement comes as a **defence partnership**, a **technology partnership** and a **space**

partnership — the examiner will ask for examples of each.

- These examples have to be arranged into a structure: **geopolitical, geosecurity and geocultural**.

EXAMPLE

US soft power.

- English scholarship automatically attracts people; the best part of the US is English. Compare how many people say the same of Russian language.
- Nothing beats the love, affinity, soft power and cultural affiliation created by **Hollywood** films — Independence Day, Rocky, Oscar-winning films — whether one looks at China or Russia.

QUICK REVISION

- The **effect of developed policies on India is nothing but the US and China**.
- In the light of **rising China**, the US is trying to engage India.
- Engagement heads: **defence partnership, technology partnership, space partnership** — each needs examples.
- Structure the answer as **geopolitical, geosecurity and geocultural**.
- US soft power rests on **English, Hollywood films and cultural affiliation** — unmatched by China or Russia.

1.9 Choke Point Vulnerability and Why Deglobalization Is the Overarching Theme

India's choke point vulnerability is a direct product of the globalization linkage: India was importing its oil from the **UAE**, from **Saudi Arabia** and from **Iran**.

EXAMPLE

The Strait of Hormuz.

- The **Strait of Hormuz becoming weaponized by Iran** led to a **global energy shock**.
- This same choke point vulnerability is one more force pushing the world towards **deglobalization**.

- A related strategy question has been asked by UPSC on India's position with respect to **Myanmar, Bangladesh and Sri Lanka** [as stated in lecture].

DATA & FACTS

Deglobalization — the overarching theme.

- Deglobalization is the umbrella term for everything discussed; its **characteristics and features must be 100% ready**.
- Last year, in **February 2025**, the Indian Prime Minister was in the US with **Trump**; the tariff measures started in **April**.

- For last year's examination the tariff trajectory was still rising and had not peaked; **now it has peaked**.

QUICK REVISION

- India's oil imports from the **UAE, Saudi Arabia and Iran** created the **choke point vulnerability**.
- The **Strait of Hormuz became weaponized by Iran**, causing a **global energy shock**.
- Choke point vulnerability is itself a driver of **deglobalization**.
- A related UPSC strategy question concerns **Myanmar, Bangladesh and Sri Lanka**.
- **February 2025**: the Prime Minister was in the US with Trump; tariffs began in **April**.
- The tariff trajectory had not peaked last year; **it has peaked now**.

1.10 US-Led Developments: The Return of Transactional Foreign Policy

The first of the perspectives is the **US-led block**. The US, Japan and South Korea count as one block, because they are all US allies.

KEY CONCEPT

Transactional foreign policy.

- There is a **return of transactional foreign policy**, which is lacking in sound principles, ethos and values; it is usable in IR as well as in GS4.
- The movement is from a **rules-based liberal order** to a **tariff-based, inward and deal-based** order.

- Earlier, Nehru or any big leader, or Clinton or Reagan, visiting a country spoke about the basics of foreign policy — the values of one's own country and their affinity with the other's.
- **Democratic congruence** is the biggest strength of the US–India relationship, which neither China nor Russia has.
  - Now the focus is only deals: 200 million dollars with them, China buys **200 Boeing**, Africa buys AI chips, India buys the **A15** — deal closed. Principles, ethos and values are set aside.

EXAMPLE

The businessman analogy.

- Like a businessman closing a deal, the only objective is the deal itself — maximum customers and the revenue from them; values are set aside as business.
- The same logic applies to US foreign policy: **Saudi Arabia investing 200 billion dollars in AI** is the point of the conversation, even if Jamal Khashoggi was killed.

- **Strategic ambiguity** is a new challenge for India — the term itself should not be used; what it means here is **unpredictability**.
- Examples: the quick transition from the imposition of tariffs on China to a recent summit at which China and the US were mentioned as **G2** by the US President, and the recent

rapprochement with China.

- **Sanctions-driven foreign policy**: sanctions on Russian oil for India.
- This comes together with a restrictive **immigration policy** — **H-1B** for Indian immigrants.
- **Overall decline in multilateralism**: the US is leaving **UNFCCC** and more than **60 international organizations**, and is even threatening to leave **NATO**.
- **Decline in transatlantic and trans-Pacific cooperation**: provision of old submarines to **Australia** under **AUKUS**.
- **NATO** allies are threatened to increase their spending to **5.5% of GDP**.
- The **annexation of Greenland**.

QUICK REVISION

- The **US-led block** is the US, Japan and South Korea — all US allies.
- **Transactional foreign policy** lacks principles, ethos and values; usable in IR and GS4.
- Shift from **rules-based liberal order** to **tariff-based, inward, deal-based** policy; **democratic congruence** remains the US–India strength.
- Deals illustrate the shift: **200 million dollars, 200 Boeing, AI chips, A15**; Saudi Arabia's **200 billion dollar AI investment** despite Khashoggi.
- New challenge for India: **strategic ambiguity = unpredictability**, seen in the move from tariffs on China to a **G2 summit** and **rapprochement with China**.
- **Sanctions-driven policy** on Russian oil plus **H-1B** immigration curbs; **decline in multilateralism** — UNFCCC and **60-plus organizations**, threat to leave NATO.
- **Transatlantic/trans-Pacific drift**: submarines to Australia under **AUKUS**, NATO spending pressure to **5.5% of GDP**, **annexation of Greenland**.

1.11 China as India's Strategic Challenge

For China, which is discussed separately, only two words are needed in a global-development answer: **China is India's strategic challenge**.

DATA & FACTS

China's grip on critical minerals.

- **60%** of critical minerals are produced in China and **90%** of processing capacities are with China.
- **Critical minerals are primarily the rare earth elements**, which can simply be written as **REEs**.

- China therefore exercises **supply chain control**, especially with respect to critical minerals.

EXAMPLE

Back-to-back visits, 2026.

- The example is the **back-to-back visits of the US and Russian Presidents to China in 2026** — always mention the year in an example.
- Never write two examples back to back in an answer.
- The visits send a **strategic message** about the **rise of China**; observations of this kind are the substance of foreign policy, because a diplomat does not always express what has to be expressed.

- India, and the world, should **not overestimate the possibilities with China and not underestimate the capabilities of the US**: no matter how great the rise of China, the US will always remain the US.
- Even if all **193 nations** were to visit China for the next **193 days**, that only informs the title 'rise of China'.
  - As a strategic learning for India, if any power in the world rules the rules, that is **100% the US**.
- West Asia shows that powers can be overestimated; for India and all South Asian nations the US lens is a different one.

1.11.1 US Outreach in South Asia

- The South Asian framework — Myanmar, Nepal, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka and Pakistan — is read through the US lens.
  - Increasing cooperation between the US and India, US and Bangladesh, US and Sri Lanka and US and Pakistan is seen as counterbalancing; the equation is not with US and Nepal.
- On Bangladesh it is said that **Muhammad Yunus** will be propped up — and the question posed is: **who did it? The US.**
- Trump said last year that how Bangladesh has to be handled is Bangladesh's own problem — a subtle signal to decide for oneself.
  - It shows the US is happy if there is strategic congruence and an improvement of India's diplomatic relationships with all its neighbours, barring obviously Pakistan.
- The point is **counterbalancing** — which is why others should not be underestimated: 'this is why you don't underestimate me.'

QUICK REVISION

- For a global-development answer on China, two words suffice: **China is India's strategic challenge**.
- China produces **60%** of critical minerals and holds **90%** of processing capacities; critical minerals are mainly **rare earth elements (REEs)**.
- Example: **back-to-back visits of the US and Russian Presidents to China in 2026**; always mention the year.
- Do **not overestimate China and do not underestimate the US** — if any power rules the rules, that is **100% the US**.
- The 'all **193 nations** for **193 days**' illustration only informs the title **rise of China**.

- South Asia is read through the US lens: US–India, US–Bangladesh (**Muhammad Yunus**), US–Sri Lanka, US–Pakistan; **Trump's Bangladesh remark** signals congruence.
- The lesson is **counterbalancing** — do not underestimate the US.

1.12 Present Times: Competitive Multipolarity and the Position of the Great Powers

KEY CONCEPT

Competitive multipolarity.

- The present times are best called **competitive multipolarity**, in which **unipolarity is no more the scenario**.

- **US**: its single focus is to preserve **US primacy** — the world's helmsman should remain the same.
  - Since it is falling, however much remains must be saved and must not be allowed to go negative.
- **Russia**: it has accepted in the Asian order that it stands alongside China's leadership; Putin's focus is basically **challenging the Western security order**.
- **China**: it is trying to **reshape the regional order**, forcing boundary disputes with Pakistan.
  - The analysis was that a China–Bangladesh axis could form [as stated in lecture].
- The **US National Security Strategy 2025** is a reference point; China is a **threat — technologically, 100% threat**.
- **Middle powers** include **Brazil** and **India**.
- Examples: India's visit to the **Nordic nations** and the **EU President's visit to India** for **Republic Day**; the **India–EU FTA**; the **India–EFTA FTA**.

When this much churn is happening at the top, the countries below will automatically diversify. Many examples exist, but they must be kept tight unless the question demands more — the same points recur across IR answers.

QUICK REVISION

- Present times = **competitive multipolarity**; **unipolarity is no more the scenario**.
- **US**: preserve **primacy** — save what remains, go no lower.
- **Russia**: accepted its place alongside China in the Asian order; **challenging the Western security order**.
- **China**: reshaping the regional order, boundary disputes with Pakistan, possible China–Bangladesh axis; **US National Security Strategy 2025** as reference; China is a **100% technological threat**.
- **Middle powers**: Brazil and India.
- Diversification examples: **Nordic nations visit**, **EU President's Republic Day visit**, **India–EU**

FTA, **India–EFTA FTA**.

1.13 Geopolitical, Geoeconomic and Geostrategic Developments

The developments already listed — transactional foreign policy, sanctions-driven policy, the decline in multilateralism and the transatlantic and trans-Pacific drift — are the **geopolitical** developments. The **geoeconomic** developments were discussed under deglobalization. The third and final head is the **geo-strategic** developments.

- First, **West Asia instability**, where the region is a theatre of great-power involvement.
- Second, **maritime choke point vulnerability**.
- Third, the **rise of asymmetric warfare**, in which drones are used — **swarm drones** and **first-person-view (FPV) drones**.
- Fourth, **AI-based threats** — the Iran war was the **world's first AI war**.

EXAMPLE

Drones in Ukraine.

- Ukrainian soldiers hid drones inside a truck, flew them out and destroyed an air base; it was like a **video game operated by Ukrainian soldiers**.
- The drone view is like wearing glasses — the operator sees the whole field.

- The **emergence of AI tools** is a separate discussion, to be taken up with **cybersecurity (GS Paper 3, internal security)**.
- The concern today is no longer terror alone but **cyber vulnerability**; India's **critical infrastructure** has vulnerabilities of its own [as stated in lecture].

CRITICAL POINT

Where these terms come from.

- These terms come from **research papers and expert views**, not from the usual newspapers.
- For the Iran war as the world's first AI war, these are exactly the words to use.

QUICK REVISION

- Three heads: **geopolitical** (transactional policy, sanctions, multilateralism decline, transatlantic drift), **geoeconomic** (deglobalization), **geostrategic**.
- Geostrategic elements: **West Asia instability** as a theatre of great-power involvement; **maritime choke point vulnerability**.
- **Asymmetric warfare**: **swarm drones** and **FPV drones**.
- **AI-based threats**: the Iran war was the **world's first AI war**.
- Ukraine example: drones smuggled in a truck destroyed an air base — a **video game operated by soldiers**.
- **AI tools** and **cyber vulnerability** will be taken up with **GS Paper 3 internal security**; critical

infrastructure vulnerabilities remain.

1.14 Global Powers Reshaping the Order and the Parallel Systems

Globally, **great powers are reshaping the global economic order** with an overlapping network of trade flows, technology ecosystems and ideological narratives, plus sanctions — for example sanctions on **Iran**.

- In response, **China and Russia are expanding parallel systems**: **BRICS Plus**, the **New Development Bank** and the **Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank**.
- **Russia is developing energy corridors with China.**
- There is also a focus on **de-dollarization**.

EXAMPLE

De-dollarization in practice.

- The best example is **October 2024**, when the **BRICS currency** was discussed.
- There is also trade between **Russia and China** and between **China and Iran** in **local currency**.

Here, great power means the US and China. The US, along with the other nations, is trying to reshape the order — and the phrase used is **global economic order** because **geo-economics now decides geopolitics**. This is the response that all these developments are producing.

QUICK REVISION

- Great powers are **reshaping the global economic order** through overlapping networks of trade flows, technology ecosystems and ideological narratives, plus sanctions (for example on **Iran**).
- China and Russia are expanding **parallel systems**: **BRICS Plus, New Development Bank, Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank**.
- **Russia is developing energy corridors with China.**
- The focus on **de-dollarization**: the **October 2024 BRICS currency** discussion; **Russia–China** and **China–Iran** trade in **local currency**.
- Great power here means the **US and China**; the phrase is **global economic order** because **geo-economics now decides geopolitics**.

1.15 The Iran War: Lessons for India and Nuclear Governance

After the Iran war the whole world took one lesson — this is the **biggest geostrategic takeaway**.

- For a country like India it taught something very interesting: **reduce dependence on fossil fuels**.
- **Supply chain vulnerability** and **critical minerals** are the related concerns.
- From a security perspective — **internal security** and external security — **geography is becoming a tool of geostrategy**, as seen at the choke points.

- **Asymmetric cost**: military cost has become a factor that the great powers had not evaluated, so India must **indigenize its ecosystem**.
  - In operations, cost was 100% a factor — the **Kargil war** taught the need for agility in troop movement.
- **Iran was an NPT signatory**: it signed the **NPT**, fulfilled the safeguards for its civilian reactors and allowed the **IAEA** to come, visit, visualise and see.
- When the attacks took place, in **June 2025**, all the evaluation that the IAEA had done was in place.

CRITICAL POINT

What the rest of the world learnt.

- A signatory power that had agreed to the **IAEA safeguards** was treated as having **no value**: a big country came and bombarded it only on the presumption that it had a nuclear bomb.
- The IAEA had said it was **95%** uranium enriched; enrichment is done by every country that runs a light water reactor, and **60 to 70% of the world's reactors are light water reactors**.

- The development is therefore **compromised nuclear governance**, which may lead to **nuclear weapon proliferation** or force **effective deterrence**.

EXAMPLE

The India–Pakistan precedent.

- India became a nuclear power; **Pakistan tested 10 days later**, saying that it now had a nuclear power on its **eastern front**; Pakistan is the **only Muslim state to have a nuclear weapon**.
- What India and Pakistan went through post-independence, that is post-partition, will now be witnessed by the nations of the world, specifically **West Asia**.

- The attacks **targeted nuclear installations** — **Bushehr**, **Natanz** and **Cordoba** [as stated in lecture].
- So where does the signatory go? It will no longer believe in the IAEA and will take the path of **nuclear deterrence** by developing a nuclear bomb — **nuclear proliferation is going to happen**.
- The **role of maritime security has increased**.

QUICK REVISION

- Biggest takeaway of the Iran war: **reduce dependence on fossil fuels**; address **supply chain vulnerability** and **critical minerals**.
- **Geography is becoming a tool of geostrategy** at choke points; **asymmetric cost** makes military cost a factor, so India must **indigenize** (lesson of **Kargil**).
- **Iran was an NPT signatory** with IAEA safeguards in place; attacks came in **June 2025**.
- A safeguarded signatory was bombarded on presumption alone — **95% enrichment**; **60 to 70% of world reactors are light water reactors**.

- Result: **compromised nuclear governance** and possible **nuclear proliferation** or forced **effective deterrence**.
- The **India–Pakistan precedent**: Pakistan tested **10 days after** India and is the **only Muslim nuclear state**; West Asia will now live this.
- Sites targeted: **Bushehr, Natanz and Cordoba**; the signatory will turn to **nuclear deterrence**; **maritime security's role has increased**.

1.16 India's Response: Uncertainty, Shifting Alliances and Strategic Autonomy

Now to India's response. The **effect of these developments** and the **challenges thrown by these developments** imply the same thing, and both must be answered together.

1.16.1 Challenges

- **Challenge 1 — recalibration and uncertainty**: India has to recalibrate; the example is recalibration after the **US–China rapprochement**.
  - Uncertainty — 'I don't know, something can happen' — is the first challenge: today they are friends, tomorrow they may not be.
- **Challenge 2 — shifting alliances**: traditional allies and alliances have given way to new partnerships, arrangements, alliances or security measures.
  - From **NATO** to **US-Pacific** to **US–EU cooperation**, there is now **diversification away from the US**, practised by the EU, Japan and South Korea, along with the **US's accommodation of China**.
  - The challenge is to **manage India with respect to the global powers**.
- **Challenge 3 — retaining or exercising strategic autonomy**: from unipolar, the world has moved to what can be referred to as **negotiated bipolarity**, or a multipolar world with bipolar or unipolar characteristics.
- **Multi-vectored multi-alignment**: (1) manage increasing polarity; (2) deepen the US partnership without getting into an alliance.
  - Active cooperation with the **Gulf, Europe, Japan and Australia**.
  - Avoid excessive dependence on different poles and maintain an independent position on **West Asia**, **Japan** (the **cautious neutrality policy**), **Taiwan**, and **tariff and sanctions**.
- **Challenge 4 — China**: manage border stability; reduce import dependence without harming the domestic value chain (the example is imports of **solar cells** and **APIs** for the solar module and pharma industries).
  - Counter China's rising influence in the neighbourhood, which will be taken up with the neighbourhood policy.
  - China's **military, political, economic and strategic support to Pakistan**, and its **dominance over supply chain and technology**.

KEY CONCEPT

The 3 A's.

- **Autonomy, Alignment and Ambition** — the three things India has to manage at once.
- This diagram very well captures the Indian foreign-policy dilemma or challenge in the present world, where developed-world policies are changing.

- The overall formulation is **economic interdependence with strategic caution**.
- As per the Foreign Minister, India only believes in **partners** — it does not believe in getting into alliances with any particular bloc or nation.

QUICK REVISION

- The **effect of the developments** and the **challenges thrown by them** are the same thing and are answered together.
- Challenge 1: **recalibration and uncertainty**, example the **US–China rapprochement**.
- Challenge 2: **shifting alliances** — NATO, US-Pacific and US–EU giving way to new arrangements; **diversification away from the US** by the EU, Japan and South Korea; the US's **accommodation of China**.
- Challenge 3: **strategic autonomy** in a world of **negotiated bipolarity**; **multi-vectored multi-alignment** and **cautious neutrality** on West Asia, Japan, Taiwan, tariffs and sanctions.
- Challenge 4: **China** — border stability, import dependence (solar cells, APIs), neighbourhood influence, support to Pakistan, supply chain and technology dominance.
- The **3 A's — Autonomy, Alignment, Ambition**; the overall stance is **economic interdependence with strategic caution**, with **partners and not alliances**.

1.17 Global South Leadership: Opportunity and Challenge

Global South leadership is an opportunity as well as a responsibility or a challenge — the number of opportunities also creates n-squared challenges.

- The Global South wants **debt relief**.
- It wants **food plus energy plus water plus technological security**.
- It wants **climate security**, which will come when **adaptation-related finance** is delivered to it.

CRITICAL POINT

Who will deliver?.

- **'Rules are to be followed by the one who are meek'** — this is often said in a developing society.
- Who will ensure all of this for the Global South, and who will make the developed nations fulfil these expectations?
- If you have a demand against a great power you cannot sit away — you have to go through a

proper channel.

- In the recent Iran war, **African nations had no stakes and Asia-Pacific nations had no stakes**; nobody would listen to them.
  - India has to play the role of a **protagonist** in ensuring that the war ends.
- India organised the **Voice of Global South Summit three times** and projected itself as a leader.
  - But with a policy of **cautious neutrality**, how will India ensure that the war ends and the ceasefire happens, and thereby automatically ensure the supply of energy essentials?

COMPARISON

India and China on the Iran war.

- **India**: professes **cautious neutrality**, which leaves open how it will end the war and secure the ceasefire and the energy supply.
- **China**: a clear policy — it condemned the **US aggression along with Israel and Iran** and, through sending envoys, **openly supported Pakistan**.
- Nobody sees Pakistan as a leader — Pakistan is very low; the comparison is about the clarity of policy [as stated in lecture].

- Leadership demands a **bigger heart**: if Pakistan and India have the worst possible diplomatic relationship, that is none of the business of an African nation that wants its demands fulfilled.
- India cannot carry personal animosity to the global front; it has to balance its neighbourhood while keeping its responsibilities in mind.
- Given the war and the churn, **global leadership has become complicated for India** — that is the **biggest geopolitical impact**.

QUICK REVISION

- Global South leadership is an **opportunity and a challenge**; opportunities also create n-squared challenges.
- The Global South's demands: **debt relief**, **food, energy, water and technological security**, and **climate security** through adaptation finance.
- **'Rules are to be followed by the one who are meek'** — somebody must ensure delivery; demands against great powers need a channel.
- In the **Iran war**, African and Asia-Pacific nations had no stakes; India must be the **protagonist** who ends the war.
- India has organised the **Voice of Global South Summit three times**; **cautious neutrality** raises the question of how the war and energy supply will be secured.
- **China's clearer policy** — condemning US aggression with Israel and Iran and openly backing Pakistan through envoys; Pakistan is not seen as a leader.
- Consequence: **global leadership has become complicated for India**.

1.18 Challenges of Leading the Global South and of the Multilateral Order

1.18.1 Challenges

- **Lead the Global South without appearing anti-West**: criticising the US would put every partnership — every light water reactor deal and the Shanti Act — down the drain [as stated in lecture].
- **Delivery-based diplomacy**: big claims must give way to results.
- **Climate justice**: balance climate justice with India's own energy transition — both are wanted, and that is the difficulty.
- **Mobilise climate finance and reform multilateral institutions** — IMF, WTO, UN.
- **The dilemma of democracy and human rights**: India is the largest democracy; how can it engage with partners who have human rights violations?
- **Ensuring multilateralism**: **UNSC reforms are blocked**; the **WTO's dispute settlement body is not functional**; climate finance and justice are inadequate; the US has left **UNFCCC**.
  - **Technology governance is pro-West**, for example in **space global commons and space governance**, and in **cyber**.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Challenge: lead the Global South **without appearing anti-West** — criticism of the US would cost every partnership and the light water reactor and Shanti Act arrangements.
> - Challenge: **delivery-based diplomacy** — results, not big claims.
> - Challenge: **climate justice versus India's own energy transition**.
> - Challenge: **climate finance and reform of IMF, WTO and UN**.
> - Challenge: the **democracy and human rights dilemma** for the largest democracy.
> - Challenge: **ensuring multilateralism** — UNSC reforms blocked, WTO dispute settlement non-functional, inadequate climate finance, US exit from **UNFCCC**.
> - **Technology governance is pro-West** — space global commons, space governance and cyber.

1.19 Geoeconomic Challenges: Trade Growth, Supply Chains and Choke Points

1.19.1 Challenges

- **Weaponization of trade through tariffs and sanctions** is the central geoeconomic challenge.
- India's trade policy has to balance **economic growth** and **strategic autonomy** — what India needs to balance is precisely this.
- Example: the dilemma of **US tariffs** compromising the growth of India's textile sector may force India to accept the sanctions.
  - If India adheres to unilateral sanctions to save its textile industry — **Karur and Coimbatore in Tamil Nadu**, textiles in **Gujarat** — it falls into the trap of not being autonomous.
  - If India wants strategic autonomy, it must look for **alternative partners**.

- **Two contrasting examples**: on the US-led sanctions on the import of **Iranian oil**, India followed the sanctions and diversified; when the US levied sanctions on **Russian oil** imports, India did not reduce its imports.
  - **Approximately 40% of India's oil now comes from Russia** — there India upheld its strategic autonomy and independent interest.
- **Reorganisation of trade** [as stated in lecture].
- Ensure **supply chain resilience**, reduce dependence on China and manage **critical minerals or the critical mineral value chain**, which is dominated by China.
- **China plus one investments**: India faces competition from **Vietnam, Indonesia, Mexico and Malaysia**, which are already ahead in attracting US investment.
- **Choke point vulnerability**: India depends on the **Strait of Hormuz**, **Bab-el-Mandeb** and the **Strait of Malacca**.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Geoeconomic challenge: **weaponization of trade** through tariffs and sanctions.
> - India's trade policy must balance **economic growth** and **strategic autonomy**.
> - Textile example: **US tariffs** may force acceptance of sanctions; saving **Karur, Coimbatore and Gujarat textiles** at the cost of autonomy is a trap — alternatives lie in **other partners**.
> - Contrasting cases: India **diversified away from Iranian oil** under sanctions, but did **not reduce Russian oil imports** — roughly **40% of India's oil comes from Russia**.
> - Supply chain and **critical mineral value chain** dependence on China; **China plus one** competition from **Vietnam, Indonesia, Mexico, Malaysia**.
> - Choke points: **Strait of Hormuz, Bab-el-Mandeb, Strait of Malacca**.

1.20 Geostrategic and Security Challenges

1.20.1 Challenges

- A **two-front nexus between China and Pakistan** is a joint security and border threat; **Operation Sindoor** exhibited the collaboration.
- **China's growing maritime presence**: **Djibouti** in Africa, and the **Western Indian Ocean** has become an important theatre.
  - Draw the map with a precise heading — the picture it shows is the **encircling of India, or containment**.
- **Asymmetric warfare**: the use of **swarm drones**, seen in Ukraine, by Pakistan and in the West Asian conflict; **AI-enabled warfare**, with the example of the US **LUCAS system**; and **information warfare**.
- **Connectivity-related challenges**: **IMEC**, the **International North–South Transport Corridor** and **Chabahar** are susceptible to sanctions and regional conflicts.
- **Non-traditional security threats**: **narco-terrorism**, **piracy**, **fake Indian currency notes (FICN)** and **damage to undersea cables**.
- **Maritime security**: the West Asian conflict makes the **Western Indian Ocean** a conflict or war

theatre; the example is a **US submarine attacking the Iranian ship Iris Dena** as it returned after an international fleet review from India.

- **Asymmetric warfare, again**: the use of drones was exhibited by Pakistan, and Pakistan has access to all these drones from the Chinese, along with **Iranian cooperation** — though not visible, it could easily have been used.
- **The biggest loss was information warfare**: after the war, Pakistani media and diplomatic channels spread the false news of a clear-cut violation of territorial sovereignty, even though they were the ones responsible, through **proxy support to non-state actors**, for the **Pahalgam crisis**.
  - They spread fake news that important Indian cities had been bombarded; that battle was lost, and it was **information warfare** alone.
- **Piracy** has always been a threat: the **Houthis** have been responsible for attacks on **Indian seafarers and Indian ships**.
- Traditional and non-traditional security threats have been discussed in the **internal security lecture** taken last year — those points should be revisited.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - **Two-front nexus of China and Pakistan**: joint security and border threat; **Operation Sindoor** showed the collaboration.
> - **China's maritime presence**: **Djibouti**, the **Western Indian Ocean**, and the map of the **encircling of India or containment**.
> - **Asymmetric warfare**: **swarm drones** in Ukraine, Pakistan and West Asia; **AI-enabled warfare** (**LUCAS system**); **information warfare**.
> - **Connectivity under threat**: **IMEC, INSTC, Chabahar** — exposed to sanctions and regional conflict.
> - **Non-traditional threats**: **narco-terrorism, piracy, FICN, undersea cable damage**.
> - **Maritime security**: the **Western Indian Ocean** as a war theatre; the **US submarine attack on Iris Dena** after an international fleet review from India.
> - **Information warfare** was the biggest loss — false Pakistani claims and the **Pahalgam crisis**; **Houthi piracy** threatens Indian seafarers and ships.

1.21 Way Forward: India's Diplomatic Strategy

While writing the answer, **steps or the way forward must always be written**. There is no need to label the way forward with the geopolitical and geoeconomic heads; some political scientists value those keywords, but when writing what more needs to be done, something large has to be discussed.

- **Indo-African Digital Partnership** is a keyword to carry into the way forward: for instance, **IIT Delhi in Zanzibar**, and **DPI** — the low-cost innovation and scalable technology that India offers.
- **Generation Z protests**: Generation Z uses the internet, so internet technology is the **USP**

when engaging with a country like **Nepal** (the country of **Balendra Shah**) — a significant opportunity.

1. **Practise sectoral plurilateralism**: plurilateralism means sector by sector — the areas in which partnership is to be projected will have different partners.
2. **Build issue-based partnerships and mini-lateralism** rather than large groupings.
3. **Leverage India's DPI** — Aadhaar, UPI and DigiLocker.
4. **Increase India's say in technological governance** by first promoting tech sovereignty domestically.
5. **Project India as a geo-economic power** and integrate economic policy with foreign policy.
6. **Give delivery-based leadership to the Global South.**
7. **Strengthen maritime capabilities and the role of first responder in the Indian Ocean Region.**
8. **Diversify engagement.**

- Sectoral plurilateralism in practice: for **AI**, a sectoral partnership will not include Africa.
  - For **critical minerals**, the partnership will not only include Africa but also neighbouring **Myanmar**.
  - For **green technology**, it will never include an African nation — it will always include a **Nordic nation**.
  - For **defence**, it will never be with **Norway or Finland** but with **South Korea, Japan or Sweden**; **Sweden is developing a joint manufacturing plant in Haryana**.
- **Issue-based partnerships**: **Quad** for the Indo-Pacific, and the **Colombo Security Conclave** for the Indian Ocean, where **Seychelles** recently became a member.
  - Indian Ocean issues are **maritime domain awareness, maritime security and free and open sea lanes of communication**; the Quad's motive in the Indo-Pacific is a **free and open Indo-Pacific**.
  - The **Supply Chain Resilience Initiative** with **India, Japan and Australia** was formed in **2021**; the **Eurofighter Typhoon** is another example on the list.
- The idea is to **prevent large groupings with vague shared values** and move towards **smaller mini-lateral focused partnerships in sectors**, because such partnerships help middle powers **set standards, develop capabilities and have interdependence**.
  - Example: in **1951, six nations formed the European Economic Community**, which went on to become the **EU**; interdependence created by groupings has made conflict too costly.
- **DPI as an alternative**: India can leverage **Aadhaar, UPI and DigiLocker**, which can emerge as an alternative to the US model controlled by big tech companies and to China's problem of **surveillance**.
  - The example is the **US banning Huawei** over 5G equipment on charges of surveillance.
  - In **Africa**, India engages on the basis of **values**; India's civilizational value connection with Africa is different, which creates opportunities.
  - **I2U2 (India, Israel, UAE, USA)**, **IMEC** as a connectivity objective and the **International North–South Transport Corridor** are further examples.

- **Technological governance**: promote **tech sovereignty** domestically — the **National Quantum Mission launched in 2023**, the **India AI Mission** and the **bio-economy policy**.
  - For **AI**, collaborate with **France** (open-weight AI research), the **UAE** (investment capital) and **Japan** (capability to build partnerships), while India brings the **workforce** and **market** that nobody else has, as compared with the US and China.
  - This will enable India **to set standards in emerging tech** — the example is the **recent AI summit organised by India**, at which so many countries and CEOs participated.
- **Geo-economic power and domestic reforms**: focus not only on stabilising relations with the US and maintaining a strategic balance with China, but also on promoting domestic economic reforms in **trade, tech, capital flow and supply chain**.
  - Therefore **economic policy has to be integrated with foreign policy**.
  - Domestic reform examples: **GST 2.0**, taxation reforms and **labour codes or labour reforms**.
  - Economics decides foreign policy: unless the economy is strong no welfare in the country can happen and foreign policy will remain the same — focusing on the economy leads to strong diplomatic relations.
- From the IR and political science perspective, large-scale macro reforms are fine — inflation management and industrial production (**the latest IIP statistics**) — but the two major reforms are **land, labour and capital** (banking), and they matter more.
  - Therefore **the path to becoming an aspiring power goes through an aspiring resilient economy**.
- Reform examples: the **RDI scheme**, **innovation**, the **Electronic Component Manufacturing Scheme (ECMS)** and the **Indian Semiconductor Mission 2.0**.
  - **12 semiconductor plants are already complete under ISM 1.0**, showing that economic resilience and technology sovereignty are an ingrained focus and that domestic policy is connected to foreign policy.
- **Secure supply chains and critical minerals** through **critical mineral diplomacy** — secure critical minerals and be a part of the **critical mineral value chain** and of **national security partnerships**.
- **Delivery-based leadership of the Global South**: the **International Big Cat Alliance**; the **India–Africa Union Summit postponed because of Ebola**; **AU membership of the G20**; a commitment to **ASEAN centrality** in the Indo-Pacific; **IORA**; **IONS**; the **Pacific Islands**.
- **Maritime capabilities**: strengthen maritime capabilities and the role as **first responder in the Indian Ocean Region** — ensure **maritime security** and **humanitarian assistance and disaster relief (HADR)**.
- **Diversify engagement**: the example is the recent engagement with the **EU** and **Cyprus**.

With this the full strategy is covered: what the government wants, what the challenges are and what it will do. **AI governance diplomacy** will be discussed separately.

QUICK REVISION

- Always write a **way forward**; no head-labelling is needed there.
- **Sectoral plurilateralism** — different sectors, different partners (AI, critical minerals, green technology, defence).
- **Issue-based, mini-lateral partnerships**: Quad, **Colombo Security Conclave with Seychelles**, **Supply Chain Resilience Initiative 2021**.
- **Prevent vague large groupings**; the **1951 European Economic Community** shows how interdependence makes conflict costly.
- **DPI (Aadhaar, UPI, DigiLocker)** as an alternative to US big tech and Chinese surveillance; **I2U2, IMEC, INSTC**; Africa engagement based on **values**.
- **Tech sovereignty — National Quantum Mission (2023)**, India AI Mission, bio-economy policy; AI with **France, UAE, Japan**; **AI summit** as a standard-setting example.
- **Geo-economic power**: integrate economic policy with foreign policy (**GST 2.0**, taxation, labour codes); land, labour, capital reforms; **RDI, ECMS, Indian Semiconductor Mission 2.0 with 12 plants under ISM 1.0**; **delivery-based Global South leadership** (Big Cat Alliance, AU in G20, ASEAN centrality, IORA, IONS, Pacific Islands), **HADR and first-responder role**, and **diversified engagement (EU, Cyprus)**.

1.22 Official MEA Keywords for Answers

A box should be made of **all the keywords that can be used in the examination**. All of them are **official** — the list of keywords used by the **Ministry of External Affairs** — and they are to be used region-wise, as per one's own discussion.

Neighbourhood (also usable for the Indian Ocean Region and the Indo-Pacific)	**Reliable partner**; **dependable friend**; **first responder**; **net security provider** or **regional security provider**.
Global South leadership	**First voice of the Global South**; a **bridge between the Global North and the Global South**; a **development partner and not a donor hegemon**.
World leader	A **civilizational state with modern capabilities**; a **multi-aligned power**; a **reformist power**; **Vishwabandhu**.

- **Neighbourhood**: the best example of the first responder is **Operation Brahma**, launched in the aftermath of the **earthquake in Myanmar in 2025**, and also **Operation Dost**; the same terms work for the Indian Ocean Region and the Indo-Pacific.
- **Global South**: 'a development partner and not a donor hegemon' is used in the context of

Africa, South Asia, the Caribbean and the Pacific Islands.

- **World leader**: the **most important part** is being a **civilizational state with modern capabilities** — India combines **Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam** with **DPI, vaccines, space, tech and development partnerships**.
- As a **multi-aligned power**, India is a member of **Quad plus SCO plus BRICS**, with engagement with **Iran, the Gulf and US–Israel**.
- As a **reformist power**, India focuses on **multilateralism plus UNSC reforms plus norms**.
- All these adjectives, along with being **Vishwabandhu**, are what the government has used over the past many months.

KEY CONCEPT

NORM.

- **NORM = New Orientation for a Reformed Multilateral System** — the norm used during India's **UNSC membership in 2021–22**.
- India believes in **reformed multilateralism**; the government can mix and match these keywords, but they are official.

- Reference was also made to India's **UNSC non-permanent membership (2021)** and to a contest in which **Pakistan mobilised immediately** and India lost out — described as a diplomatic loss [as stated in lecture].

QUICK REVISION

- Keep a box of **official MEA keywords**, usable region-wise.
- **Neighbourhood / Indian Ocean / Indo-Pacific**: reliable partner, dependable friend, **first responder** (Operation Brahma, 2025 Myanmar earthquake; Operation Dost), **net security provider**.
- **Global South**: first voice of the Global South, bridge between North and South, **development partner and not a donor hegemon** (Africa, South Asia, Caribbean, Pacific Islands).
- **World leader**: civilizational state with modern capabilities (**Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam** plus DPI, vaccines, space, tech), multi-aligned power (**Quad plus SCO plus BRICS**), reformist power.
- **Vishwabandhu**; and **NORM = New Orientation for a Reformed Multilateral System** (UNSC 2021–22).

CHAPTER 2

Various Diplomacies in India's Foreign Policy

2.1 Various Diplomacies: A New Framework for India's Foreign Policy

Various diplomacies is a new way to understand the topic, replacing the earlier approach of discussing one bilateral relationship at a time.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Framework for every diplomacy.**
>
> - Define the diplomacy → identify the **challenges** → list the **steps taken** → state the **way forward**.
> - Wherever trade and geoeconomic dimensions exist, you must cover all the countries with India, the challenges and the way forward.

- Diplomacy now spans several new lenses — **quantum diplomacy, AI diplomacy, energy diplomacy and economic diplomacy**.

> **PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION**
>
> **Exam relevance.**
>
> - This year's exam asked which agreement India signed with **Germany** — which of the following was or was not signed.
> - A likely framing: **critical minerals** is a very important fulcrum of India's geopolitics — discuss the challenges and the steps taken by India.
> - The question on **energy security** has already come two or three times.

Prepare every diplomacy on the same template — definition, challenges, steps taken and way forward.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Approach of substantiation.**
>
> - Marks come from concrete examples, not assertions. Roughly **20-25 agreements** were signed (as explained by Indian Express); remember the major ones — **critical minerals, semiconductors and technology**.
> - Example: a semiconductor agreement with **Japan**, with **South Korea**.
> - Way forward is an extension of the steps taken, so add one example in brackets: recent engagement with South Korea on semiconductor development (**chip diplomacy**); diversification

with African nations such as **Angola**; gas from the **Rovuma Basin, Mozambique**.

- Have **broad knowledge** of all nations in the news, all regional organisations, the meetings in the news and their broad developments.
- **Knowledge-based acquisition first, then structure** — read The Hindu and Indian Express and then organise the facts under headings.

QUICK REVISION

- **Various diplomacies** is the new lens that replaces the bilateral-relations approach.
- The universal framework: **define** → **challenges** → **steps taken** → **way forward**.
- Kinds of diplomacy: quantum, AI, energy, economic.
- Wherever geoeconomic and trade dimensions exist, cover the countries, the challenges and the way forward.
- Substantiate with current examples — semiconductors, critical minerals, technology.
- Way forward = steps taken + one example each.

2.2 Energy Diplomacy

2.2.1 Definition and Core Idea

Energy diplomacy basically means the **steps a nation takes for energy security**.

KEY CONCEPT

What is energy diplomacy?.

- Diplomatic steps taken by a nation that involve, **first, ensuring energy security**.
- **Second, energy transition** — energy security is not to be thought of only in terms of fossil fuels.
- **Third, access to critical minerals** — write this separately so the examiner sees it.
- **Fourth, climate justice** — that is, ensuring **JET (Just Energy Transition)** within the framework of **strategic autonomy**.

Energy security is now more about **HEP, nuclear, solar and wind**, especially after India acknowledged the **phase-down of coal**. It is not limited to oil and gas.

DATA & FACTS

India's import dependence.

- Crude oil — **88%**.
- LPG — **60%**.
- LNG — **45-50%**.

Presentation template: show this as a **graph** or a **table** (both are acceptable), and let the diagram's heading read **'Energy diplomacy is not limited to oil and gas'**.

2.2.2 Challenges

Whenever a new government comes to power there are opportunities and challenges. With India's push for energy security — and after the West Asian crisis exposed the dependence on choke points, which became a **weaponised** keyword — the first set of challenges concerns **fossil fuels**.

- **Structural challenge — high import dependence.** Just as weak language proficiency is a structural problem for an otherwise knowledgeable writer, some limitations are structural. India imports most of its crude oil, LPG and LNG and is therefore **susceptible to global developments and global energy shocks**.
  - Illustration: importing **coal from Indonesia and Australia** and importing **crude oil** are structurally very different — a ground-to-sky difference.
  - Example: LPG prices increasing in the aftermath of a shock; **90% of LPG imports come from West Asia**, which automatically raises India's susceptibility.
- **Dependence on West Asia.** India's energy security is tied to the **regional security** of West Asia and to **choke points**, so energy diplomacy is dependent on the **political and security developments in West Asia**.
  - Fuel-wise dependence on West Asia (these figures were flagged for verification in the lecture):

Crude oil	35% of total imports
LNG	60%
LPG	90%

- **Unilateral sanctions.** US sanctions on the import of oil from **Iran and Russia** are a hindrance to energy security.
  - The supplying nation is ready, but the sanctioning country does not allow India to import.
- **Critical minerals as a strategic bottleneck.** The resource distribution of rare earth elements is limited to a few geographies.
  - **Lithium** in Australia; **graphite** in Sri Lanka and China; **samarium** in China (also indium and other elements).
  - Because the options are few, **diversification is limited** — no matter how good the diplomacy, without these elements India cannot build a solar power plant, run a wind power plant or manufacture a turbine.

Nuclear Diplomacy Challenges Nuclear energy is one of the important parts of the **base-load capacity** that will replace fossil fuels; nuclear energy and the nuclear liability law are relevant across all three papers.

- **Balancing civil nuclear liability with foreign technological cooperation.**
  - The **Civil Liability for Nuclear Damage Act, 2010** allowed the **operator** to channel liability and to seek compensation from the **supplier** for faulty or defective manufacturing that led

to a nuclear disaster.
  - That provision has since been repealed (2020): liability can be channeled to the supplier only if the **contract agreement** provides for it. This **limited investment from the US and France**.
  - Because of civil nuclear liability, this sector — which clearly depends on technology cooperation — **could not take a single step ahead from 2008 onwards**.
- India is a **non-signatory of the NPT** and lacks **Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG) membership**.
  - Effect: limited ability to shape nuclear export-control rules, hence **limited stakes in nuclear diplomacy**.
- **Technology dependence** — India's own reactors are **Pressurized Heavy Water Reactors (PHWR)**, while global reactors are **Light Water Reactors (LWR)** or **Small Modular Reactors (SMR)**.
  - Effect: this **limits scaling up** and makes India susceptible to **foreign technology restrictions**.
- **Commercial and technological uncertainty** — SMR is promising but carries **cost, financing and safety concerns**, which limits nuclear cooperation.
  - Analogy: importing a **Tesla EV** — is it cost-sustainable and affordable for 20-30 years? That decision itself limits the government's EV diplomacy.
  - Analogy: in AI, if a model like **Bhashini** can do the job, there is no need to go to **NVIDIA**; such chips are meant for companies building very large language models.

> **GOVERNMENT & POLICY**
>
> **Civil Liability for Nuclear Damage Act, 2010.**
>
> - Allowed the **operator** to channel liability and seek compensation from the **supplier** for faulty or defective manufacturing that caused a nuclear disaster.
> - Repealed (2020): liability now applies only where the **contract agreement** provides for channeling to the supplier.
> - Effect: **investment from the US and France was limited**, and nuclear diplomacy could not move forward from 2008 onwards.

The liability debate is a trade-off: the culpability of a foreign operator must be pinned down, yet over-reaching with a **right of recourse** automatically keeps foreign investment away.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Bhopal Gas Tragedy analogy.**
>
> - Union Carbide's Warren Anderson fled to the **US** after the **MIC leakage** at Bhopal.
> - One side: the law must be able to hold a foreign company responsible.
> - Other side: if the operator can always recover from the supplier, **no foreign investment will come in** — as happened with nuclear suppliers.

Instability of Nuclear Governance (Nuclear Geopolitics)

- **Disagreements over the Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT).**

- **Poor nuclear governance under the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA)** — example: the attack on **Iran's nuclear sites despite Iran's commitments to the IAEA**.
- **Increasing role of nuclear deterrence** after the recent **US-Israel attacks on Iran**, and **coercive diplomacy** by the US despite Iran's IAEA compliance — there have to be layers of attack.
- **Trump's withdrawal from the JCPOA** acted against the development of nuclear deterrence.
- Nuclear deterrence is connected with nuclear energy:
  - The world generates power with a **light water reactor**; an LWR needs **enriched uranium**; enrichment needs **centrifuges** — so a country with an LWR must possess centrifuges.
  - If **0.8% uranium-235** in natural uranium can be enriched to **5%, 10% or 20%**, it can be stretched to **90%** — the **biggest loophole of light water technology**.
  - Caveat: plutonium generated in a PHWR could still be used for a plutonium bomb — the possibility remains.

> **COMPARISON**
>
> **India's PHWR vs the world's LWR/SMR.**
>
> - India's reactors are **Pressurized Heavy Water Reactors** — they use **natural uranium**, need **no centrifuge or enrichment**, carry no West-imposed technology backwardness, and India also has **thorium**.
> - Global reactors are **Light Water Reactors / Small Modular Reactors** — they need **enriched uranium** and hence **centrifuges**; the ability to stretch enrichment to 90% is the biggest loophole of this technology.

The sixth set of challenges is **climate finance**, where energy security meets climate change.

- **Limited climate finance** — finance for **adaptation** is limited and climate finance is **mitigation-centric**.
  - Example: **COP29 at Baku** gave only **USD 300 billion** against a demand of **USD 1.3 trillion** (more than 1 trillion).
  - It is centred on **loans instead of grants** and is loosely defined, which raises the cost of finance and thereby throttles energy transition.

1. To be energy-resilient, India requires fossil fuels, which are imported.
2. To reduce dependence on fossil fuels it requires critical minerals, which are not found in the country — hence an external matter.
3. For a just energy transition it requires climate finance, which is again a matter of foreign policy.
4. Energy diplomacy requires energy security; energy security requires reduced dependence on fossil fuels; that requires a sharper focus on renewable energy, which raises India's costs; that is meant to be met by global finance led by developed nations; and that limits energy transition and energy security.
5. Therefore climate finance and the negotiations under COP are an inherent part of the discussion on climate change mitigation and adaptation.

2.2.3 Way Forward

After the challenges, state the **steps taken to embed energy diplomacy in foreign policy**, and then what needs to be done. The way forward is treated as only an extension of the steps taken.

- **Diversification.** India is importing oil from more than **40 nations**.
  - Energy engagement is being pursued with **Brazil, Colombia, Guyana and Suriname**.
- **For LPG.** Reduce dependence on West Asia (which supplies 90%); India has signed a **long-term LPG import agreement with the US**, a good percentage of domestic demand.
- **For LNG.** Development with **Angola and Gabon**; India has signed a **20-year LNG supply agreement with Qatar starting from 2028** — this shows diversification plus a long-term supply arrangement with a stable partner.
- **Building strategic petroleum resilience.**
  - **2026:** agreement with the **UAE** to store **30 million barrels** of crude oil in India's strategic petroleum reserve.
  - The **UAE in 2018 was the first nation** to partner India for building a strategic petroleum reserve.
  - India has **three storage reserves**; UAE helped build one. India has **no strategic storage reserve for LPG and LNG**, only limited capability for petrol.
  - The UAE has left OPEC; OPEC's production cap has been removed, so its capacity can rise (Saudi capacity about 5 billion) [as stated in the lecture].
- **Engaging with international organisations** — **OPEC**, the **India Energy Forum**, the **International Energy Agency (IEA)** and the **International Renewable Energy Agency (IRENA)**.
- **Developing a South Asian electricity grid** — importing HEP from **Nepal and Bhutan** and constructing transmission lines.
  - Providing **transit** is a major confidence-building measure: **Nepal** → **India** → **Bangladesh**; the **Kaptai Dam** lies in this region.
- **Nuclear diplomacy — promoting nuclear cooperation.**
  - India-Russia: **life-cycle support** to **Kudankulam** (**VVER-1000**, a Russian reactor); life-cycle support is very important and was prioritised during Putin's recent visit.
  - India-France: cooperation on **SMR and AMR**.
  - India-US: recently **authorised nuclear technology to Holtec** under **10 CFR Part 810**.
- **Critical mineral diplomacy** — engaging with **Australia for lithium**.
- **Providing leadership to international organisations** — the **International Solar Alliance**, the **Global Biofuel Alliance**, the **One Sun, One World, One Grid** initiative, the **IPEF (Indo-Pacific Economic Framework)** clean economy agreement, and at UNFCCC/COP29 Baku the demand for increased climate finance.
- **Green hydrogen diplomacy** — collaborating with the **Netherlands** (recent visit), the **US, France, Germany, Australia and Japan**; if it is green hydrogen, the developed nations will be involved.
- **What needs to be done.** Diversification and reduced dependence on **maritime choke points** (recent engagement with Brazil, Suriname and Gabon); **forge strategic partnerships**; **critical**

mineral diplomacy (Mineral Security Partnership; the Quad Foreign Ministers' critical minerals framework of 2026); ensure **low-cost climate finance** for a smooth energy transition; **nuclear + HEP + green hydrogen diplomacy**; and **engage and provide leadership for energy transition** with OPEC/OPEC+.

- **Domestic steps** — promotion of **piped natural gas (PNG)** as an essential commodity, and the **India-Bangladesh pipeline** for diesel.

US	Long-term LPG import agreement	A good share of India's domestic demand
Qatar	20-year LNG supply agreement	Starting from 2028
UAE	Strategic petroleum reserve	30 million barrels of crude oil

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Exam relevance.

- Energy diplomacy is both **current affairs and static** — it will matter this year and next.
- Next year you will also have to study **South Asian elections** and the neighbourhood.
- **Critical mineral diplomacy** has been necessary for the last three years and will remain relevant.

QUICK REVISION

- **Energy diplomacy = steps for energy security**, covering energy security, energy transition, critical minerals and climate justice/JET within strategic autonomy.
- It goes **beyond oil and gas** — HEP, nuclear, solar and wind.
- Challenges: structural import dependence, West Asia dependence, unilateral sanctions, the critical-mineral bottleneck, nuclear diplomacy, unstable nuclear governance and climate finance.
- **PHWR vs LWR/SMR**, the enrichment loophole, and India's NPT/NSG position.
- Steps: diversification (40+ nations), strategic petroleum resilience (UAE, 30 million barrels), international organisations, the South Asian grid, nuclear cooperation, critical mineral diplomacy and green hydrogen.
- Partnership table — **US (LPG), Qatar (20-year LNG, 2028), UAE (SPR)**.
- Way forward = steps taken + current examples, with low-cost climate finance at the centre.

2.3 Integrating Energy Security with India's Foreign Policy: The 2025 Question

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

2025 UPSC-style question.

- "Energy security constitutes the dominant kingpin of India's foreign policy and is linked with India's overarching influence in Middle Eastern countries. How would you integrate energy security with India's foreign policy in the coming years?"
- The statement has two parts: **(1)** energy security is the dominant kingpin of foreign policy and is linked with India's **overarching influence** in the Middle East; **(2)** how to **integrate** energy security with India's foreign policy trajectory.

Foreign policy carries geopolitical, geoeconomic, geostrategic and geocultural interests; the examiner wants you to **substantiate** the statement rather than merely restate it.

- India's **geocultural interest** is limited in Pakistan (small diaspora) but substantial in **West Asia** (large diaspora).
- The examiner's control is in the wording — 'dominant kingpin' is not to be simply repeated, because foreign policy also carries geocultural and geoeconomic interests.
- **Part 1 (about 125 words):** heading **'Energy security as the dominant driver'** — (a) import dependence for fossil fuels, with the stats and diagram; (b) access to critical minerals, limited to a few nations with a restricted supply chain, for example China's control; (c) the requirement of climate finance.
- **Part 2 (about 60 words each):** India's overarching influence in the Middle East.

The introduction can give the role of energy security in any economy (no economy can sustain without energy — solar, renewable or nuclear), or, better: "The recent West Asian conflict has exposed the vulnerabilities of nations with respect to energy security, which is of great importance for a nation."

- **Why India has influence in West Asia:** India's dependence on the Middle East and its position as a huge market and export market give it leverage — India imports oil, LPG and gas, and its own demand creates influence.
- **Diaspora:** India's diaspora is about **10 million (1 crore)**; it has contributed to the development of West Asian societies, and India is seen as the **leader of the Global South**.
- **Connectivity** with West Asian nations reinforces India's overarching influence.

EXAMPLE

Overarching influence — the two-way analogy.

- As Jinnah argued, more than Pakistan needing the US, the **US needs Pakistan** to keep its stranglehold in the region — influence runs both ways.
- Likewise the US is a strong influence for India, but India is also a strong influence for the US.
- **Bangladesh** finds the US very important, and at the same time Bangladesh is very important

for India.

- **Institutional step:** create a **separate energy security division / dedicated wing** in the **Ministry of External Affairs**.
- **Diversification:** nuclear diplomacy, green hydrogen diplomacy and critical mineral diplomacy, each with current examples.

CRITICAL POINT

Geo-strategic vs geo-political steps.

- Dealing with a country for fuel is one thing; **securing that fuel from a choke point is another**.
- **Maritime security, the vulnerability of choke points and the security of seafarers are a hundred times more important** than engaging with a country.
- **Geo-strategic steps matter more than geo-political steps** — stated as the view to take, especially after the recent conflict.

QUICK REVISION

- The 2025 question is a **two-part** question: substantiate the statement, then answer 'how would you integrate'.
- Break the answer into **125 words (Part 1) + 60 words each (sub-parts)**.
- Part 1 heading: **energy security as the dominant driver** — fossil-fuel imports, critical minerals and climate finance.
- Part 2: India's **overarching influence** in West Asia through markets, the **10-million diaspora** and connectivity.
- Institutional step: a **dedicated energy security wing in the Ministry of External Affairs**.
- Emphasise **maritime security and choke points** over geo-political engagement.

2.4 Critical Mineral Diplomacy

2.4.1 Challenges

Critical mineral diplomacy is prepared the same way — **challenges first, then the steps**, and then the way forward (as introduced in the first demo class).

- **Structural challenge — high import dependence.** India has limited production and reserves and therefore imports.
  - India has **100% import dependence on lithium, cobalt, nickel, silicon and other rare earth elements**.
- **Concentrated supply chain.** Critical-mineral supply chains are **more concentrated than oil** — India imports oil from almost **40 nations**, but for critical minerals it depends on just a few.
  - The supply chain is therefore **narrower and more vulnerable**.

DATA & FACTS

Concentration of supply.

- **OPEC+** holds **40%** of oil production.
- The **DRC** holds **more than 70%** of the world's cobalt.
- **China** processes **60% of lithium, 70% of cobalt and 90% of rare earth**.

- **Chinese dependence.** China controls the supply chain — production, refining/processing and the component supply chain — and **weaponises exports**.
  - Examples: **graphite** and **germanium** — China has **66% of global processing** of germanium.
  - **April 2025:** China imposed **export controls on 7 rare earth elements, including samarium** — a current-affairs example.

EXAMPLE

F-35 and samarium.

- **Samarium** has very high **thermal resilience** and sits at the **nose of a fighter jet**, which cuts through air at very high speed and temperature.
- An **F-35** aircraft uses roughly **25 pounds of samarium magnets** [as stated in the lecture].
- Such aircraft are made by **Boeing** and **Lockheed Martin** — a supply-chain constraint embedded in a strategic platform.

- **Late entry.** India is a late entrant compared with **China, Japan, Korea and the EU** — supply-chain partnerships have already been formed by some nations.
- **Competition from major powers** over a limited mineral geography.
  - They are competing in **Australia**, in **Africa**, and in the **ABC countries — Argentina, Bolivia and Chile**.
- **Resource nationalism**, especially in African nations like **Zambia and Zimbabwe**.
  - The old 'dig and export' model is being discarded; host nations now demand **value addition in their own country** — set up processing plants, spend on processing, create jobs, and then export the finished product.
- **Poor delivery of MOUs** — MOUs signed by India have not been converted into **bankable projects**.
  - Reasons: (1) geological uncertainty; (2) environmental clearance; (3) offtake commitment; (4) logistics; (5) financing; (6) processing and commercial viability; (7) ESG concerns.

EXAMPLE

Where projects have stalled.

- **Lithium mining in the salt flats of Bolivia** has degraded the area and caused illness among local people, making **ESG norms stringent**.
- In India, lithium was explored but **no mining came up** — concentration is low and the mineral is spread out, so it needs very large resources.

> - India's **copper mining project with Zambia got stalled**.

- **Offtake commitment** — India must assure the host country of a **minimum capacity utilisation**.
  - Example: if a deposit has 1,000 million tonnes and India commits to exploiting only 1 million tonnes, it is not viable; a contract of 10 or 20 million tonnes is needed so that investment, jobs and facilities are created.
- **No global regime for critical minerals** — nothing comparable to the **WTO for trade** or the **International Energy Agency for energy**.
  - There are only **overlapping and duplicated initiatives** — the **Mineral Security Partnership**, **Pax Silica**, the **Quad critical minerals framework** and the **EU Critical Raw Materials framework**.
  - Every country or region regulates as it pleases; there is **no governance mechanism and no set of rules**.
- **Trade rules and standards challenge.** The US and the EU are linking supply chains to **climate standards** — environment-friendly mining, origin rules, ESG compliance and carbon intensity.
  - Example: India's **critical minerals MOU with the US does not give automatic benefits** the way a full critical-minerals trade agreement does under **US clean vehicle rules**.
- **Strategic autonomy challenge.** India must balance **US/West-led platforms** (Mineral Security Partnership, Pax Silica, IPEF, Quad) with its simultaneous exposure to **China** in electronics, solar, battery and rare earths.
  - Signing US-led agreements can **antagonise China**, on whom India depends for **active pharmaceutical ingredients, solar cells and modules, electronics and batteries**; US batteries are very expensive.
  - If China controls supply, no framework can substitute for these manufactured components, which India simply must have.
  - Balancing arrangements with China without antagonising Chinese imports is described as the **biggest hiccup for the government of the day**.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **Why this matters for the exam.**
>
> - Even if you write all 10 points, the brain absorbs only 7-8; writing 7-8 of them with proper structure can put you in line for **60-65% marks**.
> - Because critical minerals have been in the news for 3-4 years, there is a **high probability** that a question will come from this area.

2.4.2 *Way Forward*

- **Engage in Australia for lithium** — add the keyword **lithium diplomacy**, and add the **ABC countries**.
- Build **trusted bilateral partnerships** — the **Mineral Security Partnership**, the **critical minerals framework under the Quad**, **IPEF**, **critical mineral cooperation with Canada**, **Chile**, and **Sri Lanka** (exploring graphite).

- **2025:** work towards a **full value chain**.
- **US Strategic Mineral Recovery Initiative** — 'recovery' here means **recycling** [stated as February 2020 in the lecture].
- India launched a **Rs. 1,500 crore Critical Mineral Recycling Mission**.

> **COMPARISON**
>
> **Choke points: fossil fuels vs critical minerals.**
>
> - For fossil fuels the concern was **choke points** — West Asia, maritime security and the security of seafarers.
> - For critical minerals, choke-point and geo-strategic concerns are **not as huge**.

The critical-minerals discussion closes this topic for the class; the same news-reading discipline — read, extract and structure the facts — is what secures marks.

> **PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION**
>
> **Prelims record.**
>
> - The **Mineral Security Partnership** came in **Prelims 2025**.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Challenges: **100% import dependence**, a concentrated supply chain, **Chinese dependence**, late entry, great-power competition, resource nationalism, non-bankable MOUs, no global regime, trade/standards and the strategic-autonomy dilemma.
> - Key data: **OPEC+ 40% of oil**, **DRC more than 70% of cobalt**, **China 60% lithium / 70% cobalt / 90% rare earth**, **germanium 66%**, **April 2025 export controls on 7 rare earths**.
> - Case studies: **F-35 and samarium**, **Bolivia salt-flat lithium**, the **Zambia copper project**.
> - Way forward: Australia (lithium), Mineral Security Partnership, the Quad framework, IPEF, Canada, Chile and Sri Lanka (graphite), and a full value chain.
> - US **Strategic Mineral Recovery Initiative** and India's **Rs. 1,500 crore Critical Mineral Recycling Mission**.
> - The Mineral Security Partnership appeared in **Prelims 2025**.

2.5 Semiconductor and AI Diplomacy: The Same Framework

The same framework — **define** → **challenges** → **steps taken** → **way forward** — is the key to **any** diplomacy: **semiconductor diplomacy, AI diplomacy, quantum diplomacy or space diplomacy**.

- **Semiconductor diplomacy** essentially involves **late entrance, technology constraints and developed nations** (for example Singapore and South Korea).
- **AI diplomacy** should be analysed with the same template, and its unfolding in the coming months is to be watched.
- The class discussion is to be supplemented by the written material; the basic facts are to be played with, and the framework is the key to understanding.

KEY CONCEPT

Next in sequence.

- With this, the discussion on various diplomacies closes, except AI diplomacy, which will be seen as it unravels.
- The next lecture then moves to **bilateral relations — South Asian diplomacy: Nepal, then Bangladesh, then Myanmar**.

QUICK REVISION

- **Semiconductor and AI diplomacy follow the same framework** as every other diplomacy.
- Semiconductor diplomacy centres on **late entrance, technology constraints and developed nations**.
- Framework: define → challenges → steps taken → way forward.
- Bilateral relations (South Asian diplomacy — Nepal, Bangladesh, Myanmar) are taken up next.

CHAPTER 3

South Asian Diplomacy and India's Neighbourhood First Policy: Nepal

3.1 Setting the Frame: Bilateral Relations and the Primacy of Neighbourhood First

With the discussion of development-policy effects and AI diplomacy concluded, the lecture opens the first leg of bilateral relations. That leg is broken into heads, and the first head is Neighbourhood First, which covers South Asian diplomacy.

- For the examination, the most important cases in South Asian diplomacy are **Nepal, Myanmar and Bangladesh**.
  - Nepal and Myanmar are the priority cases to prepare.
  - Bangladesh is in the news because of its elections.
- Elections in South Asia changed the entire framework of **geopolitical, geostrategic and geoeconomic interests** — this is the essential context.
- Afghanistan matters because Mr. Muttaki's visit was a big step, almost equivalent to recognition.
- Maldives also figures in the discussion (covered through a recorded class).
- Sri Lanka is taken up with basic information so that the concerns of South Asian diplomacy can be understood.
- Pakistan is taken separately because of the recent role Pakistan has played as a mediator.
- Other nations — Israel and Japan — have been repeatedly asked; notes are provided rather than discussed in class.

> **DATA & FACTS**
>
> **Exam weightage.**
>
> - The EU is laying the framework of diversification.
> - From 2013 to 2025, no question apart from this has come up when bilateral relations have been discussed.

The USA and Russia are taken separately, while the USA, Russia and China are taken together as a trio, in order to understand the interlinkages and interdependences among them.

> **PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION**
>
> **Always asked in context.**

- The rise of China is asked in the context of something — 100% it is asked.
- The US defence partnership and Russia are asked in context.
- China, the USA and Russia are asked in the context of something.

QUICK REVISION

- The first leg of bilateral relations is Neighbourhood First, which covers South Asian diplomacy.
- Most important for the exam: Nepal, Myanmar and Bangladesh.
- Bangladesh is in the news for its elections; South Asian elections changed the geopolitical, geostrategic and geoeconomic framework.
- Afghanistan (Muttaki's visit), Maldives, Sri Lanka, Pakistan (as mediator), Israel and Japan are the other cases.
- The EU is laying the framework of diversification; from 2013 to 2025 no other question has come up on bilateral relations.
- The USA and Russia are taken separately; the USA, Russia and China together as a trio, always asked in the context of something.

3.2 Nepal: Location, the Madhesh Question and the Political Backdrop

Under South Asian diplomacy, Nepal is taken up first. The discussion follows a fixed plan.

1. Importance of Nepal.
2. The recent protests and their reasons.
3. The elections and their impact or significance.
4. Strengths and opportunities.
5. What must be done to ensure better coordination and a better relationship between India and Nepal.

To begin, drawing the map of Nepal quickly makes the discussion easier to follow. The map should show the northern part of India as well.

- The border region is important for India because its people are **ethnically connected** to India.
  - This region is called **Madesh** and its people are called the **Madheshi**.
  - Madhesh means **Madhya Desh** — the middle land between the hills and the plains.
- From Nepal's independence in 1950 up to 25 September 2025, Nepal's politics was dominated by the hill Brahmin castes — the Hill Brahmin and the **Chhetri**.
- Nepal has strong ethnic ties with Uttar Pradesh and Bihar — a **roti-beti** relationship, because there is intermarriage between the two societies.

EXAMPLE

Familial ties in practice.

- An air crash about one and a half years ago involved people from Eastern UP who had gone

> to Nepal for travel and tourism — an illustration of how closely the two populations move across the border.

- The Madheshis live between the plains of the Ganga and the Himalayas in the north; they have historically been ignored in the politics of Nepal.
- **Balendra Shah** — about 34–35 years old, a rapper and social-media figure, and a mayor — is a significant opportunity for India as far as engagement is concerned.

The relationship is best shown as a chain: open borders lead to shared culture and familial bonds, which lead to the diaspora, and then to **intertwined politics** in which developments in India affect developments in Nepal.

> **GOVERNMENT & POLICY**
>
> **Priority partner.**
>
> - Nepal is a **priority partner (PP)** in India's Neighbourhood First foreign policy.

The recent political development is that the post-2015 order has been overturned. After the adoption of the Nepali constitution, politics was a game of musical chairs among three parties.

- **CPN (Communist Party of Nepal) Marxist–Leninist** — led by K.P. Oli, with a pro-China tilt; all these leaders, in fact, studied in India.
- **Nepali Congress** — actually formed in India, in Kashi or Banaras; it was led by Sher Bahadur Deuba.
- A **Maoist party** — the third of the three.
- That field has now opened up: a single party, the **RSP (Rashtriya Swatantra Party)**, dominates, and Balendra Shah is the new Prime Minister.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Nepal is taken first; the plan is importance, protests and reasons, elections and impact, strengths and opportunities, then the way forward.
> - Draw the map of Nepal, showing the northern part of India.
> - Madesh is the middle land (Madhya Desh) between the hills and the plains; its people are the Madheshi.
> - Nepal's politics from 1950 to 25 September 2025 was dominated by the hill Brahmin and Chhetri castes.
> - Nepal's ethnic ties with UP and Bihar are the roti-beti relationship; the Madheshi were historically ignored.
> - After 2015, politics was musical chairs among the Nepali Congress, the CPN (Marxist–Leninist) of K.P. Oli and a Maoist party.
> - Balendra Shah of the RSP is the new Prime Minister; Nepal is India's priority partner.

3.3 Why Nepal Matters to India: Importance in Every Dimension

Importance is examined first. It runs through the geopolitical, civilizational–cultural, geoeconomic, connectivity and geostrategic dimensions.

3.3.1 Geopolitical Importance

- Nepal is India's immediate neighbour and a priority partner under the **Neighbourhood First** foreign policy.
- Nepal is important to **counterbalance China**: it is a Himalayan state sandwiched between India and China, and Chinese influence is increasing under the **Belt and Road Initiative (BRI)**.
- Nepal is a member of **BIMSTEC**, which India supports as a regional organisation for regional development and as an alternative to SAARC.

India does not want to focus on SAARC because Pakistan is a member of it, and India does not want to engage with Pakistan. To improve regional connectivity and keep the whole region in focus, India therefore supports BIMSTEC as a regional organisation and an alternative to SAARC. Nepal's membership of BIMSTEC is what attaches all three geopolitical reasons to it.

> **GOVERNMENT & POLICY**
>
> **BIMSTEC.**
>
> - Full form: Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation.
> - A regional organisation supported by India for regional development, presented as an alternative to SAARC.
> - Nepal is a member, which is one of the reasons for its geopolitical importance to India.

3.3.2 Civilizational and Cultural Importance

- Nepal is central to the **Hinduism and Buddhism connect** — religion diplomacy, and the civilizational circuit.
- For Hinduism, there is the **Janakpur** and **Ayodhya** connection (Janaki).
- For Buddhism, there is **Lumbini**, the birthplace of the Buddha, and **Bodh Gaya**.
- The historical link runs through the shared experience of the colonial struggle and through the **Gurkhas** who serve in the Indian Army — making them a **military-cultural bridge**.

> **DATA & FACTS**
>
> **Gurkhas in the Indian Army.**
>
> - In 2025, the Indian Army has **34,000 Gurkhas**.

Field Marshal Sam Manekshaw's much-quoted remark — that if a person says he is not afraid of death, he is either lying or he is a Gurkha — and his preference for being called "Sam Bahadur", carry historical weight for the cultural relationship between India and Nepal.

This section of Nepali society serving in the Indian Army acts as a cementing factor: they are culturally connected to India, and at the same time they serve in India's armed forces and contribute to the security of the state.

3.3.3 Geoeconomic Importance

Nepal's economy is **structurally connected** to India; the two are structurally interlinked.

- For India, Nepal is a market: **6 lakh Indians live in Nepal**, and **remittance from Nepal to India is 3 billion dollars**.
- For Nepal, India is the **largest trading partner — 63% of Nepal's trade is with India**; remittance is **1 billion dollars**; and **Indian tourists make up 30% of Nepal's tourists**.
- **80 lakh (about 8 million) Nepalis work in India**, mostly in the unskilled and semi-skilled hospitality sector and restaurants; although the number is very large, the remittance they send back is small.
- **About 1300 MW is exported from Nepal to India** — this is part of India's **HEP (hydroelectric power) diplomacy**.
- There is a **tripartite agreement** to sell electricity from Nepal to Bangladesh.
- Energy security is normally written under geoeconomics, but where it carries a strategic angle — as with the West Asia choke point — it can be placed under the geostrategic dimension as well; primarily it belongs to geoeconomics.
- **Bangladesh and Nepal depend on India for their energy needs** — gas cylinders, LPG and petroleum products — so India has a major role in ensuring supply while keeping its own domestic needs in mind.

Trade	Largest trading partner; 63% of Nepal's trade is with India	A market for Indian products
Remittance	1 billion dollars	3 billion dollars
People movement	80 lakh (8 million) Nepalis work in India	6 lakh Indians live in Nepal
Energy	Dependence on India for LPG and petroleum products	About 1300 MW of electricity exported to India

3.3.4 Connectivity

- Connectivity is the key to reach Nepal; the **3C approach — Culture, Commerce, Connectivity** — is the standard set of keywords used for the neighbourhood.
- **Digital connectivity** matters: Nepal accepts **UPI**, so a person can go to Nepal and pay through UPI.
- Physical linkages include **petroleum pipelines, cross-border railways and integrated check posts**.
- All of this makes Nepal important for India's **regional connectivity vision**.

3.3.5 Geostrategic and Security Importance

- Nepal is a **strategic buffer** — a **1850 km natural barrier** between India and China, with a demarcated border [as stated in lecture].
- Had Nepal been a part of India, India would have had a **direct state boundary with China**, running from Aksai Chin in the north-west to the tri-junction on the Arunachal Pradesh border.
- The new phase of the **Kailash Mansarovar Yatra** passes through the **Kalapani–Limpiyadhura–Lipulekh Triangle**, which Nepal claims as its own territory; this has raised contestation against India and also against the Chinese, since the arrangement cannot be bypassed.
- Nepal's external alignment has direct ramifications on India's security concerns — for example, military engagement with China would hamper India's security interest. This is stated as a concern, not as a claim that it is happening.
- **Internal security**: porous borders have led to fake Indian currency notes (**FICN**), smuggling, narco-terrorism, drug trafficking, and illegal and human trafficking.
- **Human security**: common disasters such as floods and earthquakes increase susceptibility to human trafficking.
- **Increasing military engagement with China** — for example military drills — makes Nepal important in India's security matrix for regional stability and the maintenance of strategic balance.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **The balancing dilemma.**
>
> - Every neighbour — Sri Lanka, Nepal, Bangladesh, Myanmar — faces the same dilemma: strategically balancing the two major powers, India and China.
> - Nepal's location is an advantage in itself, sandwiched between India in the south and China in the north, but it is automatically also an open invitation to instability.
> - Precariously located, it may be trapped in great-power conflict, and may be trapped between Iran in the north and the aspirations of the US and Israel in West Asia [as stated in lecture].

Taken together, Nepal matters on every dimension — security, politics and economy. It is a strategic buffer, there is increasing external engagement, and to maintain the right security environment in India's backyard, India must ensure strong cooperation and coordination with Nepal.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Nepal is India's immediate neighbour and a priority partner under Neighbourhood First.
> - Geopolitically, it counterbalances China (BRI influence) and, as a BIMSTEC member, anchors India's alternative to SAARC.
> - Civilizationally, it links Hinduism (Janakpur–Ayodhya) and Buddhism (Lumbini, Bodh Gaya); the Gurkha link (34,000 in the Indian Army, 2025) is a military-cultural bridge.
> - Economically India is Nepal's largest trading partner with 63% of its trade; India receives 3 billion dollars in remittance and hosts 80 lakh Nepalis; Nepal exports about 1300 MW to India.

- Connectivity runs on the 3C approach — culture, commerce, connectivity — with UPI, pipelines, cross-border railways and integrated check posts.
- Strategically Nepal is a buffer between India and China, with border, internal-security (FICN, narco-terrorism) and human-security (disaster, trafficking) dimensions.
- Every neighbour must balance India and China; Nepal's location is both an advantage and a source of instability.

3.4 The Recent Protests in Nepal: Causes

The second head is the recent protest and its reasons.

- **Political elitism along with political corruption**: politics was dominated by the Brahmin, Chhetri and hill castes, and power shifted among only three leaders.
- The **proportional system of representation** is one of the reasons; it led to the formation of coalition government.
- India's Lok Sabha has **543 seats**, all based on direct elections.
  - Imagine that, apart from the 543 seats, there are 200 more seats distributed among the major political parties on the basis of their proportional vote share in the country.
  - Out of the 543, the majority mark becomes around 270 (whatever the number).
  - But in each of the 543 constituencies a candidate only needs to come first, whatever the voting percentage. So a party may end up with a significantly higher relative share of seats under proportional representation than its overall vote share suggests.
- This is the mechanism through which proportional representation produces coalition government.

COMPARISON

Coalition management versus single-party decisiveness.

- In Bihar, the JDU and the BJP mean a government that is always engrossed in managing the coalition, and it cannot take hard decisions easily.
- In Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Odisha, Rajasthan, Haryana, Delhi and at the Centre, the BJP does not have to manage a coalition, so it can take hard decisions.
- The same coalition dynamic could arise in Kerala unless a party has a very strong organisational network like the BJP.

- Nepal had three political parties: the **Nepali Congress**, a **Maoist party**, and the **CPN (Marxist–Leninist)** — the UML.
- Coalition government automatically promotes political instability, and political instability led to short-sighted policy.
- **Youth disconnect**: the bandwagon of the protest was picked up through **26 websites**, the Prime Minister, Telegram and WhatsApp under the "**Nepo kids**" theme — initially targeting politicians' children, then expanding to all the elites who came from good families and had studied and worked abroad.

- Nepal's **median age is 26**, so there is a disconnect between a restless youth and a political leadership that is self-absorbed and in its seventies.
- **Unemployment**: the share of manufacturing fell from **10% in 2002 to about 5% at present**; only about 5% of people are employed in manufacturing.
- **14% of Nepal's population works abroad** — one in every four young Nepalis works abroad.
- **Economic mismanagement**: coalition government led to poor resource allocation, and this led to unemployment.

> **DATA & FACTS**
>
> **Hard numbers.**
>
> - Unemployment among 15–24 year olds in Nepal reached **22.7% in FY23**.
> - **No Prime Minister has ever completed a full term** in Nepal.
> - India's own political history has 22 years of coalition government, from **1989 to 2014**.

India's democratic heft stands out in South Asia. There are always adventures in democracies — as with the coming of Sheikh Hasina in 2008, 2014 and 2018, up to the point that Tariq Rahman has now become the Prime Minister of Bangladesh, which also opens up many opportunities.

India	Strong democratic credentials; rise of the Left, Samajwadi and Bahujan politics, though upper castes still dominate
Sri Lanka	Parliamentary form until 1978, then semi-presidential
Pakistan	A failed state
Myanmar	A failed state
Nepal	A feudal state

Experts who have studied the political history of South Asia say that South Asia is culturally the same and that South Asian values are the same to some extent; South Asian politics is like a dissonance in which India clearly stands out because of its democratic credentials. India's democratic traditions, values and aspirations are very strong, so no neighbouring political environment can match India's — and this is an opportunity as well as an insecurity for the neighbouring nations. Pluralism is an asset, a demerit and a challenge all at once.

- The banning of **26 websites on 4 September** led to the **Gen Z protest**.
- From the Gen Z protest came an **interim government under Sushila Karki**, and then elections.
- **Balendra Shah of the RSP** became the **first Madheshi Prime Minister** and the first to win an **absolute majority**.
- Of all the andolans seen in Nepal, this was the **cleanest**, with clear public support.

QUICK REVISION

- Causes: political elitism and corruption, proportional representation and coalition politics, a youth–leadership disconnect (median age 26), unemployment and economic mismanagement.
- Manufacturing fell from 10% (2002) to 5%; 14% of Nepal's population works abroad; youth unemployment (15–24) reached 22.7% in FY23.
- No Nepali Prime Minister has ever completed a full term; India's own coalition experience is 22 years (1989–2014).
- Sequence: 26 websites banned on 4 September, then the Gen Z protest, then the interim government under Sushila Karki, then elections, then Balendra Shah of the RSP.
- Balendra Shah became the first Madheshi Prime Minister and the first to win an absolute majority; this was Nepal's cleanest andolan.
- India stands out in South Asia for its democratic credentials, which is both an opportunity and an insecurity for the neighbours; pluralism is an asset, a demerit and a challenge.

3.5 Impact and Significance of the Recent Developments on India

The impact must be written under four dimensions: **geopolitical, geoeconomic, geostrategic and geocultural**. Predicting the future impact requires knowing the present reality.

3.5.1 Geopolitical Impact

- With the three-party arrangement completely changed under the **RSP**, which is youth-driven and delivery-oriented, there will be a **recalibration of foreign policy**.
- There is an **opportunity for a reset**: the new beginning provides new vistas of engagement and increasing sectors of cooperation.
- Traditional diplomacy has shifted towards **stable government and stable politics**, so India must change with it.

3.5.2 Geoeconomic Impact

- Energy-security cooperation is likely to continue, along with the strengthening of cross-border transmission links (for example Inaruwa, Rua, New Purnia and the Lanki–Bareli transmission) [as stated in lecture].
- Trade: the economies are structurally connected and intertwined, but the recent imposition of **customs duties** might affect bilateral trade.
- Employment and the digital economy: a youth-led government will focus on visible, quick delivery on jobs, start-ups, tourism and digital governance.
- This opens opportunities for India in **DPI, skilling, education, start-up support and cross-border tourism**.
- These are India's strengths; if the partner government is itself youth-driven and tech-driven, the fit is automatic — customs duties may stall the interest, but structural interlinkage limits the damage.

3.5.3 Geostrategic Impact: Border Diplomacy and Security

- On China: **less engagement with China** is expected under Balendra Shah, and the **strategic balance between India and China is likely to continue**.
- Border diplomacy may be compromised, because the approach of the new government is **overt nationalism**: it has protested India's territory — **Kalapani, Lipulekh and Limpiyadhura** — to be Nepalese territory.
- Nepal has also suggested **third-party mediation**, which might derail border diplomacy or affect border management.
- Nepal's clarification was that the treaty was signed by the British, and it suggested going to UK libraries to study the agreement and see if something could be unravelled; initially it suggested mediation by the UK.
- India issued a clear **demarche** that it will not tolerate any third-party mediation as far as the Lipulekh–Kalapani dispute is concerned: this is completely territory that belongs to India and there should be no debate about it.
- A small step such as the border dispute raises the fact that **border management will be a tough nut to crack**.
- On internal security, cooperation — FICN, narco-terrorism, human trafficking — is likely to continue, but the **degree of enforcement may change** because of anti-establishment and assertive nationalism.

3.5.4 Geocultural Impact

- The **biggest impact is cultural**: cultural ties are likely to improve.
- The **Madheshi identity of the Prime Minister** improves people-to-people ties and gives India–Nepal relations a **social dimension**; continued civilizational, historical and religious linkages follow.
- Caste affinity will always create an affiliation, so a Madheshi Prime Minister means a natural closeness.
- **Stability leads to long-term decisions**: if the government is stable, it would be able to sign a pact with India lasting 10, 15 or 20 years.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **The Bangladesh model and its collapse.**
>
> - Under the Awami League, Sheikh Hasina was a leader who lent stability to Bangladesh, and that relationship panned out like anything for India — a model relationship that India would want with any neighbour.
> - What has happened now is the worst that could have happened with a neighbour.

- Stability and trade will grow; being a **Generation Z government**, it could take up **UPI, India's DPI and India's connectivity**.
- At the same time, because it is a stable government, it **will not tolerate any interference** and will be assertive about its sovereignty.
- Previously, elected Prime Ministers used to individually meet the ambassadors of different

countries, primarily India and China — a huge gap in protocol; governments were run by managing the external environment, which hurt Nepalese sentiment: "it is our country, our Prime Minister".

- Balendra Shah has **not met any of the ambassadors of India and China**; forget an appointment in India, he has not met anyone who has come from India. As the head of the RSP and the orchestrator of the election outcome, he is not giving appointments.
- The **first requirement is therefore a recalibration of foreign policy** — 100% in Nepal, 100% in Bangladesh; everything will change.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **A double-edged outcome.**
>
> - A stable government might lead to better delivery of outcomes, but it might also compromise India's strategic interest.
> - Example: the nationalist approach of the RSP and the Balendra Shah government.

This question has been asked in Mains with respect to the Shahbagh Square protest that took place in Bangladesh in 2013. The same structure applies here, and the Bangladesh answer can be written on the same template.

> **PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION**
>
> **Precedent.**
>
> - Asked with respect to the Shahbagh Square protest in Bangladesh (2013) — already asked in Mains.

The examiner wants your analysis in a scenario that nobody knows: what will happen? The answer justifies the case by observation for the future, grounded in structural interlinkage and dependence — Nepal's strong dependence on India means that even with small concerns, the broad structure holds.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Write impact under four dimensions: geopolitical, geoeconomic, geostrategic and geocultural.
> - Geopolitically, the three-party order has given way to a youth-driven, delivery-oriented RSP, forcing a recalibration of foreign policy.
> - Geoeconomically, energy cooperation continues with cross-border transmission links, and trade is structurally intertwined, though customs duties may affect it.
> - Geostrategically, less engagement with China is expected and the India–China balance is likely to continue; border diplomacy may be compromised by assertive nationalism over Kalapani, Lipulekh and Limpiyadhura.
> - Geoculturally, ties should improve because of the Madheshi identity of the Prime Minister, giving the relationship a social dimension.
> - The new leadership is assertive about sovereignty and has not met the Indian and Chinese ambassadors; still, the Foreign Minister chose India for the first visit, so the direction is yet to

be seen.

3.6 Post-Election Strengths and Opportunities for India

Importance and challenges are correlated — one builds the other. After the elections, India's own strengths create the opportunities.

1. A **generational reset** in the Nepal government for welfare and the improvement of bilateral cooperation.
2. The leadership is educated in India and abroad, oriented towards technology and rapid development, eager to work, and oriented towards stability — which might lead to a politically stable government.
3. Strategically, the balance between India and China is likely to be maintained: anti-India sentiment did not exist during the election, and China supported the Communist Party of Nepal, which has been rejected — the CPN lost the government.
4. The government is aware of **China's debt diplomacy** as compared with India's support during the [Gulf] crisis [as stated in lecture].
5. Climate change and **HADR (humanitarian assistance and disaster relief)** are openings where India can act.

EXAMPLE

HADR example.

- **Operation Maitri** — the earthquake that came in 2015.

At the end of the day, these are India's strengths, and this strength itself creates the opportunity. The strategic balance between India and China shall be maintained by the government; there was no anti-India sentiment; China supported the CPN and lost; and the government is aware of China's debt diplomacy as compared to India's support during the crisis.

On this strength, India can engage a development-driven, delivery-oriented, newly elected government that has a **Madheshi Prime Minister for the first time**.

QUICK REVISION

- Opportunities: a generational reset, a leadership educated in India and abroad and technology-oriented, and a politically stable government.
- Strategic balance between India and China is likely to be maintained.
- Anti-India sentiment did not exist during the election and China's support for the CPN was rejected.
- The government is aware of China's debt diplomacy compared with India's support during the crisis.
- HADR and climate change are openings; Operation Maitri (2015 earthquake) is the example.
- India's strengths themselves generate the opportunity to engage a development-driven, delivery-oriented government with a Madheshi Prime Minister.

3.7 Challenges and the Way Forward for India

To close the discussion, the question is what India must do to improve bilateral relations with Nepal. The points remain the same; they only need to be organised.

3.7.1 Challenges

- The new government is assertive about its sovereignty and flourishes on **overt nationalism**, which makes the relationship harder to manage.
- The **border question** is a tough nut to crack. Some experts say the border issue should be kept in a separate diplomatic track, but that logic of separation does not hold very strongly here, because this is a **cartographic misinterpretation** and a clear example of **incursion into India's territory**.
- Interference in territory is one thing; entering the territory becomes a **violation of India's sovereignty**. This has been happening historically since **1962**, it comes up in the news every four or five years, and it normally remains only a diplomatic protest, with no occupation by force.
- India's image suffered in **2015**, when the new constitution of Nepal came: India is said to have played a major role in the 2–3 month blockade, and that moment took Nepal away in terms of people-to-people ties and the cultural impression of India.
- A restive youth that has seen an unsettling past will not be persuaded by repeatedly reciting cultural, historical and religious mantras.

3.7.2 Way Forward

- First, go for **careful diplomatic recalibration**: India must project itself as the **elder brother and not the big brother**. This was given by **Sushma Swaraj**, the first External Affairs Minister in the first term of the BJP government.
- Redefine the relationship on **trust, people-to-people ties, DPI and regional connectivity** — physical, pipeline and digital — and, very importantly, on **youth**, since 50% of the population is 26 years old.
- Promote **start-up tourism, health, education and skilling**, and focus on **development diplomacy**.
- Second, cooperate as **partners rather than patrons**; do not act as a big daddy; keep Nepal equal.
- Keep the **border issue in a separate diplomatic track** and expand cooperation separately in **education, disaster management, trade and digital connectivity**.
- For **border management**, adopt smart border-management strategies using technology such as **AI and drones**, and avoid hard border closure of the kind done in **2015**, which produced a months-long blockade that fuelled anti-India sentiment.
- Take it easy as the elder brother.
- Learn the lesson from Bangladesh: after engaging with the other political actors, engage with the **new actors — youth, provincial and local governments, entrepreneurs and civil society**.

- Remain the **closest power without becoming the controlling power** — elder brother, not big brother — and do not be a paternalistic neighbour.
- Be careful about reiterating the old mantras of culture, historical and religious ties, or roti-beti; instead invest in developing "**Naya Nepal**" (New Nepal).
- Roti-beti is a respect for civilizational contact, but India must believe more in **delivery** and **engagement**; keep pursuing the approach of **non-interference**, be a partner and elder brother, and be the **first responder** for humanitarian assistance and disaster relief — practise **crisis diplomacy** and help when a neighbour is in crisis.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Discussion questions — high probability.

- Discuss the recent developments in Nepal in the past one year. What is the significance of these developments on India? — 100% probability of being asked.
- Should the recent political developments in Nepal be of any concern to India? If yes, then discuss the changes in the foreign policy vis-à-vis Nepal.

QUICK REVISION

- Recalibrate carefully: project the elder brother, not the big brother (Sushma Swaraj).
- Redefine the relationship on trust, P2P ties, DPI, regional connectivity (physical, pipeline, digital) and youth — 50% of the population is 26 years old.
- Cooperate as partners, not patrons; keep Nepal equal.
- Keep the border issue in a separate diplomatic track and expand cooperation separately in education, disaster management, trade and digital connectivity.
- Use smart border management with AI and drones; avoid hard border closure like 2015, which fuelled anti-India sentiment.
- Engage new actors — youth, provincial and local governments, entrepreneurs, civil society — and be the closest power without becoming the controlling power.
- Avoid old mantras (roti-beti, culture, religion) and invest in developing Naya Nepal; be the first responder in HADR and practise crisis diplomacy.

CHAPTER 4

Supreme Court on Child Rights, Abortion, Online Blocking and Bail

4.1 Supreme Court and Child Welfare: Constitutional Jurisprudence

The discussion now moves to child welfare, after earlier discussions on the welfare of women and on the concerns of the environment. The approach is to first examine the constitutional provisions, then the Supreme Court judgments — and the judgments are divided into two groups: the historically important and the recent.

Constitutional jurisprudence on child welfare is divided into two parts: **Fundamental Rights** and **Directive Principles of State Policy (DPSP)**.

Fundamental Rights

- Article 14 — equality; it applies to everyone.
- Article 15 — special provisions for women and children.
- Article 21 — free and compulsory education for children between 6 and 14 years (Article 21A).
- Articles 23 and 24 together — the **right against exploitation**.
  - This right is very important because most of the Supreme Court judgments on the rights of the child revolve around Articles 23 and 24.

Directive Principles of State Policy

- Article 39(e) — protection of children from abuse.
- Article 39A — free legal aid; important for child-related cases.
  - Children must be given the benefit of free legal aid — free lawyers for the family.
- A DPSP on early childhood care and education for children below six years.
- Article 47 — public health and nutrition.

Fundamental Duty

- The fundamental duty of parents or guardians to provide education to a child between 6 and 14 years.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Theme — Constitutionalization of Important Subjects.**
>
> - The theme is the **constitutionalization** of important subjects: women's rights, the environ-

ment and child rights.

- What is to be discussed is the expansive or broad view taken by the Supreme Court under the provisions of **Article 21**.
- To expand this framework, one must first know what the Fundamental Rights, DPSPs and Fundamental Duties given in the Constitution relate to — what the Constitution says.

QUICK REVISION

- Child-welfare jurisprudence is split into Fundamental Rights and DPSPs.
- Articles 23 and 24 (right against exploitation) carry most child-rights judgments.
- DPSP anchors: 39(e) protection from abuse, 39A free legal aid, 47 public health and nutrition, plus early childhood care below six years.
- Fundamental duty covers education of the 6–14 child.
- The overarching theme is the constitutionalization of subjects through an expansive Article 21.

4.2 Statutory and Legal Framework for Child Rights

Whenever the legal framework is discussed, both laws and jurisprudence are written. A box can be shown to the examiner listing the laws that deal with the rights of the child — this is the **statutory or legal framework**, and it is very important.

- **Immoral Traffic Prevention Act 1956**.
- **Juvenile Justice Act 2005** — where children are kept in the juvenile justice board.
  - The delinquency rate (delinquency means breaking the rules) is very high here.
  - Children below 17–18 years cannot be tried as adults, and the regular legal framework cannot be applied to them.
  - Kept together, they meet fellow child inmates; the influence of that company plays out and they end up becoming hardcore, dreaded criminals as adults.
- **Criminal Law Amendment Act 2013** — enacted in the aftermath of the Nirbhaya case because of the involvement of a juvenile; it also deals with trafficking.
- **Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita** — provisions dealing with the selling and buying of minors.
- **POCSO Act 2012** (Prevention of Children from Sexual Offences Act) — under which fast track courts have been set up.
  - 400 fast track courts evaluate these cases.

DATA & FACTS

Figures and Exam Notes.

- POCSO set up **400 fast track courts**.
- The full form of the POCSO Act was asked in one of the state services, and it is recalled in UPSC forest services, only about 3–4 months ago.

- The Court has asked for **100% DNA paternity testing**.

QUICK REVISION

- The statutory framework is the box of laws that deal with child rights.
- Five anchors: Immoral Traffic Prevention Act 1956, Juvenile Justice Act 2005, Criminal Law Amendment Act 2013, BNS provisions on selling/buying minors, POCSO Act 2012.
- Juvenile Justice Act 2005 — delinquency risk and the ban on trying under-18s as adults.
- POCSO set up fast track courts — 400 of them.
- POCSO's full form is a past exam question; 100% DNA paternity testing has been sought.

4.3 Abortion and the POCSO Overlap (MTP Act 1971)

POCSO is a very interesting law. The abortion issue that has been in the news is primarily about the rights of the fetus as compared with the rights of the female — which one trumps which fundamental right. The Supreme Court has given controversial opinions.

CRITICAL POINT

Conflicting Positions on the Fetus vs the Female.

- At one point the Court said that it is the right of the fetus that matters.
- At another point the Court said that it is the reproductive choice and the autonomy of the female that is guaranteed to her — not only under **Article 21** but clearly specified by the Supreme Court in the **K.S. Puttaswami case**, which recognised the right to privacy as a fundamental right.
- This balance between the two is very interesting, and it has a strong overlap with POCSO.

The controversy is the overlap of the abortion law, the **MTP Act 1971**, with the POCSO Act.

- A rape victim's abortion is allowed, and the gestational period matters. A person who commits rape will be tried under the POCSO Act, while the same female will have higher grounds of termination of pregnancy under the MTP Act 1971.
- In some cases the time duration for terminating pregnancy is extended — from **20 to 24 weeks** — for specific categories of women.

4.3.1 The Consensual-Adolescent Puzzle

Take metropolitan adolescent sexual activity, where females and males are trying to explore their sexuality. Say an 18-year-old male and his 17-year-old girlfriend have unprotected sexual intercourse and she becomes pregnant. Theoretically it is a consensual act, so the male is not a criminal, because she will not report it.

But that consent is applicable only when there is a trial. If the girlfriend says she will not take him to the court of law but she becomes pregnant, the remedy has to run through the abortion procedure.

For that abortion the **Registered Medical Practitioner (RMP)** — the legal term for a doctor — is

stuck by the law and will inform the police.

Because under the MTP Act she is a female and she is not an adult, the consent requirement applies, and doctors want to keep themselves safe, so they will automatically inform the police.

The male adolescent therefore automatically ends up getting trapped in the framework of POCSO, despite the female not charging him and despite the act being consensual — because abortion is still seen as an exception to the criminal law.

CRITICAL POINT

Why These Provisions Are Controversial.

- Those provisions are very controversial in the present scheme of things, when the effort is to recognise the rights of women.
- India is one of the progressive nations that had an abortion law as far back as **1971**.
- But from 1971 till 2026 the jurisprudence of abortion and the framework of fundamental rights and bodily privacy has completely changed, so some amendments are needed in the jurisprudence and in the legal and statutory framework of abortion — a tricky area.

QUICK REVISION

- The debate is fetus rights vs female autonomy; K.S. Puttaswami anchors privacy under Article 21.
- Overlap is between the MTP Act 1971 and POCSO.
- Rape triggers POCSO for the accused and higher termination grounds for the female; the limit rises from 20 to 24 weeks for specific categories of women.
- The consensual-adolescent puzzle: an RMP's duty to inform the police traps the male under POCSO even without a complaint.
- Abortion is still treated as an exception to criminal law; the 1971 law needs updating to match modern privacy jurisprudence.

4.4 Historically Important Supreme Court Judgments on Child Rights

The framework of child rights is limited, because very few child-related cases come up. The cases that do arise concern human trafficking, the right to education and adoption of a child. The judgments are first traced historically — a gut feeling says this carries a good possibility of being asked.

Bandhua Mukti Morcha (1984)

- A famous PIL-era case which expanded **Article 21** into a guarantee of living conditions of dignity for bonded labourers and vulnerable workers; it has ramifications on child rights.
- It is a landmark case for upholding the rights of the bonded labourers, so child rights are automatically involved.

Lakshmi Kant Pandey v UOI (1984)

- This was a foundational, framework case on **inter-country adoption** — a major issue in child-rights cases.
- The Court laid safeguards to prevent commercialisation of adoption and exploitation of abandoned children.
- It led to **CARA (Central Adoption Resource Authority), 1990** — an organisation that manages the adoption of a child and functions under the Ministry of Women and Child Development.
- It is an example of **institutional convergence, or coordination, between Parliament and the judiciary**; it can be written under separation of powers, showing that the two institutions are not separated by disjunction but also work together.
- It was also a foundation for the juvenile justice framework.

Mohini Jain (1992) and Unni Krishnan (1993)

- Both **constitutionalized the right to education before Article 21A** existed.
- Mohini Jain — the Supreme Court said the right to education is implicit under Article 21; education flows from the right to life.
- Unni Krishnan — the Court read Article 21 together with the DPSP, making it an example of **harmonious interpretation of Fundamental Rights and DPSPs**.

MC Mehta v State of Tamil Nadu (1996)

- The Supreme Court laid guidelines prohibiting the employment of children in **hazardous industries**.
- It is remembered along with the environment cases already studied — the oleum gas leak at the Shri Ram factory, the oleum gas principles, the public trust doctrine, absolute liability, the Taj trapezium case, the leather tannery case and water pollution.

Gaurav Jain v UOI (1997)

- It dealt with the **children of sex workers**.
- The Court rejected the idea of segregated schools and hostels for children of sex workers and recommended **mainstreaming, care, protection and rehabilitation**.

Sakshi (2004)

- The Court gave **child-friendly procedural directions** for recording the evidence of child victims of sexual abuse.
- A child cannot straight away be exposed to a vulnerable environment while giving evidence, so this was one of the starting judgments; in **2017** further guidelines laid down a methodology for taking the evidence of children and vulnerable sections.

Bachpan Bachao Andolan

- The organisation was founded by **Kailash Satyarthi**.
- The Court gave directions to address **widespread exploitation and trafficking**.

Society for Unaided Private Schools of Rajasthan (2012) Private schools in Delhi and elsewhere follow a 25% criterion for economically weaker sections. In practice such students are kept in

separate sections, so a child whose father is from the economically weaker sections and whose classmates are from well-to-do sections has his economic backwardness turned into a stigma — a divisive separation in the best schools, including Kendriya Vidyalayas.

- The Supreme Court **upheld the validity of the RTE (right to education) along with the 25% EWS reservation** — 25% reservation for the economically weaker section.
- Schools such as Springdale, Modern School Barakhamba and Sanskriti School protested against giving 25% to the economically weaker sections, and the Supreme Court 100% side-tracked their request.

Independent Thought (2017)

- The Court **read down Section 375(2) of the IPC**, which exempted sexual intercourse with a wife who is less than 18 years old.
- It was important because it **harmonised the IPC with POCSO and the Prevention of Child Marriage Act 2005**.

Sampurna Behura (2018)

- The Court gave **wide-ranging directions for the juvenile justice board, the child welfare committee and child care institutions**.
- In state services there is a women and child development service; a child development and protection officer reports to the DM on welfare measures and the implementation of laws, because the DM chairs all these committees.
- A separate cadre does not exist in every state — it exists in UP, Rajasthan and Bihar; in Haryana there may not be a separate women and child development officer cadre.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

How to Use This List.

- This carries a good possibility of being asked.
- Do not stress over it — if two or three keywords per case are remembered, the evaluation is fine; the examiner wants the judgment and the important framework, not heavy framing as in International Relations.
- Write the case name with the year in brackets, and demonstrate constitutional language — a couple of lines will do.

QUICK REVISION

- Bandhua Mukti Morcha 1984 — Article 21 as dignified living conditions for bonded labourers.
- Lakshmi Kant Pandey 1984 — inter-country adoption safeguards, CARA 1990, institutional convergence, juvenile justice foundation.
- Mohini Jain 1992 and Unni Krishnan 1993 — right to education read into Article 21 before Article 21A.
- MC Mehta 1996 — ban on child employment in hazardous industries; Gaurav Jain 1997 — children of sex workers mainstreamed.

- Sakshi 2004 — child-friendly evidence; Bachpan Bachao Andolan — anti-trafficking directions.
- Society for Unaided Private Schools of Rajasthan 2012 — RTE upheld with 25% EWS; Independent Thought 2017 — IPC 375(2) read down.
- Sampurna Behura 2018 — directions for JJB, CWC and child care institutions; child development officers report to the DM.

4.5 Recent Supreme Court Judgments on Child Rights

After the historically important cases, the recent judgments on child rights are taken up.

- **Nipun Saxena case (2000)** — a big case because the Court protected the identity of **rape survivors and child sexual abuse victims**.
- **CSEAM (child sexual exploitative and abuse material)** — a judgment from last year; on this basis a question was asked on the **NCPCR**.

The NCPCR question is best answered through the structural-functional approach of regulatory bodies, also used for tribunals.

CRITICAL POINT

Approaching the NCPCR Question.

- **Structural**: there is no statutory provision for the chairman or members; there is governmental interference; it is not an independent body; it reports and works under the framework of the Ministry of Women and Child Development; there are infrastructural concerns; it does not align with the Supreme Court judgments and international precedents.
- **Functional**: it has the powers of a civil court but implementation is missing; suo moto powers are hardly exercised; orders passed by the NCPCR are not adhered to by the government.
- The question is not really about the NCPCR — it is about whether the regulatory bodies framework (NHRC, NCPCR, NCBC, NCM) was learnt; the framework is the same, so examples are written in one table.

- **Jaya Thakur (2026)** — the Supreme Court ruled that the **right to menstrual health is a fundamental right**, guaranteed under **Article 21**.
- **Hansa Nanduri case** — the Court upheld the rights of **adoptive mothers** under the **Maternity Benefit Act 1961**, and thereby the rights of the adopted child. If rights are given to a mother, she secures rights for her child, so the child certainly benefits; the logic that it is a women's rights case and not a child rights case does not hold.
- **KP Kiran Kumar case (2026)** — provided **strict guidelines to prevent child trafficking**.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Possible Question Framing.

- "Discuss the expanding jurisprudence of social justice in recent times; give examples of recent case laws."
- The child-welfare discussion is being woven into the larger social-justice story because the

question can be asked in exactly this way.

QUICK REVISION

- Nipun Saxena (2000) protects the identity of rape survivors and child sexual abuse victims.
- CSEAM drove the NCPCR question — answer it structurally and functionally.
- NCPCR lacks statutory independence, works under the Ministry of Women and Child Development, and its orders are not adhered to.
- Jaya Thakur 2026 — right to menstrual health under Article 21.
- Hansa Nanduri — adoptive mothers' rights under the Maternity Benefit Act 1961, benefiting the adopted child.
- KP Kiran Kumar 2026 — strict guidelines against child trafficking.

4.6 Recent Supreme Court Decisions Upholding Fundamental Rights

This is a compilation of the recent decisions of the Supreme Court. Most of these cases relate to **Article 21**, so they justify the argument that the framework of fundamental rights has been expanded by the Supreme Court.

- **Amar Jain case** — the Court upheld Article 21 to encompass the **right to digital access** and directed companies to revise their KYC norms. When KYC has to be done, the banks' norms such as facial recognition and other requirements prevent access to those facilities for several physically disabled persons.
- **Rajeev Raturi case (2024)** — the Court ruled that **accessibility is central to the right to life** under Article 21.
- **Save Life Foundation case (2026)** — the Court ruled that **trauma care is integral to Article 21**. The right extends from the site of injury to definitive hospital treatment and covers the entire chain that connects the injured person to medical care.
  - The chain from injury to medical care: the paramedic, the nurse and the receiving facility, which is the hospital.
- **Pila Pahan case — timely pronouncement of reserved judgments is a part of Article 21**; the Court ruled that Article 21 is not confined to a speedy trial alone.
  - It goes beyond a speedy trial: the case goes to the court of law, the court listens to the arguments and then has to pass the judgment; all the facilities run their course. The decision came up on 20 May.
- **Andhrabi case** — the Court ruled that the statutory embargo to bail under **Section 43D(5) of the UAPA** is subject to Articles 21 and 22; even where a statute provides stringent conditions of bail, that is subject to the inherent fundamental rights enshrined under Articles 21 and 22.
  - A two-judge bench had denied bail to Umar Khalid; this case gave bail in another matter where the accused had been arrested five years earlier under the UAPA.
  - The Court said the earlier case was a wrong application of the principles of bail laid down by the Supreme Court in the 2021 Najeeb case.

- **Maniyar Iliyasi case** — the **right to walk on a demarcated footpath is a fundamental right**, guaranteed under Article 21 and Article 19 (freedom of movement). Footpaths are occupied by hawkers selling balloons, notes, maps, tables and chairs, which led to a PIL.
  - Mnemonic: remember it as "walking" — the host of India's Most Wanted, who was convicted for killing his wife.
- **Right to safe travel on highways** — it is a part of the **right to life**. The Court laid out the following directions: (1) immediate prohibition on the construction or operation of a new dhaba, eatery or commercial structure; (2) no heavy or commercial vehicle should park or stop on any national highway carriageway or paved shoulder; (3) permission of the district highway safety task force.
- **Stray dogs case** — the most discussed case on social media in the past year. The Court held that the **right to move freely in public places without fear of attack** is a fundamental right.
  - A two-judge bench had said that all stray dogs need to be picked up and castrated and kept restricted at the places where animal centres are located; this was an interpretation of the ABC rules under the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Act 1960.
  - After a review, the Supreme Court said that the fact that dogs are cute or lovable is not a ground for humans to create restrictions on fundamental rights; many children had died and many people were harmed.
  - The hearings concluded in April and the judgment was reserved; there was strong criticism and strong points in support on both sides, a decision was given, an organisation got it reviewed, and a decision followed the review.

DATA & FACTS

National Highway Figures.

- National highways are equal to **2% of India's road length**.
- National highways carry **40% of traffic** and account for **40% of accidents**.
- **30% of total fatalities** occur on national highways.

QUICK REVISION

- Most of these decisions expand Article 21.
- Amar Jain — right to digital access and KYC norms; Rajeev Raturi 2024 — accessibility is central to right to life.
- Save Life Foundation 2026 — trauma care is integral to Article 21, from the site of injury to definitive hospital treatment (paramedic, nurse, receiving facility).
- Pila Pahan — timely pronouncement of reserved judgments is part of Article 21, beyond a speedy trial alone.
- Andhrabi — UAPA Section 43D(5) embargo subject to Articles 21 and 22; earlier denial of bail to Umar Khalid called a wrong application of the 2021 Najeeb principles.
- Maniyar Iliyasi — right to walk on a demarcated footpath under Articles 21 and 19; highways right to safe travel; stray dogs — right to move freely without fear of attack.

- National highways: 2% of road length, 40% of traffic and accidents, 30% of total fatalities.

4.7 Answer Framework: The Constitution as a Living Document

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Question.

- "The Constitution is a living document ensuring social justice. Discuss the above statement in the light of recent Supreme Court case laws."
- There are three key words: **living document**, **social justice**, and **in the light of Supreme Court case laws**.

4.7.1 *Introduction*

The Constitution is a living document because the amendment procedure under **Article 368** not only ensures flexibility along with rigidity, but the provisions of **judicial review** (Article 32 [as stated in lecture: 326]) have led to an expansive framework of fundamental rights.

4.7.2 *Part 1: Constitutional Provisions Ensuring Social Justice*

1. Preamble.
2. Fundamental Rights.
3. Directive Principles of State Policy.
4. Articles 330 and 332 — reservation of seats.
5. Recent Constitutional Amendment Acts passed by Parliament — list them as A, B, C, D, E.

- The Preamble should not be expanded too much — either show it in a box or in two lines; the **arrow technique** can be used here.
- The introduction can be finished within about 200 words; the Preamble portion should stay compact.
- The **106th Constitutional Amendment Act** provided reservation for women, ensuring social justice (Article 334 [as stated in lecture]).
- The **EWS amendment** inserted Article 15 clause 6 and Article 16 clause 6 for economically vulnerable sections. Perceptions of social justice differ — an interview board may ask what exploitation means for a particular community, and data is needed to show how strongly the argument is felt.
- The **97th Amendment 2011** dealt with cooperatives.

4.7.3 *Part 2: Role of the Judiciary*

However, it is the judiciary which has played an important role in upholding **constitutional morality**. This is the connecting link (it may or may not fit, but there is no fixity about it).

- For **women** — the judgments expanding women's rights.
- For the **elderly** — including the dogs judgment on the right to move freely in public places without fear of attack.

- For the **child** — the child-rights judgments.
- For **acid attack** victims.
- For **SC/ST** — the **Davinder Singh case** held that the homogenization of Scheduled Castes is no more a reality and thereby allowed the **sub-categorization of Scheduled Castes for reservation**.

KEY CONCEPT

Conclusion.

- India's Constitution is based on a living ethos — **constitutional morality** or **transformative constitutionalism**; either can be written.

QUICK REVISION

- Three key words: living document, social justice, in the light of Supreme Court case laws.
- Intro: Article 368 (flexibility with rigidity) plus judicial review building an expansive framework of fundamental rights.
- Part 1 lists Preamble, Fundamental Rights, DPSPs, Articles 330/332 and recent amendment Acts (A–E); 106th (women), EWS (Articles 15(6), 16(6)), 97th 2011 (cooperatives).
- Part 2 shows the judiciary's role across women, elderly, child, acid attack victims and SC/ST.
- Davinder Singh — sub-categorization of Scheduled Castes for reservation.
- Conclusion: India's Constitution rests on living ethos, constitutional morality or transformative constitutionalism.

4.8 Online Takedowns and Blocking versus Fundamental Rights (Article 19)

The issue being discussed is that the government passes orders and platforms such as Telegram and Facebook get blocked, so their users are unable to exercise fundamental rights — for example, if Telegram is blocked a teacher cannot express himself and share his thoughts. The question is to what extent this is justified and what concerns — the internal security and public order threats — arise.

- The government of India recently gave a notice to Telegram regarding the steps it has taken to prevent piracy of content, books, movies and everything else, and Telegram now has to give a review.
- If a review is not given, a ban is not ruled out, because there is then an internal security concern with respect to protests and undercurrents like those seen in Bangladesh and Nepal; an interim measure of restrictions or piracy control may be taken instead.
- The government did not act for so many years, but once its own papers were leaked it automatically moved in the right direction.

India's cyber security framework is old. The IT Act contains **two provisions** — **Section 69A**, which is very important because it has procedural safeguards, and **Section 79(3B)**, the **safe harbour clause** for a social media intermediary, which is more legally binding.

4.8.1 Procedure under Section 69A

- Who blocks: the Central Government — and within the Central Government, the Ministry of Electronics and IT.
- Nodal officers from the central government and the states forward content to the Ministry of Electronics and IT.
- The applicable rules are the **IT Blocking Rules 2009** — different from the **IT Rules 2021** (significant social media intermediaries) that were studied for the civil services prelims; the 2009 rules are completely meant for blocking.
- There is a **blocking committee** which issues the order; it is chaired by a designated officer from the Ministry of Electronics and IT and also has representatives from the Ministry of Law and Justice, the Ministry of Home, the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting and the Computer Emergency Response Team.
- The order needs to be approved by the Secretary, Ministry of Electronics and IT.
- In an emergency, the order can be issued by the designated officer and later approved by the blocking committee, within 48 hours.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **The Catch.**
>
> - The Ministry of Electronics is just a stamp; the individual is just a stamp.
> - Ever since the 2009 rules have been implemented, the blocking committee has not even once disapproved a blocking order passed by the designated officer.
> - This means that if a website, any content or any social media intermediary firm has to be taken down tomorrow, there is no parliamentary, no judicial and no other safeguard available against the orders passed by the chairman — these are the powers of the Ministry of Electronics under the blocking rules framed under the IT Act.

4.8.2 Grounds and Scope of Blocking

- Sovereignty and integrity of India.
- Defence.
- Security of the state.
- Friendly relations with foreign states.
- Public order.

- What can be blocked: access to any information generated, received or hosted by any computer resource.
- It has to be adhered to by any agency of government or an intermediary.
- Such an order under Section 69A has to be through a court order or an appropriate government notification, and must give reasons in writing.

4.8.3 The Telegram Blocking

- Telegram is used for spreading pirated material, so on Telegram the pirated material has to be banned.
- There are three options: one, remove the content from the channel and spare the channel; two, kill or block the entire channel; and three, forget the post on the channel.
- Because the law clearly says "access to information", this information can be construed to be the entire platform — and the whole platform has been closed under Section 69A.
- Blocking can be of a social media platform, a user, a channel or a particular channel; seven days are given to block.
- **Overbreadth** means the government takes disproportionate steps for one action; but when the Delhi High Court received the petition from Telegram it said the blocking of Telegram was nothing but a 100% proportionate exercise — proportionate to the objective of smoothly conducting the examination and preventing paper leakage.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Telegram as Information.**
>
> - In the recent Telegram blocking order, the entire intermediary platform of Telegram was interpreted as **information** under **Section 69A**.

4.8.4 Section 79(3B) and the Shreya Singhal Case

- No specific grounds are mentioned; safe harbour protection is given to the social media intermediary that observes due diligence while discharging its duties and, upon receiving actual knowledge, expeditiously removes or disables access to the material.
- Actual knowledge includes a court order or a government notification, and must relate to the same grounds as provided in **Section 69A**.
- This is the **Shreya Singhal case** — the grounds interpreted for Section 79 are the same as, or similar to, the grounds under Section 69A.
- Previously the takedown orders that governments issued were under Section 79(3)(b); the recent Telegram ban took recourse to Section 69A instead, because it has more legal clarity, it was meant to prevent the paper leak, and it carries a stronger weight of the government in the court of law.
- Telegram had said two years earlier that Section 79(3)(b) only grants it safe harbour protection but is being repeatedly used by the government to target it under the due diligence clause, issuing notifications to remove content despite the safeguards under Section 69A.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **The Grounds Question.**
>
> - The grounds which are clearly, statutorily provided in Section 69A — or grounds similar to those — will be the grounds when a takedown order of any content is issued under Section 79.

4.8.5 Reasons for Takedown

1. To uphold national security, public order and other grounds.
2. To regulate cybercrime — certain websites are involved in malicious trading activities, dark web access and some URLs.
3. To regulate VPNs — Proton VPN became a FIFA World Cup sponsor, and the government has told VPN providers to act; VPNs are used for access to content, such as an editing software used for videos which has been banned in India since 2020, it is recalled, because of Chinese investment in that project.
4. Prevention of paper leaks, piracy, and upholding the intellectual property rights of creators, authors, producers and educators.
5. Prevention of privacy violations and child pornography — the new term is **CSEAM, child sexual exploitative and abuse material**, devised by the Court.
6. AI-generated content — deepfakes and synthetically generated information (SGI); the example is MP Tharoor's deepfake video.
7. Misinformation and fake news.
8. Communal hatred — posts and videos provoking communal violence.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

The Government's Justification.

- Statutory safeguards.
- Judicial review.
- Fundamental rights are not absolute.
- The government argues that procedural safeguards exist and grounds are clearly mentioned, and that anyone with a doubt should fight the case in a court of law.

4.8.6 Issues Concerning Blocking or Takedown Orders

- One, it **restricts or violates fundamental rights** — blocking affects the right to express, the right to receive information and the right to criticize.
  - Example: the **Anuradha Bhasin case (2020)** — a very important journalist of Jammu and Kashmir, an editor of a newspaper started by her father, who also wrote a book on J&K; in February 2020 the Court held that freedom of speech and expression and the freedom to practise any profession over the internet are protected by **Article 19(1)(a)** and **Article 19(1)(g)**.
  - The context was the internet shutdown proclaimed in J&K in the aftermath of the abrogation of **Article 370** of the Constitution.
- Two, it is criticized for **overbreadth** — a keyword; the **functional creep** keyword from the Aadhaar case applies here too, where Aadhaar, meant for asserting proof of identity, may be sought by a private organisation, but the individual has the right to reject sharing Aadhaar data and give any government ID proof in that case.
- It is also criticized for a disproportionate response, because account-level or platform-level blocking has a **chilling effect** for journalists, activists, political commentators, satirists, civil

society organisations and media platforms.

  - Example: blocking of individual accounts on X — a local news reporter who has a very small shop in which he built a small studio and holds a camera; social media gives such reach that two or three people can have almost 3–4 lakh followers and give pure content, criticizing government actions in a very responsible manner. A Saturday article in the Hindu, in the Spotlight section, covered this.
  - The government had even blocked the account of Justice Sanjay Hegde, who had drafted the Lokpal Bill in 2010, 2011 and 2012, when Anna Hazare had started the protest.
- Three, **parallel exercise of Section 79(3B)** of the IT Act despite Section 69A being the statutory provision containing procedural safeguards — as pointed out by Twitter.
  - Insert a table of comparison.

Objective	Blocking	Safe harbour clause
Grounds	Clearly mentioned (similar to Article 19(2))	No grounds mentioned; the Supreme Court says the grounds are the same as under Section 69A
Safeguards	Stringent	Lesser stringent
Authority	Only the Central Government, through the Ministry of Electronics and IT	Other ministries, plus the states through the Sahayog portal

4.8.7 *Criticism of the Increasing Use of Blocking Powers*

- **Doubling of takedown orders** — the numbers are **12,600** and **24,300**. Draw a proper diagram and box it, showing the doubling.
- **Increasing censorship**, as the government plans to decentralize blocking powers under Section 69A to several ministries and thereby create a censorship regime.
- **Dilution of the Supreme Court's Shreya Singhal case (2015)** — in that case the Court struck down Section 66A (under which the police could arrest a person for saying anything bad on the internet) and upheld Section 69A because of its procedural safeguards, such as grounds, reasoned orders, and judicial review. In practice the exercise has diluted it: unilateral decisions taken by the designated officer of the blocking committee, and use of **Rule 16 of the Blocking Rules 2009**, where blocking proceedings can be kept confidential — meaning the blocking order and reasons are not provided to the affected parties. Rules 8, 9 and 16 exist in these rules.
- **Lack of independent oversight** — there is no parliamentary oversight or approval of Parliament; blocking orders are to be reviewed by the blocking committee, which is an executive body, and, interestingly, the blocking committee has never overturned a blocking order.
- **Limited legal remedy** — the mandatory hearing requirement under Rule 18 / Rule 8 of the

Blocking Rules 2009 is bypassed by invoking emergency powers.

- **Collateral blocking** — a website ban on intermediaries also leads to the blocking of lawful content.
  - Example: in July 2025 the account of **Reuters on X** was blocked. Reuters is a news agency that usually supplies international news to India; many accounts were blocked, including the X account of Reuters, and it was then found that the account of a primary news agency had been blocked — like PIB's account getting blocked. A safeguard was later brought and the block removed, but it took a lot of time and the criticism was severe.

CRITICAL POINT

Net Position.

- Therefore, despite the sufficient statutory safeguards provided under the rules, the law has been criticized for having a chilling effect on speech and expression.

4.8.8 *Way Forward*

1. Account-level or platform-level blocking to be prevented, instead of URL blocking.
2. Independent oversight mechanism led by the judiciary or Parliament.
3. Exercise under Section 69A instead of Section 79.
4. Publishing of transparency reports by the platforms — providing data on takedown requests, categories of content and compliance rates.
5. Issuing time-bound orders having sunset clauses, in order to prevent permanent blocking.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Questions Framed in the Lecture.

- "Online digital free speech is a vital expression of freedom of speech and expression but subject to regulation. Discuss the need and issues concerning the regulation under the IT Act 2000."
- "Fundamental rights are not absolute. Discuss in the light of recent takedown or blocking orders of the government under the IT Act." (Do not go into the sections here.)
- "The IT Act 2000 has outlived its purpose. Do you agree? Discuss by providing relevant case laws."
- For the third question there is no case law on "outlived its purpose"; the Supreme Court has never struck down the IT Act, it has only struck down some sections. Do not directly disagree — say that there are concerns, but in your opinion it still serves the relevant purpose, and give the points in support of why the IT Act is required, along with the observations of the Supreme Court: for example, the Shreya Singhal case (2015) upheld Sections 69A and 79 because of their inherent procedural safeguards.

QUICK REVISION

- Two IT Act routes: Section 69A (procedural safeguards) and Section 79(3B) (safe harbour, more legally binding).

- Section 69A blocking is ordered by a blocking committee chaired by a MeitY designated officer, approved by the MeitY Secretary, and can be issued by the designated officer in an emergency within 48 hours.
- The catch: the committee has never disapproved a blocking order since 2009, leaving no real safeguard.
- Grounds: sovereignty and integrity, defence, security of the state, friendly relations with foreign states, public order.
- Telegram: the entire intermediary platform was treated as "information" under 69A; three options (spare the channel, block the channel, forget the post); 7 days to block.
- Issues: fundamental rights affected (Anuradha Bhasin 2020), overbreadth and functional creep, disproportionate response and chilling effect, and parallel exercise of 79(3B).
- Criticism and Way Forward: doubling of takedown orders (12,600 to 24,300), censorship regime, dilution of Shreya Singhal 2015, no independent oversight, limited legal remedy, collateral blocking (Reuters on X, July 2025); cure via URL-level blocking instead of platform blocking, independent oversight, use of 69A, transparency reports and sunset clauses.

4.9 Bail Jurisprudence: Bail as the Rule, Jail as the Exception

This is a historically important topic. The principle is that **bail is the rule and jail is the exception**, but it has been overpowered by the recent interpretation of the Supreme Court. Even under stringent laws such as the **PMLA 2002** and the **UAPA**, the Supreme Court is saying that Articles 20 and 21 overpower the statutory framework of anti-bail or stringent laws that revert the logic of bail as the rule and incarceration as the exception.

DATA & FACTS

The Andhrabi Judgment.

- The Bench comprised Justice Bhuyan (from Assam) and Justice B. Nagaratna, who is the daughter of the former Chief Justice of India Venkat Chaliah and would be the first woman Chief Justice of India — though only for 35–40 days, in 2027.
- The courts themselves are at divergence: even if a person has been kept behind bars for 5–6–7 years under the UAPA, prolonged incarceration even under an anti-terrorist law becomes a ground for release or bail.
- Tushar Mehta, the Solicitor General, made an interesting argument that this would mean giving bail to Kasab and Hafiz Saeed after 4–5 years — a remark made because he had to defend the government.

4.9.1 Framework

1. Statutory and constitutional provisions.
2. Issues concerning the right to bail — bail as a rule and jail as the exception.
3. Way forward.

4.9.2 Constitutional Basis of Bail

- A person cannot be made to undergo punishment before conviction.
- **Article 22** provides safeguards against arbitrary arrest; these safeguards are essential to secure bail.
  - Example: the grounds of arrest — unless the ground of arrest is stated by the government in the order, bail cannot be secured. Procedural safeguards under Article 22 are essential for laying the foundation of an individual's bail.
- **Article 14** ensures non-arbitrariness in bail decisions.
- **Article 39A** provides for free legal aid.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Statutory Provisions.

- Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita provisions **478–483** provide for bail, the release of undertrials after detention, bail in a non-bailable offence, anticipatory bail, and the special powers of the High Court and the Sessions Court.

4.9.3 Important Case Laws

- **State of Rajasthan v Balchand (1977)** — popular for the principle "**bail not jail is the rule**".
- **Hussainara Khatoon** — held that speedy trial, legal aid and undertrial liberty are integral to Article 21.
- **K.A. Najeeb case (2021)** — statutory restrictions to bail under the UAPA cannot justify indefinite incarceration where the trial is unlikely to conclude soon.

QUICK REVISION

- Bail is the rule and jail is the exception, but stringent laws (PMLA 2002, UAPA) have been read down by Articles 20 and 21.
- Andhrabi judgment — Justices Bhuyan and Nagaratna; prolonged incarceration under an anti-terror law can ground bail; Tushar Mehta's Kasab/Hafiz Saeed remark.
- Framework: statutory and constitutional provisions, issues concerning the right to bail, way forward.
- Constitutional basis: no punishment before conviction; Article 22 safeguards (grounds of arrest), Article 14 non-arbitrariness, Article 39A free legal aid.
- Statutory base: Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita 478–483.
- Case laws: State of Rajasthan v Balchand 1977 (bail not jail is the rule), Hussainara Khatoon (Article 21), K.A. Najeeb 2021 (no indefinite incarceration).

CHAPTER 5

Right to Bail, Abortion Jurisprudence and the Anti-Defection Law

5.1 Bail as the Rule, Jail as the Exception: Issues and Concerns

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **The governing principle.**
>
> - **Bail is the rule and jail is the exception** is the principle laid down by the Supreme Court, and it frames the entire discussion.
> - The issues below examine the problems with this idea as it has been set by the Supreme Court.

- **First issue — undertrial crowding:** the lack of grant of bail by the courts has led to overcrowding in prisons.
  - Overcrowding means that a very large share of those lodged in prison have not yet been convicted — they are undertrials.
- **Second issue — delay in release of undertrials:** bail is granted, but hurdles prevent actual release.
  - Provision of security: after bail is granted, someone has to stand guarantee, and local guarantors are often not available.
  - Bond money: the bond amount has to be deposited.
  - Documentation: documents also have to be deposited.
  - The court grants bail but will still take surety and ask for documents; if these are not possible, the person is automatically not released despite bail having been granted — it can take a day or two, or a week or more, and the undertrial still cannot secure bail.
  - The United States concept of **cashless bail** is relevant here; action on it was recently carried out by Donald Trump.
- **Third issue — delay in bail hearings** because of frequent adjournments or poor case management.
  - **Case management** in law means the administrative side of law: once a case is filed, there has to be a listing order — whose case comes first, second and third — but even that requires a method in the madness.
  - Prioritisation matters: if my bail application is pending, my case must be prioritised over another person's property dispute, and a hearing under UAPA requires more assistance than an ordinary matter.

  - Pendency of cases compounds the problem: cases pending in the courts lead to a situation where bail hearings are automatically delayed.
  - The National Judicial Data Grid keeps a running count of such pendency.
- **Fourth issue — risk-averse lower courts:** in the Manish Sisodia case, the Supreme Court observed the tendency among lower courts to play safe and ignore that bail is the rule and jail is the exception.
  - Current-affairs aside noted while discussing the CBI, which was in the news: in the recent Haryana scam almost Rs. 600 crore was diverted from an IDFC account; an IES officer who had got elected and two or three HCS officers were involved in siphoning off funds, and they were arrested.
- **Fifth issue — transmission and implementation delays:** physical transmission of release orders for bail delays actual release, and therefore restricts personal liberty under **Article 21**.
  - Recently, the Allahabad High Court directed an **electronic bail order management system** to prevent communication delays.
- **Sixth issue — bail rights versus anti-bail legislations:** this is the important concern that the stringent statutes reverse the usual principle of bail, and it is taken up in the next sub-topic.

DATA & FACTS

Figures to remember.

- **75% of the prison population consists of undertrials** — given by the NCRB (National Crime Records Bureau), 2023.
- About **5 crore to 5.5 crore cases are pending across the three tiers** of the judiciary.
- Supreme Court: about **80,000** pending cases (stated as 86,000; an earlier class wrote 93,000 — the National Judicial Data Grid keeps updating, so write 80,000).

QUICK REVISION

- Bail is the rule and jail is the exception — the Supreme Court principle being examined.
- Undertrial crowding: 75% of the prison population are undertrials (NCRB 2023).
- Delay in release: security, local guarantors, bond money and documentation block release even after bail is granted; compare the US concept of cashless bail.
- Delay in bail hearings: frequent adjournments, poor case management, and about 5–5.5 crore pending cases across the three tiers.
- Risk-averse lower courts — observed in the Manish Sisodia case.
- Transmission and implementation delays restrict personal liberty under Article 21; the Allahabad High Court directed an electronic bail order management system.

5.2 Bail Rights versus Anti-Bail Legislations

The concern here is bail rights versus anti-bail legislations: the grant of bail is a complex matter under stringent laws, because they reverse the usual principle that bail is the rule.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Stringent laws that reverse the usual principle.

- **UAPA, Section 43-D, clause 5:** bail is restricted where the court finds reasonable grounds for believing that the accusation is prima facie true.
- **PMLA, Section 45:** the Supreme Court construed these provisions in the light of the Enforcement Directorate case.
- The stringent laws repeatedly in question are UAPA and PMLA; the specific provisions are Section 43-D(5) of UAPA and Section 45 of PMLA, along with the NIA.

- **Doctrinal uncertainty:** courts are applying the established Supreme Court precedent under the **K.A. Najeeb case, 2021** in divergent ways; in that case the Court ruled that the right to a speedy trial can be a ground for bail even under a stringent law like UAPA.
  - **Sayyad Andrabi v. NIA** [as stated in lecture]: a recent two-judge bench ruling held that smaller benches are hollowing out the principle laid down in the K.A. Najeeb case.
  - **Gulfisha Fatima case** [as stated in lecture]: a divergent application of the K.A. Najeeb case, 2021, by the Supreme Court.

EXAMPLE

How the two strands emerged.

- **K.A. Najeeb case, 2021:** in the case of the student Najeeb, a three-judge bench held that if a person has been kept in prolonged incarceration, then — because the right to a speedy trial is a fundamental right — if there is no speedy trial, the person must be released.
- In the case of a terror law, that right gets restricted; even there the Court said that if incarceration is prolonged because of delay in trial, and the delay is the prosecution's fault and not the person's, the person has to be released — a very liberal interpretation by the Supreme Court.
- **2018–19:** a two-judge bench authored by **Justice Khanwilkar** [as stated in lecture] had said that material satisfaction is enough for the courts to accept that there is an apprehension of the crime being committed, or that the accusation is prima facie true; the Najeeb case, in a way, gave rights to the accused.
- **Sayyad Andrabi v. NIA** [as stated in lecture]: in this case the journalist was released.
- **Gulfisha Fatima case** [as stated in lecture], decided in February: Gulfisha Fatima is a student; two or three students have been in jail for six years, as they were arrested under UAPA in 2020, when Trump had come to India; in this case, despite the trial being prolonged, that was held not to be a sufficient ground, and not a restriction on the statutory provisions of UAPA that restrict bail; **Justices Ujjal Bhuyan and Nagarathna** [as stated in lecture] have been criticised for the Gulfisha Fatima case.
- A subsequent ruling by **Justice Kumar** [as stated in lecture] held that there is a doctrinal uncertainty of application — the doctrine is set, but different courts and different benches lay it out differently.
- Because of this doctrinal inconsistency, the matter has been referred to a five-judge Constitu-

tion Bench to resolve, with respect to bail jurisprudence under stringent laws — for example PMLA, NIA and UAPA, that is, Section 45 PMLA and Section 43-D(5) UAPA.

- The position of the Supreme Court vis-a-vis bail in stringent laws is therefore divergent.

5.2.1 Way Forward

- The right to bail is one of the important constitutional rights, and it is also applicable in cases of stringent laws like UAPA.
- Until the point the Constitution Bench adjudicates on the right to bail under stringent laws, the lower courts should adhere to the K.A. Najeeb case, 2021.

QUICK REVISION

- Stringent laws reverse the usual principle of bail: UAPA Section 43-D(5) and PMLA Section 45.
- UAPA 43-D(5) restricts bail where the court finds reasonable grounds for believing the accusation is prima facie true.
- K.A. Najeeb case 2021: right to speedy trial can ground bail even under a stringent law like UAPA, because of prolonged incarceration.
- Doctrinal uncertainty: divergent application of K.A. Najeeb in the Gulfisha Fatima case and the Sayyad Andrabi v. NIA case; smaller benches are said to be hollowing out the principle.
- The two strands were referred to a five-judge Constitution Bench.
- Way forward: right to bail is an important constitutional right even under stringent laws; lower courts should adhere to K.A. Najeeb until the Constitution Bench decides.

5.3 Abortion and Reproductive Autonomy: The Core Debate

The concern is the unmarried woman's — or any woman's — choice to abort the fetus.

COMPARISON

Pro-life versus pro-choice.

- **Pro-life:** talks about the rights of the fetus; you can also write down ethics.
- **Pro-choice:** the female's choice; females have the right to **reproductive autonomy** under Article 21.

When the fetus being carried by the mother is aborted, the life of that fetus — his or her life, whichever way you want to put it — ends. The abortion debate therefore runs between two opposite sides of the discourse.

KEY CONCEPT

The dilemma and the statutory balance.

- This is the dilemma underlying abortion in India.
- The balance is **wonderfully struck under the Medical Termination of Pregnancy Act, 1971**

— women's rights on one side and the rights of the fetus on the other.

- But the problem is that this balance is tilting in favour of choice, because in the present times we are in the **post-Puttaswami framework**.
- The underlying constraint of life versus choice is basically the debate of religion and ethics versus pro-choice.

QUICK REVISION

- The concern is an unmarried woman's, or any woman's, choice to abort the fetus.
- Pro-life rests on the rights of the fetus and ethics; pro-choice rests on the female's choice and reproductive autonomy under Article 21.
- Abortion ends the life of the fetus, so the debate runs on two opposite sides of the discourse.
- The balance is wonderfully struck under the MTP Act, 1971, but it is now tilting in favour of choice — the post-Puttaswami framework.
- Underlying constraint: religion and ethics versus pro-choice.

5.4 Evolution of Abortion Law: Pre-1971 to the Present

- **Pre-1971 — abortion was a crime:** it was a colonial-era framework in which religion or the Victorian legal framework dominated, and there were limited rights for women.
  - The Indian Penal Code punished voluntary miscarriage.
  - The balance was completely in favour of life, as compared to choice, or the rights of women, or the rights of the fetus.
- **Towards 1971 — unsafe abortions and maternal mortality:** unsafe abortions were taking place and were leading to maternal mortality; the **Shantilal Shah Committee** was formed to address the concern, and finally, in 1971, the **Medical Termination of Pregnancy Act, 1971** was passed.
  - MTP 1971 was an example of a progressive law that sought to balance choice versus life.
- **2021 amendment:** the gestational limits were increased to 24 weeks for certain categories of vulnerable women.
- **2022 — a big Supreme Court case: X v. Principal Secretary, Health and Family Welfare, Government of NCT of Delhi** broadened the category of women benefiting under the law by including unmarried women, so that they can exercise their reproductive right.
- **2024 [as stated in lecture] (referred to as 2026 in the lecture):** the Supreme Court asked the Union Government to remove the time limit of 24 weeks on medical termination of unwanted pregnancies in the case of minor rape victims.
  - If a girl below 18 is sexually assaulted and the pregnancy is discovered at 24, 25 or 26 weeks, there are currently constraints; these should be removed — there should be no time limit for such victims.
  - The Supreme Court upheld the right to reproductive autonomy for females and told the Government to amend the law.

DATA & FACTS

Timeline of the statute and the case law.

- **1971** — the Medical Termination of Pregnancy Act is passed.
- **2021** — amendment raising gestational limits to 24 weeks for certain categories of vulnerable women.
- **2022** — X v. Principal Secretary, Health and Family Welfare, Government of NCT of Delhi, extending the benefit to unmarried women.
- **2024 [as stated in lecture] / 2026** — Supreme Court direction to remove the 24-week limit for minor rape victims; and the 30-week pregnant minor girl case.

- The Court's directions involve consent: it is specifically focusing on cases where consent was not there — non-consensual sexual intercourse by the male, leading to sexual assault and thereby to unwanted pregnancy — despite the age of consent being 18.
- So if a female of 17 years engages in consensual intercourse with her partner, becomes pregnant and wants to terminate it, she will not come under the recent recommendation to amend and remove the time limit, because that is not rape — though technically that is a rape.

CRITICAL POINT

Doctrinal inconsistency in the Supreme Court's own record.

- In recent cases the Supreme Court has **denied MTP, privileging fetal viability over the woman's reproductive choice**.
- In 2026, in the case of a 30-week pregnant minor girl, the Court clearly allowed termination of pregnancy despite a curative petition filed by the medical team of AIIMS.
- Despite ruling in that way, a doctrinal inconsistency is visible in two cases written by the same author: **Justice Chandrachud** in one opinion gave clear primacy to fetal viability, and in the other case gave primacy to women's rights.
- There is therefore **no clear framework** with respect to the legal application or legal enforcement of the Medical Termination of Pregnancy Act, 1971.
- The balance is still not perfect — this is only what the law wanted to achieve.

QUICK REVISION

- Pre-1971: abortion was a crime under a colonial-era, Victorian framework; the IPC punished voluntary miscarriage; the balance favoured life completely.
- Unsafe abortions caused maternal mortality; the Shantilal Shah Committee led to the MTP Act, 1971 — a progressive balance of choice versus life.
- 2021 amendment: gestational limits raised to 24 weeks for certain vulnerable women.
- 2022: X v. Principal Secretary, Health and Family Welfare, Government of NCT of Delhi — unmarried women brought within the benefit.
- 2024 [as stated in lecture] / 2026: Supreme Court asked the Union Government to remove the 24-week limit for minor rape victims; it upheld reproductive autonomy.

- The 2026 direction turns on absence of consent; a 17-year-old's consensual pregnancy is not covered.
- Doctrinal inconsistency: recent cases deny MTP privileging fetal viability, while Justice Chandrachud's opinions take both sides — no clear framework.

5.5 MTP Act: Legal Provisions by Gestational Period

The legal provision depends on the gestational period, and along with it the category to which the woman belongs.

Up to 20 weeks (about five months)	One registered medical practitioner	The registered medical practitioner performs the procedure
Above 20 weeks to 24 weeks	Two doctors, and the woman must fall in a limited category (2021 amendment)	The two registered medical practitioners
Beyond 24 weeks	Medical board evaluation	The court, after the medical board's decision

- The **limited categories** that qualify for termination between 20 and 24 weeks are: survivors of sexual assault, rape and incest; minors; and change in marital status during an ongoing pregnancy.
  - **Incest** — the term was posed as a question in the lecture, and its meaning was not defined there.
  - **Change in marital status is not applicable to live-in partners** — put a question mark against this; the position was to be confirmed.
  - Example: if a woman was pregnant with the child of her husband, got divorced, and a new partner came during the pregnancy, she can terminate the pregnancy beyond 20 weeks, up to 24 weeks.
- **Beyond 24 weeks the decision lies with the court:** the court decides after the medical board's decision — a medical board is constituted for this purpose.
  - The conditions are **substantial fetal abnormality** — a deformity in the fetus, or something that threatens its life, such that it cannot breathe, as happens when stillbirths or unborn children are delivered — and termination to save the life of the pregnant woman.
  - All the cases that appear in the newspapers are beyond 24 weeks.
- **Late detection:** where a woman discovers the pregnancy late, is a rape victim, and there is no threat to the fetus's life and no threat to her own life, she may still be distressed and distraught, because her emotional and mental well-being is totally affected.
  - **The evolving benefit of technology:** earlier, babies delivered at 6, 7 or about 8 months had a very low chance of survival and a high possibility of major disease; today a premature

baby of even seven months can be kept in ICU, given medicine and saved by technology.

- This has further made the exercise of reproductive autonomy much tougher for women: earlier it could be said that the mother's life was at risk, but now the risk to the mother and to the fetus has reduced because of technology — so technology has, in a way, become a hindrance.

KEY CONCEPT

Consent in termination of pregnancy.

- **Consent belongs to the woman**, but in practice the registered medical practitioner and the persons around her are decisive.
- If a married adult woman wants to terminate, the doctor says that spousal consent is not required; a recent Supreme Court decision also holds that the decision is the patient's — even if the husband objects, she can abort.
- Where she is a minor, and in both cases, unless the doctor agrees, the abortion will not happen.
- Therefore consent in both cases, depending on marital status, is taken from the doctor and other persons around the woman, and not necessarily from the woman alone; the doctors' legal role here is very large.

QUICK REVISION

- The provision depends on the gestational period and the category of the woman.
- Up to 20 weeks: one registered medical practitioner performs the procedure.
- 20 to 24 weeks: two doctors, and the woman must fall in a limited category — survivors of sexual assault, rape and incest; minors; change in marital status during an ongoing pregnancy.
- Change in marital status is not applicable to live-in partners (to be confirmed; marked with a question mark).
- Beyond 24 weeks: the court decides after the medical board's decision, on substantial fetal abnormality or to save the life of the pregnant woman.
- Late detection and the benefits of technology have made reproductive autonomy tougher, because risk to the mother and fetus has fallen.
- Consent belongs to the woman, but the registered medical practitioner's agreement is decisive.

5.6 Arguments in Support of the MTP Act 1971 Framework

The case in support of the Medical Termination of Pregnancy Act, 1971 framework rests on four arguments.

1. The State will take care of the child — if the child has to be taken care of, the State will take care of that.
2. It aligns with international legislations, as most countries internationally restrict the period of safe abortion to 24 weeks.
3. It is a forward-looking statute that recognises unsafe clandestine abortions, even where the

consent of parents, family members and the doctors is required.

4. It aligns with technological progress, as advances in medicine ensure the survival of premature babies — premature babies born at seven months survive with proper natal care — and thereby remove the need for MTP, that is, medical termination of pregnancy.

EXAMPLE

The doctor and medical board example behind the fourth argument.

- Earlier, if a baby was found to be premature at 6 or 7 months, the courts treated its life as being at risk, and the medical board would say that the baby would come into the world with some lung or brain ailment, and that it was better to abort.
- Today a premature baby born at even seven months can be given proper natal care and made healthy with proper technique, so there is no need for medical termination of pregnancy.
- This is why the 24-week duration is exactly right: if it were 30 weeks, one would have to answer why, because it cannot simply be that the child's life is at risk or that there is fetal abnormality — technology and medicine have improved, so even a 30-week baby, that is a premature baby, can be cared for.
- Who decides whether the child's life is at risk? The doctor. Earlier, without technology, risk to the child's life could be a reason for abortion; now, because of technology, that risk may not exist, so even a premature baby can be delivered and cared for.
- These provisions of the law align with the progression and change happening in technology.

QUICK REVISION

- First argument: the State will take care of the child.
- Second argument: it aligns with international legislations — most countries restrict safe abortion to 24 weeks.
- Third argument: it is a forward-looking statute that recognises unsafe clandestine abortions, even where parental, family and doctors' consent is required.
- Fourth argument: it aligns with technological progress — advances in medicine let premature babies born at seven months survive with proper natal care, removing the need for MTP.
- The 24-week limit is justified by technology; at 30 weeks one would have to explain why termination is needed.
- Whether the child's life is at risk is decided by the doctor.

5.7 Issues with the MTP Act Framework

The issues with the provisions of the Medical Termination of Pregnancy Act are set out below, beginning with the biggest issue.

- **A. Colonial-era framework:** the law represents a colonial-era framework, where the existing legal and statutory mechanism punishes voluntary miscarriage.
  - Example: the penal law criminalises voluntary miscarriage; the MTP Act is itself subject to a larger legal ecosystem, an overall framework of this kind.

- **B. Limited reproductive autonomy:** the law limits the right to decide with whom and how to have children, plus the right to reproductive choices — to procreate as well as to abstain.
  - Once I have conceived, the right to decide that I will not bear the child does not belong to me; it is subject to the decision of the registered medical practitioner.
  - **Fetal viability is prioritised despite undefined fetal rights.**
- **C. Poor mental health is not a ground for termination beyond 20 weeks**, despite the Supreme Court ruling in the **Sukdeb Saha case** [as stated in lecture] that the right to mental health is an integral part of the right to life under **Article 21**.
- **D. Procedural barriers and social stigma:** registered medical practitioners require spousal or parental consent, plus extensive paperwork, plus lengthy medical evaluation.
  - Social stigma and lack of awareness of entitlements delay access.
  - Therefore, delayed access is not because of choice, but because of institutions, family structures and violence — do not do it, you will need the husband's or the parent's permission, what will the doctor think, what will society think — and all these factors end up causing a delay in the exercise of rights.
- **E. Legal loopholes and complexities:** the law allows change in marital status as a ground for abortion for pregnancies between 20 and 24 weeks, but it is not applicable to a live-in relationship.
  - If a woman's husband changes and she is pregnant between 20 and 24 weeks, she can get that pregnancy aborted.
  - But if she is pregnant with the first partner and is in a live-in relationship with a new partner, that cannot be a ground for termination if it exceeds the time limit of 20 weeks.
  - This is clearly a violation of the right to equality and of the application of the principles of the MTP Act, which is based on the rights of women.
  - It makes no difference whether you are a married woman or unmarried, whether it is your husband or your boyfriend — these are implementation concerns.
- **F. Other implementation barriers:** geographical barriers for tribal and backward belts; limited healthcare facilities, because the law does not take into account the shortage of service providers and of adequately equipped facilities, especially in cases of later gestational termination; and legal indeterminacy or uneven interpretation of the law.
  - The legal-indeterminacy strand is elaborated below.
- **G. Divergence with other laws:** as per MTP, an adolescent or minor can seek termination of pregnancy, but under **POCSO** the doctor has to mandatorily report to the police.
  - Though in 2022 the Supreme Court reconciled MTP with POCSO by directing that the identity of the minor should not be revealed, implementation remains shoddy.
- **H. Issues related to medical practitioners or doctors:** fear of prosecution among registered medical practitioners is a barrier to abortion access, especially in cases of late-stage terminations.
  - Ethical tensions of managing fetal considerations and rights, reproductive rights or patient autonomy, legal compliance, and fear of prosecution.
  - The doctor must weigh the woman's rights, fetal viability concerns and fetal rights, and the

fear that the police may come after him — the parents may ask why the abortion was done, and since the minor falls under POCSO, why it was not reported — and the doctor cannot simply tell the police that a 2022 judgment of the Supreme Court exists.

Legal Indeterminacy and Uneven Interpretation

- In practice the marital status of the woman makes a perverse difference: a married woman at 27 weeks may be permitted termination, while an unmarried woman asking at 27 weeks on the ground of poor mental health may be told she is characterless, that she took a step, that she is married, and so on.
- When judges decide these matters, the principle of balancing the rights of the fetus and the rights of females is inconsistent — judges apply their individual morals and societal morals to rule on the need to terminate the pregnancy, which should not be connected with the morals or ethics of society. It is a law, and it has to be applied and implemented like a law.
- Different courts may assign different moral and legal weight to different grounds, leading to variability in outcomes.
- Example: for minors and sexual assault survivors, the courts permit MTP by citing legal precedent, but for other personal reasons it depends on the whims and views of the bench.

CRITICAL POINT

Conclusion of the critique.

- Therefore, despite the law being progressive, it prioritises a conditional, qualified, consent-based criminal framework as compared to a reproductive-rights or patient-autonomy framework.
- In effect the law says: if you want an abortion, take the doctor's permission and meet the conditions — all of these must be met for it to happen.
- But the law does not intend this. The objective of the law is clear: consent belongs to the woman, not to the husband. If a husband wants his wife's pregnancy terminated, the doctor will take the consent of the wife, not the husband; the opposite is clearly against the principles of the law, and against reproductive rights and patient autonomy.
- The mistake is not in the law; the mistake is that times have changed and the law is not suited to them. From 1971 to 2026 is 55 years — almost half a century, more than half a century — so changes must be brought to the entire mechanism of viewing and the perspective on termination of pregnancy.

- MTP mandates that it is the decision of the individual, but when doctors implement it, they tend to advise or promote their own view and to keep themselves safe from prosecution, so they ensure that the consent of the individual is also taken.
- That is why the Supreme Court has recently said that it is the decision of the patient to abort without any consent required from any husband or live-in partner, in case the patient is an adult.

KEY CONCEPT

Student doubt — the rights of the father.

- **Doubt:** the father, or the husband, is also an equal party in the process of procreation — so what about paternal rights, or the rights of the father?
- **Answer:** theoretically there is no error here. Tomorrow, if the wife conceives with the husband and wants to carry the child forward, the husband is involved too, and vice versa. But this dimension can be refrained from in this perspective, because it was not found in the literature on the field that was referred to — those documents did not mention paternal rights, though it can be quoted. There is no disagreement; it is relevant, and it can be written.
- Because the child is born by the mother, the debate is choice versus life only; primarily, that is the prime concern. The point can be substantiated in these terms, and if the answer is about ethics, the rights of a father may be written; otherwise, since there is already a lot to write, it need not be mentioned.

QUICK REVISION

- A. Colonial-era framework: the legal mechanism punishes voluntary miscarriage.
- B. Limited reproductive autonomy: the right to decide with whom and how to have children, and to procreate or abstain, is constrained; the RMP decides; fetal viability is prioritised despite undefined fetal rights.
- C. Poor mental health is not a ground beyond 20 weeks, despite the Sukdeb Saha case holding mental health to be part of Article 21.
- D. Procedural barriers and social stigma: spousal or parental consent, paperwork, lengthy medical evaluation, lack of awareness.
- E. Legal loopholes: change in marital status works between 20 and 24 weeks, but not for live-in relationships — a violation of equality.
- F. Implementation barriers: geographical barriers for tribal and backward belts; limited healthcare facilities; legal indeterminacy and uneven interpretation; different courts, different weights, variable outcomes.
- G. Divergence with POCSO: mandatory police reporting versus confidentiality; the 2022 reconciliation on non-disclosure of the minor's identity, with shoddy implementation.
- H. Doctors' issues: fear of prosecution and ethical tensions; the conclusion is that the law prioritises a consent-based criminal framework over reproductive rights, and the fault is the changed times, not the law.

5.8 Way Forward on Abortion Law

1. Revisit or amend the statutory framework as per the Supreme Court's 2026 decision vis-a-vis unwanted minor pregnancy for victims of sexual assault.
2. Strict procedural timelines for medical boards.
3. Harmonise POCSO and MTP for adolescent healthcare, which preserves mandatory reporting for abuse and exploitation while protecting confidentiality in consensual adolescent care —

the requirement to report must be adhered to along with the aspect of confidentiality.

- Concludingly, the law should uphold a rights-based framework, enshrining reproductive rights and autonomy, along with medical oversight as a safeguard.
- Termination of pregnancy is a technical affair; after 20 to 23 weeks it becomes a tough affair — an article in The Hindu noted that the baby's bones have formed by then, so the complexities are far greater.
- On one side there is autonomy, on the other side there is health; therefore clear-cut standards for doctors are very necessary, and eventually a clear statutory framework for doctors is required.

QUICK REVISION

- Way forward 1: revisit or amend the statutory framework as per the 2026 Supreme Court decision on unwanted minor pregnancy of sexual-assault victims.
- Way forward 2: strict procedural timelines for medical boards.
- Way forward 3: harmonise POCSO and MTP for adolescent healthcare — mandatory reporting for abuse and exploitation with confidentiality in consensual adolescent care.
- The law should uphold a rights-based framework, enshrining reproductive rights and autonomy, with medical oversight as a safeguard.
- Termination is a technical affair and becomes tough after 20 to 23 weeks; clear statutory standards for doctors are essential.

5.9 Parliament and Associated Current Affairs: Preparation Framework

The Parliament discussion begins with the anti-defection law, and then moves to the issue of delimitation and the constraints of increasing the seats of the Lok Sabha, along with bills.

- Analysis of Parliament and of parliamentary committees is part of this topic and is simple.
- The **RPA (Representation of the People Act), 1951** also forms part of this topic.
- Recent-issue and recommendation material on the anti-defection law includes articles by writers on defection law, such as PRS Legislative Research's **Chakshu Roy**, and a young writer, **Akanksha Bhomik** [as stated in lecture].

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Exam relevance and PYQ framing.

- In civil services, 10 to 12 bills have been passed in the last one to two years, so those bills should be prepared; even if one or two of them are asked, it matters.
- In previous years, questions have come around bills that are very important — such as the unfair means examination bill, and the NIA Amendment Bill, 2019 (not the 2018 version).
- Questions come around very big developments.
- For RPA 1951, five to six straight questions come; it does not require the structure and framing approach that fundamental rights requires.

QUICK REVISION

- Parliament: first the anti-defection law, then delimitation and the constraints of increasing Lok Sabha seats, along with bills.
- Analysis of Parliament and parliamentary committees is simple and forms part of the topic.
- RPA 1951 forms part of the topic and yields five to six straight questions.
- Bills: 10 to 12 passed in the last one to two years should be prepared.
- PYQ pattern: important bills such as the unfair means examination bill and the NIA Amendment Bill, 2019.
- Recent-issue and recommendation material on defection law is available from writers such as Chakshu Roy of PRS Legislative Research.

5.10 Anti-Defection Law: Resignation versus Defection

The recent issues under the anti-defection law are the delay by presiding officers in acting, the merger issue, and resignation versus defection.

- **Constitutional ambiguity: original party versus legislature party.**
- **Resignation versus defection** — earlier studied with **Article 101**: a member of Parliament resigns by writing to the presiding officer, and the resignation has to be accepted if it is voluntary and genuine.
- What is happening now is that legislators are defecting, but in order to evade the anti-defection law they resign before the presiding officer can disqualify them.
- The Supreme Court, in the Karnataka case, has said that it is not possible to act against your political party and then resign to escape disqualification.

COMPARISON

Resignation versus disqualification.

- **Resignation:** in both cases the member loses the seat, but after resignation the ex-member can be appointed a member of the Council of Ministers; the Constitution does not debar such a member from becoming a minister, so he can be appointed a minister the very next moment.
- **Disqualification:** if I am declared disqualified, I would need to recontest the elections, contest the by-election, and only then can I come back and be a minister — I have to go back to the electorate, the tables might turn by the time they vote again, and the constituency might penalise me.

- **Example — AIADMK:** AIADMK MLAs disobeyed the directions of their political party and supported Vijay.
  - The AIADMK Chief Whip told the Speaker to disqualify them, but while the Speaker was adjudicating on the disqualification of those four MLAs, they resigned in the meanwhile.
  - The Speaker, who is from Vijay's party, accepted the resignations; and in the case of some MLAs, the AIADMK Chief Whip had condoned the actions — **condoned** means pardoned or forgiven.

  - This is why the case came back in the context of the anti-defection law, and it is also important for political science.
- The example shows how members evade disqualification under the anti-defection law by resigning.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Supreme Court on resignation and disqualification.

- **Shrimanth Balasaheb Patil case, 2019:** the Supreme Court ruled that the taint of disqualification does not vaporise just because a member submitted his resignation prior to adjudication.
- **Limited deterrence:** a disqualified legislator can recontest, and therefore the purpose of the anti-defection law is defeated.
- In the same 2019 case, the Supreme Court struck down the decision of the Speaker to disqualify the defecting legislator for the remainder term.
- **Karnataka narrative, 2017:** defections took place in Karnataka; the Congress and JDS had formed the government in 2017; Mr Yeddyurappa was first called by the Governor — the Governor was from Gujarat, Vajubhai Vala — to take the oath; Yeddyurappa resigned, and then Congress and JDS formed the government, after which some defection took place.
- The Speaker disqualified legislators despite their resignations, and the Supreme Court upheld the Speaker's disqualification of those legislators; but the Speaker had also said that they would be disqualified for the entire remainder term of the assembly, and that aspect of the Speaker's decision was struck down.
- So an amendment is required in the anti-defection law: the Supreme Court said that such a disqualified legislator, if he is recontesting, has served his punishment and also has the right to profession.

QUICK REVISION

- Recent issues under the anti-defection law: presiding officers delaying action, the merger issue, and resignation versus defection.
- Resignation is governed by Article 101 — a member resigns to the presiding officer, and it must be accepted if voluntary and genuine.
- Defecting legislators resign before the presiding officer can disqualify them, to evade the anti-defection law.
- After resignation an ex-member can become a minister (the Constitution does not debar it), whereas a disqualified member must recontest and win a by-election.
- Shrimanth Balasaheb Patil case, 2019: the taint of disqualification does not vaporise because of prior resignation.
- Limited deterrence: a disqualified legislator can recontest, defeating the purpose of the anti-defection law; the remainder-term disqualification was struck down.
- Karnataka 2017: the Speaker's disqualification was upheld but the remainder-term part was struck down; an amendment is required.

5.11 Anti-Defection Law: Mergers and the Tenth Schedule

- **No punishment for the recipient party:** there is no sanction on the party that receives the defecting legislators — nothing penalises the BJP or any other party that receives them.
- Whether MPs joining the BJP is allowed under the anti-defection law or is defection is something the presiding officer has to decide.
- **Constitutional ambiguity in the merger clause:** it is unclear whether a deemed merger requires the permission of the original political party, or whether a merger may be deemed if two-thirds of the legislature party agree without a corresponding merger at the national level.
- The anti-defection law originally carried two exceptions: the provision of **split** and the provision of **merger**.
  - **Split:** one-third of the members separating from the parent political party — this is what took place, and it was struck down by the **91st Amendment, 2003**.
- Presently the merger provision applies when: (1) the parent political party agrees; or (2) two-thirds of the members of the legislature party agree.

KEY CONCEPT

Terminology — the parties and Paragraph 4.

- **Parent political party** — the party that is running the show; it has a legislature party as well as a parliamentary party.
- **Legislature party** — basically all the MLAs of that particular political party inside the legislature.
- **Parliamentary party** — all its members of the Lok Sabha and the Council of States.
- This is **Paragraph 4** of the **Tenth Schedule** — the merger clause of the anti-defection law.

- If both merger conditions are read in a **disjunctive manner** — that is, read separately — then it follows that a merger is deemed if the political parties agree, and alternatively if more than two-thirds of the members of any state assembly or of Parliament agree.
- This is what happened in the Aam Aadmi Party case: 10 members agreed, and a disjunctive reading was given because the parent political party had not agreed to the merger.
- The Supreme Court's position in these cases is that the legislature party — comprising the MLAs in the assembly or in Parliament — cannot be read as an entity different from the parent political party.
- So if the Aam Aadmi Party's merger has to fructify, it must first be agreed by the Aam Aadmi Party, and second by two-thirds of the members of the Aam Aadmi Party in the legislature in the country — which includes the Lok Sabha, the Council of States and the state legislatures.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Case law on mergers and splits.

- **Rajendra Singh Rana v. Swami Prasad Maurya, 2007:** the Supreme Court ruled that a split in the legislature party must stem from a corresponding split in the original political party.
- **Subhash Desai case, 2023:** the Supreme Court declined to interpret the Tenth Schedule in a

manner that severs the figurative umbilical cord between the legislature party and the parent political party — the umbilical cord connects both.

- **Punjab example:** 93 to 94 MLAs of the Aam Aadmi Party out of 117 voted in the Punjab Assembly; the merger decision of the legislator who later became a member of the Council of States was accepted by the presiding officer, because he or she represents the ruling party — but that does not imply that the legislature party and the parent political party are two different entities.
- **Trinamool Congress example:** the Trinamool Congress legislators merged themselves into another party, a citizens' journalistic party or whatever that party is named. Who merged? The legislators. Who is the parent political party? Didi and her nephew. But determining the parent political party involves the role of the Election Commission, what that particular party's constitution says, how that party's elections are being held, and whose hands the command is in.
- In both the split and merger cases the same rule applies: the original political party must agree first, and only then are the MLAs counted — at least the required numbers are needed.

CRITICAL POINT

Traditional criticism of the anti-defection law.

- The anti-defection law penalises individual defections and retail defections, but exempts wholesale defections.

QUICK REVISION

- Mergers: no punishment or sanction on the recipient party.
- Constitutional ambiguity in the merger clause: permission of the original political party versus a deemed merger on two-thirds of the legislature party agreeing without a national-level merger.
- Two exceptions originally: split (struck down by the 91st Amendment, 2003) and merger.
- Present merger conditions: the parent political party agrees, or two-thirds of the legislature party agree.
- Parent political party, legislature party and parliamentary party are distinct concepts, but the legislature party cannot be read as an entity separate from the parent party (Paragraph 4, Tenth Schedule).
- Rajendra Singh Rana v. Swami Prasad Maurya, 2007: a split in the legislature party must stem from a corresponding split in the original party.
- Subhash Desai, 2023: the figurative umbilical cord between the legislature party and the parent party cannot be severed.
- Traditional criticism: individual and retail defections are penalised, wholesale defections are exempted.

5.12 Anti-Defection Law: Presiding Officer and Way Forward

- A recent issue is that presiding officers have been delaying action under the anti-defection law.
- The role of the presiding officer is as covered in the existing material, where the **Keisham Meghachandra case, 2020** is the Supreme Court judgment on point; a new judgment on the same line came in 2025.
- A new case has now come from a Telangana matter: the **Padi Kaushik Reddy case** [as stated in lecture].
- In that case, the Supreme Court directed the presiding officer to act within 3 months.

5.12.1 Way Forward

- For mergers, **codify the twin test**: Paragraph 4 should be amended to clarify that merger protection applies only when both conditions are satisfied.

QUICK REVISION

- Recent issue: presiding officers delay action under the anti-defection law.
- The role of the presiding officer is covered by the Keisham Meghachandra case, 2020, with a new 2025 judgment on the same line.
- A new Telangana case, the Padi Kaushik Reddy case, directed the presiding officer to act within 3 months.
- Way forward for mergers: codify the twin test — amend Paragraph 4 so that merger protection applies only when both conditions are satisfied.

CHAPTER 6

Local Self-Government: Democratic Decentralization, Devolution and Functionality (GS Paper 2 Current Affairs)

6.1 Local Self-Government: Exam Relevance and the Nature of PYQs

- **Local Self-Government** is part of polity and is the **most repeated area** in polity — this is the reason the topic is being taken up.
- On an average, **8–9 questions** have come from this area between **2013 and 2025**.
- Out of the **12–13 polity questions** that come up every year in General Studies Paper 2, **one question comes straight from Local Self-Government**.
- This year there was **no question** from this topic in the Civil Services Main Examination.

6.1.1 Two Traditional Strands of Questions

- **Strand 1 — the role of local bodies:** questions such as 'role in good governance', 'role of local self-government', 'how local bodies have led to good governance' and 'how have they promoted local self-government'. This is the classic question any examiner would ask.
  - Examples given in class: how Panchayats, Panchayat Samitis and Zilla Parishads were created in villages, and how the Municipal Corporation of Delhi installed equipment and vehicles at the end of the road to extract water from the road surface, which is why Delhi's water logging this year was not as bad as in earlier years.
- **Strand 2 — the three classic problems or concerns of local bodies, that is F-cube: funds, functionaries and functions**. These strands of questions were asked till **2022–23**.
  - **Funds (finances):** bodies such as the Municipal Corporation of Delhi say they have no money. This is the classic problem.
  - **Functionaries (people):** there is no separate cadre of trained officials that can address the concerns of local bodies — the civil services serve the central government and the state services serve the state government, but no dedicated local-body cadre exists.
  - **Functions:** the **29 subjects in the Eleventh Schedule** and the **18 subjects in the Twelfth Schedule** have not been completely devolved — this is prelims knowledge and must be known.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **The Latest Strand of Questions — Functionality.**

- UPSC is opening up the framework and there is an interesting expansion of questions; the latest strand is **functionality**, and it requires your basic observation.
- First generation, **1994**: the constitutional scheme created Gram Sabhas, panchayats and municipal corporations, and they always complained — 'we do not have funds, we do not have functionaries, we do not have functions'.
- It is now **more than 30 years** since the third tier was created, so they can no longer say they have no funds — the government has devolved.
- A bulk of devolution is still pending, but they must now move on from F-cube and prove that whatever was given has been discharged well.
- Out of the **29 subjects of the Eleventh Schedule**, if a state such as Punjab, Haryana or UP devolved 10–15 subjects, something was given — the question is how well those were discharged.
- The latest trend is that instead of questioning the state governments about the lack of devolution of F-cube, **the ball now lies in the court of the panchayats**.
- Even if all the **Sixteenth Finance Commission** grants are devolved, this area should have produced a 100% question in Paper 2 — it did not come.

6.1.2 *Sarpanchpati Syndrome — A Long-Standing, Not the Latest, Concern*

- **Sarpanchpati syndrome:** in several states a **50% reservation** is guaranteed for women. Women get elected, but the actual powers of that authority and post are exercised by the husband. The problem is visible in many television series.
- Example from this very area: the councillor of the Bada Bazaar Road ward in Old Rajinder Nagar, **Aarti Chawla**, who moved from the AAP to the BJP following the footsteps of the one who could not be followed. Her powers are not exercised by her but by the men around her — **Sarpanchpati culture** is still prevalent.
- This is **not** the latest strand: it has been in discourse for many years, ever since reservation was given.

6.1.3 *Second Latest Strand — Merger of Rural Local Bodies with Urban Local Bodies*

- Observation-based question from Delhi: several areas lie **inside** Delhi but are villages. The help or the cook making food in Old Rajinder Nagar actually stays in a village, even though Delhi is a municipal corporation; the entire staff comes from **Todapur**, the nearest village.
- **Todapur** is a village caught up inside the Municipal Corporation of Delhi — a village right in the centre of the MCD — and almost **100% of Delhi NCT is urban area**.
- Question asked: if the panchayat of a village such as Todapur is removed and the village is added to the MCD, what are the **merits and demerits**? That is, the merit and demerit of picking up villages lying within municipal areas and adding them inside the urban local body.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

The Two Invariable Questions.

- Out of the 8–9 questions of this area, **two questions are always asked — F-cube** and **role in**

good governance.

- The new strands are **functionality** and the **merger of RLBs (Rural Local Bodies) with ULBs (Urban Local Bodies)**.

QUICK REVISION

- Local Self-Government is the most repeated area in polity; 8–9 questions on average from 2013–2025; one of the 12–13 GS2 polity questions every year comes from here.
- Two traditional strands: role in good governance, and F-cube (funds, functionaries, functions).
- The latest strand is **functionality** — after 30 years the third tier can no longer complain about F-cube; the ball is in the panchayats' court.
- Sarpanchpati syndrome (50% reservation for women, powers exercised by the husband) is a long-standing, not the latest, concern.
- The other new strand is the merger of rural local bodies with urban local bodies — merits and demerits, using Todapur in Delhi as the example.

6.2 Structure of the Topic: The Legs of the Answer

Structure means the different dimensions to be prepared under a topic head. The way to open up any topic is again the **PYQs**: if you have seen the PYQs of an area you know how those questions are being asked, and around that particular PYQ we build a lens and add the current developments around that area — that becomes the subject matter of the topic.

- Once this topic is done, for next year's mains it is **done and dusted** — unless there is a major amendment to the Constitution (which will not be there) or a major law passed by the government for ULBs and RLBs. It then only has to be revised, and the pages turned before Paper 2.
- If a question comes beyond these notes, the way to attempt it still comes from these notes.
- Example of how topics connect: this year's Paper 2 question on **Indo-Pacific maritime domain awareness** cannot have notes of its own — it is the notes of **three topics**: the **importance of the Quad**, the **geostrategic importance** of a region or country, and **maritime security**.
  - **Quad strand:** has the Quad declined in the aftermath of the shift of US focus from the Indo-Pacific towards West Asia; has it increased in the light of the Japanese PM's visit to India and the Indian PM's visits to important nations such as Vietnam, Indonesia and Australia right after the prelims?
  - **Maritime security strand:** the Indian Navy, the international fusion centre, the IOR, maritime domain awareness, and the need to engage and improve maritime domain awareness.

KEY CONCEPT

One Answer, Many Questions.

- These framings all take the **same answer**: 'role in good governance'; 'how local bodies have

led to democratic decentralization'; 'importance of local bodies'; 'the role of local bodies in local self-government'.

- Also: 'It has ushered in a new era of good governance — do you agree?'; and 'local bodies have upturned the framework of democracy in India by bringing democracy to the grassroots — do you agree?'

6.2.1 The Legs the Topic Will Be Written In

- **Introduction** — with numbers that the Government of India itself uses in PIB and Kurukshetra, the basic framework, and how these terms are to be written in the exam.
- **Role** — role in good governance, democratic decentralization, importance of local bodies.
- **Issues** — concerns and challenges, analysed in two generations.
- **Steps taken by India** — which UPSC asks in the form of schemes; and then the **way forward**.

6.2.2 How the Issues Are Divided: First Generation vs Second Generation

- **First-generation problems** — F-cube and other issues: the 30-year-old story.
- **Second-generation problems — functionality**.
- Economy analogy: in the Indian economy the structural problem of taxes was answered with GST; 30 laws were put into 4 labour codes; GST 2.0 and the labour codes are the **2.0 problems of the economy**. In the same way, the problems of 30 years ago were different from the problems of today.
- The Municipal Corporation of Delhi and the Municipal Corporation of Mumbai have a lot of money, but municipal corporations farther from Delhi — **Sonipat, Panipat and Karnal** — are not as fiscally and functionally capable as Delhi. So Delhi cannot say it does not have talent; Delhi has the best talent. These dimensions belong to the **second generation**.
- Analogy: a student first said there were no funds to join a coaching institute, no good eating facility, and that he fell ill; the parents then said they would give Rs. 30,000 a month plus a good cook and organic food. The problem of funds is over — now the student has to **perform as an individual and give the result**. That is what the second generation, functionality, discusses.

6.2.3 Steps Taken by India — Asked in the Form of Schemes

- **MGNREGA** is implemented by Gram Panchayats, but from the theoretical aspect of a local body it is a problematic scheme: a Gram Panchayat head or the head of a Panchayat Samiti would not be very happy implementing such centrally sponsored schemes.
- **RGSA (Rashtriya Gram Swaraj Abhiyan)** — a scheme implemented by the **Ministry of Panchayati Raj**. Local bodies lie with the state government (an entry in the **State List**), and RGSA addresses **functionality**: it trains the members of Gram Panchayats, who may be only 5th, 6th, 7th or 8th pass.
  - For urban local bodies the members would still have better education and the skills to use, say, an app or **Bhashini** — that is not the case for rural local bodies.
  - Under RGSA, selected Gram Panchayat members have a mechanism to interact with the

students of **IIM Ahmedabad**, where a 2, 3 or 4-month training module runs for them.

- Capacity building is essential — training at the UPSC level is the best, then state services training, after which posting comes only after 6 months; but there is no such order of officials or training for panchayats, and none for those who could work in a municipal corporation.
- **PAI — Panchayat Advancement Index** — launched by the Government of India last year; it is the **first index launched by the Ministry of Panchayati Raj** and it rates all the panchayats with respect to their performance.

QUICK REVISION

- Structure = the dimensions to be prepared under the topic head; it is built from PYQs (a lens around the PYQ) plus current developments.
- The legs: introduction with numbers, role/importance in good governance, issues, steps taken by India as schemes, and way forward.
- One answer serves the framings 'role in good governance', 'democratic decentralization', 'importance of local bodies' and 'role of local bodies in local self-government'.
- Issues are split into first-generation (F-cube and other issues) and second-generation (functionality) problems.
- Steps taken by India appear in answers as schemes — RGSA (functionality, training of Gram Panchayat members, IIM Ahmedabad module) and PAI (Panchayat Advancement Index of the Ministry of Panchayati Raj).
- MGNREGA is implemented by Gram Panchayats but is problematic from the theoretical aspect of a local body, being a centrally sponsored scheme.

6.3 Way Forward: How to Write Recommendations in Polity

- In polity, way forward means what recommendations and suggestions you have to give. In core polity the way forward is **Supreme Court judgments**, **committee recommendations** and, best of all, a **commission** — a commission lies higher than a committee in terms of hierarchy.
- You will **not be innovative** in core polity: stick around a commission, committee, court judgment, a law, a parliamentary standing committee, or important observations such as **Om Birla's observations on the working of the MCD**.
- But **for this topic you have to be innovative**, because the commission that went into the modalities of the working of the panchayats — the **Second Administrative Reforms Commission (Second ARC)** — gave its recommendation in **2007**, more than 20 years ago, and is now **redundant**.

EXAMPLE

How Specific Judgment Questions Have Become.

- A straight question came on **judicial legislation** — after the PIL class, the question on **living will** and **passive euthanasia**.
- **Harshit Rana**, a young child, went to hospital on the day of Rakhi some years back, had a fall

from the 4th floor, and was bed-ridden for the past 10–15 years — he was the first person for whom passive euthanasia was actually applied.

- **Aruna Shanbaug**, a very popular nurse working in a hospital in Kerala, was strangulated by one of the attendants there and remained on the bed for the past 30–40 years.
- **2012** — the first judgment on passive euthanasia came; **2017–18** — the Court further rejigged it and gave the concept of **living will**.

- That judicial-legislation question was a tough question to come: in the past 10 years the judgments being asked were **not so specific** — they hovered around the **right to privacy**, a latest fundamental-right dimension, **environmental jurisprudence**, and the **concerns for women**.
- In the past decade the Second ARC report is to be **modified by adding some current affairs**. For this topic, use the **RBI report on the working of municipal government finances** (which came last year) and the **CAG audit that came in 2024**, along with some recommendations of the Second ARC.
- Together these build the **way forward** — the next reform that addresses **functionality** after F-cube has been addressed — and they are also needed to address the poor functionality of the local bodies.

QUICK REVISION

- Way forward in polity = Supreme Court judgments, committee recommendations, and best a commission (commission ranks above a committee).
- Do not be innovative in core polity: commission, committee, court judgment, a law, a parliamentary standing committee, or observations such as Om Birla's on the MCD.
- Be innovative here: the Second ARC reported in 2007 and is now redundant.
- Use the RBI report on municipal government finances (last year) and the CAG audit (2024) with Second ARC recommendations for the next reform — functionality after F-cube.
- Judgment questions have become specific — e.g. judicial legislation, living will and passive euthanasia (first applied to Harshit Rana; Aruna Shanbaug case; 2012 and 2017–18 judgments).
- In the previous decade judgments hovered around right to privacy, fundamental rights, environmental jurisprudence and concerns for women.

6.4 Introduction: The Third Tier and the Numbers to Quote

- There is **no need to define local bodies** in the introduction; simply mention that **local bodies constitute the third tier of governance**.
- **Diagrams are very important** — the target is to have at least **10–15 diagrams in 20 questions**, and they must always be drawn in **pencil**.
- Rural Local Bodies (**RLBs**) are the panchayats, popularly called **Panchayati Raj institutions**. Urban Local Bodies (**ULBs**) are the urban local bodies — primarily either a **municipal corporation** or a **municipal committee**.

- This is a 100% mains-oriented topic: if you do not know what PRIs and municipal corporations are, go back and read the chapter.

DATA & FACTS

The Scale of Representation (for the Introduction Diagram).

- **Centre:** 543 representatives in the House of the People plus 245 in the Council of States — approximately **800 representatives**. There is no need to be specific here; this is not a prelims question.
- **States:** almost **4,000 to 5,000 representatives** — that is, Members of Legislative Assemblies and Members of Legislative Councils.
- **Third tier: 31.5 lakh elected representatives** in Panchayati Raj institutions (RLBs). This is the number that must be remembered — it is very important.
- Significance to state in the answer: approximately 800 at the centre, 5,000 in the states and about 30 lakh representatives in the third tier automatically leads to **good governance by deepening democracy at the grassroots level**.

- **Villages in India: 6.5 lakh.** A couple of villages usually share one gram panchayat, so the number of gram panchayats is always less than the number of villages.
- **Gram Panchayats: 2.6 lakh** (also stated as 2.65 lakh).
- These gram panchayats **represent 64% of India's population**.
- Women: the Constitution sanctions **33%** reservation. Several states — Haryana, Rajasthan, Bihar, UP — have gone beyond it; a good number, at least **11 to 14 of the 28 states**, provide reservation beyond 33%. The actual representation is therefore **46%**.
- So if there are 100 representatives in the third tier, about **46% — nearly half — are women**. In absolute terms this is approximately **14 lakh women representatives**.
- This year's mains asked how the framework of reservation exists in the Constitution starting from the third tier up to the centre: at the third tier, women are 46% despite the constitutional minimum of 33%, so local bodies not only deepen democracy but also play an important role in **social justice**.
- **ULBs: approximately 4,800**, that is about **5,000**. This is the number of urban local bodies, not the number of representatives, and it is almost the same as the number of MLAs/MLCs — a simple way to remember it.

DATA & FACTS

Urbanisation and the Sixteenth Finance Commission.

- Urban population: the Census says **31%** (those figures are of 2011, more than 10 years old); the latest studies and surveys say **40%**. So write **40% urban population in 2026**, which will increase to **50% by 2050**.
- The **Sixteenth Finance Commission** has approved almost **Rs. 7.35 lakh crore** worth of grants for ULBs and RLBs, with basic grants and performance grants — but the major criticism is that it is **more tilted towards the urban areas**.
- For rural local bodies the main source of revenue is **not its own source**: it is dependence on

the Finance Commission at the centre and on State Finance Commission grants. There is a **perceived bias towards urban local bodies vis-à-vis rural local bodies**.

- Diagram heading for the merger question: **increasing importance of ULBs in comparison to PRIs/RLBs** — this is the diagram to draw alongside the pros and cons of merging RLBs with ULBs.
- Numbers to remember: about **30 lakh representatives**, **6.5 lakh villages**, **2.65 lakh gram panchayats**, and **46% women representatives**.
- The **multiple answer-writing templates** given in the brochure have to be memorised and simply written in the answer; nothing has to be thought afresh for them, and there must be **no uniformity** — every candidate has to have a different template.

QUICK REVISION

- No definition of local bodies in the introduction — open with 'local bodies constitute the third tier of governance'.
- Numbers for the diagram: about 800 representatives at the centre, 4,000–5,000 in the states, and 31.5 lakh in the third tier (panchayats).
- 6.5 lakh villages, 2.6–2.65 lakh gram panchayats, and 64% of India's population represented by these gram panchayats.
- Women: constitutional minimum 33%, actual representation 46% (about 14 lakh representatives); 11–14 of 28 states go beyond 33%.
- ULBs: about 4,800, that is roughly 5,000 institutions.
- Urban population: 31% per Census 2011, 40% per the latest studies, 40% in 2026 rising to 50% by 2050.
- The Sixteenth Finance Commission approved about Rs. 7.35 lakh crore for ULBs and RLBs, tilted towards urban areas — and RLBs depend on Finance Commission and State Finance Commission grants rather than their own sources.

6.5 Constitutional Framework: What to Write on the 73rd and 74th Amendments

These are the points to be written for the 73rd and 74th Amendment in the answer. The detailed prelims provisions are not re-discussed here — namely **33% reservation for women**, **reservation for SCs, STs and OBCs as per population**, the **District Planning Committee**, and the **grant of constitutional status to the Gram Sabha**.

What must already be known: the **73rd and 74th Amendments** and their **broad provisions** — a chapter of 4–5 pages in any standard book.

- **Grant of constitutional status** to Panchayati Raj institutions, for example the **Gram Sabha**.
- **Provision for different types of institutions** — a **three-tier** structure in rural areas and **three types** of institutions in urban areas.
- **List of subjects to be devolved** by the state: **29 subjects in the Eleventh Schedule** and **18**

subjects in the Twelfth Schedule.

- **Direct elections** to these institutions.
- **Reservation for SC, ST and women** — thereby upholding **SJ (social justice)** and **GJ (gender justice)** — along with voluntary representation for the backward classes.
  - SJ and GJ are specific keywords written in Paper 2; keywords are the currency of the answer.
- **Creation of constitutional posts** such as **SFC (State Finance Commission)** and **SEC (State Election Commission)** — on the lines of the **Finance Commission** and the **Election Commission**.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Planning Role, Provision of Funds and the DPC — and Where They Fail.

- **Provide a planning role — very important.** Like the Centre or a state: there is no planning commission but there is a separate mechanism of having a 2-year, 3-year or 4-year plan, and no concept of five-year plans. In bracket: **PRIs and ULBs prepare plans for economic development and social justice**.
- Why this point is written: the Government of India is devolving planning responsibilities to these institutions, but because of training and capacity-building deficits **the constitutional planning role given to the third tier is not fully fulfilled**.
- **Provision of funds** — grants-in-aid to be provided by the states and the centre, along with the states legislating and authorizing **ULBs and RLBs** to collect and appropriate **taxes, duties, tolls and fees**.
- This is the second concern: even if the power of collecting a tax or a fee is given — the garbage collection fee that all of us pay in an urban area, maintenance of street lights, maintenance of any such community project — **none of them is levied by the panchayat in a village**; even the most popular tax, the **property tax**, is not levied by panchayats. The panchayats are therefore themselves incapable of generating funds.
- So even if all the funds, all the functionaries and all the 29 and 18 subjects are devolved, the third-tier institutions have their own problems — this is the second-generation problem of functionality.
- **Provide for the DPC — District Planning Committee** — in bracket: **consolidates the plans prepared by the RLBs and ULBs**.
- Problem: if the gram panchayat of that district, or the municipal corporation/municipal committee of that district, does not do the homework of preparing plans, the working of the **DPC as a constitutional body is completely hamstrung** — again not because of F-cube but because of the second-generation problem, namely that these third-tier institutions themselves do not want to function in an empowered manner.

- Apart from reservation for SCs, STs and women, states may also give reservation to the **backward classes** if they want. Whenever a state tries to do so — the case in **Maharashtra**, the case in **UP** — the case is definitely likely to be pending in a court of law, because of the way the state legislatures identify the backward classes for reservation.

QUICK REVISION

- 73rd/74th Amendment points to write: constitutional status to Panchayati Raj institutions (Gram Sabha); different types of institutions (three-tier rural, three types urban); list of subjects to be devolved (29 in the Eleventh Schedule, 18 in the Twelfth Schedule); direct elections.
- Reservation for SC, ST and women — upholding SJ and GJ — plus voluntary reservation for backward classes.
- Constitutional posts created: SFC and SEC, on the lines of the Finance Commission and the Election Commission.
- Planning role: PRIs and ULBs plan for economic development and social justice (2/3/4-year plans, no five-year plans) — but this role is not fully fulfilled.
- Funds: grants-in-aid plus powers to levy taxes, duties, tolls and fees — yet panchayats levy nothing, not even property tax, so they cannot generate their own funds.
- DPC consolidates the plans of RLBs and ULBs; if these bodies do not prepare plans, the DPC is completely hamstrung — a second-generation problem.
- Reservation for backward classes is voluntary for states, and cases (Maharashtra, UP) are likely to be pending in court.

6.6 Importance of Local Bodies: The Role in Good Governance

This is the second leg after the introduction. All the framings of this leg — importance of local bodies in good governance, role of local bodies in local self-government, democratic decentralization — are answered with the same points, written dimension by dimension in point form.

6.6.1 1. Democratic Decentralization

- **Democratic** means elections — if this class has to choose a class representative, that is democracy. **Decentralization** — what does the word mean — means that the functions or the powers which were being performed at an earlier tier are now being performed by the third, bottom-most tier.
- Even if no reservation is given and even if there were no 73rd and 74th Amendment, simply creating a local body in Delhi — without any constitutional status — would mean a much greater number of representatives performing the task earlier performed by the Government of NCT of Delhi. Powers and functions have been given to the lower tier: this is **democratic decentralization**.
- **Social sector schemes or programmes are implemented by local bodies rather than by state government agencies**, and they **promote direct participation** through **Gram Sabhas, ward committees and local body elections**. People's participation in schemes is growing, so it automatically leads to the penetration of democracy.
- Consequence to state: the powers that were with the second tier of the triangle are now being exercised by the third tier.

6.6.2 2. Efficiency

- It **promotes efficiency**, because local bodies or governments have **smaller jurisdiction**, enabling **targeted, proper and efficient service delivery**.
- Example: in this area of Rajinder Nagar I have my own representative, a ward member. My problem of garbage collection definitely cannot be solved by the Member of Parliament from this area, Bansuri Swaraj — she is at the top and has a huge area to cover, and there are only **seven** constituencies in Delhi.
  - The MLA has a smaller area than the MP, but there are only **70 MLAs** for the huge expanse of Delhi.
  - There are almost **300–400 ward members** in Delhi, so it is much easier for me to reach the ward member; and because the ward member's area is small, service delivery will be efficient there.

6.6.3 3. Participatory Governance

- It **promotes participatory governance**, as local bodies are **administratively located closer to the people** and thereby enable **grassroots democracy**.
- Example: the **Gram Sabha** is involved in the preparation of the **Gram Panchayat Development Plan**, in **social audit**, and in the **identification of beneficiaries under various schemes**.

6.6.4 4. Last-Mile Delivery

- Local bodies lead to **last-mile delivery**.

6.6.5 5. Better Identification of Beneficiaries and Better Targeting

- Local bodies bring administration and people together, leading to **better identification of the beneficiaries**, **optimum allocation of the resources** and **better targeting**.
- Recap of the framework so far: first, democratic decentralization — the functions earlier performed by a higher tier (in India the states; elsewhere a **prefecture in Japan** or a **province in Pakistan**) are now performed by third-tier local bodies; second, better service delivery because the area of work is comparatively smaller; third, local bodies bring administration and people together.

6.6.6 6. Promotion of Social Justice

- India has given reservation to **SCs and STs**, to **women** and to the **backward classes** — that is the specific benefit of the 73rd and 74th Amendment Acts.
- But even if no reservation exists and not a single seat is reserved, will a local body still promote social justice? **Yes** — because a platform called the local body is created, and because there is local participation of the local people, the socially deprived lot — SC, ST, OBC — will automatically participate and automatically get the benefit of social justice. That is an added advantage.
- Analogy: if there are 1,000 people in this class, there is no better representation — the weakest student's voice would be clearly subdued; but if the number of students is reduced, then even without any reservation that weaker student will still be able to ask questions, because the size

is less.

- Write it as: local bodies enable a **participatory framework**, as citizens can **participate, deliberate or audit decisions** taken by the local body.
- Example: **approval of the Gram Sabha** is required for a **mining project** or a **developmental project**.

6.6.7 7. Promotion of Gender Justice and Women Empowerment

- It **enables gender justice** because of the **increased participation of women** in local governments. In bracket: **46% of the total representatives in PRIs are women** — in absolute numbers approximately **14 lakh** women representatives. Remember that there are **2.6 lakh gram panchayats**, but their members are much more than the number of gram panchayats.
- Why does it promote women empowerment? For a female, getting elected to a local body is **much easier** than getting elected to the state or the centre — one, some women will get elected even without reservation; two, for those who are not elected, because a local body has been created they are still able to participate in governance.
- Example: a gram panchayat may have, say, 5 representatives, and the village may have 500 women. Those 500 are not getting elected, but because a local body exists there is a **panchayat office** that a woman will engage with sometimes, and because a local body involves interaction with state government officials, some of those women will also engage with state government offices.
- This automatically leads to **increased exposure, increased mobility and increased capacity building**.
- Whenever we talk about human empowerment we discuss **three things — economic, social and political**: political empowerment is happening because participation is enabled; social empowerment is happening because women are coming out, addressing people and talking to the authorities even at the third tier; and economic empowerment is happening because the experience of interacting with officials helps them engage in various economic activities such as forming or joining a **self-help group**.
- So write: local bodies enable **women participation**, **increased mobility**, **increased social capital**, and the **gain of experience and skills**, leading to the **creation of economic opportunities** and the **identification of the specific concerns of women**.
- Example: if there are no local bodies there is no forum where local women can raise their voice. Take a scheme started in **1975** — the most important scheme for the welfare of women: women themselves would not be capable enough to interact with the officials in those centres, because there is no forum of interaction of women with the state. The example is **Anganwadi centres**, established by the **Ministry of Women and Child Development in 1975**.
- Without local bodies there would be no Gram Sabha, and without a Gram Sabha there would be no representation for women, so a scheme enabled by the government for the interests of women would automatically be **poorly implemented**.
- With local bodies, women evaluate the working of the Anganwadi centres; the centres will be **better identified** and will perform in a much more efficient manner — in bracket: **better monitoring and audit of Anganwadi centres leading to a virtuous cycle of development**.

EXAMPLE

Diagram to Draw: Local Bodies and Women Empowerment.

- Earlier situation: women had **limited participation**, and to access any government service they had to travel a large distance, mentally and physically, to reach the state — the Indian state.
- After the creation of local bodies, the local body comes in between, so that **distance is reduced**; the reduced distance leads to **better participation, enabling women empowerment**.
- Other titles that can be used for the diagram: **local bodies as a bridge**, or **local bodies as an interface between the state government and citizens**.

- Underline this keyword: **local bodies** and their **constitutionalization by the 73rd and 74th Amendment** has led to the implementation or operationalization of **Gandhiji's vision of Gram Swaraj**.

QUICK REVISION

- Democratic decentralization = democratic (elections) plus decentralization (functions earlier performed at a higher tier are now performed by the third, bottom-most tier).
- Efficiency: smaller jurisdiction enables targeted, proper and efficient service delivery — ward member (300–400) versus MLA (70) versus MP (7 constituencies in Delhi).
- Participatory governance: local bodies are administratively closer to the people; the Gram Sabha does the Gram Panchayat Development Plan, social audit and beneficiary identification.
- Local bodies lead to last-mile delivery, better identification of beneficiaries, optimum allocation of resources and better targeting.
- Social justice is promoted even without reservation, because a local body is a platform for participation, deliberation and audit — e.g. Gram Sabha approval for a mining project.
- Gender justice: 46% of PRI representatives are women (about 14 lakh); women gain exposure, mobility, social capital and skills, leading to economic opportunities and a virtuous cycle of development (Anganwadi centres, Ministry of Women and Child Development, 1975).
- Constitutionalization by the 73rd and 74th Amendment operationalized Gandhiji's vision of Gram Swaraj.

6.7 Organizing the Issues: Broad Heads and Substantiation

The most important part of this topic is the **structure** — you have to absorb the issues in a framework. The framework has to be clear, because the question is only about organizing your thoughts in a structured manner.

- By public administration or political science, the issues can be written as **structural and functional issues** — or else bifurcated or trifurcated under different heads.
- A structural-functional approach suits a question on NCSC, NCST, NHRC or NCPCR (the question on **NCPCR in the light of increased child pornography**), and smaller bodies such as **NGT**, **ED** and **CBI**.

- But local bodies are an entire large framework — **31.5 lakh representatives and almost 5,000 ULBs** — so the issues have to be organized differently.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **State Finance Commission vs Finance Commission.**
>
> - The problems related to the **State Finance Commission** are very important, and the **Finance Commission** is very important for GS Paper 2.
> - The Finance Commission was a 100% expected question in Paper 2; a 100% possibility remains that a question on the Finance Commission will come in Paper 3 this time. Its relevance does not end till the **17th Finance Commission in 2031** — a question every year in prelims and mains is very necessary.
> - What is needed here is a **comparison of the State Finance Commission and the Finance Commission at the centre** — the difference between their working is a **world of difference**.

6.7.1 *Broad Heads of the Issues*

- **Elections** — delay in elections, delimitation issues, delay in the formation of councils, and defection/floor-shifting.
- **F-cube** — funds, functions and functionaries.
- **Problems related to the State Finance Commission.**
- **Specific concerns of RLBs** — **Pati Panchayat** (more prevalent in rural areas), **local dominance** and **local elites**.
- **Specific concerns of ULBs** — for example, the concerns of Delhi are totally different from the concerns of a village that has a gram panchayat.

6.7.2 *An Example of a ULB-Specific Concern*

- A problem that is very big for the Municipal Corporation of Delhi but would not exist for the sarpanch of a village: **urban flooding / water logging** in Delhi.
- It is a manifestation of the **renewed challenges which have been thrown to the cities** — not so commonly to the villages — by **climate change**: heat waves and cold waves. If it becomes very cold or very hot, the MCD will have to make some arrangement for delivery workers.
- In villages there is a **piyao** (a drinking-water point) and there are no delivery services, so the village is self-sufficient in that respect; but in cities the water logging can be severe.
- No great expectation can be placed on a gram panchayat, but in a municipal corporation the **ambit of expectations is very large**.
- There are **4–5 broad points** in this head, and a specific point may be asked separately in Paper 2 — **Sarpanchpati** was asked as a **10-marker**. Sarpanchpati is just one point among the RLB concerns; the introduction and the other points give you the cushion to add some detail for the examiner.
- From all these points the **impact is studied with respect to functionality**.

6.7.3 Substantiation = Data Plus Data Sources

- In the civil services mains, **substantiation means giving data and data sources**.
- **Second ARC** is the earlier data source, but that report came in **2005** and they submitted in **2007**.
- **CAG's audit report** and the **RBI's report on municipal finances** are the two **primary reports** in current affairs of the past four years — these will be used.
- There is also a non-governmental organisation called **Janaagraha (Jan Agarai)**, which has done research on urban and rural local bodies; its report and facts can also be used to substantiate.

QUICK REVISION

- The most important part of the topic is the structure — the framework in which the issues are organized.
- Issues may be written as structural and functional concerns, but local bodies are too large a framework (31.5 lakh representatives, almost 5,000 ULBs) for that alone.
- Broad heads: elections, F-cube, State Finance Commission, specific RLB concerns (Pati Panchayat, local dominance, local elites) and specific ULB concerns.
- ULB-specific example: urban flooding/water logging in Delhi, a climate-change challenge for cities, not villages.
- Sarpanchpati was asked as a 10-marker — one of the RLB points.
- Substantiation in the mains means data and data sources: Second ARC (2005–07), CAG audit, RBI report on municipal finances, and Janaagraha's research.
- The State Finance Commission's working is a world apart from the Finance Commission; the Finance Commission remains a very important topic till the 17th Finance Commission in 2031.

6.8 Issues Related to Elections: Delay, Delimitation, Formation of Councils and Defection

How do you enter a local body? By reason of **elections**. There cannot be a single state in this country where there is no delay in the organization of elections of the PRIs or of a municipal corporation; and unlike the Lok Sabha or state elections, local body elections are not uniform and frequent every five years.

6.8.1 Delay in Elections

- Example: the **Municipal Corporation of Delhi's elections were held 8 months late**.
- The concern at the level of the centre and the states, which has led to the **north–south divide**, is the **delimitation of constituencies** — done every 10 years, though the government might amend that provision. Constituencies for the Vidhan Sabha and the Lok Sabha are created by a **statutory body** and the decision of that body cannot be questioned by a court of law, though a judgment that came up last year said that in certain circumstances the decision might be reviewed.

- The **Delimitation Commission** is a statutory body appointed by Parliament, and its decision cannot be questioned by a court of law.
- At the third tier, however, the delimitation exercise is **not done by the State Election Commission**, the constitutional body — it is usually done by the **state government**.
- State governments which are in power want to recreate and redraw the constituencies in such a manner that their political party ends up winning the bulk of the seats in the ward or in the Panchayati Raj institution. There is no role of the State Election Commission, and because it is not a statutory body and is not headed by a retired judge, all these issues go to the court and the court grants a stay.
- Example from Delhi: Delhi earlier had **four municipal corporations** — West Delhi, South Delhi, East Delhi and **NDMC**; the three have now been merged into one. The State Election Commission in Delhi — an IAS officer [as stated in lecture] — had done the delimitation of the wards, and that led to a **delay of eight months** in the elections.
- Compare Delhi with **New York** (Zohran Mamdani) and **London**, or any of the cities of the world, where elections to the mayor and the wards are held exactly on time.
- After the elections, the problems begin — first **F-cube** (funds, functions, functionaries), and then **functionality**.

6.8.2 The CAG 2024 Audit and the Worst Delay

- **CAG's 2024 audit** of the **74th Constitutional Amendment Act** — a constitutional report on the working of the municipal bodies — found that elections were delayed in about **60% of the ULBs in India** [as stated in lecture]. This is a startling number.
- The most popular city and the most popular municipal corporation — it is not Indore, not Bangalore, not the Delhi MCD and not Madras (Madras is now **Greater Chennai**, which has a beautiful office and was the first municipal corporation in the country) — is the **BMC, the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation**. It works much better than the municipal corporation of Delhi, and yet gave the **worst example of delay ever possible in the history of the working of the 74th Amendment Act, 1993** [as stated in lecture].
- Recently a woman became the **first Municipal Commissioner in the history of Bombay**.
- Example in point: in the **Greater Chennai Municipal Corporation** — the first municipal corporation in the country — elections were held in **2022** after a delay of **six years**; they had to happen in **2016**. The **Hindustan Times** reported this in several articles over two years. The delay was **more than one full term**.

6.8.3 Delimitation-Related Concerns

- Delay in the delimitation commission submitting its report has led to delay in elections. **However, this violates the Supreme Court judgment in Suresh Mahajan vs State of MP** [as stated in lecture].
- The term of an urban local body is **five years**. If the state wants to change the boundary of the ward or of the constituency, it could have done it in the third year or the fourth year, or at the start of the fifth year — but the state governments **deliberately announce the appointment of the delimitation commission in the fifth year**, right at the nick of the time when the

five-year period of that municipal corporation is ending.

- Second, the district administration of that particular state is directly told that it will not cooperate with the delimitation commission: the District Magistrate has to cooperate, has to give a list of all the ward committees and wards, and has to coordinate with the commission. There is deliberate delay in the provision of the relevant documents by the state government to the state-government-appointed delimitation commission.
- Another four or five months are taken in understanding the documents, and another four or five months in the field visit and in talking to all the political parties — the same way as it is done at the centre — and this interaction further causes a delay.
- Eventually this led to the Supreme Court case: in **2022 the State of MP** did not organize the elections to local bodies in time, and the Court said you cannot give the reason that constituencies have not yet been delimited, and that therefore elections cannot be organized.
- The Court said that delimitation of constituencies, like at the centre and the state, is a **continuous process**: before five years, before **2029**, the delimitation bill has to be passed, it has to be approved by Parliament, the commission has to be made and it has to give a report before 2029 — only then will elections be organized.
- The five-year constitutional mandate that **Article 83** gives to the Lok Sabha cannot be delayed or violated.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

What the Court Ruled — Suresh Mahajan vs State of MP.

- The court ruled that **delimitation of a ward cannot be a legitimate ground for not notifying** the election at an opportune time.
- The court further ruled that **delimitation is a continuous exercise and must commence well in advance**.
- And the court ruled that **timely elections are a sine qua non** — a prerequisite — **for democracy**.

- Why this judgment is being written down: a specific strand of any of these issues can be asked in the Civil Services Main with respect to the working of the ULBs and RLBs. F-cube and functionality are one dimension, but they can go deeper — they can ask only about functions, only about funds, only about delay.
- They can ask whether, more than F-cube, it is actually the **delay in the elections** that is the most problematic feature. If so, almost **50% of the write-up** has to be given to delay.

CRITICAL POINT

The Perceived Bias in Delimitation.

- The report of the delimitation commission is **perceived to be biased**, because it is carried out by the **state government** rather than by the **State Election Commission**.
- Write it as: at the state or the centre there is a delimitation commission, which is a **statutory body**; but at the third tier, for the delimitation of local bodies, it is done by the **state government** — leading to **bias in favour of the ruling party**.

- Substantiation: the **Janaagraha (Jan Agarai) report published in 2025**, quoted in the **Indian Express**, said that the **34 State Election Commissions** examined did not have the powers of delimitation.
- Of those **34 State Election Commissions**, **24 are totally of no use**, because they can neither delimit nor decide the reserved seats.
- **Two** State Election Commissions have only the power of delimitation and not the power of reservation.
- Both powers together — delimitation and reservation, a **perfect combo** — are available only with **eight** State Election Commissioners.
- Why the reservation power matters: at the centre the Delimitation Commission, which shall be appointed very soon, will not only decide the boundary of the seats and the number of seats but also decide **which constituencies out of the 543** will actually be getting **reserved for women**, and which constituency, assuming there is no seat increase, will be reserved for **SC/ST**.
- Because many states have **50% reservation for women**, the total representation of women is **46%** — and the reservation decision is tied to the delimitation power which only eight State Election Commissions have.

6.8.4 *Delay in the Formation of Councils*

- Third, within elections itself there is **delay in the formation of councils**: state governments, post elections, **do not call the first sitting**, which leads to delay in the election of the mayor and in the constitution of the standing committees.
- Different states have different provisions for the election of the mayor. The mayor is the one representative who represents the entire city; unfortunately, the **mayor is a very weak office** in India — the mayor of Delhi, the mayor of Bombay or the mayor of Indore does not have the constitutional or statutory framework of powers, and the fanfare, that is there in other nations such as the mayor of Copenhagen, the mayor of Paris, the mayor of New York or the mayor of a city anywhere in the US.
- In some states the mayor is elected **every year** — every year there is a new mayor, elected by the ward members. So sometimes the mayor is indirectly elected, depending on the provisions of the law made by the state.
- The entire **73rd and 74th Amendment and its implementation is contingent on the states**.
- In Delhi, until the MCD meets for the first time, the members are administered the oath given in the respective law enacted by the Assembly of Delhi to give powers to the municipal corporation's ward members — at the centre the oath is given in the Constitution, because Parliament and the Assembly are very big offices.
- If the first meeting does not happen, the election of the mayor cannot happen — there would be **no elected mayor**, even in a case where the mayor is indirectly elected.
- In the Municipal Corporation of Delhi about **350 people** (say 300–400 ward members) sit and vote for the mayor; the first meeting has to happen not only to elect the mayor but also to constitute the **standing committees**, in which different ward members are given specific responsibilities.

- The entire work of a municipal corporation is performed by those standing committees — just as the **Department-Related Standing Committees (DRSCs)** at the centre perform the entire role of Parliament. There would be small committees, for example a **committee for water logging**.
- Like the parliamentary committees at the centre, whose working is a favourite area for Civil Services Main Paper 2, there is a delay of **4 to 5 months, sometimes 11 months**, in the constitution of a standing committee at the centre; here too the first meeting has to happen.
- **Janaagraha's 2024 study** of municipal corporations and committees in **Karnataka** — which has almost **200 urban local bodies** — noted a delay of **11 months** in the first meeting, with an **average delay of one year**: out of five years, one year went by without the meeting happening.
- This further leads to the election of the mayor and the appointment of standing committees, and to **urban local governments continuing to work under the state government, defeating the basic principle of decentralization**.
- The beautiful architecture of parliamentary committees at the centre is **much less beautiful at the level of the states**; very few states have the same mechanism, and it is worst with respect to municipal corporations — for a huge city like Delhi, one municipal corporation is not enough and it needs to function through these standing committees.

6.8.5 *Defection and Floor-Shifting at the Third Tier*

- The **Chandigarh case**: elections to the Chandigarh Municipal Corporation were held — about **40–50 seats**, with board members elected from different areas of Chandigarh — and the **first sitting happened on time**, so this is not an example of delay.
- At that first sitting there was close competition between the **AAP and the BJP**, and the main observer, the electoral officer himself, was involved in voting in support of the BJP against the AAP — he voted himself despite not being a ward councillor, and he did it openly with his full affiliation, all of which was captured on camera.
- Second issue in that election: several councillors from the AAP actually voted in favour of the BJP. (When we say legislator we imply Parliament and the state legislature; these were councillors.)
- That election was finally **countermanded, cancelled and declared null and void by the Supreme Court**.
- This points to the question: can I vote in favour of any other political party at the centre or the state? The **anti-defection law prevents voting against the party whip**. Is there an anti-defection law at the third tier?
- The anti-defection law that we all know as the **Tenth Schedule** is meant only for the centre and the state. The **Tenth Schedule is the proper noun** and **anti-defection law is the common noun** — any law that prevents defection is an anti-defection law. At the centre and state it is referred to as the Tenth Schedule, a clear constitutional provision inserted by the **52nd Amendment, 1985**.
- But several states — in fact **most of the states** — do not have any specific law to prevent defection at the third tier. In local bodies **floor shifting is very common**, because local body

elections are also usually fought on party grounds; it is very common for individuals to change their floor to vote in favour of a mayor who does not come from their political party.

- Best example: **Kerala** — the number one state in terms of the devolution index. The state legislature of Kerala has enacted a separate law to ensure that a legislator at the third tier is bound by the whip of the political party on which he or she got elected.
- So the last point under elections: **no anti-defection law enacted by the state legislatures**, and therefore **floor shifting and related malpractices are a concern**.

QUICK REVISION

- There is no state without delay in local body elections; local body elections are not uniform and frequent every five years like the Lok Sabha and state elections (MCD: 8 months late).
- At the third tier, delimitation is done by the state government, not by the State Election Commission, and is perceived as biased in favour of the ruling party; at the centre it is a statutory Delimitation Commission.
- Delhi had four municipal corporations (West, South, East and NDMC); three have been merged, and the SEC's ward delimitation led to an eight-month delay.
- CAG's 2024 audit of the 74th Constitutional Amendment Act: elections delayed in about 60% of ULBs [as stated in lecture]; Greater Chennai's elections were held in 2022, six years late (reported by the Hindustan Times).
- Suresh Mahajan vs State of MP: ward delimitation is no legitimate ground for not notifying elections at an opportune time; delimitation is continuous and must commence well in advance; timely elections are a sine qua non for democracy.
- Janaagraha 2025: of 34 State Election Commissions, only 8 have both delimitation and reservation powers, 2 have only delimitation, and 24 have neither.
- Delay in formation of councils: no first sitting means no mayor and no standing committees; Janaagraha's 2024 Karnataka study found an 11-month delay, an average of one year, defeating decentralization.
- Chandigarh: the first sitting was on time, but the electoral officer voted for the BJP and AAP councillors voted for the BJP; the election was declared null and void by the Supreme Court.
- The Tenth Schedule (52nd Amendment, 1985) applies only to the centre and the states; most states have no third-tier anti-defection law, so floor shifting is common — Kerala alone has enacted such a law.

6.9 F-Cube: The Problem of Functions (Devolution)

F-cube means funds, functions and functionaries. The problem of funds will be taken with the **RBI's report**; the first of the three to be taken up is the **problem of functions**.

- The problem of functions is the **lack of devolution of the subjects by the state government**.
- **CAG 2024 report:** out of the **18 subjects or functions in the Twelfth Schedule** (29 are for the rural areas in the Eleventh Schedule), **only four are, on an average, fully devolved to the ULBs**.

6.9.1 What Fully Devolved Means

- **Fully devolved** means the function is entirely performed by the local body. Example: **urban sanitation** is one of the entries in the Twelfth Schedule, but sanitation as a function is not entirely being performed by the Municipal Corporation of Delhi. These entries have to be **read broadly**: the function may be devolved, but there is also some **sub-function within sanitation** that is not allocated to the MCD and is performed by a Delhi government department, for example the **Delhi Jal Board**.
- So two things are needed: **first, devolve all the 18 subjects of the Twelfth Schedule** from the state government to the municipal corporations; **second, it has to be full devolution — there should not be any overlap of functions**.
- Overlap example — water logging in Delhi: in some sub-functions of water logging, and in some functions of urban sanitation, the role is the MCD's, and in others the role is the Delhi Jal Board's. When we say MCD we mean the **councillor** — if I have any concern in the MCD in Old Rajinder Nagar I will catch hold of the councillor; but if that sub-function of sanitation overlaps with the Delhi Jal Board, then the **CEO of the Delhi Jal Board is an IAS officer representing the Government of NCT of Delhi**.

6.9.2 The Challenge

- Cumulatively, **only 4 of the 18 subjects were devolved**, and even those four were given without considering **which four** should have been given. The list of 18 subjects is very interesting and has a wide paraphernalia of entries, and selectively the ones that should have been given were not given.
- If it is fully devolved, then for a concern such as water logging there would be **no budgetary expenditure made by the state government** and **no mechanism to prevent water logging**: in that case, in Delhi or in any city, it will be your municipal corporation, and **100% responsibility lies there**.

6.9.3 Specific Functions or Subjects

- **Land use** — the first of the specific functions.
- **Public health — very important:** it includes **disease prevention** and **mohalla clinics** (the mohalla clinics in Delhi and in Punjab). Public health plays a very important role in preventing the spread of communicable diseases, along with the department that actually looks after water supply.
- These functions are usually **not devolved** and are performed by agencies called **parastatals** — essentially a body or an official chosen not by the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, or by the municipal corporation of any city for that matter.
- The simplest tasks of sanitation, of public health, of providing water and of waste management — these basic functions that municipal corporations perform in the whole world — are performed by such parastatals.
- Example: if you use water beyond a certain amount that was given to you free, you have to pay that bill, and that is again being headed by the **Delhi Jal Board**. The Delhi Jal Board **should have no role**; the Delhi government should not create any specific agency — it should be

demolished, abandoned. The entire function of collecting water charges, that entire machinery, should be **transferred to the municipal corporation**, because that is their job.

- Consequence: if tomorrow I want to debate the provision of free litres of water to every household in Delhi, I should **not have to go to the MLA** — the MLA is located far away from me and I cannot redress my grievances. If there is improper water supply there is a problem; today in Delhi and other cities you have to go to the MLA or the department, which should not be, because it is a **local body function**. The resolution should come from the councillor, or from any institution or person working under the MCD, so that grievance redressal is very easy for me.
- So this is **not a problem of the MCD** but the traditional problem of F-cube, where the states themselves have not given anything to the respective municipal corporations, gram sabhas or gram panchayats.

6.9.4 *Devolution Case Studies*

- **Kerala** — a very high rank in the devolution index; the devolution index basically discusses certain parameters and is **prepared under the Ministry of Panchayati Raj**.
- **Maharashtra and Jharkhand** — again higher devolution of functions. (Case studies and examples are needed in the answer.)
- **Odisha and Uttarakhand** — low or less devolution of functions. (This is Uttarakhand — self-corrected in class, not Jharkhand.)
- **Uttarakhand** is a hilly state where reaching the MLA is very difficult. In its important cities such as **Haridwar, Tehri, Pauri, Dehradun and Mussoorie**, and in the hilly areas generally, **representation is poorer** — these states are poorer in that sense.

QUICK REVISION

- F-cube = funds, functions, functionaries; the problem of functions is the lack of devolution of subjects by the state government.
- CAG 2024: of the 18 subjects of the Twelfth Schedule, only 4 are on average fully devolved to ULBs.
- Entries must be read broadly — e.g. urban sanitation has sub-functions performed by the Delhi Jal Board rather than the MCD.
- Full devolution means no overlap of functions; if fully devolved, 100% responsibility and all expenditure for water logging would lie with the municipal corporation.
- Specific functions: land use, and public health (disease prevention, mohalla clinics) — usually not devolved and performed by parastatals.
- Way forward in practice: devolve all 18 subjects, avoid overlap, and transfer parastatal functions such as water-charge collection from the Delhi Jal Board to the municipal corporation, so that grievance redressal sits with the councillor and not the MLA.
- Case studies: Kerala high; Maharashtra and Jharkhand higher devolution; Odisha and Uttarakhand low — with Uttarakhand's hilly terrain making the MLA hard to reach.

6.10 The Devolution Index: Parameters and Rankings

The **devolution index** is prepared under the **Ministry of Panchayati Raj**; this ranking is a **PIB brief** that came up on **16th July**.

Write down quickly the parameters that the devolution index contains:

- **Framework** — it includes **reservation of seats**, **regular elections**, **panchayat duration** and the **constitution of DPCs**. This sub-heading analyses whether the main constitutional provisions have been fully fulfilled or not: if a state has **50% reservation** that state will have a higher framework rank (the constitutional requirement is 33%), and if elections are regular the rank is comparatively higher.
- **Functions**.
- **Finances**.
- **Functionaries** — that is, after the framework, F-cube is analysed.
- **Functionality** — the Government of India is also acknowledging that functionality is a concern.
- **Capacity building** — in bracket: focus on training of the functionaries.
- **Accountability** — in bracket it includes **accounting and audit of panchayats**, **social audit**, **regular meetings of the Gram Sabha**, and **transparency and anti-corruption**.
- Also analysed: **how much the state government incentivizes the panchayats**, and **whether the state has a separate anti-defection law enacted at the third tier**.
- For states that do not devolve, one cannot talk about functions, one cannot talk about devolution and one cannot give numbers in the same way — but these **anecdotes belong in answers** in the civil services examination.

Top of the devolution index	Kerala (first); Karnataka was also named in the discussion; Tamil Nadu (third); Maharashtra (fourth); Uttar Pradesh (fifth)
Low performance — north-eastern and eastern states	Assam and Tripura; Sikkim is named as the happiest state
Other states named among the low performers	Uttarakhand and Punjab [as stated in lecture]
Union Territories — poor rank	Lakshadweep and Andaman and Nicobar (very good administration); Chandigarh (well governed because of central funding as a UT); Dadra and Nagar Haveli

CRITICAL POINT

Administration Is Not Democratic Decentralization.

- What is being discussed is **not administration** — it is the concept of **democratic decentral-**

ization.

- A city like **Chandigarh** is very well governed, not because of its municipal corporation but because of the amount of funding it gets from the central government, being a Union Territory.
- It is a beautiful thing administratively, but it is an equally poor thing for democratic decentralization: for the people of Chandigarh, Lakshadweep or Dadra and Nagar Haveli, the money is being spent by the **central government**. If that same money were spent by the **municipal corporation**, we would see the good results and would obviously praise it.

QUICK REVISION

- The devolution index is prepared under the Ministry of Panchayati Raj; the ranking discussed is a PIB brief of 16th July.
- Parameters: framework (reservation, regular elections, panchayat duration, DPCs), functions, finances, functionaries, functionality, capacity building and accountability.
- Accountability includes accounting and audit of panchayats, social audit, regular Gram Sabha meetings, and transparency and anti-corruption.
- Also assessed: how much the state incentivizes panchayats, and whether it has a separate third-tier anti-defection law.
- Ranking discussed: Kerala first (Karnataka also named), Tamil Nadu third, Maharashtra fourth, Uttar Pradesh fifth.
- Low performers: Assam, Tripura and other north-eastern/eastern states; Sikkim is the happiest state; Uttarakhand and Punjab; and the Union Territories (Lakshadweep, Andaman and Nicobar, Chandigarh, Dadra and Nagar Haveli) rank poorly.
- Central funding makes UTs well administered but does not advance democratic decentralization — that is the distinction to draw.

CHAPTER 7

Local Self-Government: Functions, Functionaries and Funds — Devolution Problems and the Way Forward

7.1 Devolution of Functions: Direct Cash Transfers and the Shrinking Role of the Gram Sabha

The discussion continues from the dimensions of local self-government already covered — importance of local self-government (administrative importance, the keyword being **democratic decentralization**), social justice, women empowerment, the concept of the **Gram Sabha**, and **Gram Swaraj** as a very important field. The next dimension taken up is the **devolution of functions**.

- Devolution of functions is inseparable from the role of **direct cash transfers**.
  - Under **JAM** — Jan Dhan Yojana, Aadhaar and Mobile — the gram panchayats are left with only a limited role: the selection of beneficiaries.
  - Under **PM Kisan Yojana**, Rs. 6,000 is transferred directly to farmers, eliminating the need of PRI institutions.
- Under **MGNREGA**, the beneficiaries of the scheme were always identified by the **Gram Sabha**.
  - The Gram Sabha looked at the provisions, evaluated all the job cards, and the job cards were then given to the beneficiaries.
- Ever since 2015 the central government has focused on the identification of beneficiaries itself.
  - In PM Kisan-type transfers, if farmers are to be given Rs. 6,000, the farmers are not identified by the Gram Panchayat; it is the responsibility of the agricultural department of the state in which the farmer's village lies — that is, of the state government.
  - The reason is the central government's need for pinpoint focus: the beneficiary should directly receive the money.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **The latest nuance.**
>
> - In any such cash transfer scheme where the central government or the state government is trying to identify the beneficiary, the role of the Gram Sabha has reduced.
> - This applies specifically to **direct cash transfer-based schemes**, not to all schemes.
> - Schemes such as the Forest Rights Act, mining laws, MGNREGA and now Viksit Bharat Yojana

stand in contrast.

QUICK REVISION

- Devolution of functions must be read along with the role of direct cash transfers.
- **JAM** = Jan Dhan Yojana + Aadhaar + Mobile; under such transfers the gram panchayat retains only beneficiary selection.
- **PM Kisan Yojana** transfers Rs. 6,000 directly to farmers and eliminates the need of PRI institutions.
- Under **MGNREGA** the Gram Sabha identified beneficiaries by evaluating job cards; since 2015 the central government identifies them itself, through the state agricultural department.
- The Gram Sabha's role has shrunk specifically in **direct cash transfer-based schemes**, not in all schemes.

7.2 The Office of the Mayor: Structural Constraints

- The **Speaker of the Lok Sabha** is the representative of the Lok Sabha and presides over it; the **mayor** is elected by the ward councillors — for example wards 370 and 380 in Delhi.
  - The mayor is the head of the entire municipal corporation (in Delhi, the MCD), which deliberates the issues concerning that particular area.
  - So he is also carrying the role of a speaker as the head of that municipal corporation.
- Simultaneously, the mayor has executive functions.
  - The mayor deliberates within the municipal council's meeting, legislates and participates in it.
  - The same mayor also implements certain schemes in coordination with the municipal commissioner.
  - At one level he is like a Pradhan Mantri — an executive head; at another level he is like a member of the Council of States. That functional clarity is not there with respect to local bodies.
- When the office of the mayor is strangulated, he himself becomes dependent on the **municipal commissioner**.
  - While trying to implement the resolutions and proposals passed by the municipal corporation, all his powers rest on the municipal commissioner, who is appointed by the state government and will not listen to him.
  - His role is not clearly segregated: whether the mayor is the legislative head or the executive head is not settled.

KEY CONCEPT

Write down.

- The mayor heads both the **elected and administrative wings** of the city government.
- The mayor has **limited executive authority**, as in most Indian cities: the real administrative

control lies with the municipal commissioners appointed by the state government.

- **NITI Aayog** has pointed out that mayors are mere **titular heads** — M-E-R-E, mere titular heads — while the real power lies with the municipal commissioners.

1. Limited authority with the mayor.
2. No clear function.
3. No uniformity in tenure — the mayor's tenure varies from one year to five years in different states.

- The term of the Prime Minister, or of any leader — a leader of the house or a member of Parliament — is fixed.
  - But the third tier and the powers of the third tier are dependent on the state legislature, and every function has to be given to it by the state legislature.
- Hence the variation: in some municipal corporations there are five mayors in a span of five years, while elsewhere there is one mayor for that city for five years.
  - In some places the mayor is indirectly elected and in others directly elected; an indirectly elected mayor may serve one year or five years.
  - An overall uniformity in that office is therefore not achieved.
- The first two points hold everywhere — the mayor is dependent on the municipal corporation/commissioner and has no clear function.
  - The absence of uniformity in tenure is a state-by-state concern.

QUICK REVISION

- The mayor is elected by ward councillors and heads the municipal corporation, combining a speaker-like role with executive functions.
- The mayor heads both the **elected and administrative wings** of the city government but has **limited executive authority**; real control lies with the state-appointed municipal commissioner.
- **NITI Aayog**: mayors are mere **titular heads**.
- Three issues: limited authority, no clear function, and no uniformity in tenure — one year to five years across states.
- The state legislature gives every function to the third tier, so the tenure and powers vary from state to state.

7.3 Parallel Administrative Agencies and the Erosion of Local Bodies

After the problem of the mayor, the biggest problem in functions — and Delhi is the best example — is the creation of **parallel administrative arrangements**. The union government and the state government have set up several parallel agencies, which has led to a diminished role of local body institutions.

- **MCD (Municipal Corporation of Delhi)** is the local body that is supposed to perform the entire role of urban management in New Delhi.

- Alongside it stands the **DJB (Delhi Jal Board)**, a parastatal.
  - A **parastatal** means a separate body which has been formed by the state with a specific function — here, the provision of water supply.
- The **DDA (Delhi Development Authority)** is headed by the **Lieutenant Governor** as chairman.
  - The Vice-Chairman is the highest officer chosen by the central government.
- There is also the **CPWD (Central Public Works Department)**.
- All of these bodies reduce the importance of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi.
  - The DDA builds flats — but if DDA flats are built, that land is Delhi's land, and the revenue rights, ownership and management should not rest with the DDA; they should be entirely with the MCD.
  - In Jaipur it is the JDA's approved land and in Indore the Indore Development Authority's approved land; that development authority's role should not exist after the third tier has been created.
- Other parallel bodies in the same city: the **Delhi Slum Development Board**, and for transport the **DMRC (Delhi Metro Rail Corporation)**.
  - Urban transport plays a very important role in all other western nations.
- Functions such as addressing water logging, providing water supply and running urban transport do not belong to the MCD — they belong to these agencies.
  - Delhi's green buses, red buses and the new e-buses are run and administered by the Delhi state government; the MCD has no correlation with that agency.
  - **Last-mile connectivity and last-mile service delivery** cannot be delivered by any agency better than by the municipal corporation — yet only small functions such as garbage management have been given to it, though the person lifting the garbage may be an MCD employee.
  - Housing and Urban Affairs has a large role in Delhi because it is a union territory; in other cities this may not be so, but state government agencies will exist there too.
- In rural areas the PRIs — the gram panchayat upwards — coexist with a second, parallel administration: the **BDOs (Block Development Officers)**, who represent the state government.
  - The BDO reports straight to the district administration, so both together lead to **administrative confusion and duplication**.
  - All rural development work belongs to the PRIs, so a parallel BDO arrangement should not exist; the BDO's work should be that whatever rural development there is should all be done by the PRIs.
  - In practice the PRIs bring their own plans while the BDO's reporting is to the SDM and the SDM's to the DM — a parallel arrangement created at the rural level. In the cities the arrangement is far more complex.

CRITICAL POINT

Why the parallel agencies exist.

- It is because the state governments want to retain the power; they do not want to completely devolve the functions to the local bodies.

- So the problem of **functionality** is added to the problem of FQ. FQ has not ended and has remained; it has transferred to functionality — functionality has become an added concern, and it has now become **F4**.
- Had there been complete devolution, these bodies would have no role and the control should be given to the municipal corporation. It is basically appropriation of authority — and with authority will automatically come responsibility.

QUICK REVISION

- Delhi is the classic case study of parallel administrative arrangements that diminish the local body.
- **MCD** is the local body for urban management; **DJB** (water), **DDA** (development, chaired by the Lieutenant Governor), **CPWD**, the **Delhi Slum Development Board** and **DMRC** (transport) run alongside it.
- A **parastatal** is a separate body formed by the state with a specific function.
- Water logging, water supply and urban transport are handled by these agencies, not by the MCD; last-mile service delivery suffers.
- In rural areas the parallel agency is the **BDO**, who reports to the SDM and not to the PRIs — causing confusion and duplication.
- The reason is the states' desire to retain power; the result is that functionality has become an added concern — **F4**.

7.4 No Activity Mapping: Why Merely Devolving Subjects Is Not Enough

- The last and very important point on functions is the **lack of activity mapping**.
  - The functions or subjects in the **11th and 12th Schedules** have not been broken into activities and sub-activities.
  - This has led to a limited role of the RLBs and the ULBs.
- Any single entry of the Schedules is too broad to fix responsibility — take sanitation.
  - Example: in old Rajinder Nagar the sewer lines get clogged in the monsoons because remains of plants or leaves block them, and because all the drains clog, there is flooding during the monsoon.
  - Even if the Delhi government has devolved urban sanitation to the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, that is not enough.
- Merely giving a function is not sufficient; the activity must be broken into different sub-activities or smaller domains.
  - The smaller the area in which you block activities, the stronger the fixing of responsibility.
  - Analogy: organising a class is one function, but it involves maintenance of the equipment, checking access to the internet, maintaining a proper seating arrangement, knowing whether there will be a power cut, and having an alternative arrangement if this floor encounters any issue.
- What states actually do is devolve a broad entry such as sanitation without mapping which of

its parts the ULB will handle.

- Functions are devolved, but at the end of the day, because activity mapping has not been done, there is no **functional clarity**.
- Without functional clarity, the MCDs, the RLBs and the PRI institutions end up getting dependent on the state government.
- Analogy: if the entire activity of organising a class is broken into six sets and allocated, there is automatically no confusion; if it is not broken well, the individual gets confused, comes back to me, and dependence on me increases.
- Even when 18 subjects are devolved, it is not full devolution — some layer is always kept by the state.

KEY CONCEPT

Remember.

- Breaking the main function or main subject into activities and sub-activities is **one of the six criteria of the devolution index**.

QUICK REVISION

- Lack of **activity mapping** is the reason the 11th and 12th Schedule entries remain broad and the role of local bodies stays limited.
- Devolving a subject such as sanitation is not enough; it must be split into sub-activities with fixed responsibility.
- The finer the break-up, the stronger the responsibility fixing — the class-organising analogy shows how many activities a single function hides.
- No activity mapping means no **functional clarity**, and without functional clarity local bodies become dependent on the state.
- Activity mapping is one of the **six criteria of the devolution index**.

7.5 Devolution Without Officials and Revenue: Scheme Implementers, Not Formulators

- There is **devolution without officials and without revenue augmentation**.
  - This has led to limited operational efficiency for panchayats and municipalities.
  - Local bodies have become **scheme implementers** rather than **scheme formulators**.
- Example — urban transport in Delhi shows how ownership is fragmented.
  - The best option is the metro, an entirely separate organisation run and maintained by the **DMRC**.
  - Coming from Meerut there is the Namo Bharat train, again with a separate set of ownership.
  - Even if the entire function of urban transport were given to the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, the job would not be done.
- What is needed is devolution of officials, not only of functions.
  - Till the point proper officials are devolved from the state government — officials who work

with the MCD, get their experience and ensure that capacity building takes place — nothing changes.
  - If the corporation does not have **concomitant sources of finance** and does not have concomitant staff, it will again end up becoming a flawed entity.
- Example — parking shows the full chain a function requires.
  - Delhi Metro is successful because of its big stations — Mukherjee Nagar, Hauz Khas, Green Park and Karol Bagh.
  - Creating urban transport is one thing, but parking spots must also be identified; for that, land — public land — has to be acquired.
  - At that parking spot the municipal corporation must be given the right to collect the fee: the ability to collect the parking fee, together with the **power to levy a tax**.
  - That power reaches the municipal corporation only after the state legislature has devolved it and given it to the corporation — the scheme of the **73rd and 74th Amendments** discussed earlier.
- Full devolution has three steps: **function first, functionaries second, and funds third**.
  - If the corporation is not enabled to tax, is not provided the best staff, and no source such as parking fees is created, the function automatically becomes redundant.
  - Parking services would be created but there would be no parking spots, so there would be congestion; in the end the conclusion is that the municipal corporations were not able to handle it.

KEY CONCEPT

Hourglass syndrome.

- State governments are always against municipal corporations because they think the centre has been very powerful; after the creation of the third tier, local bodies may not be powerful, but they have surely taken some constitutional space and some share of revenue from the states. This fear is called the **hourglass syndrome** — as if an hourglass has been made of the state's position.
- Therefore states devolve only the functions: 'I will give you all the functions and make the CAG report look very good because I devolved the functions, but I will not give the funds, and I will not give the functionaries.'
- Devolution as an idea is therefore unaddressed and is still not fully functional.

- Consequently the MCD's role today remains garbage collection and limited functions — water and basic sanitation.
  - The work the Delhi government is doing is precisely the work the Constitution says the MCD should do.
- Recap of the earlier discussion on elections: elections are not held on time, after the elections there is no constitution of the first meeting, and the State Election Commissions have got no powers.
- Recap of the functions discussion: devolution does not happen, activity mapping is not being done, the mayor has certain constraints, parallel agencies have been created in the villages and

in the urban areas, and even where functions are devolved the mayor ends up a puppet — the power, resources and dependence of the ULBs and the RLBs remain on the state governments.

- Functions was the first problem studied — the problem of the **F-cube (F^3)**. The second is the problem of **functionaries**.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Devolution without officials and without revenue augmentation turns local bodies into **scheme implementers** instead of **scheme formulators**.
> - Urban transport is fragmented between the DMRC, the Namo Bharat train and the state — giving the function to the MCD alone would not work.
> - Parking shows the chain: identify the spot, acquire land, give the corporation the right to collect fees and **the power to levy a tax** (after state legislature devolution).
> - The three steps of full devolution are function, functionaries and funds — otherwise the function becomes redundant.
> - The **hourglass syndrome** explains why states devolve functions but withhold funds and functionaries.

7.6 Functionaries: Staffing and District Control

- The way a municipal function is delivered is flexible and can be arranged in several ways.
  - The corporation may enter a **PPP** arrangement with a local contractor, where it outsources a tender and, under that tender, the garbage van together with the entire waste collection is the contractor's headache.
  - It may hire a garbage van from the state government, pay the requisite due to the state government, and the waste collection is done by the contractor.
  - It may itself buy 10, 20, 30, 40 or 50 garbage recovery vans and allocate them to a private player who merely collects the waste and deposits it at the waste collection point.
  - Drivers may be of the contractor or employed on the payroll of the municipal corporation.
- Analogy: the PWD itself can build a road, can outsource that task to a separate entity, or can enter a PPP model for 10–15 years in which the private entity does the revenue generation and gives the control back later.
  - In practice it is usually all privatised and outsourced: waste collection is usually outsourced by any municipal corporation. It is only one of the arrangements that can exist.
- The first issue in functionaries is **staffing**: there is limited staff with the local government.
  - There is also a lack of **specialised staff** — for example, engineers.
  - The shortage concern is grave in rural local bodies; the biggest shortage is for the gram panchayat.
- The condition of the gram panchayat office shows the shortage.
  - Many panchayats share a single secretary: a qualified gram sachiv (panchayat secretary), who qualified the examination and has been deputed to assist the panchayat, runs into four or five gram panchayats.

  - Four or five gram panchayats imply that a population of almost 25,000–30,000 is covered by one panchayat secretary, in a north Indian area.
  - That is far too much, because this is a local body and services are being delivered to the citizen at his doorstep.
- Second, there is **direct control of the district administration** over the sub-district staff.
  - The sub-district staff is controlled by the **collector** — the DM — and the collector's role is still as important as it was in the pre-1993 scenario, when everything in the district was controlled by the district collector.
  - Now that the third tier has been created, a district contains so many gram panchayats and at least one local body: Lucknow has one DM under whom the municipal corporation works, and Lucknow district or Noida has so many gram panchayats and sarpanches.
  - District administration's powers are reduced, because the powers which the state government exercised through the DM are now inserted in the 11th and 12th Schedules — but because there is a lack of permanent staffing, that does not translate into local capacity.
- Sarpanchas and gram panchayats protest at the DM office whenever land acquisition happens or whenever development takes place, because the DM office is still powerful.
  - That activism is a reflection of the fact that there is no devolution of funds, no devolution of functions and no devolution of functionaries.
  - Once functions are given to the local bodies, the DM has a limited role; the DM is one agency representing the state government.
- Why local staff are not loyal to the local body: if I am employed with the district administration as my boss, I will have no affiliation with the local body.
  - Why will I work for a gram panchayat, and why will a BDO listen to the sarpanch, when the BDO's reporting is to the SDM and therefore to the state government?
  - State government officials working with the local bodies often function as **birds of passage**: if they have five or six months, or 1–1.5 years, they will go to their house, because their affiliation is with the state government department and not with the department where they have been deputed.

QUICK REVISION

- Municipal functions can be delivered by the corporation itself, through a PPP, by hiring from the state, or by buying its own fleet — waste collection is usually outsourced.
- First issue: **limited and non-specialised staffing**, gravest for the gram panchayat — one panchayat secretary for four or five panchayats, i.e. 25,000–30,000 people.
- Second issue: **direct control of the district administration**; the collector's role remains as important as pre-1993.
- Powers over the district have moved to the 11th and 12th Schedules, but without permanent staffing the gain does not reach the local body.
- Protest at the DM's office is a symptom of non-devolution of funds, functions and functionaries.
- State officials deputed to local bodies act as **birds of passage**, loyal to their parent state department.

7.7 Functionaries: Training, Capacity and Financial Dependence

- Along with staffing come the concerns of **limited capacity building, limited training and limited awareness** about planning, budgeting and governance processes, and the **lack of induction training**.
- Every job — in every company, in any government service — first has an induction training.
  - The training lasts at least three months; it is two years if you become an IES, and two and a half years for the forest service, because forest management is a technical endeavour.
  - That training is called the **FC — foundation course**.
  - After five, seven or eight years there is mid-career training; there are two or three trainings in all, and one has to travel to the academy (LBSNAA) to be trained.
- Governance cannot be handled without training.
  - When you are trying to discuss governance, you first need to teach public administration, the process of planning and the process of budgeting — which entry, how much expenditure.
  - Budgeting is the most difficult and the most technical exercise; it is not something easily achievable.
  - Therefore all this training should happen at induction, when the job is given, and then year after year — every two to three years.
- Disaster example: when a disaster strikes — for example in Uttarakhand — who takes all the decisions? The DM. Should he?
  - Once gram panchayats, municipal corporations and the local body mechanism have been created, if the local body staff is untrained, the gram panchayat will call up the BDO again and again.
  - The BDO then says that these people know no work — but how will work happen when no one taught them how to work?
  - It is something they straight away learn on the job.
- In gram panchayats the situation is worse because of the lack of education qualifications.
  - The elected sarpanch may be a 4th, 5th or 6th pass.
  - Several states such as Haryana have made educational qualifications and the number of children a criterion for a person to contest or win an election; the bar goes up to 10th pass.
  - Haryana has better literacy; in the so-called BIMARU states the situation is even worse.
- But the staff's condition is equally bad.
  - They have been treated in such a way that nothing will be done — the gram sachiv will simply learn on his own.
  - By contrast, the state government gets training for its own employees done at big head-quarters, where senior officers have AC offices and all facilities — none of that is there for these local body staff.
- Independent sources of income have been given, but in such a way that the dependence of the local body still remains.
  - The MCD has a separate budget; the **Safai Karamcharis**, and the Class 3 and Class 4 employees, are completely on the rolls of the municipal corporation of that area.

  - At the higher levels there may be deputation of officials from the state government: for example, the municipal commissioner derives his salary from the budgetary expense of the state government of that respective state.

QUICK REVISION

- Capacity building, training, awareness of planning and budgeting, and induction training are all limited for local bodies.
- Every government job begins with an induction training — at least three months, two years for the IES, two and a half years for the forest service — called the **foundation course (FC)**, followed by mid-career training.
- Budgeting is the most difficult and technical exercise; without it governance cannot be run, so training must begin at induction and continue periodically.
- An untrained gram panchayat keeps calling the BDO; the BDO concludes they know no work — the fault is the absence of training.
- Gram panchayats suffer from low educational qualifications of elected representatives; states such as Haryana prescribe qualifications and a limit on the number of children.
- The staff's own training and facilities are far worse than those of state government employees; higher posts such as the municipal commissioner remain on the state's payroll, so dependence continues.

7.8 Funds: Own Source Revenue and the Property Tax Problem

- The third problem is the problem of **funds or finances**.
  - Theoretically on paper, if you look at the constitutional scheme, none of these problems should exist.
  - The Constitution assumes that all the subjects should be devolved; it assumes that the state government might give powers (referred to here with respect to backward classes); and it assumes that every five years there would be a constitution of a **State Finance Commission**.
  - Because the state government is not doing it, it is basically a flaw of implementation — theoretically a better enactment could not have been made, compared to the other areas.
- The first and major issue, for both municipal corporations and the RLBs, is **limited OSR — own source revenue**.
  - Limited own source revenue increases the dependence of the local body on centre-level and state-level grants.

Panchayats (RLBs)	1%	RBI report on finances of PRIs, 2022-23
Urban local bodies	32%	CAG, 2024
ULBs of Jharkhand, Manipur, Tripura and Uttarakhand	15%	CAG, 2024

- Money reaches a local body from two directions: the union's grants are **Finance Commission grants**, and the state's are **State Finance Commission grants**.
  - So if own source revenue is what is in the pocket of a municipal corporation, only Rs. 1 is what it is earning; the rest, 99%, comes in the form of grants.
- The other side of the story is the per capita picture.
  - As per the **Ministry of Panchayati Raj Report on Own Source Revenue of RLBs** — both reports being of 2022 — the per capita own source revenue from 2017-18 to 2021-22 was **Rs. 59 annually**.
  - Illustration: a gram panchayat such as Todhapur with 5,000 people generates revenue from those 5,000 people of only about Rs. 60; that is the annual earning of the gram panchayat per person.
  - Seen at the national level, that Rs. 59–60 translates to 1% of the total revenue owned by the gram panchayat — very low.

COMPARISON

The national figure versus Goa.

- The per capita own source revenue of a gram panchayat is about **Rs. 59 annually** nationally, while in the state of **Goa** it is about **Rs. 1,640 annually** — and in Goa devolution of powers is very less as per the devolution index.
- Goa's gram panchayats have still been successfully generating a lot of wealth by different metrics.

- How Goa's gram panchayats earn, and why the same is hard elsewhere.
  - If a road has been built in the village, a fee is levied for its maintenance.
  - Where solar lights are installed, the gram panchayat says that it will install common solar lights and provide electricity, and will charge whoever uses the solar power.
  - A community pond was created where cattle drink water; a playground, or a park, was created and charges are levied for its use.
  - But how can a gram panchayat levy a tax or a charge for a service? It is too close to the people of that area, so it will be limited.
  - The sarpanch has to win the election, so he will think ten times before suggesting any tax; in a gram panchayat everyone knows everyone, so the tax will not be levied.

  - That is why the working of municipal corporations is very different from the working of panchayats.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **Reasons for low own source revenue in panchayats (these reasons may be asked).**
>
> - Absence or outdated nature of state-level rules and guidelines.
> - Inadequate devolution of taxation powers.
> - Limited cooperation from the citizens — people will not pay the tax.
> - Weak enforcement against defaulters — if the tax is levied, all become defaulters and nobody is watching.

- Why enforcement is weak: it is a question of people's mentality about paying for a service they use.
  - If anyone gives you an income tax notice, unless you are a big con man you would be 100% worried about it, even if it is a fine of Rs. 5,000–6,000 or unpaid GST.
  - But with a parking charge the payer always knows who is collecting and feels nothing will happen — you know who is taking money from you.
  - So for a service that is actually being used there is always limited cooperation, and even where there is cooperation, there is weak enforcement against defaulters; this is the reason rural local bodies generate very little own source revenue.
- The urban picture is comparatively better, but still bad: the own source revenue of ULBs is more than that of rural local bodies.
  - The **CAG in 2024** revealed that for urban local bodies it is **32% of total revenue** — much more than the RLBs, but still very low.
  - In the states of Jharkhand, Manipur (a northeastern state), Tripura and Uttarakhand, it is merely **15%** for urban local bodies — again much more than RLB, but 15% for an urban local body is very less.
- The biggest problem is **overt dependence on property tax**.
  - Many innovative mechanisms exist through which a municipal corporation earns money, but the problem is that it depends on property tax, and its taxation rates are far too low.
- Example — Old Rajinder Nagar: owners convert residential property into a commercial occupation.
  - The land given to them is residential accommodation, with shops below and a house above, because it is basically a refugee colony — Rajinder Nagar was built for the people who came from Pakistan.
  - But the house owners have made PGs: not one, not two, not four, but twenty PGs.
  - Officially they therefore require the charges to be paid to the municipal corporation, because they are converting their residential property into a commercial occupation — a commercialisation charge that is due to the MCD and is not paid.
- Example — parking charges in Delhi are Rs. 10, Rs. 20 or Rs. 30 at the top places.
  - If the parking charge were raised to Rs. 360–400, because congestion is to be prevented, a

big chunk of revenue could be earned by the Municipal Corporation of Delhi.
  - Common areas need not be touched, but in the high-profile areas money can certainly be charged; in Lutyens' Delhi the marketplaces have next to no parking charges.
  - A good amount of land is available with the municipal corporation where a parking facility could be given and money earned — yet there is a single dependence: property tax.
- **Property tax** explained: if I register a property — say I buy this building floor from the owner — then, because I am engaging myself in a transaction, I pay the respective tax to the municipal corporation.
  - It is the MCD's land and the transaction has happened in its domain; whatever the percentage rate, that percentage is paid to it.
  - This is their fixed method, because nothing has to be done — the building has stood there for years and everybody knows the market rates.
  - But there are no innovative methods; dependence on property tax is too much, and the utilisation or revenue collection from it is suboptimal.
- Why property tax collection is suboptimal — the valuation gap.
  - If I buy this floor, the price I pay to the owner may be Rs. 12–15 crore, but the registry and the taxes will not be on Rs. 10–12 crore.
  - They will be at a rate at least 6–7 times less than the price I am paying for the property.
  - So the municipal corporation itself decides the prevalent market rates of the property, because eventually it depends on me — if I am willing to pay the premium, I may go on paying the price I want; but the corporation has to give a certain ballpark.
  - These are called **market rates**.
- The market rates are kept far too low.
  - If the corporation repeatedly revised the rates, the revenue source would automatically increase.
  - Illustration: if I buy the floor for Rs. 12 crore on paper while the market rate should not be beyond Rs. 4–5 crore, then I transact with the individual for Rs. 12 crore but the government books only Rs. 4–5 crore — the remaining Rs. 8 crore transaction is not visible.
  - Tax is levied at the government market rate only on what is shown, so automatic renewal of market rates would benefit the corporation.
- Vast property escapes the tax net.
  - There are huge patches of land in the territory of Delhi controlled by the municipal corporation which have no accounting, have been occupied, and on which localities have come up.
  - Permission was given for one floor but 6 floors were built, so that property tax was foregone.
  - There is also limited use of GIS and limited use of technology.
- Net result: the easiest source of revenue is not exploited.
  - Buildings have been standing for years, yet money is not earned through other means, and even on property tax the corporation remains dependent.

DATA & FACTS

As per the CAG, only 56% of property tax demand is realised by the ULBs.

- **Incomplete property data** — the taxable value — leading to poor revenue.
- **Undervaluation of the property** — the taxable value is often much below the market value, as improper valuation methods are used.
- **Political sensitivity** — citizens protest against the rise in property tax.
- **Broad exemptions and rebates** — for example, if a property is registered in the name of a female, the property tax is automatically much lesser; there are many such exemptions in the collection mechanism.
- **Poor administrative enforcement.**
- **Poor service delivery** further weakens tax collection from the citizens.

India	0.15%
Developing countries	0.6%
Developed nations	1%

- There is also a general reluctance to use fiscal powers: the right to levy tax on business, the right to levy tax on markets and the right to levy tax on fares.
  - The same reluctance applies to service collection fees such as those for street lighting or public toilets.

QUICK REVISION

- On paper the constitutional scheme leaves no room for these problems — devolution of all subjects, powers to the state, and a State Finance Commission every five years; the failure is one of implementation.
- Limited **OSR (own source revenue)** increases dependence on centre-level and state-level grants.
- Panchayats' own source revenue is only **1%** of total revenue (RBI, 2022-23); for ULBs it is **32%** (CAG, 2024) and just **15%** in Jharkhand, Manipur, Tripura and Uttarakhand.
- Per capita own source revenue of a gram panchayat is about **Rs. 59 annually** (2017-18 to 2021-22), against **Rs. 1,640** in Goa.
- Reasons for low OSR: outdated state rules, inadequate taxation powers, limited citizen cooperation, weak enforcement against defaulters.
- Property tax is the easiest revenue source but is under-exploited: market rates are kept low, huge property is unaccounted, and only **56% of demand is realised** (CAG) — property tax is just **0.15% of GDP** in India against 0.6% in developing and 1% in developed countries.

7.9 Funds: Grants, Intergovernmental Transfers and State Finance Commissions

- The next issue concerns **grants**: number one is the RLBs' dependence on **IGT — intergovernmental transfers** — that is, grants from the union and the state.
- There is **limited flexibility and autonomy**, because even though Finance Commission grants have increased, a certain proportion of grants is **tied** to a specific activity.
  - Tied means that only if that activity is performed will the money be given; the Finance Commission has given a direction to the ULBs and the RLBs to that effect, and the amount is **Rs. 7.45 lakh crore**.
  - There are two types of grants: **basic grant** and **performance grant**.
  - As per the Finance Commission referred to as the **16th FC**, **50% of the basic grant is tied to solid waste management and water management**.

13th FC	2010–15	Rs. 87,000 crore
14th FC	2015–20	Rs. 2.87 lakh crore
Next in the sequence	Not stated	Rs. 4.36 lakh crore
Referred to as the 16th FC	2021–26	Rs. 7.1 lakh crore

- Draw this diagram: it compares the grants of the Finance Commissions over the years.
  - Earlier the grants were all untied; now they are tied based on certain developments and conditionalities.
  - Finance Commission grants to local bodies — rural and urban — have been increasing: about Rs. 87,000 crore, then Rs. 2.87 lakh crore, then Rs. 4.36 lakh crore, and then almost Rs. 7.1 lakh crore, a figure also given as almost Rs. 8,000 crore / Rs. 8 lakh crore for the 2021-26 period [as stated in lecture].
- Not all of that money reached the local bodies.
  - Because the grants are performance based, there is a shortfall: about Rs. 3.3 lakh crore came to the local bodies in the 2021-26 period.
  - There were also issues like delay in the constitution of State Finance Commissions and non-adherence to the criteria set by the Finance Commission.

> **DATA & FACTS**
>
> **15th Finance Commission period.**
>
> - During the 15th FC period only **63% of the recommended grants** were released to the ULBs.

- This is a tough topic — it is not like the usual questions that are found.

7.9.1 Delay in the Constitution of State Finance Commissions

- The first issue with the SFCs is **delay in their constitution**; the example is a **CAG audit in 2024 of 18 states**, which revealed that only 10 have set up a State Finance Commission every five years.
- The arithmetic shows what the states owe.
  - Fifteen Finance Commissions have been constituted at the centre, and a Finance Commission at the centre and in a state is constituted for five years.
  - Constitutional implementation started in 1950, so $15 \times 5 = 75$ years — exactly in 2025 the recommendations of the 15th Finance Commission ended, with about a year's variation because some issues were separated.
- At the centre, a Finance Commission is formed every five years with no problems at all, before time, and its report comes before time; the 16th Finance Commission has already given its report and it has already been implemented — this is the very first year of implementation.
- The same five-yearly discipline should have existed in every state after the 73rd and 74th Amendments became a reality in April 1993.
  - The year today is 2026, and 2026 minus 1993 is almost 30 (33) years.
  - Every state should constitute a State Finance Commission every five years, so there should have been at least **six finance commissions in every state** — six into five is thirty.
  - That is not the case: leaving aside the sixth or the fifth, many states have not even constituted the fourth State Finance Commission yet.

> **DATA & FACTS**
>
> **Average lag in the appointment of a State Finance Commission.**
>
> - A CAG report revealed the lag in the appointment of a State Finance Commission: a figure of **600 days** was also cited, which is very high but is not true all over the country; by the law of averages the average delay works out to **412 days**.

7.9.2 Why the State Finance Commissions Fail

- Second point: **resource constraints**.
  - Only limited infrastructure support is provided to the SFC.
  - Limited office space is provided, which leads to delay.
  - There is poor data quality, because the SFCs are not presented with accurate data on the finances of local bodies.
- Third: their **reports are not placed before the House**.
- Fourth: state governments **do not follow the recommendations of the SFC** — unlike the central government, which fulfils the recommendations of the Union Finance Commission.
- This time the 16th Finance Commission also recommended that it be given a **permanent office**.
  - Three or four months go into arranging a secretariat, clerks and basic infrastructure — even who will make the tea.
  - A proper infrastructure has to be given: they are not given an office, and a government car

only if some officer on leave has not taken it.

- A Finance Commission is a technical body: it has to study the revenues and the budgets and decide how much augmentation is needed, yet state government officials do not cooperate at all — no office, no car, no staff, no material and no records.

COMPARISON

The centre and the states: the same body, two worlds.

- At the centre the Commission is constituted every five years, ahead of time, and its report comes before time; its members are the top of the top of economists — **Arvind Panagariya, Vijay Kelkar and C. Rangarajan**.
- In the states, 'bottom of the bottom' officials are appointed; the government appoints its own man, retires him, and does not even give him an office.

- At the centre the whole exercise is a hundred percent technical exercise.
  - To fulfil its task the Commission travels across the entire country, studies the response, talks to political parties, collects data, obtains data from the central government and then prepares a report.
  - A layperson cannot do it and a babu cannot do it — the person must be a technical government economist, of the kind who has been the governor of the central bank or who knows financial management by having studied it.
  - The Constitution says this for **Article 280**.
- Local bodies get money from both the state budget and the union budget: the recommendation for the state route must come from the **State Finance Commission** and for the central route from the **Finance Commission**.
  - So for the money of a local body, the recommendation of the SFC is needed here and of the FC is needed there.
- The congruence argument: if a local body is to get money from the State Finance Commission, the SFCs must be appointed, organised and must function in a congruent manner, because this is a five-yearly functioning without any stop.
  - This might function or might not function in a state.
  - When the Finance Commission at the centre is trying to give grants to a particular state, it should also know the position, because eventually this money is coming from the central government's tax kitty.
  - If the State Finance Commission is properly constituted on time and its recommendations are accepted by the state government, then automatically the Finance Commission at the centre knows what the framework of the grants to be given by it should be.
  - Till the point a recommendation is written and it is told how much money will be given, nothing moves — because it is the SFC that will decide the amount of money coming from the state finances to the local bodies.
- Analogy: think of the local body on one side; one side of the class is the Finance Commission and one side is a State Finance Commission — and that State Finance Commission is completely temporary, ad hoc and not functioning on time.

- The central Finance Commission depends on the behaviour of the states, which do not fulfil the recommendations; and the State Finance Commission has not been constituted in law — that is why these grants, even if approved, do not flow.
  - Another reason is the poor functioning of the ULBs, which are incapable of getting the performance grants because they are not fulfilling the conditions of the government.
  - When will the State Finance Commission function properly, or on time? If its recommendation is written and if the state is correct, then the central government will release the money.
- Analogy: it is like your mother and father — the father is giving money all the time, the mother is not responding, so the father is not waiting for the mother to take a step; in that father-mother arrangement the child (the local body) is having a revenue shortfall.
- In the states the outcome is the opposite of the centre's.
  - Their report is such that nobody reads it — in today's times even an AI tool would do a better augmentation exercise; the report becomes a vicious cycle.
  - State governments ask whether they are fools to follow it, and the report is put in cold storage; it is not even mentioned in Parliament.
  - That is totally unlike the budget this year, when it was clearly stated on the floor of the house that all the recommendations of the Finance Commission have been followed.
- Because of all these problems the mechanism of intergovernmental transfer coming from the states is completely distraught.
  - Some states have not even constituted the third or the fourth Finance Commission.
  - There is no money of one's own, so there is dependence on grants; the grants carry conditionalities; and the condition of the State Finance Commission is bad.
  - There are institutional concerns, structural concerns and functional concerns; all of these lead to the classic problem of not only functions and functionalities but also funds.

QUICK REVISION

- **IGT (intergovernmental transfers)** — union and state grants — create dependence, and **tied grants** reduce flexibility and autonomy.
- Finance Commission grants to local bodies rose from Rs. 87,000 crore (13th FC) to Rs. 2.87 lakh crore (14th), Rs. 4.36 lakh crore, and Rs. 7.1 lakh crore (2021-26); the tied amount involved is **Rs. 7.45 lakh crore**, with 50% of the basic grant tied to solid waste and water management.
- Grants are performance-based, so there was a shortfall — about Rs. 3.3 lakh crore reached the local bodies in 2021-26, and only **63% of recommended grants** were released to ULBs in the 15th FC period.
- SFC problems: **delay** (CAG 2024: only 10 of 18 states set up an SFC every five years; average lag **412 days**), **resource constraints** (limited infrastructure, office space, poor data), **reports not placed before the House**, and **non-compliance** by states.
- The 16th FC recommended a **permanent office** for itself; SFCs get no office, staff, material or records even though they are technical bodies — the FC at the centre has top economists like

Arvind Panagariya, Vijay Kelkar and C. Rangarajan.

- Local bodies draw money from both the state and union budgets, under the SFC and the FC respectively — the constitutional anchor for the FC is **Article 280**.
- Devolution of funds is a five-yearly chain: unless the SFC reports on time and its recommendations are accepted, the central grants too get delayed and the local body suffers a revenue shortfall.

7.10 Other Concerns Limiting the Functionality of RLBs and ULBs

Apart from the above traditional issues, the following concerns have limited the **functionality** of the RLBs and the ULBs. These problems are self-created: everything that was wanted has been given, and now it is the task of the local bodies to qualify — the ball is in their court.

- First, the **meetings are non-timely**.
  - Specifically in municipalities, their councils are not held throughout the year.
- The Speaker of the Lok Sabha, **Mr. Om Birla**, recently pointed out that sometimes only a budget meeting takes place, and that too is adjourned within 30 minutes; this was reported in a Hindi article last year.
- Do not think the budget of a municipal corporation is small — the MCD's budget, the **BMC (Brihan Mumbai Municipal Corporation)**, Noida's, and Bangalore's corporation (whose 'BB' name could not be recalled) handle budgets of thousands of crores.
  - In big cities the budget may run into thousands of crores — cited as Rs. 30,000–40,000 crore [as stated in lecture].
  - Yet half an hour and a Rs. 1,000 crore account is passed with no basis at all — so there is no deliberation at all.

CRITICAL POINT

Only a budget meeting, adjourned within 30 minutes.

- By contrast, the Union Budget approved this year — about **Rs. 53 lakh crore** (stated as 53 or 58) — goes through a proper procedure: part 1 of the budget, then discussion, then adjournment, then a month of examination by the DRSCs, then re-meeting after the recess is over, then discussion, then the demands for grants are voted in 7–8 days, and then it is passed.
- The state budget might not be that great compared with a union budget and will not have that fanfare, but at least the entire state budget will not be passed in 30 minutes.
- In the local bodies nothing of the kind is happening, and the amount is too big — it is antithetical; local self-government institutions cannot be deepened in this manner, and the allocation of funds suffers.

- Second, there are **weak financial practices**.
  - Local bodies suffer from **poor bookkeeping**.
  - There are **delayed audits**.
  - There is **weak disclosure**.

  - And there is **low quality financial data**.
- A software created by the **Ministry of Panchayati Raj**, called **Samarth**, is basically a portal, meant so that decentralised planning becomes a reality.
  - But because of the poor working of these panchayats, this too ends up getting into the dustbin.
  - So at their end the local bodies are completely incapable, as compared with the problem of the F-cube (funds, functions and functionalities) that they have historically raised.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Exam framing.

- How then can one question the fact that the F-cube has not been given? The problem is in functionality — this is the kind of question UPSC asks.

QUICK REVISION

- Apart from the traditional issues, the functionality of RLBs and ULBs is limited by their own internal practices.
- **Meetings are non-timely** — in municipalities the councils are not held throughout the year; the Speaker of the Lok Sabha, **Mr. Om Birla**, noted that sometimes only a budget meeting takes place, adjourned within 30 minutes.
- The Union Budget (about Rs. 53 lakh crore) follows the full procedure — discussion, DRSC examination, recess, voting of demands for grants in 7–8 days — while big city corporations pass Rs. 1,000 crore accounts in half an hour.
- **Weak financial practices**: poor bookkeeping, delayed audits, weak disclosure and low quality financial data.
- The **Samarth** portal of the Ministry of Panchayati Raj, meant to make decentralised planning a reality, ends up in the dustbin because of poor functioning.
- So the F-cube cannot be blamed alone — the problem is also in the functionality of the local bodies themselves.

7.11 PRI-Specific Concerns

7.11.1 Gram Sabha: Size and Timeliness

- The size of the gram sabha in some states is more than **25,000**.
  - With 25,000 people, how can people talk to each other and deliberate?
  - What then do we do with the constitutional principles, and what do we do with the gram sabha meeting?
- Second, the meetings are non-timely: in the villages a gram sabha meets once a year, or once or twice, or not at all.
  - So the principle of decentralisation and of participatory governance remains only for the answer — on paper.

7.11.2 Meetings Held in Secrecy

- Even when a meeting is held, it is often held in **secrecy**.
  - If a forest development plan has to be approved, or if a road being constructed in the village requires the permission of the Gram Sabha, then instead of notifying the meeting for the Gram Sabha, the notifier notifies only those members of the Gram Sabha with whom he has good camaraderie.
  - So on paper the meeting was held, on paper the Gram Sabha approved the project, on paper the principles of decentralisation were fully upheld — the best example of participatory governance, but on paper.
  - For the most important body, which is the Gram Sabha, great importance has been given.

7.11.3 Societal Constraints

- There is **less participation of women**, because of societal, patriarchal and socio-cultural restrictions.
  - The mothers and grandmothers of the villages do not participate at the same frequency as the male relatives.
  - Even when they attend, they cannot speak their mind.
- There is **domination of local elites**.
  - Whoever has bigger numbers has bigger weight in that gram sabha meeting; the caste that dominates politically continues to dominate the seat.
  - The third tier has been added, but there is very little scope for the voice of the weaker sections to be heard, because they are not given a chance to speak.
  - So the penetration of democratic values is on paper: on the ground the meetings, the decisions and the allocation of money — which mohalla will get what — are ruled by the dominant caste of that area.
- **Pati panchayat** or **sarpanch-pati**: women are proxy leaders and the decision-making is taken by the males.
  - This happens on reserved seats — it may happen on every reserved seat.
  - **NOTA** is also high on reserved seats, because the upper castes want to express that these candidates are not good for leadership; this was said in the context of the assemblies, but it can happen here too.

7.11.4 Digital Constraints

- There is a **digital divide**: the panchayats lack digital literacy.
  - How will they upload? The gram panchayat cannot even touch the development plan or the government portal.
  - There is also a problem of **digital connectivity**.
- There is limited electricity supply.
  - Very few people in the class would be coming from villages which have a 24-hour supply of electricity.
  - If there is no electricity, there is no computer; and with no computer there is no internet.

  - So automatically the functioning of the local body as an agency and institution of governance gets affected.

7.11.5 Declining Importance of the PRIs

- There is **declining importance** of the PRIs because of increasing urbanisation.
  - And there is the **merger of rural local bodies in the peri-urban areas with the ULBs**.
- Examples: Noida and Jewar; the areas towards Jaipur along the major highways from Delhi; any city that is expanding, for example Gurugram.
  - The nearby districts and tehsils — the first villages — are made a part of an urban area as the area expands, and they are given an urban municipal committee.
  - People resent this.

COMPARISON

When a village is merged with a ULB: benefit and cost.

- There is benefit: there would be better provision of services in the urban area — the municipal corporation provides waste collection, street lighting and maintenance of roads.
- There is cost: at the same point they will also charge for the provision of those services, which is not the case in a village.
- There is benefit: the land value will increase stupendously.
- There is cost: the higher cost of living, and at least something has to be paid to a municipal committee.
- Net effect: the overall importance of the PRIs is reducing as compared with the ULBs.

QUICK REVISION

- In some states the gram sabha's size exceeds **25,000**, which makes deliberation impossible; gram sabhas meet once, twice or not at all in a year.
- Meetings that do happen are held in **secrecy**, with only friendly members notified — participation exists on paper only.
- Societal constraints: **less participation of women**, **domination of local elites**, and **pati panchayat/sarpanch-pati**, where women are proxy leaders and males decide; **NOTA** is high on reserved seats.
- Digital constraints: the digital divide, limited digital literacy, poor connectivity and limited electricity mean the local body cannot even upload its development plan.
- Increasing urbanisation and the **merger of peri-urban villages with ULBs** reduce the importance of the PRIs, generating both benefits (better services, higher land value) and costs (charges, higher cost of living).

7.12 Urban-Specific Challenges of ULBs

Finally, and concludingly, it is important to note that unlike the RLBs, the ULBs have been susceptible to challenges such as the following.

1. **Extreme climate events.**
2. **Spatial inequality.**
3. **Informalisation of livelihoods** — this is the biggest example.
4. **Increase in gig work** or platform work.
5. **Urban mobility and housing crisis.**
6. **Environmental degradation** — last and very important.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **Why these are primarily urban challenges.**
>
> - It becomes a challenge because **functionality is a challenge**: the local body does not know what a climate change event is, and it does not know what vulnerability is.
> - The framework of governance itself differs between the village and the urban area.

- **Spatial inequality**: the houses in the villages are historically caste-based segregated, and that reflection is not very strong there — it is an accepted norm in a village.
  - The same acceptance is not possible in urban governance in Delhi.
- The most important persons for any economy are not the upper castes but the people involved in cleaning the roads and the libraries, the cooks and those serving and providing basic services.
  - Their inequality, and its management, is a major concern with respect to the responsibilities of the municipal corporations, because the corporations are earning money in thousands of crores and they have to rehabilitate them.
- Illustration: **Arvind Kejriwal**, when he won the election the first time, had the support of the auto drivers, and the auto drivers spread his wave — but that might not be the case in a village.
  - The **CJP** protests happening in Delhi have a different strand when CJP enters a village: in Rajasthan they were bashed.
  - That is the framework of the difference of governance in villages and in the urban areas.
- **Informalisation of livelihoods**: the e-rickshaw has provided last-mile delivery but has also added to congestion, and every now and then a student is hurt because of an e-rickshaw.
  - How to manage this informal livelihood — should they be allowed, should they not be allowed, should they be given proper rights?
  - Street vendors have got statutory rights under the **Street Vendors Act, 2014 (or 2015)**.
- **Increase in gig work** or platform work — the delivery persons.
- **Urban mobility and housing crisis**.
- **Environmental degradation**, which is a part and parcel of any urban environment.
  - Whether it is waste dumping, or a sewage pipeline leak, or the excessive use of air conditioners, or an energy-intensive lifestyle — all of it is a concern that you see in an urban area.

QUICK REVISION

- Unlike RLBs, ULBs face six challenges: **extreme climate events, spatial inequality, informalisation of livelihoods, increase in gig work, urban mobility and housing crisis, and environmental degradation**.
- These bite because functionality itself is a challenge — the local body does not know what a climate change event or vulnerability is.
- **Spatial inequality** works differently in the city: caste-based segregation is an accepted norm in the village but cannot be accepted in urban governance like Delhi's.
- The people cleaning roads and libraries, the cooks and basic-service providers are the most important for the economy; managing their inequality is a core municipal responsibility, since corporations earn thousands of crores and must rehabilitate them.
- Informal livelihoods (e-rickshaws, street vendors with statutory rights under the **Street Vendors Act, 2014 or 2015**) raise the question of allowance, prohibition or rights; gig and platform work keep rising.
- Urban mobility and housing, and environmental degradation (waste dumping, sewage leaks, excessive air-conditioning, energy-intensive lifestyles), complete the list.

7.13 Way Forward

After the issues, the fourth part to write is the **way forward** — the suggestions and recommendations, taken in the same order in which the problems were taken: elections, functions, functionaries, funds, and the working of the local bodies.

7.13.1 For Elections

- First, states should enact an **anti-defection law** quickly.
- Second, **delimitation powers** should be allotted to the State Election Commission.
- Third, there should be **increased coordination between the SECs and the EC**.
- Fourth, there should be **independence of the SEC** — the Governor should appoint the SEC.
  - The Governor should appoint the State Election Commissioner not on the advice of the state council of ministers, but on the recommendations of a **collegium**.
  - The collegium should consist of: (1) the **Chief Minister**; (2) the **Leader of the Opposition**; (3) the **Speaker of the Legislative Assembly**.
  - Context: till 2023 the Chief Election Commissioner and the Election Commissioners were appointed by the President, and without any collegium; in 2023 the law was enacted. That same thing should be the case for the State Election Commission or Commissioner.

7.13.2 For Functions

- There should be a **separate list of local subjects**.
- There should be an **amendment to the 12th Schedule**, with the addition of the following functions:
  - **School Education**

  - **Public Health**
  - **Traffic Management**
  - **Urban Environment Management**
  - **Urban Management and Heritage**
- Traffic management is the test case for this addition.
  - In Delhi, who does traffic management? The Delhi Police, which is under the Home Ministry; in your state, traffic management is done by the state government.
  - So we are saying that traffic policing can be done by the Municipal Corporation, while regular policing stays with the state government — traffic policing should go to the local body.

7.13.3 For Functionaries

- **Proper training** of the local body staff.
- A **separate cadre of panchayat officials**.

7.13.4 For Funds

- **SFCs should be appointed**, with a prescription of qualifications, under a law.
  - The State Finance Commission is mentioned in the Constitution, but who can become a member of the State Finance Commission?
  - The nitty-gritties of the working of the SFC — will they get infrastructure? — all those details must be given in a law.
  - Precedents: the Finance Commission is a constitutional body, yet a Finance Commission Act has been enacted; the CAG is a constitutional body, yet a CAG Act (of 1948 or 1951) adds further details to the office.
  - Every state should enact such an act; since the working of the SFCs is uniformly bad, it should be brought under one common scheme.
- The SFCs should evolve **objective and transparent norms** for the devolution and distribution of funds.
  - The norms should be **linked to backwardness**.
- **Municipal corporations should issue municipal bonds** — a municipal bond is an innovative mechanism for the funding of local body projects.
  - As per **SEBI**, since 2017 only **17 municipal bonds** have been issued, raising an amount of **Rs. 2,800 crore**.
- For **property tax**, the **RBI** has recommended **GIS mapping**.
  - There should also be a **digital payment system**, so that people will not pay the money to the officers — all UPI digital payment systems.
  - There should also be **dynamic valuation** and **better monitoring**.
- **Non-tax revenues should be enhanced** — for example, fee collection for waste management and parking charges; basically, user charges should be levied.

7.13.5 For the Working of Local Bodies

- For the **Gram Sabha**, the states should ensure that the gram sabha is of **appropriate size**.
- For a **large gram panchayat**, the states should constitute **ward sabha**, which shall perform such functions as the state government shall **entrust** to them — entrust means to give.
  - Where 30,000 people are on the gram sabha, the gram sabha itself cannot be made smaller; on delimitation, create 3, 4 or 5 ward sabhas of 5,000 each, and let them meet at a higher frequency as compared with the gram sabha.
  - If 30,000 people meet once in a year, that is okay, because the actual work is being performed by a smaller body, which is called the ward sabha.
- For the **municipal corporations** (very important): they should incorporate provisions like **zero hour**, **question hour**, and **extensive discussion on the budget**.
  - The meetings should be held **throughout the day**, with detailed deliberations and with the plans — the Lok Sabha meets from 10 a.m. to 5–6 p.m.
- There should be **adoption of PPPs** in: (1) renewable energy; (2) urban transport; (3) waste management.
- There should be **adoption of the latest technologies** — GIS, satellite-based mapping, drones and AI — for better service delivery.

QUICK REVISION

- Elections: enact an **anti-defection law**, allot delimitation powers to the **SEC**, increase coordination between the **SECs and the EC**, and ensure **independence of the SEC** through a collegium of the Chief Minister, the Leader of the Opposition and the Speaker of the Legislative Assembly.
- Functions: a **separate list of local subjects** and an amendment of the **12th Schedule** to add school education, public health, traffic management, urban environment management, and urban management and heritage.
- Functionaries: **proper training** of local body staff and a **separate cadre of panchayat officials**.
- Funds: appoint **SFCs** with qualifications prescribed under a law, evolve objective and transparent norms linked to backwardness, issue **municipal bonds** (SEBI: 17 bonds, Rs. 2,800 crore since 2017), use **GIS, digital payments and dynamic valuation** for property tax, and enhance non-tax revenues such as waste-management fees and parking charges.
- Working of local bodies: ensure an **appropriate-sized gram sabha** and constitute **ward sabha** for large panchayats; introduce **zero hour, question hour and budget discussions** with all-day meetings in corporations.
- Other suggestions: **adoption of PPPs** in renewable energy, urban transport and waste management, and **adoption of the latest technologies** — GIS, satellite-based mapping, drones and AI — for better service delivery.

CHAPTER 8

GS Paper 2 Current Affairs: Local Self-Government and Malnutrition

8.1 Exam Trends and PYQ Insights

The session opened with an analysis of the kinds of questions the recent papers carried, and of how the topics discussed in class were asked in them.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Questions analysed from the recent papers.

- A question on the **Belt and Road Initiative (BRI)** and the strategic implications it holds for India came in General Studies Paper 2 (referred to as the twentieth question); **BRI** is a very common topic that every individual knows about.
- The implications of BRI were discussed under several IR topics — India–Bangladesh, India–Sri Lanka, India–Maldives and the rise of China — and the recent elections in Bangladesh are a significant concern.
- In the past **one and a half years, great powers have entered the South Asian subcontinent**.
- The **importance of education** was asked as a straight question this time, although it had earlier been described as the most abstract topic.
- A question held that **rights-based welfare cannot be fulfilled with the idea of non-integrated governance and the increasing role of the private sector**; the discussion on health fitted that question fully.
- **Malnutrition** is not a straight topic of the poverty-and-hunger discussion, yet **three questions have come from this topic in the past 12–13 years**.

QUICK REVISION

- GS Paper 2 carried a question on **BRI and its strategic implications for India**.
- BRI implications were covered through the IR topics of India–Bangladesh, India–Sri Lanka, India–Maldives and the rise of China, plus the Bangladesh elections.
- **Great powers have entered the South Asian subcontinent** in the past one and a half years.
- The **importance of education** was a straight question; a question also linked rights-based welfare with non-integrated governance and the private sector.
- **Malnutrition has produced three questions in 12–13 years** and is not a straight topic of the poverty-and-hunger discussion.

8.2 Local Self-Government: Funds, Functions, Functionaries and Functionality

- The **basic aspects of local self-government** — the **73rd and 74th Amendments** and the exact changes they introduced — are part and parcel of the prelims examination.
  - Prelims questions on local self-government come around **two themes**.
  - Theme 1 is the classic problem of **funds, functions and functionaries** and theme 2 is the question of **functionality**.

8.2.1 *The Classic Problem: Funds, Functions and Functionaries*

- For the past **30 years** the same set of problems has continued, and they can now be substantiated with facts.
  - **Property tax is not utilised** and in villages there is a **lack of will to demonstrate the need to raise taxes**.
- There is **improper devolution** of powers to the third tier.
- **Elections are not organised on time**; even when they are held on time, the **first sitting of the municipal council** can come after a year.
  - Example: **MCD**.
- **State governments are not politically willing** to devolve power to the third tier.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Hourglass syndrome (drawn as a diagram).**
>
> - The diagram shows the **hourglass syndrome**: the **73rd and 74th Amendments** have made the powers of the State look narrower in its own perception — both vis-à-vis the Centre and vis-à-vis the third tier.
> - This is the reason the State resists parting with power, and it is the same perception that later explains the States' discomfort with centrally sponsored schemes.

8.2.2 *Questioning Functionality: Is the Third Tier Performing?*

- After 30 years the functionality of the third tier was itself questioned: **Gram Sabha meetings are not held**.
- **Cultural practices** in the northern and southern parts of the country still prevent women from participating in the **Gram Sabha** process.
- **Proper capacity building and proper training are not undertaken** for the staff of the third tier.
- A **separate cadre of panchayat officials** is wanted at the third tier.
- **Climate change-related disasters** have added a new challenge at the third tier.
  - The best example is what happened in **Nepal two-three days back**.
  - This new challenge is **more important for urban bodies** than for villages.

8.2.3 Way Forward

- **More and more powers must be devolved to the third tier**, as is done in the West.
  - The way forward for local self-government was completed; the next thing to write down is the **steps taken by the Government of India**.

QUICK REVISION

- Two themes of prelims questions on local self-government: **funds, functions, functionaries** and **functionality**.
- Thirty-year problems: **property tax not utilised**, no will to raise taxes, improper devolution, delayed elections, municipal council's first sitting after a year (**MCD**), unwilling States.
- **Hourglass syndrome** — the State feels narrower both against the Centre and against the third tier.
- Functionality failures: **Gram Sabha meetings not held**, cultural practices blocking women's participation, no training/capacity building, no separate cadre of panchayat officials.
- New challenge: **climate change-related disasters**, the example being **Nepal**; such challenges matter more to urban bodies.
- Way forward: **devolve more powers to the third tier**, as in the West.

8.3 Steps Taken by the Government of India to Strengthen Local Self-Government

The steps taken by the Government of India are very important, because many of them will be asked in the prelims next year. The framing line for the answer is: though **local self-government is an entry in the State List**, the **Ministry of Panchayati Raj has initiated several steps for the promotion of local self-government in India**. Three-four questions come on schemes every year, and the schemes of the major social sectors — health, education, malnutrition and skill development — are covered by the **Economic Survey**, so three-four points on each of them work in the prelims as well.

8.3.1 Constitutional and Legal Steps

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Constitutional and legal steps.

- **Constitutional steps**: constitutional status was given to **RLBs (rural local bodies)** and **ULBs (urban local bodies)** by the **73rd and 74th Constitutional Amendment Acts**, which provided a **framework**.
- It is a framework because the amendments contain only the basic details; the **State legislatures must enact a law** and ensure that the aspects of the 73rd and 74th Amendments are fulfilled.
- The **framework** contains the **State Election Commission**, the **State Finance Commission**, the **District Planning Committee (DPC)** and **regular elections**.

> - **Reservation is the most important element** of the framework.
> - **Legal steps**: **PESA** was enacted, extending **Panchayati Raj institutions to the Scheduled Areas**, that is the **Fifth Schedule** areas.

- **Write down everything and keep scribbling** — a large number of questions come out of exactly this material.
  - The **globalization** question of the recent paper was a straight question, and the structure drawn for it listed the impacts to be studied under **social, economic, political and environmental** heads, while the paper asked for the **cultural** impact.
- The globalization structure kept an **individual** head as well: if the impact on the individual is asked, those heads come into play.
  - Impacts on the **elderly** and on **children** were discussed, along with how India is spreading its impact in the world.
- In a way, the **impact of globalization and the impact of urbanization are the same**, so studying one serves for the other.
  - The question on the **role of caste in urban areas** and the impact of globalization on caste are 100% the same question: caste **assimilates** and there is **homogeneity**, and at the same time **caste-based groups form for assertion**, because globalization makes everything equal, so some people reassert their identities to appear different and heterogeneous.
- Prepare the **difference between the Fifth Schedule and the Sixth Schedule** — the toughest prelims questions come from them.
- A question on **asymmetric federalism** was asked this time; its examples are **Article 371** and the **erstwhile Article 370**.
  - Asymmetric federalism is not part of the current-affairs topics dealt with; the examples are taught in detail in General Studies Paper 2.
- **Ladakh** wanted the status of the **Sixth Schedule**, and a simple question was asked about the **benefits of coming under the Sixth Schedule**.
  - If all the provisions of the Sixth Schedule are remembered, that itself completes the answer to Ladakh's demand.
- The **Gorkha movement** has again come into the news after **2017–18** [as stated in lecture].

8.3.2 *The Central Government's Role in Creating the Third Tier*

- Even if it is the third tier, it was **given existence by the Central Government**, so the role of the **Narasimha Rao Government cannot be taken away**.
- It was actually started by **Rajiv Gandhi**, but that amendment could not see the light of day.
- It became a reality in **1993** under the **P. V. Narasimha Rao Government**; then in **1996** the Government again took that step [as stated in lecture].

8.3.3 *Fiscal Devolution and the Finance Commission*

- Recommendations of the **Finance Commission under Article 280 are non-binding**, but the Central Government has agreed to the recommendations — that is why a big **fiscal devolution**

is being carried out.

- Panchayati Raj institutions do raise their own revenues — **OSR, Own Source Revenue** — and the keyword to show the examiner is that this is **just about 1% of total revenue**.
  - The third tier is therefore almost completely dependent on the Centre and the States.

DATA & FACTS

Finance Commission grants as recalled in the lecture.

- About **Rs. 89,000 crore** at an earlier stage; about **Rs. 2.87 lakh crore** for the **14th Finance Commission**; about **Rs. 4 lakh crore** for the **15th Finance Commission**; about **Rs. 7.91 lakh crore** for the **16th Finance Commission**.
- These figures were to be checked before being written down.

- Over the years the grants given from the **13th to the 16th Finance Commission have increased by a great number**; because of that increase the Central Government is agreeing to those demands.
- A **graph** was drawn for this and it has to be used at different places in the answer.
  - Only roughly that much of the figures is remembered in the exam.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

How the recent papers were set.

- **Paper 2 was comparatively easy this time** — much easier than last year; **Paper 1** was also comparatively easier; **Paper 3 was one notch tougher**.
- The **10-markers were comparatively easier**, but about **5–10% of Paper 3's 15-markers were upping the game** — they asked **Article 370 and Article 35A**, and those questions cannot be predicted or covered.
- Two or three such unpredictable questions will come **every year**; a discussion on the **J&K Reorganization Act** will be taken up.
- **Border area development** is a straight write-up of about **1.5–2 pages** and is covered along with **border management** (hearts and minds).

8.3.4 *Rashtriya Gram Swaraj Abhiyan: Capacity Building*

- **RGSA — Rashtriya Gram Swaraj Abhiyan — is the main centrally sponsored scheme to strengthen PRIs.**
  - The actual launch year is **2022 or 2023** (2020 or 2021 may have been said in the civil services class).
  - Even the **basic facts** of a scheme should be noted, because revision then becomes very easy and this knowledge helps a lot.
- This scheme was asked in the prelims and is also given in the **Economic Survey**.
  - The Survey carried only **two lines**; reading the Survey alone cannot get you through the paper.
- For the civil services mains only the **keywords** are needed; here the focus is **capacity building**.
- The scheme targets the **lack of functionaries and the lack of proper training of functionaries**

— the staff is ill prepared, which automatically affects **functionality**.

- It **trains elected representatives** and **functionaries**, trains them in **computerization**, and organises **exposure visits**.
- It assists in the preparation of the **Gram Panchayat Development Plan (GPDP)** — the most technical area, in which the most assistance is needed.
  - Capacity building thus takes place within **Gram Swaraj Abhiyan**; training modules help in the preparation of the **Gram Sabha** or the **Gram Panchayat Development Plan**.
- **Template for the mains**: if an issue is asked, write the remembered step **in brackets** next to the issue — for example, MoPR has launched **Rashtriya Gram Swaraj Abhiyan** to address the problem of capacity building or poor capabilities of the staff.

8.3.5 *Leadership and Management Programmes, and Women in PRIs*

- **Leadership and management programmes** have been started with the help of **IITs** and **IIMs**.
- **IRMA** — given in the lecture as the **Indian Rural Management Institute** — is in **Anand, Gujarat**, and was described as the only institute in the country for **rural management**.
  - In Anand there is also a **cooperative university named after Tribhuvan Das Patel**, a prominent Congress leader [as stated in lecture].
  - This material is part of **development processes and development models**, one of the syllabi in General Studies Paper 2.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Prelims-to-mains linkage.

- Environment questions in current affairs or in Paper 3 are often questions **already taken up at the prelims stage**; last year a **climate change** question was asked, this time nothing was asked from it.
- A table had been drawn mapping older initiatives with **NDC 2.0** and **Mission LiFE**, showing which missions are part of NDC 2.0 [as stated in lecture].
- **Solid waste management** was asked in Paper 3 this year; it was taught at the prelims stage, when new solid waste management rules **reclassified waste from 5 types to 3** (if recalled correctly).
- The structure of **municipal solid waste management** is simple: **source-related problems** → **transportation-related problems** → **processing-related problems** → **downstream pollution** (four boxes).
- Last year a question was asked on the **direct use of carbon — Direct Air Capture**; **Iceland built the first direct air capture plant in 2024**; it was discussed for the prelims and came in the **2025 mains**.
- **Ethanol** (its role, whether it is good or bad) and **isobutanol** were taken at the prelims stage; no question came on the **Shanti Act** or on **nuclear energy** [as stated in lecture].
- Therefore what is read for the prelims can come **straight as a question in the mains**.

- The **representation of women in PRIs is 46%**, and the role of women here is very important.
- **Sashakt Panchayat Netri Abhiyan** was written down for women's leadership in panchayats

[as stated in lecture].

- This material fitted the **Paper 2 question on reservation** for women, where women are **neither a class nor a minority**.
  - That answer starts with the **73rd and 74th Amendments** and the **recent Constitutional Amendment passed about three years back** [as stated in lecture].

8.3.6 A Separate Ministry, and Urban Governance

- The Central Government has constituted a **separate ministry** even though local self-government is an entry in the State List.
  - The **Ministry of Panchayati Raj** was formed in **2004**, in the decade of the 2000s (to be checked with facts).
- There is **nothing called a Ministry of Urban Local Bodies**.
  - Municipal governance is encouraged inside the **main schemes of the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs**, which have layers for improving municipal governance.
- Ownership in a city is spread across many agencies, so a separate ministry brings no advantage.
  - Example: **DDA** land (its **chairman is the Lieutenant Governor**, its **vice-chairman is about the 35th–36th post in seniority**), land owned by the **Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs**, many joint ventures and **special purpose vehicles** such as the **Delhi Metro's agreement with the MCD**, and the DDA's agreement with the Central Government for redevelopment of the city.
- The **Smart Cities project has now ended** — it was started in **2015** and was not extended, so it will be wound up.
  - About **99.99% of the money** has already been spent by the Government of India.
- **AMRUT 2.0** is now the **main scheme for urban governance**.
  - **AMRUT = Atal Mission for Rejuvenation and Urban Transformation.**
  - Any urban problem is covered under its head: decline of wetlands, poor transportation, poor solid waste management (asked in Paper 3 this year), improper water distribution, and even the need for **parking spaces and green spaces** in urban areas.

> **GOVERNMENT & POLICY**
>
> **AMRUT 2.0 strengthens ULBs through.**
>
> - **Water supply** and **sewerage**.
> - **Septage management.**
> - **GIS planning.**
> - **User charges.**
> - **Non-revenue water reduction** — water supplied free: units are consumed but not a single penny is paid as the water bill.
> - **Municipal finance reforms** — an additional and very important point.

- Under AMRUT, **credit rating was undertaken in almost 468 cities**, which enabled the raising of monies through **municipal bonds** — the most important instrument.

  - Credit rating tells an investor which municipal corporation has strong credentials, so it helps generate **own source revenue** instead of depending on the Centre and the States.
- **MCD property tax reforms**: there is a big chunk of land in Delhi which can be taxed, but there are concerns of **disputes** and a **lack of GIS**.
- **Unauthorised extra floors** are a big loss for the municipal corporation: a permit is taken for **three floors** and the building is extended to **five or six**.
  - The misuse is more at the smaller scale, though the corporation also catches the big fish.
- **Drones** today cost about **Rs. 10,000–Rs. 20,000** and are used for mapping.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Simple governance issues: the waterlogging case.**
>
> - Drones plus rainfall data — how much it rained in the last 10 years and when waterlogging occurred — would automatically show where **two or three pumps** must be installed.
> - The **NDMC chairman apologised**, saying the mistake was that **two water pumps were installed instead of four**.
> - The waterlogging around **Connaught Place** was blamed on **Panchkuian Road**; the water came from the **Pusa Road–Karol Bagh** side [as stated in lecture].
> - It was a **planning failure**, and simple drone monitoring would have solved it easily.
> - All of these are **very simple governance issues**.

8.3.7 *Development of Indexes*

- UPSC has started asking questions on **indexes**.
- The **RBI's Financial Inclusion Index** was asked this time; it is given in the **Economic Survey** and was discussed twice.
- The **digital rupee** was the **first question in Paper 3**.
  - It came from the controversy over **stable coins**: the Finance Minister, **Nirmala Sitharaman**, went to the **Cato Institute** in September–October and said the time had come to promote stable coins [as stated in lecture]; in rebuttal the RBI Governor, **Sanjay Malhotra**, said stable coins should not be promoted and the **digital rupee** should be promoted instead.
- The index points are **straight from PIB**.

Devolution Index	Ranks States on the devolution of powers to the third tier	**F-cube** — Funds, Functions and Functionaries — **plus a Framework** dimension; the parameters include reservation, Gram Sabha meetings, capacity building and training, and, most importantly, **accountability** (is it responsible, is it accountable, is there a social audit, are Gram Sabha meetings held)	**Karnataka ranked first**; Karnataka, Kerala, Maharashtra and Tamil Nadu are the leading States — the southern States are clearly better than the northern States
Panchayat Advancement Index (PAI)	A **multi-dimensional index** assessing the implementation of **localization of the SDGs**, which cannot be achieved in a top-down manner and must be seen from the bottom up	Localization of SDGs across **9 themes**, with **144 targets** under them	No ranking for this index was given in the lecture

- The **Devolution Index ranking is a 100%, hyper-important question** for the prelims, where the State ranked first has to be known.
- The **Panchayat Advancement Index assesses localization of the SDGs across 9 themes**, and the themes are:

1. **Poverty-free and enhanced livelihoods.**
2. **Healthy panchayat.**
3. **Child-friendly panchayat.**
4. **Water-sufficient panchayat.**
5. **Clean and green panchayat.**
6. **Panchayat with self-sufficient infrastructure.**
7. **Socially just and socially secure panchayat.**
8. **Panchayat with good governance.**

9. **Women-friendly panchayat.**

8.3.8 Youth Unemployment, NEET and the Human Capital Chain

- **Youth unemployment is the biggest theme in unemployment at present**, and it is connected with the next topic — the **demographic dividend** — which will be taken at the end.
- A **NITI Aayog report** says youth unemployment is a major thing and that **BA and BSc degrees should be stopped**; there is no role for educational qualifications without **skilling**.
  - Unless the degree involves serious research, interdisciplinary work, liberal arts or something genuinely phenomenal, there is no use in it.
- **NEET means not in education, employment or training** — neither studying, nor in training, nor holding a job, just sitting and observing.
  - About **8 crore youth in India are NEET** (the number was given as 8–9 crore) [as stated in lecture].
- **All articles on this issue must be followed** — reading the newspaper and the notes made from it is very important.
- **Unemployment rate** = number of unemployed divided by the total of the number of unemployed and the number of employed.
  - If 5 are unemployed and 95 are employed, the unemployment rate is **5%**.
- **Thought exercise**: if the unemployment rate falls from 5% to 4%, is it a matter of happiness or of sadness? Every happiness hides some sorrow — think about what the sorrow is; this will be discussed with the topic of unemployment.
- **Diagram (to be drawn)**: **poverty** is connected with **hunger**; **malnutrition**; **health**; **education**; and **skill development (kaushal vikas)** — five separate topics.
  - All of them acting in unison produce **human capital**; well utilised it becomes a **demographic dividend**, and poorly utilised a **demographic disaster**.
- Any question on the **demographic dividend** has to focus on addressing poverty, malnutrition, health, education and skill development.
- **Human resource management** is a different and broader concept in management.
- **Current debates have to get reflected in the answer**; the diagram shows the examiner's strong pattern of **interlinkage**.

8.3.9 Own Source Revenue Push and the Samarth App

- **OSR push means Own Source Revenue push** — a major step of the **Ministry of Panchayati Raj**.
- The Ministry has **training modules**: panchayat members and female elected functionaries are called to **Delhi** and trained and addressed by the **Ministry of Women and Child Development** and the **Ministry of Panchayati Raj**.
  - The Centre is promoting this even though local self-government is an entry in the **State List**.

CRITICAL POINT

The States' objection to this central push.

- This is seen as an intrusion — the sarpanch who won on my ticket, in my own department, is being called to Delhi — and it is viewed as a **constitutional violation**.
- This is a major concern with respect to **Centre–State relations**: centrally sponsored schemes acting as a major hindrance to **cooperative federalism** between the Centre and the States.

- The training module is with **IIM Ahmedabad**.
- **Samarth** is a **digital application for tax demand, collection and generation**, for helping panchayats collect taxes and generate the maximum own source revenue.
  - It is **predictive software**: it shows that if a certain tax is levied, a certain revenue can accrue to the panchayat; it was developed to ensure that panchayats are **self-dependent**.

8.3.10 SVAMITVA: Property Records and Local Revenue

- The **SVAMITVA scheme provides property records in rural inhabited areas**.
- Its effects: **land disputes will come down** → with fewer land disputes there is **credit access** → and **property-based local revenue is strengthened**.
- **Mechanism**: **property tax can be levied only when the property papers are clear** — that is why the scheme matters for panchayat revenue.
- **Ownership records are common in cities but not in villages**; the farther you go from the city towards a village, the higher the possibility of a dispute, because there are no papers: whoever gets a place in that habitation builds a house, then the children expand it, and then the neighbour fights.
  - **Drones** are used in the SVAMITVA scheme to generate these records.
- **Swami means owner**: if there is no ownership record there is no owner, and therefore no owner-tax.

EXAMPLE

Wealth locked up by a property dispute.

- A building worth about **Rs. 100–110 crore** caught up in a property dispute locks up enormous wealth, and the municipal corporation cannot collect property tax on it until the papers are clear.

8.3.11 Digital Panchayats: e-Gram Swaraj and PFMS

- **Digital panchayats** — the concept, meant for **transparency and fund flow**.
- **e-Gram Swaraj** is the **main digital platform**, for transparency and fund flow, and it has been **integrated with PFMS**.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Paper 2 question: digital governance and social empowerment.

- The question asked was that **digital governance leads to social empowerment**; it was a

> **10-marker, with both sides expected**.
>
> - The material for the positive side: the many schemes and platforms for **women, the disabled, rural people, divyang jan, senior citizens, transgenders** and, obviously, the **backward classes** — a huge number of schemes of the Government of India are now digitised, such as the **Digital Agriculture Mission**.

- **The other side**: technology or digital governance does not always lead to empowerment; it also creates a **divide** between rural and urban areas, between poor and comparatively richer areas, between **PRIs and ULBs**, and between **tribals and deprived castes** (backward classes, scheduled castes) as compared to the **privileged**.
- These dimensions are discussed under **poverty, inequality and inclusive growth**; in the poverty alleviation programmes it was said that **excessive use of technology also disempowers**.
  - In the examination hall you have to recall **where each point came from** — poverty, inequality, hunger — and pick according to the need of the question.
- The **khichdi analogy**: the knowledge base is a melting pot in which the **vegetables are poverty**, a bit of **salt is inequality**, and **rice put in water is inclusive growth**; from that melting pot the ingredients have to be taken out again as per the need of the question, and for that the **structure must be strong**.
  - The content of **Paper 2 can be used in Paper 3 and vice versa**, but with the **specific keywords of that subject** — for example, while discussing urbanization in Paper 1, stress **urbanism** rather than urbanization.
- **PFMS — Public Fund Management System** (as stated in the lecture) — is the system through which the Central Government transfers money to the States or to the third tier for the implementation of a **centrally sponsored scheme**.
  - It allows **real-time payments** to **vendors and service providers**.
- **Till March 2026, 96% of the Gram Panchayats had uploaded their Gram Panchayat Development Plan.**

8.3.12 *Other Recent Steps: Bhashini and Sabha Saar*

- **Bhashini** is a **translation platform** — an enabling platform behind the language interface in AI apps, like the Government of India translating your notes; the ministry's trainers will improve it further.
- **Sabha Saar** was launched on **14 August 2025** — Pakistan's Independence Day — the date being first said as 27 August and then corrected.
  - It is **voice-to-text with meeting summarization** of **Gram Sabha minutes**: whatever is discussed in a Gram Sabha meeting is summarised and the points enter the records.
- The **infrastructural support and the data generated are maintained by the India-AI Mission** under the **Ministry of Electronics and IT**.
- PIB says **Sabha Saar has not been adopted in Delhi and Chandigarh**, because both are **Union Territories and 100% urban areas**.
  - **Gram Sabha is prevalent only in rural local bodies**; urban areas have a **municipal**

corporation.

- **Sabha Saar was important for this year's prelims**; four-five schemes had come — **Yuva, SOR** and others — discussed under skill development [as stated in lecture].

DATA & FACTS

Adoption of Sabha Saar.

- Out of **2.65 lakh Gram Panchayats**, about **1.11 lakh have adopted Sabha Saar**.

8.3.13 *Accountability Tools and the Overall Picture*

- For **performance, competition and accountability**, first **indexes are developed** and then **awards are given**.
- **National Panchayat Awards** — for rural areas.
  - **Swachh Survekshan (Swachhata Sarvekshan)** is the famous award and survey for **urban areas**.
- Such surveys are **accountability tools** that ensure increased **transparency and accountability** and **citizen feedback**; it is very important to know the response of citizens.
- All in all, the broad steps taken by the Government of India follow the lines of the problems: a **separate ministry**, **constitutional changes**, **legal changes**, several **indexes** and **training modules**.
- **Rashtriya Gram Swaraj Abhiyan is the most important scheme** launched by the Ministry of Panchayati Raj; it develops the **capacity of the PRIs**.
- Then there is **urban governance** under different **centrally sponsored schemes** run by the **Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs**, and several **ranking mechanisms and indexes**.
- Together, these are the broad steps taken by the Government of India to promote **decentralization** or **capacity building of local self-government**.

QUICK REVISION

- Answer opens with: local self-government is a **State List** entry, yet the **Ministry of Panchayati Raj** has initiated several steps for its promotion.
- **Constitutional steps**: 73rd and 74th CAA gave constitutional status to RLBs and ULBs and provided a framework (SEC, SFC, DPC, regular elections, reservation).
- **Legal steps**: **PESA** extended PRIs to the **Scheduled (Fifth Schedule) Areas**; prepare Fifth vs Sixth Schedule; **asymmetric federalism** = Article 371 and erstwhile Article 370; **Ladakh's Sixth Schedule demand**; **Gorkha movement** after 2017–18.
- **Fiscal devolution**: Article 280 recommendations are non-binding but accepted; **OSR is about 1% of total revenue**; FC grants recall — Rs. 89,000 crore, Rs. 2.87 lakh crore, Rs. 4 lakh crore, Rs. 7.91 lakh crore.
- **RGSA** is the main centrally sponsored scheme for strengthening PRIs (capacity building, training of elected representatives and functionaries, computerization, exposure visits, GPDP assistance).

- **Indexes**: **Devolution Index** (F-cube + framework, accountability; **Karnataka first in 2024**) and **Panchayat Advancement Index** (localization of SDGs, **9 themes, 144 targets**).
- **Other steps**: OSR push with **Samarth** app and IIM Ahmedabad, **SVAMITVA**, **e-Gram Swaraj + PFMS**, **96% GPDP upload by March 2026**, **Bhashini**, **Sabha Saar** (14 August 2025; 1.11 lakh of 2.65 lakh GPs), **National Panchayat Awards** and **Swachh Survekshan**.

8.4 Answer-Writing Exercise: Role of Local Bodies and Merging RLBs with ULBs

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Question asked in General Studies Paper 2.

- **Analyze the role of local bodies in providing good governance at local level and bring out the pros and cons of merging RLBs with ULBs.**
- It looks like a 10-marker, but it has to be written as a **15-marker in 250 words**; ten minutes were given to write it.

- The **first step of answer writing** is to break the question into **keywords**.
- The question has to be **simplified, not complicated** — it has to be demystified (khangalna); the examiner is not to be examined.
- **15-marker framework**: introduction of **20–30 words**; body of about **200 words**; conclusion of **20–30 words**.
  - For this question the body splits into **100 words on the role in local governance** and **100 words on the pros and cons**.
- A **diagram is a must** — make it a rule; either the **pentagon of good governance pillars** or the **triangle with the Union, the States and the ULBs**.

8.4.1 Introduction

- Model introduction in about **15 words**: 73rd and 74th CAA **constitutionalized local bodies**, fulfilling the vision of **Mahatma Gandhi's Gram Swaraj**.
- Another introduction, taken from a classmate: the 73rd and 74th have **layered the framework of constitutionalization and good governance**, upholding **transparency, accountability, citizen delivery and also a strong audit framework**.

8.4.2 Role of Local Bodies in Good Governance

- **Role has a positive side and a negative side** — the negative side is rarely written, but it is part of the role.
  - **Role points**: promotes **democratic decentralization**; promotes **last-mile service delivery**; **efficiency in administration**; **social justice**; and thereby **grassroots democracy**.
- **The negative side of the role**: concerns, issues or challenges — **functionality** along with the **digital divide** and **capacity building concerns**.
  - With only 100 words for the role, **no substantiation is required** — just write the points;

two words can be written as two lines.

8.4.3 Pros of Merging RLBs with ULBs

The question asks for pros and cons, so show exactly that, in a **tabulated manner**, and then give the content. Pros and cons must not be tempered. Where a table can be made, make it.

- **Leads to integrated planning** — integration is very important in public administration.
  - Important in the light of **increasing urbanization** and the **horizontal expansion of peri-urban areas**.
- **Better service delivery and infrastructure** — sewerage network, piped water, drainage, solid waste management and public transport.
  - Thereby it leads to **disaster resilience**, which is important in the light of an increase in **climate-related extreme events**: flash floods, heat waves and the cold wave.
- **Improves financial capacity and overall capacity building**, as urban areas have stronger potential for taxes.
  - Examples: **property tax**, plus **user charges** — the best example of a user charge being **parking**, both in Delhi and in village settings.
  - Capacity building comes with **trained engineers**, **accounting and tax experts**, and improvement in **water, sanitation and hygiene**.
- **Provides access to urban development programmes** which focus on urban infrastructure.
  - Transport and **last-mile connectivity**, metro, piped water and **sewerage infrastructure**.
- **Better planning, or integration of the core with the periphery** — increasing urbanization leads to **urban sprawl**, which can be regulated by municipal local bodies.
  - This gives **better management of pollution, sewage, traffic and waste generation**.
  - Therefore it leads to **equity between core ULBs and the peripheries**, that is the **RLBs**.
- A problem **never changes instantaneously at a municipal boundary**: a village in **Sonipat** or **Panipat** and a municipal corporation in Delhi face the same problems, because they lie in the periphery of Delhi.
  - Where a city expands — **Pune**, **Greater Bengaluru Municipal Corporation**, **Greater Chennai Municipal Corporation**, the **NCD** area — the surrounding areas must be merged, and **the earlier the better**.
- Early merger lets you bring the area into context and plan its **urbanization, cultural change and service delivery**.
- **State governments use political calculations while delimiting**: whose sarpanch will come there, and whose councillor will come in which ward.
  - When expansion happens, the **District Magistrate** sends the **SDM**, listens to the representations of the people in the periphery, and only then takes a step; people resist when their **Gram Panchayat is converted into a ward**.
- Political issues thus arise over the **expansion of ULBs**, and the peripheries have their own problems — which are the **cons**.
- In peripheral areas — far-flung parts of **Gurgaon** or the parts of **Uttar Pradesh, Haryana and**

Rajasthan adjoining Delhi — **development is much greater and investment equals the city's, but the facilities are like a village's**, so planning is very important.

8.4.4 Cons of Merging RLBs with ULBs

- **Increase in the cost of service delivery** — village members suddenly face **property tax, user charges and building permission fees**.
- **It can limit or stop access to rural development schemes** — **MGNREGA** and **VB-G RAM G** — and may lead to a **transitionary period** in which neither urban scheme nor rural scheme benefits are provided.
  - In a rural scheme the beneficiaries are listed by a government official, and once the area becomes urban the benefit of the urban scheme takes three to six months, so the **stop-gap period is very long**.
  - Example: women in a village who were getting let us say **Rs. 400, Rs. 500, Rs. 600 or Rs. 800** under a scheme move to an **urban bus service scheme** and have to wait.
- **Participatory governance gets weakened** as the transition goes from the **Gram Sabha to a ward** in a large municipal corporation, diluting the **local political voice**.
  - The office of sarpanch itself disappears, and a **ward counsellor** in a big city lacks the glamour of the office of **sarpanch** — many songs glorify the sarpanch, but there is no song about a ward counsellor.
  - The distance also increases because in a village there is a **strong correlation of politics and society**: the **Gram Sabha and Gram Panchayat resolve social problems**, for example an issue between two young individuals is resolved at the social level by the same body that takes political decisions.
  - The entire framework of **grievance redressal gets transferred** — a total upturning of service delivery; things are gained but there is also loss.
- **Limited revenue augmentation** — the area has been converted into an urban area and expectations have become urban, so taxes must be paid, but a villager who never paid parking charges, property tax or building conversion fees sees the new demand as a **threat** and refuses to pay.
  - This leads to **resentment to pay municipal taxes** and therefore **limited revenue despite the increase in infrastructure and service delivery responsibilities**.
  - The municipal corporation has to give more, and residents also demand facilities like those of Delhi, but they do not pay.
- **Municipal gigantism — economies of scale** is a merit of expansion, but municipal expansion can lead to a corporation so big that **it forgets what its job is**.
  - That leads to **increased bureaucratic distance, slower grievance redressal and weak attention to peripheral wards**.
- **Limited service delivery** — an **unplanned or premature merger** may increase infrastructure and service delivery responsibilities for ULBs, leading to **poor service delivery for the poor and for the peripheral areas**.

8.4.5 Way Forward

- The focus has to move **from F3 to functionality** — F3 being funds, functions and functionaries.
- Strengthen the **State Election Commission** and the **State Finance Commission**.
- Strengthen the **State legislatures** in devolving powers to the third tier.
- Ensure that **competitive federalism** is promoted by promoting indexes such as the **Panchayat Advancement Index** or the **Devolution Index**, which create competition between different municipal corporations and rural local bodies.
- Any merger of an RLB into a ULB has to take the **above cons into consideration** and be planned in a more efficient manner.
- **Conclusion line**: though the **integration of RLBs and ULBs is beneficial** and would lead to good governance, the above-mentioned cons have to be taken into consideration while planning or while delimiting an RLB into a ULB.

COMPARISON

Two answer templates.

- **Diagram-plus-heads template**: a diagram is drawn and heads are given with points underneath — this feels a bit **loose and informal**.
- **Point-wise template**: points are written directly under the asked heads — this is the preferred style.
- Either may be used; what matters is that the **head asked in the question is visible**.

- **Civil services rule**: no forced quotes, no forced sentences, no forced English; keep things **as basic as possible**.
- The examiner first looks for whether the **role has been written at all**; even if a film story is written inside, it does not matter.
- Even a professional or a good student can attempt only about **17–18 of the 20 questions** in the civil services mains — that is the benchmark to plan for.
- **Comparison questions are answered in a table**, for example the **President-versus-Prime Minister** comparison asked this year; the **anti-defection law** question also came straight from class discussions.
- **Structure is the most important part of any topic**, and many questions can be answered from the structure itself.

QUICK REVISION

- **Question**: analyse the role of local bodies in good governance and bring out the pros and cons of merging RLBs with ULBs (10-marker wording, to be written as a **15-marker, 250 words**).
- **Framework**: intro 20–30 words, body about 200 words (100 words role + 100 words pros and cons), conclusion 20–30 words; **keywords first**; **diagram is a must**.
- **Role (positive)**: democratic decentralization, last-mile service delivery, efficiency in administration, social justice, grassroots democracy; **negative side**: functionality, digital divide,

capacity building.

- **Pros of merger**: integrated planning; better service delivery and infrastructure plus disaster resilience; financial capacity and capacity building; access to urban development programmes; better core–periphery planning and equity.
- **Cons of merger**: higher cost of service delivery; loss of rural schemes with a transitionary period; weakened participatory governance and shifted grievance redressal; limited revenue augmentation and resentment; municipal gigantism; poor service delivery for peripheral areas after premature merger.
- **Way forward**: move from F3 to functionality, strengthen SEC and SFC, strengthen State legislatures, promote competitive federalism through indexes, and plan any merger taking the cons into account.
- **Exam discipline**: no forced quotes, write what is asked, use tables for comparisons, only **17–18 of 20 questions** can realistically be attempted, and the **structure carries the answer**.

8.5 Malnutrition: Concept, Framework and Answer Structure

Malnutrition is not a straight topic in the syllabus. It is connected with **poverty and hunger**, which come under the framework of **social justice** in General Studies Paper 2.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Exam framing.

- General Studies Paper 2 carries about **13–14 polity questions, 4 IR questions, 1–2 governance questions and 1–2 social justice questions** — that is how the four sub-pillars pan out.
- A question came **straight from the structure of this topic in the 2026 paper** — it was a **structure question**.

8.5.1 The Human Capital Chain and the Demographic Dividend

- The discussion of **social justice** moves in this order: first the **concerns of malnutrition**, which automatically include **hunger**; then malnutrition's role in **harming health**; then **education**; then **skill development**.
- All of them, if they act in unison, produce **human capital**; if well utilised it becomes a **demographic dividend**, and if poorly utilised a **demographic disaster**.
  - Therefore **malnutrition is one of the pillars, or focus areas, for utilising the demographic dividend**.

8.5.2 Framework of Malnutrition

- The framework is **causes, challenges and impacts**.
- **Poverty** — and equally the condition **above poverty**.
- **Social and cultural issues**: in a household the females, including the grandmother, eat at the end.

  - If the household is a non-veg eater, the **best piece goes to the males** and the **worst piece**, which is not even a piece, goes to the **females**.
- **Gender and caste issues** are involved, along with matters of **equity**.
- Representation matters when discussing malnutrition: are you an **Adivasi**, and within the Adivasi population a **primitive vulnerable tribal group**?
- Even a rich State like **Karnataka** has a divide: **Bangalore and Mysore** are developed, while the **Hyderabad-Karnataka region represented under Article 371-J — Ballari, Bidar, Gulbarga** — is completely backward.
  - Karnataka is otherwise the **best State with respect to devolution of powers**.
- **Tamil Nadu, Telangana and Andhra Pradesh** show the same pattern: **coastal Andhra** (Visakhapatnam, Amravati) and the areas along the **Krishna and Godavari** rivers are developed, while **Rayalaseema** and the backward areas of **Kurnool, Kadapa and Chittoor** are less developed.
- Every State has its own divide and its own disparity of access, so malnutrition is a concern with respect to **human development**.
- The youth in the room are at the **top of the pyramid** — the top socio-cultural-economic group of the country, from families that gave good education and good financial backup.
  - Many of them consume food which is **right in the number of calories but not diverse**; after the break most will never prefer eating fruits and will have **UPF, ultra-processed food**.

8.5.3 *Why Malnutrition Is a Different Ball Game*

- **Malnutrition is a totally different ball game** — it is not like agriculture, poverty, unemployment, education or health.
- To reform education you reform **primary education**; to reform health the **primary health centre is converted into AAM, Ayushman Arogya Mandir**; to get jobs you run **wage employment and self-employment schemes**.
- But to provide **nutrition**, what is the way out? For all the other problems there are schemes.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Malnutrition is multidimensional.**
>
> - **Malnutrition includes both over-nutrition and under-nutrition.**
> - In this scenario **malnutrition is multidimensional** — it is not only poverty, and it is not only the absence of food.
> - There are **social and cultural factors**, matters of **equity** and matters of **human development** involved.
> - Therefore malnutrition has to be seen from the lens of **human development**, and the way to understand it is to think in terms of **convergence**.

- Malnutrition is like the **essay paper**: the essay has **no fixed syllabus** out of Papers 1, 2, 3 and 4, and it requires a **good angle** from all the papers.
  - So malnutrition is, in a way, essay-like in representing human development.

8.5.4 Structure for Answering Malnutrition

1. Introduce **what malnutrition is**.
2. Give the **statistics**.
3. **Historical background** — not needed in this type of question, though it is a normal part of a structure.
4. Give the **latest survey — NFHS Round 6**, which is important for the prelims next year and has to be prepared with facts.
5. **Compare NFHS Round 5 with NFHS Round 6.**
6. Write the **concerns**.
7. Write the **steps**.

- **Steps**: the classic scheme is **Saksham Anganwadi** — the **Anganwadi centres have been converted into Early Childhood Education and Nutritional Centres**.
- There are also certain **initiatives which are run by the Department of Health and Family Welfare**.
- A discussion on **obesity, that is over-nutrition**, is to be taken up separately, on the **factors that have led to it**.
- Practical advice given along with the topic: **do not eat ultra-processed food; eat fruits and good peanuts**.

QUICK REVISION

- **Malnutrition is not a straight topic**; it is connected with **poverty and hunger** under **social justice** in GS Paper 2.
- The chain: malnutrition (with hunger) → **health** → **education** → **skill development** → **human capital** → **demographic dividend** or **disaster**; malnutrition is one of the **pillars for utilising the demographic dividend**.
- **Framework**: causes, challenges and impacts — poverty and above-poverty, social and cultural issues, gender and caste issues, equity; the food hierarchy within a household is an example.
- Regional divides matter: Karnataka's rich Bangalore/Mysore against backward **Hyderabad-Karnataka (Article 371-J: Ballari, Bidar, Gulbarga)**; coastal Andhra vs Rayalaseema and Kurnool, Kadapa, Chittoor.
- **Malnutrition includes over-nutrition and under-nutrition** and is **multidimensional** — like the **essay paper** — so it needs **convergence** and a **human development** lens.
- Other sectors have obvious reforms (**primary education**, **AAM — Ayushman Arogya Mandir**, wage and self-employment schemes), which is why nutrition stands apart.
- **Structure**: what malnutrition is → statistics → (historical background not needed) → **NFHS Round 6** → compare **NFHS Round 5 and 6** → concerns → steps (**Saksham Anganwadi**, Health and Family Welfare initiatives); obesity to be discussed separately.

CHAPTER 9

Malnutrition in India — Part 1

9.1 PYQs and Exam Weighting of This Topic

Before anything else, write down the PYQs of this topic. There are only a handful, but they repeat.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

PYQs of Malnutrition.

- **2026 PYQ:** malnutrition is a challenge of social equity, a challenge of human development and a challenge of **effective welfare governance**.
- **2014 PYQ:** poverty and hunger form a vicious cycle. A very simple question, but it has to be answered with the vicious-circle diagram and the intergenerational-equity framing — these concerns keep coming, so just expand the answer a little around them.
- **2021 PYQ (asked twice):** can microfinance through women's Self-Help Groups break the cycle of gender inequality, poverty and malnutrition? Give examples. This is essentially the SHG as a model of governance, so the impact of the SHG has to be written.

- For the SHG answer the impact must be written on three fronts, and the SHG diagram must be drawn:
  - **Economic impact** of SHGs.
  - **Social impact** of SHGs.
  - **Political impact** of SHGs.

CRITICAL POINT

The most ignored theme.

- Theme-wise question load: education about **9 questions**, health about **9 questions**, poverty **4–5 questions** (the paradox of poverty) and malnutrition only **2 questions**. The theme is the most ignored one in civil services.

QUICK REVISION

- 2026 PYQ: malnutrition = social equity + human development + effective welfare governance.
- 2014 PYQ: poverty and hunger form a vicious cycle — answer with the vicious-circle diagram.
- 2021 PYQ (twice): SHG microfinance breaking the cycle of gender inequality, poverty and malnutrition — write economic, social and political impact and draw the diagram.

- Theme-wise load: education ~9, health ~9, poverty 4–5, malnutrition only 2.

9.2 Introduction: Definition and Dimensions of Malnutrition

The first part of this topic is the introduction — how will you introduce malnutrition? It is not compulsory to reproduce the exact definition of an organisation; even a definition you frame yourself will work. The lecture used the World Health Organization definition, found online, and the obesity data was found in PIB.

9.2.1 Anthropometric Measurement: Stunting, Wasting and Underweight

- **Stunting** — the child's height as per the child's age. In an Anganwadi centre children below five come, the Anganwadi worker gives dalia and records weight; weight and height together are called anthropometric measurements.
  - Stunting is a problem that starts the moment the child is born: if a child is one, two, three or four years old, what is the height of that child as per that age?
- **Wasting** — the weight of that person as per the height.
  - Example: if the height is two feet and the weight should be 50 kg but is only 40 kg, the child is wasted — the body organs have not formed as per the height.
- **Underweight** — low weight for age, and it can occur across all age categories and across the whole age span.
  - The CAPF physical test is the everyday illustration: weight is judged against height, so underweight is not fixed to one age.
- Dietary problems do not mean only dietary problems — they mean poverty, social and cultural issues, equity, the mistakes of the government and poor human development. This is the framework of IGNOU, which teaches public nutrition in its master's course.

9.2.2 Why the Anganwadi Worker Is Central

- The Anganwadi worker is very important because the earlier stunting is tracked, the earlier intervention in that particular activity becomes possible — so Anganwadi workers need to be efficiently trained in anthropometric measurement.
  - There are roughly **9–10 lakh** Anganwadi workers in India (the lecture also recalls 11 lakh Anganwadi centres or workers); the exact number was to be discussed separately.
- **ICDS** — the Integrated Child Development Services, started in **1975** by the Ministry of Women and Child Development; that is the scheme under which the Anganwadi centres run.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

ICDS turns 50.

- ICDS completed **50 years** last year. All Anganwadi workers were summoned by the government in mid-September (the news of the time) and were warmly welcomed.

9.2.3 The Three Dimensions of Malnutrition

Undernutrition	Stunting, wasting and underweight in children; it also includes micronutrient deficiency	Low haemoglobin and iron deficiency, vitamin D deficiency in women — there is no natural capability of absorption of vitamin D
Micronutrient deficiency	Deficiency of vitamins and minerals	Vitamin A, vitamin C, iron and zinc deficiency that does not show now but may slow metabolism later
Overnutrition	Leads to being overweight and obesity	Weight above what the age and height require

These three dimensions lead to **diet-related non-communicable diseases** — anaemia, protein deficiency, diabetes, hypertension (high BP), cardiac arrest (heart attack) and, in the worst cases, cancer.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Double or triple burden of malnutrition.**
>
> - **Double burden** = undernutrition + overnutrition.
> - **Triple burden** = undernutrition + overnutrition + micronutrient deficiency.
> - Example: a person whose weight is exactly the 80 kg the CAPF test wants may still not be suffering a double burden yet may suffer micronutrient deficiency — vitamin A, C or D, iron or zinc. It is not showing now, so fitness-wise the person looks perfectly fit, but in the future it may slow the metabolism.

India is facing this double or triple burden along with a **nutrition transition** — the existence of undernutrition with the emergence of obesity or overnutrition as a problem. The drivers are liberalisation, privatisation, globalisation and urbanisation; whatever the impact of globalisation, the impact of urbanisation on a sector is the same.

The disease burden has shifted: communicable diseases have significantly reduced, but the burden has moved towards non-communicable diseases. Thirty to forty years ago nobody in a village had diabetes or hypertension; today undernutrition still exists, and alongside it a second disease — overnutrition — has arrived. The food- and water-contamination related diseases have not been stopped either; only a new concern has emerged.

> **DATA & FACTS**
>
> **Why obesity is a separate sub-topic.**
>
> - For the past two years, including this year, the **Economic Survey 2025-26** has given a separate

chapter and a separate discussion, within the chapter on health, on the role this problem of obesity has played in reducing productivity.

- The Prime Minister has run a campaign with the motto **"a little less from today"** — a little less salt and sugar (and oil).

Until now all the debates were of undernutrition; when you become officers, the debates that come will be of overnutrition as well. That is exactly why obesity deserves to be studied as a separate sub-topic under malnutrition.

QUICK REVISION

- Stunting = height for age; wasting = weight for height; underweight = low weight for age across the age span.
- Three dimensions of malnutrition: undernutrition, overnutrition, micronutrient deficiency.
- Double burden = undernutrition + overnutrition; triple burden adds micronutrient deficiency.
- These lead to diet-related NCDs: anaemia, protein deficiency, diabetes, hypertension, cardiac arrest and, worst case, cancer.
- Nutrition transition = undernutrition persisting with emerging obesity; drivers are liberalisation, privatisation, globalisation, urbanisation.
- ICDS started in 1975 under the Ministry of Women and Child Development; Anganwadi workers do the anthropometric measurements.
- Economic Survey 2025-26 carries a separate discussion on obesity and productivity; the motto is "a little less from today".

9.3 NFHS Round 6: Undernutrition Data and the Anganwadi–PHC Connect

DATA & FACTS

The two rounds being compared.

- **NFHS Round 6:** numbers released in **May 2026**; data collected from households in **2023–2024**; released by the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare. One thousand per cent important for prelims.
- **NFHS Round 5:** data collected over **2019–2021** and released in 2022, just after COVID.
- For anaemia the comparison has to shift to **Round 4 (2015–16)** against **Round 5**, because Round 6 has no anaemia data.

Comparing the two rounds for children under five gives the most important metrics of undernutrition.

Stunting	Low height for age	35.5%	29%
Wasting	Low weight for height	19.3%	No change; still the same
Underweight	Low weight for age	32%	31.8%
Severe wasting	Severe low weight for height	7.7%	5.2%

- One in three children in India was stunted just six years ago — a child of five who has not even entered the first class — and this is 100% connected to poor human capital formation and the demographic dividend.
  - Stunting has reduced by about **6 percentage points** (35.5% to 29%), and this is genuinely good news.
- Wasting has not moved at all — it remains as it was, which is a startling number.
  - Severe wasting, if it must be written separately, has declined from **7.7% to 5.2%**.
- Underweight has barely moved: from 32% to 31.8%, a fall of only **0.2%**.
  - So of the three parameters of undernutrition, two are exactly where they were six years ago.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **A failure of implementation.**
>
> - **May 2018:** the National Nutrition Mission / **POSHAN Abhiyaan** was launched with great fanfare and was implemented for three years, till 2021.
> - In the **2021–22 budget** the Finance Minister announced a new scheme — **Saksham Anganwadi and Mission POSHAN 2.0** — which subsumes the Anganwadi centres under ICDS (started 1975) and also POSHAN Abhiyaan.
> - Despite POSHAN Abhiyaan, stunting fell while wasting and underweight did not move: in the last six years all the policies of the government have failed. This is a failure in the implementation of schemes, in the Anganwadi centres and in the framework for addressing malnutrition.

Why is this called a governance failure? **Welfare governance** has three steps: (1) counting the number of people suffering from undernutrition, (2) designing, formulating and planning a scheme, and (3) actually ensuring that the benefits of that scheme reach the beneficiaries. The third step is where the last six years have failed.

- Nutrition is not the task of any one ministry — not Women and Child Development, not Education, not Agriculture, not Health and Family Welfare. It requires **convergence** of all of them.
  - Nutrition and malnutrition measures keep returning to the question of convergence whenever schemes are discussed.

- About five articles had appeared in an edition of The Hindu on this theme [context garbled in the transcript].

9.3.1 The Anganwadi Worker and the Primary Health Centre

- An Anganwadi worker, under the Ministry of Women and Child Development, goes to the home, collects data for the child and makes the anthropometric measurement.
  - If there is a symptom of **severe wasting**, meaning the child is severely wasted as per height, the child goes to a nutritional resource centre; the Women and Child Development department is then no longer the one in charge — the health hand, doctors and trained medical care take over.
- This is how the role of the Anganwadi is intrinsically connected to the very problem of malnutrition: malnutrition cannot be discussed without discussing Anganwadi workers, and health cannot be discussed without discussing the problems of primary health centres.
- In the mains, where health appears as a sub-theme under social justice, three out of six times the question will be on the reforms wanted in primary health — which is the first centre of location.
  - Health basically means the primary health centre. Fix the primary health centres and 99.99% of health problems are solved.
  - Increase the remuneration of Anganwadi centres and Anganwadi workers and train them, and welfare governance is automatically addressed — all these measurements are taken by these Anganwadi workers.

> **DATA & FACTS**
>
> **Vaccination coverage.**
>
> - **Full vaccination coverage:** 84% in Round 5, increased to **87%** in Round 6.
> - **Rotavirus vaccine coverage:** rose from **36.4%** to a figure heard as about 85% [figure indistinct in the lecture]; these are very strong numbers.

- Full vaccination coverage is very important for nutritional security because **nutritional security includes absorption**.
  - If typhoid, malaria or cholera strikes, body weight can fall by about 10 kg — and we are adults; imagine the same for a child.
- Even if the child is given the best dalia and the best fortified foods, if open defecation and poor WASH practices prevail around, that child will automatically not be able to absorb the food.
  - Many of us had worms in the stomach as children and were given deworming tablets — albendazole.
- Protein needs fibre to be digested: eating ten or twelve eggs will not build the body if carbohydrates and fibre are missing — the protein is not absorbed and it produces gas and harms the liver.
  - If chicken breast is eaten in the evening, kheera with it helps better absorption.
- If diarrhoea is spreading around the child and vaccination coverage is poor, the food will not be absorbed; that is why these numbers matter for undernutrition.

QUICK REVISION

- NFHS Round 6: released May 2026, data for 2023–24, by the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare; Round 5 data is 2019–21, released after COVID.
- Stunting 35.5% → 29%; wasting 19.3% → unchanged; underweight 32% → 31.8%; severe wasting 7.7% → 5.2%.
- Two of three undernutrition parameters unchanged despite POSHAN Abhiyaan (May 2018) → implementation failure; in the 2021–22 budget it was replaced by Saksham Anganwadi and POSHAN 2.0.
- Welfare governance = count the undernourished + design the scheme + ensure delivery.
- The Anganwadi worker tracks stunting and hands over severe-wasting cases to health care; three of six health questions in mains are on primary health reform.
- Full vaccination 84% → 87%; rotavirus 36.4% → [as stated]; absorption needs WASH, deworming and fibre with protein.

9.4 NFHS Round 6: Obesity, Anaemia and the Nutrition Transition

Obesity is determined on the basis of the **body mass index** — effectively the weight-to-height ratio. Comparing Round 5 with Round 6 gives striking numbers.

Women	24%	30%
Men	22.9%	27.3%

DATA & FACTS

Obesity is an urban phenomenon.

- In Round 6, **43% of women in urban areas are obese**, against only about **23% in rural areas** — rural is obviously much less.
- Rural women are extremely lean because they work day in and day out — in the field, tending cattle, carrying fodder, milking, and walking at least 10,000 steps a day — and then take up household responsibilities as well.
- City living keeps even the lean at risk: those walking 20,000 steps a day are still in the risky bracket.

- One of the biggest reasons women show higher obesity is that they do not get mobility because of improper socio-cultural norms.
  - A male can always take a stroll after a heavy biryani, butter chicken and naan at midnight with his friends; a female cannot, because of the responsibilities she carries for domestic care — the child, the family.
- Obesity and overnutrition in India are an affair primarily restricted to the cities: the effect of

globalisation and of urbanisation, broadly, is much greater on cities than on villages.

- This is the same theme as General Studies Paper 1 — once the impact of globalisation on a sector is attempted, the impact of urbanisation on that sector is one hundred per cent the same.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **Cash transfers and female empowerment.**
>
> - Schemes such as **Ladli Behna Yojana** give **Rs. 1.52 lakh (Rs. 1,52,000)**, and a survey says that a big amount of this money is actually taken by in-laws and husbands.
> - If the husband is not earning well, the "ladli behen" will provide the money to the "ladla" — so female empowerment itself gets compromised, and this is the demerit of the cash-transfer schemes planned recently.
> - The reference point is states like Jharkhand, states governed by the Aam Aadmi Party, and Madhya Pradesh; now every state is trying to give this cash transfer after looking at the success — how far it is successful is a separate question for civil services.

On the sugar-related point: this is not required to be written in the answer.

9.4.1 *Anaemia: the Data Gap in NFHS Round 6*

- NFHS Round 6 did not test for anaemia, and the anaemia numbers have not been released.
  - This became a big criticism of NFHS Round 6: the recent edition of Frontline Magazine has strongly criticised it — household sizes and the sample size were increased, yet several data were not collected.
  - The Ministry of Health and Family Welfare says it will conduct a separate, proper test only for anaemia.
- Children (6–59 months) who are anaemic in India: **61.1%** [also stated as almost 59% in the lecture].
  - The implication for skill development and cognition is direct when 61.1% of the children of the country are anaemic.
- Women aged 15–49, the cohort able to raise a child: **53%** were anaemic in the Round 4 data, and this **rose to 57%** in Round 5 — the number for children is higher still.
  - So anaemia in women and anaemia in children both increased from Round 4 to Round 5.

This is an intergenerational issue. When the woman was born as a child she was ignored from the start because of intergenerational exclusion from dietary practices; when she became a mother she was herself anaemic, so she automatically gave birth to a child who is anaemic. In the urban case the overnutrition of the mother leads to a prevalence of type 2 diabetes in the child; the same mother in a village, who has not undertaken proper nutrition, transfers undernutrition instead.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **A significant multi-dimensional challenge.**
>
> - India's nutritional transition is a significant **multi-dimensional challenge** because of (1) wasting, (2) undernutrition in children, (3) obesity, which is more for women than men, and

(4) anaemia, which has increased from Round 4 to Round 5.

- The dilemma that follows: should overnutrition be addressed, or undernutrition, or social equity, or should the Anganwadi centres be improved? It is unlike health — to address the health of the workforce, the nutrition of the workforce must first be addressed.

Skill development does not start after class 12 — it starts the day the child is born. All these problems begin there: the child is breastfed, and in Ayurveda, which the Hindu rituals follow, comes **Annaprashan (anna-prasam)**, the important ceremony of the child's first solid food. Yet children beyond six months are usually still not breastfed, because mothers do not have information. This is the discourse that turns the nutrition transition into a demographic disaster — there is no skill in the mind without proper nutrition.

QUICK REVISION

- Obesity — women 15–49: 24% → 30%; men: 22.9% → 27.3%; urban women 43% against rural 23%.
- Obesity is primarily urban; globalisation and urbanisation hit cities harder — a GS Paper 1 theme.
- NFHS Round 6 collected no anaemia data; Frontline Magazine criticised it; a separate anaemia test was promised.
- Children 6–59 months anaemic: 61.1% (also stated as almost 59%); women 15–49: 53% in Round 4 → 57% in Round 5.
- Intergenerational transfer: an anaemic mother gives birth to an anaemic child; maternal overnutrition in the city raises type 2 diabetes risk in the child.
- Cash transfers (Ladli Behna Rs. 1.52 lakh) get captured by in-laws and husbands — the demerit of the model.
- Skill development starts at birth with breastfeeding and Annaprashan; the nutrition transition risks a demographic disaster.

9.5 Nutritional Security and Its Pillars: Beyond Food Security

Write down **nutritional security to address malnutrition** — do not turn this into a discussion of food security, and it is not a discussion of the National Food Security Act 2013. Food security is about food.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

The mission has been renamed.

- The Prime Minister said last year that the **National Food Security Mission** has now been transformed into the **National Food Security and Nutrition Mission**.

Food-security needs may be fulfilled and yet nutritional insecurity can persist — even among the people sitting in the room, who have no unmet food-security need, all are nutritionally insecure.

KEY CONCEPT

Food security defined.

- **Food security** means all people at all times have physical, social and economic access to sufficient, safe and nutritious food.

Nutritional security implies that all people at all times consume food which is sufficient in quantity and quality — the first requirement is variety, diversity and a balanced diet, then a focus on nutrient content, and, the most important thing about food, food safety. Food security is necessary but **not sufficient** for nutritional security.

EXAMPLE

The state of food safety.

- This was studied through FSSAI: a top five-star hotel in Aerocity and a JW Marriott had cockroaches and rotten tomatoes. That is the state of affairs for nutritional security.

9.5.1 *Broad Pillars of Nutrition Security*

These are the broad pillars of nutrition security (an IGNOU framework). Any governance strategy must focus on these pillars.

- **1. Food availability** — and this availability has to be diverse. Food must be available in the market, which implies agri productivity and a proper supply.
  - For diversity you cannot follow unsustainable agriculture; you have to stop rice–wheat monoculture and build diverse food production systems. You cannot grow just one type of crop.
  - Crop diversification is today very successful: Delhi has demand for broccoli, kiwi, dragon fruit and avocado. The huge variety of multi-grain rotis, 100% whole wheat bread and preservative-free bread is entirely a post-COVID phenomenon; before that everything was refined-flour bread.
- **2. Access** — the market may have a restaurant, but if that restaurant is beyond your reach there is no access. The focus is on affordability, on physical access to markets, and on infrastructure for storage and transportation.
  - Social safety nets cannot be ignored: the Ministry of Consumer Affairs implements the **PDS** and **One Nation One Ration Card**.
  - Fair and transparent pricing matters — fruits sometimes become very costly, with pomegranate and mango at Rs. 300 a kilo. “An apple a day keeps the doctor away” becomes impossible when even a doctor cannot eat an apple, let alone the patient.
- **3. Utilisation** — this focuses on maximising the nutritional value of food. Eat fresh, and do not reheat again and again, especially protein: every time protein is reheated the amino acids are no longer available for absorption, so eating it has no effect on the body.
  - The most important part of utilisation is promoting **nutritional education** — a mango or papaya shake is vitamin C, but in a milk-and-mango shake the body is confused between the milk and the fruit.

  - **Behavioural change** is very important, and micronutrients must also be promoted — but with care: four videos on YouTube made everyone believe rock salt is the thing to eat. Rock salt is very dangerous, it does not contain iodine, and iodine shortage causes thyroid problems. Moringa (drumstick) is a vitamin A source, but excess moringa generates an extra immune response — during COVID everyone was self-medicating.
- **4. WASH** — this is what sets nutritional security apart from food security, since availability and access are already part of food security.
  - **Water:** clean water is needed to digest food; if the water is contaminated you get cholera and all the protein is lost.
  - **Sanitation:** open defecation must be addressed.
  - **Hygiene:** hygiene, too, has to be addressed.
  - Swachh Bharat schemes are the ones focusing on WASH.
- **5. Food stability** — this is very uncommon in India: sometimes onion prices, sometimes tomato prices, either reaching peaks or leaching lows.
  - What must be written is that there has to be **household access during shocks and crisis**, so the focus has to be on **resilience** and on **reducing vulnerability**.
  - Nepal was the illustration: a good chunk of people unfortunately died and there was talk of a secondary lake formation that could lead to a further disaster; that theory was later set aside because the upstream mountain ranges are not getting sufficient water and the lake height is not increasing due to glacial stoppage, so a secondary flood is not expected there.
  - Economic shocks: this time the West Asian crisis did not affect us so much, but it is a major crisis — fertiliser prices increased significantly and almost **25–30% of urea is imported**. Price fluctuations also have to be written, so the focus has to be on food stability.
- Governance must also focus on **energy** and, above all, on **women's nutrition** ["energy" as stated in the lecture].

9.5.2 Governance: The Most Important Part

If there is any suggestion for reforming nutrition, if any question is asked in the interview, it is primarily a **governance challenge** — governance means coordination amongst stakeholders.

- **Stakeholders in governance are three:**
  - The **government**, which is trying to give you laws, rules and regulations.
  - **Industry**, which has the products and is trying to give you services — the restaurants and the halwais are all service providers to you.
  - **Civil society organisations or the citizens** themselves.
- The **regulatory framework** is very important: in restaurants the fried items are cooked in oil that is reused again and again. **FSSAI** and the **Eat Right** movement matter, because food items such as chips are processed and sold as "healthy".
  - **Food labelling:** in the United States, South Africa and even Latin American nations the labelling norms are very strict and accurate. Foods high in salt, sugar and fat should carry clear labelling in India — an ultra-processed chip cannot be healthy, and it has to be labelled clearly.

  - Last year FSSAI released a fact-versus-myth PDF stating clearly that A2 milk has no such benefit over A1 milk; large dairy start-ups pushed back and the notice was withdrawn. Even regulators are not clear what the right framework should be.
- **Empowering individuals and communities to make informed decisions** about food choices is what the pillars finally mean.
  - Nutritional security is related to food choices, and in many societies that consume non-vegetarian food the protein needs are fulfilled anyway.
- There are several tribes in the country that are hunter-gatherers, and a hunter-gatherer will not eat oats, quinoa, millet or roti. A question on the tribal development policy came up in mains this year too.
  - Because of acculturation their food practices have changed: the essentially protein-intensive diet became vegetarian, and their nutritional needs, historically fulfilled over generations, are no longer met — they have become examples of hunger and undernutrition. This tribe is in Madhya Pradesh — the **Korku tribe**, who have assimilated and adopted a Hindu way of living, which to some extent promotes vegetarianism. For that specific section it is a question of **equity**.
- Healthy food is context-specific: for someone in Kashmir, J&K, Tamil Nadu or Kerala it is non-vegetarian food; for someone in Haryana or Rajasthan it is a sin of the highest order, and they would prefer milk and milk-based products. Their diet must not be interfered with, because that is not locally sustainable.

ives as a heading.

9.5.3 Way Forward Flowing From the Pillars

- **Go vocal for local** — this was the main argument of the Economic Survey two years ago and is the theoretical logic of the Prime Minister's call.
  - Eating Californian almonds and avocado does nothing for you: an enormous amount of fuel is consumed in transporting them. Even if they come by a hydrogen-production-enabled vessel, resources are still being converted into wrongful practices.
  - Some assimilation is necessary, but following completely globalised dietary practices is dangerous. You must also know the nutritional value of what you are eating.
- **Mission LiFE**, the theme India gave to the world at Glasgow — the fight against climate change will start from the people. It talks about **PPP**, not the usual PPP but **pro planet people**.
  - Food systems have to be sustainable, which means eating food that is locally available and inherently part of one's own society.
- **STR — strengthening local institutions** — this is the theory, and it must be paired with promoting community participation.
- Promote the **Gram Sabha** and communitarian-based governance, which automatically incorporates into the diet what is easily available nearby; this gives a balanced sense of nutrition consumption and you do not have to homogenise anybody's diet.
- **Capacity building** is the third requirement, because it is for females to make the choice about what food the child will eat.
  - There are many myths and practices about what a pregnant woman should or should not

eat, and they are not 100% wrong — but a woman is made to eat so much that it actually leads to overnutrition and becomes the start of type 2 diabetes, or the possibility of the child getting diabetes.

  - On one side the poor mother gets no food at all; on the other she is overfed so that the child, and the family, look "healthy" — the beginning of a pre-diabetic propensity.

- **Gender equality** is very important, and along with it women's education and welfare governance — unless women get their rights, all the social justice issues discussed will get resolved, since the protagonist of the family is the woman, and today she has no decision-making power.
- A strong **social protection scheme** is needed: nutritional security cannot be addressed by ICDS alone, nor by PM POSHAN (which was called the midday meal earlier), nor by merely providing millets (shree anna).
  - The questions to ask are simple: what do you eat in your house, what does your father eat, what does your brother eat, what does your mother eat — and what changes are there?
- Any programme for nutritional security that focuses only on a diverse food palette is a stupid strategy and a governance misadventure.
- Convergence is required among the Ministry of Agriculture, the Ministry of Commerce and Food Processing, the Ministry of Women and Child Development and the Ministry of Education — the last must prepare a curriculum on nutrition and home science (a subject that very few schools teach in classes 11 and 12), and the government's role in promoting something as simple as the egg is a good example of such a push.
- Nutrition needs even more convergence than health does, because its multi-dimensional impact is one thousand times more: health education is an established vertical, nutrition is not — nutrition is like anthropology, sociology, history and geography, established subjects in their own right.
- The Green Revolution, though its question has died out in Paper 1, is part of the same debate: it led to monoculture practices and, while it delivered food security, it compromised to some extent the nutritional security of the Indian masses.
- Finally, dietary diversity must be central to any such strategy.

QUICK REVISION

- Food security = all people at all times have physical, social and economic access to sufficient, safe and nutritious food; it is necessary but not sufficient for nutritional security.
- National Food Security Mission is now the National Food Security and Nutrition Mission; do not answer this with the NFSA 2013 instead.
- Pillars of nutrition security: food availability (diverse), access (affordable, stored, transported, fair prices), utilisation (nutrient value, nutritional education, behavioural change, micronutrients), WASH and food stability — plus governance, energy and women's nutrition.
- Governance = coordination among government, industry and civil society; the regulatory framework runs through FSSAI, the Eat Right movement and labelling of HFSS foods.
- Way forward: go vocal for local, Mission LiFE and pro-planet people, STR (local institutions), community participation and Gram Sabha, capacity building, gender equality, women's

education, social protection, dietary diversity.

- Nutrition is not an established vertical like health or education, so it needs far greater convergence — its multi-dimensional impact is a thousand times more.
- The Green Revolution gave food security but weakened nutritional security through monoculture.

9.6 Causes of Malnutrition: The Economic Dimension

The causes of malnutrition are, in a way, also the challenges of dealing with malnutrition. If an individual is suffering from malnutrition, it is because he is not consuming enough — and that in turn is because of a number of reasons.

The reasons run along five tracks: **economic reasons**, **agriculture or food-systems related causes**, **social and cultural reasons**, **environmental reasons** and **governance reasons**. Every scheme is, in effect, a governance failure, so the governance track carries its own weight.

KEY CONCEPT

Economic reason: poverty.

- Poverty compromises **affordability**, which leads to a lack of economic access to nutritional security or nutritious food.

Eating healthy is costly, and this is a very simple but real comparison: eating poha costs about **Rs. 20**, while eating a bread omelette certainly costs **Rs. 30–40**. For vegetarians wanting protein within vegetables, paneer is a luxury; for those who eat non-vegetarian food, mutton, chicken and fish are all luxuries, measured by the money spent for the calories needed to fulfil food security.

DATA & FACTS

UN State of Food Security and Nutrition 2024.

- The report says that almost **55% of Indians cannot afford a healthy, balanced and diverse diet**.

Diverse (first requirement)	Protein, carbohydrates, healthy fats, vitamins and minerals, drawn from individual and different sources — even carbohydrates must change source: three days rice and three days roti is more diverse than six days of the same
Adequate	It must fulfil your energy needs; 2,000 calories in one meal and 1,000 in another is not adequacy
Balanced	The right amount of protein, carbohydrate, vitamins and minerals
In moderation	Eating eight rotis instead of four because the paneer and sabzi are good is also not right; everything has to be done in moderation

1. Poverty or lack of affordability.
2. Limited access to nutritional food.
3. Malnutrition.
4. Poor cognition, which affects learning, skill development and education.
5. Reduced health and increased out-of-pocket health expenditure — hospitals and medicines.
6. Poor human capital formation, which is the worst outcome in a world where AI skills are taking over routine work.
7. Low productivity, which automatically leads back to poverty — and the cycle continues.

- The second economic reason is not poverty at all but **food prices and food inflation**, where there is **supply-side uncertainty**: natural disasters, war and crop loss can temporarily increase the price of food.
  - The recent Iran–Israel war increased the price of sulfur and of fertilisers, and also of grains: the processed wheat and buns that are eaten come from Ukraine and Russia, and potato is grown in the cold of Europe.
  - So when the price of anything rises, economic access to it is automatically limited.

QUICK REVISION

- The causes of malnutrition are the same as the challenges of malnutrition.
- Poverty compromises affordability → no economic access to nutritious food.
- UN State of Food Security and Nutrition 2024: almost 55% of Indians cannot afford a healthy balanced diverse diet.
- Healthy diet = diverse + adequate + balanced + in moderation.
- Vicious circle: poverty → limited access → malnutrition → poor cognition → reduced health

and out-of-pocket expenditure → poor human capital formation → low productivity → poverty.

- Food inflation and supply-side uncertainty (disasters, war, crop loss) temporarily raise prices and restrict access.

9.7 Causes of Malnutrition: Agriculture and Food-System Causes

1. Prevalence of monoculture — rice–wheat after the Green Revolution in Punjab, Haryana and Western UP.
2. Limited crop diversification, because land holdings are fragmented: 88% of farmers are small and marginal.
3. Limited transportation, storage and processing infrastructure.
4. Lack of sustainable cropping practices — overuse of urea, which has distorted the NPK ratio.

- On storage and processing: more than **80–90% of food storage is potato-oriented**, and storage for fruits and vegetables is very limited.
  - Vegetables from the areas around Delhi — Alwar, Meerut, Baghpat, Sonipat, Panipat and Karnal — come into Delhi, and if they are not consumed there is no storage facility; frozen peas, easily available in Western nations and in urban pockets, are not available everywhere.
- On fertiliser: there are three kinds — urea, potassium (potash) and phosphate.
  - **Potash is 100% imported**, from countries such as Canada; potash does not occur in India, and potassium is simply not added.
  - **Phosphate is almost 70–80% imported** and only about 20% is made in India. India lacks the raw material and the intermediate product: rock phosphate is mined at the Jhamarkotra mines in Rajasthan, phosphoric acid is made from it (and is itself imported), and from phosphoric acid comes DAP (diammonium phosphate) or super phosphate.

EXAMPLE

The Indian Express chain.

- Indian agriculture practices have led to **depletion of micronutrients and soil organic carbon from the soil** (example: zinc), which further leads to **nutrient deficiency** (again example: zinc) in **rice and wheat**, leading to **stunting in children**.

Soil organic carbon explained: when a crop grows in the soil it absorbs nutrients from the soil, just as a child absorbs nutrients from the mother. The soil is the main medium of aeration that provides energy to the plant. When trees, crops and leaves decay, that carbon is entrapped in the layers of the soil profile, and this entrapped carbon plays a very important role in the efficient absorption of fertiliser. So if soil organic carbon is very high, fertilisers are absorbed better; but if too much fertiliser is added, the soil organic carbon depletes, which then depletes soil micronutrients, for example zinc. Zinc is very important for metabolism — zinc and magnesium tablets are very common nutraceutical supplements.

DATA & FACTS

Soil Health Card Scheme.

- As per the Soil Health Card Scheme, soil samples tested (8.8 million in 2024) show that: **less than 5%** have sufficient nitrogen, **40%** have sufficient phosphate, **30%** have sufficient potash and just **20%** are sufficient in soil organic carbon.

There is one more consequence: where there is deficiency and where there is metal pollution, traces of uranium, traces of cadmium and other dangerous metals are found in food.

- There is a lack of crop diversification, of integrated farming systems and of natural and organic farming — all of which aids a lack of food diversity.
  - Food diversity exists in the North-East, and shifting cultivation is another example.
  - Travelling down an expressway you only find lush green fields of one type of crop, because the agricultural system is too prone to the application of fertilisers — apply fertiliser and the crop that gives gains will be grown.

Farmer rationality explains why diversification fails: if a farmer is coaxed to grow olives, moringa, aloe vera, amla or dragon fruit because Delhi has demand, he will refuse — there is no MSP and no guaranteed procurement. He will end up growing the crops for which an established system exists. The **Fair and Remunerative Price (FRP)** is determined by the central government and is paid by the sugar mill to sugarcane farmers; about **10–12 crops** — rice, wheat, maize, jowar, bajra, soybean, moong, groundnut and a few others — have such an established system.

An **integrated farming system** is the answer: in Bihar a pond sits beside the field, and water is not scarce; in Andhra Pradesh rice fields can carry fisheries — fish, eggs, prawns — and the fish waste is an important source of manure for the pond, essentially uric acid, a nitrogenous waste, a form of urea. Organic farming is possible when the food system is integrated, but it needs standardisation, certification and verification mechanisms; this is a problem of the agricultural system, not the fault of any one person.

EXAMPLE

The model diet.

- The **Mediterranean diet** is the best and the most naturally diverse: seasonal fruits, vegetables and grains together. Otherwise monoculture dominates the diet.

QUICK REVISION

- Rice–wheat monoculture in Punjab, Haryana and Western UP; 88% of farmers are small and marginal, so crop diversification is limited.
- More than 80–90% of food storage is potato; storage for fruits and vegetables is scarce.
- Overuse of urea distorts the NPK ratio; potash is 100% imported, phosphate 70–80% imported; India has neither raw material nor intermediate product.
- Soil Health Card Scheme 2024: 8.8 million samples — less than 5% sufficient in nitrogen, 40% phosphate, 30% potash, 20% soil organic carbon.

- Depleted soil micronutrients and organic carbon (zinc) in rice and wheat lead to stunting in children; metal pollution adds uranium and cadmium traces.
- Without MSP and procurement the farmer will not diversify; FRP is fixed by the central government; integrated farming and organic certification are the way out; the Mediterranean diet is the diversity model.

9.8 Causes of Malnutrition: Social Causes

9.8.1 The Intergenerational Cycle of Malnutrition

1. A female adolescent has limited nutrition — because of the patriarchal household and society. The example is women eating in the end.
2. Limited nutrition means limited education, which increases dependence on the family and on males.
3. That dependence leads to child or early marriage.
4. Food practices then operate with limited knowledge about nutrition.
5. Undernutrition is carried into motherhood: as a mother she has to take care of two bodies, but the diet is the same and the knowledge and awareness are the same.
6. Undernutrition and poor nutrition are transferred to the child, who is born suffering from malnutrition — stunting, wasting and undernutrition.
7. When the child grows, that poor nutrient absorption and status is carried forward till he or she becomes an adolescent, and the cycle starts again from the same point.

- Awareness of nutrition is itself very recent. Seven or eight years ago very few people knew about nutrition, and nutrition for most people meant protein; the common person's understanding of a balanced diet, calories, dieting, fasting and micronutrient deficiency has come late — and YouTube has played a very important role in creating that awareness.
- Why has the cycle not been broken? Because of low female literacy, societal and cultural restrictions, and the male-dominated setup.
  - **Double burden:** for women, work that is primarily unpaid plus household responsibilities, which leaves very limited time for **breastfeeding and complementary feeding**.
- The mother who already carries her own responsibilities, with four or five children, cannot give proper care to each child — she still has to run the house and go to the field.
  - The time that should go into giving the child the right nutritious diet gets compromised, and these responsibilities are not shared by the men.
  - Even the mother-in-law, who herself faced the double burden as a female 35–40 years ago, is not in the loop with the young woman. Because of entrenched patriarchy the female does not get an equal share; the husband's family decides. This is why a strong social protection scheme is needed.

DATA & FACTS

The anaemia marker.

- **60% of females in the age group 15–50**, the age at which they can bear a child, are anaemic — they do not have sufficient iron.
- **Iron is the easiest metric to track**, which is why anaemia becomes the visible proof of the intergenerational cycle.

Complementary feeding means that after the child is six months and beyond, along with breast-feeding, proper food has to be started — not biryani, mutton or haleem, but simple rice and the usual carbohydrates that take care of that person's nutrition, given at the right time.

- Answer-writing note: the intergenerational cycle is very important and must be written with a **diagram plus substantiation**.
  - The approach is like geography — show the diagram and then substantiate; the typical point-wise writing of Social Justice has to be given up.
  - If the answer does not fill 200 words even then it is not a problem, provided the diagram has made the point clear.

9.8.2 *Poor Sanitation and Lack of Focus on WASH*

- The continued practice of **open defecation** persists despite the success of the Swachh Bharat Mission.
  - Toilets have been created in households, but the question is not creation — the question is what percentage of households actually use those toilets. If they are not used it is an absolute waste.
- The causal chain of open defecation runs straight into nutrition:
  - If somebody defecates in the open, the faeces are released into the open environment; certain types of bacteria and microbes feed on the faeces; those microbes contaminate the available soil and water surface; and from there the contamination enters the ecosystem and the food cycle.

QUICK REVISION

- Intergenerational cycle: adolescent girl → limited nutrition → limited education → dependence → early marriage → poor food practices → undernutrition transferred to the child → adolescent → repeat.
- Why it persists: low female literacy, societal and cultural restrictions, the male-dominated setup, and the double burden of unpaid plus household work.
- Limited time for breastfeeding and complementary feeding; men do not share the load; even the mother-in-law is not in the loop.
- 60% of women aged 15–50 are anaemic; iron is the easiest metric to track.
- Complementary feeding after six months: simple rice and usual carbohydrates, not biryani, mutton or haleem.
- Write the cycle as a diagram plus substantiation, like geography; 200 words are not compulsory.
- Open defecation continues despite Swachh Bharat; faeces → microbes → contaminated soil

and water → the food cycle.

9.9 Causes of Malnutrition: Governance Concerns

- **Poorly designed agricultural policy:** MSP is given only for **23 crops** and is tilted in favour of rice and wheat, which has promoted monoculture.
- **Limited focus on nutritional diversity as compared to food security:** all the attention is on food and on calories — 2,000 calories, 2,500 calories, calorie deficit. Nobody counts the nutrients. The focus on **shree anna (millets)** is only post-COVID, to be precise **2023**.
- **Poor implementation of Saksham Anganwadi and Mission POSHAN 2.0.**
- **Poor infrastructure for primary health centres**, which are now called **Ayushman Arogya Mandir**.

Ministry of Education	PM POSHAN
Ministry of Women and Child Development	Saksham Anganwadi and Mission POSHAN 2.0
Ministry of Health and Family Welfare	Anemia Mukt Bharat
Ministry of Food and Consumer Affairs	National Food Security Act 2013

CRITICAL POINT

Multiplicity, or lack of convergence.

- Four ministries run four different nutrition schemes, and the result is multiplicity or lack of convergence.
- Every scheme, it was argued, is really a **governance failure** — institutional mechanisms are failing, policy is failing, implementation is failing. The government is not able to do it; the District Magistrate is not able to do it.
- This is the most important part of the topic: if there is any suggestion for reforming nutrition, it is primarily a governance challenge, and even the government is confused about the framework.

QUICK REVISION

- MSP covers only 23 crops, tilted towards rice and wheat → monoculture.
- Attention stays on calories (2,000–2,500) and not on nutrients; shree anna only post-COVID, precisely 2023.
- Poor implementation of Saksham Anganwadi and POSHAN 2.0; poor primary health infrastructure, now Ayushman Arogya Mandir.
- Convergence failure: Education (PM POSHAN), Women and Child Development (Saksham Anganwadi, POSHAN 2.0), Health and Family Welfare (Anemia Mukt Bharat), Food and

Consumer Affairs (NFSA 2013).

- Every scheme is, in effect, a governance failure — institutional, policy and implementation failure, at every level down to the District Magistrate.

9.10 Causes of Malnutrition: Cultural Causes

- **1. Limited awareness** about a balanced diet, or about the ill effects of food that is high in fat, salt and sugar.
- **2. Urbanisation- and globalisation-induced shift in food practices** and in food culture — an increased demand for ultra-processed food.
  - Ready-to-eat (RTE) noodles, ready-to-eat nuggets, chicken and potato products (for instance McCain) have entered the market and are totally full of externally added salt; food with high salt content should be completely avoided.
- **3. Rise in sedentary lifestyle** — even if the food is not bad, a sedentary lifestyle will take you towards malnutrition.
  - Even a person who is extremely thin is not thereby healthy: being thin and unhealthy is more dangerous than knowing that one is not thin and unhealthy, because at least then some steps are taken.
- **4. HFSS food** — food high in fat, salt and sugar; the packaged items, whether Maggi, potato fritters, chips, biscuits or cake.
  - The question here is the **recommended dietary allowance (RDA)** — what percentage of it is coming from added salt and sugar.
- **5. Rise of e-commerce** — non-healthy items are now within easy reach.
- **6. Cultural assimilation** — traditional, nutrient-diverse food practices have given way to uniform, homogenised dietary choices.

EXAMPLE

The Korku tribe of Madhya Pradesh.

- From being hunter-gatherers and thereby consuming non-vegetarian food, the Korku tribe has embraced vegetarianism, and thereby its protein intake has been compromised.
- This is an illustration of how acculturation itself becomes a cultural cause of malnutrition — and a question of equity.

QUICK REVISION

- Limited awareness of a balanced diet and of the ill effects of fat, salt and sugar.
- Globalisation- and urbanisation-induced shifts in food culture towards ultra-processed RTE foods and HFSS items (Maggi, chips, biscuits, cake); the RDA question of how much comes from added salt and sugar.
- Sedentary lifestyle: being thin does not mean being healthy.
- E-commerce has brought non-healthy items within easy reach.

- Cultural assimilation: the Korku tribe of MP moved from a protein-rich hunter-gatherer diet to vegetarianism, compromising protein intake.

9.11 Causes of Malnutrition: Environmental Causes and Climate-Induced Migration

9.11.1 Climate Change Induced Insecurity

1. Increased frequency of natural disasters — floods, droughts and heat waves.
2. Hampered productivity of the crops (to be underlined).

9.11.2 Environmental Degradation

1. Land degradation (excessive use of fertilisers).
2. Desertification (west of the Aravallis, in Rajasthan).
3. Soil salinisation (the Malwa belt of Punjab) and in the Indira Gandhi Canal command area in Rajasthan.
4. Decline in natural water bodies and wetlands.
5. Water pollution, which has hampered overall crop productivity and thereby led to nutritional insecurity.

EXAMPLE

Reading the map of Rajasthan.

- The Aravallis act as a barrier, but the desert is expanding; **Harike Barrage (Harike Pattan) is a Ramsar wetland**.
- The areas of soil salinisation are **Barmer, Jaisalmer, Jodhpur, Bikaner, Ganganagar and Hanumangarh**, where poor irrigation practices cause accumulation.
- The tribal belt of Rajasthan lies around **Sirohi, Dungarpur, Banswara and Udaipur**; other locations marked were **Kota, Bundi, Jhalawar, Karauli, Jaipur** and then **Delhi**.
- These are all Aravallis that would have vanished had the Supreme Court's 100-metre definition of the Aravallis been upheld.

9.11.3 Climate-Induced Migration and Ration Access

- Climate change induces migration, and migration has a direct nutritional consequence.
  - A migrating blue-collar worker holds a ration card in his hometown, so he has an assured supply of sugar, an assured supply of dal, and assured wheat and rice.
- Despite **One Nation One Ration Card**, it is not so easy in practice: you cannot simply come to a new place, walk into a fair price shop and ask for grain against your card.
  - A big chunk of malpractice (dhandli) happens in the food department: the beneficiaries are not given the grain, but in their names the grain is diverted and sold off in the open market.
- This is the point to be developed specifically as a challenge when the challenges of malnutrition

are taken up.

QUICK REVISION

- Climate change → more floods, droughts and heat waves, and hampered crop productivity.
- Environmental degradation: land degradation, desertification west of the Aravallis, soil salinisation (Malwa belt of Punjab; Indira Gandhi Canal command area), loss of water bodies and wetlands, water pollution.
- Map: Barmer, Jaisalmer, Jodhpur, Bikaner, Ganganagar and Hanumangarh are salinised; Harike is a Ramsar wetland; the Aravallis act as a barrier against the expanding desert.
- Had the Supreme Court's 100-metre Aravalli definition been upheld, these Aravallis would have vanished.
- Climate migration: workers carry ration cards from their hometown; One Nation One Ration Card is not frictionless; grain is diverted in the beneficiaries' names.

9.12 Practice Questions to Attempt

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Write these down and attempt them.

- **1.** Do you think India is undergoing a nutritional transition, and how far shall this nutritional transition affect India's demographic dividend?
- **2.** Malnutrition is not merely a public health problem but also a challenge of social equity, human development and effective welfare governance — discuss. (This is the PYQ that came this year, 2026.)
- **3.** Addressing malnutrition requires a multi-dimensional approach. Do you agree? Discuss in the light of the steps taken by the Government of India.
- **4.** Malnutrition is a multi-dimensional challenge — discuss.
- **5.** Do you think that more than a public health issue, malnutrition is a welfare governance issue or challenge? Give reasons in support of your answer.

There is no need to be anxious about these questions — they are given to remove the insecurity of an aspirant. What has to be practised is the identification of keywords and the structuring of the answer; that is what is being evaluated.

QUICK REVISION

- Question 1: nutritional transition and India's demographic dividend.
- Question 2: the 2026 PYQ — malnutrition as social equity, human development and effective welfare governance.
- Question 3: multidimensional approach plus steps taken by the Government of India.
- Question 4: malnutrition as a multi-dimensional challenge.
- Question 5: malnutrition as a welfare governance issue or challenge, with reasons.

CHAPTER 10

Malnutrition in India — Part 2: Consequences, Government Steps and Way Forward

10.1 Consequences of Malnutrition: The Organising Structure

The consequences of malnutrition are taken up after the causes and the challenges, and the head must be opened with the structure before the points are opened.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **The larger thought: the demographic dividend.**
>
> - Health, education, malnutrition, poverty and hunger are all hindrances in the journey of utilising the **demographic dividend** — this topic will be asked in the context of the demographic dividend.
> - The question actually asked this time was framed on a different dimension; it will be attempted separately alongside this treatment.

- Organise the consequences under six heads, in this order: (1) health, (2) economic (with education), (3) social, (4) political, (5) geographical, (6) strategic and international.
- The same structure recurs for each of these heads — the first consequence is always the impact on health.
- The sequence of the topic as a whole is: challenges → consequences → steps taken by the government → way forward → the question.
  - New terms, new statements and new schemes are to be written down as they appear when the way forward is taken up.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Consequences are written under six heads in this order: health, economic (with education), social, political, geographical, and strategic/international.
> - The overarching thought is the demographic dividend — malnutrition, hunger, poverty and poor education are hindrances in the journey of utilising it.
> - The topic sequence is: causes → challenges → consequences → steps taken by the government → way forward → the question.
> - The same consequence structure is repeated for every such topic, and health is always the first impact.

10.2 Health Consequences

Health is the first impact of malnutrition and the main impact; it is taken up before everything else.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Write-down list: the impact of malnutrition on health.**
>
> - Malnutrition leads to **type 2 diabetes**.
> - Malnutrition leads to **stunting and wasting** — that is, child malnutrition.
> - Malnutrition leads to **weak immunity**.
> - Malnutrition leads to recurrent infection, and thereby increased vulnerability to **non-communicable diseases**.

- Hypertension is more a consequence of obesity, so it is kept out of this list and weak immunity is written in its place.
- Cognitive impairment is also part of the health impact; it is developed in detail under the educational consequences.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Health is the first and the main impact of malnutrition.
> - Health list: type 2 diabetes; stunting and wasting (child malnutrition); weak immunity; recurrent infection.
> - Recurrent infection increases vulnerability to non-communicable diseases.
> - Hypertension belongs with obesity, not with this list.
> - Cognitive impairment is carried forward to the educational consequences.

10.3 Economic and Educational Consequences

Nutrition is the bridge between health and the economy: the demographic dividend can be utilised only if the Indian nutritional transition is effectively addressed.

- Malnutrition leads to **cognitive impairment**, which leads to reduced learning abilities.
- It reduces attention — a high-carbohydrate lunch during lunch spikes glucose and reduces attention to the topic being discussed.
- Reduced attention leads to poor learning outcomes, and then to **absenteeism** — classes start being missed because of the nutritional imbalance and the glucose spike.
  - The class becomes a class to bunk.
- Absenteeism leads to lower employability, and finally to reduced **human capital formation**.
- HCF here stands for human capital formation, not for the highest common factor, which was the joke attached to it.
- After the economic consequences, the loss of human capital is to be written as the concluding point.

KEY CONCEPT

The deficit chain — write it in a box.

- **Nutrition deficit** → **cognitive deficit** → **learning deficit** → **skill deficit** → **employability deficit** → under-employment → **no demographic dividend**.

- The economic impact is divided into three levels: the **individual level**, the **household level** and the **national level**.

DATA & FACTS

World Bank estimate.

- According to estimates by the World Bank, India loses approximately **2 to 3 percent of its GDP annually** due to the reduced productivity of the malnourished workforce.

10.3.1 Individual Level

- Individual level: low productivity, poor employability and lower lifetime earnings.
- Together these produce the **poverty trap**, that is, the vicious circle.
  - The poverty trap means you are incapable of coming out of poverty: poverty means fewer resources for human capital formation → less skill development → less productivity → poor employment → less spending on nutrition → you are stuck perpetually in the poverty cycle.

10.3.2 Household Level

- Medical expenditure rises at the household level.
- In the light of the increasing **privatisation of health** and the malpractices witnessed in private hospitals, this leads to **out-of-pocket expenditure**.
- Out-of-pocket expenditure leads to poverty.
  - Street-vendor households earning Rs. 20,000–25,000 a month with very limited savings: one accident in the family, and the borrowing that follows, pushes them into the poverty cycle — they are above the poverty line but fall back.
- Informal lenders do not peg their interest to the **RBI repo rate** — they charge according to their own dominance and the vulnerability of the individual, and repayment of about Rs. 10,000 a month keeps many people trapped in the poverty cycle.
- It also leads to **loss of working days**.

Why the Female Workforce Matters Here

- Increasing the **female labour force participation rate** is the most important step if India is to grow — women, including those engaged through government schemes, have to be brought into the workforce.
- The female labour force participation rate is **40 percent** in India and **60 percent** in China.
- Central European nations such as **Poland, Germany and South Korea** succeeded because they were able to utilise women and their potential — the most important reason for their success.
- India is getting stuck in the **middle-income trap**: there are educated and skilled women, but

India is incapable of engaging them in the workforce.

- Civil services remain very limited for women because of domestic responsibility.
- Women can be set free only if **crutches** are provided — professional household facilities such as Urban Company, which has done wonders in reducing the **double burden** women face.
  - The working mother carries the responsibility of the home and, in a household with a civil services aspirant, that aspirant's nutrition as well, alongside her work.
- Working mothers in metropolitans and in villages are the most hardworking women; many of them could prepare for civil services at a much better level, but household responsibilities and societal pressures push them out of the race.
- There is a male side to the story as well: both are conditioned to the belief that men have to be better, so men carry the added pressure and the added burden of performing, while women face societal pressure of a different kind — the point was put to the class for their view.

10.3.3 National Level

- If there is lower labour productivity there is lower **national output**.
- Lower national output reduces **economic competitiveness**.
- This matters in the light of emerging technology — **biotechnology, AI, semiconductors and space** — where India would be losing the race.
- The **Indian Semiconductor Mission** has been launched and is now promoting design; it was flagged as a high-probability question area.
- The impact can be written at the international level as well — it will impact **tech sovereignty**.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Paper 1 Geography, already asked.

- They asked — in connection with a NISAR application — what the role of technology in agriculture is: **satellite-based applications**, which is the same as the application of technology in agriculture, and AI-based data. A full answer was written for a **15-marker**.
- **NISAR** was cited as a very interesting mission with a **dual-band radar**.

QUICK REVISION

- Nutrition is the bridge between health and the economy; the demographic dividend is available only if the nutritional transition is addressed.
- Chain: malnutrition → cognitive impairment → poor learning outcomes → absenteeism → lower employability → reduced human capital formation.
- Write the deficit chain in a box: nutrition deficit → cognitive deficit → learning deficit → skill deficit → employability deficit → under-employment → no demographic dividend.
- World Bank: India loses about 2–3 percent of its GDP annually because of the reduced productivity of the malnourished workforce.
- Three levels: individual (poverty trap), household (out-of-pocket expenditure → poverty, loss of working days), national (lower output → lower competitiveness).

- India's female labour force participation is 40 percent against China's 60 percent; engaging women is the most important step for growth.
- Reduced competitiveness also shows up as compromised tech sovereignty and as losing the race in emerging technologies.

10.4 Social Consequences

- Malnutrition leads to an increased **societal divide**.
- It **perpetuates poverty** — because a person is malnourished he is poor, and because he is poor he is malnourished.
  - Poverty is the cause and also the consequence of malnutrition; the causes and consequences of poverty and of malnutrition are to a large extent the same.
- It increases **caste, tribal, gender and educational inequality**.
- The tribals are already backward and are further malnourished, so inequality increases further.
- It leads to **poor social mobility**.
- Poor social mobility arises from **intergenerational inequality**: a malnourished mother raises a malnourished boy or girl; a malnourished girl becomes a malnourished adolescent and adult, and the next generation is likewise malnourished.
  - You cannot leave the society you come from and cannot take the leap, because malnourishment pulls you down — you cannot study, skill development does not work, productivity does not work, consistency does not work.
- Civil services is the shortest and the quickest way to reach the top of the hierarchy of your society; aspirants want to break out of their social fabric — you are doing good, but not great.
  - To do great, the intergenerational nature of malnutrition has to be broken.

KEY CONCEPT

Malnutrition is both the cause and the consequence of inequality.

- This is a **very important keyword** and it is asked in the examination — get familiar with it.
- Poverty is the cause as well as the consequence of malnutrition, and malnutrition is the cause as well as the consequence of inequality.

QUICK REVISION

- Social consequences: increased societal divide, perpetuation of poverty, and widened caste, tribal, gender and educational inequality.
- Tribals, already backward, are further malnourished, so inequality increases further.
- Poor social mobility is caused by intergenerational inequality — a malnourished mother gives rise to a malnourished child and the next generation repeats it.
- Malnourishment pulls you down because studying, skill development, productivity and consistency all fail to work.
- Malnutrition is both the cause and the consequence of inequality — a keyword that is asked

in the examination.

- Civil services is the quickest route up the social hierarchy; breaking the intergenerational nature of malnutrition is what takes you from doing good to doing great.

10.5 Political Consequences

Politics, at one point, is the relationship between you and me as the citizen and the state, along with the associated points.

- Increased **fiscal burden**: governments at the centre and in the states have to expand more and more money out of the revenues they generate in order to address malnutrition.
- Two dimensions run through the political consequences: a **fiscal dimension** and a **rights dimension**.
- Awareness of rights: as globalised citizens people saw what happened in Nepal and in the neighbouring nations, and the youth united.
- Awareness of climate change and of the environment followed the same route — Earth Day and switching off the lights at 8:30 are basic information at the individual level about your right, about the state and you, and about the state's expenditure on that social matter.
  - In the same way, awareness of the burden of AI and data centres has grown: a single GPT search consumes about two times more energy than a normal Google search, reflecting the consumption needed to keep large datasets running.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Article 47 — the constitutional anchor.

- Malnutrition affects the role of the state as a **welfare state** and compromises the constitutional responsibilities enshrined under the **DPSP**.
- **Article 47** — the duty of the state to raise the level of nutrition and public health.
- All the DPSPs, all the Fundamental Rights, all the Fundamental Duties, all **12 schedules** and the Preamble have to be on your fingertips — one or two questions are sure to come in Civil Services Mains.

- Governance consequence: it creates the need for **integrated, networked and convergent governance**.
- It also increases the importance of **welfare governance**, so that the **double burden of nutrition** can be addressed.
- Welfare governance increases the **cost of utilising the demographic dividend**: had malnutrition not been a problem, Rs. 1 would have been enough to utilise the demographic dividend; with malnutrition the state now spends Rs. 2 — on health, education and skill development.
  - The state has to spend more and more to address malnutrition.
- The **demographic window** further gets limited, because the time goes into making the population nutritionally secure.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Prelims reflection.

- In prelims the class had been told to compare the **5th and the 6th Schedule**; this time the question came on **Ladakh**.
- Credit will not be claimed for it since it had not been taught, but 5th versus 6th Schedule was a common topic in the news.

QUICK REVISION

- Politics is the citizen–state relationship and the associated points.
- Political consequence one: increased fiscal burden on the centre and the states to address malnutrition.
- Two dimensions: a fiscal dimension and a rights dimension; globalisation has raised awareness of rights (Nepal, neighbouring nations, the youth uniting).
- Governance needs integrated, networked and convergent governance, and welfare governance grows more important with the double burden of nutrition.
- Welfare governance raises the cost of utilising the demographic dividend from Rs. 1 to Rs. 2 and shrinks the demographic window.
- Malnutrition compromises the role of the state as a welfare state and the constitutional duty under Article 47 — the duty to raise the level of nutrition and public health.
- DPSPs, Fundamental Rights, Fundamental Duties, the 12 schedules and the Preamble must be on your fingertips; prelims has already tested 5th versus 6th Schedule (Ladakh).

10.6 Geographical Consequences

- It increases the **regional divide in nutritional poverty** — interstate and intrastate.
- It increases the need for reform in **agri-food systems**.
- To become nutritionally secure India has to grow more **millets** and more **pulses**, have more **hatcheries** to promote the consumption of eggs, and promote **dairy farming**, **animal husbandry**, **integrated fish farming** and **fish culture** — that is how protein and dietary diversity arrive.
- The state's policy towards agriculture is 100 percent regulated: what is to be grown is decided by the state.
- No major structural change has ever come in India's agriculture sector beyond the single **Green Revolution**.

COMPARISON

Reform of agri-food systems: the two sides of the debate.

- **Market side** — free agriculture completely and let the farmer grow what the market demands: if people want avocado or dragon fruit around Delhi, farmers should be told to grow exactly that; prices will be discovered, supply will rise, and consumption will adjust by itself.

- **MSP side** — MSP is given for rice and wheat; MSP is notified for **23 crops**, but actual implementation happens only for two, and procurement takes place only in certain states. The biggest perpetrator of this inequality is the government: why give MSP for only two crops? That is why the question of a **legal guarantee** has come up.

- The **food security buffer** is far larger than needed: 30, 35, 40 million tonnes of buffer stock is being held, and the system should be dismantled to what food security actually requires.
- Agri-food systems reform has two aspects: the role of the mother, because malnutrition passes from the mother to the child, and the agricultural system.
- The farmer is not at fault; the government is at fault — which policy to apply, what to promote and how to scale crop diversification is a government policy initiative.
- The MSP and the policy architecture came in the 1960s and 1970s; 70 years have passed and agricultural policy now needs an overhaul — which is why agriculture and food systems are spoken of together.
- Dietary diversity arrives only when two options are visible in the market, and they become visible only when two are grown; today they are not visible.

Promotion of — the Keyword List

- **CDP** — the **Crop Diversification Programme**.
- **Fox nuts (makhana)** — the most nutritious food; the whole world wants to eat fox nuts and the scope is tremendous.
- **90 percent of fox nuts** are grown in a single state, which has tremendous scope to overhaul its agriculture.
- Branding model suggested for that state: a district-level brand, for example a **Bhagalpuri makhana**, a good desi name that is also westernised, a manufacturing unit and a vacuum machine, and a brand aimed at the aspirant market.
  - An idea worth copying: the **Ministry of Food Processing Industries** (the ministry of Chirag Paswan) holds **World Food India** at Pragati Maidan every year, where food processing industries put up stalls — a makhana stall could be put up there. It is worth attending after the mains.
- Why do we eat popcorn? What we think is healthy is not necessarily healthy; we eat what is available — the West eats popcorn.
- Food systems need to be overhauled and it is now high time; the food system and the mother's nutrition must be seen together.
- Until **Poshan Abhiyaan** was launched in 2018 a convergent approach to nutrition was not being followed — the government's understanding of nutrition evolved out of food security.

QUICK REVISION

- Geographical consequence: the regional divide in nutritional poverty widens, both interstate and intrastate.
- It creates the need to reform agri-food systems: millets, pulses, hatcheries and eggs, dairy,

animal husbandry, integrated fish farming and fish culture.

- Agriculture policy is 100 percent regulated, and no major structural change has come beyond the single Green Revolution.
- Debate: free the farmer to grow what the market demands versus the MSP regime — MSP is notified for 23 crops but implemented for only two, and procurement is confined to certain states.
- The buffer of 30, 35, 40 million tonnes is far more than food security requires and should be dismantled to what is actually needed.
- The farmer is not at fault, the government is: crop diversification, promotion and scale are policy decisions, and the MSP architecture of the 1960s–70s needs an overhaul.
- Keywords: CDP, fox nuts (makhana, 90 percent from one state), and dietary diversity that appears only when two options are visible in the market.

10.7 International and Strategic Consequences

The strategic consequence is stated first: if you have to rule the world, you have to use the demographic dividend.

- Germany and all such countries are strong because they have a strong, skilled labour force; the best civil servants and the best aspirants are in India.
- Even an educated and skilled workforce cannot contribute strategically if it falls ill very frequently because of poor nutrition — demography is a **disaster** as well as a **strategic opportunity**.
- These nations want people like these: the US cannot run, and Germany, France, South Korea and Australia (where the Prime Minister had been a couple of months earlier) cannot work unless they have Indians.
- They can get Chinese, but the Chinese speak Mandarin; Indians are the best English-speaking people, and that is why India has a great **social capital**.
- The role as **leader of the Global South** will get compromised if the society is malnourished, and the **Sustainable Development Goal** has to be kept in view.
- It leads to slower progress towards the **SDGs (Sustainable Development Goals)** — hunger and malnutrition have to be eliminated, and this has an effect on India's interests.
- It affects India's **international reputation**.
- It reduces **global competitiveness** and **strategic competitiveness**, because malnutrition-induced productivity is reduced.
- **Technological sovereignty** ambitions are compromised, because malnutrition-induced poor human capital formation increases dependence on foreign human capital.
  - If this is addressed, dependence on foreign human capital falls by itself.
- Thereby it affects India's **great power ambition**.
- It produces the **growth and human development paradox**.

COMPARISON

The growth and human development paradox.

- **Saudi Arabia, Qatar and Kuwait** have among the highest per capita incomes in the world, but women's rights, gender rights and human rights are nil — not a model India wants.
- **Denmark, South Korea, Japan, the Netherlands** and the Scandinavian and European nations are high on growth and on human development.
- India is getting 8 percent growth (7.8 percent to be precise) and has wonderfully withstood the impact of the war, but in human development it is absolutely nowhere in the race — India is the best example of the growth and human development paradox.

- This affects India's **leadership and development model** and its role as leader of the Global South.
- The Global South is looking for a development model, and India offers several state models.

Punjab model	Focus on agriculture
Kerala model	Focus on human development — let the state increase welfare measures
Delhi model	Health and education were given a stupendous hike by the Aam Aadmi Party government
Gujarat model	The crime rate is low; development and happiness concerns, including malnutrition, remain [as stated in lecture]
Andhra Pradesh model under Chandrababu Naidu	The entire IT sector was propelled by one individual in that state; it fuelled the supply of labour from India to the West through outsourcing — people work in Hyderabad and after five years move to the US to work in the parent company, which is why many Andhraites went abroad
Tamil Nadu model	Mentioned as another model, without elaboration in the lecture

- Where does India stand in the world? If malnutrition is a concern, no African nation and no Pacific nation will try to look at India.
- How can India call itself the leader of the Global South when **BRI, China, the US, Saudi Arabia** and the Scandinavian nations are already there? What makes India stand apart is exactly what is missing.
- **Multilateral platforms** are where this is handled: the **BRICS summit** (10th, 11th, 12th) and the question of managing the divide between **Iran** on one hand and the **UAE and Saudi Arabia**

on the other.

- The **SCO** offers an opportunity to bilaterally engage nations — the bilateral with the President of Iran, **Masoud Pezeshkian**, happened because of the SCO.
- The one-to-one relationship between leaders plays a very important role in deciding the trajectory of two nations and their foreign policies — camaraderie between two leaders decides the bilaterals of a nation.
- This time there was no bilateral with **Xi Jinping**; it may have been kept for BRICS and the **MEA** may have deliberately played the cards accordingly — a separate engagement at BRICS would be a major thing.
- The **SR talks**, led by the **NSA**, were just held (the **25th round**) and led to certain developments, though India is still not at the stage of de-escalation.
- This is the importance of multilateral organisations — that is what was asked in the **BRICS** question, though that lens was not stated explicitly.

QUICK REVISION

- Strategic framing: if you have to rule the world you have to use the demographic dividend; poor nutrition turns demography into a disaster rather than an opportunity.
- The US, Germany, France, South Korea and Australia cannot work without Indians — the English-speaking Indian workforce is India's social capital; the alternative, China, speaks Mandarin.
- Slower progress towards the SDGs, damaged international reputation, reduced global and strategic competitiveness, compromised technological sovereignty and a dent in great power ambition.
- The growth and human development paradox: high-income Gulf economies with nil rights versus Denmark, South Korea, Japan, the Netherlands and Scandinavia; India at 7.8 percent growth yet nowhere in human development.
- India's state models — Punjab, Kerala, Delhi, Gujarat, Andhra Pradesh under Chandrababu Naidu and Tamil Nadu — are what the Global South is looking at.
- If malnutrition persists, no African or Pacific nation will look at India, and there is already BRI, China, the US, Saudi Arabia and Scandinavia to compete with.
- BRICS and the SCO show the value of multilateral platforms and of leader-to-leader camaraderie; the SR talks (25th round, led by the NSA) are still short of de-escalation.

10.8 Steps Taken by the Government of India

The steps taken by the Government of India are written under two approaches — the **whole-of-government approach** and the **whole-of-society approach** — followed by the schemes, ministry by ministry.

- **Ministry of Women and Child Development** — implements Mission **Saksham Anganwadi** and **Poshan 2.0**.
- **Ministry of Health and Family Welfare** — runs the Primary Health Centres and addresses

children who are **SAM**.

  - **SAM** is **severe acute malnutrition**.

- **Ministry of Jal Shakti** — the **Jal Jeevan Mission**, important for water, sanitation and hygiene needs.
- **Ministry of Rural Development** is also involved.
- In government schools, poster, painting and quiz competitions are held to promote awareness of nutritional education; **Poshan Maah**, **Poshan Pakhwada** and many festivals are held under **Saksham Abhiyaan**.
- **PM POSHAN** is the scheme for children: children come to school and eat, and **700–800 kilocalories** per meal are provided; parents also send children to school for that one meal, so nutrition is promoted in that sense.

KEY CONCEPT

Supplementary information — write this in a box: the journey of nutrition governance.

- **1975 — ICDS (Integrated Child Development Services)** was launched under Indira Gandhi's government: one anganwadi centre in every village.
- ICDS focused on three groups: children **0–6 years**; **PM and LM** — pregnant mothers and lactating mothers; and **adolescent females aged 15 to 19**.
- In the ICDS approach nutrition was a **welfare service** — if nutrition was low, its supply was to be improved; ICDS was the centre from which the approach advanced.
- **2018 — Poshan Abhiyaan** was made the flagship **National Nutrition Mission**, and nutrition became a **national priority**.
- The reason for the shift: the focus on **human capital** and on the **SDGs (2015–30)** — if money is to be earned, nutrition has to be the focus.
- Poshan Abhiyaan targets: reduce stunting by **2 percent** and wasting by **3 percent** [as stated in lecture].
- Poshan Abhiyaan embedded **convergence**, brought in **digital monitoring**, called for **networked and integrated governance** and community involvement, and today brings together **20 ministries and departments** under a **unified nutrition framework**.
- **2021–2022** — the Union Budget launched **Mission Poshan 2.0**, with **Mission Saksham Anganwadi** and **Poshan 2.0** as its two schemes.
- This box is only an explanation and is not part of the main answer, but these are high-probability areas for prelims and must not be missed.

- The meaning of nutrition changed: earlier nutrition meant food, calories and food diversity through ICDS; now nutrition also means **sanitation** (food will not be digested if the water is dirty), **education and awareness**, **water**, and **women's empowerment**.
- Unless women are empowered they will not have the stakes to take decisions in the family on any matter, including child marriage; wherever there is a **self-help group**, its women members have fought elections and taken gender-specific decisions.

10.8.1 Women's Empowerment and the Judiciary — the Lecture's Digression

- India gave women the right to vote at the same platform as men at Independence, yet in 75 years there has not been a single female **Chief Justice of India**.
- Justice **Nagarathna** will be the first woman CJI in **2027**, and for not more than **50 to 60 days**; it is not her fault but the fault of the **collegium**, which is riddled with opacity.
- Mr. **Prashant Bhushan** has written that in the past 5–6 years very few Chief Justices have actually led the institution.
- At the **NALSAR** convocation the students rebelled and said they would not take their degree from the CJI; the same happened at **NLU Jodhpur** and **NLU Bangalore**, the best law institutes.
- In **January 2018**, four Supreme Court judges — **Justice Madan Lokur**, **Justice Jasti Chelameswar** (who wrote the minority judgment in the **NJAC 2015** case), **Justice Ranjan Gogoi** and **Justice Kurian Joseph** — held a press conference and said there was something utterly rotten in the way cases were being assigned in the Supreme Court; the then CJI was **Dipak Misra**.
- CJI Dipak Misra retired that year after landmark judgments, including the **Joseph Shine case (2018)**, which struck down **Section 497** (adultery); the second judgment was not recalled.
- Except for the period of **Justice Chandrachud**, the past many years have not been very exciting for the institution, which is not something to be proud of as a citizen.
- Articles have appeared on the **uncle judge syndrome**; the personal opinion expressed was that the judiciary's legacy families train you very well, and that this is a most preserved institution carrying a colonial hangover.
- Justice Nagarathna's father, **Justice Venkatachaliah**, was also CJI and led important decisions around **2003–04**.
- **Mr. Ranjan Gogoi** became a Rajya Sabha member right after resigning, and he was targeted over the sexual harassment of a law clerk, with the in-house committee in the matter headed by him.
- Justice Nagarathna's minority judgment in the mining levy case held that if every state is allowed to levy a mining levy separately, there will be a lack of uniform mining development in the country, which will affect the energy transition; the **Mines Amendment** followed to set the house in order.
- **UPSC** has asked once that there should be diversity in the judiciary; women in the judiciary were asked this year in Mains from the polity perspective — how reservation plays out in the third tier while the top tier is untouched.

10.8.2 Mission Poshan 2.0 — the Framework

- **Mission Poshan 2.0** creates a **unified and integrated framework** and subsumes three schemes: **Anganwadi Services**; **Poshan Abhiyaan**, launched in 2018; and the **Scheme for Adolescent Girls**.
- It has **three verticals**.

Nutrition support	Children 0–6 years (in practice 6 months to 6 years), pregnant women, lactating mothers and adolescent girls	Supplementary nutrition and nutritional services; the first 6 months are left out because the child has to be completely breastfed
Early childhood care and education (ECCE)	Children 3 to 6 years, with **early stimulation** for the 0–3 age group	ECCE at anganwadi centres; for the under-3s the official keyword is early stimulation — activities at the anganwadi centre that increase brain development in a toddler who cannot yet speak
Upgradation of anganwadi infrastructure	Anganwadi centres	LCD screens, the full count of children, how many students there are and which child was vaccinated when; this is now called **Saksham Anganwadi**

- The latest **PIP** records the shift: the earlier approach was **calorie-oriented** [a Parliamentary answer of 1 July was cited, as stated in lecture].
- **Poshan bhi, Padhai bhi** (recorded in the lecture as PPP) — a Ministry of Women and Child Development initiative to improve the quality of early childhood care and education at anganwadi centres; it is not nutrition alone or education alone but both, and it is working very well for civil services aspirants.
- **March 2024** — MoWCD launched two things: **Nav Chetna** and **Aadhaar Shila**.
  - **Nav Chetna** — a framework for **early childhood stimulation** for the **0–3** age group; this age check is the catch.
  - **Aadhaar Shila** — the **National Curriculum for Early Childhood Care and Education**, for ages **3–6**, available in **12 languages**.
- Schemes have to be absorbed and felt; they cannot be learnt by reading a scheme document at the end — a scheme document stays a document.

10.8.3 Technology Governance, Grievance Redressal and Community Engagement

- The foundation for technology governance was laid by **Poshan Abhiyaan**.
- **Poshan Tracker**, launched in **2021**, is a digital platform for nutrition governance.
- It has ensured monitoring of **infrastructure and service delivery** and facilitated **real-time data collection** for anganwadi services.
  - The data collected covers the **daily attendance of children**, **ECCE activities** and **growth monitoring**.

- **Catch them young** here means growth monitoring: tracking the child's body development — the weight in one month, supplementation for malnutrition, and the weight after two, three and eight months.
- If the condition is still poor the child is referred to a **Nutrition Rehabilitation Centre**, which comes under the **National Health Mission**.
- Recently the **FRS — Facial Recognition System** — has been introduced.
- **Grievance redressal**: the **Poshan Helpline 14408**.
- **Community engagement** is very important for nutrition — people have to know about nutrition; under Poshan Abhiyaan, nutrition has become a **Jan Andolan**.
- **Poshan Pakhwada** is a **two-week intensive outreach for community mobilisation**, held **once every year in April** under Mission 2.0; this year (2026) it was held in April.
  - Pakhwada is neither a week nor a month — it is a fortnight.
- This year's theme was **brain development**, because **85 percent** of a child's brain development happens by age 6, and most of it in the **first 3 years**.
- In the first three years a village child goes to the anganwadi centre, so it is very important to tell the whole society that brain development takes place at a lightning pace in the first three years.
- **Poshan Maah** is also observed along with it, as part of community outreach.
- In the examination the schemes can be written ministry-wise or scheme-wise — it is your choice.

10.8.4 *Schemes, Ministry by Ministry*

- **Ministry of Health and Family Welfare**
  - **Anemia Mukt Bharat**, started in **2018** — iron and folic acid supplementation for women and children.
  - A question on folic acid supplementation came in prelims two years ago.
  - The best source of iron is **nutritional education** — green leafy vegetables such as spinach.
  - Spinach should not be eaten in the monsoon because worms sit on the green leaves; clean it and wash it in hot water. It should not be eaten at night because iron-rich foods are tough to digest — have it as a vegetable in the afternoon; in winter a lot of spinach can be eaten. This is nutritional advocacy.
  - PIB says MoHFW keeps a record of children and women suffering from **anaemia** — data is the oil.
- **FSSAI — Food Safety and Standards Authority of India** sets standards for **fortification** and generates awareness about foods high in **fats, salt and sugar**; whatever is processed is 100 percent high in salt and sugar.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **Global brands, Indian labels — the sugar question.**
>
> - Global brands add sugar in India that they do not add in European and Western countries: the same brand's same products are loaded with sugar in India, and Nestlé's products in India

and in the parent country are totally different in terms of quality.

- India is far behind on **food labelling**, while more than **130–140 nations** have acted at a vehement pace in the last 10 years to address malnutrition and food labelling.
- FSSAI enforces labelling norms: calories and the sugar and compounds added are printed on every product, and restaurants and hotels now display calories; FSSAI norms require the **portion size** to be declared so that people know what they are eating.
- **Mother Dairy** products — lassi, mishti doi and chocolate milk — are loaded with sugar (at least 10, 15 to 20 grams); never have them, they are the worst form of milk product with added sugar. The best form of energy is one or two bananas a day — befriend a fruit seller and sign a long-term strategic deal instead.
- This discussion becomes more relevant when obesity is taken up.

- **National Food Security Act 2013** — provides food and nutritional security **as a legal right**; **millets** have been included as part of the **Targeted Public Distribution System**.
- **Ministry of Agriculture** — the **National Mission on Natural Farming**.
- **CDP — Crop Diversification Programme** under the **Rashtriya Krishi Vikas Yojana**.
- Last year the **National Food Security Mission** was renamed the **National Food and Nutrition Mission (NFSNM)**.
- Refer the crop diversification notes — this is more than enough for GS2 current affairs; do not write all the food-system schemes, one or two are enough because the discussion is about food systems.
- **PM Matru Vandana Yojana** — Rs. 5,000 is provided on the birth of the first child, for wage compensation and nutritious food.
- **PM POSHAN** is under the **Ministry of Education** — hot cooked meals for children in Balvatika or pre-school and in classes 1 to 8; it addresses hunger and education; this is the midday meal scheme.
- For **WASH**: the **Swachh Bharat Mission** aims to prevent open defecation — open defecation has been eliminated, but cultural norms still prevent people.
- The **Jal Jeevan Mission** brings **piped drinking water** to every household.

QUICK REVISION

- The steps are written as the whole-of-government and whole-of-society approaches, then ministry by ministry: Women and Child Development (Saksham Anganwadi, Poshan 2.0), Health and Family Welfare (PHCs, SAM — severe acute malnutrition), Jal Shakti (Jal Jeevan Mission) and Rural Development.
- Boxed journey: ICDS 1975 (anganwadi in every village, 0–6 children, pregnant and lactating mothers, adolescent girls 15–19, nutrition as a welfare service) → Poshan Abhiyaan 2018 (flagship National Nutrition Mission, national priority, human capital and the SDGs, 20 ministries, unified framework) → Mission Poshan 2.0 (2021–22 budget).
- Mission Poshan 2.0 subsumes Anganwadi Services, Poshan Abhiyaan and the Scheme for Adolescent Girls, and runs three verticals: nutrition support, early childhood care and

education (early stimulation for 0–3), and upgradation of anganwadi infrastructure (Saksham Anganwadi).

- PIB additions: the calorie-oriented PIP now shifted, Poshan bhi Padhai bhi, and the March 2024 launches Nav Chetna (0–3 stimulation) and Aadhaar Shila (ECCE curriculum for 3–6, in 12 languages).
- Technology governance: Poshan Tracker (2021) for real-time data, daily attendance, ECCE activities and growth monitoring, referral to a Nutrition Rehabilitation Centre under the National Health Mission, FRS, and the Poshan Helpline 14408.
- Community engagement: Jan Andolan, Poshan Pakhwada in April (two-week outreach; theme of brain development, 85 percent of brain development by age 6 and most of it in the first 3 years), Poshan Maah.
- Ministry-wise schemes: Anemia Mukt Bharat (2018, iron and folic acid), FSSAI (fortification, labelling norms), National Food Security Act 2013 (food security as a legal right, millets in the TPDS), National Mission on Natural Farming, CDP under Rashtriya Krishi Vikas Yojana, NFSNM, PM Matru Vandana Yojana (Rs. 5,000), PM POSHAN, Swachh Bharat Mission and Jal Jeevan Mission.

10.9 Way Forward

The way forward addresses the challenges and the causes already seen; it touches the same legs already discussed and the list can go on and on.

- **Dietary diversity will come only when there is supply**, so the first requirement is agri and food related change.
- Educate people about **nutritional awareness** — a feeling of nutritional education and awareness has to be created.
- The schemes have started, but they will not be complete until nutrition enters the schools; school is a very important place of learning.
  - The idea of **responsible nutrition** has to be promoted in schools. The school chart-making activity was recalled: the charts carried 2–3 marks as extracurricular credit and were put up on the board, so that at least all the children saw them.
  - In the top schools the parents are also held accountable; the parents have to be accountable.
- Governance is fragmented, and convergence will now have to happen at every level.
- **Technological change**: AI can be the biggest use of the data lying in the **Poshan Tracker**.
- There is no **one-size-fits-all** strategy — diets for students and for mothers can be tailored to their cultural, social, religious and regional norms.
  - GPT-type tools can compute the best particular combination of supplementary nutrition for a given body and area, which makes the government's task easier.
- **WASH** has to be a focus (the lecture also spoke of a water-mission-driven implementation, a phrase that was unclear); **Swachh Bharat Mission** cleanliness and **rural hygiene** have to be made a focus.
- Most important is **spreading awareness** — FSSAI's work is very important, and in an urbanised

setting everything turns on awareness.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **Should labelling be mandated? The two positions.**
>
> - **For it**: a sticker saying high in sugar on mishti doi and other sweet drinks would ring a bell in the consumer's head — but if that were done, nothing could be eaten either. The consumer has to be informed and allowed to make the choice, because increasing the disease burden cannot be a logic.
> - **The government's position**: these labelling norms are the West's issues and cannot be superimposed on India; if samosas and such products had to be labelled, many people would stop selling them; certain practices, even if unhealthy, are an organic part and people will organically change their food practices.
> - **The response to it**: that organic change will never happen — the norm is still the way to inform the consumer.

- Head one: **sustainable agricultural practices**; **agro-forestry**, **horticulture** and **aquaculture** were dictated as the heads that follow.
- With these, people have been provided with good food — the provision side of the job is done.

Behavioural Change — the Next Head, and the Most Important

1. **Nutritional communication should be culturally grounded** — do not tell a vegetarian to eat eggs, and do not tell a non-vegetarian to take only plant proteins; communication has to be effective and, as studied in ethics, persuasive. Provide the food available in the local food chain; this also ensures **climate resilience**, because nothing has to be brought from a foreign land.
2. **Joint capacity building** of **anganwadi workers**, **ASHAs** and **ANMs (Auxiliary Nurse Midwife)** in advising families on improving dietary practices. (The class was asked to use GPT to find the difference between the three.)
3. **Role of the Gram Sabha** — child nutrition should be the focus and an important agenda, along with upgradation of **anganwadi infra** and **safe drinking water and sanitation**.
4. **Ensure multi-sectoral governance and engage NGOs** — several NGOs in India have developed **crèche models** that combine **childcare plus nutrition plus early learning**. A crèche does not merely take care of the child: it ensures nutrition and provides early stimulation or early childhood care, as discussed in **Aadhaar Shila** and **Nav Chetna**. NGOs are already expert in this work, so bring them forward and promote them — this is an example of **integrated governance**.
5. **Promote female empowerment** — until women are given strength the nutrition problem will remain. This means promoting the **care economy**; engaging men in child care and the sharing of domestic responsibilities; and promoting the **anganwadi as a one-stop hub for women's welfare**.
6. **Promote social protection** by embedding nutrition in government schemes such as **subsidised food grain** and **PM POSHAN**, and focusing on **mother and child** — the mother's and the child's nutritional needs cannot be seen separately.

7. **Use of technology** — artificial intelligence and other digital tools — for (1) analysis of **anthropometric data**, (2) **nutritional counselling**, and (3) proper capacity building of anganwadi workers to address **digital literacy and the digital divide**.

- **Esther Duflo**, the Nobel Prize winner, has argued that when women control extra income they are more likely to spend on nutrition and children's well-being.

EXAMPLE

Student doubt, answered.

- A student asked about the article recently suggesting a **health tax**.
- The answer: yes — a case study of **Saudi Arabia** will be given, and there are many studies that will be given in the **obesity** class.

QUICK REVISION

- Way forward mirrors the challenges: agricultural and food change first, because dietary diversity comes only with supply, plus nutritional education and awareness; promote responsible nutrition in schools with parents accountable, and drive convergence at every level because governance is fragmented.
- Use AI on the data lying in the Poshan Tracker: no one-size-fits-all strategy, diets tailored to cultural, social, religious and regional norms.
- Focus on WASH, Swachh Bharat Mission cleanliness and rural hygiene, and most importantly on spreading awareness — FSSAI's work matters most in urban settings.
- The labelling debate: the case for informing the consumer versus the government's position that Western norms cannot be superimposed on India; organic change, the lecture held, will never happen.
- Agricultural heads: sustainable agricultural practices, agro-forestry, horticulture and aquaculture — provision of good food is then done.
- Behavioural change: culturally grounded communication, joint capacity building of anganwadi workers, ASHAs and ANMs, the role of the Gram Sabha, multi-sectoral governance with NGO crèche models, female empowerment (care economy, men in child care, anganwadi as a one-stop hub), social protection embedding nutrition, and technology for anthropometric analysis, counselling and digital literacy.
- Esther Duflo: when women control extra income they spend more on nutrition and children's well-being; the health tax doubt was answered with a promise of the Saudi Arabia case study in the obesity class.

10.10 Answer Framework: Malnutrition as a Public Health, Social Equity, Human Development and Welfare Governance Challenge

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

The question.

- **Malnutrition is not merely a public health problem but also a challenge of social equity, human development and effective welfare governance. Discuss.**
- Given as a **10-marker**, to be written as a **15-marker**, in **10 minutes**.

- First **underline the keywords**. The question says malnutrition is not merely a public health problem; it is also a challenge of **social equity, human development and effective welfare governance**.
- Structure the answer as **intro, body and conclusion** — first things first: state what is asked.

10.10.1 Introduction — About 20 Words

- Write in about 20 words: **India is facing a unique nutritional transition where it suffers from the double burden of nutrition** — under-nutrition, shown through wasting, stunting and underweight, and over-nutrition, shown through obesity.
- Show it instead of merely writing that it is a multi-dimensional issue — which is what most answers wrote.
- Two diagrams are carried over from the class: one for under-nutrition and one for over-nutrition.

10.10.2 Body — The Four Heads

Head 1: Malnutrition as a Public Health Challenge

- Malnutrition leads to increased vulnerability to **non-communicable diseases** and increases the possibility of infection, and thereby leads to increased health **out-of-pocket expenditure**.
- On the over-nutrition side, obesity leads to **type 2 diabetes**, **hypertension** and increased vulnerability to **kidney, pancreas and even cancer**.
- Malnutrition is both over-nutrition and under-nutrition — both dimensions are shown as public health challenges. This head runs to about **50 words**.

Head 2: Malnutrition as a Social Equity Challenge

- The **poverty trap**: the poor are more susceptible to under-nutrition — draw the **vicious circle** diagram.
- Increased vulnerability of deprived sections, where malnutrition is a cause and a consequence of the already existing societal divide.
  - Example: **SC, ST and OBC women** have higher malnutrition rates.
- The increase in **female obesity** is also to be shown, because malnutrition is not only under-nutrition — obesity also includes women. **NFHS Round 6** statistics were given for this.
- Therefore an **intersectional approach is a must**.

- Social equity simply means existing societal divides — class, caste, tribe, male versus female, male and female versus transgender, and other vulnerable groups such as the **PVTG (primitive vulnerable tribal groups)**.

Head 3: Malnutrition as a Human Development Challenge

- Malnutrition leads to poor **cognitive ability**, which leads to **learning deficit**, which leads to **productivity deficit**, which leads to poor **human capital formation**.
- Nutrition is the **bridge between education and the demographic dividend** — good education plus skill development shall not lead to the demographic dividend if malnutrition is persistent.
- Malnutrition leads to loss of work and education hours, as it increases vulnerability to diseases and infection, thereby causing **absenteeism** and impacting the **Human Development Index**.
- Diagram: **health plus education plus skill development** all depend on nutrition for the demographic dividend — nutrition as a bridge.
- Every part of human development — health, skill development, education and nutrition — can be shown separately on the diagram; as many diagrams as needed may be drawn.

Head 4: Malnutrition as an Effective Welfare Governance Challenge

- It requires **targeting of beneficiaries**.
- It requires **fiscal spending on both** over-nutrition and under-nutrition.
- It requires **upgradation of anganwadi centres**, which are currently facing challenges.

10.10.3 Conclusion

- In the light of the multi-dimensional challenge, India's approach is **whole of government and whole of society**, with **Mission Poshan Abhiyaan 2.0** as the flagship scheme, focusing on **digital, convergent, multi-sectoral and integrated governance**.
- The shift from **ICDS to Poshan Abhiyaan to Mission Poshan 2.0** can also be shown here, along with the diagram — and if there is no scope in the body, the diagram can be shown in the conclusion.

10.10.4 If It Is Written as a 10-Marker

- Write **only the points**, with no substantiation; the intersectional approach, the obesity point and the diagrams can be left out, and the intro and the outro take one line each.
- Out of 150 words only about 110–120 will actually be written, because there will not be that much time in the examination hall.
- **Nip the question in the bud** by giving its exact premise — India is facing a double burden of nutrition, which includes over-nutrition and under-nutrition; first, because it is multi-dimensional, the challenge as public health; second, the challenge of social equity; and so on.
- The substantiating points that get left out become the **differentiator** in the examination hall, because time is short.

QUICK REVISION

- The question: malnutrition is not merely a public health problem but also a challenge of social equity, human development and effective welfare governance — a 10-marker to be written as a 15-marker in 10 minutes.
- Underline the keywords first, answer exactly what is asked, and structure as intro, body and conclusion.
- Introduction in about 20 words: India faces a unique nutritional transition with a double burden — under-nutrition (wasting, stunting, underweight) and over-nutrition (obesity), shown through two diagrams rather than declared as multi-dimensional.
- Body: four heads — public health (NCD vulnerability, infection, out-of-pocket expenditure; obesity, type 2 diabetes, hypertension, kidney, pancreas, cancer), social equity (poverty trap and vicious circle, deprived sections such as SC, ST, OBC women, female obesity and NFHS Round 6, hence an intersectional approach), human development (cognitive → learning → productivity → human capital deficits, nutrition as the bridge to the demographic dividend, absenteeism and the HDI), and welfare governance (targeting beneficiaries, fiscal spending on both over- and under-nutrition, upgradation of anganwadi centres).
- Conclusion: whole of government and whole of society, with Mission Poshan Abhiyaan 2.0 as the flagship, focused on digital, convergent, multi-sectoral and integrated governance; the ICDS → Poshan Abhiyaan → Poshan 2.0 shift can be shown here.
- For a 10-marker write only the points — drop the diagrams and the substantiation, keep a one-line intro and outro, and give the exact premise of the question to nip it in the bud.
- The substantiating points left out are what differentiate answers, because the examination hall leaves no time.

10.11 Additional Governance Challenge to Record

One more point was to be added to the governance challenges already written earlier.

- In the governance challenges, write down that there is **limited focus on women outside the reproductive age, men and senior citizens**.

QUICK REVISION

- Add to the governance challenges: limited focus on women outside the reproductive age.
- The same gap applies to men.
- And to senior citizens.

CHAPTER 11

Malnutrition in India — Part 3: Challenges of Malnutrition

11.1 Framing the Challenges of Malnutrition

This part takes up the **challenges of malnutrition** and the way forward. Challenges, issues and concerns of malnutrition are one and the same — whatever is written for the issues or the concerns is also written for the challenges, and all of it is kept under a single heading.

Before listing them, a **framework** is required — a way of organising how the challenges are to be written and how they are to be addressed.

- Economic issues or concerns — where an individual is not economically well off and therefore automatically becomes nutritionally insecure.
  - Poverty makes people incapable of addressing their nutrition concerns; the economic situation, and poverty itself, must be addressed in order to address malnutrition.
- Social challenges — the societal divide within society that produces division.
  - The division (for example along SC, ST lines) has to be addressed first if malnutrition is to be addressed.
- Agriculture and food-system related challenges — whatever is eaten, whatever is served on the platter, is produced in the system, and agricultural policies decide what is to be grown.
  - If agriculture supplies only rice and wheat, the food system itself is responsible; despite affordability and access, nutritional insecurity cannot be addressed.
- Political or institutional / governance-related challenges — several schemes and several ministries whose coordination is required, several tiers of governance, and NGOs, civil society and self-help groups as different players.
  - The third tier of governance must be involved in the delivery of nutritional schemes.
- WASH-related challenges — water, sanitation and hygiene.
  - Even if a person eats well, a lack of proper hygiene means the body will not absorb that food.
- Maternal and intergenerational challenge — the most important challenge, because from here malnutrition gets transferred.
  - If the mother does not have nutritional security, that poor maternal nutrition gets transferred to the child.
- Cultural or behavioural challenges — the limited propensity or limited knowledge among citizens about the importance of nutrition, and food practices carried over years and generations

that act as a hindrance.

  - Examples: preference for vegetarian over non-vegetarian food; restriction on the consumption of eggs.

KEY CONCEPT

The framework, in sequence.

- Economic · Social · Agriculture and food system · Political / institutional / governance · WASH · Maternal and intergenerational · Cultural or behavioural.
- Governance and institutional challenges include the framework of **Aanganwadi centres** — the working pillars of the Ministry of Women and Child Development for addressing nutrition.
- Challenges, issues and concerns are treated as the same and written together as one.

QUICK REVISION

- Challenges = issues = concerns of malnutrition; all written under one heading.
- Always give a framework before listing the challenges.
- Seven baskets of challenges: economic, social, agri–food system, political/institutional, WASH, maternal–intergenerational and cultural/behavioural.
- Agricultural policy decides what is grown, and hence what the food system supplies.
- Delivery of nutritional schemes needs the third tier of governance, along with NGOs, civil society and self-help groups.
- Aanganwadi centres are the working pillars of the Ministry of Women and Child Development for nutrition.

11.2 Economic Challenges

Economic challenges are those where an individual is not economically well off and therefore automatically ends up becoming nutritionally insecure. Under this head the class discussed the poverty trap, migration-induced malnutrition and regional disparities.

11.2.1 The Poverty Trap

- The **poverty trap** means that poor or limited income limits access to food, to nutrition or to dietary diversity.
  - Fruits, vegetables, meat and milk — important sources of diet — become beyond affordability.
- Money is the first constraint: even if everything is available in the market, because people are poor they still end up with malnutrition.
- Even if food is provided, so long as access remains limited, this is the first case of poverty acting as a trap.

1. Poverty
2. Limited access to nutritional food
3. Malnutrition

4. Low cognitive abilities
5. Poor learning
6. Poor skill development or poor education
7. Further poverty

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Poverty–malnutrition trap (diagram to draw).**
>
> - **Poverty is both the cause and the consequence of malnutrition** — poverty causes malnutrition, and poverty is also a consequence of malnutrition.
> - Draw this as the **poverty–malnutrition trap** (poverty–malnutrition vicious cycle), with the chain looping back into poverty.
> - The argument being made is that poverty not only leads to malnutrition; malnutrition also leads to poverty.

11.2.2 Migration-Induced Malnutrition

- A big chunk of the migrant workforce suffers from **migration-induced malnutrition**.
- Example: street vendors and informal marketplaces in Delhi, in the surrounding area or in any metropolitan city are migrants from nearby states.
  - Whenever the crops have to be harvested, they go back — a frequent shunting between host and destination.
- This frequent shunting makes them incapable of getting themselves registered on government records, so they do not get access to the **PDS**.
- **Seasonal and circular migration** — people frequently moving between villages and cities — leads to a series of disruptions:
- Disruption in **Aanganwadi registration**, where the nutrition benefits provided by the Ministry of Women and Child Development are obtained.
- Disruption in **supplementary nutrition** provided to 0–6 year olds, to lactating and pregnant mothers, and to adolescents.
  - When they shift frequently, they end up getting deleted as beneficiaries.
- Disruption in **immunization**, in **growth monitoring** and in **antenatal care**.
- **Antenatal** care is when the child is not born and the mother is in the state of pregnancy; **postnatal** care is after the child has been born.
- Because migration moves a person from the city to a new city, or from the village to a new city, it automatically creates a problem of access to the services that have been provided.

11.2.3 Regional and Intra-State Disparities

- **Regional disparity** means that different states, and different regions within states, have different nutritional standards.
- This can be written as a **societal challenge**, because it is an example of a societal divide — societies in forward states are comparatively ahead and need a different strategy, while societies in backward states need a different strategy.

- It is also a **governance challenge**, because the approach cannot be a one-size-fits-all approach.
- It is also an **economic challenge**; it can be written as a social challenge, as a socio-economic challenge, or even as a fragmented challenge.

DATA & FACTS

Latest numbers cited (NFHS Round 5 vs Round 6).

- Jharkhand — underweight children have actually **increased from 39.4% to 41.1%**.
- UP and Rajasthan — there has been an **increase in wasting** and an **increase in underweight children**.
- National Family Health Survey (NFHS) data recently released in **May this year**: for India, wasting has, if not increased, **remained the same — no progress**; in these states it is increasing.
- Stunting — **Kerala 20%**, **Bihar 35.6%**, **Jharkhand 35%**.

The figures point to **interstate disparity in nutritional outcomes**, and to stunting being a major concern with respect to the division between states. Both sets of states are totally different, so the approaches also have to be totally different.

CRITICAL POINT

- Therefore India **cannot have a one-size-fits-all approach** as far as nutritional governance is concerned.
- Even within a single state the same caution applies.

- **Intra-state divide** (backwardness within a state): in Karnataka, **North Karnataka** has a higher prevalence of child malnutrition compared to Bangalore, Mysore or Mangalore.
  - The relatively backward districts cited are **Bidar, Ballari, Raichur, Kalaburagi and Yadgir** — comparatively backward regions within the forward state of Karnataka.
- So even within Karnataka a one-size-fits-all approach cannot be used to discuss the problem of malnutrition.

QUICK REVISION

- Economic challenge = not economically well off → nutritionally insecure.
- Poverty trap: limited income limits access to food and dietary diversity; fruits, vegetables, meat, milk go beyond affordability.
- Poverty is cause and consequence of malnutrition (poverty–malnutrition trap / vicious cycle).
- Migration-induced malnutrition: seasonal/circular migration → no registration on records → no PDS; disruptions in Aanganwadi registration, supplementary nutrition, immunization, growth monitoring and antenatal care.
- Antenatal = before birth; postnatal = after birth.
- Regional disparity is societal + governance + economic; no one-size-fits-all.
- Data: Jharkhand underweight 39.4% → 41.1%; Kerala stunting 20%, Bihar 35.6%, Jharkhand

35%; India's wasting unchanged.

- Intra-state divide: North Karnataka (Bidar, Ballari, Raichur, Kalaburagi, Yadgir) behind Bangalore, Mysore, Mangalore.

11.3 Agriculture and Food-System Challenges

These are the challenges where nutritional insecurity and malnutrition exist because the agriculture policy and the food systems are themselves not producing enough. This is a major challenge.

- Even if the system is producing enough, the focus is on **producing more and more**; the focus of agriculture in the country has been on producing more, and not on providing nutritional security.
- The focus is on **calorie or food security** rather than on **nutritional security**.
- The focus is on **rice and wheat** and on **monoculture practices**, driven by the government's **MSP policy** and by the **Green Revolution**.
  - The Green Revolution played a very important role, as it began with hybrid crops of rice and wheat.
- There is **limited crop diversification**.
  - A crop diversification scheme is run by the Ministry of Agriculture, but overall crop diversification remains limited. The crop diversification programme is surely part of agriculture and is taken up separately later.
- There is **limited focus on IFS — Integrated Farming Systems** — and on natural farming, conservation agriculture or organic farming, which has led to **limited dietary diversity**.
- Because of the rice-and-wheat focus, there is limited production of fruits, vegetables, milk, eggs, meat and other protein sources.
- The result is the promotion of a **cereal-dominated diet**.
  - A cereal-dominated diet means either rice or wheat. Other cereals include bajra, ragi and mota chana — the **coarse cereals**. Focus on these areas too is important for nutritional diversity.
- Nutritional insecurity is therefore not only a problem of people not being aware (awareness can be one reason), but also a problem of the food system not producing enough.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- The Government of India has renamed the **National Food Security Mission** as the **National Food Security and Nutrition Mission** in **2025**.
- This renaming itself tells you the problem being discussed — a shift from food security alone towards nutritional security.

QUICK REVISION

- Agri–food system challenges: the system is not producing enough, or is not producing for nutritional security.

- Focus on calorie/food security over nutritional security; rice-wheat monoculture due to MSP policy and the Green Revolution.
- Limited crop diversification despite the Ministry of Agriculture's crop diversification scheme.
- Limited focus on IFS (Integrated Farming Systems), natural and organic farming → limited dietary diversity.
- Rice-wheat focus → limited fruits, vegetables, milk, eggs, meat and other protein sources; promotion of a cereal-dominated (coarse cereal) diet.
- National Food Security Mission renamed the National Food Security and Nutrition Mission in 2025.

11.4 Maternal and Intergenerational Challenge

This is a very important challenge — the **maternal and intergenerational challenge**. It means that malnutrition is primarily a problem in the child, because there is a transfer of malnutrition from the adolescent female: she gets married, she becomes a mother, and when she gives birth to a child, that child ends up carrying malnutrition through generations.

KEY CONCEPT

Malnutrition through generations (diagram to draw).

- The diagram is called **malnutrition through generations** or malnutrition passed through generations.
- The idea is that **malnutrition reproduces itself across generations** — malnutrition is inherited.
- A child does not merely become malnourished by eating badly; it has been passed to it from the mother.

11.4.1 The Intergenerational Cycle of Malnutrition

1. An adolescent girl who is malnourished because of limited education, limited decision-making choice and societal factors such as patriarchy — females commonly eat their food in the end and eat the diet that is least in terms of nutrition.
2. She marries and becomes a mother with poor maternal nutrition and anaemia.
3. She gives birth to a child, who is suffering from wasting, stunting and undernutrition.
4. When this child grows into an adolescent, he or she is again malnourished.
5. If that adolescent is a female, she again becomes a malnourished adolescent girl, and the cycle repeats.

This is the **intergenerational cycle of malnutrition**. If malnutrition in the country is to be addressed, the entire cycle must be addressed — you cannot look only at the child or only at the mother. Placed in brackets in the answer: **therefore a life cycle approach is required**.

KEY CONCEPT

Life cycle approach.

- You cannot look only at the child or only at the mother, because the mother was herself an adolescent and, before that, a child some fifteen years earlier.
- Measures must therefore be adopted for all of them — mother, adolescent and child — which is the **life cycle approach**.
- This is the approach followed under **Mission Poshan Abhiyaan**, already discussed among the steps.

11.4.2 Poor Maternal Nutrition

- **Poor maternal nutrition** arises from several factors.
- **Anaemia** — deficiency of iron.
- **Low maternal weight**.
- **Poor diet during pregnancy** — the most important part, because it is what the mother eats.
- **Inadequate care** — antenatal care.

DATA & FACTS

- NFHS Round 6: only **37.8% of mothers consumed iron and folic acid tablets for 180 days or more** during pregnancy.
- Iron plays a very important role in the mother's health and nutrition. So if only about 38–40% of women consume it, the rest, about 60%, do not.
- This means poor nutrition is automatically passed on to the child — a major problem explaining why the child's nutrition comes from the mother.

11.4.3 Postnatal Care and the First 1000 Days

- In **postnatal care** the most essential point is the period of 0–6 months, when the child is to be **only breast-fed**.
- After 6 months, up to about six years, **complementary feeding** is introduced; the whole period runs up to 2 years.
- **Lack of exclusive breast-feeding** — very important for the first 6 months, when the child must take exclusive mother's milk and nothing else.
- **Lack of timely introduction of complementary feeding** — the child must be given the right food at the right time, from after 6 months.
- In **Ayurveda**, feeding the child khichdi, rice or grains at 6 months is called **Annaprashan** (the first time the child eats something); it is very important to give this at the right time.
- If complementary feed is not given right after 6 months, **nutritional needs are compromised**.
- Other factors matter: the **frequency of feeding**, and the **right quantity and diversity** of complementary feed.

KEY CONCEPT

The first 1000 days.

- The first 1000 days are counted from the date the **mother conceives** — not from the birth of the child.
- They comprise the 9 months before birth, plus 6 months of exclusive breast-feeding after birth, plus the period up to 2 years.
- These first 1000 days are very important for the government and for the country.

The latest data on breast-feeding and complementary feeding are startling facts — presented from NFHS Round 6 and compared with Round 5.

DATA & FACTS

NFHS Round 6 — startling facts.

- Only **60% of children between 6 and 8 months** received solid or semi-solid foods along with breast-feeding — complementary feeding should have been introduced timely for all.
- Exclusive breast-feeding among infants under 6 months has **fallen from 64% to almost 56%** between NFHS Round 5 and NFHS Round 6.
- **UP** has fallen from **60% to 34.6%** — almost a 25-point decline; there has also been a decline in **Jharkhand** and **Rajasthan**.
- **Kerala** has instead **increased from 55.5% to 71.7%** — Kerala has performed very well on exclusive breast-feeding.

For the entire country the trend is declining, and UP has seen almost a 25-point decline. This shows where the problem of breast-feeding practices and mother-to-child nutrition is leading.

CRITICAL POINT

The mother is **not** being blamed: she is involved in several activities — domestic care and many other tasks — and this ends up compromising the nutrition of the child.

11.4.4 Other Gender-Related Concerns

- **Low female education** limits nutritional awareness.
  - Low female education automatically limits understanding of the nutritional requirement, of breast-feeding, of complementary feeding, of immunization, of hygiene and of healthcare. The female's own knowledge and education level is low, so all these factors come into play and lead to poor nutritional standards of the female, which then get transferred to the child.
- **Gender discrimination** with respect to receiving nutritious food in the family.
- **Limited decision-making power**, which affects several things:
  - Reproductive choices — how many children the female can have; males have the say, so the female is subjected to repeated pregnancy, which affects her choices and her diet.
  - How much money is to be spent on food, on food expenditure or on the feeding of children, and at what frequency the children are to be fed.

  - Access to health facilities, especially in the rural areas — when going for institutional delivery, females do not have the decision-making power, because males or other family members decide where the delivery is to take place.
- Hence, placed in brackets in the answer: **therefore, to address malnutrition, female empowerment must be addressed**. Unless women are empowered, no practice of addressing malnutrition can be ensured.
- **Limited domestic care services** force females to perform a **double task or double burden** — domestic household care along with economic services, i.e. participating in income generation.
  - If a female is made to do two things at one time, the concern of malnutrition remains unaddressed: limited time is left to take care of the child, for breast-feeding and for complementary feeding.

QUICK REVISION

- Maternal and intergenerational challenge: malnutrition is transferred from the adolescent female to the child and carried through generations.
- Diagram: malnutrition through generations — malnutrition reproduces itself across generations and is inherited.
- The intergenerational cycle: malnourished adolescent girl → mother (poor maternal nutrition, anaemia) → child (wasting, stunting, undernutrition) → adolescent again → cycle.
- Therefore a life cycle approach is required — the approach of Mission Poshan Abhiyaan.
- Poor maternal nutrition = anaemia (iron deficiency), low maternal weight, poor diet during pregnancy and inadequate antenatal care.
- Data: only 37.8% mothers took iron and folic acid tablets for 180 days or more (NFHS Round 6).
- First 1000 days are counted from conception; exclusive breast-feeding for 6 months, complementary feeding after 6 months, up to 2 years.
- Lack of exclusive breast-feeding and delayed complementary feeding compromise nutrition; Annaprashan is the Ayurvedic first feeding at 6 months.
- Exclusive breast-feeding fell 64% → ~56%; UP 60% → 34.6%; decline in Jharkhand and Rajasthan; Kerala rose 55.5% → 71.7%.
- Gender concerns: low female education, gender discrimination in food, limited decision-making power, and the double burden → address female empowerment.

11.5 WASH-Related Challenges

KEY CONCEPT

WASH.

- **W** — Water.
- **A** — not applicable; the word is **WASH**: Water, Sanitation, Hygiene.
- **S** — Sanitation.

- **H** — Hygiene.

- **Poor sanitation and unsafe water** lead to diarrhoea, intestinal infection, parasitic infestation and environmental enteric dysfunction.
- **Environmental enteric dysfunction** means that if there is contamination of water, or open defecation, the microbes feeding on that faeces end up reaching the food system and the body — and all of this leads to **poor absorption of nutrients**.

There is also the **disease–malnutrition vicious cycle**.

1. Malnutrition → weaker immunity.
2. Infection because of poor sanitation and hygiene.
3. Infection and poor hygiene cause disease (for example typhoid, diarrhoea, cholera).
4. Disease leads to poor absorption and to weight loss — a person may lose 5, 7, 8 or 9 kilos.
5. Once weight loss happens, the nutrients that are eaten are not absorbed, and malnutrition returns.
6. Malnutrition again leads to weak immunity, and any disease brings the person back to malnutrition.

So **disease and malnutrition form a vicious cycle**, which is propelled ahead by the problem of poor sanitation. That is why the government, in the steps discussed, is doing the following.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- **Swachh Bharat Mission** — to eliminate open defecation.
- **Jal Jeevan Mission** — to provide water that is absolutely non-contaminated, potable and drinkable, i.e. piped drinking water to the societies.

QUICK REVISION

- WASH = Water, Sanitation and Hygiene.
- Poor sanitation and unsafe water → diarrhoea, intestinal infection, parasitic infestation, environmental enteric dysfunction.
- Environmental enteric dysfunction: faecal microbes reach the food system and body → poor absorption of nutrients.
- Disease–malnutrition vicious cycle: malnutrition → weak immunity → infection → disease → poor absorption → malnutrition.
- Weight loss (5–9 kg) from diseases such as typhoid, diarrhoea, cholera worsens absorption.
- Government response: Swachh Bharat Mission (end open defecation) and Jal Jeevan Mission (piped potable drinking water).

11.6 Socio-Cultural Challenges

11.6.1 Societal Divide

- **Societal divide**: the deprived and vulnerable sections have a higher rate of malnutrition.
- Examples: **scheduled castes**, the **disabled** and **women** — they are more vulnerable, have a higher rate of malnutrition and are more susceptible to any concern emanating out of malnutrition.
- Therefore the societal divide that is prevalent has to be addressed.
- The **regional divide** can also be added here.

11.6.2 Intersection of Vulnerabilities

- For certain sections there is an **intersection of vulnerabilities**.
- Example: an individual who is **disabled**, is a **female**, comes from a **deprived caste or tribe** and is also **poor**.
- Disability, gender-wise vulnerability, poverty and a deprived background all overlap to produce an intersection of vulnerability — and all of them together create a big challenge for addressing malnutrition.

KEY CONCEPT

- Placed in brackets in the answer: **therefore an intersectional approach is required to address malnutrition**.
- The experiences of a male individual from an ST community will be different from those of someone from these vulnerable sections.
- Hence a one-size-fits-all approach cannot be there — policies need to incorporate these different changes.

11.6.3 Cultural or Behavioural Challenges

- **Poor nutritional awareness**.
- **Traditional food practices** limit the adoption of nutritional guidelines or nutritional awareness.
- **Pregnant women or young children are discouraged from eating particular food** because of beliefs and customs.
  - Every household has certain beliefs and practices that may not hold good with respect to nutrition, and that is surely a concern for nutritional insecurity in the country.

EXAMPLE

- The simplest example is the **consumption of eggs**, which many will agree with.
- In certain households eggs are avoided; this is not being judged as good or bad, but it is a concern with respect to adoption of the right practices and of the food that is suited to nutritional welfare.

QUICK REVISION

- Societal divide: deprived and vulnerable sections (scheduled castes, the disabled, women) have higher malnutrition.
- Regional divide can also be added here.
- Intersection of vulnerabilities: disability + gender + deprived caste/tribe + poverty overlapping.
- Therefore an intersectional approach is required, and a one-size-fits-all approach cannot work.
- Cultural/behavioural challenges: poor nutritional awareness and traditional food practices limiting adoption of nutritional guidelines.
- Beliefs and customs discourage pregnant women and young children from particular foods; example: consumption of eggs.

11.7 Governance and Institutional Challenges

Whenever a **political challenge** is discussed, it is the interaction of the state and the citizens that is being discussed, so these points are also reflected here in governance or institutional challenges.

11.7.1 Fragmented and Non-Integrated Governance

- First (number one) is **fragmented or non-convergent governance**, which can also be called **non-integrated governance**.
- Several ministries and departments are involved, each with its own scheme, and there is a lack of convergence or integration between them.
- There is also the concern of **limited centre-state-local coordination**, which is sometimes called **vertical integration**.
- There is also the challenge of **increased budgetary spending because of the double burden**: usually nations spend their money either to address obesity or to address undernutrition, but India has both overnutrition and undernutrition.
  - Therefore **increased fiscal space** has to be created for these activities.

Education department	Implements PM Poshan
Ministry of Women and Child Development	Implements Mission Poshan Abhiyaan 2.0
Ministry of Health and Family Welfare	Plays an important role in addressing anaemia and in primary health centres
Ministry of Jal Shakti	Addresses WASH
Ministry of Panchayati Raj	Also involved in the delivery of nutrition

11.7.2 Aanganwadi-Related Concerns

- **Aanganwadi centres are the backbone of India's child nutrition** and are the working pillars of the Ministry of Women and Child Development; they are discussed separately because they provide **last mile service delivery**.
- If you visit any village you will find an Aanganwadi centre providing nutrition not only to children but also to pregnant mothers, lactating mothers and adolescents, addressed by **Aanganwadi helpers**.
  - Without these helpers the entire framework of nutrition — of the mother, the child and the adolescent — would be left totally unaddressed.
- **Inadequate Aanganwadi infrastructure** — deficiencies in buildings, lack of functional toilets, drinking water and kitchen.
- **Weighing machine** — very important, because the child has to be caught as early as possible; if the child has low weight for height, that measurement is made with a weighing machine.
  - **Growth monitoring equipment** is needed to measure stunting; without a weighing machine and growth monitoring equipment the Aanganwadi helper cannot perform the role well.
- **'Catch them young'** — if a student is undernourished, undergoing stunting or wasting, that child has to be caught as early as possible; that is how the concern is to be addressed.
- **Vacancies** — the required number of Aanganwadi workers is not available.
- **Overburdening of work** — the Aanganwadi workers perform many roles at once:
  - Provide supplementary nutrition to beneficiaries — children, mothers, lactating mothers and adolescents.
  - Provide pre-school education for three to six years.
  - Perform household visits for counselling.
  - Perform growth monitoring.
  - Conduct surveys.
  - Recently, perform digital data entry on an app.
  - Participate in health programmes.
- Because they are incapable of performing so many roles, the outcome is that they get **limited remuneration**.
- These Aanganwadi concerns end up creating the **failure of the nutritional programme**.
- **Monitoring-related challenge within Aanganwadi**: errors in the anthropometric measurement of height and of weight.
- **Lack of early identification, referral and nutritional support to SAM and MAM children**.
  - The Aanganwadi worker performs anthropometric measurements of the child; if the child is suffering from SAM or MAM, the child is referred to an **NRC — a Nutritional Rehabilitation Centre**.
- Problems at this end: poor measurement, lack of proper training, and late referral.
  - The later a child is sent to a nutritional rehabilitation centre, the more the task of providing nutritional security to that child gets compromised. The point is that Aanganwadi workers

are overburdened and face monitoring-related issues — not that they are wrong.

KEY CONCEPT

- **SAM** = severe acute malnutrition; **MAM** = moderate acute malnutrition.
- SAM/MAM children are referred to **NRC** — Nutritional Rehabilitation Centres.
- Aanganwadi centres come as a sub-part of the governance challenge (the fifth point, after A, B, C, D).

11.7.3 Digital Divide in Aanganwadi Functioning

- Because the **Poshan Tracker** app is the main real-time data source, there is a **digital divide** with the following concerns:
- **Weak internet connectivity**.
- **Smartphone availability**.
- **Digital literacy**.
- **Inaccurate data entry**.
- **Excessive reporting burden** on the Aanganwadi workers.

CRITICAL POINT

These are described as the **six major concerns** affecting the functioning of Aanganwadi centres in the country; the matter therefore requires great care, because there is excessive reporting.

11.7.4 Limited Targeting

- There is **limited targeting** — of women who are outside the reproductive age, of men, and of senior citizens.
- All schemes are focused on children, on mothers (pregnant and lactating) and on adolescents.
  - It is not being said that this focus is wrong; the point is that other groups must also be focused upon. This is a governance-based issue.

QUICK REVISION

- Political challenge = interaction of the state and citizens; reflected in governance.
- Fragmented / non-convergent / non-integrated governance: Education → PM Poshan; MoWCD → Mission Poshan Abhiyaan 2.0; Health and Family Welfare → anaemia and PHCs; Jal Shakti → WASH; Panchayati Raj also involved.
- Limited centre-state-local coordination = vertical integration; double burden (obesity + undernutrition) needs increased fiscal space.
- Aanganwadi centres: backbone of child nutrition, working pillars of the Ministry of Women and Child Development, providers of last mile service delivery.
- Aanganwadi problems: inadequate infrastructure, vacancies, overburdening (many roles, low remuneration), errors in anthropometric measurement and late referral of SAM/MAM children to NRCs.

- SAM = severe acute malnutrition; MAM = moderate acute malnutrition; referral to NRC (Nutritional Rehabilitation Centre).
- Digital divide via Poshan Tracker: weak internet, smartphone availability, digital literacy, inaccurate data entry, excessive reporting.
- Limited targeting: women outside reproductive age, men and senior citizens are left out.

11.8 Urbanisation and Globalisation-Induced Challenges

In the end there is also the challenge of **urbanisation and globalisation-induced challenges**. This will be discussed separately in obesity in great detail, but it may be added here that it has led to the following.

- **Change in food practices or food culture**, and a behavioural change towards food practice and food culture.
- There is now a focus on **HFSS** — the food that is rich in fat, salt and sugar.
- There is also use of **UPF** — ultra processed food — and there is micronutrient deficiency.
- Consumption matters as much as quantity: if somebody is eating 2000 calories, what he eats also makes a very important difference.
- **Increase in sedentary lifestyle** — less and less time for activities.

KEY CONCEPT

Terms to note.

- **HFSS** = high fat, salt and sugar.
- **UPF** = ultra processed food.
- Examples of such foods: buns, bread, biscuits and quick ready-to-eat food.

All of these create challenges of **obesity** and of **malnutrition** — undernutrition includes both, and obesity and undernutrition cannot be forgotten together.

QUICK REVISION

- Urbanisation and globalisation induce changes in food practices and food culture.
- Focus on HFSS (high fat, salt, sugar) and use of UPF (ultra processed food).
- Micronutrient deficiency; the composition of 2000 calories matters.
- Examples: buns, bread, biscuits and quick ready-to-eat food.
- Increase in sedentary lifestyle and less time for activities.
- These create challenges of both obesity and undernutrition.

11.9 Climate Change Challenge and the Nutritional Transition

- **Climate change related challenges**: climate change induced weather extremities have affected natural yield.

- There is an **increased frequency of natural disasters**, which has led to a **decline in yield and productivity**.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> - Apart from the challenges discussed above, India is undergoing a **nutritional transition**.
> - This nutritional transition has led to a **double or triple burden of malnutrition**.

To recapitulate the whole set of challenges covered: economic challenges, agri and food system challenges, maternal challenges, societal challenges, governance challenges, the climate change challenge, and the challenge of urbanisation and increasing globalisation that is altering food practices.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Climate change → weather extremities → affected natural yield and more frequent natural disasters.
> - Result: decline in yield and productivity.
> - India is undergoing a nutritional transition.
> - The nutritional transition has led to a double or triple burden of malnutrition.
> - Recap of challenges: economic, agri–food system, maternal, societal, governance, climate change, urbanisation/globalisation.

11.10 Integrated Governance and the Way Forward

- **Vertical integration** means that all the tiers of governance — centre, state and local — need to work in close coordination.
- **Horizontal integration** means that different ministries of the government, at the centre or in the state, need to integrate and work together.
- Finally, **integrated governance** includes, besides vertical integration (between different tiers) and horizontal integration (across different ministries and departments), something called **community engagement** — engagement with societal players such as civil societies, self-help groups and NGOs.
  - All of them, together and in an integrated manner, perform the task of governance.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> - **Challenges and causes are 100% similar** — the causes of malnutrition are nothing but the challenges of malnutrition.
> - There is no need to worry about the syllabus area, as the discussion of the challenges is complete.

- On crop diversification: the **crop diversification programme** is surely a part of agriculture and is to be taken up later, in the month of December.

QUICK REVISION

- Vertical integration = centre, state and local tiers working in close coordination.
- Horizontal integration = different ministries at the centre/state working together.
- Integrated governance = vertical + horizontal integration + community engagement (civil society, self-help groups, NGOs).
- Challenges and causes of malnutrition are 100% similar — causes of malnutrition are nothing but its challenges.
- Crop diversification programme belongs to agriculture and is taken up later.

CHAPTER 12

Obesity in India — Part 1

12.1 Obesity as Part of the Malnutrition Discussion

The discussion on malnutrition continues: under-nutrition has already been studied, and now the concern of obesity is taken up. Write down the heading — **obesity**, which can also be called **over-nutrition**.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Why obesity sits inside every malnutrition answer.**
>
> - Any question on malnutrition must discuss obesity — whenever malnutrition is talked about, obesity is automatically included.
> - There is **no straight previous-year question** on this topic, but it can still be asked.
> - It can be asked because the **economic survey** has already discussed the rise of **UPF**, that is, **ultra-processed food**; the economic survey for the past two years — **2025-26** and **2024-25** — has done it.
> - Write the keyword that **India is undergoing a nutritional transition**; this becomes an added concern.

- Usually countries suffer from either obesity or under-nutrition: sub-Saharan and African nations suffer from **under-nutrition**, Western societies suffer from **over-nutrition** — India has both.
- India has become a **diabetes capital** — a point already seen for the "India for your health" topic in prelims.
- With the diabetes capital status comes the **rise of non-communicable diseases**; the disease burden is shifting from communicable to non-communicable diseases.

The frame of the whole topic: the **demographic dividend is contingent on efficient management of the nutritional or nutrition transition**. India must first manage the nutrition challenge and the nutritional transformation.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Diagram that is a must.**
>
> - Nutrition is underexplored, and **nutrition is a bridge** that connects the two dimensions of education and skill development with the utilisation of the demographic dividend.
> - The chain to show: education and skill development → efficient management of the nutrition transition → utilisation of the demographic dividend.

- The economy will not benefit if there is over-nutrition.

- In the examination, for any question on malnutrition, **both aspects — under- and over-nutrition — have to be collated and written in one place**; they are taught separately only so that they are understood separately.
- A little more depth is taken here because a **straight question can come in General Studies Paper 1**.
- Food for thought to think about separately: the impact of **globalization and urbanization** on obesity or over-nutrition.
  - Globalization is a very open-ended topic — a broad thought has to be there, and one has to spread one's wings to attempt any question on globalization in Paper 1.
  - In Paper 1, urbanization means open and women mean open as well.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

The PYQ on the fast food industry.

- A previous-year question recalled in class by a student — there was no straight PYQ on obesity; the question spoke about the **growing fast food industry in the country despite increasing health consciousness**: the health concern increased, but the fast food industry also increased.
- How such a question is analysed: write the **economic, social, political and international** factors, the role of **urbanization and globalization**, and also the **legal and administrative** factors.

QUICK REVISION

- Obesity, also called over-nutrition, is the next head under malnutrition; every malnutrition question must discuss it, and both under- and over-nutrition are collated in one place.
- There is no straight PYQ on obesity, but it can be asked — the economic survey for 2025-26 and 2024-25 has discussed the rise of UPF, and India is undergoing a nutritional transition.
- Usually countries have either under-nutrition (sub-Saharan and African nations) or over-nutrition (Western societies); India has both, is a diabetes capital, and is shifting its disease burden from communicable to non-communicable diseases.
- The demographic dividend is contingent on managing the nutrition transition; nutrition is the bridge between education and skill development and the utilisation of the dividend — the diagram is a must.
- The fast food PYQ is analysed through economic, social, political, international, urbanization-globalization and legal-administrative factors.

12.2 The Fixed Structure of an Obesity Answer

The structure of the answer is fixed, and **structure is the first step** for stimulating the mind for every topic — only then can one score well in the paper.

1. **Introduce** the topic — write the definition of obesity and of over-nutrition, a fact, and whatever

article is being referred to.

2. Write the **causes** — economic, social-cultural and legal-administrative reasons, plus the role of globalization, which is an essay in itself.
3. Write the **consequences** or impact of obesity — very important, because the greatest impact is on health.
4. Write the **steps**, with specific focus on the steps and the role of **FSSAI**, the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India.
5. Write the **way forward**, from one's own recommendations.
6. Give the **international case studies or examples** — Saudi Arabia, Chile, China and the US.

- **Globalization's best example is you and me** — from shirt to speech, English to food, iPad to stylus and technology, everything done from morning to evening is 100% an impact of globalization: the library where one studies, the coffee one drinks, the Lipton one drinks — these practices are not what we used to do.
  - In Paper 1, globalization, urbanization and women all have to be read open-endedly.
- The consequences head is very important: the greatest impact of obesity is on **health**, and if the impact is on health then the greatest impact is on the **demographic dividend**.
  - People who are unwell cannot concentrate in class, or cannot attend class at all — this is called **presenteeism and absenteeism**; presenteeism means you are present but cannot concentrate, absenteeism means you are absent (noted in class as applying only for the answer).

FSSAI does not fall within the framework of the regulatory and constitutional bodies of the General Studies Paper 2 syllabus. In the core-to-current interface part of GS Paper 2 the bodies taken up in great detail are NCSC, NCST, NCPCR, NCBC, NCW, CBI and NHRC (referred to in the lecture collectively as eight organisations). For any body in public administration the discussion has to cover **structural concerns, functional concerns** and, to be very specific, **process-oriented problems**.

12.2.1 *The Example Head — Food Safety Warning versus Nutritional Labelling*

- In every country of the world except India a **food safety warning** is very common — not a nutritional warning.
- India has nutritional labelling: behind any item, from a Mother Dairy product to a chips packet to any protein source, there is nutritional information, but it does not say whether the item is good or bad.
- What the label does say is the recommended nutrients and the values per serving; the general observation is that **nobody follows per serving** — if a chips packet says per serving 20 grams, the whole packet is eaten.
- **RDA** means **recommended dietary allowance**; the label shows the percentage of RDA.
- Maggi in India has a very high salt content compared with Western nations, so the Maggi there and here is different — the Maggi here has a salt content that is **20 to 25% of the daily diet**, so a small Maggi means 20% of salt intake.
- Therefore there should be a **star rating** on a particular product saying that it is high in fat,

high in salt or high in sugar.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

FSSAI's affidavit to the Supreme Court.

- FSSAI has given an affidavit to the **Supreme Court** about a week before the class, saying that it will address high fat, high salt and high sugar in a particular product; it is still a **draft**.
- There is a catch: the labelling will be there **only if two out of the three are high** — fat, salt and sugar.
- This is a folly: ghee is ghee and ghee has so much fat that one cannot imagine; if ghee is labelled, all the "ghee" of northern India will be read on the back of the pack — so there is a debate on the two-of-three rule.
- If a product is high in salt but not high in sugar and not high in fat, it will **not** be certified as unhealthy as per the latest guideline — so this is a mistake.

- Class exercise: after the class, pick up the products that are unhealthy and find out how many of them are high in **at least two parameters**.
  - Usually sweet things are high in sugar but not in salt or fat — chini, chini sucrose, is a carbohydrate; a gulab jamun bought from Haldiram would not be certified unhealthy because it is only high in sugar.
- There is a **big lobby of all the companies**: if they follow these norms they end up losing their business, just as happened to cigarettes in the 1970s and 80s.

EXAMPLE

How the tobacco industry behaved.

- When vaping was cancelled as an activity in India, a big tobacco lobby was after it, because people left smoking cigarettes and picked up vapes — a huge loss to the tobacco industry.
- Big industry is a very good example of marketing and of becoming cool: cigarettes were promoted as if they were a liberation.
- In the 1960s and 70s the regulations were lax, and then came the idea of depicting a photograph covering almost **80%** of the pack, saying it is injurious to health.

QUICK REVISION

- The structure is fixed and is the first step to stimulate the mind: introduction, causes, consequences, steps with the role of FSSAI, way forward, and international examples.
- The introduction carries the definition of obesity and over-nutrition, a fact and the article; globalization's best example is you and me, from shirt and speech to food and technology.
- The greatest impact of obesity is on health and through health on the demographic dividend — presenteeism and absenteeism.
- For any body in public administration write structural, functional and process-oriented issues; FSSAI is outside the GS Paper 2 list of NCSC, NCST, NCPCR, NCBC, NCW, CBI and NHRC (called eight organisations in the lecture).

- India has nutritional labelling and not a food safety warning; nothing says good or bad, nobody follows per serving, RDA means recommended dietary allowance, and Maggi's salt is 20-25% of the daily diet — hence the demand for a star rating.
- FSSAI's draft affidavit to the Supreme Court flags HFSS only when two of the three are high, which is a mistake for ghee and for salt-only products; the company lobby behaves as the tobacco lobby did after 1960s-70s, ending in labels covering 80% of the pack.
- The class exercise is to test how many unhealthy products in the market are high in at least two parameters.

12.3 Introduction — 2025 as a Turning Point

Before the introduction is written, start with the point that **2025 is a turning point**.

DATA & FACTS

The fact that changes the debate.

- For the **first time ever**, the **global prevalence of obesity in school-age children and adolescents has surpassed the number of underweight children**.
- UNICEF's numbers: **888 million** children and adolescents are obese, and this has crossed **184 million** school-going children and adolescents who are suffering from under-nutrition [figures as stated in lecture].
- This fact came in **The Hindu** about a week before the class; the exact month was not recalled.

Therefore **obesity is the most prevalent form of malnutrition**, and this itself changes the flavour of the debate.

- The debate is **no longer undernutrition, no longer food security and no longer poverty removal**; the debate is removing inequality, addressing nutritional poverty, addressing nutritional security, and addressing obesity vis-a-vis malnutrition.
- The question is not only sending a person to school but also, simultaneously, going for skilling — **learn while you earn**; these are the points of the transition India is going through under the overarching framework of social justice.
- **Obesity is 100% connected to globalization.**

EXAMPLE

The samosa versus the McDonald's burger.

- It is **1000% healthier** to eat a samosa, a kachauri, a dal ki kachauri or any other fried item that is full of trans fat compared with a chips packet or, let us say, a McDonald's burger which might certify itself to be 100% missing in trans fat.
- Food that is part of the **local palate**, with a **shorter food chain**, easily available and easily consumed, is much healthier than what we know — this is what McDonald's and all those organisations have done to the entire world.

- **Obesity is more than underweight**: in all regions of the world, in every place one can think

of, obesity is more than the underweight children — **except South Asia**.

- India still has big awareness; in **Pakistan, Bangladesh and Iran** every meal is had with a coke — consumption of sweetened calorie food is even more in Iran — and obviously Africa; these continents are not yet globalized and will be 100% globalized.
- Globalization came to the south of Africa, that is, the English areas: the English colonies in Africa were **South Africa, Zimbabwe, Botswana, Zambia**, then Eastern Africa and **Kenya**, and also **Tanzania** — the places where all tourists go and where India has bilateral relationships.
- But **Africa has 55 countries**; one has not been to areas like **Burkina Faso, Mali, Chad, Gabon, Benin, Sierra Leone, the DRC, Ivory Coast and Cameroon**.
- In those places the impact is limited — once globalization happens there (the US is not going full gas there and there is a lot of Chinese influence), these numbers will be totally in favour of obesity in the entire world.
  - The poorest regions do not have it; in middle-income and rich areas obesity is already a concern.

This is a life-changing, important fact to quote in any question.

DATA & FACTS

World Obesity Atlas 2025 — released on World Obesity Day.

- Days are mainly important for the state services, and they are very easy to remember — two or three hours are enough for them.
- **World Obesity Day is 4 March** — take Women's Day, 8 March, and do a minus 4.
- In the Atlas, **number 1 is China, number 2 is India and number 3 is the US**; the fact is about obesity in children, so write that **India is the second most obese nation in the world as far as children are concerned** — that is good to go for the examination.

QUICK REVISION

- 2025 is a turning point: for the first time ever the global prevalence of obesity in school-age children and adolescents has surpassed the number of underweight children.
- UNICEF's figures — 888 million obese children and adolescents against 184 million under-nourished, as stated in the lecture — came in The Hindu about a week before the class.
- Obesity is the most prevalent form of malnutrition; the debate is no longer undernutrition, food security or poverty removal but inequality, nutritional poverty, nutritional security and obesity vis-a-vis malnutrition, with skilling added to schooling (learn while you earn).
- Obesity is 100% connected to globalization; a samosa or kachauri from the local palate and short food chain is 1000% healthier than a chips packet or a burger claiming to be free of trans fat.
- Obesity is more than underweight in every region of the world except South Asia; Pakistan, Bangladesh, Iran and Africa are still globalizing, and Africa's 55 countries include many untouched areas.
- The World Obesity Atlas 2025 was released on World Obesity Day, 4 March (Women's Day

minus 4): China first, India second and the US third — write that India is the second most obese nation as far as children are concerned.

12.4 Defining Obesity — Over-Nutrition and BMI

The definition is kept simple: **over-nutrition implies that there is energy intake more than relative expenditure**, because of a **poor quality diet plus a sedentary lifestyle**, leading to **obesity and other metabolic disorders**.

KEY CONCEPT

Count your own calories first.

- This is a basic component of the daily life of an individual, especially because there is **rising health consciousness** — a point UPSC has asked.
- The first thing to do is tell ChatGPT the daily calorie consumption of the food one eats — start from breakfast, then the tea, then lunch, then dinner, and also an ice cream.
- Then count how much one is expending — how much one is walking, the steps, and how the body burns calories, which is called **metabolism**.
- There may be ten people in the class and all ten will have a different metabolism; every individual burns his calories as per his individual metabolism.

1. Consumed calories more than what is expended — that is over-nutrition.
2. With over-nutrition the person becomes overweight.
3. In the final stages, technically in medical terms, the person becomes **obese**.
4. Therefore over-nutrition only means consuming more than one is spending: it leads to being overweight and finally to being obese.

12.4.1 BMI — the Body Mass Index

- **BMI is the Body Mass Index**: weight divided by height squared — weight in kilograms divided by metre square; height is usually taken in centimetres.
- Outside India the parameters are **25 kg per metre square** for overweight and **30 kg per metre square** for obese.
- In India, **NFHS — the National Family Health Survey** — classifies even an obese person under a common category of "overweight or being obese", and the BMI has to be **more than 25 kg per metre square**.
- So in India it is taken as one category; it can be written as a point that a BMI of more than 25 kg per metre square automatically ends up in the category.

EXAMPLE

Worked example given in class.

- For a height of **6 foot 2 inch**, that is almost **188 cm**, which is **1.8 metre**, and a weight of **100 kilos**, the BMI is **100 divided by 1.8 square**.

- From that one can calculate whether the person has obesity or over-nutrition.

- Although there is **criticism against BMI**, the purpose here is obesity and not body building — weight by height squared has to be calculated.
- Class aside on the medical examination for the services: there is **no BMI category** for the services; there should be **no knock knees, no flat feet**, and one should be of a **certain height**; after that candidates are given **three months**; colour blindness is tested with a booklet in which a number is shown [as stated in lecture].
- There is no need to feel bad about being obese — the task is to qualify the examination [advice given in class].

QUICK REVISION

- Over-nutrition means energy intake more than relative expenditure, because of a poor quality diet plus a sedentary lifestyle, leading to obesity and other metabolic disorders.
- Count your calories with ChatGPT — breakfast, tea, lunch, dinner and ice cream — and count the expenditure and steps; metabolism differs from individual to individual.
- The chain is consumed calories more than expended → over-nutrition → overweight → obese.
- BMI is weight divided by height squared; outside India 25 kg per metre square is overweight and 30 is obese, while in India NFHS clubs both under "overweight or being obese" above 25 kg per metre square.
- Worked example: 6 foot 2 inch (about 188 cm, that is 1.8 metre) and 100 kilos gives 100 divided by 1.8 square.
- There is criticism against BMI, but weight by height squared is what has to be calculated; on the services' medical side there is no BMI category — only knock knees, flat feet, a certain height and colour blindness, with three months given.

12.5 Statistics — The Rising Trend

- Write down the statistics — they are **very important**: they tell the **rising trend of obesity**, which is a **health concern**.
- Health leads to the demographic dividend and obesity leads to the demographic dividend.
- Paper 1 may ask this: India is undergoing a **demographic transition** in which (a) the **birth rate is coming down** and (b) the **percentage of the elderly is increasing**.
- For India's malnutrition crisis there is **not only under-nutrition but also over-nutrition** — both have to be written.

12.5.1 The Numbers — NFHS Round 5 to NFHS Round 6

Obesity, women aged 15-49 (Round 5 to Round 6)	24%	30.7%
Underweight, women aged 15-49	18.7%	19.7%
Underweight, men	16.2%	19.7%

- This is a very **startling and unfortunate fact**: the obesity figure for women aged 15 to 49 was **24%** and it is now **30.7%**.
- For comparison, underweight among women aged 15 to 49 rose from **18.7 to 19.7** and among men from **16.2 to 19.7** — so the underweight proportion among both males and females is **increasing**.

12.5.2 Women — Mobility, Cultural Restrictions and the Double Burden

- To some extent there is also a **cultural phenomenon** for women: they cannot be mobile, they cannot easily go and work out; there are sociocultural factors — restrictions on what they wear and restrictions on how they want to perform their workout.
- For men it is not a problem: a man can easily wear a pair of shorts and go to the gym or go for an early morning run.
- If a man in shorts is running early in the morning everybody praises him, but if a female runs the perception, the gaze, the glance **totally transforms** — so they would rather not run; this has to be added as a layer.

> **COMPARISON**
>
> **Urban versus rural obesity figures.**
>
> - **Urban women: 43%** — almost out of every ten women, four are suffering from obesity.
> - **Urban men: 36%.**
> - **Rural men: 23%.**
> - **Rural women:** the lecture noted a difference of **2%** between rural women and rural men, obesity being **higher among females** [the rural women figure itself was not recoverable from the recording].

- The constraints behind these numbers: lack of public spaces, lack of proper working-out areas and lack of common places; everybody cannot afford to go to the centre of the city, and there are no parks here, so one cannot just run.
- Compared with the Western nations — the US, England, the European nations — every area would have a **community park**; in the US it is phenomenal: a basketball court, open station, pull-up station, dip station — one need not go to the gym, and if one wants a personal trainer one has to pay.

- Third, **rural women** — slightly less important, but taken: low mobility, but calories burned in agricultural work; in agricultural states they are automatically lean because of the amount of work performed in the fields and in the household.
- **Mobility**: females always have less mobility, but opportunities are comparatively less; in urban areas mobility should be even higher — females come, they migrate.
  - Globalization and urbanization have given working opportunities to females, so they have become socially and economically empowered, but that does **not transcend into equal opportunities for taking care of their health**.
- She suffers from a **double burden of work**: she has to take care of the family, the husband, the children and the grandparents, and also go for work; but males go for work after getting 3-4 hours to work out — that leisure time is even less for women.

12.5.3 Time Use Survey — the Source of These Facts

- These are not opinions but the thoughts and stats from the **TUS, the Time Use Survey** — the **second Time Use Survey**, released last year; the first was released in **2024** and the second came in **2025**.
- The Time Use Survey tells how a male, a female or a child spends the entire day, with a record of every **30 minutes**, so that one can comment on how a male is spending his time.
- For next year's exam, write that **Time Use Survey 3, 2026**, will in all probabilities come before the exam.
- **Unpaid females have a double burden of labour**; they have to contribute to domestic activities even as we want to promote the female labour force participation rate — again connected with the demographic dividend.

12.5.4 What the Statistics Tell You

- In a developing society like India that wants to utilise the demographic dividend, **these statistics speak so much**.
- Imagine a country with a **median age of 30** — the younger nation compared with you is **Nepal**, which has almost **15-20% unemployment** because of an utter failure in terms of governance.
- For India there is a strange phenomenon: the proportion of underweight women and underweight men is increasing, and the percentage of obesity or over-nutrition is also increasing — so the number of people who are actually healthy is even **less than 60%, even 50%**.
- If there are **100 people in India in the golden period of 15 to 49**, **30% of them are obese females** and another **20% of them are underweight** — about **50%** of people, across genders, are not rightly placed in terms of their body weight.
- To work, health is required; to earn, health is required; health is required to utilise the demographic dividend — malnutrition thereby tells you that this is a **major problem that India is going through**.

DATA & FACTS

The conclusion to write in brackets.

- Write in brackets "important facts": therefore the above statistics reveal a **startling fact** that in the age group **15 to 49**, women — **30.7 plus approximately 20** — that is, **approximately 51%**, are suffering from **malnutrition**, which is **limiting FLFPR**, the female labour force participation rate.
- Presently it is **41%**, while for **China it is 60%**.

12.5.5 *The Wrong Metric and the Vicious Cycle*

- The Government of India's policy right now is to increase the participation of females in the workforce; out of 100 females in the working age bracket of **15 to 59**, just **40** are actually participating — that is, either working or looking for work; the rest are neither looking for a job nor wanting one.
- Even if all the 60 are converted and there is a legendary **100% female participation rate**, the **wrong metric is still being targeted**, because one has to simultaneously understand that India is undergoing a **nutritional transition**.
  - So much before getting the females into the workforce, keep skilling them, keep providing them education, keep having schemes like **PM Vishwakarma**, and keep promoting schemes such as **Kaushal Vikas Yojana** and **PM Mudra** — any scheme for women.
- But simultaneously one has to understand that **malnutrition is a much bigger crisis**.

1. **Females participate** in the workforce — but their malnutrition rate is higher than that of males.
2. They are **low productivity**, have **low skill** and make a **low contribution** to the economy.
3. They are **automatically shunted out**.
4. Being shunted out means **no income**, and they end up in **poverty**, leading to **nutritional poverty** — and the cycle begins again.

The fuller cycle to draw for women: **poverty** — why poor? Because they have a **low FLFPR** and thereby increased **economic dependence on males**. If poor, then **poor education and poor health**; the startling part is that they will suffer from **malnutrition, both over and under**, which leads to **poor cognition**, which leads to **poor productivity**, which leads to **poor work performance**, which leads to **lower wages**, and it shall lead again to poverty. This cycle has to be broken.

- The way to break the cycle is the focus — **this is the biggest aspect**: all three topics are in the syllabus, and the fewest questions have been asked on the most important aspect; after the stats, this is the firm framework.
- **Malnutrition is the biggest focus and the most important area for India**; the government has not opened it as a policy challenge, which is why a question has not come; it may come in **2027 or 2028** if the government picks it up — right now the economic survey has commented on the rise of ultra-processed food.

QUICK REVISION

- The statistics are very important: they show the rising trend of obesity as a health concern, and health and obesity both lead to the demographic dividend; India's transition means a falling birth rate and a rising share of the elderly, and malnutrition now has both under- and over-nutrition.
- NFHS Round 5 to Round 6: obesity among women aged 15-49 rose from 24% to 30.7%, while underweight women rose 18.7 to 19.7 and underweight men 16.2 to 19.7 — a startling and unfortunate fact.
- Women's sociocultural restrictions (dress, working out, the male gaze) explain higher female numbers: urban women 43%, urban men 36%, rural men 23%, and rural women 2% apart from rural men with obesity higher among females.
- Reasons: no public spaces or parks against the Western community park; rural women are lean through field and household work; urban mobility does not convert into health opportunities; women carry a double burden of work.
- The Time Use Survey (first 2024, second 2025, records every 30 minutes; Time Use Survey 3 of 2026 is likely before the exam) shows unpaid females' double burden of labour.
- Statistics: underweight and over-nutrition are rising together, less than 50-60% are healthy, about 50% are not rightly placed in weight; gangs of 30% obese women plus 20% underweight equal roughly 51% malnourished females, limiting FLFPR at 41% against China's 60%.
- Only 40 of 100 women aged 15-59 participate, so even 100% participation would target the wrong metric; the vicious cycle runs from low FLFPR and poverty through malnutrition (over and under), poor cognition, productivity, work performance and lower wages back to poverty, and malnutrition is the biggest focus, likely to be asked in 2027 or 2028.

12.6 Reasons — Building the Framework

The next topic is the second point — the **reasons**. A framework has to be created for the reasons; capacity building is very important, and this structure helps in the mains.

- **Economic factors.**
- **Social-cultural factors.**
- **Behavioural factors.**
- **Food systems.**
- **Urbanization and globalization** — written separately, with the same effect and the same reason.
- **Environmental factors.**
- **Media and social media.**
- **Legal-administrative factors.**
- **Genetics**: a student's suggestion of genetic predisposition will not be written here; it will be written in a different place.
- **Behavioural factors**: binge eating, stress eating and all such factors; usually anyone who is

overstressed wants to have sweet food, for civil services aspirants in particular.

- **Food systems**: in the villages, in the food and agri systems, a lot of roti used to be eaten 50-60 years ago — bajra, ragi and millet; and promoting **Shri Anna** came up in the main examination also.
- Food system basically means **your food practices**.
- **Media and social media** have revolutionised food practices; influencers and content creators play a role; the West promoted its own items, but in India there are easily available alternatives to avocado; India fell behind **palm oil**, which is unhealthy — every food packet carries palm oil.
- Sources: the **Indian Express** carries a full-page health section on Monday or Saturday in which a very good doctor is interviewed — a very good source of knowledge; **All India Radio** also calls a doctor.
- **Health** as a factor: genetics will not be written; instead comment on the mother's health — write **maternal and intergenerational reasons**.

COMPARISON

The alternative framework — supply side versus demand side.

- This is the second level of analysis: **supply-side factors** include agriculture, globalization, urbanization and legal-administrative reasons.
- **Demand-side factors** include social, behavioural and cultural factors.
- Things are coming into the market that are promoting obesity and people are demanding and consuming them, so the market is only fulfilling the demand; both factors exist, and it is slightly technical.

- **Urbanization and globalization** have the same effect, the same reason and the same example — two topics on which two questions are fixed, with separate notes.
- Legal-administrative policies must promote **MSME development and food processing development**.

QUICK REVISION

- The second point is the reasons, and a framework has to be built for them — this capacity building is what helps in the mains.
- The heads are economic, social-cultural, behavioural, food systems, urbanization and globalization (written separately, same effect and reason), environmental, media and legal-administrative factors.
- Genetics will be written elsewhere; behaviour covers binge and stress eating (overstressed people want sweet food); food system means your food practices, from bajra, ragi and millet to the push for Shri Anna.
- Media and social media have revolutionised food practices, and the slide is visible in the fall behind palm oil; the Indian Express health section and All India Radio doctor interviews are good sources.

- Health is written as maternal and intergenerational reasons rather than genetics.
- The second level of analysis is supply side (agriculture, globalization, urbanization, legal-administrative) against demand side (social, behavioural, cultural).
- Urbanization and globalization carry the same effect, reason and example, and legal-administrative policy must promote MSME and food processing development.

12.7 Economic Factors

- **Rising incomes**: post LPG there has been a rise in household income, which has led to increasing consumption of **UPF (ultra-processed food)** or fast foods, an eating-out culture and increasing economic access.
- If somebody is eating out, he or she is going to eat at a place which is serving junk food — salad bars are rare.

DATA & FACTS

Two figures to quote here.

- The average **GDP growth rate in the 2000s has been 7 to 8%**.
- **Services contributes approximately 55 to 60% of India's GDP.**

- **Servicification of the economy**: post LPG there has been a services transition, bypassing manufacturing, which has led to changing work patterns and longer sitting hours.
- There is also a **WFH culture, work from home, post COVID**; and there is a rise in the IT sector, which has led to the increasing importance of time and thereby obesity or over-nutrition.
- Why the work pattern matters: in the manufacturing sector there is a strict schedule of **9 to 5**; for agriculture one has to go to the field in the early morning or in a limited span of the day; in services it is not so — one can do the editing of videos at night, freelancing is increasing, and students enrolled online can watch the class as per their own schedule.
- **Jobless growth**: because of stagnation of income in agriculture plus limited corporate investment, which has limited manufacturing, plus the increase in the role of services, which is skill-oriented, contributing to a rise in **NEET**.
- **NEET** means **not in education, employment and training**.
- About **7 crore** youth in India are NEET — neither studying, nor in education, nor in training — basically promoting over-nutrition and obesity in the country [figure as stated in lecture].
- This leads to **low motivation and a sedentary lifestyle**: in unemployment, how will a person take care of himself; motivational factors in work are very important, which is why so many bureaucrats resign from the highest job that one can achieve in the country; if there is less motivation in work it automatically ends up having a perpetual, continuous vicious-cycle effect on one's overarching choices, which includes food choices.

QUICK REVISION

- Rising incomes: post LPG household incomes rose, leading to increased consumption of UPF

and fast foods, an eating-out culture and greater economic access.

- If one is eating out one goes to a place serving junk food, because salad bars are rare.
- Figures: the average GDP growth rate in the 2000s was 7 to 8%, and services contributes about 55 to 60% of India's GDP.
- Servicification of the economy — the post-LPG services transition bypassing manufacturing — changed work patterns and lengthened sitting hours; with post-COVID WFH and the rise of the IT sector, time became more important than ever.
- Work patterns differ: manufacturing is 9 to 5, agriculture demands early mornings, services allow night-time video editing, freelancing and self-paced online classes.
- Jobless growth — stagnant agricultural income, limited corporate investment and a skill-oriented services boom — raised NEET (not in education, employment and training) to about 7 crore youth.
- Unemployment brings low motivation and a sedentary lifestyle; with so many bureaucrats resigning from the highest jobs, low motivation creates a perpetual vicious cycle affecting overarching choices including food choices.

12.8 Food Systems and Agriculture-Related Reasons

- There is **limited crop diversification**, and no **organic, natural or integrated farming systems**, which has led to **monoculture of the rice-wheat cropping pattern**.
- **Institutional factors in agriculture**: small and marginal farmers have limited landholding, poor agri extension, insurance and credit, limited storage and infrastructure, the role of technology, and government policy which has limited diversification of agriculture and dietary diversity.
- In brackets write: **limited MSP and price support** for coarse cereals, fruits, vegetables and other allied products.
- The allied products: **eggs**; **meat**; **fish and fisheries**; and most importantly **milk and dairy items** — doodh, dahi, paneer, shrikhand, mawa. **Honey** is very important, and the scam of 100% Dabur honey was referred to. **Crab** is a delicacy which the poor man's pocket cannot afford [as stated in lecture].
- There is a topic in civil services **Paper 3** called the **economics of animal rearing**, so animal husbandry should be promoted.
- **Best example**: Andhra Pradesh has a growth rate of **8 to 10%** in agriculture every year, where the entire sector in the country is almost **4.4%**; and the 4.4% growth rate in agriculture is not in crops but in **agriculture and allied sectors** — the growth in actual crops is just **2 to 3%**.
- A big chunk of growth has to come not from rice and wheat but from other allied sectors; this will lead to **diversification of agriculture** and will automatically promote **dietary diversity**, and thereby supply many **non-packeted products** in the market — brown rice, multigrain atta and such naturally available items should be promoted.

DATA & FACTS

Explosion of UPF — the stat from the Economic Survey.

- The most important change in the food systems is the **explosion of UPF**, that is, ultra-processed food.
- If one looks at **Economic Survey 2025-26**, UPF sales have grown from **2009 till 2023 by 150%** — a 150% boost in the consumption and sales of UPF; this fact is taken from the economic survey and is basically about how much UPF has been sold.

- **What processing of food means**: if this is the raw material, you introduce high temperatures, add preservatives and add additives; in chips packets and in packets of any kind, additives such as **acidity regulators** are added; in every packet of cheese there is a big list; in high-protein products there are preservatives and acidity regulators, and they are made at high temperature. This **reduces the nutritional value**.
- The biggest reason for the further increase in UPF consumption is the **protein bar**: the behavioural change was that earlier there was no time — you feel hungry, you get up and eat and 30 minutes are wasted, so 2-3 protein bars are eaten.
- This phenomenon has actually been promoted by **e-commerce**: earlier one had to go to a shop to buy diet coke, now it is a click away — Swiggy, Zepto, Blinkit; "add 300 to get a discount" — so the rise of e-commerce is one of the biggest factors, apart from globalization, that has promoted the consumption of ultra-processed food.

QUICK REVISION

- Limited crop diversification and the absence of organic, natural or integrated farming systems produced monoculture of the rice-wheat cropping pattern.
- Institutional factors: limited landholding of small and marginal farmers, poor extension, insurance and credit, limited storage and infrastructure, the role of technology, and a policy that limited diversification and dietary diversity (limited MSP and price support for coarse cereals, fruits, vegetables and allied products).
- Allied products to promote: eggs, meat, fish and fisheries, and above all milk and dairy (doodh, dahi, paneer, shrikhand, mawa) plus honey; crab is a delicacy beyond the poor man's pocket; the economics of animal rearing is a Paper 3 topic.
- Andhra Pradesh grows agriculture at 8 to 10% a year against the country's 4.4%, and that 4.4% is in agriculture and allied sectors, with crops growing only 2 to 3%, so growth must come from allied sectors, giving diversification, dietary diversity and non-packeted products like brown rice and multigrain atta.
- The most important change in food systems is the explosion of UPF; processing means high temperature, preservatives and additives such as acidity regulators, and it reduces nutritional value.
- Economic Survey 2025-26: UPF sales grew 150% from 2009 till 2023.
- The protein bar shows the behavioural change (no time, so 2-3 bars instead of a meal), and e-commerce — Swiggy, Zepto, Blinkit and discount add-ons — is one of the biggest factors

> apart from globalization pushing UPF consumption.

12.9 Social and Cultural Factors

- **Number one: limited workout or a sedentary lifestyle**, because of desk-based jobs, reduced occupational labour and increased recreational screen time.
- **Urbanism or urbanization** has led to **easy food availability or access** — in the villages there is no Blinkit, it is here; in the village people think "let me leave it", here it is available in five minutes, and brain mapping begins.
- There is the **explosion of HFSS food items** — foods high in fat, sugar and salt.
- **Consumerism**: "no difference, the money will be paid later; if we want to eat we will eat, no one can stop us" — all have become mavericks in urban areas, whereas in rural areas one thinks twice.
- **Increased choices because of economic and social empowerment**: there is nobody to stop you when you want to eat a particular item; in a village you were restricted by family norms. Your food choice in Delhi and your food choice back in your own city or state are totally different.
- Once the examination is qualified **you will also be a part of this**; right now you are not, because you are preparing, but every person around you is working — your peers, your friends and your colleagues are all part of this eat-out culture.

12.9.1 The Cultural Shift in the Perception of Food

- The **emergence of the weekend culture**: weekends are meant for enjoyment, for going out and for eating out; when going out you will not eat a khichdi, a porridge, a plain dosa or a fruit chaat — you will indulge in easily available food items such as butter chicken, pasta, pizza or a burger — all promoting over-nutrition. Bombay is even more dangerous than Delhi in this respect.
- There is a **commercial or consumption environment** that promotes obesity: everybody is consuming; nobody says that he will not eat a pizza or a burger, so because of that environment, whoever lives in the city automatically ends up consuming these items.
- **Cultural shift in the perception of food**: earlier food was for need, or food as preventive medicine — you ate what you needed for calories, haldi ka doodh, hot water or neembu ka pani in the morning.
- Food has now emerged as **comfort, celebration and status**: at a party something rich is eaten and there is no khichdi, porridge, dalia, oats or upma; in a five-star restaurant one must try Italian, Tex-Mex or Japanese cuisine and the chef's special — that is what happens in an urban area.
- This changing perception is very much reflected in the increasing obesity seen in the **NFHS Round 6** numbers.
- The cultural shift has led to phenomena like **emotional eating** — "my mood is bad, let me eat or drink something" — and **frequent snacking** during breaks.

- **Eating out**, already discussed, and **irregularity in meal patterns**.
- **Stress eating**, the most common for aspirants: if you are stressed, some people do not eat and some end up eating a lot, but those who eat a lot are more than those who do not.
  - In the village there is no stress — you eat, drink lassi and sleep for 3-4 hours, there is no insomnia, in fact there is a lot of sleep; but in urban areas, in the cultural shift, this leads to stress eating.
- The thought to hold in the head: **globalization has played a big role in urbanization, and urbanization has led to a social, cultural and behavioural shift** — the brain has to click in this way; the changes happen continuously.
- **Destination weddings**: the excitement is understood, but at a destination wedding one gets a lot of calories in the food that is served — celebration-driven eating, which is not required.

QUICK REVISION

- Number one is limited workout or a sedentary lifestyle from desk-based jobs, reduced occupational labour and increased recreational screen time.
- Urbanism brings easy food availability and access — no Blinkit in the village, five-minute delivery in the city and brain mapping begins; HFSS items have exploded.
- Consumerism makes people mavericks in urban areas, economic and social empowerment increases choices, and once the exam is qualified one becomes part of the same eat-out culture as one's peers and colleagues.
- The weekend culture means eating out and avoiding khichdi, porridge, plain dosa or fruit chaat in favour of butter chicken, pasta, pizza and burgers; Bombay is more dangerous than Delhi.
- Food's perception has shifted from need and preventive medicine (haldi ka doodh, hot water, neembu ka pani) to comfort, celebration and status (five-star restaurants, Italian, Tex-Mex, Japanese, chef's special), reflected in the NFHS Round 6 obesity numbers.
- The shift produced emotional eating, frequent snacking, eating out, irregular meal patterns and above all stress eating, which is far more urban than rural.
- Globalization drove urbanization and urbanization drove the social, cultural and behavioural shift; destination weddings show celebration-driven calorie intake.

12.10 Governance, Legal and Administrative Factors

12.10.1 Lack of a Stringent Law and of an Innovative Levy

- **First: lack of stringent regulation, or a separate law**, to regulate food that is rich in **HFSS**.
- There is also **no innovative exercise or innovative levy** of this kind; we do this with cigarettes and with liquor, but we do not do it with this, which is even more dangerous — it is a **silent assassin**. There is no innovative levy and no **health tax**.
- Example of the levy's effect: if chips that are of 10-20 rupees are sold for 40 rupees, and the cost of **makhana** is subsidised, then automatically a behavioural change is promoted, started by the government — the role of the government is big here, and the government needs to

focus on this area.

12.10.2 Limited Regulation by FSSAI

- **Second: limited regulation by FSSAI.**
- The **Maharashtra incident**: a kitchen in Maharashtra was shown with so many layers of oil; some officer had done a food inspection, also in **Delhi**, and had caught them because the kitchens were very dirty. **Tukaram Mundhe** was the name of that individual [as stated in lecture].
- There is a **lack of food safety audit**: at any restaurant where one eats, drinks tea or has a cold coffee, we know that there is nothing called food hygiene in this country — it is an accepted norm. If one started rebelling and fighting with every place there would be no option left, and everything cannot be made at home.
- **Time poverty** is a major concern, and the biggest constraint that a student and a teacher has is the availability of time; despite good spending power in this area one would rarely have a good tiffin seller or a supply of healthily prepared items.

12.10.3 Capacity Building of Food Inspectors and Testing

- **Third: limited training or capacity building of food inspectors**; the role of the **food safety inspector** is very important.
- Food inspectors should not start extracting free kulfis, 15-20 cups of tea and omelettes; they have to be trained in **proper inspection**, in ensuring the **proper oil temperature** that has to be maintained, and in the **testing of food items**.
- Testing food items is very difficult: honey's quality needs **European techniques** and the machine itself is rare in India; few companies have it and it is a very costly test — some **spectroscopy** test, which is an application of chemistry.
- For milk, the **fat content** is very easy to find out with a fat meter and adulteration is easy to detect; but whether honey is **100% pure cannot be analysed even by you and me**.
- So there is no guarantee for 100% pure honey or organic honey unless it is certified — and even if it is certified, **how many batches are being tested and at what frequency is not there in India**.
- So there has to be a **frequency of audit visits and proper testing**; these are very costly equipment that one is dealing with and proper training is required.

12.10.4 No Front-of-the-Pack Health Labelling

- **Fourth: there is no specific health regulation or health guideline**, and specifically no health-related **front-of-the-package labelling** on foods that are HFSS. **Front of the package labelling** is the keyword.
- The **Supreme Court in August 2026** has directed **FSSAI** to take adequate steps to regulate foods high in HFSS.
- There is also **limited availability of food inspectors**.

12.10.5 Fragmented Policy Making and Limited Integrated Governance

- **Fifth: fragmented policy making and limited integrated governance.**
- **Horizontal coordination** is limited between the **Ministry of Health and Family Welfare**, which wants everybody to be healthy; the **Ministry of Food Processing**, which (as stated in class) wants everybody to be obese; and the **Ministry of Consumer Affairs**, which wants consumer rights to be upheld.
- Consumer rights matter because if something is wrong in a packet or proper safety norms are not followed, a consumer will use his rights.
- The items these ministries deal with: chips, dairy items and investment in air-fried items — earlier namkeen used to be fried and now **roasted namkeen** has come, which needs a costly machine and hot air; bakery items, which are rich and ultra-processed — cream, maida, chini and chocolate. All these are the work of three ministries at once: one gives permission, one promotes and one has to stop them.
- **Vertical coordination** is limited: the centre makes the law and has to look after overall public health; then there are the states, where **health is in the State List**; and then the local body, where actual enforcement happens — the **MCD** removes the thelas at old Rajinder Nagar and Bada Bazar Road, but the responsibility of inspection is the state government's.
- If a food inspector starts going to every thela it is a waste of time; so **self-certification** has to be brought in on thelas — some thela owners do wear plastic gloves and at least try to show that they are healthy, but a self-certification mechanism is not there.
- The major guidelines made by the central government through FSSAI also do not coordinate.

12.10.6 Stakeholder and Community Engagement

- **Sixth: there is limited stakeholder or community engagement.** As citizens and students one can talk to the street vendors — there may be at most fifty on this road; train them and tell them how the food has to be kept safe and how the tea has to be made.
- As consumers we should have stakes in the consumption of these products.

QUICK REVISION

- First, there is no stringent regulation or a separate law for HFSS food, and no innovative levy or health tax — although we do it for cigarettes and liquor; a levy that makes chips costlier and makhana cheaper would promote the behavioural change the government must start.
- Second, FSSAI's regulation is limited — the Maharashtra and Delhi kitchen inspections (Tukaram Mundhe) exposed dirty kitchens; food hygiene is an accepted norm, and time poverty is the biggest constraint for students and teachers.
- Third, food inspectors need training and capacity building — not free kulfi, tea and omelettes, but proper inspection, oil temperature and testing; honey testing needs rare, costly European spectroscopy machines, so even 100% pure or certified honey has no guarantee of batch frequency testing.
- Fourth, there is no specific health regulation or guideline and no front-of-the-pack labelling for HFSS foods; the Supreme Court in August 2026 directed FSSAI to regulate HFSS foods,

and food inspectors are in short supply.

- Fifth, policy making is fragmented: horizontally the Health and Family Welfare, Food Processing (which wants everyone obese) and Consumer Affairs ministries pull apart over chips, dairy, air-fried items, roasted namkeen and bakery items; vertically the centre, the states (health in the State List) and local bodies like the MCD do not coordinate.
- Self-certification for thelas is missing and FSSAI's central guidelines do not coordinate.
- Sixth, stakeholder and community engagement is limited — citizens and students can train the street vendors, and consumers should have stakes in what they consume.

12.11 Other Factors — Media and the Food Processing Industry

- **Role of media** — in brackets, especially **social media** — in promoting **consumerism** and a **sedentary lifestyle**, because of reel culture or increased screen time.
- **Increasing commercialization in the media because of influencer culture**: earlier television advertisements were seen — the Lays advertisement and the Thums Up advertisement with Salman Khan, which still come, and the very popular Cadbury advertisement of celebrating Rakhi, an item loaded with sugar; now it has all shifted to social media.
- As consumers you have your limited influencers whom you follow; those influencers and those **content creators** play a very important role in deciding your choices — the big companies tell the content creators to try to sell a particular product.
- The increasing culture of **food vlogging and commercialization of food**: food vlogging has played a terrific role; whenever one goes to a new city one tries to see what items are available — in a hill station or in Delhi — and that automatically promotes food which is actually promoting over-nutrition.
- On wording: it is better to write "**regulation**" than "**corporate lobby**" [a wording point made in class].

12.11.1 Increase in Food Processing Industries

- **Second: increase in food processing industries**; food processing is **good also and bad also** (to be taken up with agriculture).
- Foods marketed as healthy carry a heavy price while others are cheap; the West's consumption patterns are promoted — chocolates and such items; the **cocoa is from West Africa**, it is processed, and they will make their own local taste; it is completely unhealthy but they are trying to earn money.
- The paraphernalia: different food items have come in — air-fried items; earlier there were only chips and chips were fried; now there are **kettle-cooked chips, air-popped chips, air-fried chips and roasted chips**.
- For milk there was only doodh; now there is **full cream, double toned, single toned, zero fat, chocolate milk, almond milk** (for the lactose intolerant), **oat milk and coconut milk**. People are buying these, and this paraphernalia has become part and parcel of food practices.

QUICK REVISION

- The role of media, especially social media, promotes consumerism and a sedentary lifestyle through reel culture and increased screen time.
- Influencer culture has shifted commercialization from television ads (Lays, Thums Up with Salman Khan, Cadbury's Rakhi ad) to social media, where the content creators big companies use decide consumer choices.
- Food vlogging has played a terrific role — a new city means hunting for the available items, which automatically promotes food that promotes over-nutrition.
- It is better to write "regulation" than "corporate lobby".
- Food processing is both good and bad; marketed health foods are costly while the West's promoted patterns, such as chocolate processed from West African cocoa, are unhealthy but profitable.
- The paraphernalia has expanded — kettle-cooked, air-popped, air-fried and roasted chips instead of only fried chips, and full cream, double toned, single toned, zero fat, chocolate, almond, oat and coconut milk instead of plain doodh.

12.12 Environmental Factors

- **Environmental factors**: first, **climate change**. The dimensions are open, and if the structure is known the points come automatically.
- **One**: increasing **extreme weather disasters** have led to **limited crop diversification**.
- **Two**: **uncertain yields**.
- **Three**: increasing **frequency of natural disasters**, leading to **disruption of traditional food systems**.
- **Example**: recent **flash floods in Nepal** have limited the food choices and thereby increased the chances of consumption of **RTE, ready-to-eat, or packaged foods**; in any disaster food packets are distributed — as on Vande Bharat and Shatabdi trains — and the items are processed.
- In the flash floods in Nepal, in the agri food system a farmer may have been growing **bajra**, another **buckwheat** and another **rice** — all of that food practice gets affected.
- In urban areas, the increasing effect of a disaster also promotes a **sedentary lifestyle** — be it a heat wave, be it a flood — basically a disruption of normal living happens whenever a natural disaster rises.
- A disaster will affect **dragon fruit, broccoli and olives** more, but it will not affect **rice and wheat** the same way: the yield of rice and wheat may fall, but the farmer knows that the government will procure — grains will not change as drastically as fruits and vegetables — so automatically the whole food system becomes problematic.
- **Second, in Delhi**: a student mentioned an **Indian Express** article about disaster leading to **disease ecology**, that is, disaster management.
- Because of trauma in the life of a disaster — like the rain floods — people get angry when the rains come, remembering how it was; this creates **PTSD, post-traumatic stress disorder**, and

there is **no counselling**.

- In **Wayanad** there was a landslide and families were wiped out, and in **Bihar** floods are on — this creates a lot of problems for that society also; the speaker added his own monsoon anxiety as an illustration.
- **Third, pollution**: an article in **Down to Earth** said that **increasing pollution affects the overall metabolism**.
- How pollution in Delhi contributes to obesity: you cannot run for three months of the year; Diwali this time is on **7 November**, and stubble (fasal) will be cut in the north-western part of India.
- **Fourth, pesticide exposure** also affects metabolism and is a **major factor in obesity globally**.
- Pesticides are basically harmful **organochlorine compounds**; because they are chemicals, they enter the food chain — they are just like the **catalyst in cars and bikes**.
- They **prevent proper respiration** and the natural reactions going on inside the body which convert the food consumed into energy.
- That pesticide exposure inside the body, because of the **decline in organic farming** and the use of fertilizers and pesticides, has become an increasing concern for obesity.

QUICK REVISION

- Environmental factors open with climate change: extreme weather disasters curb crop diversification, yields become uncertain, and the rising frequency of natural disasters disrupts traditional food systems.
- Nepal's recent flash floods limited food choices and pushed people towards RTE and packaged foods — the food distributed on Vande Bharat and Shatabdi trains is processed; bajra, buckwheat and rice farmers all lose their food practice.
- Disasters promote a sedentary lifestyle in urban areas through the disruption of normal living, and hit dragon fruit, broccoli and olives harder than rice and wheat, which the government procures — so the whole food system becomes problematic.
- Disaster management also covers disease ecology (a Delhi student's Indian Express reference): trauma from floods and landslides, as in Wayanad and Bihar, produces PTSD and there is no counselling.
- Pollution, per a Down to Earth article, affects the overall metabolism; in Delhi one cannot run for three months, Diwali falls on 7 November and stubble burning starts in the north-west.
- Pesticide exposure affects metabolism too: organochlorine compounds enter the food chain like a catalyst and prevent the respiration and natural reactions that convert food into energy; the decline of organic farming makes this a global concern for obesity.

12.13 Role of Globalization in Promoting Over-Nutrition and Obesity

Write an answer on the **role of globalization in promoting over-nutrition and obesity in India and the world** — a **500-word** answer for which **10 minutes** are to be taken.

- **Structure**: do not start writing straight with the pen; make a **diagram**, think — it makes

things clearer — and then write.

- Globalization as a Paper 1 topic: if a person has studied globalization for Paper 1, the knowledge reaches the Paper 2 people as well; the core-to-current interface has a lot of material in the market.

> **PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION**
>
> **The mains question of this year.**
>
> - The question asked in this year's mains was **globalization's impact on the individual** — on **youth** — and the structure written was that globalization has a **social, economic, political and environmental impact, with the human being placed in the middle**: all the impacts fall on the human.
> - Whether the question asks about youth, women, the elderly or the disabled, the structure is clear: for any person — human or even an animal — the impact of globalization will be in the economic, social and political dimensions.

- The dimensions of the impact: **economic impact**; **socio-cultural or behavioural impact** (either can be taken, there is no problem); **political or governance impact**; and, most important, **technological impact**.
- On the technological dimension: everyone uses **e-commerce**; earlier there was the dabba wala in Bombay, which is not there everywhere now; the biggest thing is the **10-minute delivery** started by Zepto and Blinkit — in 10 minutes they cannot serve mutton, so definitely fast food is served, made earlier and given.
  - This is the **most important thing** — if this is understood, **60% of the mains is done** for every question.

12.13.1 *Economic Impact*

- **1. Rising disposable income**, which has led to increased consumption of **UPF and HFSS**.
- **2. Servicification of the economy** — already seen.
- **3. Entry of multinational corporations**, which have altered the food culture — McDonald's, whose aloo tikki one must have eaten, Pizza Hut, and KFC, the deep-fried chicken zinger which is the biggest cause of a heart attack; a better chicken can be had at a normal restaurant.
- It has also promoted the **domestic food processing industry or MSMEs** — the domestic **junkification of food**.
- **4. Contractual farming**, inspired by the entry of MNCs: **Lays** needs potatoes of a proper dimension and a proper starch content, not the potatoes we eat; and for **diet Coke or Pepsi** the biggest ingredient is water, and the ground water has to be exploited and must be of certain parameters, so the factory can be set up only in some places in India — this is called a **Coke bottling plant**.
- Like **Scotch whisky** being famous because of the water of Scotland; in India some areas of **Alwar** and some areas in **Uttar Pradesh** have that water, and **Nashik** has wine because of its grapes. Contractual farming has promoted **monoculture** and has **limited crop diversification**.
- **5. Rise of FDI** — foreign capital not only in food equipment but also in domestic companies

which are in food processing, which has led to an increase in the **availability of processed food**.

- **6. Globalization of food markets** — greater movement of food items like sugar, chini, refined oil, processed foods, beverages and packaged food, which has led to **increased calorie availability**.

- Today McDonald's aloo tikki is made in India, but the oil, the ingredients and the spices are not; if a **Haldiram** centre is to be opened in the US, Haldiram will never take local cheese — its spices and ingredients go from here; if a branch of **Kake Da Dhaba** is opened in New York, the oil, ghee and chicken can be taken locally, but all the items are sent from here, so consumption there is increasing.
- If one goes to any fine dining restaurant in Delhi and wants Italian food, the best **parmesan cheese** comes from **Milan in Italy**; **Domino's** — who knows whether it is cheese.
- They source the best of the best ingredients because the food market has economically globalized: one gets spices from here, dates from **Afghanistan**, and other products from different parts of the world.
- You are sending food and you are bringing food; the food that can be sent in a ship for **three months** is food that does not spoil, so it will definitely be refined and processed; it has led to an increase in calorie availability, and something must have been done to **increase shelf life**.
- Even within the country: if something is to be sent from **Andhra to Dallas**, only those products which have a long shelf life are sent — you would not send something healthy; so the food market has got globalized.

- The **biggest economic impact**, and the visible aspect: **e-commerce and supermarkets** — everyone takes daily items from e-commerce.
- **Supermarketization**: **Reliance** stores; for middle class families it has become a source of happiness, because the wife, who works day in and day out, gets to go out and see what is happening in the world; instead of buying from the kirana store the family ends up enjoying this as an **outing** — in this country it is a source of entertainment.
- When one goes to a supermarket there is a **BOGO offer, buy one get one**: with a plan to buy one Maggi one ends up buying two, and there is a chocolate item there, so consumption is automatically promoted. Consumerism is a social aspect, but the supermarketization of the local retail stores is an economic dimension which has got a social-cultural phenomenon.
- In the US the stores are so big that one cannot imagine — from here to **Agra sweets**; in the US and Europe too, because there it is much more. Kirana shops have finished; now there is buy one get one and buy two discounted offers, which promotes them to clear their stock — they are playing on **volumes**.
- They buy the whole week's provisions at once and cook the whole week's food at once; even the roti and phulka will be processed and the towel is put in the tiffin — these are all a social aspect, and we do the same.
- Supermarketization has led to a change **from local fresh food markets**; the economic survey also said that our food chain is essentially **short** and we do not believe in long supply chains for food — the biggest loss is that a longer food chain increases **emissions**.

- From local food it has become **organized**, so it will be **packaged**, and if packaged then **processed**, along with **RTE ready-to-eat foods**.
- In the West meat is not chosen live: one cannot see it, it is animal-friendly, it is processed, and one can keep it one day, two, three, four or five days — now **Licious**, "fresh to home form", **Reliance and Swiggy**. Earlier, to eat meat one had to get a **broiler** from some factory in the fringe areas, with proper butchering, and it came to daddy and then we ate it — one day, two days, three days; in the garden it will be one day; but in the West it does not happen like that.
- The **biggest catch**, which everybody falls a prey to, including the speaker when he was a student: **promotional pricing**. Licious advertises to non-vegetarian eaters; **Telangana has the highest meat consumption in the country**; the packet is in the packet, and once it is in the packet do not freeze it — eat it fresh; they do not themselves promote putting an item in the freezer; they are trying to strike a balance between the local food chain and proper practices; the idea is simple — "**served fresh but not frozen**".

12.13.2 Social and Cultural Impact

- **1.** It has promoted a **sedentary occupational lifestyle or work-from-home culture**.
- **2. Homogenization of diet**, also called **McDonaldization of diet**, introducing burger, pizza and other items as part of your diet. It is bad because it has disrupted the **local food chain**; they are serving aloo tikki, which means they also respect your identity, but at the same time they are serving an aloo tikki burger.
- **3.** It has promoted **global advertising**, which has promoted increased consumption of processed and sugary foods. Best example: 30 years ago there was **Pepsi and Coke**, and in today's times it is **diet Coke or Red Bull** — "drink Red Bull 20 times a day and prelims, mains and interview will be cleared in one go".
- **4. Convenience store culture** — **24x7** stores (in India the chain would have shut by then); in a convenience store one automatically gets ready-to-eat and packaged foods.
- **5, very important: the relative cheapness of unhealthy calories** — an **energy-rich and nutrient-dense protein bar or whey protein** becomes more convenient and cheaper compared with nutritious alternatives.
- Example: I have worked out and I instantly want **50 grams of protein** in my body; the instructor says 50 grams of protein — it will take **9 days** to eat that; so instead take a simple scoop of whey protein, add two whey proteins in the bottle, do a quick jiggle, add water or doodh or almond milk — in the garb of convenience, and it might also be cheaper. It would not be surprising if 50 grams of protein taken in this form ends up becoming cheaper than the same amount of protein from a natural source.
- A **homemade protein bar will be 10 times healthier** compared with an energy-rich processed bar, because the bar has to be consumed in **6 months**, so the shelf life is increased by adding some external compound or additive.
- Clarification given to a student who wrote that he is a professional muscle builder and footballer: whey protein powder itself is **not** being called bad, and protein bars are not being called bad — **processed does not mean good and bad**; the point is that because of the inherent culture of globalization one gets pulled towards other non-healthy processed and

ready-to-eat food; even if an item becomes healthy, human tendency sways one towards the unhealthy ones.

- **6.** It has promoted **fast food** and the **eating-out culture**.
- **7.** It has promoted **portion size expansion**.
- **8.** It has promoted **aspirational consumption** — example: a **Starbucks** coffee; if you have not gone there, you have to go to that restaurant, and unnecessary calories are consumed. A student's point was endorsed: the goal is to stay humble, eat mess food and qualify the exam.
- **9. The rising opportunity cost of cooking** — because of longer work hours along with commuting time, which makes home-based food consumption a time-consuming exercise, leading to **time poverty**.
- In a service-sector-driven economy like the **US**, everybody could make their own coffee in the morning, but it is a common trend to go to a coffee store; one takes the car to the **drive-through**; the person who takes the order eventually knows you because you come there every day.
- Even if a particular item becomes healthy, one gets swayed towards other unhealthy items because of the inherent culture of **time poverty**.
- **Portion size expansion** means that if you eat a samosa the size is so big; **globalization means abundance, because there is capital**. In the US there are huge numbers of products — cars, things and food items — and the US will have a **two-page menu**; Europe has not been like this; because the globalisation of the idea as a cultural phenomenon has come from that country.
- **Celebrity and influencer culture**: if a celebrity tells you to eat something, everybody is going to eat it; so much of the consumption of brands like **Nike, Adidas and Puma** is based on the concept of attracting sports style; it is not good and bad, it is the fact that we are too much pressurized to buy that thing; we are indulging in consumerism, which is essentially also reflected in food practices.

12.13.3 *Political Impact*

- **1.** The **entry of MNCs has prevented governments from framing stringent regulations** — in brackets, **lobbying**, commercial lobbying practised by large food processing industries.
- Example: **Coke** — because Coke became unhealthy, they made **Coke Zero**, which itself is zero calorie, so the focus shifted to calorie.
- **2. Global food regulations have been influenced by the interests of global food companies** — like **Nestlé's Milk Powder** and the **Nestlé Maggi controversy**, and **Nutella**, which is there with pancakes; all of these are ideas promoted by Western companies, and they ensure that no government can take actions which are against their interest.

12.13.4 *Technological Impact*

- It has led to the rise of **quick commerce and e-commerce**.
- **Latest food processing technology and equipment** — if **Israel** gives, because of globalization, a water-resistant crop, the same country might also provide a machine that can fry **100 kg of aloo in just 5 minutes**.

- Example: the machine **McDonald's** has for heating fries — a very simple device with hot oil in it, in which only the temperature is controlled, with a hand-like pan handle and a rectangular bowl-like holding structure; the item is put inside, the timer runs, and one takes it out, sprinkles some salt and gives it to the other person.
- **Bakery items** are processed in machines; ovens can bake without a baker; the latest **air fryers** — Philips advertises one air fryer with two different items — all of it promoting UPF food.
- This is the effect of globalization, and it is also a part of **Paper 1**: globalization affects festivals and culture; when one says effect on culture one should know what culture is; different facets of culture become a part of Paper 1, and the GS2 people can open that topic; it is slightly tough to handle, but once one gets a hang of it, it is a cake walk.

QUICK REVISION

- The task is a 500-word, 10-minute answer on the role of globalization in promoting over-nutrition and obesity in India and the world; make a diagram first and do not write straight with the pen.
- The mains question this year was globalization's impact on the individual (youth); the structure is social, economic, political and environmental impact with the human in the middle, and it works for any person.
- The dimensions are economic, socio-cultural or behavioural, political or governance, and most important technological — the 10-minute delivery of Zepto and Blinkit shows it; understanding this covers 60% of the mains.
- Economic impact: rising disposable income, servicification, entry of MNCs (McDonald's, Pizza Hut, KFC) and the domestic junkification through MSMEs, contractual farming (Lays potatoes, Coke bottling water, Scotch, Alwar, Nashik), FDI fuelling processed food, and the globalization of food markets with greater movement of sugar, refined oil and packaged food raising calorie availability.
- Food markets source the best ingredients globally (Haldiram's spices, Kake Da Dhaba in New York, Milan's parmesan, dates from Afghanistan); anything that travels three months by ship must be refined and processed, and even Andhra to Dallas means long shelf life, not health.
- Supermarketization turns shopping into an outing and an entertainment, with BOGO and promotional pricing, packaged, processed and RTE foods, meat processed in the Western style (Licious, Reliance, Swiggy), the loss of the short local food chain and higher emissions, and Licious's "served fresh but not frozen" idea over Telangana's highest meat consumption.
- Social and cultural impact: sedentary and WFH lifestyle, McDonaldization of diet disrupting the local food chain, global advertising (Pepsi and Coke to diet Coke and Red Bull), 24x7 convenience stores, the relative cheapness of unhealthy calories (protein bars and whey protein against 9 days of natural protein, a homemade bar being 10 times healthier), fast food and eating out, portion size expansion, aspirational consumption like Starbucks, the rising opportunity cost of cooking leading to time poverty, and the celebrity and influencer culture of Nike, Adidas and Puma.
- Political impact through MNC lobbying (Coke Zero) and global food regulation shaped by

> Nestlé's Milk Powder, the Nestlé Maggi controversy and Nutella; technological impact through quick commerce, Israel's frying machine, the McDonald's fryer and Philips air fryers; and the whole thing links to Paper 1 culture.

CHAPTER 13

Obesity in India — Part 2

13.1 Consequences of Obesity — the Organising Structure

The demerits of the body called **FSSAI** having been studied, the next head is the merits, taken up when the steps taken by the government are studied. The third point to write down is **consequences**.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Keywords for this head.**
>
> - **Consequences** is also written as impact; for the civil services the keyword is **implications**, as in the question "Discuss the implications of the Belt and Road Initiative".
> - While discussing the consequences of obesity, the keyword and the most important thing is **human capital formation / the demographic dividend**, along with the economic survey and the effect on health.

The most important element of the answer is the **structure**. The consequences are opened under these heads:

- **Economic** implications.
- **Health** implications — health and economic implications are connected: the health implication is because of the economic implication.
- **Social** implications.
- **International / global** implications.
- **Strategic** implications.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **What "strategic" means.**
>
> - **Strategic** means long term and **tactical** means short term; both words have come from warfare — when the impact is studied in order to plan, the long-term plan is the strategy.
> - Example: the US might have tactically won the war with Israel and Iran in West Asia, but the strategic loss is more for the US.
> - Strategically, Iran's stakes in the entire West Asia vis-à-vis the Gulf nations have increased — reflected in the insecurity of the Gulf nations after they signed, and in Saudi Arabia being keen on engaging with the US.

13.1.1 Political Impact

- The political impact of obesity basically implies the relationship between obesity and **political governance**.
- Sale of sugary food, and of food high in fat and salt, can lead to a situation where a lot of people fall ill; students and citizens might then launch a protest, which obviously causes **mistrust against the state**.

13.1.2 Child Obesity

- Child obesity is a **new field** — children are getting more and more addicted to **screen time**, and they watch television.
- Example from public transport: the child is not having food while the mother or the father keeps the child engaged with a mobile phone — not a very healthy example of the societal progression being witnessed in the light of increasing instances of child obesity.
- Parents' **food practices** are reflected in the child: the bulk of what you and I consume is impacted by what our families consume.
  - To some extent this holds for over-nutrition and under-nutrition alike — keeping aside economic strata, the role of the family as an institution itself is very important. Family and school are both important societal institutions.
- The impact of the **fast food industry** on obesity and on consumption is a straight, outright impact.
  - Where scope is available, indirect impact can also be written.
- The **community is the first responder and it is also the first victim** — the point has depth, is in all dimensions, and opens up for the civil services main examination.

QUICK REVISION

- The third point under this topic is consequences — also called impact, and keyworded as implications ("Discuss the implications of the Belt and Road Initiative").
- The overarching keyword is human capital formation / the demographic dividend, along with the economic survey and the effect on health.
- The structure is the most important thing; the heads are economic, health (connected to economic), social, international/global and strategic.
- Strategic means long term and tactical means short term, drawn from warfare — the US won tactically in West Asia but suffered the greater strategic loss, while Iran's stakes and the Gulf states' insecurity rose.
- Political impact is the obesity–political governance link: sale of sugary, high-fat, high-salt food leads to illness, protest and mistrust against the state.
- Child obesity is a new field — screen time, the parent-and-mobile-phone scene on public transport, and parents' food practices carried into the child; family and school are both important societal institutions.
- The fast food industry's impact is outright (indirect impact where scope allows), and the

> community is the first responder and also the first victim.

13.2 Health Consequences

Health is written first. Obesity is the **mother of all diseases** — it leads to many diseases.

- **Insulin resistance**, popularly called **type 2 diabetes** — excess adiposity leads to insulin resistance.
- A fact to quote: **NFHS** — high or very high blood sugar among women and among men has increased from **NFHS-5** to **NFHS-6**, and India is the **diabetes capital**.
  - The increase is seen for women as well as for men.
- **CVD — cardiovascular disease**, heart attack and heart-related ailments.
- High **BP**, that is **hypertension**, which means high blood pressure; BP medicine follows.
  - Example: hypertension is common enough that roughly **one out of thirty candidates at a medical board** is found to have a high BP.
- **Metabolic syndrome**, that is, poor metabolism — this is very important; different diets and different workouts exist to boost metabolism.
- Long term it can also lead to **stroke**, to some **cancers**, and to loss of muscle that increases with ageing [as stated in lecture].
- **Mortality** — it can lead to premature death — and **healthy life years lost**: your healthy, youthful years get used up (health is wealth).
- **Chronic diseases** — obesity-associated diseases are chronic because obesity is not like a common cold (**zhukam**), where you take a medicine and get fine.
  - They require: (1) constant medicine; (2) constant monitoring of blood sugar and blood glucose levels; (3) cardiac care, with no indulgence in junk food; and (4) in case, surgery.

13.2.1 Women's Reproductive and Maternal Health

- Almost **30% of women** are obese; obesity can affect **reproductive and maternal health**.
- It can cause pregnancy complications, and obesity increases the risk of **gestational diabetes** (diabetes that affects the woman who is pregnant), **hypertensive disorders**, and **cesarean delivery**.
- In the worst cases it can also lead to **infertility** — and this is not only for females; obesity can also cause infertility in **men**.
- Men and women are both equally susceptible to obesity becoming a concern for health, but females have **gestational diabetes and cesarean delivery** as extra points as compared to males.
- Student doubt raised in class — why is C-section delivery increasing? The answer was that there are several factors, and the class's reasoning was not disagreed with.
  - Mothers also want to avoid the unnecessary pain and concern, and doctors, in the light of increasing **privatization**, do not want to risk and also want to earn money.
- Analogy: cesarean delivery has become like a **LASIK surgery** done for the eye — every Tom,

Dick and Harry can do a LASIK because it is all done by a robotic computer.

- There is also another side: in the rural areas females have got limited choice, especially with respect to reproduction.
  - Even in cases where a C-section delivery is medically required, societal pressure means the family does not allow it and pressurizes going for the natural process without taking any institutional help — that too becomes a health-related concern.
- It is like a **double burden**; both the sides are visible, but if one has to tilt, it would surely be in favour of C-section increasing.

13.2.2 *Child and Adolescent Health*

- It has child and adolescent health consequences — most important, **early onset of diseases**: childhood obesity increases the probability of adult obesity.
- There is also a concern that the mother's **over-nutrition** can get transferred to the child; the child can inherit it from the mother or from the parents.
- Usually, though there is no study, it is said that diabetes is almost genetic and cancer is almost genetic — but there is no research that we have that certifies the fact.
- If the child's own dietary practices continue, then in the coming times, when he becomes an adult, a person who would have got diabetes at 30-40 years of age will get it at 20 years.
- Example: several heart attacks are happening among the young — a young female who was working with **Ernst and Young** passed away in Pune two years back.
- A person who looks completely thin and fine is even **more dangerous** than looking obese, because it might be that the body is not showing the symptoms.
  - People who are very thin say they have cholesterol; one fine day, if they get a proper test done, they see high values because they did not understand the bodily changes happening in them — which is worse than somebody being obese.

QUICK REVISION

- Obesity is the mother of all diseases; health is written first.
- Insulin resistance, popularly type 2 diabetes, comes from excess adiposity.
- NFHS-5 to NFHS-6: high or very high blood sugar rose for both women and men; India is the diabetes capital.
- CVD and heart-related ailments, hypertension (high BP), metabolic syndrome or poor metabolism, stroke, some cancers, loss of muscle with ageing, mortality and lost healthy life years.
- Obesity diseases are chronic because they require constant medicine, constant monitoring of blood sugar, cardiac care with no junk food, and in some cases surgery.
- Women: about 30% obese, with pregnancy complications, gestational diabetes, hypertensive disorders, cesarean delivery and infertility; men also face infertility; C-section rising (avoiding pain, private doctors' incentives, LASIK analogy) versus rural women denied a medically needed C-section by societal pressure — a double burden.
- Children: early onset of diseases, childhood obesity raising the probability of adult obesity,

> transfer of the mother's over-nutrition, diabetes at 20 instead of 30-40, and the greater danger of looking thin while being unhealthy.

13.3 Economic Consequences

The economic impact of obesity **is grave**.

- It will lead to a **high fiscal burden**, because there will be **high out-of-pocket expenditure** — medicines have to be taken, tests will be frequent, and then treatment.
- You are looking at diseases that are dangerous: type 2 diabetes, hypertension and liver disorder — the medicines for all of these run **permanently**, whatever the frequency, the medicines have to be taken.
- It can lead to **poverty**: high expenditure on health can force households **below the poverty line**. The term for this is **medical impoverishment**.
- Every medicine has side effects, and the side effect itself is another medicine.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Diagram to draw: expenditure against time.**
>
> - Take the **poverty line** on the expenditure axis and time on the other axis; show the household **before obesity** and the household **post obesity**, with expenditure rising as time passes.
> - The **World Bank poverty line** is **$3.15 per day** (referred to in the lecture as three dollars per day) — this can also be added to the diagram.

- It will lead to **poor human capital formation**, or poor utilization of the **demographic dividend**.
- **Vicious cycle** of obesity and poor human capital formation: obesity leads to high out-of-pocket expenditure and frequent hospital visits.
  - That leads either to **absenteeism** from work, or to **limited skill development** because of poor concentration and lethargy, or to poor physical capacity.
  - That leads to **low productivity**, which leads to **limited income**, and further to a **sedentary lifestyle**, low motivation and low self-esteem — which leads back to **obesity**.
- Limited income also means fewer work opportunities, which further promotes the sedentary lifestyle.
- The full chain: obesity leads to high health out-of-pocket expenditure, which leads to poor skill development and productivity, poor human capital formation and **working years lost**, and then to poor utilization of the demographic dividend — which is an **economic disaster**.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Where diagrams work.**
>
> - Everything need not be written in the easy areas; diagrams can also be drawn.
> - You can play with diagrams in **social justice** and in **economy**; in **International Relations** it is a little less so — IR will need a slightly more **descriptive** approach.

13.3.1 National-Level Economic Impact

- It will lead to an overall **national impact** — countries like **Greece** and countries like **Israel** have mandatory one year or six months of training that has to be taken in a military force, an added responsibility of every citizen.
- There will be a **GDP-level economic cost**.
- The **World Obesity Federation** estimated India's obesity impact to be **1% of GDP in 2019**.
- It is projected to increase to **1.57% of GDP by 2030**, and to further increase to **2.47% of GDP by 2060**.
- Economic loss occurs because the affected person is not able to contribute to the economy.

QUICK REVISION

- The economic impact is grave: high fiscal burden through high out-of-pocket expenditure on permanent medicines, frequent tests and treatment for diabetes, hypertension and liver disorder.
- High health expenditure can force households below the poverty line — medical impoverishment; and every medicine's side effect is another medicine.
- Diagram: poverty line against expenditure over time, household before obesity versus household post obesity; the World Bank poverty line is $3.15 (three dollars) per day.
- Vicious cycle: obesity → high out-of-pocket expenditure and frequent hospital visits → absenteeism or limited skill development (poor concentration, lethargy) or poor physical capacity → low productivity → limited income → sedentary lifestyle, low motivation, low self-esteem → obesity.
- Chain to the demographic dividend: obesity → high health OOPE → poor skill development, productivity, human capital formation and working years lost → poor utilization of the dividend, an economic disaster.
- Diagrams can be played with in social justice and economy; IR needs a more descriptive approach.
- National impact: state responsibility for fitness (Greece, Israel), GDP-level cost — World Obesity Federation: 1% of GDP in 2019, 1.57% by 2030 and 2.47% by 2060.

13.4 Social Consequences

Therefore, apart from the health dimension, write **apart from intergenerational transmission of obesity risk**.

The whole topic is being perceived with the broad lens of the **utilization of the demographic dividend** and of **promoting the female labour force participation rate** in the economy.

- **Social stigma**: there is one side that says you should be comfortable in your body and there should be no **body shaming** — but that is an impact of globalization, something learned from the West.
- Big brands like **Adidas** and **Nike** are trying to promote **oversize models** — in fact, oversize models have got a higher probability of getting work as compared to a normal model.

  - This is because of the changing nutritional burden, and because that sector has a high growth rate in the economy.
- **Discrimination** — in Hindi, samajik apvarjan, which is **social exclusion**.
  - Apvarjan is the Hindi synonym; **social exclusion** is the term itself, a subject you must have studied in the sociology optional.
- Linkage for the sociology optional: social exclusion is studied through **Hilary Silver** and **Amartya Sen**.
  - In India, **Naila Kabeer** has written about social exclusion in this country, and **Ashwini Deshpande**, a Delhi University professor, has written on it; two or three female feminist economists have also written here.
- Other forms: **ridicule** — weight-based ridicule — and **bullying**.
- **Mental health burden**: it can lead to **psychological distress**.
- Student doubt answered: a remark from the class that this is a matter of **social culture** was affirmed in class as absolutely right.

13.4.1 Obesity as an Equity Issue

- It leads to a **new form of health inequality** — inequality of health is not only in terms of access to nutrition and access to primary health centres; obesity itself is a concern that the government has to accept.
- Therefore **obesity is an equity issue**: it affects **urban rich households**, and it also affects **poorer groups**.
- Example: **cheap, calorie-dense food** — and the concept is not like a McDonald's burger; it is not related to the concept of poverty alone.
- US example: obesity is comparatively very high among **Black Americans** and **Hispanics**, the weakest lot in terms of their standing in US society racially.
  - White Caucasians have a lesser percentage of obesity; Indians, Browns and Asians have lesser obesity; but obesity is extremely high in the **poorer sections** in America.
- India today is at the very beginning: a very large section is still very poor, so we speak of **under-nutrition**.
  - Twenty to thirty years from now, when calorie-dense items penetrate, the **urban versus rural** divide and the **rich-obese versus poor-under-nourished** divide will finish, and this will be an all-encompassing phenomenon.
- It is also possible that the rich are not obese because of access to food items and because they are more aware of health and nutrition — so a **new form of inequality or divide** is likely to emerge.
- India is at the very start of this: the issue is not even in the **policy discourse**, and the government is not going ahead on it vehemently.

13.4.2 Gender Divide

- There is also a **gender divide**, because the **burden is disproportionate on females**.
- Numbers to quote: **NFHS Round 6 — 30% for women versus 23% for men**.

- A new kind of divide is emerging that we are not even aware of.

These are the social issues — stigma, bullying and divide; a societal transformation is under way. There is a **double burden**, and along with the social consequences come **cultural consequences**.

QUICK REVISION

- Apart from the health dimension, write apart from intergenerational transmission of obesity risk.
- The whole topic is perceived with the broad lens of utilizing the demographic dividend and promoting the female labour force participation rate.
- Social stigma and body shaming (an impact of globalization learned from the West); Adidas and Nike promoting oversize models, who get work more easily than normal models.
- Discrimination as social exclusion (samajik apvarjan), studied through Hilary Silver, Amartya Sen, Naila Kabeer and Ashwini Deshpande; also weight-based ridicule, bullying and the mental health burden of psychological distress.
- Obesity is an equity issue — a new form of health inequality that hits urban rich households and poorer groups through cheap calorie-dense food; in the US it is highest among Black Americans, Hispanics and the poorer sections, and in India the urban–rural and rich–poor divide is expected to finish within 20-30 years while the issue is still absent from the policy discourse.
- Gender divide: the burden falls disproportionately on females — NFHS Round 6 gives 30% for women against 23% for men.
- Social consequences bring cultural consequences with them; a societal transformation with a double burden is under way.

13.5 Nutritional Governance Challenge

The fourth consequence is the governance challenge — a **nutritional governance challenge**.

13.5.1 Challenges

- **A complex administrative and policy challenge.** India is facing the **double or triple burden of malnutrition**, and therefore government focus or policy is required to address both.
  - The historical focus was on **under-nutrition**; managing both over- and under-nutrition is an ongoing policy challenge for the **Ministry of Health and Family Welfare**.
- In anganwadi centres, **supplementary nutrition** is promoted for girls aged **15 to 19** — but along with supplementary nutrition come further challenges, because if there is obesity a different policy response is required.
  - For that response the government is not prepared, and the main body for labelling, **FSSAI**, is not prepared for addressing obesity — so where one is heading, nobody knows, and this is dangerous.
- It is dangerous in the light of the **demographic dividend** — India has a **low median age** and a very **narrow window** till the year **2041**; some people say it is a **15-25 year game**.
  - When today's children enter the working-age cohort, India's condition will be like **Italy,**

Europe and Japan — total fertility rate very low, children not marrying, single parenting; therefore planning has to be done policy-wise now, otherwise the workforce and the economy will be totally in shambles.

- Education, health and skill development take all the attention and this area is way behind — but demographic dividend is the big true word, seen in the social justice topics and in its utilization in the economy.
- **Increased fiscal burden**, because of an increase in healthcare expenditure by the government.
  - It will lead to an increased focus on primary health centres or **Ayushman Arogya Mandirs** to address both under-nutrition and over-nutrition.
  - It will also put increased pressure on **tertiary care**, because of the emergence of obesity-related **non-communicable diseases**.
  - Obesity is not like typhoid, jaundice or dengue — these concerns require constant expenditure, and finally they will require **life-long primary care** at primary health centres (Ayushman Arogya Mandir).
- It will lead to the need of a **whole of government and whole of society approach** — this is not merely the coordination you have between the Ministry of Agriculture and the Ministry of Consumer Affairs.
  - Unlike the West, there is no availability of a good stadium — forget a stadium, not even a good place to play, which is the simplest form of recreation; there is no place for cricket, football or badminton, and in schools there is none either, so what recreation will the poor get.
  - The **Commonwealth Games 2010** stadiums now allow you to pay and use those services, but that is very limited; the **DDA playing arenas in Delhi are 10-12 places**.
  - The Ministry of Health and Family Welfare and the Ministry of Women and Child Development must work together, because obesity is **inter-ministerial** and **convergent** — an area that requires convergence across the schemes.
- It also requires a **strong regulatory mechanism**.
  - Illustration: the **Delhi Gymkhana** — established, as recalled in the lecture, by **Lord Willingdon's wife**; Willingdon was Viceroy, and **Linlithgow** was Viceroy from **1936 to 1943** after him. These were flagged as necessary facts to remember.

QUICK REVISION

- The fourth consequence is the nutritional governance challenge.
- Challenge one: a complex administrative and policy challenge — the double or triple burden of malnutrition, with the historical focus on under-nutrition and the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare left managing both.
- Anganwadi supplementary nutrition for girls aged 15-19 now runs alongside obesity, for which neither the government nor FSSAI (the labelling body) is prepared.
- Challenge two: the demographic dividend — low median age, a narrow window till 2041 (a 15-25 year game); without planning now India will look like Italy, Europe and Japan, with a shrunken workforce and economy; education, health and skill development take all the

attention while this area lags.

- Challenge three: increased fiscal burden — more healthcare expenditure, more focus on primary health centres and Ayushman Arogya Mandirs, more pressure on tertiary care from obesity-related NCDs, and life-long primary care, because obesity is not typhoid, jaundice or dengue.
- Challenge four: it needs a whole of government and whole of society approach — not just coordination between Agriculture and Consumer Affairs; no stadiums or playing spaces in India (Commonwealth Games 2010 venues on payment, 10-12 DDA playing arenas in Delhi); Health and Family Welfare must work with Women and Child Development because obesity is inter-ministerial and convergent.
- Challenge five: a strong regulatory mechanism — illustrated by the Delhi Gymkhana recollection of Lord Willingdon's wife, Willingdon and Linlithgow (1936-43).

13.6 International Consequences

International consequences are the most grave of all — this is the last tough part before the steps and the way forward.

1. It shall impact the achievement of **SDGs**.
2. It will reduce India's **global competitiveness** as a supplier of **skilled workforce**.
3. It will affect India's **tech sovereignty**, because of limited productivity and workforce utilization — and thereby affect its role as **Leader of the Global South**.

KEY CONCEPT

Additional linkages for the answer.

- **Sports diplomacy** can also be done: some sportspersons cannot be obese, but the probability of good sportspersons is affected.
- In an IR answer, the **dividend**, the **skill capital of the world**, the **utilization of capital formation** and **sports performance** can also be written.
- In humanities everything is interconnected in the web — a point that is not wrong can be added.

QUICK REVISION

- International consequences are the most grave and are the last tough part before the steps and the way forward.
- One: damage to the achievement of the SDGs.
- Two: reduced global competitiveness as a supplier of skilled workforce.
- Three: compromised tech sovereignty because of limited productivity and workforce utilization, and thereby a weakened role as Leader of the Global South.
- Sports diplomacy, the dividend, skill capital of the world, utilization of capital formation and sports performance can be added in an IR answer.

- In humanities everything is interconnected in the web — a point that is not wrong can be added.

13.7 Steps Taken by the Government of India (Ministry-wise)

The steps are written **ministry-wise** — in the examination, if a scheme is asked and a ministry is asked, it is very important to have a connection with which ministry implements which particular point.

KEY CONCEPT

The opening line of the steps.

- The Government of India follows the **whole of government and whole of society** approach. (In the lecture this was described as the line of the P.I.P. [as stated in lecture].)
- If space is available in the answer copy, this line should be written.

13.7.1 Ministry of Health and Family Welfare

- The **National Program for Prevention and Control of NCDs** — a very popular programme of the ministry.
- It performs **screening, early diagnosis, referral, treatment and awareness** concerning **NCD risk factors**, undertaken regularly in **Ayushman Arogya Mandir**, along with **large-scale obesity screening**.
- **10% reduction in edible oil consumption** — reduce the oil in high-carb food like paranthas, tell the cook to add less oil, and use a spray can (easily available); supervise a little at first and she will get used to it.

FSSAI — Eat Right India and the Labelling Steps

- **Eat Right India** — described as FSSAI's strongest step; it wants to change the **food environment** plus **consumer behaviour**, through posters at public places.
- Recently FSSAI has **proposed a red hexagonal label** — red meaning dangerous — which will flag foods rich in **fat, sugar and salt (HFSS)**.
  - This is important for prelims; the proposal can be seen in the steps, and a **bill** can also be written in the answer as a step.
- The label applies to **added sugar, added fat / saturated fat and added salt** — the added salt in Maggi, the added salt in chips (not the roasted namkeen), and the saturated fat added in Mother Dairy's cold coffee, flavoured milk, butterscotch milk, ice cream and mishti dahi, which also contain added sugar.
- **Criticism from nutritionists**: they will display only if it is "added" — is sugar that is naturally there not harmful for health?
  - Sugarcane juice (two glasses), fruit juice, mango juice, mango shake and any popular fruit-based drink are taken as healthy, but they are not: you are consuming **unfiltered sugar**. Whole fruits should be eaten; a sudden amount of sugar is even more risky.
- Ghee is naturally rich in fat — the point is not that you should stop eating ghee, but that even

for naturally sugar-rich or fat-rich items there should be some **advisory**.

- You should not have a strong **dichotomy between added and non-added** — "sugar is sugar". Doctors and nutritionists say added sugar is better than non-added, but sugar is sugar, that is what the experts are saying.
- The label will be displayed only when **at least 2 of the three** are in high quantity.
- Two or three years back FSSAI had planned a **star rating system**, indicating stars on the food item just like the stars on an air conditioner.
  - As stated, the unhealthier the food, the higher the star — but the general propensity is that a chips packet with a 5-star rating would still be eaten, so that is also **poor communication**; communication has to be very clear, specifically with respect to food.
- The **font** of the warning will be just **one notch higher** than the usual font at the back of any packet — if the usual font size is 10, the warning will be size 11; between 10 and 11 the difference is negligible.
  - Small font is a commercial trick: non-fried and popped items, such as those with whey protein, are written in a **larger** font, while the warning font, as told to the **Supreme Court**, will only be one notch more than the usual font.
- Campaign **Aaj Se Thoda Kam** — a campaign of FSSAI: you have to **gradually reduce salt, sugar and fat**; the message is not to suddenly leave mithai or fat but to reduce the quantity.
- Campaigns **Fight Obesity** and **Stop Obesity**.
- **Safe Food and Balanced Diet for Children in School Regulation, 2020** — HFSS food cannot be sold to school children, or within **50 metres** of the school.
  - In practice school canteens still sell samosa, pizza and chowmein and the rule is not followed, which is absolutely wrong — it should be followed, because school is a very important part of your learning.
- **Labelling and Display Regulation** (this came up in 2020) — nutritional information has to be shown: **fat, trans fat, sugar and added sugar**.
  - If an item has no added sugar, "**no added sugar**" is written in big letters — but that is natural, and sugar is sugar.
- **Food adulteration** is a different initiative, also addressed by the food safety authority: too many **additives** can stop your metabolism and make you more prone to obesity.
  - Adulterated cheese that spoils metabolism, or milk adulteration that cannot be digested, leads to over-nutrition and slow metabolism, which affects your overall propensity to get to obesity.
- About **five, six or seven major points** such as these are what the government also writes on **PIB**; there may be many more, but this is good to go for the exam.

13.7.2 *Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports*

- The **Fit India Movement** — it promotes daily **physical activity, exercise and sports**.
- **Khelo India** — focused on **children and youth**.

13.7.3 Ministry of Ayush

- A very important ministry with a lot of **budgetary hike** in the budget over the past 5-6 years.
- It has promoted **community yoga** and **preventive wellness** — credit to the Prime Minister for the way yoga has emerged as a phenomenon in the past 10-11 years.
- **International Yoga Day** was declared — recalled in the lecture as **2016**, the year being noted as uncertain between 2015 and 2016 [as stated in lecture].
- **Vipassana** is preventive; vipassana is a part of preventive wellness.

13.7.4 Ministry of Women and Child Development

- **Mission Poshan Abhiyan** — it is now focusing on nutrition with a **life-cycle** or **double burden** approach.
- Earlier Poshan Abhiyan was focusing only on under-nutrition; now it focuses on both.

13.7.5 Recent Current-Affairs Steps

- **Mission Sehat** — a recent initiative of **ICAR (Indian Council of Agricultural Research)** plus **ICMR (Indian Council of Medical Research)**, described in the lecture as a **2026** mission: **science excellence for health through agri-transformation** [as stated in lecture].
- Its focus is **convergence between agriculture, health and nutrition**, and it promotes **nutrition-sensitive agriculture**, **diversified diets** (millets, pulses) and finally a **healthier food system**.
  - The reasoning given: if science researches healthier crops and dietary diversity, and proper soil utilization and absorption of nutrients are ensured, those nutrients will automatically come into humans — nutrition and health depend on what we eat, and to eat right, the right crops have to be grown.
- **Let's Fix Our Food** — reported in **The Hindu**; led by an ICMR institution, the **National Institute of Nutrition (NIN)**, which the lecture located in Hyderabad.
- It is a **multi-stakeholder approach** to create a **healthier food environment for adolescents**, through: (1) **evidence-based policy**, (2) **nutrition literacy**, and (3) **campaigning for a regulatory framework**.

QUICK REVISION

- Steps are written ministry-wise, so that the ministry implementing each point is known.
- Opening line: the Government of India follows the whole of government and whole of society approach (the line of the P.I.P.), to be written if space permits.
- Ministry of Health and Family Welfare: National Program for Prevention and Control of NCDs — screening, early diagnosis, referral, treatment, awareness of NCD risk factors and large-scale obesity screening in Ayushman Arogya Mandir; plus a 10% reduction in edible oil consumption.
- FSSAI: Eat Right India (food environment plus consumer behaviour), the proposed red hexagonal label for HFSS foods restricted to added sugar, added saturated fat and added salt and displayed only when at least 2 of 3 are high, the earlier star-rating plan, the warning font

only one notch larger (as told to the Supreme Court), Aaj Se Thoda Kam, Fight Obesity and Stop Obesity, the Safe Food and Balanced Diet for Children in School Regulation 2020 (no HFSS sale in school or within 50 metres), the Labelling and Display Regulation 2020, and action on food adulteration.

- Nutritionists' critique: natural sugar and natural fat (sugarcane juice, fruit juice, mango shake, ghee) also need an advisory — there should be no strong dichotomy, sugar is sugar.
- Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports: Fit India Movement (daily physical activity, exercise, sports) and Khelo India (children and youth).
- Ministry of Ayush: community yoga and preventive wellness, International Yoga Day (recalled as 2016), vipassana as preventive.
- Ministry of Women and Child Development: Mission Poshan Abhiyan now follows a life-cycle / double burden approach, addressing both under- and over-nutrition.
- Current affairs: Mission Sehat (ICAR plus ICMR, 2026 as stated) for convergence of agriculture, health and nutrition through nutrition-sensitive agriculture and diversified diets; and Let's Fix Our Food (NIN, Hyderabad) — a multi-stakeholder approach for adolescents through evidence-based policy, nutrition literacy and a regulatory framework.

13.8 Way Forward

Way forward means extending the steps the government has taken — the steps can be added here, and even the Ministry of Agriculture's **crop diversification** scheme is a step: if pulses and millets are not grown, a diverse diet cannot be obtained.

KEY CONCEPT

How the way forward is written.

- In the way forward, one should **reverse the issues**, or **extend the steps taken by the Government of India**; in the way forward one should also write **international best practices**.
- The reasons themselves are the way forward — the reasons that we know are themselves the way forward.
- The **economic reason** cannot be addressed: we cannot say that the rich should be made poor, because with more money they can buy more. Instead address **nutritional awareness, advocacy, regulation, popularisation of right food practices, a strong role of FSSAI and multi-sector governance**.
- Industry cannot be wished away — they have got so much of wealth and the economy will not work without them; they have to be taken hand in hand, and then a **stakeholder approach** can be followed.

- Content measures given in class: **food regulation**, **warning signs**, **behavioural campaigns**, **food should not be written as a status symbol**, **promoting the local diet**, **awareness**, **role of media and influencers**, **advocacy**, **government involvement**, **agricultural food reforms and crop diversification**.
- Governance measures given in class: **whole of government**, **whole of society**, **networked**

governance, **integrated governance**, **stakeholder approach**, **decentralized governance**, **involvement of civil society**, **NGOs**.

Broadly, the government needs to **promote the whole of government and whole of society approach** and **strengthen integrated, intersectoral governance**.

1. Promote **nutritional education and nutritional literacy** into the **school curriculum**.
2. **Medical education** to focus on **nutritional education, nutrition science**.
3. **Embed nutrition education in school education** by promoting **food diversity**, **local ingredients**, and — very important — **label reading**.
4. Promote **local for local**: tell people to consume what is available locally — shorter food chains mean less processed food automatically.
5. **Capacity building of primary health centres in nutritional counselling**.
6. **Use of technology**: use of **applications and AI** to promote local and diverse **food choices along with crops**, **meal planning**, and to ensure **reminders** — the drink-water kind of reminder, nutritional reminders in **regional languages** ("it is time to eat roti", "drink one glass of water", "eat an apple", "eat a banana"); do not waste time. This is **very important**.
7. **Legal recommendations**: (a) **health tax**; (b) stringent **law to regulate obesity**; (c) a stringent **front-of-the-pack marketing labelling system**.

13.8.1 *Front-of-the-Pack Labelling — Why It Works*

- The best case study is **smoking**: the front-of-the-pack labelling that covers **70, 80, 85%** of the pack rings a bell in your head that this is injurious to health.
- For **liquor**, the advertisement of the liquor takes almost **80% of the space**, and the two-line warning that consumption of alcohol is injurious to health is written so small — it is written that way so that a person does not read it, and in sorrow and in happiness he drinks it.
- This is again **marketing**: how would the big companies stop, they have got so much of wealth (a cricket franchise sponsorship was referenced). Some **persuasive public counselling and communication** and **public advocacy** are needed.

13.8.2 *Example: The Saudi Arabian Model*

- The example is the **Saudi Arabian Model**, which came up in a **Hindu** article.
  - Aside on Saudi priorities in the lecture: acquiring nuclear weapons, maintaining a true presence vis-à-vis Pakistan; and oil — there is an abundance of oil, with all the refineries.
- Saudi Arabia has embedded **NCD prevention as a vertical into its national policy framework** under its **Vision 2030** — its own version of India's **Vikasit Bharat** — ensuring that obesity does not come in the way of its developmental pathways.
- **Calorie labelling in restaurants** — every restaurant has to state, in every item, the calories given in that portion.
  - It has a stupendous effect: if a brand like Domino's starts labelling, on its 1+1 Wednesday offer, the number of calories in one slice, it will surely make you take a step back.
- **50% excise tax on sugar-sweetened beverages**.
  - Illustration from India: the campaign that asked people to drink neembu paani, lassi and

RO water led to a decline in the sale of cola, but it picked up in terms of the sale of **diet cola**, and then the size was reduced — a two-litre bottle was shrunk smaller.

  - Amul lassi is of 15-20 rupees; if a can of Pepsi of Rs 40 is taxed at 50%, it becomes Rs 70 — so people will automatically start reducing their consumption of these sweetened beverages: Fanta, Mirinda, Dew and the others advertised.

- **100% tax on energy drinks**.
  - **Red Bull** is an **Austrian** company, and its speciality is that it promotes itself in a very different style: it sponsors every adventure sport in the world — super bike, motocross, endurance events, dirt biking, air-based racing and paragliding; Red Bull motorsports events are held in India too, and Formula 1 as well.
  - The promotion suggests daredevils who carry their life in their own palm, and that is why they drink Red Bull — and seeing them, we drink it too. We have drunk all the energy drinks, but that energy is not being used.
- **Sodium limit in processed food** — in Saudi Arabia.
- All these **4-5 examples** are a part of Saudi Arabia's Vision.

DATA & FACTS

How widely the health tax has spread.

- **Levy a health tax** — as per **WHO**, since **2017** at least **133 nations** have introduced or increased a health tax.

QUICK REVISION

- Way forward means extending the steps already taken by the government — even the Ministry of Agriculture's crop diversification scheme is a step, because without pulses and millets there is no diverse diet; international best practices should also be written.
- The reasons themselves are the way forward; the economic reason cannot be addressed (the rich cannot be made poor), so nutritional awareness, advocacy, regulation, popularisation of right food practices, a strong FSSAI role and multi-sector governance must be pursued, with industry walked hand in hand through a stakeholder approach.
- Content measures: food regulation, warning signs, behavioural campaigns, food not as a status symbol, local diet, awareness, media and influencers, advocacy, government involvement and agricultural reforms; governance measures: whole of government, whole of society, networked, integrated, stakeholder and decentralized governance, civil society and NGOs.
- Broadly: promote nutritional education and literacy in the school curriculum and in medical education, embed nutrition education with food diversity, local ingredients and label reading, local for local, capacity building of primary health centres in nutritional counselling, technology (apps, AI, meal planning, reminders in regional languages), and legal recommendations — health tax, a stringent law and front-of-the-pack labelling.
- Front-of-the-pack labelling works because of the smoking case study (labels covering 70-85% of the pack) and fails where the liquor warning is squeezed into two tiny lines; persuasive public counselling, communication and advocacy are needed against wealthy marketing.

- Saudi Arabian Model under Vision 2030: NCD prevention as a vertical in the national policy framework, calorie labelling in restaurants, 50% excise tax on sugar-sweetened beverages, 100% tax on energy drinks and a sodium limit in processed food — 4-5 examples in all.
- Levy a health tax: as per WHO, since 2017 at least 133 nations have introduced or increased a health tax.

CHAPTER 14

Framework of IR: India's Diaspora

14.1 Framework for IR in the Examination

International Relations is examined as a distinct segment of the Mains General Studies Paper 2. Before the first topic of the syllabus is taken up, the framework that governs how IR has to be handled in the examination is set out here.

- IR carries **four questions** in Mains GS Paper 2 — the number is usually fixed at four, and can sometimes go to five.
  - The four are the last two questions of the 10-mark set and the last two questions of the 15-mark set of the paper.
- Out of the 20 questions of GS Paper 2, the IR portion is expected to be covered completely — from core concepts to current affairs.
- Of the four IR questions, two to three are comparatively attemptable; the fourth is not so much tough as one that demands **innovative** framing.

> **DATA & FACTS**
>
> **IR in the Mains GS Paper 2 — the numbers.**
>
> - Total questions in GS Paper 2: **20**
> - IR questions: **4** — usually fixed, occasionally **5**
> - **Question 9 and Question 10** — the last two 10-markers
> - **Question 19 and Question 20** — the last two 15-markers (referred to once as the 20 markers; the figure repeated and corrected in the class is **15 markers**)
> - Attemptable in comfort: **two to three** of the four

- Content alone does not do the job in the examination: the analogy used is that of making **khichdi** — many different ingredients have to be collected and kept in one place.
  - The content will be supplied; the student's part is to revise it and extract the answer out of it.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - IR is examined in **Mains GS Paper 2**.
> - Normally **four questions** — two of 10 marks (Q9, Q10) and two of 15 marks (Q19, Q20); occasionally five.
> - Two to three are comfortably attemptable; the fourth needs the **innovative** angle.

- The head runs **from core to current affairs** and is to be covered entirely.
- Collect the content like the ingredients of a **khichdi**; revision and extraction are the student's share of the work.

14.2 IR Answer-Writing: Keywords, Strategic Framing and Decoding Questions

The polity analogy first: a polity question cannot be evaded unless the Article is cited — everything else is of no use. IR works the same way. Every question on a country — India–Belgium, India–Japan, India–Israel — must automatically carry the flavour of that engagement, and in particular the inroads made in that country by the US and by China.

- Write in **keywords**, never in descriptive sentences. 'He is my friend', 'he is my neighbour', 'I trade with him', 'there is diaspora here', 'I have a military deal with him' carry no weight in international relations.
  - An expert examining an IR script wants to see the keywords.
- Attach the prefix **strategic** to whatever is being discussed — strategic importance of a country, strategic importance of a factor — so that the answer speaks the language of IR.
- Discuss every country the way **Belgium** was discussed — as a full profile, not as a passing mention.
- Never quote authors on IR — not one scholar, not another, not any ambassador. Write the **Prime Minister's** statements instead.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

IPMDA (2022) — what the Quad question really tested.

- **IPMDA** — Indo-Pacific Maritime Domain Awareness, an initiative launched by the **Quad in 2022**.
- Its stated purpose: to promote **maritime security**.
- That is the Quad's **geo-strategic** importance — and only two lines were given on it in the Quad class.
- Exam reading: the question did not ask for the importance of the Quad; it asked, in effect, for the importance of **maritime domain awareness**.

1. Strip the label — the question is not about the organisation (here, the Quad).
2. Identify the concept actually being tested (here, maritime domain awareness).
3. Define the concept in plain words with a familiar analogy.
4. Link the concept to the outcome the organisation claims (here, maritime security).
5. Bring in India's own stakes and the region involved (the Indian Ocean Region and the Indo-Pacific).

EXAMPLE

The analogy used for domain awareness.

- Domain awareness is like installing a **CCTV** and watching what moves on the road — how many students are out, how large the scope of the offline market is, whether anybody is troubling my car or a student's bike.
- It is also asking the shopkeepers nearby what is happening in their area — whether water is logged, what the footpath is like, how many children are going towards Kausa Road and coming back, how many samosas and bhature are being fried, it being a Sunday.
- Collating all of that information is the practical application of domain awareness.
- Maritime domain awareness is the same exercise, done at sea.

- **Maritime security** is a static question that came in Civil Services **Paper 3 last year**; for security at sea the precondition is maritime domain awareness — knowing what is happening in front of this building, at that corner, on this side and behind it.
  - An agreement was signed with **Belgium** two days earlier by Defence Minister **Rajnath Singh**; the last three lines of that report in **The Indian Express** said that maritime security is very necessary.
- The question plays a little with English: the bridge being referred to is the bridge between the **IOR** and the **Quad** — that is, the Indo-Pacific.
  - Do not step back mentally; one may defend mentally, but the points will come from this content and from nothing outside it.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Where these have been asked.

- **Civil Services Paper 3** — a question on maritime security, last year.
- **Mains GS Paper 2** — the Quad's 2022 initiative, IPMDA [as stated in lecture].

QUICK REVISION

- Two rules of IR writing: an answer lives on **keywords**, and every country must be discussed in full.
- Prefix **strategic** wherever it fits.
- Quote the **Prime Minister**; never quote authors or ambassadors.
- **IPMDA (2022)** = Indo-Pacific Maritime Domain Awareness, launched by the Quad to promote maritime security.
- The Quad question of this year was in substance a question on **maritime domain awareness**.
- **Maritime security** was a Paper 3 question last year and rests on domain awareness.

14.3 Great Powers, Global Developments and Their Impact on India

The first step in reading the world is to ask what is happening in the world and who decides the top players. In IR those top players have a name — **great powers**.

DATA & FACTS

The current IR calendar cited.

- The **BRICS summit** is being hosted on **September 10–12** — a big event for international relations.
- The **SCO** engagement gave the opportunity to meet the **President of Iran**; the SCO is rated far more important than any other platform (the recording abbreviates it as 'SEO').

These are big events for international relations.

KEY CONCEPT

Great powers.

- The phrase IR uses for the players that decide the shape of world politics.
- In the present phase the three are the **US** and **China**, with **Russia** as the third that has dwindled.
- Every country has to be read through the powers present in it and the inroads they have made.

- **The great-power lens on every country**: whenever a country figures in an IR question — India–Belgium, India–Japan, India–Israel — the answer must carry the flavour of that engagement, that is, the powers and the inroads made in that country by the US and China.
  - Russia has dwindled; a comparison of all three — the US, China and Russia — is to be done separately.
- The same lens applies to reading: when an article is written by an IR scholar or by an ambassador, look beyond the article itself at what China and the US are doing in that country.
  - This one extra step is the whole exercise; nothing beyond it is expected.
- **Global developments** to be tracked: what steps the US and China take in the world and what effect those steps have on India.
  - Example given from the earlier classes: de-dollarisation and the decline of transatlantic trade — a Paper 1 question came on this and the whole of it had been covered there.
- **West Asia as a policy** was explained in detail in a separate session; the implications of developments in West Asia must be known.
  - The region has been in the news for more than two years; there was a war in June last year and another war is running now.
  - For the examination one should hope that there is no peace — peace would change the current affairs somewhat.

Out of sight, out of mind: in personal life we say that what goes out of sight goes out of the mind. In IR the same truth has even greater force — if a country is not engaged with repeatedly, the relationship with it is affected.

EXAMPLE

Belgium — the lesson in engagement.

- Belgium is rarely read about during preparation or in professional life, yet it turns out to be a very important country.
- It is important in sports, and very important because of defence.
- **Antwerp** — studied in world history; the **DRC** — a very important country that was ruled by the Belgians, studied with the First World War and its implications.
- The Belgian Prime Minister's visit had just concluded [as stated in lecture].
- These nations are not heavy in themselves — they are only examples of how the framework works.

- **Effect of the policies of the developed and developing world** — the second head of the syllabus: what policies and steps the **US, Russia and China** devise in the world, and what their impact on India is.
- The best example of this head is the previous year's Paper 2 question ['**BRI has converted South Asia into a space for strategic competition**']; the US is not only engaged with China, it has also engaged the countries of South Asia.
- The implications of the **BRI** and the implications of the **rise of China** are the same, because the BRI is that country's biggest **flagship initiative**.
  - This is to be written up under **Rise of China**.

EXAMPLE

Bangladesh — the BRI question made concrete.

- **Bangladesh**: with **Mohammed Yunus** as interim Prime Minister, the biggest beneficiary has been the **US, the UK and Pakistan**; India has suffered a loss; China got a perceived benefit.
- Earlier, when **Sheikh Hasina** was Prime Minister, the biggest irritant was Sheikh Hasina herself — the US government was after her because of the turmoil it had caused in that part of the world; US–Bangladesh relations were at their worst under her.
- So when the BRI came in and Mohammed Yunus became interim PM, that was the best opportunity.
- The US is also engaging Pakistan; Pakistan is engaging the US and simultaneously engaging China.
- All of this had to be written; it will be covered in the **Rise of China** discussion.

QUICK REVISION

- The top players of IR are the **great powers** — the US, China and a diminished Russia.
- Every country answer must show the inroads of the **US and China**, with **strategic** framing.
- Track **global developments** — de-dollarisation, the decline of transatlantic trade — and their effect on India.
- **Out of sight, out of mind**: non-engagement damages the relationship — the Belgium example.
- Second syllabus head: effect of the policies of the developed and developing world (US,

Russia, China) on India.

- Model PYQ: **BRI has converted South Asia into a space for strategic competition**; implications of the BRI = implications of the rise of China.

14.4 Regional Organisations in the IR Syllabus

Under regional organisations, one question is fixed every year. Two organisations are the pet favourites of the examination — **BRICS** and the **SCO**.

DATA & FACTS

The two favourite organisations.

- **SCO** — four questions have come so far.
- **BRICS** — count its questions on the same lines; this time a **10-marker** was asked from it.
- Conclusion: a question from these two will come — will come.

- This year the examination also opened up the **Quad** — and the question was on the Quad's initiative of **2022, the IPMDA** (Indo-Pacific Maritime Domain Awareness), not on the Quad's importance as such.
  - In the Quad class only two lines had been given: in 2022 the Quad became important because it launched an initiative to promote maritime security — the Quad's geostrategic importance.
- Order of treatment for the region: **Quad, then SCO, then ASEAN**.

KEY CONCEPT

Four dimensions for any organisation question.

- **Geo-political** importance
- **Geo-economic** importance
- **Geo-cultural** importance
- **Geo-strategic** importance — these four words are to be memorised and used whenever an organisation such as BRICS is discussed

- The importance of **ASEAN** is that the Prime Minister visits every year, and India pushes **ASEAN centrality** with the ten Southeast Asian nations.
- ASEAN and Southeast Asia can still be asked.

CRITICAL POINT

The read: ASEAN's weight has come down.

- A **100% guarantee** was given on ASEAN, yet no question came from it.
- The **Act East Policy** has become dull and drab.
- The focus of the paper has moved to the **Indo-Pacific** and to **West Asia**.
- **ASEAN/Southeast Asia has not been seen in the papers for three years** — though it can be asked now and then.

- Hence ASEAN's importance, as a preparation priority, has decreased.

- **NATO** and other organisations fall under the head **other current phase**.
  - When a new current body appears — something new that India creates within BRICS, or a meeting of 45 countries — it is absorbed into this head.
- The **European Union** also falls under regional bodies: the EU and the India–EU relationship will be discussed.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

I2U2 (2023) — the 'other' question.

- **I2U2** — India, Israel, UAE and the USA — the agreement signed in 2023, asked in the examination then.
- The idea: **UAE is the gateway to the Gulf**, and from there one can straightaway reach Israel.
- It was a very far-fetched idea, and it is now completely in the drain; the UAE might still come towards Israel.

- The Gulf picture: the **UAE is very fast** — it is the 'Gen Z of West Asia'; **Saudi Arabia** is a generation above, the generation of the earlier teachers.
  - **Mohammed bin Salman** is gradually opening things up, but he is confused.
- The **UAE is 100% clear that it wants to earn money** — 'this scheme can go to hell, I want to earn money'; it is precariously located, and the more money and the more technology, the better.
- Hence the UAE **stands apart in the entire Gulf Cooperation Council**, the six nations of the Gulf.

COMPARISON

UAE vs Saudi Arabia — two Gulf mindsets.

- **UAE**: fastest-moving; clear that earning money is the goal; precariously located, so more money and more technology is always better; has signed the **Abraham Accords**; stands apart in the six-nation GCC.
- **Saudi Arabia**: a generation older — the generation of the earlier teachers; Mohammed bin Salman is gradually opening things up but remains confused.

QUICK REVISION

- One question from **regional organisations** is fixed every year.
- The two pet favourites: **BRICS** and the **SCO** — four SCO questions so far; a BRICS 10-marker this time.
- **Quad** opened up this year; the question was on **IPMDA (2022)** — Indo-Pacific Maritime Domain Awareness.
- For any organisation use the four dimensions: **geo-political, geo-economic, geo-cultural, geo-strategic**.

- **I2U2 (2023)** — India, Israel, UAE, USA; the UAE is the gateway to the Gulf; the idea is now in the drain; the UAE signed the **Abraham Accords**.
- **ASEAN's** exam weight has declined — Act East is dull and drab, and the focus has moved to the Indo-Pacific and West Asia.

14.5 Bilateral Relations and the 'Other Nations' Basket

Bilateral relations are simple; they are primarily the **gist** of the discussion that follows. The section breaks into two parts — **regional** and **bilateral** — and it starts this week, with **BIMSTEC** being added to it.

- **SAARC has had no summit since 2016**, which is why **BIMSTEC** is treated as its part; ASEAN is understood.
- **South Asia watch-list**: Nepal, Maldives, Mauritius, Bangladesh, Seychelles — the developments in these countries and their impact on India are what has to be seen.
  - Not natural events such as an earthquake, but political developments — for example, elections in Nepal.

14.5.1 *Nepal: a Changing Framework*

- **Balendra Shah** speaks only on social media — otherwise he says nothing.
- Earlier, Indian Foreign Service officers posted in Nepal would meet the Prime Minister directly; India's standing and respect in Nepal were that high.
  - Foreign Service officers are also deputed in Delhi, so the posting pattern keeps them close to the centre.
- The new-generation Prime Minister has sidelined the age-old archaic leadership of the **Koiralas** and of parties such as the **CP Marxist–Leninist** and the **Maoists**, and meets nobody — that is his state policy.
- His foreign minister — the main figure of the **Rashtriya Swatantra Party (RSP)** — has already visited India and has said that this leadership too is new and that they are with India from within [name as stated in lecture].
- After the **2015 Madhesi protests** Nepalis turned away from India; earlier India had dominance in Nepal, and today Nepalis resent India.
- Nepal's position on aid: 'we do not want aid' — the aid being described as **compensation for the climate disasters** that are a result of India's activities, which is the idea that a **disaster is an opportunity**.
- Earlier the Koirala leadership would first come to India's side and then drift towards China; the terrain makes climbing up difficult and coming down easy.

14.5.2 *Afghanistan: Dealing with the Taliban*

- A meeting was held with the **Taliban**; **Mullah Muttaqi** was invited.
- The embassy's employees were officials of the previous **Ashraf Ghani** government; the embassy has now given its agreement and submission to the Taliban.

14.5.3 The 'Other Nations' Basket

- The **'other nations'** list is unending.
- UPSC has asked about **flash floods** in this head — a very important topic, to be taken up in class.
- **Israel and Japan** are the two important countries here — each has been asked **twice**.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Israel: the February diplomacy and the strike.**
>
> - The meeting with Israel took place; the Prime Minister was there on **28 February**, and a day later the operation was carried out [as stated in lecture].
> - Many experts called it a very big blunder — peace-agreement diplomacy was being conducted there while missiles were being fired.
> - The person struck down commanded enormous respect: the biggest protagonist of the **Shia revolution** and of the **state of Iran**, which is a **theocracy**.
> - His writ ran as no one else's — the dollar, cryptos, the entire monetary policy was being run under him; 'his coin ran' would be an understatement.
> - It was a big step and a miscalculation — that is how Israel works.

- **Japan**: it was **Sanae Takaichi** who had come to India; the development with Japan is the same as with Israel — an **infrastructure partner** with very high geo-strategic importance.
  - Japanese technology is used and the **bullet train** is being built.
  - Japan is a friend who never left India's side.
- **Russia** too has not left India, but Russia is like the friend of childhood — the analogy of a friend who speaks one's own language, while Japan is the friend who speaks another language and is culturally completely different, yet whose ideas match ours.
- So the **all-weather friend** in the West is **Japan**; in the other world it is **Israel** — the one partner for technology that cannot be left, because without it one's existence itself is at stake [phrase partly garbled in the recording].
- **Russia is now moving towards the East** — Russia has lost its flavour.
- In the present phase the world is moving from a **unilateral world** to one of **negotiated polarity** — 'negotiated' meaning that one has to grab the other by the collar and say 'I stand with you too'.
- Another observation of geopolitical experts: there are not two parts but **two and a half parts** — the **US**, **China**, and **Russia** as the half.
- Japan, Israel and all the other nations that appear in the news cannot all be prepared; a **template** will be given for the ones that are necessary, and content added to it.
  - Roughly **two to three hours** are needed per country.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - **Bilateral relations** are the gist; the section splits into **regional** and **bilateral** and begins this week with **BIMSTEC** added.

- **SAARC** has had no summit since **2016**.
- South Asia watch-list: **Nepal, Maldives, Mauritius, Bangladesh, Seychelles**.
- Nepal: **Balendra Shah** meets no one; the **RSP** leadership has said it is with India from within; the **2015 Madhesi protests** changed Nepali attitudes; aid is now read as **climate compensation**.
- **Taliban**: a meeting was held; **Mullah Muttaqi** was invited; the embassy has come round to the Taliban.
- **Israel** and **Japan** have each been asked twice; Japan is the West's **all-weather friend**, Israel the technology partner.
- **Russia** is moving east and has lost its flavour; the world is described as **two and a half parts** — US, China and half Russia.

14.6 Abstract Topics: UNSC, WTO, Central Asia and the EU

After bilateral relations comes a slightly **abstract** part of the syllabus — abstract because it has no head or tail. **PYQs are the lens** through which to open what the examination will ask.

- **UNSC and UN reforms** — to be taken up (the neighbours have already been covered under bilateral relations).
- **WTO** — a very interesting question, asked because of the **subsidies agreement in agriculture**; it was taken straight in **Paper 3 agriculture** and will be taken again in December, before the shift to the prelims classes.
- In Paper 3, with respect to agriculture, they asked the **role of the WTO with respect to the decline in global trade** — so two dimensions of global trade have to be prepared for the examination, following the IR approach.
- Along with the WTO they once asked about the **BRICS New Development Bank** — a **2015** question, when the Bank was formed.
- They once asked about the **McBride Commission** or something of that kind — abstract, with no head or tail.

CRITICAL POINT

Why this head cannot be dodged.

- It cannot be prepared in full, because there is no head or tail to it.
- The content supplied while studying the **reforms of global bodies** is enough to attempt **any global body** that appears in the paper.
- This type will certainly come among the four questions — it cannot be left out, unless it is a committee of which one has no knowledge at all.

- A country such as **Uzbekistan** will not be asked; the **importance of Central Asia** will be asked — that is taken separately.
  - Central Asia has **7–8 countries**; there is a **Connect Central Asia** policy; the developments within the region have to be seen.

- One ready line for the answer: **Central Asia's geoeconomic importance is energy security** — it has ample reserves of **uranium**.
  - Example: the recent agreement on uranium signed with Uzbekistan.
  - The importance of Uzbekistan is the same as the importance of Central Asia.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Policy and instrument cited for Central Asia.

- **Connect Central Asia** policy — the framing policy for the region
- The recent **uranium agreement with Uzbekistan** — the example to quote
- **BRICS New Development Bank (2015)** — the one-off question on the Bank
- **WTO** — the subsidies agreement in agriculture (Paper 3)

- **Template and structure matter even more here**, because the question will come out of the blue and will hit you; with the keywords and the structure given, the job will be done.

QUICK REVISION

- This head is **abstract** — no head or tail; **PYQs are the lens**.
- **UNSC and UN reforms** are to be taken up.
- **WTO** is asked because of the **agricultural subsidies agreement** — a Paper 3 question; the December class precedes the prelims shift.
- **New Development Bank** was asked once, in **2015**; the **McBride Commission** was asked once.
- **Central Asia**: 7–8 countries, **Connect Central Asia** policy; geoeconomic importance = **energy security**; ample **uranium**; the recent uranium agreement with **Uzbekistan**.
- Structure and template matter most where the question comes out of the blue.

14.7 Role of Diaspora: The Static Entry Topic

The first topic of the syllabus is the **role of diaspora** — the easiest topic and the best one to get familiar with, which is why it is taken first. It is the **static topic of IR** and it belongs to **General Studies Paper 2**.

KEY CONCEPT

Terms that must be on your lips.

- **Geopolitical**
- **Geostrategic**
- **Geoeconomic**
- Whenever IR is discussed, these words — and the word **strategic** — have to be ready.

- A straight question came straight from the class notes — 100% a straight question.
- Diaspora is a **static and simple topic**: there is no problem in it; four to five hours and the game is over; it is easy to teach and the question will also be easy.

  - It is the question to pick up first in Paper 2.
- **Contrast with the dynamic head**: the head that follows — the effect of the policies of the developed and developing world on India — is the dynamic one; diaspora is the static one.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **The trap students fell into.**
>
> - Several students who wrote the Mains this year said that they knew the question, but could not write the **introduction**.
> - Exam stress happens and is forgivable — but the opening of the answer must be planned in advance.
> - The topic itself is not to be feared; the **structure** is what has to be fixed.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - **Role of diaspora** is the first topic — the easiest and the best to get familiar with.
> - It is the **static topic of IR**, examined in **General Studies Paper 2**.
> - A straight question from the class notes has been asked — 100% straight.
> - Keep **geopolitical, geostrategic and geoeconomic** on your lips.
> - Students lost marks not on content but on the **introduction** — plan the opening.
> - Diaspora is static; the head that follows, the effect of the policies of the developed and developing world, is the dynamic one.

14.8 Opening the Answer: Structure and the Prime Minister's Framing

How does one open the topic? The question may be about benefits, but the **introduction** is written first — and the cleanest opening is the Prime Minister's own statement on the diaspora.

1. **Introduction** — with the statistics.
2. **Keywords and terms** — the vocabulary that belongs specifically to the diaspora.
3. **Importance** — in two dimensions: the importance for India and the advantage for the host nation.
4. **Issues** — those faced by the diaspora, and those caused by it.
5. **Steps taken by India.**
6. **Way forward.**

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **The Prime Minister's three keywords for the diaspora.**
>
> - **Pride of India**
> - **Rashtradoot** — the ambassador of the nation
> - **Living bridge**
> - These keywords have to be shown to the examiner.

- The statement is old but remains the best opener: the Prime Minister, speaking at **Trinidad and Tobago** in **2025**, said that India's **35 million** diaspora is not only of great importance — it is **India's pride**, the nation's **rashtradoot**, and a **living bridge**.
  - This is the start that was to be used in the introduction: India's 35 million diaspora is India's pride, its ambassador, a living bridge.
- Context of that visit — a **five-nation tour**: the **BRICS summit**, then **Trinidad and Tobago** on the way back, then **Ghana**, and one more country in the southern part of Africa, whose name was not recalled at the time of speaking.
- **Trinidad and Tobago** is known for cricket — the West Indians, with names such as **Chris Gayle** and **Shivnarine Chanderpaul**; and in athletics, **Usain Bolt**, the sprinter who seemed to talk to the wind, with many other sprinters also Jamaican.
  - India's diaspora is present in **Jamaica**, then in **Trinidad and Tobago**, then in **Antigua**.
- These people are the **Girmitiyas** — those whose forebears were brought from India as indentured labourers under the British.
- These islands have seen three generations — in fact **300 years**, six to eight generations of persons of Indian origin; they have seen **300 years of diaspora history**.
- **Ghana** is the Gold Coast, in West Africa.
- So the answer opens on this note: in the world, India has built a **bridge** — India on one side and the diaspora on the other.

QUICK REVISION

- The answer opens with the **Prime Minister's statement**, not with benefits.
- Three keywords: **pride of India**, **rashtradoot**, **living bridge**.
- Sample opening: India's **35 million** diaspora is the nation's pride, its ambassador and a living bridge.
- The statement was made at **Trinidad and Tobago**, on a five-nation tour that also took in the **BRICS summit**, **Ghana** and a southern African country.
- The **Girmitiyas** of Jamaica, Trinidad and Tobago and Antigua give that region **300 years** — six to eight generations — of diaspora history.
- Answer skeleton: **introduction** → **keywords** → **importance (India and host)** → **issues** → **steps taken by India** → **way forward**.

14.9 Benefits of the Diaspora: For India and for the Host Nation

The importance of the diaspora has to be written in **two dimensions** — the importance for India and the advantage for the host nation. The PYQ has asked both: what is the importance of the diaspora for us, and what does the presence of Indians give to the host country — in Europe, Italy, the Netherlands, Singapore, the Gulf.

- **Economy — what the diaspora does for the host**: it does not give only remittances; it also benefits the local population. Indians in the US are employed in a **highly skilled workforce** and are generating the economy there.

  - CEOs of many **Fortune 500** companies are Indian — **Satya Nadella**, **Sundar Pichai**; the list is long.
  - Now even AI firms, for instance the CEO of **Perplexity**, have Indians at the top; and these are the older-era examples.
- **Impact in society and politics**: Indian-origin persons have risen to the highest political offices of their adopted countries.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Zohran Mamdani — Mayor of New York.**
>
> - His parents: **Mira Nair**, the director of **Monsoon Wedding**, and a renowned academician of the global order.
> - Mira Nair was a classmate of **Shashi Tharoor** at **St Stephen's**; the two were together in the college drama society.
> - Shashi Tharoor says it was a big loss to the acting industry that she became a director, because she was a very good actress — fate made her a director.
> - From the two of them came **Mamdani**, who became the **Mayor of New York**.

- **Political representation in the US**: there are **five to six** Indian-origin Members of Parliament in the US Congress — the community's clout is felt there too.

Parliament	Congress
Rajya Sabha	Senate
Lok Sabha	House of Representatives

- The resemblance stops at the names: in India the **parliamentary form** means the Prime Minister has to come from the legislature, whereas in the US there is a **clear separation of powers** — which is why power does not run the same way there.
- **Singapore**: **Shanmugaratnam** — a popular Tamil surname — is the Prime Minister of Singapore [as stated in lecture], and has been the Finance Minister and the Defence Minister.
  - Singapore is the one country with which India has a terrific relationship in South East Asia.
- **Culture — what the diaspora teaches the West**: Indians abroad carry **multiculturalism**, which the majority societies of the West do not themselves understand; the diversity of states, castes and food practices is in our blood.
  - **Globalization** homogenises; it shows how different types of societies have to get their act together — and in the West that is exactly what is now happening.
- In the West, after the **Second World War**, the instinct was to protect one's own products and markets — a market model that some call a **new form of imperialism**.

CRITICAL POINT

Multinational corporations as a threat to sovereignty.

- **Multinational corporations** are emerging as a threat to your sovereignty — and indeed they are.
- A country like India **cannot hold a candle** to a company such as **Boeing**, **Lockheed Martin** or **Raytheon**.
- Even a company like **Anthropic** is, in a sense, more important than a country.
- Contrast China: when its leaders travel they take the whole business consignment with them, and a businessman there carries more value than a diplomat — the bureaucrat bows to him, because it is a developed society. In India, a Prime Minister or a Foreign Service officer will not even seat a businessman with them on a foreign tour.
- Post-1970s–80s, as Indians began entering those countries, their political parties turned **far-right**; an **anti-immigration** wave is now running.

QUICK REVISION

- Write the importance in **two dimensions** — for India and for the host nation.
- Host-nation gains: a **highly skilled workforce**, wealth generation and corporate leadership — **Satya Nadella**, **Sundar Pichai**, the CEO of **Perplexity**.
- Politics: **Zohran Mamdani** is Mayor of New York; **five to six** Indian-origin MPs sit in the US Congress; **Shanmugaratnam** heads Singapore.
- Institutions map as Parliament = **Congress**, Rajya Sabha = **Senate**, Lok Sabha = **House of Representatives** — but the US has a clear **separation of powers**.
- Culture: the diaspora exports **multiculturalism**.
- Critique: **MNCs** — Boeing, Lockheed Martin, Raytheon, Anthropic — are a threat to sovereignty, and an anti-immigration wave is running in the West.

14.10 Issues Faced by the Diaspora and Issues Caused by It

The issues come in two baskets — the issues **faced by** the diaspora, and the issues **caused by** the diaspora.

14.10.1 Challenges

- **Issues faced**: Indians being sent back **handcuffed**, and a very large volume of **illegal immigration** led by India.
- **Issues caused**: **Diwali** and the cracker question. In Delhi a **Rs. 500** fine and a limited window apply, with the reminder that the goddess would be displeased.
  - In Canada the **air quality index** is in the region of 0 or 1, and the Canadian government says: it is Diwali, burst as many crackers as you like.
  - In Toronto and in the provinces there are such opportunities that are not available here [this passage is partly unclear in the recording].

- These are different societies — they have not seen the commotion that we are used to seeing here.
- **Canada is basically Bharat**; there is a **Punjab-puram** — Toronto, Brampton — and in Brampton it feels as though everyone there is one's own brother.
- **Khalistani separatism** runs there; it cannot run here, so it is supported from there.
- The college students involved here — such as **Lawrence** — were not goons but decent students, some of them studying law; one fire kept meeting another and the movement qualified; the nexus then passed from separatism to **international terrorism** and to the **organised crime** that we read about.
- **India–Canada relations were at their worst in the time of Trudeau**, because of issues caused by them; a good number — **six** — of Indian-origin MPs sit in the legislature of Canada.

CRITICAL POINT

The diaspora is not one bloc.

- In **England** too the community is a very strong force and very strong in voting — but it does not vote homogeneously: some vote **Conservative**, some **Labour**.
- So the diaspora is not one; **35 million is not one**.
- That is the limitation: numbers do not translate into a single political instrument.

- The dynamics of India are carried abroad — the resentments of here appear there, and the UK example shows how far that can go.

EXAMPLE

The UK embassy protests — both sides.

- A year ago in the **UK**, Khalistani protests took place outside the embassy with the demand for Khalistan; **Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale**'s photographs came up, as also happens in Punjab during elections; there were ultra protests as well.
- Many Indians outside the embassy said that the whites do not understand — for them it is an opportunity and they enjoy it: 'look, this is happening in India' — because the West works that way.
- The reply given to them: they are not the protagonists, those leaders are not representative; it is not like that in our country and not everyone is a Khalistani; their thinking is limited and they carry that overburden [phrase unclear in the recording].
- A counter-protest followed in which the Indian flag was raised in England — and that was appreciated.

- **Soft power is a separate discussion**: soft power is **Diwali**, the regional new years, **Bollywood**, **bhangra**, Indian cuisine, **biryani**, **Ugadi** — that is for us, not meant for them.
  - Here the discussion is confined to the benefit that the diaspora gives to that country.

QUICK REVISION

- Two baskets: **issues faced by the diaspora** and **issues caused by it**.

- Issues faced: deportations of Indians in **handcuffs**, and large-scale **illegal immigration**.
- Issues caused: the **Diwali** cracker question — Delhi's **Rs. 500** fine and limited hours against Canada's air quality of 0–1 and free bursting.
- **Canada is basically Bharat** — a **Punjab-puram** in Toronto and Brampton, and a base of **Khalistani separatism**.
- The nexus runs from separatism to **international terrorism** and **organised crime**; ties with Canada were worst under **Trudeau**; Canada has six Indian-origin MPs.
- The diaspora does not vote as one bloc — some Conservative, some Labour; **35 million is not one**.
- **Soft power** — Diwali, Bollywood, bhangra, biryani, Ugadi — is a separate discussion.

14.11 India's Approach: From Nehru's Scepticism to the Way Forward

The steps that India has taken for its diaspora are a **must-write section** of the answer.

14.11.1 Steps Taken by India

- **Jawaharlal Nehru's scepticism**: the diaspora was always a tricky affair and a tough walk — if you engage with the diaspora too much, tomorrow they will create problems in your own country.
  - His position: whoever went abroad has gone; let them look after that country, they belong to that country.
  - If an Indian went to the US, that is fine — let him be a good Indian; good riddance; you be happy in your place, we will be happy in ours.
- The shift came when **Atal Bihari Vajpayee** came to power — the realisation that the diaspora is also a vote base, one that the **Congress** had as well.
  - **Sam Pitroda** played a very important role in that phase; after the Congress's decline he lost his importance.
- **Atal Bihari Vajpayee** started the **Pravasi Bharatiya Divas**; **Modi ji** then picked it up fully, and the diaspora acquired real clout.
- When the Prime Minister travels to the US or to Canada the diaspora turns out in strength — even the US President notices that there is something in it; and the large business delegation that accompanies him creates weight for the personality.
  - The following that the diaspora gives abroad thus has a direct political return.
  - Keywords too have emerged in the light of that leadership.

14.11.2 Way Forward

- After the steps taken by India, the answer closes with the **way forward** — the section that shows where diaspora engagement is headed.

QUICK REVISION

- The **steps taken by India** are a must-write section.

- **Nehru** was sceptical — the diaspora was a tricky affair and a tough walk; whoever left belonged to that country.
- The shift came with **Atal Bihari Vajpayee**; **Sam Pitroda** mattered in that phase and faded with the Congress.
- **Pravasi Bharatiya Divas** was started by **Vajpayee** and picked up fully by **Modi ji**, giving the diaspora real clout.
- The diaspora's turnout abroad and the accompanying business delegation create weight for the leadership.
- The answer closes with the **way forward**.

14.12 The PYQ Pattern on the Diaspora

The PYQs of this topic are the easiest — there is nothing much in them. **Four questions have come in the last 13 years**, that is, from **2013 to 2026**.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

What has been asked.

- Role of the diaspora in the **politics and economy** of America and the European nations — to be read as the **West**: what benefits the diaspora has in politics and economy there.
- Role of the diaspora in the **South-East Asian countries**.
- **Economic and political benefits** of the diaspora **for India**.
- The **2026** PYQ — to be taken up at the end of the topic.

- For this topic **nothing outside this content needs to be referred to** — whatever is written here should be learnt by heart; the question comes 100% from it.
- The importance of the diaspora has been asked in both directions — what it does for India, and what it does for the host nation (Europe, Italy, the Netherlands, Singapore, the Gulf).
- The PYQs must be seen once — they are the map of this topic.

QUICK REVISION

- **Four** diaspora questions in the last **13 years (2013–2026)**.
- Asked: role in the politics and economy of the **West**; role in **South-East Asia**; **economic and political benefits for India**; and the **2026** question, kept for the end.
- Learn this content by heart — nothing outside it is needed.
- The importance question can be framed for India or for the host nation.

14.13 Diaspora: Definition, Numbers and Categories

The numbers to quote are the **MEA** numbers. Whoever is outside — whoever went abroad — is the diaspora. When the term diaspora is used it implies **overseas Indians**, which is what the MEA calls them.

DATA & FACTS

The diaspora in numbers (MEA).

- Total overseas Indians: **37.3 million** — approximately **3.7 crore**, or **370 lakh**.
- Conversion tip: millions convert more easily into crore; our own population is **150 crore** (160 crore in Hindi), so the familiarity helps.
- **PIOs (persons of Indian origin): 19.5 million**, that is, about **20 million**.
- **NRIs (non-resident Indians): 17.7 million**.

- **NRI — non-resident Indian**: any Indian abroad who has a **green card** or a **blue card** and is not a citizen of that country; such a person holds an Indian passport but is a non-resident Indian.
- **PIO — person of Indian origin**: one who has taken the citizenship of another country.
  - They are also taunted as **white-washed**: if you go abroad and I come to you 30 years later, you will have become a citizen — an American — while I am still an NRI, so I would call you white-washed.
  - That is the **PIO-versus-NRI** fight.

COMPARISON

NRI vs PIO.

- **NRI** — holds an Indian passport; has a green card or a blue card but is not a citizen of that country; counted at **17.7 million**.
- **PIO** — has taken the citizenship of another country; taunted as **white-washed**; counted at **19.5–20 million**.

- Examples of PIOs: **Zohran Mamdani**; **Rishi Sunak** — the son-in-law (damaad) of **Narayan Murthy** of **Infosys**; **Kamala Harris**, a US citizen.
  - **Suella Braverman** traces her roots to an East African country — Indians first went to East Africa, and she later moved on to England.

KEY CONCEPT

OCI — a misnomer.

- The **OCI (Overseas Citizen of India)** card is studied in the polity textbook, in the chapter on citizenship.
- It is a **misnomer**: a citizen of India is a citizen of India. An overseas citizen of India is basically a person of **Indian origin** who went to Canada or the US and has become a citizen of that country.
- Such a person can hold an OCI card and will not have to face too many hassles on coming to India — there are **easy immigration facilities**.

- One and a half years ago (last year) the Government of India, led by the **Ministry of Home Affairs**, launched a **portal** for easy immigration into India for PIOs.
  - It has made immigration very easy for any NRI or PIO arriving from the US, from Canada or from Dubai.

  - The name of the portal was not recalled at the time of speaking [as stated in lecture].
- A note on the service that produces these numbers: entry into the Foreign Service means training in Delhi — earlier at **Metcalfe House**, and training still happens there — the **Sushma Swaraj Institute**, right in front of the JNU and between the IIT and the JNU.
  - Foreign languages are taught there — Chinese, Arabic, Persian, the language of the region posted to — and reading local newspapers is essential: posted in Pakistan, one reads **Dawn** in Urdu.
  - Then one is posted as **Third Secretary**, so the learning is very strong.
- There are also deputations and study leave: the UN, or a top school in the West such as the **Harvard Kennedy School**, or Singapore for public policy — two and a half to three years with family, good contacts and the best minds of the world.
  - This is also the route by which an officer becomes an **NRI** — the government gives many such opportunities.

QUICK REVISION

- Quote **MEA** numbers: **37.3 million** overseas Indians — about **3.7 crore** or **370 lakh**.
- **PIO ≈ 19.5–20 million**; **NRI = 17.7 million**.
- **NRI** holds an Indian passport with a green card or blue card; **PIO** has taken another country's citizenship.
- The PIO is taunted as **white-washed**; that is the PIO-versus-NRI fight.
- **OCI** is a misnomer — an overseas citizen of India is a person of Indian origin with easy immigration facilities.
- The **Ministry of Home Affairs** launched a portal for easy immigration of PIOs; the name was not recalled [as stated in lecture].

14.14 Country-wise Distribution of the Indian Diaspora

United States	5.69 million (about 57 lakh)	The migration there is only about 100 years old; about 3–3.5 lakh students a year study there and the number has come down after Trump; students now go to England and Europe
Canada	3.6 million	The Punjab-puram — Toronto and Brampton; six Indian-origin MPs in its legislature; relations were at their worst under Trudeau; the migration shift is moving away because of separatism; it is the second-largest country in the world by area, with the melting Arctic and Arctic fishing set to open up
Malaysia	22.9 million [as stated in lecture]	Unexpected country with a medieval history — British-made plantations of 300 years ago whose people are now citizens; migration of doctors and skilled workers; its Islamic bent and its attempt to lead the Islamic world create strong competition with Pakistan and Turkey; Islamisation and fundamentalism spoil the relationship; its PM has recently visited India; it is part of ASEAN
Saudi Arabia	2.7 million	Part of the Gulf concentration — respect without stakes
Gulf (overall)	6.6–8 million; also cited as about 9 million	Huge social and economic capital but politically almost zero; in Kuwait, Qatar, Bahrain and Oman Indians earn a great deal; Kerala Muslims who migrated have done very well; the Middle East really respects

- **Australia** — no number was given: immigration is being promoted there, and the Prime Minister has visited Australia, New Zealand and Vietnam.
  - The migration shift has moved towards Australia as Canada goes slightly down and the US goes very down; New Zealand, Australia and Canada are the three areas inviting a lot of skilled migrants.
  - Post the transatlantic and trans-Pacific decline in cooperation, and with the US telling all partners to be on their own, Australia has become a very important country.
- **New Zealand** — **Rachin Ravindra**, whose father named him after **Sachin** and **Ravindra**; a very good player.
- Cheap destinations: **Georgia**, **Armenia**, Russia and China — China has realised that this is a source of earning money; one goes there and comes back, and they are all students.
  - **Iran**: the diaspora is very small, but a lot of people go there.
- **Skilled capital and the demographic dividend**: the Prime Minister is looking at the diaspora because the economy has to grow, which means our people have to be placed there.
  - Anti-immigration protests happen a little everywhere in developed countries and should not be taken to heart.
- **Migration history — United States**: the **Ghadar movement** reached the West Coast, California, and then Seattle — just above Seattle is Vancouver in Canada — and that was in the 1900s, in **1910–1911**.
  - So US migration is only about **100 years** old; the real migration was **post-1950s**, when IIT-trained people came and found opportunity, US Presidents encouraged it, Nehru was Prime Minister till **1964**, and some government policies and hand-holding followed, also in **Indira Gandhi's** time.
- **Migration history — the Gulf**: Indians began going there after the **1960s**, to Saudi Arabia, Qatar and Oman, because oil was found; the **oil boom of the 1960s–70s** set off the migration (a reference was made to an attack on the North Dome gas field, 2006).
- The Girmitiya countries and the older diaspora layers have **lost their attraction** because of the numbers in the Gulf and the US, but in terms of history they are much older.

QUICK REVISION

- Largest concentrations as given: **US 5.69 million**, a second concentration of **3.9 million** (country not named), **Canada 3.6 million**, **Malaysia 22.9 million** [as stated].
- **Saudi Arabia 2.7 million**; the Gulf overall **6.6–8 million**, also cited as about **9 million**; Kuwait almost **1 million**; **Sri Lanka 1.6 million**; **South Africa 1.3 million**; **Mauritius 0.89 million**.
- The Gulf holds economic and social capital but almost **no political capital**.
- Migration to the **US is only about 100 years old** (Ghadar movement, 1910–1911); the real migration is post-1950s; Gulf migration began after the **1960s oil boom**.
- **New Zealand, Australia and Canada** are the three areas now inviting skilled migrants.
- Cheap destinations: Georgia, Armenia, Russia, China; **Iran** has a very small diaspora.

14.15 Girmityas, the Indo-Pacific and the Quad: India's Civilisational Claim

14.15.1 Girmityas: Who They Are

KEY CONCEPT

Girmityas.

- **Girmityas** are former **indentured labourers** — they were taken from India during the colonial period to the **Indo-Pacific**.
- Mentioning the Girmityas is absolutely necessary when writing any answer on this topic.
- The **Girmitiya** term itself comes from the agreement (girmit) under which they were taken [gloss as used in the lecture].

- Broad groups of Girmitiya destinations: **Fiji** (with Mauritius along with it); **Southern Africa**; and the **Caribbean — Trinidad and Tobago**, that is, what we know as the **West Indies**.
- When the Prime Minister visited **Trinidad and Tobago** last year, the local **Bhojpuri** instrument and song were played — possibly the **Chautal** [as stated in lecture].

14.15.2 India's Civilisational Claim in the Indo-Pacific

- The **geocultural importance of the Girmityas determines the importance of the Quad**, because when the importance of the Quad is discussed it is also geoculturally important — several important Indians reside in this region.
- India has a claim on the Indo-Pacific: the **actual protagonist of this region in IR is India**, because the people staying there are either Indians (500 crore in India [as stated in lecture]) or Southeast Asian nations with a Girmitiya history of at least **200–300 years**.
- Everyone says that India has stakes there — the answer is that India has **historical and civilizational stakes**, which is stronger ground.

KEY CONCEPT

The line to write (in brackets).

- Write on: '(... are a proof of India's **civilizational and geocultural importance** in the **Indo-Pacific and Indian Ocean region**, and thereby improve India's importance in **regional platforms like the Quad**.)'
- The argument order is: Girmityas → proof of civilizational reach → improved standing in the Quad and other Indo-Pacific platforms.

14.15.3 ASEAN Centrality and the Two Audiences

- With **ASEAN** — the **ten Southeast Asian nations** — India gives the push and the importance: 'this entire Indo-Pacific and your Asia-Pacific region belongs to you; the Indian Ocean is mine and the Pacific Ocean is yours.'
  - When India goes to them it says everything is theirs; the language flatters the audience.
- With the **US and China**, on the global platform — because they are lesser in importance in the power matrix — India says that the **Indo-Pacific has more stakes than any of these regions or countries**.

- So the **IOR is ours** — and China is breaking that.

14.15.4 China in the Indian Ocean Region

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

How the infrastructure is used.

- China is using **infrastructure as a tool** and as a **weapon**, and the **BRI as a weapon**, while increasing its presence in the IOR.
- **Kyaukphyu port** in Myanmar
- **Sittwe** in Myanmar
- **Hambantota** in Sri Lanka
- **Gwadar** in Pakistan
- **Djibouti** in East Africa

- The keyword to carry: **Pakistan and China are revisionist powers** — they will break the status quo, and to break it China used the **BRI**; the question asked was about the **regional implications of China for India**.
- The sense to convey: no one can become a goon in **my backyard** — in my area, in my institute; the biggest goon here is me.
  - So whatever China does in the IOR is my backyard being disturbed — that is the **impact of the BRI**.
- Every question and every topic has its keywords — for instance, for nutrition the keywords are nutrition poverty, nutrition transition, obesity and nutrition education.

QUICK REVISION

- **Girmityas** = indentured labourers taken from India in the colonial period to the Indo-Pacific; they must be mentioned.
- Girmitiya destinations: **Fiji** (with Mauritius), **Southern Africa**, the **Caribbean** — Trinidad and Tobago (West Indies).
- Their **geocultural importance determines the Quad's importance**; India is the **actual protagonist** of the Indo-Pacific.
- Write the bracketed line: proof of India's **civilizational and geocultural importance** in the Indo-Pacific and IOR, improving India's importance in the **Quad**.
- **ASEAN centrality** is pushed with the ten Southeast Asian nations; with the US and China, India claims the Indo-Pacific has the most stakes.
- China breaks the IOR with **infrastructure as a weapon** and the **BRI**: Kyaukphyu, Sittwe, Hambantota, Gwadar, Djibouti.
- **Pakistan and China are revisionist powers** — the keyword; the BRI's impact is my backyard being disturbed.

14.16 Brand Ambassadors and the Living Bridge

- The diaspora are **brand ambassadors** — the strongest brand ambassadors of India, of India's values and of India's culture.
- They are the **cultural ambassadors** of the country, and their strength lies in carrying those values with them.

> **GOVERNMENT & POLICY**
>
> **What they are brand ambassadors of.**
>
> - **Make in India** — the illustration given is the **Vikram**, made by **Skyroot**
> - **Yoga** — with tremendous potential in **wellness tourism**
> - **India's values and culture** — carried by the community into every host society

- **Living bridge** — the phrase was given by the Prime Minister in **June 2016** (in Malaysia).
  - A bridge is a two-way structure, so the living bridge works in both directions.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **The living bridge, drawn as a diagram.**
>
> - **Indian influence on the host** — the values that we carry as Indians are taken to the host and change and reform that society's culture.
> - **The host's influence on India** — the diaspora also increases the host country's influence in India.
> - The diagram to draw in the answer is therefore a two-way arrow: **India** ↔ **host nation**.

- The host nations have been getting a stake in India: a lot of **equity investment** has come into India because the West has seen the Indians' **work culture, ethics and overall understanding of skills**.
  - So if one wants to raise money in India for a startup, a big chunk of that money — until AI came in, 10 years back — was coming from these host nations, because the diaspora was a **living replication of India**.
- A US investor who sees those hundred people and their values and sees tremendous potential tells his fellows: let us go to India and put our money there — it will be great.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - The diaspora are the strongest **brand ambassadors** of India's values and culture.
> - They are brand ambassadors of **Make in India** (illustration: the **Vikram** of **Skyroot**) and of **yoga**, with potential in **wellness tourism**.
> - **Living bridge** — the Prime Minister's phrase, given in **June 2016** in Malaysia.
> - The bridge is **two-way** — draw **India** ↔ **host nation**.
> - Host nations invest in India because of the diaspora's work culture, ethics and skills — the diaspora is a **living replication of India**.
> - Startup and equity money, until AI arrived, came substantially from these host nations.

14.17 The Diaspora as Ambassadors, Pride and a Mini India

The Indian diaspora is the reason a host country is willing to come to India on different parameters — those who have gone out are, in effect, India's ambassadors, carrying the country's case into the host society.

- **Brain circulation and reverse brain drain**: those who left — the top IIM students of the 1970s generation and those who followed — created social capital and economic capital abroad, and then invested it back in India.
  - The **ISB — the Indian School of Business** — is one of the top business schools we have; it was started by its initial members, including **Rajat Gupta**.
- **Rajat Gupta — what he means for this topic**: an **IIT Delhi** graduate and a global CEO of **McKinsey**, a very big consultancy firm.
  - He was also caught for some siphoning of money and **insider trading** and went behind prison — that is a different matter, not the concern of this topic.
  - The point that matters: having gone to the US and proved his mettle in the world of consultancy and finance, he was also the reason an institute got established in India.
- **Ideas flow with people**: brain circulation means ideas arrive with the diaspora — **Flipkart**, **Amazon**, e-commerce models that everyone in India now uses, and the app-based taxi idea (Uber has ten people, Ola has many) [the passage about the first co-operative taxi and the interview of its drivers is garbled in the recording].
- **Pride and mini India**: the diaspora is our **pride**, and it also represents a **mini India**.
  - Go to any country and you will find the values of this country in them; the aberrations are different, but overall the values — Indian values, Asian values, very easily South Asian values — are the same.
- **The South Asian mix found abroad**: the neighbours are **Bharat, Bangladesh, Nepal, Pakistan and Afghanistan** — Afghanistan is different, culturally not South Asia though it is in the geographical location of the world, and the language differs too.
  - Abroad, many Pakistanis and Bangladeshis are also present; Bangladeshis can still be separated because of the **Bangla dialect** and slightly different **anthropometry**, but Pakistanis and Indians look very much the same.
- **The counterfactual**: if no Indians go out, there is no diaspora and there are no inventions — the going out is what makes the coming back possible.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **The keyword — brain circulation.**
>
> - **Brain circulation**, not brain drain: people, ideas and capital move in both directions.
> - The proof cited is **Rajat Gupta** and the **ISB** — an institute established in India by someone who had made his mark abroad.
> - A reply carried in the class discussion: Modiji says you don't complain and you don't have to blame — the meaning running back to brain circulation, against the complaint that those abroad are not willing to do the same for India [the passage is partly garbled in the recording].

QUICK REVISION

- The diaspora is the reason a host country engages with India on different parameters — they are India's ambassadors.
- **Brain circulation** and **reverse brain drain** are the keywords; the **ISB** was started by its initial members, including **Rajat Gupta**.
- **Rajat Gupta**: IIT Delhi, global CEO of **McKinsey**, jailed for siphoning and **insider trading** — and the reason an institute was established in India.
- Brain circulation means ideas flow in — **Flipkart**, **Amazon**, e-commerce, app-based taxis.
- The diaspora is our **pride** and a **mini India**; the same values are found in any country.
- Pakistanis and Bangladeshis are also part of the mix abroad; Bangladeshis are told apart by dialect and anthropometry, Pakistanis are not.
- No Indians going out means no diaspora and no inventions.

14.18 India's Engagement with the Diaspora: The 4C Approach and the Keywords

For the Government of India, whoever has gone out is a very big thing. The answer line to write down is: **India's engagement with the diaspora is based on ...** — and what fills that blank is a set of keywords and the **4C approach**.

- **The keywords to carry**: **Rashtradoot**, **Living Bridge**, **Pride**, and the **4C approach** — every one of these is a keyword, and all of them are to be written.
- **The Prime Minister's tourism line**: every Indian should ensure that somebody from abroad comes to India.
  - It will basically promote tourism; **medical tourism** is obviously very important.
  - The larger point: you want people to come to India — that is very important.

KEY CONCEPT

The 4C approach.

- **Care** — the first C.
- **Connect** — the second C.
- **Celebrate** — the third C: celebrate togetherness, celebrate festivals, celebrate with them.
- **Contribute** — the fourth C: we will contribute for their welfare.

QUICK REVISION

- Write the line: **India's engagement with the diaspora is based on** the 4C approach.
- **Keywords**: Rashtradoot, Living Bridge, Pride, 4C approach.
- **4C = Care, Connect, Celebrate, Contribute** (numbered one to four).
- **Celebrate** — togetherness and festivals, celebrated with them.
- **Contribute** — for their welfare.

- The Prime Minister's line: every Indian should ensure that somebody from abroad comes to India — it promotes tourism, and **medical tourism** matters greatly.

14.19 Economic Importance I: Remittances, Forex Reserves and Household Income

The importance of the diaspora is the main part of the topic. The first economic benefit is money — the remittances that reach home.

- **A student's answer that opened the point**: your friends abroad have promoted the Indian economy — they have been a source of **remittances**, and a very great force.
- **Benefit 1 — money comes home**: the first economic benefit is the money the diaspora sends back.

DATA & FACTS

Remittances — the numbers to quote.

- In **2024** India got remittances worth **130 billion dollars**.
- As per the **World Bank's World Remittance Report**, **India is the largest receiver of remittance**.
- **Mexico** is second, with almost **70 billion dollars**.
- **China** is number three, with **48 billion dollars**.
- **Pakistan** — **33 billion dollars**; the country's name was deliberately left as a blank letter in class for the students to fill.

- **Why Mexico comes second**: a lot of Mexicans are in the US. Mexico is culturally just like India — in Mexico too the **family values** are similar; there is no racial similarity, but there **is** cultural similarity.
- **Pakistan and the hospitality industry**: Pakistanis go abroad in very large numbers; in major US cities such as **Seattle, New York and California** they are found more in the **hospitality industry** — the shawarma roll and similar food.
  - Indians are in the skilled sector — and in other areas as well — but Pakistanis are concentrated more in that profession.
- **Exam note**: a related point also came up in the examination in **Paper 1** — **water security**, under water resources; it is to be discussed [the link is not spelled out in the recording].
- **It boosts foreign reserves**: remittances are very important in the light of the **recent depreciation of the rupee** — in fact, it is the **NRIs who saved it**. The **RBI** had allowed FCNR and NR deposits, and a good amount of billions of dollars came in.
- **It boosts household income**: the NRI sends a part of his salary home, to his parents and his family.
  - If somebody is earning **Rs. 20,000** in India against somebody earning **2,000,000** in **Saudi Arabia**, out of that 2,000,000 a share comes home — and with that money the son's **NEET** coaching happens; that is what remittances do to an economy like India [figures as stated

in lecture].

- **The Gulf factor**: the Gulf sends more than anywhere else, because in the West the whole family is called over; in the Gulf you will not call your family — you do the job yourself and come back.
  - Africa: you will not call your family. US: whoever went would surely have called in his family. Singapore: the family would have been called over.
  - Therefore the overall remittance flow from the **Gulf** is very much larger than from the West.
- **Benefit 3 — therefore it strengthens rural consumption**.
- **Sequencing note given here**: the economy, with the Economic Survey, and global issues are to be taken after the prelims along with current affairs; economy carries **three-four questions in Paper 3** [the recording's reference to '120 economic survey' is unclear].

1	United States	27.7%	Almost 35 billion dollars a year — about a quarter of the 130 billion
2	UAE	About 19%	Not stated
3	United Kingdom	10.8%	Not stated
4	Saudi Arabia	6.7%	Not stated
5	Singapore	6.6%	Not stated

- **Singapore — the fifth source and its oddities**: outside India, the highest density of **IIT and IIM students** is found in **Singapore**; Tamil is spoken there; it is a tiny country, it begins and ends at once, and only a three-to-four-hour flight from India.
  - Its other problem: everything is far too organised, and that organisation kills the flavour of being an Indian; the hustle and bustle is not a skill, but we take it as a skill [passage partly garbled in the recording].
  - Someone known to the class who was working in Singapore, seeing the retirement scenario, decided he too would come to India and prepare [name as stated in lecture].
- **The shift in migration**: earlier the dependence was on the **Gulf**; today there is a **shift towards the advanced economies**.
  - The Gulf takes both the skilled and the blue-collar worker — the buildings going up, the construction, the hotels — which is the **semi-skilled to skilled** movement.
  - The skilled go to the **OECD nations** — technology, doctors (US top doctors earn a lot of money), millionaires, engineers, finance: it is like the **American dream**.
- **The earnings gap**: going to the US is a million dollars a year — one million dollars is about **Rs. 10 crore a year**, against about **Rs. 2.5 crore a year** in Bharat; compare on purchasing power. The OECD fields named are technology, medicine, finance, engineering and research

[figures as stated in lecture].

- **What this shows**: India's **demographic dividend** — however many technologies develop in the times to come, it is Indians who will provide the workforce.

QUICK REVISION

- **2024**: remittances of **130 billion dollars**; per the **World Bank's World Remittance Report**, India is the **largest receiver**.
- Order: India first, **Mexico** second (almost 70 billion), **China** third (48 billion), **Pakistan** 33 billion.
- Mexico is culturally similar to India — family values, not race.
- **Benefit 1 is money**; it boosts **foreign reserves** (crucial in the depreciation of the rupee — the NRIs saved it) and **household income**, and therefore **strengthens rural consumption**.
- Gulf remittances are the largest because the family cannot be called over there.
- Shares of the 130 billion: **US 27.7%**, UAE about **19%**, UK **10.8%**, Saudi Arabia **6.7%**, Singapore **6.6%**.
- **Shift towards the advanced economies**; a million dollars is about Rs. 10 crore a year against Rs. 2.5 crore in Bharat — it shows the **demographic dividend**.

14.20 Economic Importance II: Investment, Entrepreneurship and Employment

Second, the diaspora promotes investment and entrepreneurship; third, it drives employment and skill development — and both are argued through named examples.

- **Investment and entrepreneurship (second point)**: the skills, knowledge and capacity acquired abroad are diverted into India — by investing in **startups, manufacturing, infrastructure, financial services and green technology**, and by promoting and establishing **entrepreneurship**.
- **Wind turbines and small modular reactors**: the illustrations — one went to the **Netherlands** and worked five years in a **wind turbine** company; another went to the US and worked with **Holtec (H-O-L-T-E-C)**, the biggest company making **small modular reactors**, and the **CEO of Holtec is an Indian**.
- **The green-sector multiplier**: that person may be leading a US company, but he will promote green technology, establish entrepreneurship, promote several startups, provide the **initial capital** and the **initial thought**, and share his information, knowledge and skill — to promote the green sector, which in this case is **nuclear energy**.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Nuclear Energy Mission — the PYQ link.

- A question came this time on the **Nuclear Energy Mission** — attaining **100 gigawatt of power by 2047**.
- An Indian heading a small-modular-reactor company abroad is exactly the technical and

capital capability that such a mission needs.

- **Economic Survey 2025-26**: as per the Survey, **diaspora return pathways need to be created for tech capabilities**.
- **Employment and skill development (third point)**: the goal is to be **technologically sovereign** — technologically independent, reducing dependence on supply chains and on nations. The diaspora members are the leaders, the people who have seen how it is done.
- **The best example — CAR-T cell therapy**: a therapy that uses **T cells to cure cancer**, developed by a **doctor from India**; he had trained in the US and developed a **cost-effective technology for Indian application**.
- **The market and the algorithm**: India is a huge market — see the YouTube subscriber counts and YouTube revenue — but the algorithm works differently here and differently in the US and the West; the experience the diaspora gathers there is what becomes usable here [passage partly garbled in the recording].
- **GCCs — Global Capability Centres**: diaspora members have set up, or used their expertise and networks to set up, **GCCs in India**, which has led to **employment plus utilisation of human capital**.
- **The example to write down, 100 percent**: India's **IT industry and startup ecosystem** has been actively supported by the **US diaspora**.

QUICK REVISION

- **Second point**: the diaspora promotes **investment and entrepreneurship** — startups, manufacturing, infrastructure, financial services, green technology.
- **Holtec** — the biggest small-modular-reactor company — has an **Indian CEO**; the other illustration is the **Netherlands** wind-turbine stint.
- A question came on the **Nuclear Energy Mission — 100 GW by 2047**.
- **Economic Survey 2025-26**: **diaspora return pathways for tech capabilities**.
- **Third point**: employment and skill development, aimed at technological sovereignty.
- **CAR-T cell therapy** — developed by a doctor from India who trained in the US, cost-effective for Indian application.
- **GCCs (Global Capability Centres)** built with diaspora expertise → employment plus utilisation of human capital; the **IT industry and startup ecosystem** was actively supported by the **US diaspora**.

14.21 Economic Importance III: Brain Circulation and Company Building in India

The next illustration is the mechanics of how a diaspora entrepreneur builds a company in India — and, in doing so, creates employment on a large scale.

- **How the company is formed**: there will always be the involvement of one major Indian — he will be a partner. The illustration given: 'I am working in the US, I have been in the US

for twenty years; I will incorporate my company with three or four **Goras** I found during my master's or my PhD; we formed a company; I told those Goras — you want to earn money? Pin your hopes on me; you have seen me.'

- **The India end**: take a good place and office in **Delhi, Gurgaon, Bangalore, Hyderabad, Chennai or Mumbai**; a rent of about **Rs. 10–12 lakh** [as stated in lecture]; **three-year lease agreements** signed.
  - In a matter of **three months** you are creating employment for at least **500–1000 people** — and that is just one person.
- **They mentor the Indian workforce**: the diaspora sits at the hub of the world — California, for instance — and they promote employment, they show your style, and they actually **mentor the Indian workforce**.
  - Hence the instruction: **do not call them brain drain**; 'go back go back' is the wrong reaction — you are promoting the idea of **brain circulation**.

EXAMPLE

One person, 500–1000 jobs.

- The chain as narrated: an NRI incorporates a company abroad with three or four local partners, opens an office in India — **Delhi, Gurgaon, Bangalore, Hyderabad, Chennai or Mumbai** — on a three-year lease, and within three months creates employment for at least **500–1000 people**.
- That is the scale of what one diaspora entrepreneur does, and it is why the phrase **brain drain** is rejected in this topic.

QUICK REVISION

- The company is incorporated abroad with local partners, but **one major Indian is always a partner**.
- The office comes up in **Delhi, Gurgaon, Bangalore, Hyderabad, Chennai or Mumbai**; three-year lease; in **three months**, employment for **500–1000 people** from one person.
- The diaspora **mentors the Indian workforce** and sits at the hub of the world.
- **Do not call them brain drain** — the keyword is **brain circulation**.

14.22 Economic Importance IV: Stable External Finance and FDI

The next point is **stable external finance** — the deposits that hold the rupee up in exactly those periods when outside money runs away.

- **Where the money sits**: NRIs have invested in savings in Indian banks. For NRIs there are **NRE** and **NRO** accounts — the difference between the two is **not to be studied**; it is enough to show **NRE** and **NRO**, and that is very important. Alongside these there are **FCNR (B) deposits**.
- **They act as a cushion**: they have acted as a cushion during periods of **rupee depreciation**, of external financing pressure, and above all when there is a war and **global financial uncertainty**.

  - The analogy: when you are short of money you call your friends — give me Rs. 5,000 for a month, I will return it. You cannot go to a foreign bank and seek money; you will talk to the diaspora.

> **GOVERNMENT & POLICY**
>
> **RBI's special FCNR (B) window — the facts to quote.**
>
> - **FCNR (B) = foreign currency non-resident deposits**.
> - Under the RBI's special FCNR (B) window, India attracted **127 billion dollars** [recorded as '1 27 billion dollars'] from **8 June to 31 August**.
> - It thereby provided a cushion against the fall of the rupee.
> - India's **forex reserve** is about **700 billion dollars**.
> - The rupee was depreciating and had reached the mark of **96–97**; the RBI Governor opened this window to arrest that fall, and the **psychological mark of Rs. 100 was avoided**.

- **Why the window works**: your money in an Indian bank is held in rupees, but NRIs earn in dollars — so to promote their deposits the RBI opens this window in which dollars can be invested. **FCNR** is that scheme, and the response to it was tremendous.
- **The forex swap**: an economy term, to be opened next year when the Survey is taken; for now it is enough to know that an NRI opens an account in an Indian bank in two ways — **NRE** and **NRO** — and that the RBI periodically opens the window for foreign currency.
- **It has also led to FDI in India** [the point was already discussed].
- **The three-month fact**: so much money came into India in three months — and this is what makes it **stable external finance**. The claim attached to it: this is the most important function of the diaspora.

14.22.1 The Investor-Confidence Story

- **Investors read the NRIs as a signal**: when the NRIs put in **130 billion dollars**, investors began to think these Indians are very intelligent — they have invested 130 billion dollars [passage partly garbled in the recording].
- **The counter-flow — FPI outflow**: for the last four or five years there has been a **net FPI outflow** from India every year; the money invested in stocks and equities is being pulled out, people are taking money out of the stock market. A stock that was at **Rs. 100** had come down to **Rs. 30**.
- **Where that money went instead**: the world was uncertain; investors moved into **AI companies**, into **China** and into the **South Korean stock markets** — the investors have billions of dollars of wealth at their command.
- **What the FCNR deposits did at that moment**: in that currency depreciation, when India had nothing, these deposits played a very important role in getting India 130 billion dollars.
- **The turn in August**: India has had sufficient **FPI inflow** this month. Global investors are like **Gen Z** — they go wherever the crowd goes — because there is always uncertainty in the movement of capital.
  - Once they saw the NRIs and their hope, they understood that India's economic credentials

are strong; and the **7.8 percent growth numbers** came just two days back — this provides a cushion.

- **The export number**: despite the **West Asia war**, India exported **44 billion dollars** worth of merchandise last month — a very big thing.
- **The conclusion to write**: finance-capital-wise, this gives India's credentials a **strong foundation**.

QUICK REVISION

- Next point: **stable external finance** — NRI savings in Indian banks through **NRE** and **NRO** accounts (their difference is not to be studied) and **FCNR (B) deposits**.
- They act as a **cushion** in **rupee depreciation**, external financing pressure, war and global financial uncertainty.
- **FCNR (B) = foreign currency non-resident deposits**; under RBI's special window India attracted **127 billion dollars** from **8 June to 31 August** [as stated].
- **Forex reserve ≈ 700 billion dollars**; the rupee had reached **96–97**; the **Rs. 100 psychological mark was avoided**.
- **FDI** also follows — it has led to FDI in India.
- Counter-flow: **net FPI outflow** for four-five years (a **Rs. 100 stock fell to Rs. 30**), money going to AI firms, China and South Korea.
- August brought sufficient **FPI inflow**; **7.8 percent growth** two days back; **44 billion dollars** of merchandise exports despite the West Asia war — a strong foundation for India's credentials.

14.23 Economic Importance V: Market Access, Knowledge Networks and Transaction Costs

Beyond finance, the diaspora functions as a market-intelligence and market-access network — and as the channel through which Indian products travel out.

- **Two sets of people in the West**: the salaried — those who went with you, your friends, mostly earning well but within the company — and the business class, who play a very big role for India.
- **The petrol pump and store story (Canada)**: one went to Canada and struggled for ten to fifteen years, then took a **7-Eleven** — here we say 24/7, there it is 7-Eleven; and there the petrol pump is combined with a store.
  - There you fill the petrol yourself — stop the car and do it; and the roads are long, like life itself; there are no highways like India's, and besides humans there are dogs, cats and animals — it could even be an extinct species on the highway [passage partly garbled].
  - The policy there is that a pump will have a store with it; in that store you go, eat and drink. Indians opened one such store, earned money, then kept three, then more — and so it goes on.
- **Market knowledge is the real product**: a big chunk of entrepreneurship has been promoted by diaspora members supplying **market knowledge** — how work happens there, what the

dynamics are, which business will run; the person already doing that business knows this.

- **Family and trust** [passage partly garbled]: in that market the Indian mentality is 'these people cannot be trusted' — and the call goes to this uncle's brother, that one's brother, as long as there is no dispute, no land dispute, no movie-type feud running.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Mr Vinay Mittal's question — the Marwadi migration pattern.**
>
> - **Mr Vinay Mittal of the Railway Board** asked for the **global pattern of Marwadi migration — spatial and temporal**.
> - It felt like an answer to be written in the civil services examination — twelve marks — and the person answering was completely flummoxed; it was a very tough question.
> - The takeaway: **Marwadi networks are very strong** and carry a deep knowledge base — and this is precisely what a diaspora network creates, for business and for jobs.

- **Jobs through the company route**: placement happens when the company sends people on a company visa to work in its IT sector there — that is one way the diaspora network creates jobs.
- **Trade and market access — the line to write**: they provide **trade and market access networks** — they provide market and trade-related information, and this led to **market access for Indian products**, thereby boosting **export earnings**.
- **Indian food — the makhanas from Bhagalpur**: a friend's product; a US YouTuber with 10,000 followers, who comes to the gym, was given a sample — he ate those makhanas, said it is a wonderful product, and US people got **FOMO** — so straight from Bhagalpur you can end up exporting makhanas to a country like the US.
  - The health fad is big in the US at present, which is what makes such products move.
  - The Middle East consumes our mangoes and rice heavily, because cultural similarity is greater there.
- **Textiles, jewellery and handicrafts**: **khadi** and **silk** textiles; **jewellery** is a big item of export and jewellers are the biggest money-minters in forex earnings — because you earn in dollars there and in rupees here, a person earning in dollars will not worry before buying costly jewellery from India; and **handicrafts**.
- **Film and music**: songs are shot there and Canada has an entire music industry with musicians living there — **Daljeet** is based in the US or Canada. Earlier the Punjabi artists were in **England** — **Bally Sagoo**, **Punjabi MC** — and their songs carried a British English touch; then Canada was picked up as an area, and the whole Punjabi music scene shifted from the UK towards **Canada**, and the US, because not everyone gets a visa — Canada is the hub of that entire music industry.
- **The production army**: local artists, sound recording, video editing, a big chunk of graphics — a big chunk of Indians. For a live event you carry all the instruments — the tabla player, the dholak player, the chorus singer; the entire team travels together for concerts, and with the protagonist at least thirty, three hundred, four hundred people earn money out of it.
  - The network effect: 'he knows your songs are running here, so there is demand — now do

a show in India; people in the US will watch.' That is how you influence.

- **The other sectors named**: **pharmaceuticals** — very important, a tough nut to crack, pharmaceutical entry is very difficult — and obviously **education and financial services**.
- **Why the diaspora can do all this**: it possesses **local knowledge about regulations** — the most important of all — **consumer preferences**, **business contacts**, **distribution networks** (how the goods are to be sold) and **investment opportunities**.
- **And the most important effect**: they reduce cost — therefore they **reduce transaction costs**.

EXAMPLE

From a London garment shop to a laundry business.

- A college friend's father had a traditional garment store in **London**; for six months he would stay there in the wedding season, with a shop in Punjab, transporting Indian wear to London and selling it in pounds.
- A pound is about **Rs. 100**, so what costs Rs. 10,000 here was sold there at **three-four times** — and that was a stable business he had started, in just the **first generation**.
- In the fifteen-twenty years of market knowledge he possessed he at least called his **son, first cousin, second cousin and third cousin**; they found a lot of demand in the universities for **laundry**, put up laundry machines in that area, and a laundry business was started [the reference to LPU — Fagwara, Lovely Professional, with many patent filings — is as stated in lecture].
- That is how market information spreads: the **transaction cost** of starting it on your own would have been very high — and that is exactly the role the diaspora plays.

QUICK REVISION

- In the West there are the **salaried** and the **business class** — the latter plays a very big role for India.
- The Canadian **7-Eleven** petrol-pump-and-store story shows the business route.
- **Market knowledge** is what diaspora members supply — a big chunk of entrepreneurship has been promoted that way.
- **Mr Vinay Mittal of the Railway Board** asked for the **global pattern of Marwadi migration (spatial and temporal)** — a twelve-mark kind of question.
- **Trade and market access networks** provide trade information → **market access for Indian products** → boosted **export earnings**.
- Products and sectors: **makhanas from Bhagalpur**, mangoes and rice in the Middle East, **khadi and silk textiles, jewellery, handicrafts**, **film and music** (Daljeet; Bally Sagoo; Punjabi MC; the UK-to-Canada shift), **pharmaceuticals, education, financial services**.
- Attributes: **local knowledge of regulations**, consumer preferences, business contacts, distribution networks, investment opportunities — and therefore **reduced transaction costs**.

14.24 Economic Importance VI: Innovation, Venture Creation and the Indian-American Record

One of the strongest claims made for the diaspora is that it promotes innovation — and it is argued up to a published American study on the founders of unicorns.

- **Innovation needs capital first**: innovation does not simply happen; **capital is very necessary** for innovation. One person in a hundred does it himself and is either genetically blessed or exceptionally smart; the remaining ninety-nine have to follow that pattern.
- **Flipkart and Amazon**: Flipkart's founders are not very great — they were a little brave and intelligent; **Jeff Bezos**, who started **Amazon**, [created the model] — selling by replicating the model is a different thing.
- **The AI example**: **artificial intelligence** was spearheaded by **OpenAI** and **Anthropic**; seeing them, if **Sarvam AI** or **Hanuman AI** or **DeepSeek** builds something, we are not doing anything bad. The one who spearheads is one — everyone followed him, and everyone who followed also did very well.
- **The Apple example**: personal computers did not exist earlier — computers were used for official work; **Apple** introduced the concept of a **personal computer**; then came the **iPad**, a product that was thought not to sell. [Dates as stated, with the speaker himself unsure of them: first **iPhone** 2005; iPad in **2009 or 2010**.]
  - The **iPod**: the first one came for **Rs. 18–20,000**, in **160 GB** and **80 GB**; the iPod brought the experience of music — the intoxication of music — and they sold it so well; later they inserted all these things into phones.
- **A note on notes**: the notes of a student, on **world history** and **food processing**, were phenomenal — whatever praise one gives is less; with them a single reading was enough.
- **Caution on a question already discussed**: do not take stress over it, do not sit down to write a full answer for it, and do not waste sectional-test time — **optimise** instead [the reference is partly garbled in the recording].
- **The best example is the Indian-American diaspora**: Indians need only a little direction and they will make their way — the Chinese also work very hard and will make their way, but a little direction is needed. The reason direction matters is also **historical injustice and inequality**: access to a good college, and then going abroad, is a way of changing one's lot. Indians really do very well, very well — except the Chinese, who are even faster and even better.
- **The record — Indians in the US**: just **1.5 percent of the US population**, with a **disproportionately high presence** in **tech** and in **medicine**.
- **In medicine**: Indian doctors are highly paid — the Indian doctor's coin runs there; entire hospitals have been built up; a lot of wealth; and the whites trust them.
- **Corporate leadership**: **Ajay Banga**, head of the **World Bank**; **Gita Gopinath**, Chief Economist of the **IMF**, from **LSR, Delhi University**, who married **Iqbal Singh Dhaliwal** — All India Rank one — who left the All India Services and went to the US.

DATA & FACTS

The BCG study — Indian founders of US unicorns.

- **BCG** — the **Boston Consulting Group**, a top US-based consulting firm — studied **358 US unicorns** (stated once as 360) founded by **first-generation immigrants between 2018 and 2023**.
- A **unicorn** is a company with a **$1 billion valuation**, roughly **Rs. 10,000 crore**.
- The share of **Indian founders and co-founders** in that set is **20 percent**.
- The correction made in class: the first guess was **60 percent**, corrected to 20 — 'the way I am promoting this fact I would have said 60 — I am overselling.'
- The immigrant founders came from Mexico, the UK, Canada, China, Pakistan, the Philippines and India, among others.

- **Why these numbers matter**: understanding the US market system and seeing one's product there, when there is **no cultural affiliation**, is hard — which is why the study shows that **innovation is also transferred through investments**: through investments, through capital, through entrepreneurship, through networks and through expertise.
- **The personal note**: if the thoughts are got right, some of the students in the room can also be one of them.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

The start-up question — what it actually asked.

- **Schemes for startups** were studied from the Budget, but the question asked was on **challenges** — domestic and international.
- Challenges are difficult to fix from any single source; what has been studied is **MSME**, and the challenges of MSME are the same as the challenges of start-ups — so the question could have been caught from there.

QUICK REVISION

- **Innovation needs capital** — one in a hundred innovates, the other ninety-nine follow the pattern.
- Examples: **Flipkart** and **Amazon** (Jeff Bezos), **OpenAI** and **Anthropic** for AI (with **Sarvam AI**, **Hanuman AI**, **DeepSeek** following), and **Apple** — the personal computer, the **iPad**, the **iPod** at Rs. 18–20,000 in 160 GB and 80 GB.
- The best example of the whole argument is the **Indian-American diaspora**.
- **1.5 percent of the US population** with a **disproportionately high presence** in tech and medicine.
- Corporate leadership: **Ajay Banga** (World Bank), **Gita Gopinath** (IMF Chief Economist, LSR), married to **Iqbal Singh Dhaliwal** (All India Rank one).
- **BCG study**: of **358 US unicorns** founded by first-generation immigrants in **2018–2023**, **20 percent** had Indian founders or co-founders — a unicorn being a **$1 billion** (≈ Rs. 10,000 crore) company.

- Innovation is transferred **through investments, capital, entrepreneurship, networks and expertise**; and on the start-up question, **MSME's challenges are the start-ups' challenges**.

14.25 Tourism, the Service Sector and Religious Diplomacy

The next point after innovation is tourism and India's service sector — and from there the discussion moves to religion as an instrument of diplomacy and soft power.

- **They promote tourism and India's service sector**: the service sector brings in **financial services**, then **real estate services**, and most important of all **tourism**.
- **The December circuit**: whoever comes to India has to stay somewhere; December is Christmas — after the 25th nobody works and from the 20th people go on leave. Christmas is their Diwali, while ours are Diwali, Raksha Bandhan, Janmashtami and many more — theirs is one. So after the 20th they travel the world and spend time with family, and that is a very important circuit for tourism.
- **Religious leadership — India's edge**: religion drives politics in China and in the Southeast Asian economies, and we are the origin of many religions; if India strategically capitalises on this, it can gain **religious leadership**.
- **The Tibetan Buddhism case**: after the present **Dalai Lama** — who is their **spiritual and religious leader** and, in a way, also a political leader, although they also elect a Prime Minister — the seat of power is **McLeod Ganj near Dharamshala**.
  - There is strategy involved in who the next Dalai Lama will be, and whether he comes from Tibet; their procedure runs thus: a river flows, monks go, a name comes up, they go to that family, and the child is made the next monk — a proper method of identifying the next one.
  - If that person comes up from India, and India has higher stakes, then we rule the roost of Tibetan Buddhism — leaving aside the cultural centre, one can then play around with **religious politics and diplomacy**.
- **Kapilvastu and Lumbini**: both are in **Nepal** [as stated in lecture, India's location]; if they are promoted, the whole of **South East Asia** will come bowing.
  - Contrast **Saudi Arabia** — no matter which country comes, and however much money the **UAE** earns, that country cannot raise such a thing; it cannot attain that status in Indian Buddhism. Such is the opportunity here.
- **What the diaspora can do with that knowledge**: the illustration — you went abroad, were posted in **Belgium, in Brussels**, understood the Foreign Service, then went to the **UN**, worked at the **World Bank**; your children will not know those lanes — and that knowledge is what lets you bring foreign friends to India.
  - The whites are very sharp: you have to show them something, you have to give them a **bet** — tell them something that excites them; friends are not made just like that. Their society is **individualistic** and they work differently.
  - Mental health is not [treated as an issue] here, especially for men — that is the privilege that men have in this country [passage partly garbled in the recording].

QUICK REVISION

- **Tourism** is the most important element of the service sector push — after financial services and real estate services.
- The **December–Christmas circuit** is the tourism window: after the 20th the West goes on leave, and Christmas is their Diwali.
- **Religion drives politics** in China and Southeast Asia; India is the origin of many religions, so strategic capitalisation can win **religious leadership**.
- **Tibetan Buddhism**: the Dalai Lama's seat is **McLeod Ganj near Dharamshala**; the succession procedure (river, monks, name, family, child as monk) is a strategy in itself — if the next Dalai Lama comes from India, India rules the roost.
- **Kapilvastu and Lumbini** (Nepal) — if promoted, South East Asia will come bowing.
- **Saudi Arabia and the UAE** cannot buy that status in Indian Buddhism — that is India's opportunity.
- A Foreign Service career abroad builds the knowledge with which one brings foreign friends to India.

14.26 Cultural and Societal Impact of the Diaspora

After the economic benefits — innovation, investment — comes the **cultural impact**, which is the **societal impact**. Every issue is to be read on three dimensions: **money, politics and society** — economy, politics and society — because that is the vocabulary the examiner uses, and every issue has to be dissolved this way.

- **Basic civic sense exists among the whites** — that cannot be denied: on a customer-care call in the US they will say thank you twice. Here nobody says thank you and nobody says sorry, while every second conversation of theirs carries a thank you and a sorry — a British legacy.
- **French leave — the term carried in The Hindu**: two days ago its English section carried it — in India leave is taken without informing, and if you inform, what is the use? An **unplanned leave** is called **French leave**.
  - Why: the British always thought the French could never be trusted, and just to pull their leg — because the French used to leave the British companies and workforce without notice — they started calling it that.
  - They felt it was **uncivilised** not to have informed your boss about taking a prior leave.
- **What the diaspora brings into Indian society**: not chocolates and food, but **social and cultural issues** — how Indian society changes, and what benefit India's society gets from it.
- **First — they promote philanthropy**: **philanthropy** means charity. Outside there is so much wealth that this money has no value, so they want to give it back — to India.
- **The best eye institutes**: the class answer on the best eye institute in the country was **Shankar Nethralaya in Chennai**, and the one to remember is the **LV Prasad Eye Institute in Hyderabad**.
  - All over India, cases that fail with cataract, with **LASIK**, with any treatment go to LV Prasad,

Hyderabad; the doctors there have done their master's and are highly trained.
  - The origin story: LV Prasad was a doctor who had gone to the US; somebody told him to come and set up a hospital in **Andhra**; he was given land by the **Andhra government in Hyderabad**, and that is how the hospital was set up.
- **Maslow and the urge to give back**: when they come to Bharat, or to an orphanage, they have an emotional attachment — the **basic needs** are met, the **self-actualised stage** has been reached; for local acknowledgement, having earned a lot of money, that is what they seek as an individual personality, and they may also be self-motivated — all of which promotes them to come and invest back in their own country.
  - The film **Swades** and its song are given as the best depiction of that affection for India.
- **The thought changes**: once you meet someone after eight, nine or ten years, the basics remain the same, but there is a basic **respect**.
- **Multiculturalism, and the divide that survives**: the diaspora promotes **multiculturalism**, but the **ethnic divide remains strong, as does the religious divide** — no matter how reformed we claim to be, deep down we all carry that divide, because we have not been exposed to such an environment — 'Hindu is Hindu, Muslim is Muslim'. What is promoted is **diversity and pluralism**.
- **Human values and rights**: they also promote **human values and rights**.
  - In India the execution of our **fundamental rights** is so difficult; **human rights** is impossible; **manual scavenging** is so common.
  - **Human rights** as a concept sometimes disturbs — one needs to be at a certain level of society to respect and uphold human rights. Western society certainly has those values, and they bring them to India.
- **Third — they act as soft power**: this has to be accepted — they do tremendous work. When we meet any foreigner the first thing we want to know is what he eats, what he drinks, what he speaks and what his perception is; similarly, when Indians go out they carry our values — our food, our music, our songs — and so they project a **positive image of India** abroad.
- **Write them as Rashtradoot and India's brand ambassador** — the term must be shown to the examiner, **underlined**.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Every subject has its keywords.**
>
> - **Rashtradoot** and **India's brand ambassador** are the terms to show, underlined, in the answer on this topic.
> - Every subject has its keywords, and they must be inserted in **Papers 1, 2 and 3** — without them the marks will not come.

- **Yoga and ayurveda**: **yoga** comes first, then **ayurveda**.
- **Indian cuisine**: people are very happy with it; they are not used to spices, but if you feed them a little less spice they will be ecstatic — **butter chicken**, **Malabar parotta**, **naan**; then bring them to India and do **wellness tourism**.
  - Big vloggers are on it — 'I ordered butter chicken' from an Indian restaurant in **Switzerland**;

the Indian restaurants there have been opened by Indians, and nearby even the whites are eating — and the table next to you turns out to be Pakistani and enjoying it too.

- **Bollywood**: Indian cinema and the evolution of the **IIFA awards** come under both society and India's culture; a culture is being promoted and India benefits — India's society, India's system and India's culture are being known by the whole world.
  - The whites understand it because they have hardly any festivals — four or five in all — while here every second day is a festival; if it rains, a new festival is invented so that class does not have to be taken (something like that).
- **Classical arts and Indian festivals**: **Diwali** is a big one — Diwali is also a **day off in California**, if that is right; there it is a day off, here it is a whole month off. (The prelims will come, then we will see.)
- **Languages**: language is a big source of **assertion** — a tool of **assertion as well as of assimilation**. The **French** use language as a tool of assertion, and Chinese, **Mandarin**; the French never speak English — they know very little of it and, even though they know it, they do not speak it.
- **Religious traditions and family**: religious traditions are handed on — the choice is left with the parents and the parents hand them over [passage partly garbled]; and **family is very important**.
- **The line to write**: therefore the diaspora **familiarises and popularises India's culture and society, which creates a positive image, creating political and diplomatic benefits for India**.
- **Overall impact on Indian society**: it created a **positive image**, and it also developed **familiarity with Indian societal and cultural values**.

QUICK REVISION

- The **cultural impact** is the **societal impact**; read every issue on three dimensions — **economy, politics and society**.
- The whites have a **basic civic sense** (thank you and sorry in every second conversation — a British legacy); the term **French leave** explains an unplanned leave that is not informed.
- First, the diaspora promotes **philanthropy** — giving back; the illustration is the **LV Prasad Eye Institute, Hyderabad** (with **Shankar Nethralaya** as the other eye institute), set up with land from the **Andhra government**.
- The motive is **Maslow's** — basic needs met, self-actualisation, local acknowledgement — best captured by the film **Swades**.
- It promotes **multiculturalism, diversity and pluralism**, but the **ethnic and religious divide** stays strong.
- It also promotes **human values and rights** — in India even fundamental rights are hard to execute, human rights harder, manual scavenging common.
- Third, they act as **soft power** — write them as **Rashtradoot** and **India's brand ambassador**; the spread is **yoga, ayurveda, cuisine, Bollywood, classical arts, festivals, languages, religious traditions and family**, and it creates a **positive image** with political and diplomatic

benefits.

14.27 The Living Bridge: Two-Way Interaction and Diaspora as a Policy Pillar

The living bridge is a two-way street: the diaspora changes the host society, and it also changes India. The interaction was demonstrated with the simplest of examples.

- **The confirmation — it is two-way**: you are impacting your own society, and you are also influencing the other side.
- **The sattu example**: somebody from Bihar says we eat **sattu** — it is healthy, a protein source; so it becomes popular, and Bihar gets the benefit.
  - Someone is from Punjab, someone from Haryana, someone from UP, someone from Tamil Nadu, someone from Hyderabad, someone from J&K.
  - And not one person from **Goa** has been seen preparing for this examination — the observation is as stated in lecture; the point is that all these things run **two ways**.
- **This is the living bridge question**: the two-way interaction — **living bridge means that both sides are two-way**.
- **The Odissi example**: **Odissi dance** is taught in cultural centres and universities in **Japan**, and they are very methodical — so they might end up being better Odissi dancers than ours.
- **Diaspora engagement is a very big pillar of the government**: the strategic thought of clarity was made at the right moment, and then diaspora engagement was done.

QUICK REVISION

- The **living bridge** is **two-way** — you impact your own society and you influence the other.
- The **sattu** example shows how a regional food idea spreads and benefits its home region.
- The regional spread — Punjab, Haryana, UP, Tamil Nadu, Hyderabad, J&K — makes the point that all of this runs both ways.
- **Odissi dance** taught methodically in **Japan** shows how Indian culture is carried outward.
- **Diaspora engagement is a very big pillar** of the government, built on strategic clarity at the right moment.

CHAPTER 15

India's Diaspora — Part 2

15.1 Importance for Indian Foreign Policy and Diplomacy

After the diaspora's effect on Indian society, polity and economy, the next heading is its importance/role for Indian foreign policy or diplomacy.

KEY CONCEPT

Keyword — Strategic interests.

- India has **strategic interests** in different parts of the world, and those interests drive its foreign policy and diplomacy.
- If a question asks for India's 'benefits', frame them as **strategic benefits** — that single keyword qualifies the answer.
- Four lenses for reading the strategic benefits: geopolitical benefits, geosecurity, geocultural and geoeconomic.

- **Cultural Ambassador** — already covered in the earlier part: the diaspora is a benefit to India itself.
- It raises India's diplomatic interest and promotes diplomacy by increasing interaction between the two countries.

DATA & FACTS

Visa-free access and the passport index.

- India gets visa-free entry in very few countries — around **35-40 nations**.
- A passport index ranks countries by the visa-free access they enjoy; the most powerful passport was earlier **Singapore**, and is now **Japan**.
- A Singapore citizen has visa-free access to almost **180-185 nations**.
- The US is not at the top because it is a great power — many countries share an opposite relationship with it; Japan and Singapore are neutral players.

- The diaspora advances and promotes India's strategic interests.

EXAMPLE

Agreements and openings won by diaspora lobbying.

- The **India-US nuclear deal** was pushed by diaspora lobbying — signed **2005**, approved **2008** (write 2008 sometimes).

- Diaspora pressure promoted stronger engagement with India and the **removal of sanctions** imposed after the **1998 Pokhran-II** nuclear tests.
- The first test was in **1974**, under PM **Indira Gandhi**; the second in **1998**, under PM **Atal Bihari Vajpayee**.

- It promoted diplomatic interest and diplomacy — a big role in raising interaction between two countries.
- It improved access **beyond formal diplomacy** — connections with business associations, universities, think tanks, congress, civil society and the media.
  - If you want to win the hearts and minds of a US citizen, you must win the media.

EXAMPLE

The engagement-with-government-only problem.

- The biggest problem India has experienced in diplomacy is that it engages only with the **government**.
- **Bangladesh**: India engaged only the **Sheikh Hasina** government — it kept all its eggs in one basket.
- It was the best neighbourhood relationship any two adjacent countries could have; even Saudi Arabia-UAE or US-Canada is not of this order (US-Canada are both in **Five Eyes** since the Second World War).
- In the **US**, India catches only the party in power — the Republicans now, the Democrats/Biden administration earlier.

- **Wilmington** is the constituency Mr Biden comes from, part of the New England states (Boston, Philadelphia, New York) — the 10-12 conurbation areas with a density like the NCR/Delhi-Noida, financially and culturally Bombay-like; the East Coast and California are the most advanced parts.
- The US is a democratic, liberal society: the president matters, but sportspersons, celebrities (the Ronaldo/Messi type), NBA/baseball players and top sponsors also have influence and can speak freely.
- Contrast: no sports person in India can raise a voice against the government of the day.
- **Business associations and IT companies** such as **NASSCOM** are very large and influential; the US is a capitalistic liberal economy where money matters and presidents engage 10-20 CEOs.
- **Universities** — enormous private money and highly skilled talent; the **Ivy Leagues** matter (world's top technocrats and bureaucrats are mostly Ivy League); a united Ivy League Gen Z protest is a big thing.
- **Think tanks** — in India they are small players: **ORF** (Observer Research Foundation), the **Manohar Parrikar IDSA** and the **Vivekananda Foundation**; ORF is jointly owned by the Alliance [as stated].
  - In India these feed the bureaucracy and the lobby (e.g. the Indian Foreign Service); the ivory-tower mentality is strong; you must understand the pulls and pressures of the lobby.

– All India Services — A&P, and also foreign (the foreign service is relatively more relaxed because it has seen the world).

15.1.1 Structural Interdependence

What India requires is **structural dependence** — a structural interdependence between countries. As long as India is there, Pakistan's interdependence for the US will continue to exist; in Nehruvian times India believed 'more than we need them, they need us', and Pakistan similarly believed 'more than Pakistan needs the US, the US needs Pakistan'. India's case is different because its alternatives could be found in South Asia — to counter China, why hold hands with Pakistan? Tariq Rahman [as stated] is the kind of partner who would engage with you. There is no truth in diplomacy — it is all pretence (Sif Samayi ki wadambna); strategic autonomy means fulfilling sovereign interests while keeping in mind the times.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Structural interdependence made concrete — supply chains and tariffs.**
>
> - US-based manufacturing giants: where does Apple make a MacBook, a watch or a phone? In China (and India) — because of supply-chain efficiency in the era of globalization (post-1990s; East Asian economies from the 1970s-80s; China became manufacturing-strong in the 2000s).
> - When tariffs are levied, these companies are **structurally dependent** on China, Vietnam and India — moving the entire supply chain back home is a humongous cost (hiring people, moving plants) and a huge loss for business houses.
> - The US government cannot ignore their interest — if Boeing planes do not sell, the US economy suffers.
> - US technology sovereignty comes only when it lets innovation prosper (AI has full freedom in the US); the EU's rights-based framework is very small; India is trying to find a way out.

- This is where the diaspora does its core work — it **creates reasons or stakes** for foreign governments in maintaining good relations with India.

> **DATA & FACTS**
>
> **Stakes in the Gulf.**
>
> - **9 million** Indians live across the **GCC states**.
> - If these 9 million left the Gulf, who would carry out construction, work the oil rigs and the gas rigs? A big chunk of the investment and intellect is from India.
> - This labour has no political capital, but it creates reasons for Saudi Arabia to engage with India.
> - Saudi Arabia had taken India into confidence before signing its defence agreement last year [as stated]; what is needed is patient diplomacy — India has got our weapons, we have held them close to our chest, and there are remittances.

All in all, the diaspora advances India's interests.

QUICK REVISION

- Keyword to write: **strategic interests** — read the benefits as geopolitical, geosecurity, geocultural and geoeconomic.
- Examples of diaspora wins: the **India-US nuclear deal** (2005/2008) and the removal of sanctions after **Pokhran-II (1998)**; earlier test 1974 under Indira Gandhi.
- India's flaw: engaging only the government (Sheikh Hasina, Bangladesh) — the diaspora works through business, universities, think tanks and the media.
- **Structural interdependence**: supply chains (Apple in China/Vietnam/India), tariffs, Boeing; diaspora creates stakes for foreign governments.
- **9 million** Indians in the GCC carry the Gulf's construction and oil/gas economy — and remittances.
- Visa-free access: India only has **35-40** nations; Singapore citizens enjoy 180-185 — the passport index top is now Japan.

15.2 Importance for the Host Nation

The discussion now turns to the importance of the Indian diaspora for the host nation.

15.2.1 Political Influence, Representation and Elections

DATA & FACTS

Representation in legislatures.

- **US House of Representatives** — 435 seats; **6** members of Indian origin; informally called the **Samosa Caucus** (joked as the waffle/pancake/burger caucus).
- **UK House of Commons** — around 600 seats; **29** MPs of Indian origin (2024) [as stated].

- **Electoral mobilization** — the Indo-American community is a source of votes and there is a solid vote base.
  - South Asia is a big voting base, for example in Canada and the UK.
  - Indians bring strong political-organisation skills — how to set people up, temporarily and permanently.
- **Campaign finance** — the average Indian salary in the US is much higher than the average American's, making the community a source of campaign finance.
- The diaspora also supplies candidates — 'we are not the kings, we are king makers'.

DATA & FACTS

Why the arithmetic works.

- Madhya Pradesh: about **25 lakh** people per constituency, with **43 seats** (and delimitation is not happening).
- US: about **7-8 lakh** people per House of Representatives constituency.
- India: about **20 lakh** per constituency.

- US diversity must be 'set': Whites/**Caucasians**, **Hispanics**, **Browns** and **Negroes** — four racial groups.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Promoting foreign-policy interests and bilateral ties.**
>
> - **India-UK relations** improved during **Rishi Sunak's** leadership.
> - When **Kamala Harris** was US Vice President, the narrative changed — several students asked about that shift.
> - Counter-argument: the diaspora becomes 'whitewashed'/more American. Nehru's view was that once people are part of that country, let them be, without the hangover of coming from India — so diaspora-community ties were, if not cut off, slightly spread apart.

- **US visa asymmetry** [as stated]: under the Trump regime, single females and less-earning females have a much lower probability of getting a visa — the ICE/foreign dispensation thinks they will find a partner and settle in the US; males get visas more easily.

15.2.2 Shaping Trade Agreements and Policies

- The diaspora helps fulfil the host nation's interests by shaping favourable **trade agreements and policies**.
- Recent **FTAs**: with **Australia, New Zealand, Oman, Japan and Singapore**.
- FTA asymmetry: developed partners already have an average tariff of 2-3%, which falls to 0% under an FTA, while India levies an average of about 12% import duty that also falls to 0% — and India serves a market of 160 crore people.

> **COMPARISON**
>
> **FTA gains — India vs developed partners.**
>
> - Developed partner (Japan, ASEAN, UAE): average tariff already 2-3% → 0% under the FTA — it gains access to the Indian market.
> - India: average import duty about 12% → 0% under the FTA — it opens a 160-crore-strong market.
> - Result: partners such as Japan, ASEAN and UAE run trade deficits in their favour and 'enjoy more than you'.

- India helps them reach Indian markets; it uses lobbying to open the gates of the Indian market.
- **Piyush Goyal** meets all these diaspora communities when he goes to the US, the EU or New Zealand — the diaspora supplies on-the-ground information.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **India-UK FTA.**
>
> - It is a win-win — but it is a win that is more for the **UK** than for India.

15.2.3 Economic Asset and Human Capital

In the economy, Indians are the number one economic asset because there is an extraordinarily high human-capital concentration. The following are US statistics.

- **H-1B visa** — a visa given by the US government because you work there; the employer applies on your behalf (you do not have to run around).
  - The employer tells the US Embassy it is bringing people from India who will contribute to GDP — roughly 2 US jobs generated for every 10 workers brought.
- The **ChatGPT/data-entry and prompting** boom: many Indian IT engineers were hired to give better prompts — India's contribution is behind it.

DATA & FACTS

US diaspora — human capital statistics.

- **82%** of Indians who went to the US are graduates (bachelor's or above).
- Indians hold about **71%** of H-1B/work visas (FY24) — a talent capital; of every 100 work visas, about 71 go to Indians.
- Indians are **31%** of all international students in the US.
- FY25: **3,63,000** Indian students, concentrated in **STEM** (Science, Technology, Engineering, Mathematics).
- Median Indian household income in the US: **$176,200** per year (about $2 lakh).
- The median **US-born** household income is about half — under **$1 lakh**.
- Indian civilian labour-force participation rate is about **74%** — extraordinarily high.

- An Indian household earns about twice an average US household — 'earning twice, giving four times the efficiency of an average US worker'.
- Analogy: the Sheldon Cooper family in The Big Bang Theory typifies the roughly $1 lakh US household.

DATA & FACTS

Entrepreneurship and corporate leadership.

- The diaspora has moved from labour supply to 'up-within' jobs — controlling capital and controlling the enterprise.
- **BCG 2024 study**: Fortune 500 companies led by Indian-origin CEOs — **Satya Nadella** (Microsoft) and **Sundar Pichai** (Alphabet/Google).
- India has **120** unicorns.
- US unicorns co-founded by Indian-origin entrepreneurs: quoted as **648/about 20%**, corrected to **72 and about 11%** of US unicorns [self-correction].
- Indian-origin entrepreneurs hired **55,000** people, with a combined valuation of **$200 billion**.

- They promoted innovation in cutting-edge technology — **AI, semiconductor, software, biotechnology, pharma** — and, not to forget, **space**.
- Astronauts of Indian origin: **Sunita Williams** and **Kalpana Chawla** — a good share of **NASA**'s

best minds.

- **Higher education**: 31% of all international students are Indians; FY25: 3,63,000, concentrated in STEM — which feeds innovation at **IBM, Micron, Cisco, Apple and Google**, and even a Director-General of the Large Hadron Collider.
- Indian students pay about **$8 billion annually** (about **Rs. 80,000 crore** equivalent) in fees to the US economy.
  - If India started attracting foreign talent to its own universities, it would automatically earn a big amount of forex — that is the value India provides to the world.

> **DATA & FACTS**
>
> **Germany and the labour-market deficit.**
>
> - Germany: **50,000** Indian students in FY25 — the **largest international student group**.
> - About **3 lakh** Indians live in Germany.
> - The diaspora addresses the demographic/labour-market deficit — important in **Germany and Australia**.

15.2.4 *Diaspora as a Transaction-Cost Reducer*

Most importantly, the diaspora promotes **trade and investment** by acting as a **transaction-cost reducer**. FDI is the official route, and it requires hand-holding — someone who knows the right channels, who to contact, which organisations to connect with, and how the work has to be located. There is no single-window website where you apply and get papers in two days and start tax filing on the fourth day.

- The diaspora possesses knowledge of **both markets**, the language, cultural familiarity, trust, and information about consumer preferences.
- This reduces informational and transaction costs — leading to increased trade, investment, finance and technological collaboration.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Hand-holding in practice.**
>
> - Someone who did a master's in Delhi and a PhD in South Korea knows how South Koreans behave and how fellow Indians behave — an India-based South Korean who wants to invest can come only because this person cuts the corners and addresses the rules.
> - The water-bill/ethics example: in India some things work only with an informal payment for water and electricity; foreigners do not work that way — the diaspora knows the system on both sides and reduces the cost of entry.

- Defence companies also use lobbying agents — remember the **Niira Radia** case involving the Tatas.
  - The West knows this very well; they also want business and want to enter a trillion-dollar economy — the diaspora plays a big role in this.

EXAMPLE

Cultural change in the host society.

- **Germany**: people traditionally were not fond of buying property; buying a home is an Indian aspiration — and Germany has begun buying property because of the cultural change the diaspora brought.
- Renting culture: in the West renting is easy and 'your own' discussions rarely arise; in India finding a good rental is inefficient, with landlord preferences and disputes over security, non-veg food and pets.

QUICK REVISION

- Host-nation benefits divide into **politics/representation, trade agreements and the economy**.
- Representation: 6 Indian-origin members in the 435-seat US House (**Samosa Caucus**); 29 Indian-origin MPs in the roughly 600-seat UK House of Commons (2024).
- Elections: vote bank, campaign finance, king makers; FTAs with Australia, New Zealand, Oman, Japan and Singapore — India gains less than developed partners.
- US human capital: 82% graduates, 71% of H-1B visas, 31% of international students, FY25 3,63,000 in STEM, median income $176,200 vs under $1 lakh for US-born, labour-force participation 74%.
- Corporate leadership: BCG 2024, Nadella (Microsoft) and Pichai (Alphabet); 120 Indian unicorns; 72 US unicorns (~11%); 55,000 jobs and $200 billion valuation.
- The diaspora is a **transaction-cost reducer** — knowledge of both markets, hand-holding for FDI, and cultural change (e.g. property buying in Germany).

15.3 Effect on the Host Society and Culture

After the economy, the discussion moves to societal change — the effect and benefit the Indian diaspora has on the Western/host society and culture.

- Biggest of all: the diaspora **promotes multiculturalism**.
- It therefore acts as a **force multiplier**, helping project a liberal-democratic image for the host nation.
- India's own record is questioned: the **Press Freedom Index** and the **Reporters Index** give India very poor markings. India may not be the best like Denmark or the Scandinavian nations — and there are criticisms (e.g. from the RSS).
  - But the point stands: the diaspora makes the host society a living image of a liberal, democratic, law-abiding country that respects minorities — the pillars of soft power and very important in image projection.

EXAMPLE

The West's own glass house — George Floyd.

- Even in the US there is a big amount of racial segregation, racial violence and racial policing.
- The George Floyd incident: a young fellow was killed by a policeman who put his knee on his neck, causing suffocation — the US cannot lecture India.

- Western societies 'fire on our shoulders': they say you cannot blame us, so many countries' citizens live happily here — using the diaspora's presence to project themselves as rule-abiding and law-abiding at the international platform.
  - Democracy, respect for the rule of law and respect for minorities are the pillars of soft power, and they matter greatly in image projection.
- **Africa**: Russia is supplying mercenaries, with a huge influx.
- Indians were made to fight in the **Russia-Ukraine war** — some young people died (about 25-30 as stated).
- **China's debt diplomacy** and its 'pit-to-port' model: extract from the pit, load straight onto ships and run the whole processing chain.
  - Critical minerals: about 70% of the world's cobalt is in the DRC (Democratic Republic of Congo); it is extracted there, local gang lords and the government take their cut, and all the processing and value addition happens in China.

CRITICAL POINT

India's contrasting values.

- Against Russian and Chinese approaches, India offers **low-cost, innovative, sustainable, partnership-oriented financing**.

- On the **West Asian war**: it is the first time US forces have been directly involved in a war with a country after the Second World War.
  - Afghanistan was a war on terror — the world was with the US; Iraq was for the destruction of chemical weapons, for humanity.
  - This war is not for humanity but for the fulfilment of the international ego the US possessed — the world accepts this now.
- The diaspora enables multiculturalism, which acts as a force multiplier — the technique and the money are there, but the last push needs the diaspora.
- Their role as **soft-power ambassadors** increases **P2P (people-to-people) relations**, improves societal relations, and thereby benefits the society of the host nation.

EXAMPLE

Cultural exchange is two-way.

- Just as Indians enjoy US pop culture (Hollywood music and artists), US-based pop artists and audiences now follow Indian musicians — Diljit and others playing at festivals like **Coachella**.
- It is an acceptance: Indians are not the only ones enjoying it — the host society is enjoying it

too.

- It is said that **India-Pakistan P2P** relations are not as full of animosity as the state and the media project (though he had not himself met a Pakistani).
- P2P relations improve soft power — we get a benefit from our festivals (Diwali), our business and our culture.

EXAMPLE

India-Nepal — roti-beti ka rishta.

- India and Nepal share a **roti-beti ka rishta** (food-and-marriage ties) that was damaged after **2015**, when Nepal's economy stalled and India's image with ordinary Nepalis turned distraught.
- A Nepali student's suicide at **Kulling University** (Kathmandu University) [as stated] worsened the perception; many Nepalis have been important to India.
- Palestinian perception is similar — India took a step back and Palestinians said so; India obviously cannot be the flag bearer of humanity — in diplomacy you must fulfil your strategic interests.

QUICK REVISION

- Key benefit to the host society: the diaspora **promotes multiculturalism** and acts as a **force multiplier** projecting a liberal-democratic image.
- Soft power: the West deflects criticism using the diaspora's happy presence; India faces poor **Press Freedom/Reporters Index** markings but the US has its own record (George Floyd).
- Africa: Russian mercenaries; China's debt diplomacy and 'pit-to-port' model (about 70% of the world's cobalt lies in the DRC, processed in China); India offers low-cost, sustainable, partnership-oriented financing.
- West Asian war: first direct US war with a country after WWII — fought for international ego, not humanity.
- Soft-power ambassadors increase P2P and societal relations — e.g. Indian musicians at Coachella; India-Pakistan P2P is better than projected.
- **India-Nepal** 'roti-beti ka rishta' worsened after 2015 and the Kathmandu University student suicide; Palestinian perception also shifted.

15.4 Issues Faced by the Indian Diaspora

The diaspora question is not complete without the other side: the diaspora is not homogeneous, and issues are examined as those **faced by** it and those **caused by** it.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

How the question is asked.

- The question on importance is a repeat favourite — the **past four questions have come on importance only**.

- Whenever they ask you to discuss or elucidate the importance, **always give the other side**.
- Issues faced by them and issues caused by them will be written in the answer format separately, with the examples of West Asia and Southeast Asia.

- The diaspora is **not homogeneous** — it carries domestic issues into the West.
- A 'concoction' and fear-mongering are created every time you talk to somebody from those countries — e.g. that Khalistan is about to be made, or fears around the abrogation of **Article 370** that locals themselves later contradicted.
- **Discrimination/racism** — a real issue, and much more so in **England** (the fringe areas of North London, North England, Scotland); parts of those societies still carry the casteist and patriarchal mindset common in Indian villages.
- **Exploitation** of the workforce, a major problem in the **Gulf**: harsh working conditions, temperatures around 50°C, low pay and limited rights.
- Above all, there are **no political rights** — the biggest problem among the Arab nations; this is not the case in the West or the US.

KEY CONCEPT

Kafala system.

- The **kafala system** of West Asia/Arab nations: the worker is essentially 'owned' by a local sponsor/landlord.
- The sponsor holds the passport; there are no worker rights; the worker cannot change employer or leave the country without permission.

- A local sponsor takes 50-100 workers from India, houses them in a hostel-type accommodation, and controls them entirely — no Diwali, no freedom, the passport is not with you.

EXAMPLE

Qatar World Cup 2022.

- When Qatar hosted the World Cup in 2022, the kafala system came to the fore and the arrangement drew global attention.
- Among others, Infantino and figures like Maldini were drawn into the controversy; it is said that had the World Cup not been given to Qatar, big kickbacks would not have followed.

- **Integration/assimilation concerns** — integration is very tough, especially for children; there is segregation.
- Even at top universities such as Harvard, the university is a microcosm of the country; a child sent to a US school will witness some form of racial segregation.
- **Cultural and linguistic differences** prevent smooth integration.
- **Limited legal protection** — limited awareness and limited legal aid make the diaspora vulnerable to exploitation.
- **Political sensitivities** — the diaspora gets entangled in tensions between India and the host

nation.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Canada — the clearest example.**
>
> - The diaspora in Canada was affected by the decline in Indo-Canada relations.
> - Trudeau wanted to capitalise on his political wealth and engaged the far right of one of the communities; instead of dousing the fire he fanned it, for political interest and as a vote bank.
> - **Mark Carney** acted very practically, and with his return there has been a lot of improvement in India [as stated].

- The **Gulf** is the happy exception — there has been no rough patch in about 12 years, ever since the present government came to power.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Bangladesh under the interim government.**
>
> - The example is Bangladesh under the interim government led by **Muhammad Yunus** — there was clear targeting of Hindus that cannot be denied.
> - Power was handed to an irresponsible individual [as stated]; contrast this with **Sushila Karki**, Nepal's lady Chief Justice, who handled affairs very well.

- **Recent effect of war** — the recent US-Iran war exposed the vulnerability of the Indian diaspora: workers and professionals, along with the security of the **seafarers**.
- About **10-12,000** people were evacuated from the Middle East; Iranian missiles targeted Saudi refineries and Dubai's **Jebel Ali** — for Iran, leading asymmetric warfare, such targets are a piece of cake; Indian construction workers died.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Russia-Ukraine war.**
>
> - The Indian diaspora was forcefully made to participate in the Russia-Ukraine war — young people were caught in the crossfire.

- **Iran as a destination**: it is cheaper, with cultural similarity — significant Shia Muslims in Kashmir and Ayatollah Khomeini being a respected figure there; it also seems a preferred destination for female students (e.g. for medicine) [as stated].
  - Iranian currency: one dollar is almost two million rial; settlements are done in individual currencies.
- **Georgia**: a beautiful country on the Black Sea, with ports such as Poti and Sukhumi, popular with people from North Indian states.
- **Racial segregation** — common in Southeast Asia too.
- **South Korea** is very racial, but South Koreans are infatuated with English and Western globalization brands — ironically, speaking good English can get you treated better than an average Westerner; South Korea is nonetheless not important for the diaspora.
- Apart from the above, recent **immigration concerns**: visa restrictions imposed by Western

nations.

- Example: a **$100,000 H-1B visa fee** imposed by the US State Department on H-1B applicants.

Italy	Giorgia Meloni	Centre-right (not completely far right)
Hungary	Péter Magyar (won the election); previously Viktor Orbán	Previously hard-core right-wing under Orbán
Japan	Sanae Takaichi	A far-right temper

- Japan's far right, however, is not so much that it makes India feel racial segregation.
- In the **South Asian economies**, Indians do not really face the concern of social exclusion — that is a Western problem.

QUICK REVISION

- Always give the other side: issues **faced by** and **caused by** the diaspora are treated separately.
- Faced: racism/discrimination (worst in England), exploitation in the Gulf, kafala system (sponsor holds the passport; no worker rights; no political rights), integration and linguistic barriers, limited legal protection, political sensitivities.
- Country examples: Canada (Indo-Canada decline, Trudeau; improvement under Mark Carney) and Bangladesh (Yunus government targeting Hindus), alongside well-handled Nepal (Sushila Karki).
- Recent effects of war: US-Iran war exposed workers, professionals and seafarers; 10-12,000 evacuated; Russia-Ukraine forced participation.
- Cultural-similarity destinations: Iran (rial at about 2 million to the dollar) and Georgia (Black Sea ports).
- New worries: immigration/visa restrictions including a $100,000 H-1B fee, and the rise of far-right parties in Italy (Meloni), Hungary (Péter Magyar/Orbán) and Japan (Sanae Takaichi).

15.5 Issues Caused by the Indian Diaspora

The other half of the ledger is the issues caused by the diaspora in the host nation.

- **Illegal immigration** is promoted — a major concern in the US and Canada, and a matter of sovereignty.
- Host-nation populations are sometimes very low, so any illegal immigration changes the demographic pattern of that country.
- **Supporting violence and separatism** — an increasing proportion of criminal elements, increasing gang violence and the emergence of a terrorist-gangster nexus; the example is

Khalistan and the Khalistani-gangster nexus.

EXAMPLE

Transnational organized crime — the Delhi case.

- A person was killed in Delhi by 22-23-year-old boys, but the one giving the command is 25-30; weapons come from yet another person.
- Masterminds sit abroad — in the US, Georgia or Thailand; Indian gangs have become a concern because of the emergence of **transnational organized crime**.
- One gang screen-shares on WhatsApp with another to direct a hit — the India network and the West network are merging.

- The terrorist-gangster nexus has layers: begin as a gangster, collect extortion money by phone, gain notoriety, social media adds more small names, the network grows — and then it enters the mechanism of terrorism.
- **Khalistani networks** active in Canada form a nexus with Pakistanis there, who connect them to the nexus in Pakistan, where **ISI** arranges money and weapons.
- **Babbar Khalsa International** and incidents such as the bomb thrown at a police station in **Mohali** about 1.5-2 years back are examples.

EXAMPLE

How sophisticated the nexus is.

- The movie **Zero Dark Thirty** illustrates how somebody comes from the US and tracks developments, and how the ISI protects an individual who arrives in a white gypsy — a goosebumps movie.
- A parallel real example [as stated]: US forces evacuated an Air Force pilot after two pilots came down on Iranian soil (their jet was an F-16/F-18); one was located and evacuated, and the US has not revealed names or details.

- When both networks emerge and merge, it becomes an internal security threat not only for India but also for the other nation — the country's reputation is affected.
- Increasing **gang violence** is definitely a concern in Canada.
- A popular singer was killed coming out of his gym, and 22-23-year-olds were taking hotel rooms for the operation — the killers too were only 23-24 [as stated].
- **Frequent protests** — the Indian diaspora has carried the politics of the home country into the host nation and indulged in public demonstrations, harming India's image.

CRITICAL POINT

What to write in the exam.

- Write the emergence of the **Khalistani terror movement** — that is the accepted discourse.
- Avoid naming **Lawrence Bishnoi's gang** and associated names such as **Goldie Brar**; the Khalistani terror network is connected and significant intelligence is already available, so there is no need to enter territories that are not part of the accepted discourse.

QUICK REVISION

- Issues caused by the diaspora: illegal immigration, support to violence and separatism, and frequent protests.
- Illegal immigration is a concern in the US and Canada and a sovereignty/demographic issue.
- Terrorist-gangster nexus: Khalistan/Khalistani-gangster links, ISI money and weapons, Babbar Khalsa International, the Mohali police-station bomb.
- Transnational organized crime: Delhi-style killings with masterminds abroad (US/Georgia/Thailand) and WhatsApp screen-share coordination.
- In exams, write only 'Khalistani terror network' — avoid naming Lawrence Bishnoi/Goldie Brar.

15.6 Steps Taken: Protection, Welfare and Engagement

The steps taken are divided into two parts: **protection and welfare** of Indian citizens abroad, and **broad engagement**. Two broad themes run through them — welfare and engagement.

- The vulnerable are children and students — in **February 2022** they were brought back, and again during the recent war.

DATA & FACTS

Scale of the diaspora.

- **37 million** diaspora in total.
- **9 million** in the Gulf — a very popular number.
- About **10-12,000** evacuated from the Middle East during the recent war.

- Nepal's Himalayan disaster brought distress home; China does not share hydrographic data (how much discharge there is), which also affects Indians — the **1996 India-Bangladesh Ganga Treaty** exists precisely to discuss discharge [as stated].
- During the Russia-Ukraine war, all Ministers of State were sent to bring people back [as stated].

15.6.1 Protection and Welfare

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

ICWF — Indian Community Welfare Fund (2009).

- The **oldest scheme** in this space.
- It is a fund that offers **financial aid during emergencies**.
- It provides critical support in **emergency evacuation** of Indian citizens during conflicts, natural disasters and other emergencies.

- **One-stop centres for distressed women abroad** have been created.
  - Shelters have been built in **Bahrain, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, UAE and Saudi Arabia**, along with night shelters where women can stay a day, two or three until their documents are ready.

  - Examples of locations: **Jeddah** (the port of Saudi Arabia on the Red Sea) and **Riyadh**; also **Canada** and, surprisingly, **Singapore**.

EXAMPLE

Case that shaped the one-stop centres.

- A female who had been wrongfully married to a boy from Pakistan was evacuated from that country — this was in **2014**, during the first term (2014-19).
- There was a movie on it too; the name is not clearly recoverable [as stated].

- Note the distinction: the one-stop centres in India are under **Mission Shakti and Sambal** in the Ministry of Women and Child Development — they are similar in design but not the same as the ones abroad.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

MADAD.

- **MADAD** is a **grievance-redressal platform**.
- Consular access is very important, and the platform addresses grievances of the diaspora in developed nations as well.

- Consular access is the practical channel through which the diaspora's grievances and distress are handled.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

e-Migrate system.

- The **e-Migrate system** digitally connects **emigrants**.
- It registers **recruiting agents** and **foreign employers**, which eventually leads to a **reduction in fraudulent recruitment and human trafficking**.

- How it works: if a recruiter calls you to Oman, Kuwait or Bahrain, that recruiter's credentials must be uploaded on the e-Migrate system, so you can verify them before going.

EXAMPLE

The problem e-Migrate solves.

- An Oman construction company offers Rs. 20,000 → Rs. 1 lakh, six-day weeks and a trip home every three months with expenses paid; the worker naturally wants to go.
- The risk is the recruiter — whether credentials are right, whether the promised work and a return every three months will actually happen (the recruiter may change three months into three years).
- The e-Migrate system uploads the recruiter's details so the worker can check them, and it prevents trafficking — a woman could be pushed into prostitution/sex trafficking, and a man into work he never agreed to.

15.6.2 *Engagement*

- **Pravasi Bharatiya Divas** and **Pravasi Bharatiya Samman** are engagement measures — contracts of recognition and connection, not of security.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Steps are split into **protection and welfare** vs **broad engagement**.
> - Protection and welfare schemes: **ICWF (2009)**, one-stop centres and night shelters abroad (Bahrain, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, UAE, Saudi Arabia; Jeddah, Riyadh; Canada, Singapore), **MADAD** and **e-Migrate**.
> - ICWF is the oldest — financial aid in emergencies and evacuation support during conflicts and disasters.
> - MADAD is a grievance-redressal platform; e-Migrate digitally connects emigrants and registers recruiting agents/foreign employers, cutting fraudulent recruitment and trafficking.
> - One-stop centres in India sit under Mission Shakti and Sambal (Ministry of Women and Child Development) — similar design, not the same.
> - Engagement measures: Pravasi Bharatiya Divas and Pravasi Bharatiya Samman.

15.7 Way Forward and Overall Policy Shift

The way forward rests on a clear shift in India's approach to the diaspora and on the broader direction of foreign policy.

- **Keyword mnemonic — the Cs**: **Connect**, **Contribute**, **Celebrate**.
  - Celebrate your ties — do not forget the days spent and the connections with the diaspora; mark the Pravasi Parva/festival.
  - A final 'C' in the mnemonic is not clearly recoverable from the lecture [as stated].
- **Overall shift**: India has to follow a **multi-vector foreign policy**, fulfil its strategic interests, and remember that it cannot assert its own sovereignty without domestic reforms.
- The government of the day has become **proactive** — the legacy elite orientation of politics has been ended; responses and transfers are immediate (e.g. the Delhi Police Commissioner cannot simply sit; you have to work hard on the field).
- Engagement has evolved from dealing with provinces to a **comprehensive system — safe mobility**, **protection and partnership**, and the diaspora as a **bridge**; embassies and consulates are open and many steps have been taken.

> **PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION**
>
> **Exam and news guidance.**
>
> - Familiarise yourself and follow the newspapers — the came-in-the-mains question is on the India-BRICS dimension [as stated], and watch what happens at the summit.
> - Summit outcomes to track: a broad final declaration, e.g. the **Delhi Declaration** as the end

result (the **Bishkek Declaration** came out of the SCO) — set the disagreements aside and watch how India balances.

- India's **tough balancing** is a major diplomatic challenge; the next topic in class is the **SCO** (a regional body), with **BRICS** to follow.

QUICK REVISION

- Way-forward keyword mnemonic: the Cs — **Connect, Contribute, Celebrate**.
- Overall shift: a multi-vector foreign policy, strategic interests, and domestic reforms as the basis of sovereignty.
- The government has become proactive; the legacy elite orientation of politics has ended; immediate responses and transfers.
- Engagement has moved from provinces to a comprehensive system — safe mobility, protection and partnership, the diaspora as a bridge.
- Exam guidance: follow the newspapers and the summit declarations (Delhi Declaration vs Bishkek Declaration); India's tough balancing is the challenge; next topics are the SCO and BRICS.

CHAPTER 16

India’s Diaspora — Part 4: Answer-Writing on the Diaspora as Living Bridge, Economic Factor and Knowledge Network

16.1 The 2020 Question and Its Demand

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Question (2020 Mains — 250 words, 12 minutes).

- "India’s diaspora acts as a living bridge, as a critical economic factor and a knowledge network in transforming cultural heritage into geopolitical influence and strategic leverage worldwide."
- This is a question already done in class, to be written as a 2020 question.

The first step with any question is to underline its keywords.

- Keyword 1 — the Indian diaspora acts as a **living bridge**.
- Keyword 2 — the Indian diaspora is a **critical economic factor**.
- Keyword 3 — the Indian diaspora is a **knowledge network**.
- Together these three transform **cultural heritage** (holy Diwali, yoga, Ayurveda) into **geopolitical influence** and **strategic leverage** worldwide.

KEY CONCEPT

The demand of the question (the catch).

- The question does not ask whether the Indian diaspora is a living bridge; it supplies three heads under which the diaspora’s **role** is to be written — role as a bridge, role as a critical economic factor and role as a knowledge network.
- What students did: they wrote their own headings such as ’economic impact’ or ’political impact’. The content was the same, but the demand of the question was never decoded.
- Writing ’living bridge’ as a heading and then dumping points under it is not the demand. The demand is to show the **factors that have led to the transformation of India’s cultural heritage into geopolitical influence and strategic leverage**; under that, write the role as a bridge, the role as a critical economic factor and the role as a knowledge network.

- In the Civil Services Examination every Tom, Dick and Harry who has prepared will write this question.
- What sets an answer apart is, first, the **keywords**, second, the **structure**, and only then the

content.

- The content was used, but the inability to arrange it in the structure of the question went against the answer.
- Depth of reading alone does not fetch marks — write only as much as is needed.

EXAMPLE

Placing a fact the question did not directly ask for.

- Because the question gives three heads, a fourth head may be added: 'Apart from the three factors discussed above, Indians have taken important political positions — for example **Rishi Sunak** — and thereby played a very important role in the transformation.'

Role as a living bridge	Acts as a cultural bridge (yoga, Ayurveda, family values, Bollywood, festivals) keeping India's civilizational links alive, and as a diplomatic bridge promoting bilateral ties and lobbying for India's interests	Girmitiyas in the Indo-Pacific, the Caribbean and South Africa; the Indo-US nuclear deal
Role as a critical economic factor	Remittances, trade and investment, FDI, and exports for India and for the host countries	India is the world's number one in remittances — US$130 billion (World Bank)
Role as a knowledge network	Two-way interaction: innovation, mentorship, brain circulation, education, market information and cultural knowledge	11% of international students in the US are from India

QUICK REVISION

- The 2020 question asks how the diaspora — as a living bridge, a critical economic factor and a knowledge network — transforms cultural heritage into geopolitical influence and strategic leverage.
- Underline the keywords first: living bridge, critical economic factor, knowledge network.
- The question demands the diaspora's role under these three heads, not a general description of the diaspora.
- What sets an answer apart: keywords, then structure, then content.
- A fourth head may be added after the three factors — Indians in important political positions, e.g. Rishi Sunak.

16.2 Introduction and the Opening Line

The introduction is written first, and it must be memorised — one student had the whole answer in the notes but blanked on the introduction in the exam.

KEY CONCEPT

The opening line (memorise as if engraved in stone).

- Refined opening: 'India's **35 million diaspora** (now **38 million**) is India's pride and **Rashtradoot** (national ambassador), playing an important role in India's geopolitical influence.'
- The 38 million figure is the **NMEA-2026** number; the exact number is to be checked in the **PIB** release.
- Do not quote political-science experts ('as per so-and-so', 'he said this', 'he said that'); this is the **General Studies Paper 2 / Political Science** paper — write plainly.

- Memorise exactly what is dictated in class — treat the dictated material as written in stone.
- Do not depend on random PDFs or other teachers; they do not know what is to be written where.
- Thesis line to establish the answer: 'Now, the Indian diaspora, through the following roles, has rightly increased India's geopolitical influence and enhanced its global reputation.'

QUICK REVISION

- Always write the introduction first; memorise it, because content alone is not enough in the exam.
- Opening figure: India's 35 million (now 38 million) diaspora — the NMEA-2026 number, to be verified on PIB.
- Describe the diaspora as India's pride and Rashtradoot (national ambassador).
- Avoid expert quotations; this is a GS Paper 2 / Political Science answer.
- Use the thesis line that the diaspora, through the following roles, has increased India's geopolitical influence and global reputation.

16.3 Role 1 — The Diaspora as a Living Bridge

The first role given in the question is the diaspora as a living bridge.

COMPARISON

Kinds of bridge the diaspora forms.

- Diagram to draw: India — bridge — host diaspora.
- Diplomatic bridge
- Cultural bridge
- Economic bridge
- Strategic bridge

- Soft power bridge

Because the question separately asks for the critical economic factor and the knowledge network, the living bridge head develops only the cultural and diplomatic dimensions; the economic and knowledge dimensions are written under their own heads.

KEY CONCEPT

Role as a living bridge — the two dimensions.

- As a **cultural bridge**, the diaspora has popularised **yoga, Ayurveda, family values, Bollywood and festivals**, keeping India's civilizational links alive. Example: the **Girmitiyas** in the Indo-Pacific, the Caribbean and South Africa [as stated in lecture].
- As a **diplomatic bridge**, the diaspora promotes strong bilateral relations and pursues and lobbies for India's interests. Example: the role of India's diaspora in the US in the **Indo-US nuclear deal**.

QUICK REVISION

- First role: the diaspora as a living bridge — a cultural and diplomatic bridge between India and the host country.
- The bridge may be described as diplomatic, cultural, economic, strategic or soft power; draw the diagram India — bridge — host diaspora.
- Cultural dimension: popularised yoga, Ayurveda, family values, Bollywood and festivals; example — Girmitiyas in the Indo-Pacific, the Caribbean and South Africa.
- Diplomatic dimension: promotes bilateral relations and lobbies for India's interests; example — the Indo-US nuclear deal.
- The economic and knowledge dimensions are not repeated here; they are the question's separate heads.

16.4 Role 2 — The Diaspora as a Critical Economic Factor

The second role given in the question is the diaspora as a critical economic factor — it is this role that has driven the transformation.

- **Remittances** — the diaspora sends money home, and India is the world's number one recipient.
- **Trade and investment** — the diaspora has promoted trade and investment and has led to **FDI**.
- **Exports** — it has promoted exports not only for India but also for the host countries.

DATA & FACTS

Figures to quote.

- Remittances: **US$130 billion**, making India the world's number one; source — the **World Bank's World Remittance Report**.
- FCNR(B) deposits (latest **RBI** statistics): [amount] dollars between **June and 31 August 2026** — the figure was not recoverable from the transcript [as stated in lecture].

QUICK REVISION

- Second role: the diaspora as a critical economic factor, which has driven the transformation.
- Remittances: India is world number one, at US$130 billion, per the World Bank's World Remittance Report.
- Trade and investment promoted, leading to FDI.
- Exports promoted for India and for the host countries.
- FCNR(B) deposits are cited from the latest RBI statistics (figure as stated in lecture).

16.5 Role 3 — The Diaspora as a Knowledge Network

The third role given in the question is the diaspora as a knowledge network — the head that students most often leave unbuilt.

KEY CONCEPT

How a knowledge network works.

- A **knowledge network** is a **two-way interaction** between the host country and India — a dialogue, not a monologue; India shares and the host country shares back.
- A **network** means **interlinkage**.
- A diagram of the network is to be drawn.

Everything the diaspora carries — trade, business, cultural knowledge — moves through this two-way network.

EXAMPLE

The interlinkage, illustrated.

- 'I am in Dallas and you want to come to Dallas — I have given you the knowledge; let us sell a Telugu biryani, a samba biryani, a Moradabadi biryani. And if somebody is doing business, I will tell him my friend is in Hyderabad or Delhi. There are many students preparing for the Civil Services Examination — let us sell protein bars that are tasty and high quality; you consume them, I send them to you, I call you over to me. That is a network.'

1. **Innovation** — a role in promoting start-ups and entrepreneurs.
2. **Mentorship** — the diaspora acts as mentor, as senior students do in colleges and IITs, where second- and third-year students mentor first-year students.
3. **Brain circulation** — many Indians are coming back and setting up and leading **Global Capability Centres** in India; innovation and brain circulation are similar, but both can be written as separate points.
4. **Education** — the diaspora promotes the entry of Indian students into higher education institutions in the US. Example: **11% of international students in the US are from India**.
5. **Market information** — a market and trade network, carrying knowledge of local laws and regulations, because the diaspora has **dual familiarity**.
6. **Cultural knowledge** — India's role in the promotion of cultural knowledge; the diaspora has

increased India's civilizational influence and spread India's soft power. Here it is written as cultural knowledge, not as soft power.

QUICK REVISION

- Third role: the diaspora as a knowledge network — a two-way interaction (dialogue, not monologue) between host country and India; a network means interlinkage, and a diagram is to be drawn.
- Components: innovation, mentorship, brain circulation, education, market information and cultural knowledge.
- Brain circulation: Indians returning to set up and lead Global Capability Centres in India — similar to innovation yet written separately.
- Education figure: 11% of international students in the US are from India.
- Market information rests on the diaspora's dual familiarity with local laws and regulations.
- Cultural knowledge carries India's civilizational influence and soft power.

16.6 The Fourth Head — Political Positions and Strategic Influence

After about 220 words on the three roles, a fourth head can be added to complete the answer.

KEY CONCEPT

The fourth head.

- 'Apart from the above, several members of the diaspora have occupied political positions and have thereby increased India's strategic influence.'
- Example: an Indian-origin leader occupying a top political office [name garbled in the transcript — as stated in lecture].
- The conclusion follows: **the diaspora is a soft power ambassador**.

QUICK REVISION

- A fourth head may be added after the three roles, after roughly 220 words.
- Content: several members of the diaspora have occupied political positions and thereby increased India's strategic influence.
- Closing line: the diaspora is a soft power ambassador.

16.7 Answer-Writing Craft: Keywords, Structure and Practice

Once the answer is understood, only the craft of writing remains — and the craft is what the examiner actually rewards.

KEY CONCEPT

The basics.

- There is nothing called **exam pressure** — it is a matter of training; the exact answer comes

once the structure is learnt.

- First, **show the examiner what he wants**.
- Second, for every subject there are certain **keywords and certain facts** that must be written.
- Third, **how** you write them is your art — it will be your art.
- Flex your muscles by following the basic rules: **keyword, structure, then points**.

The method behind this: in 2014, with only two or three months to spare, all the Civil Services questions from 2013 till 2023 were framed in two or three days and then newspapers were picked up — and it became easy to re-enter the student's zone, because the framing had opened the mind. But that opening up had to be flexed like a muscle.

EXAMPLE

Warm up before you write.

- When you go to the gym, or play any sport, you warm up — you flex your muscles. In the exam too, flex them by following the basic rules: **keyword, structure, and then the points**.

- Give the examiner the points in the **structure** first — structure, structure, structure.
- 'First things first, don't write anything' — build the structure before writing.
- There is no need to write so many tests; the points arrived at were about the same (perhaps one or two fewer), and conviction comes on seeing the answer.

KEY CONCEPT

Refining the economic head (two words to identify).

- If remittances are increasing, say so — it has led to **economic sovereignty** and boosted India's **GDP**, and thereby India's influence.
- Add that the **9 million-strong Indian community in the Gulf Cooperation Council (Gulf)** has been one of the most important sources of remittances.
- Break the remittance point and add the Gulf knowledge network (9 million) under the knowledge-network head.

- You may write whatever you are thinking, but it must be put to the examiner **under the right head**.
- The head must be taken from the question itself; do not create your own structure or your own keywords.

- Keyword bells: on seeing 'diaspora', the bell rings — **35 million (now 38), pride, Rashtradoot, living bridge** — and the living bridge must be explained.
- A living bridge includes every bridge — economic, trade, cultural, geopolitical, political and network — and a bridge means **two-way interaction** (a concept given in class: a bridge is not for standing on, it carries movement both ways).

QUICK REVISION

- There is no exam pressure; there is training — and the exact answer comes from the structure.
- Basics: show the examiner what he wants; use the subject's keywords and facts; the way you write is your art.
- Work order: keyword → structure → points; build the structure before writing anything.
- No need for endless test-writing; conviction comes on seeing the answer.
- Refine heads with two identified words (remittances → economic sovereignty → GDP → influence) and add the 9 million-strong Gulf community.
- Every point must reach the examiner under the head taken from the question; never invent a structure or a keyword.
- Keyword bells on 'diaspora': 35 million (now 38), pride, Rashtradoot, living bridge; a bridge means two-way interaction.

16.8 Directive Words, the Counter-View and the Conclusion

CRITICAL POINT

Directive words and the other side of the argument.

- In the experience of writing and seeing many papers, **critically examine, elucidate and discuss** make no real difference.
- For **critically examine**, two paragraphs of the opposite side can be added: the diaspora has done this, but certain issues and concerns have been raised — the threat of **extremism** and the emergence of a **gangster-terrorist nexus**, and endorsing and indulging in increasing **protests in foreign lands**, which has brought **disrepute to India**.
- Example: **Khalistani protests in the UK**.

- Two lines would have been enough for the counter-view; they can be stretched to four — make two points out of the four points already dictated.
- Use the counter-points only where the demand is 'critically examine'.
- Answer-writing templates: multiple templates are provided, yet no one writes with only one — follow the question's own demand.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Government measures to bring into the answer.

- **e-Migrate** — launched for the **welfare of the diaspora**.
- A **two-pronged approach**: (1) **schemes for welfare**, and (2) **schemes for safety and security**.

- Conclude with a **4C** conclusion.
- Or conclude with the diaspora's role as a **soft power ambassador**.
- Or bring in the **issues** raised against the diaspora.
- Or add any recent statement or development you know — for example the e-Migrate launch.

QUICK REVISION

- critically examine, elucidate and discuss make little practical difference; only 'critically examine' calls for the counter-view.
- Counter-view: extremism and the gangster-terrorist nexus, protests in foreign lands, disrepute to India; example — Khalistani protests in the UK.
- Write two counter-lines (stretchable to four) — two points out of the four dictated.
- Multiple answer-writing templates are provided; no single template fits every question.
- Government measures: e-Migrate for diaspora welfare; the two-pronged approach of welfare schemes and safety-and-security schemes.
- Conclusion options: 4C, the soft power ambassador role, the issues, or a recent development.

16.9 Practice Questions to Structure

For the sixty questions that came in Papers 1, 2 and 3, do nothing but underline the keywords and build the structure; warm up, and the content will come on its own.

- The simple rule: **underline the keywords**, then break the question along them.
- Do not apply your own brain or rejig the structure; if you keep rearranging it, the next levels will never be understood.

1. **Do you think India's diaspora has played an important role in the transformation of India's strategic influence?** — Meaning: how will strategic influence increase when the diaspora has influence in the economy, in the society and in the culture of the host country. If the answer is yes, write those items from the notes — but not in the structure suggested.
2. **The diaspora is often referred to as the living bridge and soft power ambassador. Critically examine the statement, discussing the steps taken by the Government of India.** — Structure: the meaning of the living bridge and all its dimensions; since 'soft power ambassador' is given separately, place the cultural dimension within the living bridge and show it as soft power there.
3. **There has been a shift in the nature of the Indian diaspora abroad. Critically examine, giving examples.** — A shift is from A to B, and it must be shown in each dimension of the diaspora's life.

CRITICAL POINT

Why the critique is needed.

- Nothing is entirely good: the diaspora of about **40 million** is **heterogeneous**, not uniform, and its domestic issues have been carried abroad.
- Examples: **Hindu-Muslim** or **Hindu-Sikh** divisions, and continuing **caste divisions, divisions of religion and gender divisions** — a foreign observer reads them as the diaspora's own problems.
- Add that a **terror network** has spread through the world and that the home country could not satisfy some **unmet needs**.

QUICK REVISION

- Practise the sixty questions of Papers 1, 2 and 3 by underlining keywords and building structures only; content will come on its own.
- Never rejig the given structure or apply your own brain to it.
- Q1 (strategic influence): show the diaspora's influence in the host country's economy, society and culture.
- Q2 (living bridge and soft power ambassador): structure on the living bridge's dimensions and place the cultural dimension as soft power.
- Q3 (shift): a shift runs from A to B across each dimension of the diaspora's life.
- The critique: a heterogeneous ~40 million diaspora carries domestic divisions (Hindu-Muslim, Hindu-Sikh, caste, religion, gender) abroad; there is a global terror network and unmet needs at home.

16.10 Shifts in the Nature of the Indian Diaspora

- In the Civil Services Examination, write the **pros and cons** of everything: if the question asks for pros, also give cons; if it asks for cons, give **80% cons and 20% pros**.
- If the question clearly asks for both pros and cons, then the split is **50-50**.

1. **Economic shift** in the diaspora.
2. **Cultural shift** — earlier, occasions such as the **IFA awards** would happen; was a Diwali holiday even given in Edmonton or Canada? The diaspora is no longer only a cultural power ambassador — it **asserts** its culture, asserting holy **Diwali, Eid, Janmashtami and Onam** in the foreign land.
3. **Political shift** — earlier the diaspora were only **voters**; now they are not merely voters but **kingmakers**, not merely administrators but **leaders occupying positions of power**. Examples: **Firman, Shanmugam and Rathnam** [as stated in lecture]; the 'Madam' shown in Malaysia; **Rishi Sunak**; **Braverman**; and **Zohran Mamdani**, who became **Mayor of New York**. The New York Mayorship is almost the number two position; the **London Mayor** is very powerful, and a London Mayor even became **Prime Minister** — a big achievement.
4. **Diplomatic shift** — the diaspora now acts as **active supporters and active lobbyists**, actively lobbying for India's policy. Examples: the recent **Double Contribution Avoidance Agreement** signed between India and the UK (FTA), made possible by the role of the Indian diaspora, and the **nuclear deal of 2005**.

DATA & FACTS

The span of the shift.

- Broadly, this is a **10-15-20 year** shift.
- The reasoning: the Civil Services Examination material is itself 10-15-20 years latest, because the whole of International Relations is divided into areas.

QUICK REVISION

- Pros-cons rule: if pros are asked, still give cons; if cons are asked, 80% cons and 20% pros; if both are asked, 50-50.
- Four shifts: economic, cultural, political and diplomatic.
- Cultural shift: from events such as the IFA awards to actively asserting Diwali, Eid, Janmashtami and Onam abroad.
- Political shift: from voters to kingmakers and from administrators to leaders — Firman, Shanmugam, Rathnam, Rishi Sunak, Braverman and Zohran Mamdani (Mayor of New York); a London Mayor even became Prime Minister.
- Diplomatic shift: from passive presence to active lobbying — the Double Contribution Avoidance Agreement with the UK (FTA) and the 2005 nuclear deal.
- The shift spans broadly 10-15-20 years.

CHAPTER 17

India's Diaspora — Part 3

17.1 SCO in the News and the Roadmap for this Class

This part completes the diaspora sequence: the **steps** taken for the diaspora, and the role the diaspora has played in **Southeast Asia** and in **West Asia** (the United States and the West were already covered).

The class opened with the latest SCO developments, which are directly exam-relevant.

- The **Prime Minister clearly criticised Pakistan**: the SCO nations cannot have a **double voice** with respect to terrorism — double standards on terrorism are not acceptable.
- **Pakistan is now the head of the SCO**, and next year's SCO summit will be held in Pakistan.
- **Lahore** has been named an SCO **cultural city**; cultural cities are named every year.
- When **India was the SCO chair**, the city of **Varanasi** was the cultural city.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **Exam relevance.**
>
> - Seven to eight articles have come up in **The Hindu** and **The Express** regarding the SCO — follow them.
> - The SCO is a standing exam area, and it is being taught alongside the diaspora.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - The class covers the **steps** taken for the diaspora and its role in **Southeast Asia** and **West Asia**.
> - SCO news: the **Prime Minister criticised Pakistan** — SCO nations cannot have a double voice on terrorism.
> - **Pakistan is the head of the SCO**; next year's summit is to be held in Pakistan.
> - **Lahore** is the SCO cultural city; when India chaired the SCO, **Varanasi** was the cultural city.
> - Seven to eight articles on the SCO appeared in **The Hindu** and **The Express**.

17.2 Recap: The Diaspora's Role and the Protection–Welfare Framework

Recap of the earlier discussion — the answer on the diaspora is built from the examples already collected.

- The **Samosa Caucus** — the informal name for members of Indian origin in the US House of

Representatives.

- The diaspora's contribution to the host **society**, above all to **multiculturalism**.
- Its contribution in **geopolitics**.

KEY CONCEPT

Why the diaspora is a diplomatic instrument.

- The diaspora opens up **new channels of diplomacy**.
- India cannot always engage through **Track 1** — the inter-governmental relationship. The diaspora opens up that opportunity.

- The steps were written as **two sets** — **protection** steps and **welfare** steps — protection first, welfare next.
- This is an analytical classification used for these notes; it is **not a Government of India classification**.

CRITICAL POINT

Answer-writing instruction.

- **Diagrams are very important in the exam** — they are what you remember.
- Draw the diagram of the **two sets of steps** (protection and welfare) in the answer.

QUICK REVISION

- Recap examples: **Samosa Caucus**, contribution to society and **multiculturalism**, contribution in **geopolitics**.
- The diaspora opens **new channels of diplomacy** because **Track 1** (inter-governmental) engagement cannot always be used.
- The steps are written as **protection steps** and **welfare steps** — an analytical, not official, classification.
- **Diagrams must be drawn** in the exam; draw the two-step diagram.

17.3 Protection Steps: Pravasi Bharatiya Sahayata Kendra (PBSK)

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

PBSK — Pravasi Bharatiya Sahayata Kendra.

- **PBSK** stands for **Pravasi Bharatiya Sahayata Kendra**; in English it can be called a **migrant resource centre**.
- It provides **counselling**, **legal and employment guidance**, and **24x7 assistance**.

- In a way these are **counselling centres**, like the **one-stop centres in India for women**.
  - If you are in a Western country and want assistance or help from the authorities, the kendra provides it.
- Centres operate in **Dubai**, **Saudi Arabia** and **Malaysia**.

- A kendra also operates **in India** — there is one in **Delhi** — for **prospective migrants**.
  - In India the centre counsels prospective migrants, because they do not know about the job market.

17.3.1 The Skilling Problem

- The **biggest problem** in this area is **skill**.
- Example: **two years ago Israel demanded construction labourers**; when India went to Israel, the required skill was simply not available.
- Reason: construction techniques differ across Indian states — **Kerala, Andhra, Gujarat, Karnataka, Rajasthan, Punjab, Himachal, the North East** — the way houses are built is entirely different, and only concrete is common.
  - That diversity of technique became a problem when workers had to be sent abroad.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Gaza reconstruction — an opportunity and a warning.**
>
> - Gaza's rehabilitation and reconstruction is a **very big rebuilding opportunity**; Indians will earn very good money there.
> - Therefore migrants must be **skilled before they are sent**, and when they return to India they must be given **free skilling** and rehabilitated in India.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - **PBSK** = Pravasi Bharatiya Sahayata Kendra, or a **migrant resource centre**.
> - It gives **counselling, legal and employment guidance and 24x7 assistance** — like the one-stop centres in India for women.
> - Centres are in **Dubai, Saudi Arabia and Malaysia**, and also in India (**Delhi**) for prospective migrants.
> - The biggest problem is **skill** — Israel's demand for **construction labourers** could not be met.
> - Construction techniques differ across Indian states; **Gaza's rebuilding** is a big opportunity, so skill before sending and re-skill on return.

17.4 Protection Steps: Pravasi Bharatiya Bima Yojana (PBBY)

> **GOVERNMENT & POLICY**
>
> **Pravasi Bharatiya Bima Yojana — the insurance scheme.**
>
> - The scheme gives **mandatory insurance protection for specified emigrant workers**.
> - Cover of **10 lakh rupees** for **accidental death** or **permanent disability**.
> - Cover of **1 lakh rupees** as **medical cover**.

- Why insurance is essential: accidents happen in Dubai — someone falls from a height, someone suffers a disability, some such contingency arises.
- It has to be read with the **contract system of the Middle East** — how work is done there.

EXAMPLE

The best example of Middle East working conditions.

- **Qatar and the FIFA World Cup** — the episode that brought the conditions of migrant labour in the Middle East to the world's attention.

QUICK REVISION

- **PBBY** gives **mandatory insurance** to specified emigrant workers.
- **10 lakh rupees** for accidental death or permanent disability, and **1 lakh rupees** medical cover.
- Justification: accidents and falls in Dubai and the Middle East's contract system.
- **Qatar and the FIFA World Cup** is the best example of the working conditions the scheme answers.

17.5 Protection Steps: Pre-Departure Orientation Training (PDOT)

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

PDOT — Pre-Departure Orientation Training.

- **PDOT** stands for **Pre-Departure Orientation Training**.
- It is under the **Pravasi Kaushal Vikas Yojana**.
- It is very important: to **perform culturally** in that part of the world, you must know the culture.

- **Culture** of the destination country — every society has **unsaid rules**.
- **Labour laws** of the destination country.
- **Language** of the destination country.
- **Do's and don'ts** — the clearly stated terms of what you can and cannot do.
- How to **engage with the local government**.
- **Safe migration practices**.
- **Employment conditions**.

17.5.1 Example: Religion and Work Culture in the Gulf

- In **Saudi Arabia** the five daily **namaaz** have to be offered, so offices and institutions close; the logic is that Saudi Arabia wants to be the **flag bearer of Islam**.
- This is not found as frequently in **Dubai**; **UAE** has **seven Emirates** and not all seven are advanced — **Sharjah** and **Abu Dhabi**, for instance.
- **Kuwait** is comparatively much more advanced; it has a large Indian population, many Indian schools, and there is also a **quota in BCCI** [as stated in lecture] through which Indian players get selected for the Indian team.
- Religion is one area in which nothing can be meddled with; the **Ayodhya dynamic** therefore enters this discussion and has to be understood.

QUICK REVISION

- **PDOT** = Pre-Departure Orientation Training, under the **Pravasi Kaushal Vikas Yojana**.
- Trains the migrant in the destination country's **culture, labour laws, language, do's and don'ts, engagement with the local government, safe migration practices and employment conditions**.
- Saudi Arabia: five daily **namaaz**, offices close — it wants to be the **flag bearer of Islam**; Dubai is different.
- **UAE has seven Emirates** and not all are advanced; **Kuwait** is comparatively more advanced (large Indian population, many Indian schools, a BCCI quota [as stated]).
- Religion cannot be meddled with — the **Ayodhya dynamic** enters here.

17.6 Protection Steps: Bilateral Protection of Workers

KEY CONCEPT

Bilateral protection of workers.

- **MEA signs these agreements**, but the overall ambit also needs the **other country's involvement** — it is the diaspora that is getting the jobs.
- **Bilateral protection of workers** is the umbrella under which labour and mobility agreements sit.

- **Labour agreements** — the host country commits that it will **recruit a stated number of people** from India.
- **Migration and Mobility Partnership Agreements** — very important for **skilled workers**.
- **Specific migration agreements between two or three countries** — a specific arrangement in which the host country takes a good number of migrants from your country.
  - This is a **specific commitment and a guarantee**: a **fixed number of people** will be taken under a migration/mobility agreement.
- It is a step taken **by the other country**, giving India the assurance that it will recruit this many people.

QUICK REVISION

- **Bilateral protection of workers**: MEA signs the agreement, but the other country must be involved — the diaspora gets the jobs.
- **Labour agreements** — a stated number of Indians recruited.
- **Migration and Mobility Partnership Agreements** — crucial for **skilled workers**.
- **Specific migration agreements** between two or three countries guarantee a **fixed number of migrants**.
- These are commitments made by the host country, giving India an assurance of recruitment.

17.7 Protection Steps: Social Security Agreements (SSA)

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Social Security Agreement (SSA).

- India **recently signed a Social Security Agreement with the United Kingdom**.
- Social security exists **where the country is developed**; poor and less developed countries have little to offer — what social security does a street vendor have?

17.7.1 What Social Security Means — The Four Components

KEY CONCEPT

Social security = four things.

- **Insurance**
- **Pension**
- **Provident fund**
- **Gratuity**
- Whenever a question talks of social security, these **four** must be written.

- **Gratuity**: earlier it accrued when you worked for a certain number of years — it used to be **five years**, and under the **new labour laws** it has become **one year**.
  - So if you work for **more than one year** with an organisation, certain contributions are made by that organisation as social security.
- How it works abroad: you open a **bank account**, you are issued a **migrant card**, and the employer tells you that the first amount will be deducted from your salary as social security.
- If you fall ill in the **UK** you have **NHS services**; if you fall ill in **Canada** you can go to a Canadian hospital.

17.7.2 Healthcare Abroad: The US Contrast

CRITICAL POINT

US healthcare is problematic.

- In the US there is no such thing as being seen at will — there is a **fixed priority order** for appointments.
- To get an appointment the patient has to convince the doctor that his life is in his palm and he can pass out at any time; only then is he seen.
- The ways of fulfilling social security and the facilities attached to it are themselves as complicated as the cover.

- Consequence: many Indians in **Dallas** and other parts of the developed world come to **India for dental work and eye treatment**, because it is very costly there.
- Figure given: a **root canal in India costs about 35,000-40,000 rupees** [as stated in lecture], far cheaper than abroad.

17.7.3 Where SSAs Have Been Signed, and the Gulf's Contribution

- SSAs have been signed with **developed nations** and with the **Gulf nations**.
- In the Gulf, **every frequent building has been built by an Indian** — an Indian labourer's role is there in the infrastructure growth of the Gulf; doctors and engineers are also there, and they earn a lot of money.
- In the Gulf there is **zero tax**, which is why the money is attractive.

17.7.4 The Shift from London to Dubai

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Why the rich moved from London to Dubai.**
>
> - Earlier, many people went to **London**, because it is said that London is the place where everybody wants to have a house — the world's rich want a house in London.
> - Now the **weather** has turned them away: it is cold, the sun comes for three months, there is rain for nine months, and the gloomy weather gives people depression.
> - So the same people are buying houses in **Dubai** instead.

- India's ultra-rich have **reclaimed islands** in Dubai and contractors have built houses there; they now sell their homes in Delhi and other cities saying "take this in Dubai" — Dubai has become like a **cultural city**.
- But after the attack of the recent war (referred to in the lecture as the **Burj Al Arab** attack), that image of Dubai as a cultural capital has taken a **good dent** — a big loss.
- Property prices: in Dubai **10 crore rupees will not get you a villa**; the houses are beautiful with the beach right in front.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - **SSA** signed recently with the **United Kingdom**; they exist where the country is developed.
> - Social security = **insurance + pension + provident fund + gratuity** (four components to write).
> - **Gratuity**: five years earlier, **one year** under the new labour laws; abroad — bank account, migrant card, deduction from salary, NHS in the UK and hospitals in Canada.
> - **US healthcare is problematic** (fixed priority order); Indians therefore come to India for dental and eye treatment — a root canal here costs about **35,000-40,000 rupees** [as stated].
> - SSAs with **developed nations** and the **Gulf**; Gulf buildings are Indian-built, tax is **zero**.
> - Shift from **London to Dubai** (weather, gloom, depression); Dubai's image as a cultural city took a **dent** after the recent war; **10 crore does not buy a villa**.

17.8 Emergency Evacuation and Crisis Response

The last of the safety-and-security responses is the evacuation and crisis-response machinery of the MEA.

- **MEA carries out emergency evacuation** and **crisis response** — a large part of its work in the

last two to three years.

- The media sells these operations very well — that the MEA carried out the operation, brought back so many people, put them on flights with food and free treatment.
  - How easy the process actually is, is difficult to see; in **Russia** it could not happen and many were left stranded.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **Exam instruction — write the operations down.**
>
> - The **operation names matter for Prelims**; they can be asked in the examination.
> - Make a **mnemonic** and write the names **10,000 times** so that they stay in your head.
> - These are necessary to remember — even during preparation they are hard to retain.

The operations to remember, in order, are the following.

> **COMPARISON**
>
> **Evacuation operations to remember.**
>
> - **Operation Sindhu** — started **June 2025** — brought people back from **Iran and Israel**.
> - **Operation Ganga** — the **Russia-Ukraine** war — the most popular of them.
> - **Operation Kaveri** — from **Sudan**, in **2023**.
> - **Vande Bharat Mission** — the **COVID-19** repatriation, a major operation carried out successfully, with the **MEA coordinating with all agencies**.

17.8.1 *Operation Kaveri and Why Sudan Matters*

- Sudan is a very interesting area — a **cultural hub of Africa**.
- Above Sudan are the **Arabs**; below Sudan are the **ethnic Africans** — Sudan is a mix of both.
- Its location is right at the **equator**; there are **swamps**; the capital is **Khartoum**, where the **Blue Nile and the White Nile** meet; the war there has been going on for a long time.
- Two heads: on one side the **army**, on the other the **Rapid Support Forces**, which came out of the **Janjaweed** — it was part of the army, but there was a fight over who would be the head of Sudan.
  - Sudan therefore has an army and a **paramilitary** — the Rapid Support Forces.
- Important locations and provinces: **Abyei** (important for oil), **Darfur** (there is a good song — 'You Shall Rise, Darfur') and **Kordofan**.
- Sudan is most famous for its trees: the **Babool** tree, whose scientific name is **Acacia**; from the Babool tree is extracted the gum used in chewing gum — **gum Arabic**.
- **90% of the world's production of gum Arabic** comes from Sudan.
- **Ethiopia**: a war is going on; the **Afar Republic**; Ethiopia is a cultural centre, and airlines flying to Africa are **Ethiopian** or **Emirates**.
- Ethiopia's west touches Sudan, and the border of the two is an interesting **fringe cultural fight**; Ethiopian culture differs from Egyptian culture (the Egyptians are Arabic); Sudan is the **melting pot**, and below it Africa begins.

- **Tigray** — the Tigray Republic — is part of this region; the map of Ethiopia and this area will be drawn in the map class.
- Care follows protection: awards are given to prominent members of the diaspora, including big CEOs.
  - The emotional pull is used too — homeland songs are played at the airport ('come back home') to bring them back.
- The logic behind the courtship: they will bring money, and money brings development — money is very important in life.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - **MEA** handles **emergency evacuation and crisis response**; the media sells the operations well, but the ground process is hard (Russia was an exception where it could not happen).
> - Operations: **Sindhu (June 2025, Iran and Israel), Ganga (Russia-Ukraine), Kaveri (Sudan, 2023), Vande Bharat Mission (COVID-19)** — make a mnemonic and write them 10,000 times.
> - **Sudan**: cultural hub of Africa, Arabs in the north and ethnic Africans in the south, Khartoum where the Blue and White Nile meet, army vs **Rapid Support Forces** (from the Janjaweed), Abyei, Darfur and Kordofan.
> - Sudan gives **90% of the world's gum Arabic**, from the **Babool (Acacia)** tree.
> - **Ethiopia** (Afar, Tigray, cultural centre) and its border with Sudan; the map will be drawn in the map class.
> - Care follows protection: awards to prominent diaspora, homeland songs at the airport — they bring money, and money brings development.

17.9 Welfare Steps: Scholarships for Diaspora Children

The second broad head is **welfare-related steps**, and the approach here has changed a little. The first welfare step is **education**.

> **GOVERNMENT & POLICY**
>
> **Scholarship programme for diaspora children.**
>
> - A **scholarship programme** for the **higher education of diaspora children**.
> - Eligible children are **NRIs**, **Persons of Indian Origin** or **OCI** card holders.
> - The amount is **4 lakh rupees per year**, for **undergraduate programmes** — basically **engineering** — in the countries where they are going to work.

- Some countries require **clearance for employment** — just know this.
- About **17-18 nations** are covered: **Bahrain** and other **Gulf nations**, **South East Asia** (**Thailand**, **Malaysia**, **Indonesia**) and **Afghanistan**.

QUICK REVISION

- The **first welfare step is education** — a scholarship programme for diaspora children.
- Eligibility: **NRI, PIO or OCI** children.
- Amount: **4 lakh rupees per year** for **undergraduate (engineering) programmes** in the countries where they will work.
- Some countries need **clearance for employment**.
- About **17-18 nations**, including **Bahrain and other Gulf nations, Thailand, Malaysia, Indonesia and Afghanistan**.

17.10 Afghanistan, Central Asia and Regional Presence

The scholarship list leads into the Afghan question, and from there to why India needs a regional presence.

- The **Taliban** are in Afghanistan; a statement was made that there is **no terrorist activity** in the country, while **a report says several terrorist factions are active** — every time a new statement is released, India faces a **diplomatic challenge**.
- The **Prime Minister** went to **Bishkek** and expressed the concern that the government in Afghanistan needs to be **inclusive**.
- To know what is happening in Afghanistan you need a **presence in regional organisations** — you have to talk to **Kazakhstan**, **Tajikistan** and **Kyrgyzstan**.
- Every Central Asian country **except Kazakhstan** has a border with Afghanistan [as recalled in the lecture].

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

The Aini airbase in Tajikistan.

- India had an airbase called **Aini** in **Tajikistan**, whose capital is **Dushanbe**.
- It was established for India when India was supporting the **Northern Alliance**, during **1996-2001**, when the Taliban was ruling.

- The Taliban are frustrated; Pakistan is like a fight between an **elephant and a cheetah** — Pakistan has **air defence** and **F-16s**, and the Taliban have nothing to match it.
- India is against **cross-border terrorism**; India has said that it detests **all forms of terrorism**, and 'all forms' includes cross-border terrorism.

EXAMPLE

The 1971-72 benchmark.

- The **Simla Pact** of **1971-72** was a major breakthrough: in those years India got everything it wanted — **R. N. Kao** as the head of **RAW** and **Indira Gandhi** as Prime Minister; India's historical leadership delivered.
- Those were two **golden years** when India's stature in the world was very high.

QUICK REVISION

- Afghanistan: the **Taliban** are in power; claims of no terrorist activity versus reports of several active factions — a diplomatic challenge.
- The **Prime Minister in Bishkek** said the Afghan government must be **inclusive**; India needs a presence in **regional organisations** (Kazakhstan, Tajikistan, Kyrgyzstan).
- All Central Asian countries except **Kazakhstan** border Afghanistan [as recalled].
- The **Aini airbase in Tajikistan** (Dushanbe) was set up for India during support to the **Northern Alliance**, **1996-2001**.
- Pakistan is like an elephant against a cheetah (air defence, F-16s); India is against **cross-border terrorism** and all forms of terrorism.
- The **Simla Pact (1971-72)** — R. N. Kao (RAW) and Indira Gandhi — marks two golden years of India's global stature.

17.11 Connecting the Diaspora to its Roots: Know India Programme

17.11.1 Know India Programme (KIP)

- When the diaspora leaves India and settles abroad, they have to be **connected to their roots** — connection cannot be left to chance, it has to be promoted.
- **KIP — the Know India Programme** — is a very good and important programme for connecting with the diaspora.

EXAMPLE

The Jewish/Israeli model of connection.

- The Jewish/Israeli model is hard and fast: if there is any Jew anywhere in the world, the feeling is deliberately created that **he is our brother**.
- There are different classifications of Jews — **Ashkenazi** and four or five other categories [as stated] — and the feeling is inculcated across them.
- The message given to the diaspora is: **wherever you are, we are with you**.

17.11.2 Why Roots Matter — The Cultural Argument

- India has many fairs, festivals and cultural congregations, and enormous diversity in rural India — there is much to be proud of.
- The logic: in **globalisation everything is assimilated**, so identities look the same; in the assertion of identity you also try to show what is different from you.
  - That is where you can tell the diaspora who you are — and **India plays this card**.
- The **Prime Minister spoke in Tianjin** about a **civilizational dialogue**.

17.11.3 Multi-Vectored Foreign Policy

- But in **connectivity**, **sovereignty is very important** — this is the frame within which connectivity and the diaspora have to be seen.

- Russia has said **China will be back**; the best example of **multi-vectored foreign policy** is diversification — they are diversifying, therefore **we have to diversify**.

17.11.4 The BRI Question — Connectivity and Sovereignty

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Question asked: implications of the BRI.

- **'Discuss the implications of the BRI on the security and regional stature of India.'** — a Civil Services Mains question (2026 mention).
- The first point to write is that **sovereignty gets violated**.
- Example: **CPEC** — a **60 billion dollar** corridor passing through **Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK)**.

17.11.5 Diaspora as a Bridge

- Selected participants come, see Indian culture, and the ties between India and the diaspora improve.
- When they go back they say they saw the **grand temple in Ayodhya** and the **beautiful Somnath temple** — so **tourism, culture and the economy** are promoted.
- The diaspora is a **bridge**: it helps not only the economy, investment and culture, but has a **ripple effect in building stronger people-to-people (P2P) relations**, which is the **plinth** of improving relations between two countries.

QUICK REVISION

- **KIP — the Know India Programme** — promotes connection to roots; connection cannot be left to chance.
- The **Jewish/Israeli model**: classifications of Jews (Ashkenazi and four or five categories), the feeling 'he is our brother', and the message 'wherever you are, we are with you'.
- Globalisation assimilates identities; the assertion of difference is where India plays its cultural card; **civilizational dialogue** was spoken of in **Tianjin**.
- **Multi-vectored foreign policy**: they are diversifying, so we must diversify; in connectivity, **sovereignty is very important**.
- **BRI question**: implications for security and regional stature — **CPEC, 60 billion dollars, through PoK**.
- **Diaspora as a bridge**: tourism, culture and economy, and a ripple effect on **P2P relations**, the plinth of bilateral relations.

17.12 Pravasi Teerth Darshan Yojana and the Girmitiya Diaspora

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Pravasi Teerth Darshan Yojana.

- A scheme for the **old girmitiya diaspora** — those whose ancestors left **Bihar**, **Odisha** and

Uttar Pradesh and left their own country behind; their emotional connection with India is not that strong, yet their **roots persist** and they want to come to India for **teerth** (pilgrimage).

- The scheme enables **economically weaker PIOs aged 45 to 65** from **girmitiya nations** to undertake a **pilgrimage tour**.

- It is a very good and beautiful scheme — there is no comparison to it.
- **IRCTC** also runs a scheme: if grandparents or parents want to engage in pilgrimage, IRCTC takes the bookings — for **Pashupatinath** and other temples.
  - Under the scheme, travel by **rail and buses** is arranged; it is a very good circuit; it can be done for one's parents or for oneself.
- The IRCTC initiative has been running for **10-12 years** and is very popular; there is something like a **Hindu circuit** as well [as stated].
- **Culture and religion is a very interesting chord** — it helps improve the **bilateral relationship** and the relationship with the diaspora; this is diaspora diplomacy.

QUICK REVISION

- **Pravasi Teerth Darshan Yojana** serves the **girmitiya** diaspora from **Bihar, Odisha and Uttar Pradesh** whose roots persist and who want to come for **teerth**.
- It enables **economically weaker PIOs aged 45 to 65** from girmitiya nations to go on pilgrimage.
- **IRCTC** arranges pilgrimage travel (Pashupatinath and other temples; rail and buses) — running 10-12 years, very popular; something like a **Hindu circuit** [as stated].
- **Culture and religion** is a chord that improves bilateral relations — diaspora diplomacy.

17.13 Pravasi Bharatiya Divas and Pravasi Bharatiya Samman

- **Pravasi Bharatiya Divas** was started by **Atal Bihari Vajpayee** — a classic and very popular example, known to everyone.
- The **Pravasi Bharatiya Samman** awards are also given.
- One edition was held in **Bhubaneswar** and was a grand event; the next is to be held in **January**, though the location was not known at the time of the lecture.

DATA & FACTS

Why 9 January.

- The first **Pravasi Bharatiya Divas** was held in **2003**, on **9 January**.
- 9 January is the day **Gandhiji returned to India from South Africa**, in **1915**.
- **Gokhale** had advised Gandhiji to travel across India for a year; this is a very popular fact and has been asked in tests.

QUICK REVISION

- **Pravasi Bharatiya Divas** was started by **Atal Bihari Vajpayee**; the **Pravasi Bharatiya Samman** is also given.
- One edition was held in **Bhubaneswar**; the next is due in **January**.
- First PBD was in **2003**, held on **9 January** — the day **Gandhiji returned from South Africa (1915)**.
- **Gokhale** advised Gandhiji to tour India for a year — a popular test fact.
- Awards go to prominent members of the diaspora, including big CEOs.

17.14 Overseas Mobility (Facilitation and Welfare) Bill, 2025

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Overseas Mobility (Facilitation and Welfare) Bill, 2025.

- A **bill** introduced to **replace the Immigration Act, 1983**.
- It is a **modern framework** for: (1) **safe and orderly migration**; (2) **vulnerable worker protection**; (3) **migration agreements**; (4) **data-driven policy**; (5) an **Overseas Mobility and Welfare Council**.

- For any person going out of India, the bill simplifies **welfare, migration and the legal architecture** — a strong step.
- The proposed **Overseas Mobility and Welfare Council** is the institutional deliverable, created for the welfare of this diaspora.
- But as of today it is still **a bill** — it is a **step in the right direction**.

QUICK REVISION

- **Overseas Mobility (Facilitation and Welfare) Bill, 2025** replaces the **Immigration Act, 1983**.
- It is a modern framework for **safe and orderly migration, vulnerable worker protection, migration agreements, data-driven policy and the Overseas Mobility and Welfare Council**.
- It simplifies welfare, migration and the legal architecture for anyone going out of India.
- As of today it is **still a bill**, but a step in the right direction.

17.15 Other Steps: Bharat Ko Janiye Quiz and the OCI Framework

- Other steps include the **Bharat Ko Janiye** online quiz.
- And the **OCI framework** — the **Overseas Citizens of India** framework.

KEY CONCEPT

OCI is a misnomer.

- If you are a citizen of a foreign country you are **not a citizen of India** — you **cannot hold**

dual citizenship.

- So what does an OCI card imply? If you leave India you are a **foreigner**; and like any foreigner entering another country you are asked where you are going and how long you are staying — a US visa holder can stay six months in the same way.

- The origin: in **2003** [as recalled] **Mr. Vajpayee** said — come to India, we will not have those hassles for you.
- Some restrictions remain, for example an OCI holder **cannot buy agricultural land**.
- But many things that Indians normally do were made easier for OCI holders.
- So the meaning of the OCI card is: **even if you leave Indian citizenship, you will not face the same hassles as a foreigner faces in the country**.

CRITICAL POINT

How to read this for the exam.

- Go back to the **citizenship chapter** of **Laxmikanth** — or of any book you are reading — and see what is there in the OCI card; the details are easily available.
- It is an easy framework: usually no Prelims question comes from it, so read the chapter **lightly** — not in a heavy manner.

QUICK REVISION

- Other steps: the **Bharat Ko Janiye** online quiz and the **OCI framework**.
- **OCI is a misnomer** — a foreign citizen is not an Indian citizen, and dual citizenship cannot be held.
- An OCI holder is a foreigner on leaving India (six-month stay, questions at the border) but avoids the hassles a foreigner faces.
- Origin: **2003** [as recalled], **Mr. Vajpayee** — 'come to India, we will not have those hassles'. Restriction example: **no purchase of agricultural land**.
- In the exam, read the **citizenship chapter (Laxmikanth)** lightly.

17.16 Expanding India's Diplomatic Footprint: Embassies and Consulates

- Several **new embassies and consulates** have been opened **in more than 14** places in the **last two years**.
- Latest figure to note: **22 new diplomatic missions** globally **since 2014**; therefore India has **200 operational missions**.

DATA & FACTS

India's missions in numbers.

- New embassies and consulates in the last two years — **more than 14**.
- New diplomatic missions since **2014** — **22**, globally.

- Total **operational missions — 200**.

- **Why consulates matter**: visa applications are very large, so consulates are opened in addition to embassies — **Kolkata**, **Hyderabad** and **Bengaluru** came up in the discussion [as recalled].
- The structure: India has an **embassy** in a capital — for example in **Moscow** — with an **ambassador** and staff, and **consulates** in other cities, where Indians have access to Indian officials.
- A consulate was **inaugurated in 2015** in Russia.
- The consulate was opened in **Yekaterinburg** — remembered because the **first BRICS summit of 2009** was held there; Yekaterinburg also has a famous football team.
- Other Russian cities that came up with the map: **St Petersburg**, **Vladivostok**, **Kaliningrad**, **Volgograd**, **Nizhny Novgorod** and **Anadyr**.

CRITICAL POINT

Correction to a news error.

- A recent editorial on the SCO wrongly said the **2024 SCO summit** was held in **Kazan** — that was wrong.
- The **2024 SCO summit was held in Astana**, in **Kazakhstan**.
- The **2024 BRICS summit was held in Kazan** — where the ice was broken and the **disengagement agreement between Xi Jinping and our Prime Minister** was agreed.

QUICK REVISION

- **More than 14** new embassies and consulates in the last two years.
- **22 new diplomatic missions globally since 2014**; India now has **200 operational missions**.
- Consulates answer large visa demand — **Kolkata, Hyderabad, Bengaluru** [as recalled]; the Moscow embassy has an ambassador and staff, and a consulate was inaugurated in **2015**.
- The consulate in **Yekaterinburg** — remembered by the **first BRICS summit (2009)** held there.
- Correction: **2024 SCO summit = Astana**; **2024 BRICS summit = Kazan** (the Xi-Modi disengagement agreement).

17.17 Return to the SCO: Institutions and India's Engagement

These multilateral bodies are very important — and after the war, the relevance of the SCO has increased.

- Analogy for how war changes a multilateral: if you are at war with someone you cannot meet them alone — you want to meet everyone, and so you either humiliate them or engage with them.
  - That is the position now: India can engage with **Pakistan** and with **China**.
- The **iconic Putin-Modi photo of last year**: it was suggested that this was an intelligence failure on our part and that there was some threat, but a close contact who travels to **Tashkent**,

Dushanbe and **Beijing** for Russian translation work says that was not the concern.

- One irritant he mentioned two to three years back: the languages of the SCO are **Russian and Mandarin**, while **India pushed for English**.
- Ever since **India and Pakistan became members in 2017**, the SCO has become very interesting — because the **Central Asian nations have high regard for Mr. Doval**, and whatever stance he puts is like the **Lakir** (the line) that none of them will disobey.
- But after **Pakistan** became a member, **Pakistan-China collaboration** has really improved; this has added fervour and flavour to the SCO, and has added a lot of work for **Indian diplomats**.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

SCO institutions and the diplomatic workload.

- The SCO has a **Secretariat** and the **RATS** — the **Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure** — as its **second main body**; **Tashkent** and **Beijing** were the cities mentioned [as stated].
- The **NSCS (National Security Council Secretariat)**, the **NSA** and the **Deputy NSA** travel frequently, engage in meetings, exchange files and do file noting — it is tough work.

QUICK REVISION

- After the war the **relevance of the SCO has increased**; at war you cannot meet alone, so you engage with everyone — including **Pakistan and China**.
- The **Putin-Modi photo** episode and the claim of an intelligence failure (denied by the translation-work contact who travels to Tashkent, Dushanbe and Beijing).
- SCO languages are **Russian and Mandarin**, while **India pushed for English**.
- Since **2017** (India and Pakistan joining) the SCO is interesting; the **Central Asian regard for Mr. Doval** is like the **Lakir**; **Pakistan-China collaboration** has improved and added work for Indian diplomats.
- Institutions: the **Secretariat**, and **RATS — Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure** as the second main body (Tashkent and Beijing mentioned [as stated]); **NSCS/NSA** travel and file work is tough.

17.18 Way Forward: 4C Approach, Consular Access and Digitisation

KEY CONCEPT

Template — the 4C approach.

- The way forward is written as the **4C approach** — and **templates are very important for the examination**.
- At some point you have to stop absorbing content and find confidence in your preparation; that confidence comes through hard work.

- **Opening new embassies and consulates** — write the step **already taken** in this regard, and then the step that still has to be taken.
- The **steps already taken by the Government of India can be expanded**, and that expansion

is what is written in the way forward.

- In the exam you can tell the examiner the steps the government has taken, and also tell the government the steps it must still take.
- **Improve people-to-people access**.
- **Simplification of consular access** for **NRIs** and **PIOs**.
- **Digitisation of the processes** — if credentials are clear and the record is established, the need for repeated verification falls away and **self-certification** can be used.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **Student doubt — should there be an embassy in every country?.**
>
> - Ideally, yes — there should be an embassy in every country.
> - But sometimes there are **logistics**; sometimes there are **infrastructural concerns**; sometimes the **homework** has to be done first; and sometimes the government is **not allotted space**.
> - The exact position on an embassy in every country could not be settled in class — it depends on the facts of each case.

- Where are the embassies of important countries located? The discussion went to Delhi's diplomatic properties — designs attributed to **Herbert Baker**, properties linked to **princely states**, and a house on **Ashok Road** said to be the most plush.
- Historical colour [as stated]: when the capital shifted in **1911**, **Connaught Place** was the **Central Business District**, where English companies and their wives partied and Indians were not allowed entry — with proper ballrooms, seven-course food and restaurants such as the **Imperial** and **Wenger's**.
- **Proactive engagement by the consulates** in reaching out to **Indian students**.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Way forward template: the **4C approach**; templates are very important for the examination.
> - Write the step **already taken** (new embassies and consulates) and then the step still to be taken; the steps taken can be expanded.
> - **People-to-people access**, **simplification of consular access for NRIs and PIOs**, and **digitisation** with **self-certification**.
> - Embassy in every country: ideally yes, but logistics, infrastructure, homework and space allocation intervene.
> - **Proactive engagement by consulates** in reaching out to Indian students.

17.19 Parliamentary Committee Recommendations and Additional Measures

A parliamentary committee (standing committee) has made recommendations on the diaspora; two or three of them overlap with the steps already listed, and the rest are set out here.

1. Indian missions should make the students feel **a home away from home**.

2. A **separate policy** should be framed to harness the role of the diaspora as an **effective tool** to further India's interests and influence **globally**.
3. A **rehabilitation scheme** should be initiated to ensure **livelihood security** for the migrants facing **job losses in the Gulf region**, with a **separate policy for re-integration** of such migrants.
4. Build a **comprehensive country-wise and occupation-wise data of the diaspora** and **integrate it with e-Migrate**.
5. Ensure the **safety of Indian women migrants and students** by creating a **safety net** involving **university liaison cells**, **mental health support** and the **welfare of female domestic workers**.
6. Ensure **skills and qualification portability** by ensuring **proper training, proper socialising and proper certification**, thereby **aligning Indian skill certification with destination-country standards** and ensuring **mutual recognition**.
7. Prevent **illegal immigration** and **fraudulent recruitment** by **compulsory registration and auditing of recruitment agents**, and **digital verification of foreign employers and contracts**.

17.19.1 *Why the Anti-Fraud Recommendation Matters*

- It is very common: someone promises to get you abroad for **20-25 lakh rupees** and does get you there — but in a way that you can **never come back**; the **dunki route** and other such routes are run by **touts and thieves**.
- The victim is usually the person without privilege — someone who could not get a government job, from a background without information or networks.
  - For him 20-25 lakh rupees and a wrong choice is an enormous informational disorder: he does not know immigration or visa rules and is given **fake papers**.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **The golden visa route.**
>
> - In these countries events are held in **five-star hotels** where people are told to spend **1-2 million dollars** and they will be given citizenship.
> - The example is the **US EB-5**: you invest the amount and must generate a certain number of jobs; the amount was **doubled in the Trump era** — earlier **1 million dollars**, now **2 to 5 million dollars**, which is almost **20-30 crore rupees** invested in the US.
> - Every country calls it a **golden visa**; a big chunk of Indians have businesses in European nations and are citizens there by this route, and they frequently come to India.

- **Modernise immigration law** — a law has to be given.
- **Expand social security agreements** and ensure **prevention of double contribution** of social security.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **The shift to write in the answer — from welfare to empowerment.**
>
> - **Move from diaspora welfare to diaspora empowerment**: first **protect** them, then **care** for them, and finally **empower** them.

- Empowerment means the diaspora is **not only a beneficiary** — it is a **partner** and an **asset** in India's journey to becoming a developed nation (**Viksit Bharat**).
- **Viksit Bharat will not happen until we make the diaspora our partner.**

- If nothing else is clear, write this too: the **further strengthening of existing schemes** discussed under the steps.
- **Engage diaspora organisations** — every student has a platform: Odisha students' organisations, Bihar, Punjab and Haryana students' associations; they meet and celebrate festivals together.
  - There are **40-50 thousand** Indians in **Portugal**; engage with these organisations frequently, think about their welfare, improve engagement, organise festivals, tell them about the **Prime Minister's dream**, show movies, and ask them to bring their friends along.
- The **Tourism Ministry can work with the MEA** on this.
- At the end of the day, follow the **whole-of-government and whole-of-society approach**.
- The diaspora is **not a headache**, and the diaspora does not need your help — **you are helping the diaspora**, and the diaspora has to be made a **partner**.

EXAMPLE

The analogy for partnership.

- **Women do not need welfare; women want to be seen as partners.**
- Do not have mercy on a disabled individual — see him as a **partner** and give him **affirmative action**; **empower, do not pity**.
- The same applies to the diaspora in the journey of India becoming a developed nation.

QUICK REVISION

- Committee recommendations: **home away from home** for students; a **separate policy** to harness the diaspora; a **rehabilitation scheme** with re-integration for Gulf job losses; **country-wise and occupation-wise data integrated with e-Migrate**.
- More recommendations: a **safety net** (university liaison cells, mental health support, welfare of female domestic workers); **skills and qualification portability** with **mutual recognition**; **compulsory registration and auditing of recruitment agents** with **digital verification of foreign employers and contracts**.
- Why anti-fraud matters: the **20-25 lakh** tout culture, the **dunki route**, the victim's informational disorder; **golden visa/EB-5** at 1-2 million dollars (now 2-5 million after the Trump era) — about **20-30 crore rupees**.
- Additional measures: **modernise immigration law**; **expand SSAs** with **double-contribution avoidance** (India-UK FTA clause).
- The shift: from **welfare to empowerment** — protect, care, empower; the diaspora is a **partner and asset**, and **Viksit Bharat needs the diaspora as a partner**.
- **Engage diaspora organisations**, strengthen existing schemes, use the **whole-of-government**

> **and whole-of-society approach**; the analogy: women and the disabled want to be **partners**, not objects of pity.

17.20 Contribution of the Diaspora in Southeast Asia

The contribution of the diaspora is written under **three heads** — **economy**, **society** and **politics** — and the same structure repeats for every region.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Nature of the Southeast Asian diaspora.**
>
> - It is basically the **old settled diaspora**.
> - It has **expanded from labour to a multi-dimensional role** — in **politics**, **business**, **administration** and **culture**.
> - Therefore there is also a role in **nation-building** — show this as a **diagram**.

17.20.1 Contribution in the Economy

- **Promoted historical development in plantation economies** — example: the emergence of **rubber plantations in Malaysia**, which became the foundation for **exports and economic development**.
- **Infrastructure development** — example: the **bridge over the River Kwai**, where the Japanese hired local people to build the bridge over the river (Thailand/Myanmar).
- **Entrepreneurship, banking, finance and business** — the East Asian economies cannot forget the contributions India has made.
  - A section of merchants from **Tamil Nadu** (the **Chettiars**) acted as **financiers and money-lenders**, like the **Mahajans** in India; money came from India.
- **Modern business** — Indian business communities entered **retail, restaurants, manufacturing, real estate, transport and tax-saving structures**, and obviously **professional services** such as doctors and engineers.
- **Institutions — IIT Abu Dhabi** and the **BITS campus in Dubai** are part of this business and institutional presence.

17.20.2 Case Study: Singapore

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Singapore — the Indian contribution.**
>
> - Singapore has the **highest concentration of IIT and IIM alumni outside India**.
> - Sectors where Indians drive the economy: **finance**, **fintech**, **big banks**, **start-ups**, **IT companies**, **marine industries** and **construction**.
> - Singapore is a **transshipment hub** like **Colombo**; India wants to build **Vizhinjam** port to break that reputation.
> - Car ownership is discouraged — hefty parking and ownership costs — so the city is connected

> by **parks** and has very strong **public transport** with **last-mile connectivity**.

- Proximity matters: a **3.5-hour flight** from Singapore to Delhi, about **3 hours** to Thiruvananthapuram, and **40** to Chennai — so it is easier to go from Chennai to Singapore than to work in Delhi and face the **high AQI and pollution**.
- **Tamil is an official language** of Singapore — you can speak Tamil there.
- **Brain drain becomes brain circulation**: if Singapore is a financial centre, India's brain drain — call it **brain circulation** — has played a role.
- The Telugu and Tamil communities in Singapore are large, and the **southern Chief Ministers have been going to Singapore and the US for 25-30 years — competitive federalism**.
  - None of the major investments have taken place in **Gurugram** or the North Indian centres, because the **business environment** there is clear and the **regulatory norms** are totally different — a businessman does not want any headache: 'take 100 or 300 from me, but do not create any disturbance'.
- **Innovation and high-tech cooperation** — with **Singapore** and **Malaysia**, India is cooperating in **semiconductors**.
- Indians are about **20-25%** of the world's **semiconductor chip-design** workforce [as stated in lecture]; they **design** and do not manufacture, and they work for **foreign companies**, so the hard work and the **patenting** go to those companies.
- **AI** and **fintech** are the other areas of this cooperation.
- **Myanmar — 1.5 to 2 million** people of Indian origin, doing agriculture in **Bago State** and **Mon State** (the Myanmar map will be shown in the map class); **coffee** is also popular there.
- **Services sector** — doctors, engineers, lawyers and accountants everywhere.
- The shift: earlier Indians went abroad to do **labour**; now **others do the labour** while India earns in **high-tech sectors**.

17.20.3 Contribution in Society

- **Education** — schools and universities were created, along with **Tamil language education and cultural institutions**; Tamil is taught to people there.
- Wherever Indians go, they contribute to **linguistic and cultural diversity**; in **Singapore, Tamil is one of the four official languages**.
- Languages taught in Singapore: **Hindi**, **Sanskrit** (if I am not wrong), **Bengali**, **Gujarati** (even in Gujarati medium), **Urdu** and **Punjabi**.
- The effort is to **promote multiculturalism**; Singapore is a truly multicultural society, and **Diwali** comes first among the festivals celebrated.
- **Tamil literature and music** — Tamil music is very soothing, **100 times more soothing than what we see in Bollywood**; it retains that sense of emotion, and **Tamil cinema** is very innovative, playing all kinds of global music.
- **Religious and cultural organisations** — in **Cambodia** there is the **Preah Vihear temple complex**, a disputed region between **Thailand and Cambodia**, in the Thai states around **Buriram**; there have been mass killings from both sides there (to be discussed with the IR

map).

- **Social reform and civil society** — the **anti-caste movement**, the **labour movement**, **education** and **community welfare**.
- Note: **Sri Lanka is not counted in Southeast Asia** — it is part of the Indian subcontinent/South Asia, and will be taken with the India-Sri Lanka bilaterals, with **Anura Dissanayake** as the President.

17.20.4 Contribution in Politics

- **Participation** — in **elections**, in **political parties**, and a place in **parliaments and legislatures**; the diaspora has also contributed in **diplomacy**, **administration** and the **judiciary**.
- **Malaysia — Saraswati Kandaswamy**: a politician and **senator** who practises law; she was in a **TikTok controversy**.
- **Malaysia — M. Kulasegaran**: a politician.
- The biggest example is the **highest post**: the **President of Singapore**, **Tharman Shanmugaratnam** — earlier **Deputy Prime Minister**, **Finance Minister** and **Education Minister**.
  - He came to India last year for something related to **semiconductors**.

EXAMPLE

Tharman Shanmugaratnam — the details to remember.

- About **70 years old**; a **Singaporean politician** of the **People's Action Party**; born in Singapore in **1957** during **British colonial rule**.
- Education: **LSE** for a bachelor's, **Cambridge** (master's in economics; M.Phil) and the **Harvard Kennedy School** — where our own officers are also sent at government expense after joining service [as stated].
- **Mnemonic**: '**Shan**' — **Shan State** in Myanmar (with Sagaing, Chin and Bago); '**Muga**' — **Muga (golden) silk** of **Assam**; and **Mani Ratnam** — remembered together to retain the name Shanmugaratnam.

QUICK REVISION

- Structure: **economy, society and politics**; nature — the **old settled diaspora** that expanded from labour to a multi-dimensional role, hence **nation-building** (show a diagram).
- Economy: **rubber plantations in Malaysia**, the **bridge over the River Kwai**, **Chettiar** financiers and money-lenders, modern business and professional services, IIT Abu Dhabi and BITS Dubai.
- **Singapore case study**: highest IIT/IIM concentration outside India; finance, fintech, banks, start-ups, IT, marine, construction; transshipment hub; **Vizhinjam**; 3.5-hour flight; **Tamil an official language**; **brain circulation**; competitive federalism.
- High-tech: **semiconductors** with Singapore and Malaysia; Indians about **20-25%** of the world's chip-design workforce [as stated]; AI and fintech; **Myanmar** 1.5-2 million PIOs in **Bago and Mon** states.
- Society: schools and universities, **Tamil language education**, linguistic and cultural diversity,

multiculturalism, Tamil literature and music, **Preah Vihear** (Thailand-Cambodia), anti-caste and labour movements; Sri Lanka is not part of Southeast Asia.

- Politics: elections, parties and legislatures, plus diplomacy, administration and the judiciary; **Saraswati Kandaswamy** and **M. Kulasegaran** (Malaysia); **President Tharman Shanmugaratnam** of Singapore — the highest post.

17.21 Contribution of the Diaspora in West Asia

West Asia is the same as Southeast Asia — in brackets, **the diplomatic role of the diaspora is the same as discussed before**; and Singapore has a **Little India**.

COMPARISON

Southeast Asia vs West Asia — the diaspora's standing.

- **Southeast Asia**: the old settled diaspora has real **political capital** — the President of Singapore, Malaysian senators and MPs, participation in elections.
- **West Asia**: **citizenship is not given**, so **political capital is zero** and the contribution in local politics is limited.

- **Retail and trade**: Indians have contributed in **Thailand** — they did business, opened shacks and opened hotels; retail and trade is easy work to enter.
- **9 million** Indians live in the Gulf/West Asia, and the **concentration is in the GCC (Gulf Cooperation Council)** nations.

17.21.1 Contribution in the Economy

- **Labour force backbone** — Indians form the **largest expatriate community in almost all the Gulf nations** and are involved in **construction and infrastructure**, that is **blue-collar jobs**, along with **hospitality, retail, oil and gas**, etc.
- In the **UAE, Indians constitute 35% of the total population** — a phenomenal number.
- **Skilled and professional manpower** — there is a **shift from blue collar to a diversified workforce**, serving as **professionals**.
  - Professions involved: **doctors, engineers, nurses, architects, CAs, bankers, scientists, teachers and consultants**.
- The shift in numbers: in the **1970s-80s about 85-90%** of Indians in the Gulf were **blue collar**; now **almost 35%** are **professionally qualified**, that is **white collar**.
- **Promoting entrepreneurship plus trade** — Indians have built businesses in **retail**, **healthcare**, **construction**, **logistics** and **schools** too.

EXAMPLE

The 'real estate Mughal' of Dubai.

- A big Indian businessman in **construction and real estate** in Dubai — **Satish Sanpal** (S-A-N-P-L) — a **class 8 dropout from Jabalpur**, Madhya Pradesh, now living among the **world's tallest buildings**.

> - He is 'what **K. P. Singh** is to **Gurugram**, and what the **Lodhas** are to **Bombay**'.

- **Lulu** stores — the departmental store that is the **7-Eleven/Walmart of the UAE** — belong to the **Lulu Group**, whose chairman is **Yusuf Ali**; the **Lulu Mall in Lucknow** (on **Shaheed Path**) belongs to the same group.
- The point: India is **not only working there**, it is also **doing business there** and breaking the nexus of the local players.
- **Innovation and knowledge economy** — contributions to **software, fintech, AI, digital payments, telecommunication and engineering**, and, most important, the **energy transition — battery storage, solar and wind power**.

17.21.2 Contribution in Education and Society

- **Indian curriculum schools**, established by Indian businessmen — first they enter the economy, then they establish schools.
- In **Kuwait** there are **26 CBSE schools** and about **60,000 students** studying in them.
  - The students are very talented all-rounders; they also appear for **IIT** and Indian examinations, and may appear for the **civil services**.
- Their parents are **not citizens** but Indians hired by the big **oil companies**; they earn a lot and have a comfortable life — the **work environment in Kuwait is very good**.
- Mark of respect: in Kuwait the word '**bu**' is added before a name — '**bu Anand**' — like 'sir Anand' or 'Mr. Anand'.
- **Institutions**: **IIT Abu Dhabi** and the **BITS campus in Dubai**.
- Because salaries are good, Indians **spend freely** abroad — so **demand and consumption are being promoted**.
- **Multiculturalism** has been promoted in societies that were **historically Arab-led** — through **Indian cuisine**, **cinema** (**Bollywood**; the Khans have big fans — **Shah Rukh Khan**, **Salman Khan**), **yoga** and **festivals**.
- Festivals discussed: **Diwali** (the number one global festival), **Onam** (Kerala's historical migration to the Gulf), **Holi** (which went there long ago), **Raksha Bandhan** and **Janmashtami**.
- **Kerala's involvement**: the **telecom industry**, **local industry**, **phone stores** and **gold shops**; there are **Hindus and Sikhs**, and also **Christian religious institutions**.
- **Namaste Kuwait** — a radio show started in **Hindi**.
- The **BAPS Hindu Mandir** was inaugurated in **Abu Dhabi**, and **Ganga aarti** is held there on weekdays.
- **Social welfare and community institutions** — Indians organise **medical camps**, **blood donation**, **welfare assistance**, **education support** and **disaster relief**; therefore the diaspora **supplements state welfare**.

17.21.3 Politics in West Asia — Why the Political Capital is Zero

- Politics there is meant for the **kingdom**: all the posts and the **sheikhs** belong to **historical families who control the place**, so the diaspora has very little stake.

- Local action is controlled by their own organisation; the exact mechanism is not known — it is not like the **two-tier or three-tier** system in India, but some mechanism must exist.
  - There are criteria of being an **Arab** in the bureaucracy, and **no foreigner is given stakes or power**.
- Foreigners do **taxpayer welfare** but have **no stakes in administration**; in politics and diplomacy there are **no voting rights**.
- Therefore the diaspora's political contribution is that it **contributes to bilateral stability** by promoting **people-to-people relations**, which **creates the foundation of strong diplomatic ties**.

17.21.4 *The Bigger Player: Saudi Arabia and India's Hard-Power Gap*

- The main player in the region is **Saudi Arabia**: it upholds **100% Islamic values** and at the same time wants to **modernise** — that is its dilemma.
- Saudi Arabia is **100% dependent on the US**, and after the recent war it is looking for **stable partners**; it has a **plethora of money** and wants a **security partnership**.
- The essential **structural problem**: **India cannot provide a security partnership to Saudi Arabia right now** — they believe in **hard power**, they have to fight wars and want stable support, so they want partnership with **Turkey** and with **Pakistan**, the **only nuclear Islamic country**; that is why these three signed the **Mecca Pact**.
- But remember: India's hard power does not have to be nuclear weapons — hard power is also **maritime security**, **MDA (maritime domain awareness)**, the phenomenal reach of the **Indian Navy as a blue-water navy**, and India's role in the **IOR (Indian Ocean Region)** in the light of **piracy prevention** and several events avoided because of the maritime security offered by the Government of India.
- India is the **first responder** in a disaster and the **net security provider** of the region — so hard power does not always mean **boots on the ground in Saudi Arabia**; it works through different metrics and parallel arrangements.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **The mentorship analogy.**
>
> - Students want mentors, but one person cannot mentor everybody — ways have to be found to fulfil that need without becoming the mentor.
> - In the same way, **Pakistan is the mentor of mentors for Saudi Arabia**; India must think and innovate on how to engage and still fulfil its strategic interests professionally.

- **UAE is a stable partner** for India, and the Islamic factor is not as strong there.
- **Kuwait, Qatar, Bahrain and Oman** have no real stakes for us in diplomacy — they are dependent on the US.
- **UAE has taken a back foot in Yemen**: it supported the **Southern Transitional Council** while also supporting the traditional government that Saudi Arabia backed [as stated].
- The **Muslim population and the Sunni Muslim card** have to be handled — their act has to be got together, and it is very difficult.

- India and Saudi Arabia are **very clear in their deliverables** and it is a wonderful relationship; under the present government there have been **several high-level meetings — at least seven or eight** — between the **King** and our **Prime Minister** [as stated].
- India is willing to engage with that country, but the challenge is that **India has to give them security** — without security they will not have stakes.
  - India's own stake is the **9 million** diaspora: if they leave, **who will work? Pakistan cannot substitute.**
- On the Iran dimension: assurances and collaborations are only to show strength; **Saudi Arabia has not been attacked in the past three or four days** [as stated].

Labour and infrastructure	The largest expatriate community in almost all Gulf nations; construction, infrastructure, hospitality, retail, oil and gas	Indians are 35% of the UAE population
Professionals	A diversified white-collar workforce — the shift from blue collar to professional	85-90% blue collar in the 1970s-80s; now about 35% professionally qualified
Business and trade	Businesses in retail, healthcare, construction, logistics and schools	Satish Sanpal (Dubai real estate); Lulu Group (Yusuf Ali)
Education	Indian curriculum schools set up by Indian businessmen	Kuwait: 26 CBSE schools, about 60,000 students
Society and welfare	Multiculturalism, festivals, cuisine, cinema; medical camps, blood donation, disaster relief	BAPS Hindu Mandir, Abu Dhabi; Namaste Kuwait radio show
Politics	Minimal — citizenship is not given, so political capital is zero	No voting rights; taxpayer welfare only

QUICK REVISION

- West Asia: the diplomatic role is the same as before; **9 million** diaspora, concentrated in the **GCC** nations; politically the contribution is **limited** because citizenship is not given.
- Economy: **labour force backbone** (largest expatriate community, blue collar, **35% of the UAE population**), **professionals** (the shift from **85-90% blue collar** in the 1970s-80s to almost **35% professionally qualified**), **entrepreneurship and trade**.
- Examples: **Satish Sanpal** (the real estate Mughal, a class 8 dropout from Jabalpur) and **Lulu**

(Yusuf Ali); innovation in software, fintech, AI, digital payments and, most important, the **energy transition**.

- Education and society: Indian curriculum schools, **Kuwait's 26 CBSE schools with about 60,000 students**, 'bu' as a mark of respect, **IIT Abu Dhabi and BITS Dubai**, multiculturalism, **Namaste Kuwait**, **BAPS Hindu Mandir** and welfare work that supplements state welfare.
- Politics: the **kingdom** and historical families, no stakes in administration, **no voting rights** — hence the contribution is to **bilateral stability through P2P relations**.
- Saudi Arabia: **Islamic values vs modernisation**, 100% dependence on the US, the need for a **security partnership** India cannot yet provide (Turkey, Pakistan, the **Mecca Pact**), while India's hard power is **maritime security, MDA, a blue-water navy and the IOR**; India's stake is the **9 million** diaspora.

CHAPTER 18

The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO)

18.1 SCO in the Examination: Placement and the Perspective to Build

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Where SCO lies in the examination.**
>
> - SCO lies in **GS Paper 2**; within GS2 it lies in **International Relations (IR)**; and within IR it lies in **regional organisations**.
> - The basic facts have to be on your tips — for example, **India became a member in 2017**.

Before starting with this particular body, build a perspective. Whenever any topic or theme in IR is discussed, the broad underpinnings must be understood first — the broad developments in the globe — because those developments give the lens with which to understand that particular topic.

- **Increase in global uncertainty** — because of US policies.
- **Decline in trans-Atlantic and trans-Pacific cooperation** — this was also the subject matter of a question that came in General Studies Paper 1.
- **War in West Asia**, and the war that is going on with respect to Russia and Ukraine.
  - This war has exposed **supply chain vulnerabilities** — for food, for fuel, for fertilizer and for access to critical minerals.
- **Rise of China**, which is not so peaceful.
- **Increase in the role of Pakistan as a mediator**.
- **Increase in Russia-China cooperation**.
- **Decline in multilateralism**.
- **Emergence of a new world order**.
- Nations of the world are engaging in **diversification** — they are trying to look for new partners.
  - Central Asia, Europe, Bangladesh and many other countries are diversifying.
  - India wants new partners; Saudi Arabia wants new partners; Uzbekistan wants new partners; Central Asia wants new partners.
  - Japan is trying to forge new partnerships because of these developments.

Only against this background can the role of SCO be evaluated and analysed. Whenever a country or a regional organisation is studied, it has to be analysed from that perspective — and SCO, being a regional organisation, has **10 members**.

QUICK REVISION

- SCO is examined in GS Paper 2, within IR, under regional organisations.
- Developments that form the present context: global uncertainty from US policies, decline of trans-Atlantic and trans-Pacific cooperation, wars in West Asia and Russia-Ukraine, supply chain vulnerabilities, a not-so-peaceful rise of China, Pakistan's role as mediator, rising Russia-China cooperation, decline of multilateralism and the emergence of a new world order.
- **Diversification** is the key trend — India, Saudi Arabia, Uzbekistan, Central Asia, Europe, Bangladesh and Japan are all seeking new partners.
- This global context is the lens for analysing SCO; SCO today has 10 members.

18.2 Previous Year Questions and the Structure of the Topic

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

PYQs on SCO.

- Critical examination of the aims and objectives of SCO and its implications for India — **2021**.
- The question that says there is a **virus of conflict** affecting SCO — the functioning of the organisation is affected because there is a lot of conflict: international conflicts and inter-SCO member conflicts.

The reasoning behind the second question is straightforward: if the countries within any regional organisation themselves have conflicts, the role of that organisation will get affected. Broadly, the lens here is to understand the analysis of SCO.

- **Introduction of SCO** — when was SCO formed, what was the backdrop, why was it formed, what are the objectives, how the members got added, how many members there are.
- **Importance** — India became a member in 2017; UPSC can ask 'Discuss the reasons why India became a member of SCO'. Those reasons are nothing but the importance of SCO — both the importance of SCO for India and the importance of India for SCO.
  - In IR, importance is always **geopolitical, geoeconomic, geocultural and geostrategic** — there are no ifs and buts here.
- **Issues** — the various issues.
- **Strengths**.
- **Weaknesses**.
- **What steps India needs to take**.

QUICK REVISION

- PYQ 2021: critical examination of the aims and objectives of SCO and its implications for India.
- PYQ: the **virus of conflict** — international and inter-member conflicts that affect SCO's functioning.

- India joined in 2017; the reason for joining is the importance of SCO.
- Topic roadmap: introduction, importance, issues, strengths, weaknesses, and the steps India needs to take.

18.3 SCO for India: The S-C-O Framework

Every organisation has some relevance for India. SCO for India is best captured through the framework **S-C-O**.

- **S — Security**: for India's own security, SCO membership is very much important.
  - The security dimension has three parts: **terrorism, extremist ideology and separatism**.
  - Separatism in Central Asia: Uyghur Muslims in western China's **Xinjiang** province want to separate — this is the **ETIM, the East Turkestan Islamic Movement**.
  - The Prime Minister's declaration on terrorism: the countries should speak in one voice and there should be **no double standards** — on one side you promote that there should be no terrorism, on the other side you yourself sponsor terrorism; this was a slap on Shahbaz Sharif.
- **C — Connectivity**: the connectivity dimension of SCO.
- **C — Central Asia**: Central Asia is the second 'C' of the framework.
- **O — Opportunity**: opportunities galore — if India-SCO relations are fulfilled, there are a lot of opportunities with respect to improvement of the relationship.

The framework is drawn as a triangle, and **there is no fixed diagram** — multiple templates are possible: sometimes three vertices are drawn, sometimes four, sometimes five, sometimes six.

- **Culture will not be so important**: civilisational diplomacy is not a sufficient reason to go to a regional organisation — our own culture is so vivid; it is added only to give the organisation an all-encompassing flavour.
- **Multilateralism and multipolarity** can be added as further vertices — SCO promotes multilateralism and it promotes multipolarity.
- A square, a pentagon, a polygon or a six-pointed star (the star shown in yellow) all work — any shape that looks good can be drawn.
- Whatever the shape, **the heads have to be highlighted** in the diagram.
- An alternative layout was shown in which four vertices then become six; that particular layout is not workable [as stated in lecture].
- For the Mains question that came up last year, that polygon diagram could have been drawn straight away [as stated in lecture].

This diagram answers the question 'why SCO is important' — it gives you a capture and it gives you a framework.

QUICK REVISION

- The framework for 'SCO for India' is **S-C-O**: Security, Connectivity, Central Asia and Opportu-

nity.

- Security has three parts — terrorism, extremist ideology and separatism — with Xinjiang and the ETIM as the separatism example.
- The Prime Minister's SCO declaration: one voice on terrorism and no double standards, which was a slap on Shahbaz Sharif.
- The diagram has no fixed form: three, four, five or six vertices; culture is included only for an all-encompassing flavour; multilateralism and multipolarity are valid extra vertices.
- Always highlight the heads of the diagram.

18.4 Introduction: Formation of SCO (1991 to 2001)

The introduction starts with a very important event that took place in history — that event is the source of SCO: **1991**.

- In 1991 there was the **break-up of the USSR (United Socialist Soviet Republics)**; it led to the birth of Russia and the **CARs — the Central Asian Republics**; almost **15 independent nations** came into being.
- These countries were newly formed and had to stabilise; the region had to be stabilised, and a threat emerged.
  - The comparison drawn was with India's Partition with Pakistan: was it fruitful, was it successful? Yes. Was it peaceful? Absolutely not — it produced one of the biggest migrations the world has seen, along with ethnic tensions.
  - There was a concern about **extremist religious groups** — there would have been a threat of extremist religious groups.
- So the nations felt a **security threat** and felt that something had to be done.
- If the Taliban comes to power and is incapable of addressing other factions, and if terrorism springs up in Afghanistan, it becomes a concern for the entire region — that was the fear in 1991. The Taliban did come to power on **15 August 2021**.
  - Four-five years later, Russia and the newly born nations stabilised.

18.4.1 The Shanghai Five

- Five nations — **China, Russia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan** — came together saying 'let us get our act together; we are willing to cooperate'. The newly independent countries were also fearful of **separatism**.
- The Shanghai Five decided to cooperate on three things:

1. Regional security.
2. Reduction of border troops.
3. Terrorism.

This was 100 per cent a security organisation — the driving need was **suraksha**, that is, security.

18.4.2 Formation of SCO in 2001

- Five years later, in **2001**, the SCO was formed: the five of the Shanghai Five plus one — **Uzbekistan** — giving **six initial members**: China, Russia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan.
- **Turkmenistan** did not join. Turkmenistan is like **Switzerland**, which maintains neutrality; Austria in the EU also maintains neutrality. So whenever NATO and the EU are discussed, these nations will not be members of any such regional organisation.
  - The **TAPI pipeline** (Turkmenistan-Afghanistan-Pakistan-India) was to come from Turkmenistan through Afghanistan and Pakistan into India, in Punjab; that pipeline could not succeed.
- Two permanent bodies were established by the six members: the **SCO Secretariat**, headquartered in **Beijing**; and the **Executive Committee of RATS — the Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure** — in **Tashkent**, the capital of Uzbekistan.
- Terrorism got a **separate vertical** of its own. India will always speak against terrorism — that is why India took this step: India went ahead, we agreed, and that is how India became a member.

QUICK REVISION

- 1991: break-up of the USSR led to the birth of Russia and the Central Asian Republics — almost 15 independent nations.
- The fear of the time: newly formed nations, the need to stabilise the region, extremist religious groups and separatism — compared with the experience of Partition.
- Shanghai Five: China, Russia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan, cooperating on regional security, reduction of border troops and terrorism.
- 2001: SCO formed with six initial members after Uzbekistan joined.
- Turkmenistan stayed out because of its neutrality (like Switzerland); its TAPI pipeline never succeeded.
- SCO's two permanent bodies: the Secretariat in Beijing and the RATS Executive Committee in Tashkent.

18.5 Expansion, the 'Association of Autocrats' Criticism and India's Dilemmas

- **Belarus** got added to SCO.

CRITICAL POINT

Biggest criticism: an association of autocrats, an anti-West platform.

- The West says SCO is an **association of autocrats** and is **anti-West**.
- The illustrations cited for this: Xi Jinping in China, Putin in Russia and Nursultan Nazarbayev in Kazakhstan.
- In the Central Asian countries, a president becomes president and remains president; removing

him takes a military coup [as stated in lecture].

- **Armenia and Georgia** are very important for India, to address the concern of increasing linkages of **organised crime and terrorism** — gangsters create organised crime and run their nexus from Armenia and Georgia.
- After **Iran** and **Belarus** were added, the declaration of the recent summit **castigated the US-Israel attack on Iran** as a clear violation of territorial sovereignty.
- India has not given any statement on it; India has said that all it wants is peace. But when the Iranians bombarded the Gulf with missiles, India criticised that with an open statement.
- Every organisation has its compulsions — and weaknesses for India — but there are also merits.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Bishkek Declaration.

- India was one of the nations that agreed to the **Bishkek Declaration**, signed just days before the lecture in Bishkek.
- Agreeing to it shows the **pulls and pressures** a country undergoes when it is exercising **strategic autonomy**.
- At Bishkek India also got the opportunity to meet the Iranian President, **Mr. Pezeshkian**; at the same time the meeting, or the summit, proved a bit costly diplomatically — India had to agree that there is a **one-sided war** launched by the West against Iran.

- Against this background, alternatives matter: **BRICS** — the **BRICS Development Bank (NDB)** came up in **2015**; and India was also an **observer in SCO in 2005**.

QUICK REVISION

- Belarus joining SCO sharpened the criticism that SCO is an association of autocrats and an anti-West platform, illustrated by Xi Jinping, Putin and Nursultan Nazarbayev.
- After Iran and Belarus joined, the summit declaration castigated the US-Israel attack on Iran as a violation of territorial sovereignty; India gave no statement and said it wants peace, but criticised Iran's missile bombardment of the Gulf.
- The Bishkek Declaration shows the pulls and pressures of strategic autonomy; the Bishkek summit also gave India a meeting with Iran's President Pezeshkian, but at a diplomatic cost.
- Armenia and Georgia matter to India for the growing nexus between organised crime and terrorism.
- India was an SCO observer in 2005; BRICS and the NDB (2015) are the parallel platforms.

18.6 What SCO Is: Focus Areas, Global Weight and the Shanghai Spirit

- SCO is an organisation that focuses on **politics, economics, internal security and defence**.

DATA & FACTS

SCO's weight in the world (as stated in the lecture).

- **33 per cent** of global GDP.
- **20 per cent** of global trade.
- **20 per cent** of global oil.
- **44 per cent** of global natural gas reserves — also put as almost **50 per cent** of natural gas reserves.
- India's dependence on imported crude oil is about **90 per cent**.

This is the **geoeconomic importance** of SCO — India had to enter this place: you are getting access to the oil and access to the gas.

18.6.1 *The Shanghai Spirit*

SCO adheres to something called the **Shanghai Spirit**, which claims to focus on the following — although, as was stressed, it does not really focus on any of them.

- **Mutual trust** — in reality it is full of mutual mistrust and distrust; the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor was cited here.
- **Mutual benefit** — there is nothing called mutual benefit.
- **Equality** — there is nothing called equality; this is a platform clearly led by Russia and China, and in this case by China-Pakistan cooperation.
- **Consultation** — the platform presents itself as one of consultation.
- **Respect for the diversity of civilisations** — it says we respect the diversity of civilisations.
- **Pursuit of common development**.
- **Non-alignment, non-targeting and openness** — externally it believes in non-alignment, non-targeting and openness.

18.6.2 *Summits and the Shift in Focus*

- Recent summits looked at: the summit in **Tianjin, China** and the summit in **Astana, Kazakhstan**.
  - The recollection of Kazakhstan's capital wavered between Astana and Almaty, and it was concluded that it is Astana.
- India's summit was held as a **virtual summit** [as stated in lecture].
- The **2026 summit** marked the **25th year of the establishment of SCO**.
- SCO was formed in **2001** to focus on **security** and broadly on **stability in the region**; its focus has now shifted from security and stability to **connectivity**.
- Initially SCO was formed to control **SET — separatism, extremism and terrorism**; the focus has now become connectivity. Whether this is good or bad can be written on both the ends, but broadly it is one of the issues being faced.
- Connectivity today means China's **Belt and Road Initiative**; to some extent India also wants to popularise the **International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC)**, which starts from

India, goes to Iran, and from Iran enters Russia through countries like **Azerbaijan**.

- The details of the International North-South Transport Corridor — the kilometres and the nations — will be studied for **Prelims**.

QUICK REVISION

- SCO focuses on politics, economics, internal security and defence.
- SCO contains 33 per cent of global GDP, 20 per cent of global trade, 20 per cent of global oil and 44 per cent (also stated as almost 50 per cent) of global natural gas reserves; India's crude oil import dependence is about 90 per cent.
- Shanghai Spirit claims mutual trust, mutual benefit, equality, consultation, respect for the diversity of civilisations, pursuit of common development, and non-alignment, non-targeting and openness — none of which, in this reading, actually holds.
- Recent summits: Tianjin in China and Astana in Kazakhstan; India's was a virtual summit; the 2026 summit was SCO's 25th year.
- SCO's focus has shifted from security and stability (SET) to connectivity — the Belt and Road Initiative for China, and the International North-South Transport Corridor for India (India to Iran and on to Russia via Azerbaijan).

18.7 Importance of SCO for India: The Four Dimensions

The importance of SCO for India is nothing other than the importance of SCO. UPSC can ask 'Discuss the reasons why India became a member of SCO' — those reasons are the importance of SCO for India, and there is also the importance of India for SCO.

In IR, importance is always **geopolitical, geoeconomic, geocultural and geostrategic**. Each of these four terms must be defined and substantiated; the difference between the four has to be clear.

COMPARISON

What each of the four dimensions means.

- **Geopolitical** — 'geo' means geography and 'political' means politics, and politics means power. How powerful a country is: the importance of SCO is studied with respect to power. You might want to counter a country, which is why you want to be a member of SCO — to engage with that country, to be part of the major powers of the world, and to promote multipolarity and multilateralism. The core dimension of a state studied in political science is power — kitna balwaan, kitna shaktishali.
- **Geoeconomic** — that is economy, trade, resources, critical minerals, connectivity, infrastructure, and the number of banks and financial institutions.
- **Geocultural** — soft power, religion, civilisation and history; these are people-to-people (P2P) relations.
- **Geostrategic** — strategy is security: maritime security, defence security, security of Central Asia, security against terrorism and border security. For example, in India the Ministry of Defence, the Navy and the Coast Guard work on this dimension.

There is a technical point in IR here: the objectives of the Shanghai Five — stability, security and prevention of separatism — are the same objectives; SCO only changed the names of the agreements. The same aims and objectives, and mutual benefit: the Shanghai Spirit represents the aim.

Aims and objectives need not be very specific — 'aim 1-2-3, objective 1-2-3' is not required.

QUICK REVISION

- Importance covers both the importance of SCO for India and the importance of India for SCO.
- Four dimensions: geopolitical (power), geoeconomic (economy, trade, resources, connectivity, financial institutions), geocultural (soft power, P2P) and geostrategic (security and defence).
- The Shanghai Five objectives carried over to SCO — the same aims and objectives, with only the names of the agreements changed.
- Aims and objectives need not be listed as aim 1-2-3 and objective 1-2-3.

18.8 Importance of SCO for India: The Points

- **A continental Eurasian platform**: SCO has members from Central Asia and includes India, which is a part of India's extended neighbourhood, and therefore it has a direct bearing on India's security.
  - Because all the other nations are Central Asian, any instability in Central Asia will automatically become instability for India.
- **Exercising strategic autonomy**: SCO allows India the strategic space to independently engage Russia and China without being anti-West, and therefore allows multi-alignment and increasing diplomatic space.
  - **Strategic autonomy** implies that India can engage with different blocs without taking sides, and without becoming aligned with any of the countries or blocs.
  - India can simultaneously engage with the US; within SCO it can engage with Russia and China. It might be labelled anti-West, but because India exercises strategic autonomy, SCO becomes another platform where India can engage with both of these nations and step out without sacrificing its interest — it can engage while ensuring that it is not labelled anti-West.
  - Had there been no SCO, India would have been dependent on the traditional platforms which are led by the US, such as the Quad.
  - Example: in **2017** India became an SCO member and India also became a member of the **Quad (Quad 2.0)** — Mr. Trump and the Prime Minister.
  - SCO is a platform for strategic autonomy and it is moving towards multipolarity, because there is a simultaneous rise of Russia and China combined — there is no separate third rise of Russia — and it allows India to exercise its choices.
- **Compliments India's Central Asia policy**: India's Central Asia policy dates to **2012**, and all the Central Asian countries are members of SCO, so the logic is straightforward.
  - Iran came into SCO in **2023**; India and Pakistan came in **2017**; of the six initial members, four are Central Asian members — the fifth, which is not a member, is Turkmenistan, an

independent bloc and a neutral country.
  - The Prime Minister has remarked that Central Asia is India's **extended family**, its **first cousins**, its **blood brothers** (blood relation). We are connected by waters with the Himalayas; our neighbours are our first priorities — Nepal, Bangladesh, Bhutan, and then Sri Lanka, which is a little further (about 200 km) but is connected through a bridge; it is part of the Indian subcontinent's continuity. It is India's extended family.
- **Cooperation with Central Asian nations against terrorism**: India's concern is terrorism, especially **cross-border terrorism**, and India uses SCO to keep **SET — separatism, extremism and terrorism** — at the centre of the Central Asian security agenda.
  - Example: at the Tianjin summit the SCO declaration **condemned the Pahalgam attack** — described as a slap on the face of those present from Pakistan [as stated in lecture]; in **2026** the Prime Minister criticised the **double standards** of certain members of SCO on terrorism. This is a big victory.
  - If Pakistan says there is terrorism in its own country too, that is true, but the blame for it does not lie on India; Pakistan has never blamed India for cross-border terrorism. India's specific problem is cross-border terrorism — terrorism with a political objective that is fuelled by a state; Pakistan itself is fuelling a proxy war.
  - Proving this is very difficult: after Pahalgam, India's missile strikes on Bahawalpur and other sites, and the handling of Karachi port and Balochistan, were different [as stated in lecture]. At that time Pakistan diplomatically told the whole world that this was a war launched by India with no proof — what is the proof that the Pahalgam terror attack originated from the ISI? According to Pakistan there is no proof, so the developed world actually sympathised with Pakistan. Hence this became a diplomatic loss for India.
  - After that war the Government of India started a very good initiative — a plan to recruit members of the **Indian Information Service** for information campaigns, with about 40-50 officers to be recruited and deputed in Europe; the Indian Foreign Service resisted this and the positions were limited [as stated in lecture].
  - Pakistan's nature of terrorism is different from India's nature of terrorism: in India it is outrightly in the open that terrorism comes from the ISI, but there is no such proof that India is causing terrorism in Pakistan. In **FATF** Pakistan itself is wrong — it is itself saying that the Taliban has sheltered it and that the Taliban is linked to it, so it is opening its cards; it should have played its cards against India more smartly, because diplomatically it is smarter than India.
  - This is a very important point for asserting India's stand on terrorism — and the most important point.
- **A platform for bilateral engagement**: the keyword here is **sideline diplomacy**.
  - SCO as a platform allows engagement with Pakistan and China — very important — without normalising disputes; trade and talks cannot go together, and trade and terrorism cannot go together.
  - The bilateral with Xi Jinping could not take place at Bishkek, though it was expected and a meeting of the three did happen; the bilateral then happened at BRICS — whether a bilateral is planned there was not read in advance, but it would be good and should be

watched live. If there is a bilateral between India and China, it adds to the development that has just happened: the **25th round of Special Representative talks** between **Wang Yi** and **Mr. Doval**.

- In diplomacy, small frameworks matter a lot. With China: whatever it says it does not do, and whatever it does it does not say — it is a perpetual foreign policy of **ambiguity**.
  - In optics you have to watch for the optics — this does not mean watching with a camera; you can watch it live and try to imbibe how things progress.
- Even with SCO, India's heart's pain is not reduced and the abeyance will remain as it is — India has still completely kept the **Indus Waters Treaty** in abeyance. But SCO as a platform allows India to encash the opportunity: if India wants to engage with Pakistan, there has to be a platform and there has to be an opportunity, and that is what SCO allows. Whether India wants to engage is its own call — the ball has to be in India's court. SCO lets India take that step forward and develop possibilities for declarations and initiatives in India's favour.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Sideline diplomacy in action.**
>
> - **Tianjin 2025** — the Prime Minister's visit after 7 years to China; it creates opportunities for improvement in the bilateral relationship.
> - **Bishkek 2026** — the India-Iran first bilateral meeting after the US-Israel-Iran war; it was a major step and it allowed India to engage.

- **Staying connected with developments in Afghanistan**: SCO has a **contact group on Afghanistan**, and Afghanistan is in India's immediate neighbourhood.
  - The **Wakhan Corridor** with Pakistan-occupied Kashmir makes it important for regional stability; any kind of instability in Afghanistan will have a straight bearing on India, so India has to be in touch.
- **Strengthening multi-polarity and multilateralism**: SCO allows India to be part of an **alternative economic structure** and to create opportunities to trade or engage with **Russia and Iran**, both facing diplomatic sanctions from the US.
  - This is important in the light of **diversification by the Central Asian Republics**, which, like India, are following a **multi-vectored foreign policy**. Multi-vectored means multi-directional — as in mathematics, holding hands with the US, Russia, China and Iran at the same time, as Kazakhstan, Turkmenistan, Tajikistan and Kyrgyzstan are doing.
  - When they are diversifying, what is India waiting for? The Central Asian nations are themselves diversifying, engaging in SCO and also engaging with the US, and they believe in multipolarity. If you are talking to many partners who are similar in their level of stature, it means you believe in multipolarity and multilateralism — and that is the reason why SCO meetings take place: they want to develop an **alternative world order** believed to be run on the principles of the **UN** — that is what Iran says: any attack on me violates the **UN Charter**, as simple as that; 'I have done retaliation'.
- **A platform to counter the Belt and Road Initiative**: the **CPEC** corridor violates India's territorial sovereignty.
- **Demonstrating India's role as a bridge builder**: SCO membership demonstrates India's role

as a link between the West and the East — the East means Europe, Russia and China, and the West means the US.

- **The increasing expansion of SCO**: its increasing reach, from **Egypt** in the West to **Cambodia** in South-East Asia, both as **dialogue partners**, indicates the importance of SCO; SCO is the only platform that brings together South Asia, Central Asia, Iran, Russia and China.
- **Institutional density**: the keyword to use when many countries come together on a platform — to be used with context, and for some organisations [as stated in lecture].

QUICK REVISION

- SCO is a continental Eurasian platform: Central Asian members sit in India's extended neighbourhood, so instability there is instability for India.
- Strategic autonomy: SCO lets India engage Russia and China without being anti-West, allows multi-alignment and increases diplomatic space — India joined SCO and the Quad in the same year, 2017.
- SCO compliments India's Central Asia policy of 2012; Central Asia is India's extended family, first cousins and blood brothers; Iran joined in 2023, India and Pakistan in 2017.
- Terrorism: India uses SCO to keep SET at the centre of the Central Asian security agenda — the Tianjin declaration condemned the Pahalgam attack and the double standards of certain members were criticised.
- Sideline diplomacy: SCO enables bilateral engagement with Pakistan and China without normalising disputes — Tianjin 2025 and the Bishkek 2026 India-Iran bilateral are the examples.
- Other gains: the contact group on Afghanistan, strengthening multipolarity and multilateralism, an alternative economic structure with Russia and Iran, countering the BRI and CPEC, and India's role as a bridge builder.
- SCO's reach now runs from Egypt to Cambodia as dialogue partners, and the keyword for many countries on one platform is institutional density.

CHAPTER 19

The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) — Part 2

19.1 Geoeconomic Importance of SCO for India

The importance of SCO is being written head by head. The geopolitical importance has been completed, and the last points written under it were multilateralism and multipolarity and the expansion of SCO.

- SCO is the only platform that brings together the countries of Central Asia and South Asia as well as **Iran** — very important.
- The same way of studying importance applies elsewhere: when ASEAN is studied, the importance of ASEAN is the same as the importance of Southeast Asia as a block.

The discussion now turns to the **geoeconomic importance**. Whenever the geoeconomic importance of any block is studied, a fixed template is used — it is the first topic, and once internalised the points come automatically.

19.1.1 The Geoeconomic Template

- **Trade** — first of all, trade: the raw materials being looked at and the market perspective, that is, how Central Asia is a market for India's products.
- **Energy security** — the different types of fossil fuels and resources available in that particular part of the world.
- **Critical mineral security** — an added attention that has to be given: the different critical minerals and resources to be obtained, for example **uranium**.
- India has just signed an agreement with **Uzbekistan** for uranium; therefore SCO is not only a block, it is also important for critical minerals.
- **Connectivity** — one of the very important pillars: the big irritant is that Pakistan is a major inhibition and does not provide India access.
- **Investment** — a very important parameter for countries like Japan and Australia, and for particular bodies like the **G7**.
- **Finance**.
- **Infrastructure**, the most important thing — the example is the bullet train that is coming from Japan.

Whenever the relevance of Central Asia is asked for, it implies the **geopolitical, geoeconomic, geocultural and geostrategic** dimensions. Geo-strategic is sometimes shortened simply to

strategic; the points are the same and there is no difference.

19.1.2 Energy Security and Structural Dependence

DATA & FACTS

Numbers to quote on energy.

- **20 per cent** of global oil reserves and **44 per cent** of natural gas reserves lie in this part of the world.
- India's dependence on imports is almost **90 per cent** for crude oil and almost **55 per cent** for natural gas.

Structural dependence means a root cause that cannot be removed — the dependence will remain, and that is precisely why diversification becomes all the more necessary: if the dependence on crude is 90 per cent, India has to diversify.

- Energy security is important for the **energy transition**: **Kazakhstan** is one of the largest producers of uranium.
- The second point is **economic security**: this region is a source of raw materials and a market for India's exports.

1. India's export diversification.
2. A resilient supply chain.
3. WTO-centred multilateral trade.
4. Services mobility.
5. MSME growth.

- MSMEs can cater to these countries and blocks: as members of SCO, MSMEs have the potential to export their products in this part of the world.
- Connectivity is the most under-explored area and a very big advantage of SCO: **huge potential, but limited connectivity**, because of the denial of direct land access by Pakistan.
- All of this will be taken up in great detail in the prelims discussion and is therefore not repeated now; the map is given only for reference.

KEY CONCEPT

Connectivity keywords to write down.

- India is a member of the **International North–South Transport Corridor (INSTC)** and is promoting the **Chabahar port** in Iran.

QUICK REVISION

- SCO is the only platform bringing Central Asia, South Asia and Iran together; the ASEAN comparison works the same way.
- The geoeconomic template: trade, energy security, critical mineral security, connectivity, investment, finance and infrastructure.

- 20 per cent of global oil reserves and 44 per cent of natural gas reserves lie here; India's import dependence is about 90 per cent for crude and 55 per cent for natural gas.
- **Structural dependence** is a root cause that cannot be removed, which makes diversification necessary.
- Energy security matters for the energy transition (Kazakhstan leads in uranium); economic security rests on raw materials and a market for India's exports.
- SCO serves export diversification, resilient supply chains, WTO-centred trade, services mobility and MSME growth.
- Connectivity is the most under-explored area — huge potential, limited by Pakistan; India's answer is the INSTC and the Chabahar port.

19.2 Connectivity and the Map: Pakistan's Denial and the INSTC Route

The map is given for reference: India, Mumbai and Pakistan as reference points, and the patch through which Central Asia has to be reached — the **Wakhan Corridor** — with Afghanistan. From here the route does not come to us, so India has an alternative.

- Alternative route: the port of **Bandar Abbas** (Iran's port) → northward to Iran's border → past Azerbaijan → and finally it enters Russia.
- This route is the **International North–South Transport Corridor**.

19.2.1 The Map as an Eagle's View

- Central Asia is like an **eagle**: one can stand on Central Asia and see what is happening in the entire country of Afghanistan.
- The problem is that the shortest route to Afghanistan is through Pakistan, but Pakistan would never let that happen — which is why India is promoting SCO and connectivity and taking a very long route to reach Central Asia.
- Any regional instability in Afghanistan will affect India's security and will also affect Central Asia's security.
- Afghanistan cannot be seen from one perspective: to deal with Afghanistan, one would have to befriend Pakistan.
- Iran is domestically occupied — analogy: when one is domestically occupied, one cannot cooperate with Nepal, Sri Lanka, Maldives or Bangladesh. Iran is caught up domestically, yet it gives India access through Bandar Abbas.
- Crossing Iran's territory northward enters the Central Asian block, at the very centre of Eurasia: Georgia, Armenia, Azerbaijan, Turkmenistan, Uzbekistan, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan.
- Central Asia is the centre of Eurasia, and Afghanistan is the centre of Central Asia.

19.2.2 Gilgit-Baltistan and the Frontier of Colonial India

- Gilgit-Baltistan played a very important role in the rise of the Sheikh Abdullah family; the British wanted Gilgit taken from **Maharaja Hari Singh**, the Dogra-dynasty king of Jammu and

Kashmir, because this part of the world was the fringe area between Russia and colonial India — Iran, Afghanistan and Gilgit-Baltistan were all necessary parts.

- In the attempt to take Gilgit-Baltistan and to pressurise Hari Singh, the British promoted the **National Conference** political party; Sheikh Abdullah's activities in J&K in the second half of the 1930s — when the **Government of India Act 1935** and the 1937 elections in 11 provinces were being witnessed — were a very important card played by the British against Maharaja Hari Singh.
- The British never realised the importance of J&K — a big blunder on their part: they very easily gave Jammu and Kashmir to **Maharaja Gulab Singh**, the head of the Dogra dynasty, under the **Treaty of Amritsar**, in 1844–48 [as stated in lecture].
- It is said that the history of J&K was written the day that treaty was signed: had the treaty never been signed and had the British retained Jammu and Kashmir, the history, geography, polity, strategy and the problem of separatism in J&K would never have happened — it was one small strategic blunder.
- When the British realised the importance of Gilgit-Baltistan in the second half of the 1930s, they had signed the **Gilgit Lease** agreement and deputed a resident commissioner — a Britisher — who stayed in the Gilgit area, called the Gilgit Lease area.
- The history as shown records the atrocities — the Kashmiri Pandits — and Sheikh Abdullah was all in love with Mr. Nehru; the history of Kashmir has been portrayed in a very smart way.

Pakistan is completely bypassed on this route: India is basically entering Central Asia.

- The map to be traced by hand shows the very important location of Turkmenistan, the **Amu river**, the **Hindu Kush** mountains, Afghanistan and the **Kabul river** — the map gives a picture that is smooth enough and will not be discussed further, because time has to be optimised [as stated in lecture].
- Write it down quickly so that this image is clear in the head: India is promoting **Chabahar** and the **International North–South Transport Corridor**.
- The map shows a picture — it is enough for the moment, and the fuller details will be taken in the prelims discussion.

QUICK REVISION

- The route to Central Asia runs through the Wakhan Corridor and Afghanistan; the alternative is Bandar Abbas in Iran → northward → past Azerbaijan → into Russia, which is the INSTC.
- Central Asia is like an eagle from which all of Afghanistan can be watched, but the shortest route to Afghanistan is through Pakistan, which will never allow it.
- Any instability in Afghanistan affects both India's and Central Asia's security; Iran is domestically occupied yet provides access through Bandar Abbas.
- Crossing Iran northward enters the Central Asian block at the centre of Eurasia: Georgia, Armenia, Azerbaijan, Turkmenistan, Uzbekistan, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan.
- Central Asia is the centre of Eurasia and Afghanistan is the centre of Central Asia.
- Gilgit-Baltistan, the Dogra dynasty (Hari Singh, Gulab Singh), the National Conference, the

Government of India Act 1935 and the Treaty of Amritsar (1844–48) [as stated in lecture] form the colonial backstory of the frontier.

- Pakistan is completely bypassed on this route, and India is effectively entering Central Asia via Chabahar and the INSTC.

19.3 The Belt and Road Initiative and Why India Does Not Join It

SCO members are signatories of **BRI**, and therefore India is the only major SCO member which is not a signatory of BRI. SCO's importance is therefore further increased, and India needs to take steps in connectivity and infrastructure-related projects to counter the influence of BRI.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Examination framing.

- BRI is not to be treated merely as BRI: this time the examination has asked that the **Belt and Road Initiative is having great strategic implications for India**.

BRI means creating a belt of ports, connectivity and highway projects on land, and building a maritime sea route: land-based projects and water-based projects — ports, highways and infrastructure.

CRITICAL POINT

Why BRI is strategic, not merely economic.

- It should not be given merely infrastructure or geoeconomic importance; a lot of strategic importance is attributed to it.
- A **Parliamentary Standing Committee chaired by Shashi Tharoor** has clearly said that every move of China has two faces.

- BRI has **dual implications**: it is not only boosting infrastructure — for a country like Pakistan, a **60 billion dollar** corridor has been built.
- Watching Pakistani YouTubers travelling through the **China–Pakistan Economic Corridor** shows that China has built formidable expressways and highways for Gilgit-Baltistan; the topography is such that one would forget Ladakh, with solid concrete pavements.
- So much promotion and development has been done that the common people there would say it is China's gift.
- **Gwadar port** is the best in Balochistan province, Pakistan; but the local people there are very troubled and attack the Chinese, so there is unhappiness in Gwadar — while along the corridor, passing through Pakistan-occupied Kashmir, the development looks beautiful.
- This has become a platform where China makes big claims, gives gifts and bets to people, and tells nations to come and join BRI; for India it is a straight slap and a straight diplomatic challenge.
- The **China–Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC)** violates India's sovereignty — it passes through India's territory.

- India therefore cannot but focus on connectivity: it is the **weakest link and the strongest opportunity** — the maximum work should happen here and the minimum work is here.
- Whenever there is a war, Iran and the **Strait of Hormuz** become critical: one cannot go there, there is a naval blockade and missiles are flying, so the connectivity is 100 per cent finished.
- Why India does not join BRI: it is a 100 per cent violation of sovereignty and it is not even a question — first ensure there is no China–Pakistan Economic Corridor, then negotiate, and then India will think of joining Belt and Road.

Proponent	China	India, with Iran and Russia
Nature	A belt of ports, highways and connectivity projects on land plus a maritime sea route	A land-and-sea route: India to Bandar Abbas in Iran, then northward past Azerbaijan into Russia
India's position	Opposed — India is the only major SCO member that has not signed BRI, and CPEC violates India's sovereignty	A member, and promoting it along with the Chabahar port in Iran

19.3.1 *What Connectivity Really Means*

- Repeated talk of connectivity basically amounts to striking a blow at Pakistan and capturing Afghanistan; the trade is only **2 billion dollars** among 5 tiny countries.
- One should always be optimistic and promote it, but the game is different — the game of connectivity; India too is slowly opening its cards.
- Connectivity implies exactly this: breaking Pakistan. Today Pakistan is stuck; once friendship with the Taliban happens and the Taliban runs the country well, it is a win for India — an inclusive government, as stated in Afghanistan.

EXAMPLE

Horse meat — a delicacy of the region.

- Horse meat is a delicacy in this part of the world and is eaten very fondly: at an SCO meeting a big platter of it is served with rice around it, and the pulao has saffron (because saffron is in Iran), with horse meat in the middle.

- Connectivity is right: **maximum opportunity and the lowest gains** — almost equal to zero — and economy-wise it is very important for India.

QUICK REVISION

- SCO members are signatories of BRI, so India is the only major SCO member that has not

signed it; SCO's importance therefore increases and India must act on connectivity.

- BRI is land-based and sea-based: ports, highways and infrastructure — but it carries strategic, not merely geoeconomic, importance.
- A Parliamentary Standing Committee chaired by Shashi Tharoor said every move of China has two faces; BRI has dual implications, with a 60 billion dollar corridor for Pakistan.
- Gwadar is the best port in Balochistan but is unpopular locally, while the corridor through Pakistan-occupied Kashmir looks impressive — CPEC violates India's sovereignty.
- India will not join BRI: it is a 100 per cent sovereignty violation, and no negotiation is possible until CPEC is addressed.
- Connectivity is the weakest link and the strongest opportunity; Iran and the Strait of Hormuz become critical in wartime.
- Connectivity means striking at Pakistan and capturing Afghanistan — the trade is only 2 billion dollars — and it is maximum opportunity with the lowest gains.

19.4 Geocultural Importance of SCO

After the geoeconomic importance comes the **geocultural importance**. The infrastructure head is already written — infrastructure is important for trade, for market connectivity, for goods and services and for the promotion of MSMEs.

- In SCO, **Central Asia should be at the back of the head**: keeping Russia and China aside, all the nations are Central Asian nations; Iran and Belarus have just joined in 2023–24.
- SCO is a card to keep the Central Asian republics happy.
- Uzbekistan is a great country with medieval history and very beautiful mosques — **Samarkand** — and the **Fergana Valley**, where Babar was born.
- The Islamisation of Central Asia, or Islam in Central Asia, is completely different from the Islam of West Asia, the Islam of Africa or the Islam of Southeast Asia: Central Asian Islam is not about identity. This is the special point.
- India uses the card of projecting **civilizational diplomacy** — this is not a thing of today, not the West Asian model, and not the US model of earning through the IT industry and then brain circulation.
- It is basically the **Silk Route**: India has had a relationship with this Eurasia since the times of the Silk Route; SCO is not Central Asia — it is basically a Eurasian block, a continental Eurasian block.
- Pakistan says it has no historical identity and will follow all Islam, and Pakistan cuts India's civilizational links by playing around with the identity of Islam — an interesting discourse on how a simple religion can be an effective tool or an effective hindrance in improving a relationship.

19.4.1 India's Projection of Civilizational Diplomacy

It is important for India's projection of **civilizational diplomacy**, where India has used SCO to highlight civilizational connections with Eurasia — not culture, not history, but civilizational

connections.

- It includes **Buddhism**.
- It includes **Yoga**.
- It includes **traditional medicine** — the most important.
- It includes the **Silk Route**, or historical trade routes.
- It includes Central Asian linkages and the shared cultural memory.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Civilizational dialogue suggested.**
>
> - In **2025**, at **Tianjin**, the Prime Minister suggested initiating a civilizational dialogue between India and SCO members.

19.4.2 India's Soft Power

The second geocultural point: it is important for the projection of India's **soft power**.

- When discussing SCO, one is trying to win the hearts of Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, because Russia is anyway in good ties, so is Belarus; Iran watches India, China, Pakistan and Russia as the various pillars; China will never cooperate and Pakistan is non-cooperation.
- India is using soft power because this region has seen so much hard power and carries the historical baggage of Russian influence: the Slavs dominated Russia as Hindus are the majority in India; historically in Russia, earlier the USSR, the Slavs dominated the ethnicity, so there were rebellions among different minorities and they formed separate nations — for example Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan; they are all Islamic nations.
- The region has also seen inroads by the EU: in **2025** the **EU–Central Asia Summit** happened for the first time; the EU is now looking east and focusing on this Eurasian centre of Central Asia.
- Having already seen a lot of hard-power involvement, they now want someone who projects soft power — who does not show wrath and does not engage in debt-ridden diplomacy — so they want partnership to diversify and to exercise strategic autonomy.
- India has to balance being hand-in-hand with the US (Quad) and its Russia relationship while ensuring its diplomacies and projections do not harm its image; the image of Mr. Putin and the Prime Minister was an opportunity that was also a challenge, because the US might not have agreed to this image — a reiteration that India will keep importing more and more oil from Russia; theatrics and optics are two aspects of one thing, and one has created a challenge.
- So India has major scope: if not for SCO, India would never have projected its soft power.
- In soft power, culture: **Bollywood** has played such an important role, plus music; Mr. Raj Kapoor had a big following in this part of the world, and the music of **Mera Naam Joker** was very popular.
- The Central Asian republics like Indian men: the sex ratio in this part of the world is more than 1000, so women outnumber men, and there is a cultural phenomenon that the women there like Indian men, presumably because Indian men are more family-oriented — an added

cultural connection.

- **Ayurveda** is also a soft-power element, and the Islamic connection is very important as well.

QUICK REVISION

- After geoeconomics comes geocultural importance; Central Asia must sit at the back of the head, with Iran and Belarus joining in 2023–24.
- SCO is a card to keep the Central Asian republics happy; Uzbekistan's Samarkand and the Fergana Valley (Babar's birthplace) are the cultural markers.
- Central Asian Islam is not about identity — it is completely different from the Islam of West Asia, Africa or Southeast Asia.
- India projects civilizational diplomacy through civilizational connections with Eurasia — Buddhism, Yoga, traditional medicine, the Silk Route, Central Asian linkages and shared cultural memory.
- At Tianjin in 2025 the Prime Minister suggested a civilizational dialogue between India and SCO members.
- Soft power is the second geocultural point: Russia and Belarus are already close, Iran and China and Pakistan are not, so the Central Asian republics are the target — a region that has seen hard power and now wants partnership and strategic autonomy.
- Soft-power instruments: Bollywood, music (Raj Kapoor and Mera Naam Joker), Ayurveda, the Islamic connection, and the cultural popularity of Indian men in a region with a sex ratio above 1000.

19.5 Geostrategic Importance of SCO

KEY CONCEPT

Geostrategic means hard power.

- **Geostrategic** means hard power: now there is no trade and no culture — it is security, safety and defence.

- SCO is important for **regional security** — not merely for India's security: it is one of the few international organisations that extensively deals with security matters focused on Asia's security.
  - **NATO** is the best security organisation and focuses on West Transatlantic cooperation, whereas SCO focuses on Asia — very important for regional security.
- The most important is **counter-terrorism**, where SCO enables India to be a part of and engage with **RATS — the Regional Anti-Terrorism Structure** — to tackle **SET: separatism, extremism and terrorism**.
- RATS creates a formal channel for cooperation, information sharing and intelligence sharing, and gives India access to a **non-Pakistan-centred counter-terrorism information framework**.
- India's entire intelligence mechanism is focused on Pakistan, but apart from Pakistan there can be internal security threats: for example, ISIS becomes active in Tajikistan, or in Uzbekistan, or any other regional organisation or non-state terrorist organisation becomes active in this

part of the world — so how will it be addressed?

- With SCO and RATS, that information is available; China will be willing to cooperate because China itself faces the **East Turkestan Islamic Movement (ETIM)**, causing terror concerns in Xinjiang and often connected with the Uyghur Muslims in Xinjiang province.
- Counter-terrorism exercises are held — the exercise is named **Interaction**; in **2024** it was held in Xinjiang province, in the Uyghur Autonomous Region.
- The Chinese have not been spared either: there has been Chinese targeting by the **Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP)**, which is against Pakistan and not against India.
- The **Durand Line**: Mortimer Durand made this line of divide between the Pashtuns of Afghanistan and Pakistan — the area called the North West Frontier Province, and before that **FATA**, the Federally Administered Tribal Areas; the tribes living there, the Pathans, have the Tehreek, so attacks keep happening on Pakistan.
- It was a big concern for India too, but it is a much bigger concern for Pakistan; and the TTP is very annoyed with China because China mistreats the Muslims in Uyghur, so the TTP attacks the Chinese.
- Then there is **Al-Qaeda**, and also the **Islamic State Khorasan Province (ISKP)**, located in Afghanistan; their branches have come up in different places — like coaching institutes have branches in Bangalore and Jaipur.
- Chinese workers are everywhere — in Balochistan and in Afghanistan — and revenge is taken there.
- India has no such threat: India has no enmity with the Taliban; the Taliban's enmity is only with Pakistan, and Pakistan was running them its own way; it is said that a Pathan is never subservient to anyone, so the Pathans are being segregated somewhere.
- Third: sometimes, in the name of friendship, one has to remain alert — SCO can be used to **manage China's assertiveness**, where India can **engage, contest and shape the agenda** against Chinese aggressive tendencies.
- Add this point: **from within — openly**.

> **DATA & FACTS**
>
> **From no condemnation in 2020 to condemnation in 2024.**
>
> - Last year SCO condemned the **Pahalgam attack** vehemently.
> - In **2020** there would have been no condemnation — there may have been some mention, but surely no condemnation — of the 2020 crisis in the month of May, when there was aggression along **Chushul** and **Daulat Beg Oldi** and certain areas along **Pangong Tso** lake and nearby areas in Ladakh in the western part of the LAC.

- The strategic and security importance of SCO is further increased because of Afghanistan as a major strategic concern: India uses SCO to get involved in Afghan-related discussions, as instability in Afghanistan leads to an increase in SET, an increase in drug trafficking, in narco-terrorism and in human trafficking.
- There are **10 nations — 9 plus India**: these 10 nations repeatedly engage among themselves and want to know what is happening; SCO was created for this, because there might be

instability in the region.

- They are more worried than India as far as terrorism is concerned, so they are more proactive in engaging with Afghanistan; India is the most proactive in ensuring what is happening in Pakistan — all of India's intelligence is on Pakistan, while these countries' intelligence is focused on Afghanistan.
- So being a part of it is important for India to know what is happening — it is a very important platform.
- For security, Afghanistan is always important; the platform is also important for **increasing security threats**, where SCO's security focus has expanded from traditional security to the latest techniques: cyber security, drug trafficking, organised crime, AI, technology governance and critical infrastructure protection.
- Therefore SCO's membership leads to **better preparedness, information and intelligence sharing, and increased coordination** on security threats.

19.5.1 The Changing Nature of Security

- Security has changed: the **Russia–Ukraine war** is the best example and the **Iran and US–Israel war** is the best example — naval vessels and enemy military installations are rarely targeted now; the focus is on targeting critical infrastructure and the associated installations; the **Kharg Island attack** was a major concern.
- One would rather attack a nuclear plant, a pipeline, bridges or connectivity; the same is being done by the Russians in Ukraine — they are attacking critical information areas and critical infrastructure; that is more dangerous and easier, as with the nuclear plant attacked two years back.
- Security cooperation has to be promoted over areas where coordination and intelligence sharing are comparatively limited: one can have as many drones, submarines and aircraft carriers, but strategies are needed to prevent any such attack on critical infrastructure.
- A big concern is **drones**: with drones the reach also increases; earlier, army movement, troop movement and movement of ammunition could not be tracked — now there are 10–50–60 drones in Russia, in Ukraine and in Iran, and a drone is easily **200,000 dollars**.
- This is why the Prime Minister said the time has come when public places will be very important: a scheme called **Mission Sudarshan Chakra** was launched, and it came up straight in the Civil Services Prelims as well.
- Security's dimension will be changed.

QUICK REVISION

- Geostrategic means hard power — security, safety and defence.
- SCO matters for regional security (focused on Asia, where NATO focuses on the West), and for counter-terrorism through RATS against SET — separatism, extremism and terrorism.
- RATS gives a formal channel for information and intelligence sharing and a non-Pakistan-centred counter-terrorism framework; China cooperates because of ETIM in Xinjiang.
- The exercise Interaction was held in 2024 in Xinjiang; the TTP attacks Pakistan and the

Chinese; the Durand Line, FATA and the ISKP and Al-Qaeda branches are the region's terror landscape; India has no such threat.

- SCO lets India manage China's assertiveness — engage, contest and shape the agenda, from within and openly.
- SCO condemned the Pahalgam attack last year, whereas the 2020 crisis (Chushul, Daulat Beg Oldi, Pangong Tso) drew no condemnation.
- SCO's security focus has expanded to cyber security, drug trafficking, organised crime, AI, technology governance and critical infrastructure protection, leading to better preparedness and coordination.
- The nature of security has changed: critical infrastructure, nuclear plants and pipelines are now targeted; drones cost about 200,000 dollars; Mission Sudarshan Chakra came up in the Prelims.

19.6 Importance of India for SCO: The Geopolitical Dimension

Now write India's importance for SCO nations — in brackets, why India was made a member in **2017**. The heads are the same: **GP, GE, GC and GS**.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Question to write.

- **More than India needing SCO, it is SCO that needs India** — critically analyse the statement with examples.

India's geopolitical importance may be summarised as follows: it strengthens multipolarity; it strengthens multilateralism; the global image of SCO will get strengthened; it will balance the increasing rise of Russia–China cooperation; it will strengthen multipolarity within SCO; and it will convert SCO from a Central Asian organisation into a larger Eurasian platform.

- **Transforms SCO into an Asian organisation** — from a Central Asian focus it has become Asian focus, because it includes the **IOR**; therefore it expands the geographical reach and international profile, and SCO becomes a regional organisation.
- **India's enormous global political weight** — India is the leader of the **Global South** and the link between East and West and North and South; it is a member of several multilateral organisations — Quad, BRICS, IBSA (India, Brazil, South Africa), BIMSTEC, East Asia Summit, etc.; it has nuclear weapon capabilities and an independent foreign policy.
- **It strengthens the claims of multipolarity** — India's membership makes SCO a representative block for strengthening multipolarity and multilateralism, as India has strategic partnerships with the US, Japan and the EU and simultaneously engages with BRICS and SCO and maintains strategic autonomy.
- Therefore India transforms SCO from **anti-West or Russia–China-led** into a **non-West, plural and multipolar Eurasian international organisation**.
- The reasoning: multipolarity was in Russia and China; but when India becomes a member, the world watches that this is a country which practises strategic autonomy — SCO made it

a member and SCO itself is multipolar, so they are now rightfully and ethically right to lay their claim on the idea that SCO is multipolar and thereby that the world also needs to be multipolar; had SCO not made India a member, it would have exhibited their apprehensions about not tilting the tide in favour of India.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **The two-pillar analogy.**
>
> - If I am a big pillar and I make the other pillar a member, that shows that I too believe there should be two or three poles.
> - The West can no longer point a finger — the West knows India is a member of BRICS, of Quad and of SCO; there is no country in the whole world with so much political weight, so for them it is a blessing in disguise.

- **It provides internal geopolitical balance**, where it prevents Chinese dominance, especially through BRI.
- Today, if any country is happy, the most happy is **Russia**: Russia is badly stuck, because if it does not engage China then there is no sale of weapons and no sale of oil and the economy will not improve; the happiest is Russia — not the Central Asian nations, which anyway have no stake; when India became a member the happiest was Russia, and now an India–China–Russia triangle is emerging within SCO.
- And when China played the card of Pakistan, the happiest about Pakistan's entry is **China**, because China has found an all-weather partnership; so if Russia wanted India, China has also taken that leap in that direction — what more do you want?
- It is better than one player dominating: four players fighting; if four players keep fighting, the strategic balance always maintains — as is said for democracy also, it is always very important to have an opposition rather than a strong party with a strong leader.

These points are common for every platform that India is a member of; they are important for India's stakes in being a member of the **UN Security Council**.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Write India's importance for SCO nations with the same heads — GP, GE, GC and GS — and note in brackets that India became a member in 2017.
> - PYQ to write: 'More than India needing SCO, it is SCO that needs India' — critically analyse with examples.
> - India's membership transforms SCO into an Asian organisation (it brings in the IOR) and expands its reach and profile.
> - India carries enormous global political weight as leader of the Global South, a link between East and West and North and South, a member of Quad, BRICS, IBSA, BIMSTEC and the East Asia Summit, a nuclear power with an independent foreign policy.
> - India's membership strengthens claims of multipolarity because India partners with the US, Japan and the EU while engaging BRICS and SCO and maintaining strategic autonomy — transforming SCO from anti-West to non-West, plural and multipolar.

- India provides internal geopolitical balance, preventing Chinese dominance; Russia is the happiest about India's entry, China about Pakistan's, and an India–China–Russia triangle is emerging.
- These same points apply to any platform India joins, and to India's claim for a UN Security Council seat.

19.7 Importance of India for SCO: Geoeconomic and Geostrategic

In geoeconomics one can also write that India is trying to promote alternative payment systems like **UPI** — the promotion of UPI; UPI is India's **DPI** and it is an important metric.

19.7.1 The Geostrategic Dimension

- **Counter-terrorism experience** — India's neighbour is a rogue country and 70 years have passed dealing with them, so where else will such expertise be found? Where will one get an NSA like Mr. **Ajit Doval**? The experience and the weight he carries globally cannot be found anywhere: having been in the service in the 1960s and 1970s, he has thoroughly seen the framework of Pakistan; he is a taskmaster — only four hours of sleep, tough at work, ask anything; once he sits you down he will keep at it, and one cannot come before him with a lie, because he knows everything; SCO also respects such a person.
- This is expertise China does not have — how to counter terrorism on such a big scale; the human rights violations in Kashmir in 1947 were all led by the **Kabalis**, as the local dialect calls them.
- **India's engagement with Afghanistan** — India has historical connections, engagement because of developmental initiatives, knowledge of Afghan politics and institutional dynamics, and intelligence and information about the extremist organisations.
- Example: the **IC-814 Kandahar hijacking** — the whole RAW and the whole IB would have been involved; it was a slap; **Brajesh Mishra** was the National Security Advisor and the right hand of Mr. Vajpayee, and Mr. Doval was a single-handed influencer on the Prime Minister because he knows so much.
- At that time all the ministers were on one side and there was no talk with anyone; the CCS meetings were useless — there was only one man calling the shots; at such a time one requires one or two persons who are extremely intrinsically involved in all the engagement.
- The Prime Minister met the army head, the general, and the air force and the navy, and a Cabinet Committee on Security meeting was held, but 100 per cent of the briefing was given by the National Security Advisor to the Prime Minister.
- He is like the eyes, ears, kidney and pancreas — even a vestigial organ like the appendix — of the Prime Minister: that is the influence he has, and it is not influence but what he has built over the years because he has knowledge of all the events, so he could plan the strategic outcomes of any event that India does.
- **Rajnath Singh ji** is told what to say while someone else does the talking — that is the work he has done; that is what the IPS and experience give you: he was an IPS officer, worked hard in the field, had good experiences and knew it all, and the government wants people like you;

he will never stay out of fashion as long as the government is intact, because who would they replace him with — who will bring 15 years of field experience? Like Mr. **P.K. Mishra** and **Shaktikanta Das**, the ex-finance secretary and RBI governor, who know it all: such people are wanted by everyone.

- **Access to the Indian Ocean Region** — the landlocked CARs get access to the Indian Ocean region through India and thereby have reduced dependence on Russia-, China- and Pakistan-led maritime access.
- **India's maritime capabilities** — India's membership of SCO increases the strategic geography of SCO and enables the utilisation of India's capabilities in (1) addressing traditional and non-traditional security threats, where traditional is against a country and non-traditional is piracy, illegal, unreported and unregulated fishing and the use of maritime routes for drug trafficking; and (2) **MDA, maritime domain awareness**, with IFC-IOR in Gurgaon in brackets.
- **IFC-IOR** — the Information Fusion Centre for the Indian Ocean Region, in Gurgaon; all maritime knowledge and information about shipping and vessels comes to India there, from all the Central Asian nations.
- **Double-landlocked**: Uzbekistan is a double-landlocked nation, surrounded by nations which are all landlocked; only two double-landlocked nations exist in the world — one is Uzbekistan and the other was to be found out from the map, the answer offered being Mongolia, surrounded by China, which has the nine-dash line in the South China Sea; South Africa cannot be one.
- A very important source of a river is located in that country [as stated in lecture].

> **PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION**
>
> **The same template serves many questions.**
>
> - This is the template; the answer given here is the answer to **India's peaceful rise**, to why any regional block wants India, to the importance of India for the Quad, to the importance of India for Japan, and to India's claim to be a UN Security Council member along with its contributions to international peacekeeping forces.
> - Understand the framework: in IR, information has to be absorbed.

- **India's defence partnership with several SCO nations** — a separate point in geostrategic — which includes counter-terrorism drills, multi-force defence exercises, defence exchanges and military training, etc.
- India has one of the largest armed forces and a blue-water navy — everything is there.

19.7.2 The Geoeconomic Dimension

> **DATA & FACTS**
>
> **India's economic size.**
>
> - One of the top five economies of the world — a **1.7–1.8, almost 2 trillion dollar** economy [figures as stated in lecture].
> - With such consumption India is a market, and for the US, India is the market.

- **A massive alternative market** for crude oil, gas and critical and strategic minerals, as India is a major importer of crude oil and an approximately **2 trillion dollar** economy driven by domestic consumption — **60 per cent** of India's GDP is consumed by people; India's biggest strength is not exports; unlike China, India's strength is domestic consumption.
- **Reduce dependence on China** — as India is an alternative economic, infrastructure, technology and development partner, and thereby important for the economic diversification of SCO nations.
- The reason: these nations are dependent on China — China sells chowmein, semiconductors and tunnel boring machines, and all imports come from one country; if the nations are dependent on my exports, I can automatically tweak my tariffs and my policies to favour me, because I know you cannot go anywhere.
- Analogy: it is like saying that if I am the best current affairs teacher in the industry, I can tweak the prices as per my whims and fancies, because I know people have to come to me — but you also want to diversify; there has to be competition always in the market; there has to be somebody to hold a candle to me so that one can choose, and that will be an incentive for me to keep the price in check.
- As is always said, competition always needs to be there in the economy, and that leads to innovation — this is also the framework of the **Nobel Prize in economics** for the year that was last, where three scientists focused on the role of innovation in the West that propelled the Western nations far ahead in research; the study was primarily based on the UK as compared with other nations — why the **Industrial Revolution** took place there and how it spread to the other aspects of the world.
- **India's comparative advantages**, where India offers unique advantages and thereby economic opportunities — first, **information technology**, which is important for the digitisation of the SCO economy.
- **Pharmaceuticals** — there is no match in the world; it is important for affordable healthcare; when time is available after the preparation, after the Mains, one can go to Astana, Kazakhstan — flights go to **Almaty**, which is a tourist and relaxing place in Kazakhstan for all the Central Asian economies, as Shimla is for us; book the ticket in advance and relax for three to four days and explore.
- **DPI — digital public infrastructure**: it is scalable, low cost and thereby affordable, and it is very important for them; important for digital technologies.
- Kazakhstan offers the best and cheapest chocolates compared with Indian brands, though the brands there are not marketed as well — the chocolates are very tasty.
- **Startups**: an innovation ecosystem — what the US cannot give, India can give; India has space innovation, renewable energy and financial services.
- **Traditional medicine**: they also have it, but India can teach them; in the pursuit of medicines many animals have been made extinct there.
- All these areas are to be written — IT first, then diversification; it is important for digitisation.
- In geoeconomic importance, India's membership of the **International North–South Transport Corridor** can also be written.

QUICK REVISION

- In geoeconomics, India's promotion of alternative payment systems such as UPI — India's DPI — is a point to write.
- Geostrategic strengths of India: counter-terrorism experience (Ajit Doval), engagement with Afghanistan, access to the Indian Ocean Region, and maritime capabilities with MDA and IFC-IOR in Gurgaon.
- The IC-814 Kandahar hijacking is the example for intelligence and institutional depth; Brajesh Mishra and Mr. Doval shaped the response, and the whole briefing to the PM came from the NSA.
- The CARs gain Indian Ocean access through India; Uzbekistan is one of only two double-landlocked nations, the other offered as Mongolia [as stated in lecture].
- India's defence partnerships with SCO nations include counter-terrorism drills, multi-force exercises, defence exchanges and military training; India has one of the largest armed forces and a blue-water navy.
- India is one of the top five economies of the world — a 1.7–1.8, almost 2 trillion dollar economy — a massive alternative market, with 60 per cent of GDP driven by domestic consumption.
- India is an alternative economic, infrastructure, technology and development partner that lets SCO nations reduce dependence on China; comparative advantages are IT, pharma, DPI, startups and traditional medicine, with the Nobel Prize in economics framework on competition and innovation.
- The same template answers questions on India's peaceful rise, importance to regional blocks, the Quad, Japan and UN Security Council membership.

19.8 Importance of India for SCO: The Geocultural Dimension

- **Historical civilizational ties** — Indian traders travelled through the Eurasian caravan route (the caravan kept moving), which led to the transmission of ideas, of Buddhism and also of languages, along with people.
- Therefore **shared Buddhist heritage** with India, and therefore India is a **civilizational glue** that connects Central Asia, East Asia and South Asia — East Asia (China, Japan, Korea), Central Asia (the CAR republics) and South Asia (the SAARC nations); so three regions have India to connect them, because India is original Buddhism.
- **Islamic ties** — Eurasian linkages include Persian cultural influence and Sufi traditions.
- Then **Mughal–Timurid**: Babar was not Afghan — the Suris were Afghan; Babar was Mongolian on his mother's side and Turks on his father's side; Babar was born in the **Fergana Valley**, which is in Uzbekistan; and there are medieval trade routes along with important mosques in **Samarkand** and also in **Bukhara**.
- **India's soft power and cultural value** — soft power appeal, where in Central Asia there is popularity of Indian cinema, music, dance, yoga, cuisine (Mughlai cuisine) and education.
- Cuisine: they eat very little oil and basically eat rice and meat, while we eat oil, meat and, if

there is rice, we enjoy that too; the cuisine is different, but there is a demand for Indian food.

- They eat **maida**, not atta: they eat refined flour because they eat it in the form of bread — a piece of meat is put in a refined-flour bread with sesame, vegetables are added, and it is eaten that way, because meat alone cannot be consumed.
- We eat flat bread — roti; they eat bread: the moment one goes northwards from the Himalayas, as in J&K too, they do not consume roti but again the refined-flour bread; this is **lavash**, which is all roti; baker's bread, made by a baker, is also made of refined flour.
- The content is the same: the atta is kneaded and put inside a tandoor — the concept is the same; it is not made at home (they make it at home too, but there would be a local baker visited by a Central Asian family every morning); they buy the bread and eat it with an omelette or gosht — food practices which our culture glorifies, but we do not eat baker's bread.

Conclusion: India's membership gives SCO **global weight** plus strengthens **multipolarity**; it connects Eurasia with the IOR; and the IOR provides market, technology and opportunity for trade diversification and a civilizational connect with the Eurasian landmass.

QUICK REVISION

- Historical civilizational ties run through the Eurasian caravan route, which transmitted ideas, Buddhism and languages along with people.
- India's shared Buddhist heritage makes it a civilizational glue connecting East Asia, Central Asia and South Asia.
- Islamic ties include Persian cultural influence and Sufi traditions; the Mughal–Timurid link runs through Babar's Fergana Valley birth and the mosques of Samarkand and Bukhara.
- India's soft power rests on Indian cinema, music, dance, yoga, cuisine and education in Central Asia.
- Cuisine differs — they eat little oil, rice and meat on refined-flour bread (maida, not atta), while we eat flat bread — yet there is demand for Indian food.
- India's membership gives SCO global weight, strengthens multipolarity, connects Eurasia with the IOR, and supplies market, technology, trade diversification and a civilizational connect.

19.9 Strengths of the India–SCO Relationship and the Weaknesses to Follow

In the write-up, the strength and trends of the India–SCO relationship have to be given. The political importance should be written in brackets for any question that demands or highlights the declining importance of the India–SCO relationship, or, within SCO, the declining relevance of India, in the light of Chinese domination and the emergence of China–Pakistan cooperation.

This is a framework topic: it is the first time an IR topic and an IR body are being understood and opened up — it is a feel of how to open an IR topic. One bilateral relationship will be done in full, after which the pace will pick up, and for some topics tables may also be given; the write-up has to be prepared keeping this as a framework lecture.

19.9.1 The Strengths

- **Strategic congruence** on global issues — strengthening multipolarity, multilateralism, reform of the present world order (which is led by the West), increasing importance of peace and stability, respect for territorial sovereignty and reform of UN institutions, and respect for international rules and norms; the political strength is strong.
- **Civilizational and people-to-people ties**, which are based on the historical trade route, the Silk Route, then Buddhism and Islam, and India being a civilizational glue.
- **A strong bilateral relationship between India and the Central Asian Republics**, strategic partnerships with all of them, an India–Russia special relationship, along with strong ties with Iran.
- **Complementarity in economies** — the Central Asian Republics and Russia have energy resources, mineral resources, and critical and strategic minerals, while India has IT, pharma, health, education, DPI and agriculture, which leads to complementarity.
- India and Pakistan, and Bangladesh, have no complementarity, because they have the same infrastructure and the same main items — muslin, jute and textiles — which compete: now it is made in Bangladesh, then made in Vietnam, then made in Turkey, then made in India.

These broad strengths should be at the back of the head: strengths like geopolitical, geoeconomic and geostrategic — four words around it; it is full IR.

- The importance has comparatively **increased in the last 10 years** — it is very big.
- These are not weaknesses but strengths: whenever any person says that India does not have any role, or that India's relationship is declining in SCO, the answer is no — because India has strategic congruence, complementarity, civilizational links and good bilateral relationships, so there is no point in saying that the relationship has gone down the drain.

The most important, however, is weaknesses: the importance of SCO for India and of India for SCO has to be more diverse, because they are two different things and here both are discussed as one entity. The importance can also be quoted in strengths, which is up to the candidate, but if a question comes on strengths these points will be written to complete the 200 words.

A doubt raised in class was answered: an ambassador may not have known that last year a scheme was launched by the Government of India for **coal gasification** and contracts were invited — it was discussed in the prelims classes — but no public or private player has entered or launched that tender for coal gasification. An ambassador would have known the details, but who are they to praise us — India's IT sector does not need any review.

> **PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION**
>
> **Where the weaknesses go.**
>
> - Weaknesses are to be written where the question is on the **declining importance of SCO**, on a **critical analysis of SCO**, or on **SCO's aims and objectives** — that was a PYQ.

SCO and critical analysis implies that the initial aim and role that were seen are first written, and then whether it has been achieved — yes or no; it has not been achieved because of these aspects. So that question has to be more tilted towards the issues or weaknesses of SCO, and that question

will be written.

QUICK REVISION

- The write-up needs the strengths and trends of the India–SCO relationship, with political importance in brackets for questions on declining importance or India's declining relevance amid Chinese domination and China–Pakistan cooperation.
- This is a framework topic — the first opening-up of an IR body; later bilaterals will be in full gas and some topics may come with tables.
- Strengths: strategic congruence on global issues (multipolarity, multilateralism, reform of the world order and UN institutions, sovereignty, peace and stability, rules and norms).
- Strengths: civilizational and P2P ties (Silk Route, Buddhism, Islam, civilizational glue); a strong bilateral relationship with the CARs, Russia and Iran; and economic complementarity between Central Asian energy and minerals and Indian IT, pharma, health, education, DPI and agriculture.
- India and Pakistan or Bangladesh have no complementarity — same infrastructure and competing muslin, jute and textiles.
- The relationship's importance has increased in the last 10 years; the alleged decline is rebutted by strategic congruence, complementarity, civilizational links and good bilaterals.
- Weaknesses were deferred for the next class; they go into questions on the declining importance of SCO, on critical analysis, and on SCO's aims and objectives (a PYQ).
- A class doubt on coal gasification was answered — no public or private player has entered the tender, and India's IT sector needs no review.

CHAPTER 20

The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) — Part 3

20.1 Issues in the SCO: The Overall Frame

The SCO is connected with the Central Asian Republics — if you know the SCO, you automatically also know the Central Asian Republics. With that link settled, the discussion turns to what is wrong with the organisation.

- The issues that come up first are **domination by Russia and China** and the connected problem of **connectivity**.
- Second, when an organisation expands, the original motto of that organisation loses relevance.
- India was not a big fan of the expansion of BRICS, because that expansion was led by Russia and China.
  - Russia and China are the countries that require global weight; India does not require gratification, affirmation or review.
  - China wants to spend its influence and make BRI the main tool of strategic heft or a strategic weapon; it wanted to increase the membership of BRICS.
- There are therefore internal discords and internal disagreements inside these groupings.
- There is also a disconnect between the nations: bilateral disputes end up becoming a major concern for cooperation in these organisations — India and Pakistan being the standing example.
- The SCO is a forum dominated by Russia and China, and there is also the recent emergence of the Pakistan–China access.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **The reputational trap of staying away.**
>
> - If India does not go, it is branded the perpetrator of global peace — a country that does not believe in multilateral organisations.
> - If countries like India start boycotting the international summits of an organisation such as the SCO, that means the SCO itself is an organisation riddled with divisions — the same charge is now made against NATO and against the G7.

QUICK REVISION

- The two headline problems of the SCO are Russia–China domination and connectivity.
- Expansion dilutes an organisation's original motto; India was wary of a BRICS expansion led by Russia and China.
- Bilateral disputes and internal discord turn into cooperation problems — India–Pakistan is the standing example.
- India's absence from a summit is read as disbelief in multilateral organisations, and it labels the organisation itself as divided — the charge now faced by NATO and the G7.
- The SCO is a forum dominated by Russia and China, with the recent emergence of the Pakistan–China access.

20.2 Domination by Russia and China

The first issue is domination by Russia and China — the structural feature of the SCO that shapes every other problem.

- **Russian domination** — the basis is history and geography.
  - The four Central Asian Republics are erstwhile USSR colonies, and therefore the strategic backyard of Russia.
- **Chinese domination** — the basis is design.
  - China wishes to transform the SCO into a China-led multilateral forum and to fulfil its strategic and geo-economic interests.
  - Example: using the SCO for **BRI expansion**.
- China wants the SCO to become a China-led organisation.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

SCO Bank — announced at the 2025 summit.

- At the 2025 SCO summit [as stated in lecture: the 'T-engine' 2025 summit], China announced the plan for an **SCO Bank**.
- China will be ruling the roost in the SCO Bank, so the ambition of transforming the SCO into a China-led organisation shows up in the institution itself.
- Russia, by contrast, wants to rule the roost through its own claim — that the four Central Asian Republics are its backyard.

So the great-power relationship inside the SCO is not simple rivalry; it is cooperation and competition at the same time.

COMPARISON

Two dominances in one forum.

- Russian domination rests on the colonial past — the four Central Asian Republics were USSR colonies and are still Russia's strategic backyard.
- Chinese domination rests on ambition — China wishes to transform the SCO into a China-led

multilateral forum for its strategic and geo-economic interests, BRI expansion being the example.

QUICK REVISION

- The first issue is domination by Russia and China.
- Russian domination is explained by the four Central Asian Republics being erstwhile USSR colonies — Russia's strategic backyard.
- Chinese domination is explained by China's wish to convert the SCO into a China-led multilateral forum serving its strategic and geo-economic interests.
- China wants to use the SCO for BRI expansion.
- At the 2025 SCO summit China announced the plan for an SCO Bank, and China will rule the roost in it.
- Russia and China therefore cooperate and compete simultaneously for influence — each calls the region its backyard.

20.3 Bilateral Disputes Hampering Cooperation

The second issue is bilateral disputes, which have hampered cooperation between the nations.

- **India–China**: the boundary dispute along the **Line of Actual Control (LAC)** and over **BRI**, because **CPEC** passes through Pakistan-occupied Kashmir.
  - Added to this are the weaponization of the supply chain and the dumping of exports — the two very big problems for India.
- **India–Pakistan**: historical cross-border support to terrorism, and cross-border terrorism in Jammu and Kashmir, Punjab and other areas.
  - Pakistan is the historical supporter, and is responsible for proxy terrorism in Punjab.
- Because these disputes exist between India–China and India–Pakistan, cooperation has been limited.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Important — write this down.

- The SCO summit shall be held in Pakistan in 2027 [as stated in lecture].
- Marked in the lecture as an important pointer to be written down in brackets.

QUICK REVISION

- Bilateral disputes have hampered cooperation between the SCO nations.
- India–China: boundary dispute along the LAC and over BRI, because CPEC passes through Pakistan-occupied Kashmir.
- Weaponization of supply chains and dumping of exports are two very big problems for India.
- India–Pakistan: historical cross-border support to terrorism in Jammu and Kashmir, Punjab

and other areas, and proxy terrorism.

- Limited cooperation has been the result; the summit is to be held in Pakistan in 2027 [as stated in lecture].

20.4 Lack of Consensus on Afghanistan

There is a lack of consensus regarding Afghanistan. The lecture breaks this into three parts: how to engage with the Taliban, the Taliban's absence from SCO summits, and the objection of Tajikistan.

20.4.1 How to Engage with the Taliban

- There is a lack of consensus on how to engage with the Taliban; the example given is that only Russia has recognized the Taliban regime.
- There is simply no clarity on how to engage with Afghanistan.

EXAMPLE

Geopolitics has no permanent friends — the Bangladesh case.

- In geopolitics you have no friends, no enemies and no frenemies: today's friend is tomorrow's enemy, and today's enemy is tomorrow's friend.
- Best example — Bangladesh: while Sheikh Hasina was Prime Minister it was the model relationship any country could have with its neighbourhood; the moment she was ousted and the power struggle began, it became the worst relationship.
- India took retaliatory measures: the access was stopped, the transshipment access for exports coming from Bangladesh was stopped, and Indian ports did not allow the transshipment service.

- Historical origin of the problem: when the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan took place, the US government supplied arms and weapons to the fringe elements to fight the communists.
  - Those fringe elements actually came from Pakistan — the Taliban, basically a religious organisation.
- After ten years the communists left that country, and then the mayhem began in Afghanistan; the Taliban turned on the US.
  - That chain produced the 2001 Al-Qaeda attacks of 9/11 — the lecture day was itself the anniversary, 11 September.
- So the Russians had led to the rise of the Taliban, and they were complete enemies. Geopolitics has now changed.
  - Russia wants to engage with Afghanistan and wants to maintain a stable presence there, which is why it is now engaging with the Taliban regime.
  - Russia has become the first country in the world to actually recognize the Taliban.

DATA & FACTS

The Afghanistan chain as taught.

- 1979 — the Soviet invasion; the US supplied arms and weapons to fringe elements that were

actually from Pakistan, to fight the communists.

- 1988–89 — after ten years the communists left, the mayhem began, and the Taliban turned on the US.
- 2001 — the Al-Qaeda attacks of 9/11 (the class was held on the anniversary, 11 September).

20.4.2 Recognition, Ripple Effects and the Afghan Neighbourhood

- With the Taliban becoming recognized, there is a ripple effect for the Taliban: all the Central Asian Republics will automatically be following through.
  - The younger brother always takes his step after watching the elder brother — however much they diversify, the four Central Asian Republics will end up becoming the younger brother of Russia.
- On the map of Central Asia, all five CARs except Kyrgyzstan and Kazakhstan have a border with Afghanistan — a very important trajectory for this organisation.

20.4.3 Taliban Representation at SCO Summits

- There is limited Taliban representation at SCO summits, because the Taliban is not invited.
  - Therefore there is limited cooperation with the incumbent Taliban regime, which might create regional security implications.
- The solution offered is an incentive design: tell the Taliban that we are recognizing you, we are engaging with you, and we want you to be a part of the SCO.
  - That becomes an incentive for the Taliban to shun any such practice that attracts international disdain.

EXAMPLE

Recognition buys behaviour — the Syria analogy.

- The best example is Syria: the Syrian President, who was the head of Jabhat al-Nusra, is now President Ahmed al-Shara.
- The US President called him 'the best man I have', 'the best Syrian I have ever met' and 'a very nice boy'.
- He wants global recognition, and slowly and slowly the world is responding — Syrian development is dependent on recognition.

- The bait for Afghanistan: if you want development there — no extremism, no separatism, no terrorism and no misuse of the Afghan soil — you have to give the Taliban a bait.
  - Call them, feed them pulao and explain patiently: leave your old policies, run your country properly.
  - If you cannot bring democracy, take such steps as protect civil rights; call foreigners into your country and show them that there is security.
  - Then recognition will come to you automatically — and a start has already been made.

20.4.4 *Tajikistan and the Limits of Consensus*

- Tajikistan — which sits at the topmost point of the Wakhan Corridor — is not a big follower of recognizing the Taliban regime.
- Since Tajikistan is not agreeing while Russia has taken a great step in that direction, the lack of consensus has become a major problem.
- This limits cooperation with the SCO: India has been a part of the SCO precisely to get its concerns about the Taliban regime addressed — to know what is happening.
  - Otherwise there would be **FOMO**, and this FOMO will get reflected in failure.
- **FOMO** — the fear of missing out on what is happening in the region.
- Afghanistan is described as India's backyard, just as POK is taken to be a part of India's territory [as stated in lecture].

QUICK REVISION

- Lack of consensus on Afghanistan: on how to engage the Taliban — only Russia has recognized the regime; there is no clarity.
- The Taliban is not invited, so Taliban representation at SCO summits is limited, which limits cooperation with the incumbent regime.
- The incentive argument: recognition and an SCO place would push the Taliban to shun practices that attract international disdain (the Syria analogy).
- Historical chain: 1979 Soviet invasion and US arms to Pakistan-based fringe elements; 1988–89 communist exit and mayhem; 2001 the 9/11 attacks.
- Russia, once the Taliban's enemy, is now the first country to recognize the regime; the four CARs are expected to follow.
- Tajikistan's refusal is the practical block; Afghanistan is an observer with Mongolia, and all five CARs except Kyrgyzstan and Kazakhstan border Afghanistan.

20.5 Lack of Consensus over the Belt and Road Initiative

The next point of disagreement recorded is over BRI itself.

- India opposes BRI and is the only member of the SCO that has not signed it.
- In 2023, when India hosted the summit, India refused to join the other members on the paragraphs relating to BRI.
- The other members are full-on gaga over BRI — they get investment, they get transport and they get better connectivity. For India it is a sensitive matter, a touchy matter, a very sensitive concern.
- So there is a lack of consensus over BRI, and this limits cooperation on connectivity.

KEY CONCEPT

PM Modi's formulation.

- **Connectivity should not violate sovereignty.**

QUICK REVISION

- India is the only SCO member that has not signed BRI.
- At the 2023 summit India hosted, India refused to join the other members on the BRI paragraphs.
- Other members gain investment, transport and better connectivity from BRI; for India it is a sensitive and touchy matter.
- The lack of consensus over BRI limits cooperation on connectivity.
- PM Modi's test: connectivity should not violate sovereignty.

20.6 Lack of Consensus over English as a Formal Language

The second consensus issue recorded is the language in which the SCO keeps its counter-terrorism records.

DATA & FACTS

Bishkek — English accepted as a formal language.

- Russian and Mandarin were used to maintain the terror-related database.
- Recently accepted at Bishkek: English has now been accepted as a formal language for maintaining that database — a very happy moment.

- The reasoning behind the Indian demand: if all the terrorist data is in Mandarin or Russian, translators have to be arranged first, and information sharing then becomes difficult.
- The documents in question are documents of the highest security; if the information to be shared with me is not in my local language, sharing in it becomes a concern.
  - This is why English was India's need.

QUICK REVISION

- Russian and Mandarin were the languages of the SCO's terror-related database.
- Recently accepted at Bishkek: English as a formal language for maintaining the database.
- Reason: without a shared language, translators must be arranged first, so information sharing becomes difficult.
- Highest-security documents not available in one's own language make sharing a concern — hence India's need for English.

20.7 Expansion and the Consensus-Building Problem

The next issue is that the expansion of the SCO has further complicated consensus building.

- Consensus building is not such a big concern where the Iran–Russia–China trio is involved.
  - These three have a very strong sense of relationship.
  - India has historical civilizational ties with Persia (but not with Israel and other Arab nations), so India is also comfortable if Iranians become part of it.

  - Belarus — Lukashenko is basically a stooge of Putin, so that does not matter much.
- The more serious problem is how India and Pakistan need to strike a balance and a consensus.
- The general rule: **too many cooks spoil the broth** — too many members obviously make consensus formation a concern.

EXAMPLE

The BRICS summit test for India.

- The coming week matters — Friday, Saturday and Sunday, a three-day BRICS summit.
- If India is able to forge consensus, then the Pakistani achievement post-Sindoor of having the role of a mediator will receive a sordid reply, a sordid slap.
- If India is able to make a declaration come out that is accepted by UAE and Saudi Arabia, along with acceptance by Iran, that would be the first summit of BRICS.

- In the SCO the only claimant pair is India–Pakistan, which is the smaller issue, and India–Pakistan stakes are comparatively lower than Russia–China stakes.
  - But this BRICS summit is the first where both will sit, and when both sit, consensus is your chair and your chairmanship — you have to get the agreement signed.

EXAMPLE

Kazan 2024 — a multilateral forum as a thawing platform.

- At the 2024 BRICS summit in Kazan, Russia repeatedly made its case: if my war is in Ukraine I am not responsible — Ukrainians and NATO are responsible for building an umbrella around my country; do not trouble my area; if you talk of giving nuclear weapons and making me part of NATO and the EU, it would be a problem for me, which is why I launched the special operation.
- Russia's credentials were also displayed: 'I got the disengagement process done between the world's biggest goons, China and India.'
- That made Russia the feather in the cap of BRICS — proof that a multilateral organisation could help thaw the relationship between Mr Modi and Mr Xi Jinping.

- These are platforms for engagement, but at the same point, if you have too many players then consensus also becomes tougher to achieve.
- If India is able to achieve in BRICS what it did in the G20, it will be a big thing.
  - In the G20, India made the AU a part of the grouping; the smile carried by the AU chairman reflects how India is an important leader of the Global South.
  - Africa is even more interesting compared to Central Asia — again there is great power involvement, with different powers behaving differently.

QUICK REVISION

- Expansion of the SCO has further complicated consensus building.
- The Iran–Russia–China trio is a strong relationship, and India is comfortable with Iran because of its historical civilizational ties with Persia; Belarus follows Putin.

- The real difficulty is the India–Pakistan balance.
- Too many members make consensus formation a concern — too many cooks spoil the broth.
- The three-day BRICS summit is the immediate test; consensus there is the chair's responsibility (Kazan 2024 showed Russia using the forum that way).
- India's G20 precedent with the AU shows what a consensus outcome can deliver.

20.8 Shift in Primary Focus: From Geo-Security to Geo-Economy

There has been a shift in the primary focus of the SCO.

- The Shanghai Five was formed in 1996, and in 1996 — or, let us say, 2001 — an SCO on connectivity could not have been thought of.
  - The break-up of the USSR had just been seen; new ethnic states were emerging; there were new probabilities of the emergence of a security concern.
- So the orientation began with security, and there has been a shift from security towards trade and connectivity.
- Economic security automatically guarantees political might and right — gone are the days after the Second World War and in the 50–60 years that followed, when the number of weapons, the number of missiles, the number of aircraft carriers and the number of space missions decided your might.
  - Today it is not simply 'might is right'; it is economic might, it is technological might, it is artificial-intelligence-related might that is right. No connotation is being attached to whether this is right or wrong — only the shift is being described.
- This shift is exactly what was visible in the aims and objectives of the SCO taught earlier — there is a shift towards trade and connectivity.

KEY CONCEPT

'I started with geo-security and it has given way to geo-economy.'

QUICK REVISION

- The Shanghai Five was formed in 1996; connectivity was unthinkable then, because of the fresh break-up of the USSR and emerging security concerns.
- The SCO began with security and has shifted towards trade and connectivity.
- Economic security is what now guarantees political might and right.
- The post-Second World War metric — weapons, missiles, aircraft carriers, space missions — no longer decides might.
- The new might is economic, technological and artificial-intelligence-related.
- The shift is visible in the aims and objectives of the SCO.

20.9 Expansion and Consensus Formation on Security and Geopolitical Issues

The first effect of expansion is the expansion-related difficulty in consensus formation on security and geopolitical issues.

- Hard power is not like trade. When you want to cooperate with me on trade, we will hold hands — India and China are cooperating on trade and are willing to hold hands.
  - But were we able to give China a reply after the LAC crisis? We cannot.
  - For a violation of the Line of Actual Control, or a violation of my sovereignty, I will be talking on a different tangent with all of you; you want to do trade, I would be slightly mellow.
- So when you sit as an SCO member with so many SCO nations — 10 of them — finding commonalities over connectivity is easy.
  - If a better road is being built, my opponent and I both want to be in it; the rules rule for everyone.
- So on security matters you cannot just be negotiating; you want to keep your position hard and smart.
- When expanding, remember that India and Iran can cooperate for the next 1,000 years on Chabahar,
  - but on hard security and on engaging with Iran over the security of seafarers and access to the Strait of Hormuz, it is a tricky affair to navigate.

CRITICAL POINT

Why hard security cannot be negotiated like trade.

- Connectivity is a shared good: if a better road is built, even competitors use it.
- But when it comes to revenue from the students, strategies are not shared and there is no collaboration — there is competition, and either we fight or we lose the competition.
- The same logic runs through security: you cannot keep negotiating, you keep your position hard and smart — which is why an expanded SCO finds consensus hardest exactly on security and geopolitical questions.

QUICK REVISION

- Expansion makes consensus on security and geopolitical issues harder.
- Trade is where rivals hold hands — India and China cooperate on trade — but the LAC crisis shows the limit of that cooperation.
- A violation of the LAC or of sovereignty shifts India to a different tangent; on trade India is mellow.
- With 10 SCO nations, connectivity commonalities are easy because everyone gains from a better road.
- On security, negotiation is not enough — the position must be kept hard and smart.

- Chabahar cooperation with Iran can run for a thousand years, but seafarer security and access to the Strait of Hormuz are tricky to navigate.

20.10 Effect of the Russia–Ukraine War

The second effect is that of the Russia–Ukraine war: there is a before 2022, and there is an after.

Russia's stance on SCO economic initiatives	Reluctant to support them, because of the disproportionate benefit for China and the increased strategic advantage of China	Post-war sanctions and financial and payment hurdles have increased Russia's dependence on China — as a market for Russian goods, the best example being Russian oil

20.10.1 The Discounted Oil Windfall — and India's Import Dependence

- Russia was willing to sell oil at a discount in 2022–2023, and India minted the oil marketing companies.
  - They were sitting on a heap of dollars — that heap was the saving India got because the Russians were willing to sell oil at a discount.
  - If somebody is giving a discount of 50–60 per cent on the per-barrel cost of oil, who would want to stop?
- The uncomfortable part: instead of diversifying oil supplies and boosting domestic consumption, India's dependence on foreign crude oil has increased. What a shame.

DATA & FACTS

Numbers to carry into the answer.

- Russian oil discount: 50 per cent on oil prices in 2022–2023 (elsewhere stated as a 50–60 per cent discount on the per-barrel cost).
- India imports 90 per cent of its crude oil, and that import percentage has itself increased.
- Six to seven years back the figure was 85–86 per cent; it is now 89–90 per cent.

20.10.2 Where the Advantage Finally Went

- The Russians came to India's rescue, and Russia also found a stable economic partner in China.
  - Russia's luck was bad: the dominance in Eurasia went to Russia, but in a way the advantage went to China.
  - China has no need to buy anything; China has made Putin its servant [as stated in lecture].

20.10.3 The West Asia Laboratory

- The same thing is happening in West Asia today: the US getting entangled in a war with Iran is a visible laboratory for China.
  - China is seeing all the Tomahawks, all the Javelins, and the millions of dollars for each missile that is getting lost in the rubble.
  - A missile costing $2,000,000 is being destroyed by a counter-drone costing $20,000–25,000; Iran's technology is 100 times cheaper than that of the US — and who is taking the benefit of all this? China.
- Suddenly, when the US as the largest power and Russia as the traditional power are both involved, China sits comfortably and watches the spectacle.
- And China says: I am the country in the world which believes in multilateralism, which believes in multipolarity, which believes in global rules and order, and which believes in having a new global initiative for governance and development.
  - China tells all countries that the others are donkeys: the world order they led — the IMF, the World Bank, the UN institutions — is all led by the West.
  - Come and join my Global Development Initiative; come, hold my hands and be a part of the Belt and Road Initiative; I will show you the way to the future.

COMPARISON

China's West Asia footprint versus the US's.

- China's presence: trivial things like Kyaukphyu, Chittagong, Hambantota and Gwadar — there is no comparison at all, because China has no stakes there, no armed-power stakes, no base, no weaponization, nothing.
- The US presence: air bases and naval bases strewn across the entire West Asian part of the world.
- The comparison is nevertheless favourable to China, because strategic silence costs China nothing while the US pays for every missile.

- Sometimes, if you do not do anything, strategic silence and strategic ambiguity also end up turning the tide in your favour.

KEY CONCEPT

Strategic silence and strategic ambiguity are themselves instruments — that is the advantage China automatically got.

- So when they came to you, you also will not just be one-sided: you sold BRI, and thereby the security focus has completely declined.
  - The focus now is on trade and connectivity.

QUICK REVISION

- Effect of the Russia–Ukraine war: before 2022, Russia was reluctant on economic initiatives because they benefited and strengthened China disproportionately.

- After 2022, sanctions and payment hurdles increased Russia's dependence on China as a market — the best example being Russian oil.
- Russian oil came at a 50 per cent discount in 2022–2023 (50–60 per cent on the per-barrel cost); India's oil marketing companies sat on a heap of dollars.
- India imports 90 per cent of its crude; six to seven years ago the figure was 85–86 per cent, and it is now 89–90 per cent.
- Russia got Eurasian dominance, China got the advantage; China has made Putin its servant [as stated in lecture].
- The West Asia war is a laboratory for China — $2,000,000 missiles destroyed by $20,000–25,000 counter-drones, with Iran's technology 100 times cheaper than the US's.
- China's pitch is multilateralism, multipolarity and the Global Development Initiative; strategic silence and strategic ambiguity cost it nothing, and the focus of the SCO has tipped towards trade and connectivity.

20.11 Lack of Tangible Enforcement of Counter-Terrorism

There is also a lack of tangible enforcement and effective implementation of counter-terrorism.

- **RATS** is itself an advantage for you to be a part of this organisation — but RATS also has got inherent problems.
  - It is not a pearl or a gem that it has laid out everything; it itself has got limited capabilities to address counter-terrorism.
  - There is limited information sharing and coordination with respect to counter-terrorism.
- PM Modi says this again and again because terrorism affects the entire region.

KEY CONCEPT

Keyword to write down.

- **RATS** — the SCO's counter-terrorism structure (the lecture uses only the acronym [as stated in lecture]).
- Being a member of the mechanism is itself an advantage, but the mechanism's limited capabilities and limited information sharing are the gap the lecture highlights.

QUICK REVISION

- There is a lack of tangible enforcement and effective implementation of counter-terrorism.
- RATS is an advantage for members, but it is not a pearl or a gem that solves everything.
- Its capability to address terrorism is limited, and information sharing and coordination are limited.
- PM Modi repeatedly raises counter-terrorism because terrorism affects the entire region.

20.12 Divergent Interests on Connectivity

There are divergent interests on connectivity inside the SCO.

- **BRI-led connectivity is discarded by India** because of the sovereignty violation involved [as stated in lecture: 'HPEC'].
- China and Pakistan carry big strategic cards: you want to cooperate with me, I am willing to cooperate, but you must cooperate with me with respect to the Belt and Road Initiative.
  - So if China and Pakistan are cooperating, they want cooperation on BRI — without BRI there is no cooperation.
- India is against BRI, whereas the other Central Asian nations are willing for as many connectivity opportunities as you want to have.
  - You want BRI? No problems. You want the International North-South Transport Corridor? No problems.
- Pakistan is in absolute disagreement, because it very well knows that the International North-South Transport Corridor is the best example of bypassing Pakistan.
  - And if it bypasses Pakistan, that automatically becomes a bypassing of Pakistan and China's access.
- Except Pakistan and China, all other SCO members — especially the C-A-Rs — have sought greater cooperation on bilateral and multilateral agreements.

India	Opposes BRI; the only SCO member that has not signed it, and refused to join the BRI paragraphs at the 2023 summit it hosted	Supports it; has proposed the inclusion of Chabahar port in the International North-South Transport Corridor
Central Asian Republics	Willing for as many connectivity opportunities as are offered — BRI is no problem	No problem; they have sought greater cooperation through bilateral and multilateral agreements
China and Pakistan	Condition all cooperation on BRI — without BRI there is no cooperation	Pakistan is in absolute disagreement, because the corridor bypasses Pakistan and therefore China's access too

20.12.1 The Chabahar Trilateral Grouping and the INSTC Eastern Route

- Example: the **Chabahar trilateral grouping** between Iran, India and Uzbekistan, which seeks to link the eastern route of the International North-South Transport Corridor with Chabahar.
  - This eastern route lies east of the Caspian Sea and includes Kazakhstan, then Turkmenistan, and then Iran.

- The geography as drawn in class: Bombay/Mumbai to Bandar Abbas, and from Bandar Abbas towards Russia, is the International North-South Transport Corridor.
  - Chabahar sits near the Persian Gulf; the second line is the eastern line, running from Iran to Turkmenistan and finally to Kazakhstan.
  - Zahedan is in Iran; above Zahedan is Turkmenistan, and above that is Kazakhstan.
  - So the entire Eurasian connectivity comes into Chabahar, and linking Chabahar to it will create an emerging connectivity nexus.

DATA & FACTS

Distance to quote.

- The eastern route from Chabahar is approximately **900 km**.

20.12.2 *Pakistan's Geography and the Caspian Sea*

- Pakistan will not agree to this. If Pakistan is joined to the picture, the sequence runs: Balochistan, Karachi, Gwadar, then Pasni — the port Pakistan is talking of giving — then Chabahar, then Bandar Abbas.

DATA & FACTS

Caspian Sea — facts as stated.

- The Caspian Sea is the largest sea or lake in the world — it is basically a lake: the largest lake in the world, and also the largest, saltiest lake in the world.
- The largest freshwater lake in the world by area is Lake Superior; by volume it is Lake Baikal.
- Lake Baikal is the deepest lake in the world.

20.12.3 *India's Proposal: Chabahar Port in the INSTC and the Shahid Beheshti Terminal*

- Connectivity here is one of the areas, and it is connectivity because of the strategic push that has been given by BRI.
- A parliamentary standing committee [as stated in lecture: 'Ministry of Parliamentary Affairs Standing Committee'] says that it is dual purpose — a strategic benefit.
- India has proposed the inclusion of Chabahar port in the International North-South Transport Corridor.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Shahid Beheshti — the terminal India is building.

- A terminal is what you build — railway station platforms, airport terminals; a port also has terminals.
- The port is being built by the Indian government, and that terminal at Chabahar is called **Shahid Beheshti**.

QUICK REVISION

- BRI-led connectivity is discarded by India because of the sovereignty violation involved [as

stated in lecture: 'HPEC'].

- China and Pakistan condition cooperation on BRI; without BRI there is no cooperation.
- India opposes BRI while the Central Asian Republics welcome every connectivity option, BRI included.
- Pakistan rejects the INSTC outright, because the INSTC is the best example of bypassing Pakistan — and therefore China's access.
- The Chabahar trilateral grouping (Iran–India–Uzbekistan) links Chabahar with the eastern route of the INSTC, east of the Caspian Sea through Kazakhstan, Turkmenistan and Iran.
- The eastern route from Chabahar is about 900 km; the Caspian is the largest (and largest salty) lake in the world, with Superior largest in freshwater area and Baikal largest by volume and depth.
- India has proposed Chabahar port's inclusion in the INSTC, and the terminal India is building there is Shahid Beheshti.

20.13 Recent Issues

The issues list closes with two recent developments.

- Number one: the SCO is perceived as anti-West — in brackets it is referred to as an **association of autocrats**.
- They are all autocrats except India.
  - Iran is a theocracy — who gets elected, and how the Supreme Leader is elected, nobody knows.
  - Russia is known to everyone.
  - The Central Asian Republics, Tajikistan among them, have had the same president for 15–20 years.
  - China has one party, and whatever is decided in its primary meeting is what happens.
  - Belarus has Lukashenko.
- India, by contrast, came by winning elections — everyone was sat together, seen together, and developed together.
- The label 'association of autocrats' is therefore tougher for India to carry.

DATA & FACTS

Bishkek declaration and the accession timeline.

- The recent Bishkek declaration (year 2026) criticizing US–Israel attacks on Iran was agreed by India, thereby creating a diplomatic challenge.
- Only recently has the SCO looked like this: Iran was added in 2023 and Belarus (Lukashenko) in 2024 — three to four years [as stated in lecture: 'from 2017'].

- The double standard to note: India did not criticize the US attack on Iran even once, yet when the Bishkek declaration came, India agreed to it.
  - That is what makes the perception problem a diplomatic challenge rather than a mere

label.

- Number two: increasing Pakistan–China cooperation has restricted the strategic space of engagement for India, and India's connectivity ambitions along with it.
  - Also, covert Chinese support to shield Pakistan-sponsored terrorism has further made the region — South Asia and Central Asia — prone to terrorism and extremism.

QUICK REVISION

- Recent issue one: the SCO is perceived as anti-West and called an association of autocrats.
- The autocrat charge runs against Iran's theocracy, Russia, the long-serving Central Asian presidents, China's one party and Belarus's Lukashenko — India is the exception.
- The label is tougher for India to carry.
- The Bishkek declaration (2026) criticizing US–Israel attacks on Iran was agreed by India, though India never criticized the US attack on Iran itself.
- Iran joined in 2023 and Belarus in 2024, so these issues are only three to four years old.
- Recent issue two: rising Pakistan–China cooperation has shrunk India's strategic space and connectivity ambitions, and covert Chinese support shields Pakistan-sponsored terrorism, making South and Central Asia prone to extremism.

20.14 Afghanistan, Observers and Points Noted for Later

Closing the issues discussion, the lecture records a few structural points about membership, disputes and developments that belong elsewhere.

- The SCO does not have Afghanistan as a member: it is only an observer, along with Mongolia.
- Regional security metrics will get more complicated, because one observer and one member are entangled in a bilateral dispute, which will affect the objective of ensuring regional security and stability.
- In the aftermath of the Taliban — and in the aftermath of 1991 — the hotbed of extremism has been Afghanistan.
- Because of the bilateral relationships between India–Pakistan and India–China–Pakistan, the cooperation of the SCO as a platform has got affected.
- Kazakhstan being a signatory to the Abraham Accord is only a certification of the point that it is willing for diversification of its foreign policy — how that diversification is happening will be written up with the Central Asian Republics.

KEY CONCEPT

Noted, but not for this topic.

- The Makkah Pact — the Saudi Arabia Mutual Defence Agreement (SMDS) signed last year — has to be seen with the lens of the increasing role of Pakistan.
- This development is not very important with respect to the SCO topic; it will be taken up with the Central Asian Republics and expanded to 200–300 words so that an answer can be written.

- Just know the developments — after the CARs, some other topics will be discussed and then these points will be picked up.
- There is no wish to venture too much into Central Asia here, because the discussion is eventually on the SCO.

QUICK REVISION

- Afghanistan is not an SCO member — it is only an observer, along with Mongolia.
- Regional security metrics get more complicated because one observer and one member are caught in a bilateral dispute.
- Post-1991 and post-Taliban, Afghanistan has been the hotbed of extremism.
- India–Pakistan and India–China–Pakistan relations have affected cooperation on the SCO platform.
- Kazakhstan signing the Abraham Accord signals foreign-policy diversification, to be studied with the Central Asian Republics.
- The Makkah Pact / SMDS is to be read against Pakistan's rising role, and is deferred to the Central Asian Republics discussion.

20.15 Way Forward: Strategies for Improving the India–SCO Relationship

KEY CONCEPT

What the way forward means.

- **Way forward** means strategies for improving the India–SCO relationship.
- The method: invert the weaknesses, or frame the suggestions along the geopolitical, geocultural, geostrategic and geoeconomic parameters.
- Keep in mind what the PM has said — there should be no double speak on terrorism, on connectivity and on civilizational dialogue; these three things have been said over the last two years, and the argument is to be woven around them.

20.15.1 Points Developed in Class

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Answer points that came up.

- India has DPI and connectivity to offer — a point worth making.
- Promote multilateralism, and minilateralism within it.
- Interact with the smaller countries; use sideline diplomacy.
- The main points to write are cooperation on connectivity and on terrorism.
- Dismantling terror, no double standards.

- Dismantling terror and no double standards: the SCO cannot keep talking; condemning Pahalgam or any other incident is not enough.

  - The time has come to step up and take action.
- Ensure that the SCO does not become an anti-West platform and prevent the domination of one or two countries.
  - That means promoting multipolarity within the SCO.
- A cautious, fearful approach is not required — but the engagement must be done in such a way that everyone feels it is a very good relationship, since the talk is of multilateralism and multipolarity.
- Do not be afraid of Afghanistan: organisationally the SCO does promote security, which is necessary for the region, so there is no problem; terrorism of course has to be addressed.
  - Nothing in the organisation is bad in itself — the problem is the politics around it, not the mandate.
- Use the soft path as well: Bollywood, UPI payments, P2P exchange and tourism.
- India should leverage its strengths to improve the relationship with the SCO; India has a **unique opportunity to promote reforms within the SCO**, as it is one of the few nations that can straddle North, South and East, West — it is a bridge.

20.15.2 Eight Points to Write in the Answer

1. Make the SCO a **security, connectivity and opportunity operational framework**, as the PM said.
2. Strengthen the SCO's role as a **counter-terrorism platform** and focus on the entire terror ecosystem — first finance, then recruitment, then radicalization, and then safe havens — together with the **rejection of double standards**.
3. Improve connectivity between Central Asia and South Asia through multilateral and bilateral connectivity projects — for example Chabahar, the International North-South Transport Corridor, and the Ashgabat Agreement.
4. Improve trade by promoting trade in local currencies, and promote alternative payment systems to reduce dependence on West-led payment systems.
5. Leverage India's strengths — DPI, health, education, pharma, IT, startups and skill infrastructure.
6. Promote civilizational dialogue or diplomacy, as mentioned by the PM at the 2025 summit [as stated in lecture: the 'T-engine' 2025 summit], and leverage India's soft power advantages — utilise the influence. Promote the fact that historical connections exist, as a rebuttal to what Pakistan has been saying for this region — that this is Islam and nothing else; connectivity is basically the umbilical cord — 'if you cut my umbilical cord, you cannot move ahead' [as stated in lecture].
7. Promote **minilateral arrangements** within the SCO — mini means small. Examples: India–Iran–Central Asia for connectivity; India–Russia–Central Asia for Eurasian connectivity or energy; India–Central Asia for counter-terrorism.
8. Prevent the SCO from becoming an anti-West block by increasing engagement with SCO-related institutional frameworks.

- Keyword to write down: **rejection of double standards** — it was carried on a newspaper

front page and had to be shown in the answer.

- Finally, ensure that the SCO transforms its vision into outcomes, or becomes project-centric — as remarked by the PM at the Bishkek 2026 SCO summit.
- India's role in this frame: leader of the Global South, promoter of world peace, and stabiliser of global politics.

QUICK REVISION

- Way forward means strategies for improving the India–SCO relationship.
- Frame it either by inverting the weaknesses or along the geopolitical, geocultural, geostrategic and geoeconomic parameters.
- Weave the argument around the PM's three statements: no double speak on terrorism, connectivity and civilizational dialogue.
- Points from class: DPI and connectivity, multilateralism with minilateralism, sideline diplomacy, cooperation on connectivity and terrorism, dismantling terror with no double standards.
- The eight measures run from making the SCO a security–connectivity–opportunity framework, to a counter-terrorism platform covering the whole terror ecosystem, to connectivity projects (Chabahar, INSTC, Ashgabat), local-currency trade, India's strengths, civilizational dialogue and soft power, minilateral arrangements, and stopping the SCO from becoming anti-West.
- End with vision to outcomes — project-centric delivery as remarked by the PM at the Bishkek 2026 summit — and with India as leader of the Global South, promoter of world peace and stabiliser of global politics.

CHAPTER 21

Central Asian Republics

21.1 Exam Relevance and PYQ Analysis

Central Asia, referred to as the Central Asian Republics, is studied as a region in the International Relations component of the syllabus.

- In civil services, questions may be asked indirectly on the importance of Central Asia, South Asia, Europe, Indo-Pacific, Indian Ocean region, Transatlantic cooperation and Trans-Pacific.
- One may question how there is a shift from Trans-Atlantic to Trans-Pacific.
  - That debate was thoroughly discussed in the first two classes of IR this year.
- This topic will also be reflected in Paper 1.
- Approach to the topic: when the topic is given in the evening, first contemplate it and look at the PYQs.
  - Reading the PYQs first makes you curious for the class.
  - The class itself is meant for revision.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

PYQ 2024 and Question Hints.

- Critically analyse India's evolving diplomatic, economic and strategic relations with Central Asian nations.
- Diplomatic: the diplomatic strategic partnership.
- Economic: the economic relationship, including 2 billion dollars of trade with Kazakhstan.
- Security: the security-based relationship — how to cooperate on security under the framework of the SCO, including military exercises.
- 3 to 4 questions came straight from the class, worth 10 to 12 marks.
- Another question: Discuss the implications of BRI in China [as stated in lecture].

QUICK REVISION

- Central Asia is examined indirectly through the region's importance, alongside South Asia, Europe, Indo-Pacific, Indian Ocean region, Transatlantic cooperation and Trans-Pacific.
- PYQ 2024: critically analyse India's evolving diplomatic, economic and strategic relations with Central Asian nations.
- Question hints: diplomatic strategic partnership; 2 billion dollars of trade with Kazakhstan; security cooperation under the SCO framework and military exercises.

- 3 to 4 questions from the class, worth 10 to 12 marks.
- A separate question on the implications of BRI in China.
- Approach: read the PYQs when the topic is given, and revise in the class.

21.2 Framework of Heads for Central Asia's Importance

Central Asia's importance is to be written under a fixed set of heads, so that the answer is organised rather than scattered.

KEY CONCEPT

The Five Heads of Central Asia's Importance.

- Extended neighbourhood.
- Civilizational connection.
- Energy security.
- Critical minerals.
- Security buffer (security).

- Central Asia is India's **extended neighbourhood** — and this head must be written first.
  - Most answers missed this head; it is the point from which every other aspect follows.
- Connectivity, energy security and critical minerals can be added as heads without any problem.
  - Heads seen in the answers sent in included supply chain, trade resilience, security, energy security, connectivity, trade, civilizational connect, counterterrorism, critical mineral availability, C2C cultural exchange, geoeconomic and geostrategic.

CRITICAL POINT

Do Not Write Multilateralism/Multipolarity for Central Asia.

- Central Asia is not a pole — a region cannot be written as promoting multilateralism or multipolarity.
- Multilateralism and multipolarity belong to big organisations like BRICS, Quad and SCO.
- BIMSTEC will promote multipolarity — BIMSTEC is a grouping of countries of the Bay of Bengal: Thailand, Myanmar, Nepal and Sri Lanka [as stated in lecture].

QUICK REVISION

- Five heads: extended neighbourhood, civilizational connection, energy security, critical minerals and security buffer.
- Extended neighbourhood is written first — it is the head most answers miss.
- Connectivity, energy security and critical minerals are all acceptable additional heads.
- Do not write multilateralism or multipolarity for Central Asia — it is not a pole.
- Multilateralism and multipolarity belong to big organisations like BRICS, Quad and SCO.

21.3 Nation Profiles of the Five Central Asian Republics

A nation profile of the five republics is the starting point of the introduction, and it helps in understanding these countries.

Kazakhstan	Capital Astana; the largest Central Asian Republic; oil and gas, uranium, rare earth and critical minerals; borders both Russia and China.
Uzbekistan	The demographic and political centre of Central Asia; borders Afghanistan; important for uranium, gold (Au) and natural gas; the Prime Minister of India visited recently.
Turkmenistan	Capital Ashgabat; a neutral country; natural gas reserves; a Caspian state; the origin of the proposed TAPI pipeline; the Ashgabat Agreement originates here, with Pakistan and Oman as members.
Kyrgyzstan	Capital Bishkek; borders China; near the Pamir, Kunlun Shan, Hindu Kush and Himalayas; important for HEP.
Tajikistan	Important for the Persian cultural connection, for HEP and for India's security; India maintained the Aini air base (Tajikistan says it is not an air base).

21.3.1 Reading the Region on a Map

- The Caspian Sea lies to the west of the region.
  - Russia lies to the north and China to the east; Iran, Afghanistan, Pakistan and India lie around and to the south.
- If you want to go from India to Central Asia, you have to take a route around the region and then enter this part of the world.
  - This is the hold that the geography of the region has on it — the bypass India is forced to make.
- The five republics are Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan, Turkmenistan, Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Kazakhstan — Astana; largest republic; oil, uranium, rare earth and critical minerals; borders Russia and China.

- Uzbekistan — demographic and political centre; borders Afghanistan; uranium, gold and natural gas.
- Turkmenistan — Ashgabat; neutral; natural gas; Caspian state; origin of TAPI and of the Ashgabat Agreement (Pakistan and Oman as members).
- Kyrgyzstan — Bishkek; borders China; Pamir, Kunlun Shan, Hindu Kush, Himalayas; important for HEP.
- Tajikistan — Persian cultural connection; HEP; India's security; Aini air base.
- Map: Caspian Sea west, Russia north, China east, with Iran, Afghanistan, Pakistan and India around; India must route around the region.

21.4 Common Features of the Central Asian Republics

A brief about these nations helps in understanding these countries, because several of their features are shared and several of them are shared with India.

- They are **landlocked** — and landlocked between Russia and China.
  - They are completely surrounded by Russia and China.
- Therefore they need an outlet to the seas, for example the Indian Ocean region — this is the importance of India.
  - India's importance for the Central Asian Republics is the same as the Central Asian Republics' importance for India.
- Politically and internally, the **post-1991 generation** has taken over.
  - Earlier the society was living in the hangover of Soviet influence.
  - Now there are people who have been born after 1991 — 35 years — so a new equilibrium is being created.
- New developments are taking place and people are willing to look for alternatives.
  - India is that alternative — every point of this write-up automatically attracts them towards India.
- **Islam is the main religion, but it does not define identity and is not a political project.**
  - Where Islam is a political or identity project today: Iran, Iraq, Egypt, Yemen, Syria and Lebanon.
  - For the Central Asian Republics, the first identity is their own country — this is their layer of identities.

EXAMPLE

Analogy: Nepal and the Ties of Hinduism.

- Nepal is a secular republic which is connected to India by the ties of Hinduism.
- But that is not a political project — India and Nepal do not engage politically because both are intertwined over the identity of Hinduism.
- In the same way, Islam in Central Asia is not a political identity and not a political project — this is an opportunity.

- There is the concern of the export of instability and extremist ideology from Afghanistan.
  - Afghanistan affects India's security and their insecurity.
  - Any such threat is not originating from within Central Asia — it is coming from a neighbouring country.
- All the countries of Central Asia except Kazakhstan and Kyrgyzstan have borders with Afghanistan — that is, Tajikistan, Uzbekistan and Turkmenistan.
  - Even for Kazakhstan and Kyrgyzstan there is always the possibility of transference of concerns from Afghanistan.
- Cooperation is required because they want an outlet.
  - The increasing dominance of Russia and China makes them want diversification — the dividend in you is the dividend in them.
  - There is therefore an opportunity for increasing people-to-people (P2P) ties.
- India has an 11,000 km maritime boundary, which gives it the sea access that these landlocked states lack.
- There is a multitude of ethnicities, languages and geographies, and a resource endowment — and India is also like them.
  - So many ethnicities and so many languages; they will not have geographies more than India.
  - That resource endowment is the opportunity that India has, because we are also like them.
- India has the Himalayas, which was formed after the furrowing and upliftment of the Tethys Sea.
  - North of the Himalayas, Ladakh is an example of the Eurasian landmass.
  - They are Eurasian landmass and we are Eurasian landmass.
- There are also disputes amongst nations — the region is not homogeneous.
  - Disputes over borders, over water resources and over overlapping ethnicities.
- So there is no one connecting dot to find in this part of the world — there are several similarities that we have.

QUICK REVISION

- Landlocked, and landlocked between Russia and China — hence the need for a sea outlet and hence India's importance.
- India's importance for them is the same as their importance for India.
- Post-1991 generation has taken over; a new equilibrium is being created; people are looking for alternatives, and India is that alternative.
- Islam is the main religion but not a political project or identity — unlike Iran, Iraq, Egypt, Yemen, Syria and Lebanon.
- Concern of export of instability and extremist ideology from Afghanistan; all republics except Kazakhstan and Kyrgyzstan border Afghanistan.
- Multitude of ethnicities, languages, geographies and resource endowment; India is like them (Tethys Sea, Himalayas, Ladakh as Eurasian landmass).

- Disputes over borders, water resources and overlapping ethnicities — no single connecting dot, but several similarities.

21.5 Importance of the Central Asian Republics for India

The importance of the Central Asian Republics for India was set out as five numbered points.

1. Geopolitical — India's Extended Neighbourhood

- Central Asia is a part of India's **extended neighbourhood**, lying immediately beyond the Northwestern neighbourhood.
- Historically India was connected to Central Asia through Afghanistan, but Pakistan's denial of overland transit or access has separated India from Central Asia.
  - Had POK been India's area, this access would not have been a worry; but POK was occupied by Pakistan and this access is not provided, so India has been cut off from this part of the world.
- This part of the world was India's connection — connected by rivers, by mountains, by geography, by the multitude of diversity and by Afghanistan.
- Therefore India's foreign policy seeks to **reconnect** Central Asia.
  - The **Central Asia policy 2012** was launched with the objective not to connect but to reconnect — to go back to the roots, back to the connections and back to the historical relationship.
- The historical route was India–Afghanistan–Central Asia; it has now become India–POK–Afghanistan–Central Asia.

2. Heart — Land Bridge and Eurasian Pivot

- Central Asia is the **heart** of Eurasia, and India provides it access to the IOR.
- It is a **land bridge** between Europe in the west and Asia in the east.
- It is a **north–south bridge** between Russia in the north and the Indian Ocean in the south.
- It is a gateway that connects India with north-west Eurasia, and it is a **Eurasian pivot**.
  - A pivot is a connection — a stable hinge, a connecting link between India and Eurasia.
- Eurasia is the centre of Europe and Asia; the centre of Eurasia is Central Asia; and the centre of Central Asia is Afghanistan.

EXAMPLE

Analogy: The Pivot.

- Think of pivoting around one of your legs — one leg stays fixed and you rotate around it; that fixed leg is the pivot.
- India is one side, Eurasia is the other, and this connecting pivot is Central Asia.

3. Multipolar Asia — Strategic Theatre of Major Powers

- Central Asia is important for **multipolar Asia**, because it is a strategic theatre having great

power presence.
  - The powers present are Russia, China, Turkey, EU, USA and Iran.
- Write these as **major powers**, not as great powers.
  - Therefore the region is important for India's regional security and reach.
- If there is a region which involves the major powers, India cannot keep it aside because it is an extended neighbourhood and a centre.
  - India also needs to make strategic inroads in the region.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Analogy: FOMO and Strategic Presence.**
>
> - Wherever many people are going, you have to go — if there is a region involving many players, it creates a fear of missing out (FOMO).
> - Because of this FOMO the importance of the region has further increased.
> - If others are launching mentoring and test series and other courses, you cannot take a step back; you also need a presence to be in the game professionally — the same logic applies to India's presence in the region.

4. Support for India's Global Membership

- India needs the support of these republics for its global membership.
  - The Central Asian Republics have supported India's greater role in GG — that is, good governance.
- Example: the **India–Central Asia Dialogue 2025** supports India's UNSC Permanent Membership.
- They are strategic partners of India in the promotion of **multilateralism** and in the reform of global institutions like the UN, the World Bank and the IMF.
  - India wants reform in all of these, and these countries support India.

5. Preventing Strategic Marginalization

- Engagement is important to prevent **strategic marginalization**, and to counter and balance the involvement of major powers.
- The strategic space, or diplomatic space, of the region is already occupied.
  - China — economically; Russia — security-wise and strategically; Turkey — culturally; Europe — economically; and Iran.
- If India does not engage in this region, it is basically succumbing to increasing strategic marginalization.
  - If India does not interact as a major power, all these major powers will take the roost.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Case Study: Strategic Marginalization in Africa.**
>
> - Strategic marginalization has to some extent already taken place as far as the continent of Africa is concerned.

- India has not scaled up enough, at the pace it should have done in the past.
- No region is a backyard for India — India cannot lose the pace it has in this part of the world.

QUICK REVISION

- Point 1, geopolitical: extended neighbourhood, immediately beyond the Northwestern neighbourhood; historically connected through Afghanistan, cut off by Pakistan's denial of overland access.
- Therefore India seeks to reconnect Central Asia — Central Asia policy 2012; route has shifted from India–Afghanistan–Central Asia to India–POK–Afghanistan–Central Asia.
- Point 2, heart: land bridge between Europe and Asia; north–south bridge between Russia and the Indian Ocean; gateway to north-west Eurasia; Eurasian pivot.
- Eurasia is the centre of Europe and Asia, Central Asia is the centre of Eurasia, Afghanistan is the centre of Central Asia.
- Point 3, multipolar Asia: strategic theatre with major powers — Russia, China, Turkey, EU, USA and Iran; write major powers, not great powers.
- Point 4, global membership: support for India's role in good governance; India–Central Asia Dialogue 2025 supports India's UNSC Permanent Membership; partners in reform of the UN, World Bank and IMF.
- Point 5, prevent strategic marginalization: space occupied by China and Europe economically, Russia strategically, Turkey culturally and Iran; Africa shows what marginalization looks like.

21.6 Economic Importance — Geoeconomics, Energy and Complementarity

The strength of the India–Central Asia economic relationship, or geoeconomics, is **complementarity** — this is the keyword for the answer.

This is the introduction. If time permits, straight away write the geoeconomic importance; otherwise these points are written in the body of the answer.

21.6.1 Energy Security

- Kazakhstan has oil and gas, rare earth, critical minerals and uranium.
  - It is one of the world's largest producers of uranium.
  - It is also one of the most important players, seen at Asian Games and in boxing medals, along with Uzbekistan.
- India's approach here is diversification — India will engage with all the blocs that are willing to engage with it, whether Australia or Kazakhstan.
  - Australia is a country willing to engage in the light of a declining Trans-Pacific relationship and of the USA taking a step back.
  - As much diversification and as much reach as possible, in order to increase access to critical minerals and to uranium producers.
- Turkmenistan is important for natural gas and is the basis for **TAPI** — the Turkmenistan–

Afghanistan–Pakistan–India pipeline.
  - India's terminal for the pipeline will come at **Fazilka in Punjab**.
- Uzbekistan is important for gold (Au), uranium and natural gas.
  - This is because of the recent **uranium framework agreement signed in August 2026**.
- Tajikistan and Kyrgyzstan are important for **HEP** potential.
- Therefore the Central Asian Republics are a **cornerstone of India's energy transition and diversification**.

EXAMPLE

Example: Sport as Diplomatic Signalling (Russia and Dagestan).

- Pakistan borders Georgia and Armenia; the Slavic Russians have overpowered the identity of the Islam-following people of Dagestan.
- When Khabib Nurmagomedov defeated Conor McGregor, Putin called him — a symbolic meeting that conveyed to Dagestan that it is an integrated part of Russia, as much Russia's part as Siberia.
- UFC is an individual body, not a unified mixed-martial-arts body, and Khabib does not really represent the mainstream Russian identity — yet he was given pomp and show, creating a discourse opposite to the one built against Russia.
- This was diplomatic signalling by the administration, promoting Khabib as a Russian and creating sentiment — good optics where the cards were played well.

21.6.2 Market for India's Goods and Services

- Central Asia is a market for India's goods and services.
  - Trade stands at **2 billion dollars**, but there is significant potential.
- Goods and services that can be exported: health, education, pharma, edtech, fintech, agri and agro-processing, textiles, engineering goods and automobiles.
  - Automobile brands named: Scorpio, Fortuner, Bolero and the Thar (the four-door variant).
- Most important: **space and satellite products**.
  - India is collecting a lot of data, and this region is full of glaciers — Tajikistan and Kyrgyzstan are full of glaciers.
  - You want to ensure that glacial retreat is captured well by satellites; this will help them address their water insecurity.
  - Resource planning is a very important objective that India can assist them in, if India provides the satellite services.

QUICK REVISION

- Keyword: complementarity — the strength of the India–Central Asia economic relationship and of geoeconomics.
- If time permits, open with the geoeconomic importance directly.
- Energy security: Kazakhstan — oil and gas, rare earth, critical minerals, uranium (one of the

world's largest uranium producers).

- Turkmenistan — natural gas and TAPI, with India's terminal at Fazilka in Punjab.
- Uzbekistan — gold, uranium and natural gas, tied to the uranium framework agreement signed in August 2026.
- Tajikistan and Kyrgyzstan — HEP potential; hence the region is a cornerstone of India's energy transition and diversification.
- Market: trade is 2 billion dollars with significant potential; health, education, pharma, edtech, fintech, agri, textiles, engineering goods and automobiles; most important are space and satellite products for glacial retreat and water insecurity.

21.7 Adjacent Regions and Groupings — Caspian, Caucasus, EAEU and the Road to Europe

Alongside the five republics, the surrounding regions and groupings must be known, because they explain the routes and the blocs that connect Central Asia to the wider world.

Caspian region	The Turkic nations.
Caucasus nations	Georgia — which borders the Black Sea — plus Armenia and Azerbaijan.
Eurasian Economic Union	Russia, Belarus, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan and Armenia.

- Mnemonic for the Eurasian Economic Union: **R–B–K–K–A** — "R" for Russia (Red Bull) and "K" for Kaak.
  - The "A" is Armenia, not Azerbaijan.
- Gateway to the EU: crossing the Black Sea takes you into Romania, Bulgaria and Hungary.
  - Further westward: the Czech Republic, Slovakia and then Poland.
  - Further west still: the Netherlands, Belgium and France.

QUICK REVISION

- Caspian region countries are the Turkic nations.
- Caucasus nations: Georgia (borders the Black Sea), Armenia and Azerbaijan.
- Eurasian Economic Union: Russia, Belarus, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan and Armenia.
- Mnemonic for the EAEU: R–B–K–K–A, with "A" being Armenia.
- Route to the EU: Black Sea into Romania, Bulgaria, Hungary; then Czech Republic, Slovakia, Poland; then the Netherlands, Belgium and France.

21.8 The Great Game — Heartland and Rimland

This region used to be referred to as the Great Game during the time of the Second World War [as stated in lecture], because it was a huge expanse of land over which great geopolitical contests were played out.

Heartland	Mackinder	The fight for superiority in the world will be around the Great Game region — landlocked and full of resources; whoever controls it rules the world.
Rimland	Spykman	The opposite theory — continental areas are not relevant; the Rimland means the littoral areas along the sea, whose relevance is as a gateway to larger markets.

QUICK REVISION

- The region was called the Great Game during the time of the Second World War.
- Mackinder gave the concept of the Heartland.
- Heartland: landlocked and resource-rich; whoever controls it rules the world.
- Spykman gave the opposite theory of the Rimland.
- Rimland: continental areas are not relevant; the littoral areas along the sea matter, as a gateway to larger markets.

21.9 Connectivity — Bypassing Pakistan Through Iran

The region is also important for connectivity, because it allows India to bypass Pakistan to access Central Asia.

- India can access Central Asia through **Iran**, thereby bypassing Pakistan.
- India's diversification and reach are increased through this route as much as through access to minerals.

EXAMPLE

Example: International North–South Transport Corridor (INSTC).

- An example of this bypass connectivity is India's membership in the International North–South Transport Corridor (INSTC).

QUICK REVISION

- Central Asia is important for connectivity because it allows India to bypass Pakistan.
- The route is through Iran.
- Example: India’s membership in the International North–South Transport Corridor (INSTC).

CHAPTER 22

India–Nepal Relations

22.1 Bilateral Relations in the IR Exam: Framework and PYQ Pattern

Bilateral relationship is one head of International Relations, and **one question from it is fixed — it comes every year**. The head is broken into three parts.

1. The relationship with the **neighbourhood** — studied country by country: Nepal, then Afghanistan, then Bangladesh and the rest.
2. The **great powers** — the US, China, and Russia, India's all-weather friend.
3. **Other nations** that are in the news — Israel and Japan, and groupings such as the European Union.

- Great-power summitry is itself part of the news cycle: a **BRICS** summit was under way in Delhi, with President Putin having arrived the previous day and President Xi Jinping arriving the same day as the class.

> **PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION**
>
> **How bilateral PYQs are framed.**
>
> - In bilateral relations, questions have been asked on **Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, Maldives and Pakistan**; China is usually studied under the great powers.
> - The **importance of Maldives** has been asked.
> - Broadly, the questions come on **any recent event and its implications** — if an event takes place in Nepal, Maldives, Sri Lanka or Bangladesh, you must know its implications.
> - For South Asia, almost **8 to 9 questions** have come on the South Asian bilateral relationship.
> - About **20 questions** have come in the past 13 — in fact 14 — years.

- **Nepal — the Gen Z protest.** After it, for the first time ever since Nepal has had a constitution, **one party individually has a majority**.
  - Earlier, three parties formed coalitions and kept changing prime ministers like a game of musical chairs; now, for the first time, a new party has individually formed a majority.
- **Bangladesh — elections have taken place.** Tariq Rahman has still not come to India although he was invited to the BRICS summit as the **chair of BIMSTEC**.
  - His statement is that he must be called as the Prime Minister of Bangladesh — anything less is against his respect as the PM of an important country like Bangladesh. It is not certain that he will come.
- **Sri Lanka — the Aragalaya protests of 2022**, and **Maldives — the election of Mohamed**

Muizzu. These events have a high probability of being asked in the examination.

- The logic is very simple: **any kind of regional problem in a particular part of our neighbourhood will immediately affect us.** That is the perspective.

CRITICAL POINT

Expectation setting on coverage.

- At least **25 to 30 nations that are in the news** have to be seen; not all of them can be prepared separately, or the whole course becomes IR alone.
- Countries are read through their frameworks: **Belgium** will not be asked separately, it will be asked within the framework of the **European Union**; Israel and Japan are studied the same way.
- If the PM goes to Cyprus, Austria or Poland, that visit has to be read within the framework of the EU; the importance of a **Nordic summit** comes under India–EU relations. The geopolitical, geostrategic, geocultural and geoeconomic importance of the EU is the importance of that particular country.
- In the past **13 years not even a single question** has come from the 'other nations' category, but material will still be given and those countries will keep being discussed.

QUICK REVISION

- Bilateral relationship is one of the three IR heads, and one question is fixed from it every year.
- Three heads: neighbourhood → great powers (US, China, Russia) → other nations in the news.
- Bilateral PYQs: Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, Maldives and Pakistan; China is studied as a great power.
- South Asian bilateral relationship: almost 8–9 questions; about 20 questions in 13–14 years.
- Questions are framed on a recent event and its implications; a regional problem in the neighbourhood immediately affects India.
- Coverage discipline: 25–30 nations in the news; Belgium, Cyprus, Austria and Poland are read through the EU framework.
- Events to track: Nepal's Gen Z protest, Bangladesh's elections, Sri Lanka's Aragalaya (2022), Maldives' Muizzu.

22.2 Note-Making Structure for Every Neighbour and the Nepal Polygon

The module on any bilateral country follows a fixed sequence. Write the structure down in this order.

1. **History of the bilateral relationship** — studied only with important partners, above all the South Asian neighbours. Its purpose is to understand how India's foreign policy has evolved; a facet from history will act as an advantage in an answer on Nepal.
2. **Importance** — geopolitical, geoeconomic, geocultural and geostrategic (GP, GE, GC, GS).
3. **Recent protests and elections and their implications for India.**

4. **Strengths and opportunities** — what is strong in India's bilateral relationship.
5. **Weaknesses, issues or concerns** — split into two parts. **Recent concerns** arise because a government has changed: whenever a government changes, its domestic approach changes automatically, and its approach towards the neighbouring country changes too, so the recent protests, the recent government and their implications have to be seen. **Traditional concerns** are the ones that have always been there, such as Nepal calling India a case of big brother syndrome.
6. **China's role** — taken separately as a topic head: what China's presence is in that country, the inroads China has made in the neighbouring countries including Nepal, and its key projects. This part is new and factual.
7. **Way forward** — some of it written immediately, and the rest written as a **common way forward for all the neighbours** after the South Asia module is over. The overall suggestions and the way forward for bilateral countries will be the same.

Before opening the history, draw a **polygon representing Nepal**. Nepal means a polygon, and in the examination this diagram has to be drawn for every country in IR.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Vertices of the Nepal polygon.**
>
> - **Roti-beti** — the familial bond, and the keyword the examiner wants.
> - **Neighbourhood First** — Nepal has a land boundary with India and is a priority under India's Neighbourhood First foreign policy; the country next door is where the whole story ends, there is no comparison at all.
> - **Civilizational ties** — real, but they come much later than roti-beti. These two things cannot be evaded.
> - **Open borders** — open, not merely porous; an open border can also be called porous, and a porous border is one that is stopped at some point.
> - **1,800 km of border.**
> - **Himalayan strategic buffer.**
> - **Energy**, and **trade and diaspora**.

- **Roti-beti (the familial bond)**: people come to India for jobs and send a good amount of money back home as remittance, and weddings between India and Nepal are very common — people of UP and Bihar and the northern fringe (Pilibhit, Lakhimpur Kheri) have familial and matrimonial ties with the same **Madhesi** population in Nepal.
- **Himalayan strategic buffer**: a **buffer** is an area, a country or a region that prevents the influence of another country. China cannot straight away enter India; it has to pass through Nepal. Had there been no Nepal, India would have had a straight border with China — that is Nepal's importance.
- **Before 2006, in fact before 2001, Nepal was a big and happening country**: we used to get a lot of Chinese products, and it was a casino destination. Its king then was **King Birendra Shah**, who was killed by his own son in 2001.
  - Afghanistan was a very happening place under **King Zahir Shah** before **1979**, and Iran

was a very happening place under **Shah Reza Pahlavi** before **1970**, the Islamic Revolution. Afghan music is very soulful, like Bollywood and Kishore Kumar; now, because of the ban, Afghanistan listens mainly to Turkish, Turkic or Arabic music and not to its own, because there is no producer.

- **For many Indians, Nepal was the first foreign country**: the first foreign airline was Nepal's, flying to Kathmandu, before 2006 — in fact before 2001.

QUICK REVISION

- Module sequence: history → importance (GP, GE, GC, GS) → recent protests and elections with implications → strengths and opportunities → concerns (recent + traditional) → China's role and inroads → way forward.
- Recent concerns follow a change of government; traditional concerns such as big brother syndrome persist.
- China's presence must be inserted in every bilateral answer, with inroads and key projects kept ready as factual material.
- The way forward is partly Nepal-specific and partly a common one for all neighbours, written after South Asia.
- Draw a polygon for Nepal — and for every country in IR: roti-beti, neighbourhood first, civilizational ties, open borders, 1,800 km of border, Himalayan strategic buffer, energy, trade and diaspora.
- Roti-beti is the keyword the examiner wants; a buffer prevents another country's influence, and without Nepal China would border India directly.

22.3 History of Nepal and India–Nepal Relations

1923 — or, very precisely, 1816 — is the framework, the foundation, of India–Nepal relations, because that is how India, or let us say British India, and Nepal emerged as a region.

22.3.1 Unification and the Yam Between Two Boulders (1768)

- Before **1768** there were several kingdoms and principalities — seven or eight small kingdoms in the area.
- **Prithvi Narayan Shah**, the ruler of the Gorkhas, unified Nepal by conquest and dominated and unified the surrounding areas. **Kathmandu, the capital, was captured in 1768.**
  - This is like the unification of Germany and Italy read in world history, where Bismarck unified the principalities and the kingdoms.

KEY CONCEPT

Nepal is a yam between two boulders.

- A **yam** is a crop, a tuber crop. Prithvi Narayan Shah said that **Nepal is a yam between two boulders**.
- This laid the foundation of Nepal's need for **strategic balancing**, and it has perpetually remained in the history of Nepal — it is one of her weaknesses.

- Nepal is **destined to have the options of engaging both India and China**, and is also poorly destined to have seen the might of both nations, from the South and from the North.
- The same is true of **Afghanistan**: it is at the centre of Central Asia, West Asia and South Asia and is close to Iran, so its geography is both a problem and an opportunity.
- This strategic thinking has been present in Himalayan strategic thought, and in Nepal's own thinking, since 1768.

22.3.2 The Anglo-Nepal War and the Treaty of Sugauli (1814–1816)

- Nepal's expansion began, and Nepal started fighting.
- From **1814 to 1816** came the **Anglo-Nepal War**, in which the **East India Company defeated Nepal**.
- **Mussoorie, Nainital and the whole of Uttarakhand were part of the Nepali kingdom** after the expansion that had started in 1768 — the British stopped that expansion.

> **GOVERNMENT & POLICY**
>
> **Treaty of Sugauli, 1816.**
>
> - Signed in **1816** with the British, it **defined the boundaries of Nepal** — it demarcated present-day Nepal.
> - **Western boundary: the Kali river. Eastern boundary: the Mechi river.**
> - The **Kali river is the source of the recent boundary dispute that began after 2019** — the **Limpiyadhura–Kalapani–Lipulekh (LLK / LKL)** dispute.

22.3.3 The Shah Monarchy, the Ranas and the 1923 Treaty of Friendship

- **1816 to 1846**: with the treaty signed, the **Shah monarchy consolidated territorially**.
- **1846 — the court massacre.** The queen's very close minister died, and she called a meeting of several people to investigate the cause; in that meeting **Jang Bahadur Rana** emerged as the protagonist, coming with his force and showing his strength. This was the **emergence of the Ranas**.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Rana is not the same as king.**
>
> - The **Shahs** were the kings; the **Ranas** were the **prime ministers**, and the office was **hereditary**. The Shah kings became merely ceremonial.
> - **Rana became a tag of respect** in the hills — an **ascriptive value**, on the basis of caste: you were born into a Rana or a Shah family. It was not because of your achievement.
> - Until 1846 the kings ran the show; after 1846 the Ranas came, became powerful and were very dangerous.

- Because power was now theirs, the Ranas developed relations with **British India**.
- They **assisted the British in the 1857 war, the 1857 Kranti**, and therefore the British did not touch Nepal.
- This laid the foundation of **strategic cooperation between British India and the Ranas**.

- Whoever helped the British in 1857 earned a lot of British respect; the whole British policy towards India, specifically towards the princely states, was overhauled, and many princely states earned British respect.
- **Had the 1857 Kranti not taken place, the further strengthening of the Ranas would not have been laid**; their domination continued and it culminated in 1923.

> **GOVERNMENT & POLICY**
>
> **Treaty of Friendship, 1923.**
>
> - A **treaty of friendship between Britain and Nepal**. India was then subjugated, but **Nepal was given the label of an independent and sovereign state**.
> - Nepal was strategically located **north of India**.

22.3.4 1950 to 1960: Independence, the Three Pillars and the Fall of the Ranas

- When India became independent, in **1950** we signed the **Indo-Nepal Treaty of Peace and Friendship**.
- The Rana rule started declining, and this led to the **emergence of three pillars**.

1. The **Ranas**, who were the prime ministers.
2. The **monarchy** — the kings.
3. **Nepali Congress**, which was completely inspired by the Congress.

- **Nepali Congress played a much more important role than the Muslim League**, which was a 100% aristocratic party, because Muslims did not have that much education: those who were educated were the ones who ruled, as in the Congress.
- The Congress was said to be a party of the **bourgeoisie**, of the middle class — which was to some extent correct; in fact, if it is actually analysed, all political parties are bourgeois.
- Engaging all three of them was a big challenge for India's foreign policy: write it in the answers — **Nepal has always been a challenge**.
- **1951**: this led to the **termination of Rana dominance**. Elections followed and a Nepali Congress government came — the lecture names **Girija Prasad Koirala** of the Nepali Congress, father of actress **Manisha Koirala** — and the Ranas were removed. But as soon as that government came, the same old problems started again.
  - The government dismissed in 1960, however, was that of **B. P. Koirala**, not Girija Prasad Koirala.

22.3.5 Monarchy and the Party-less Panchayat System (1960–1990)

- **1960**: the king dismissed the **B. P. Koirala** government. At the time of independence **King Tribhuvan** had been on the throne; then **King Mahendra** dismissed the government. After 1960 there was again a lack of democratic government.
- The king then started an interesting system, one that was against the party called the Nepali Congress — the **party-less panchayat system**. Panchayats were elected, but the real power lay with the king.
  - The king consolidated, and there was no political party.

- **1960 to 1990 is very important for India's foreign policy because there was a diversification of Nepal's foreign policy**: Nepal used **China and other powers for strategic autonomy**.
- The war with India started when India tried to stop the movement, because **the king wanted Chinese arms**; the **transit points along the border were closed or restricted**.
- In **1978 Deng Xiaoping** emerged as a powerful leader in China, and India had a strong leader in **Indira Gandhi**; the two sides were trying to coordinate, while the king was consolidating himself. A protest then became likely.

22.3.6 *Jan Andolan, the Maoist People's War and the Republic (1990–2008)*

- **1990 — the First Jan Andolan.** People protested because they wanted democracy. It ended the panchayat system, a **new constitution** was adopted in 1990, and it spoke of a **constitutional monarchy**. **India supported this democratic transition.**
- Simultaneously, from **1996 to 2006**, the **CPI (Maoist)** — the Communist Party of Nepal (Maoist) faction — started and carried out a **people's war**. It was a security concern for India.
- **2001 — the royal massacre. King Birendra** was killed in the castle by his own son, along with his mother, his father and perhaps his sister — five or six people were killed. Birendra's brother **Gyanendra** became the king, and he is relevant in politics even today.
- India's dilemma in the 2000s: whom to engage — the king, or the political parties? The parties had their own factions, they were not like the Congress and the BJP of India, and they became **parallel elites**; there was a constant tussle between the king and the political parties.
  - With a Prime Minister and a king, and the people in between, the turmoil between them irritated the people and they responded in the Janandolan — but for five or six years there was no benefit; then elections came, unemployment was high, and after 10 years the Maoists said they would wage war.
- The 2000s were a very dangerous decade for Nepal, because **India was also confused**: supporting the Maoists was difficult since Maoism had fallen in India, even though they were raising the voice of the people, and they supposedly even had the tacit support of the **Communist Party of China**; supporting the Nepali Congress would have hurt **Gyanendra**.
- Even today there are followers in Nepal who say that all political parties are of no use, that **Nepal is a feudal state and should be run by the king** — the same sentiment as in **Jammu & Kashmir**, where the followers of the **Dogra Rajput** rulers (**Jamwal, Hari Singh**) say that all the money goes to Kashmir and all the development is Kashmir's.
- **2005**: Gyanendra **dismissed the government and assumed power**.
- **2006 — the second Janandolan**, against the king taking power: the **parliament was restored**, and India signed the **CPA, the Comprehensive Peace Agreement**, with the Maoists, which ended the insurgency.
  - The king was deposed because the Maoists were fighting for the political rights that had been subjugated by the king — this was a **triangulation of democratic movements**.
- Now there were three parties and no king: the **Nepali Congress**; the **Maoists**, who joined the political party system and became one of the political parties; and the **Communist Party ML — Marxist-Leninist**.

- **2006 — democracy emerged after the Janandolan**, but it was also a **foreign-policy challenge**: there are always three players in Nepal, and every now and then one player is emerging and another is going, so every time India systematically sets its game to engage with that country, the players are changing.
  - The Maoists were getting stronger in 2006, 2008 and 2013. In 2013 a big chunk of almost **200 districts** in India were suffering from **LWE (Left-Wing Extremism)**, which has now been eliminated — the Maoists have now joined political parties and say they were wrong. That Maoist faction runs the government in China.
- **2007**: an **interim constitution** was adopted — a constitution was needed to run the government, and there could not be a stalemate.
- **2008**: elections were held, and the **Constituent Assembly** — with all the political parties, the Maoists having become part of the government in 2006 — first adopted a **federal democratic republic**; the other provisions had to be deliberated.
  - Abolishing the constitutional monarchy ended **240 years of the Shah monarchy**: it started with Prithvi Narayan Shah's consolidation and it ended in 2008.
- **2008 to 2014**: repeated governments of different political parties — governments kept changing while work on the constitution went on.
- **Which period can be called the best?** None can be called the best period of the relationship, because internal society was always in turmoil and stability never really existed in Nepal — neither from 1960 to 1990 nor after the Janandolans.
- The **1950s were relatively stable**: the Nepali Congress had learnt all its politics from the Indian Congress, and Nehru's era was different — but that is a matter of many generations ago.
- **Now there is an opportunity**: for the first time, to some extent, stability has come, and India has an opportunity to take the **strategic edge**.

QUICK REVISION

- **1768**: Prithvi Narayan Shah, ruler of the Gorkhas, unified Nepal and captured Kathmandu; his warning that 'Nepal is a yam between two boulders' laid the foundation of strategic balancing.
- **1814–1816**: Anglo-Nepal War; the East India Company defeated Nepal; the **Treaty of Sugauli (1816)** defined Nepal's boundaries — Kali river in the west, Mechi in the east; Uttarakhand was lost.
- **1846**: the **court massacre** brought **Jang Bahadur Rana** to the fore; the Ranas were hereditary prime ministers while the Shahs remained ceremonial kings.
- The Ranas helped the British in **1857**, which led to **strategic cooperation with British India** and, in **1923**, to the **Treaty of Friendship** recognising Nepal as independent and sovereign.
- **1950**: Indo-Nepal Treaty of Peace and Friendship; three pillars — Ranas, monarchy and Nepali Congress; **1951** ended Rana dominance.
- **1960**: King Mahendra dismissed the B. P. Koirala government; the **party-less panchayat system** ran to 1990, with Nepal diversifying its foreign policy through China (the king wanted Chinese arms, transit points were closed or restricted); **1978** Deng Xiaoping, with Indira

Gandhi in India.

- **1990** Jan Andolan → end of the panchayat and a constitution with constitutional monarchy; **1996–2006** Maoist people's war; **2001** royal massacre and Gyanendra; **2005** dismissal of the government; **2006** Janandolan and the CPA; **2007** interim constitution; **2008** federal democratic republic, ending **240 years of Shah monarchy**.

22.4 Recent Developments: From the Modi Reset to the Gen Z Protests (2014–2026)

- **2014 — the reset.** The Indian PM visited Nepal, the **first such visit in 17 years**, and gave a keyword: **HIT**.

KEY CONCEPT

HIT — the 2014 keyword.

- **H**ighways — physical connectivity; India wants open borders.
- **I**nformation ways — digital connectivity: internet, high-speed wireless, UPI.
- **T**ransmission lines — HEP coordination, which is very important.
- The keyword showed that the problems were very well understood, and the relationship was reset.

- **April 2015 — the Nepal earthquake.** India's **Operation Maitri** demonstrated to the entire world India's capacity as **first responder** during disasters, and India's role in **HADR** — Humanitarian Assistance and Disaster Relief.
  - It also exposed the failure of Nepali politics: people began to feel that something was wrong. The evacuation and all the support were basically given by the Indian forces, with a lot of foreign support as well, and they showed that the Nepali government had failed.
- The Nepali people's accumulated grievance, as narrated: for 300 years the **Shahs** squeezed them, then the **Ranas**; democracy came in the 1950s; the king deposed the government in 1960; the party-less panchayat ran from 1960 to 1990; the 1990 Janandolan brought a Nepali Congress government; the Maoists started the people's war in 1996; the king was killed in 2001; Gyanendra dismissed the government in 2005 and the people rebelled again while the Maoists joined the political movement; from 2008 constitution-making began; Modi visited in 2014; and in 2015 the earthquake showed that the government had failed.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

September 2015 — a new constitution is promulgated.

- It **made Nepal secular** — it had earlier been a **Hindu state** — and Nepal was a **federal democratic republic**.
- **India was not happy**, with **Sushma Swaraj** then the Foreign Minister, because of the **limited federal rights of the Madhesis**.
- The Indian government was very irritated: how can a country like Nepal, a minion like Nepal, not address the rights of the Madhesis? It came as a big backfire after the success of Operation

> Maitri.

- **Who are the Madhesis?** They live in the plains of Nepal and are culturally close to **UP and Bihar**.
- With them India has a **roti-beti** relationship: they do agriculture, and there are marriage-and-job ties; people from UP and Bihar go to the plains, which are fertile with tremendous productivity, to earn money.
- The political weight is a **120-seat equation** — UP has **80** seats in the Lok Sabha and Bihar has **40**. That is why the Indian government was very irritated that Nepal could not address the rights of the Madhesis.
- **2015 to 2016 — the Madhesi agitation. India was blamed** for an **unofficial blockade**, because there was a severe shortage in Nepal.
  - The protesters were Nepali, but who was supporting them? From a Nepali perspective, India was.
- The common people were affected: things started becoming costlier, there was tremendous **inflation**, and this led to a **severe deterioration in P2P — people-to-people — ties**.
  - Nepalis became clear that they are Nepali and Indians are Indian; the roti-beti ties were strained; the ordinary Nepali working in India — in restaurants, in jobs, in the IT sector — was angry with India.
- The strategic consequence: 'you closed the road — Nepal is this Himalayan strategic buffer — you paused the game.' There was a **clear tilt under K. P. Oli (Khadga Prasad Oli)** of the Marxist-Leninist party; in the last 10 years his tilt has been towards China.

> **GOVERNMENT & POLICY**
>
> **2017 — Nepal signs the BRI.**
>
> - It was signed as a **strategic maneuver**: Nepal **indirectly penalised the Madhesi blockade that was unofficially blamed on India**, and it held hands with China.
> - The hand-holding of any neighbouring country with BRI is a **major strategic challenge**.

- **2019 — the boundary controversy**: **Limpiyadhura, Lipulekh and Kalapani**.
  - **Why it arose**: India **abrogated Article 370** and released a **new map**; Nepal was disturbed and asserted that the area was its own.
- As Mayor of Kathmandu, **Balendra Shah** had put up the map of Nepal showing **Kalapani** as part of Nepal.
- The boundary disputes flagged for detailed discussion: **two places — the Gandak river and Susta** (Susta is part of the Gandak).
- **2022 — the MoU / Joint Vision Statement on Power Sector Cooperation** was signed, and a vision was set: **10,000 MW of export from Nepal to India in 10 years**.
- This is part of a **structural shift in bilateral relations**: in the diagram of Nepal, a new vertex is being added — the **vertex of energy**. In the examination they may ask about this shift.

September 2025 — the Gen Z protests. The reasons:

1. **Political elitism** under the three parties — the **Nepali Congress**, the **CPI (Marxist-Leninist)** and the **CPI (Maoist)**. Leadership came from a narrow set of names: after Koirala, **Sher Bahadur Deuba** of the Nepali Congress — just as the Congress has Rahul, the Samajwadi Party Mulayam and the RJD Tejashwi, the names are fixed; **Prachanda** led the Maoists (he had studied at JNU); **K. P. Oli** led the Marxist-Leninists. All three were in their 70s and 80s, and there was absolute corruption.
2. **The entrance-examination analogy**: it was like the civil services examination happening in Nepal, where only some people could clear it — as in India in the 60s and 70s, when there was no Hindi medium and only those educated in good colleges and from historical families could clear. Today the field is open and anyone can qualify through hard work.
3. **Corruption** — tremendous bribe-taking, even though it is said that Nepal's society is very reformed: eve-teasing, the practice of harassing women, and assessing women by looking at their clothes with dirty eyes, does not exist in Nepal (as the class was told; the lecture itself has never been to Nepal). Nepal is **politically a failed state, but culturally not a failed state**.
4. **Disconnect between the youth and the political leadership.** Nepal's **median age is 26**.
5. **Unemployment**, because there is **no manufacturing sector**.
6. **Political instability** — the number of governments since 1990.
7. **The final nail**: **K. P. Oli banned 26 social media websites** in **September 2025**.

> **DATA & FACTS**
>
> **Nepal's economy in numbers.**
>
> - Manufacturing's contribution to Nepal's GDP fell from **10% in 2000** to **5%** now.
> - **14%** of Nepal's population works abroad — a phenomenal number.
> - The economy is **remittance driven**: **30% of remittances come from India** — every third rupee coming from outside comes from India. Money earned in India becomes two times in Nepal [as stated in lecture].
> - Unemployment in the **15 to 24** age group is a phenomenal **22.7%** (2023 figures); the class was also given a **4%** figure for that age band, stated as a fact [as stated in lecture].

India	About **10**	Three or four were coalition governments and the rest ran full five-year terms; **9** Prime Ministers have completed a full term, and since **1999** every PM — Vajpayee, Manmohan Singh twice and Modi three times — has completed a full term.
Nepal	**30**	An average Prime Minister lasts only **1.5 to 2 years** — this churn is a direct cause of the Gen Z protest.
Pakistan	No Prime Minister has completed a full term	**Shehbaz Sharif, Munir, Musharraf and Asif Ali Zardari** — the military prefers to show that a stable government can be run by a military individual, and whenever India–Pakistan relations stabilise a terrorist attack happens, because stakes have to be created to prove that the civilian government is useless.

- **March 2026 — elections were held and Balendra Shah came to power**; for the first time a new party individually formed a majority.
- **Balendra Shah never asserts his Madhesi identity** — like a Prime Minister from Tamil Nadu who never says Tamil; that is an interesting card he is playing.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Strategic and tactical.**
>
> - **Strategic means long term; tactical means short term.** Whenever you discuss any foreign-policy development, do not confuse the two.

- It was **apprehensively felt** that Balendra Shah was **protocol driven** and that he had sought **strategic equality** — he wanted India's role to move from **big brother to equal partner**.
- **After the election there is improvement**, for two reasons: (1) India's **disaster diplomacy**,

with India as the first responder; (2) **meetings of the Indian ambassador and the army chief with the Nepalese PM**.

  - A step already taken towards improvement: the **Nepal Finance Minister visited India**.

- Nepal is following a policy of **calibrated re-engagement** — it has sought **strategic equality** with India but **not dis-engagement**. This indicates the **strategic resilience** of India–Nepal relations and points to the **multi-vectored strategic autonomy** practised by Nepal under the new leadership.
- Since he got elected, **protocols have been slightly reduced**, which shows he wants **strategic autonomy** — that remains the same — but there is also **strong strategic and institutional resilience** in India–Nepal relations.
- Governments come and go and decide the stability of the relationship, but India–Nepal relations are built on a **sound footing**: there is no Balendra, Narendra, Mahendra, Gyanendra, Oli or Koirala who can play with this soundly built bilateral relationship.
- **The Nepali Prime Minister's visit to India has not happened**: because of the Nepal disaster it has been delayed, and it is expected around **March**. For one year no Nepali Prime Minister has come to India, whereas — from memory — every PM would have come within one year of getting elected, as Modi did in his first year.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Exam relevance.

- A question was expected this year in the Civil Services Main examination on this area — the protests and the elections — but no question came up. It still has to be prepared.
- This framework is how to analyse the neighbouring nations; the elections are game-changing, and Nepal's history is very important for these answers.

QUICK REVISION

- **2014**: Modi's visit — the first in 17 years — gave the keyword **HIT** (highways, information ways, transmission lines).
- **2015**: **Operation Maitri** showed India as first responder and exposed the failure of Nepali politics; the **September 2015 constitution** made Nepal secular, but **India was unhappy** over **limited Madhesi federal rights** (FM Sushma Swaraj).
- **2015–16**: **Madhesi agitation**, India blamed for an **unofficial blockade**, inflation and a severe deterioration in **P2P ties**, followed by the tilt under **K. P. Oli**.
- **2017**: Nepal signed the **BRI**; **2019**: the **Limpiyadhura–Lipulekh–Kalapani** dispute after India abrogated **Article 370** and released a new map; **2022**: the power-sector MoU with a 10,000 MW vision and a new **energy vertex**.
- **September 2025 Gen Z protests**: political elitism, corruption, a youth–leadership disconnect (median age 26), unemployment (no manufacturing), instability (**30 governments since 1990**) and the ban on **26 social media websites**.
- **March 2026**: Balendra Shah came to power; **calibrated re-engagement** with **strategic equality** but no dis-engagement — strategic resilience and multi-vectored strategic autonomy.

- The Nepali PM's visit to India is still pending; a question on this area was expected but did not come in the examination.

22.5 Importance of Nepal for India

The importance of Nepal is written **horizontally, in four pieces** — geopolitical, geoeconomic, geocultural and geostrategic — because that is how it will be remembered.

22.5.1 Geopolitical Importance

- Nepal has a **land boundary** with India and is a **priority** under India's **Neighbourhood First** foreign policy; the PM recently spoke of Nepal as a **priority partner** under the Neighbourhood First foreign policy — a priority even within the immediate neighbourhood.
- It is important to **counterbalance China**: Nepal is a **BRI signatory**, having signed in **2017**, and there is **increasing Chinese influence in infrastructure, highways and railway networks** — to be discussed separately.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Nepal is a member of BIMSTEC, SAARC and BBIN.

- **BBIN** is the **B**hutan, **B**angladesh, **I**ndia, **N**epal connectivity project.
- The aim is to connect the entire South Asian region with the help of **highways**, **information ways** and **transmission ways**.

- It is important for **India's leadership of the Global South**: Nepal's diplomatic support is essential for India's stature, and role, as the leader of the developing world; and it is essential on global issues — **multilateralism, polarity and the reform of UN bodies** — including **support for India's UNSC membership**, which is very important.
- It is **most important and necessary for climate finance** — to compensate Himalayan nations like India and Nepal for **loss and damage** incurred because of climate-change-induced weather extremes.
  - **Balendra Shah will speak at the UNGA** this month, in the last week. The **UN General Assembly meets every September in New York**. He will speak about the reform required on climate change, because many Western nations have been blamed and are responsible for climate change.
  - The Nepali **flash floods** seen in the rivers **Bhote Koshi** and **Trishuli** are clearly a result of the activities of the West. A big amount of **glacial melting** is happening at a much higher rate in the Himalayan ecosystem — in some places **seven times more than the global average** (in areas of the Arctic).

22.5.2 Geocultural Importance

- **Geocultural ties are India's biggest advantage** — the word to use for them is **strategic lever**.

KEY CONCEPT

What is a strategic lever.

- A **lever** is basically a device that moves something — like the lever in a train that, when pushed, reclines the seat behind.
- Geocultural ties are exactly that: a **strong, long-term strategic lever against any such weakness that India–Nepal relations face**.

- **Roti-beti comes first**: the best example in the class — a classmate has **three maternal aunts married in Nepal**, and another classmate has been to Nepal **five times**. The roti-beti implication is very well reflected in this foreign travel.
- Roti-beti also means **common culture**:
  - **Language.**
  - **Temples**, written separately below.
  - **Educational mobility** — there are many Nepali students in the **IITs and NITs**; they come to **Delhi** (D.U., JNU), also to **Darjeeling**, and many go to **Bangalore** — they go all over India.
  - **Intermarriage** — the most important metric: when you marry outside your own section, **social mobility** has come.
- **Gurkha military tradition** — this is India's **internal security**: **34,000 Gurkhas were recruited into the Indian Army in 2025**.
  - Gorkhas are very brave — as **Sam Bahadur** used to say, if somebody is not afraid, either he is lying or he is a Gorkha. Englishmen also have Gorkha recruiters; they play football and volleyball; they are short in height but they are like jumping. This is a **military–cultural bridge**.
  - Some restriction on the countries that may recruit Gurkhas is there, and the lecture refers to **Group A and Group B** [as stated in lecture].
- **Civilizational network — Hindu**: **Janakpur** and **Radha–Janak**, and **Ayodhya** and **Shri Ram** — the Janakpur relationship is as old as the Ramayana, so religious mythology is intertwined in the details of the two countries; there is **Banaras (Kashi Vishwanath)** here and **Pashupatinath** there.
- **Civilizational network — Buddhist**: the Mahajanapadas and **Kapilvastu**; **Lord Buddha died in Kushinagar** after consuming pork that was supposedly not well cooked; **Bodh Gaya**; and **Lumbini**. The recently elected military President of Myanmar came to India and first went to **Bodh Gaya**.
  - Such an important circuit — the **Buddhist and Ramayana circuit**: the Ramayana is incomplete without Nepal, and the whole Buddhist culture is incomplete without Nepal.
- The same civilizational-network logic extends to **Pakistan** through the **Kartarpur corridor** and the Gurdwara [as stated in lecture].
- **Tourism** — this can also be written under geoeconomy: **Indians account for 30% of all tourists in Nepal**, the largest source.
- **Scholarships**: India provides **1,500 scholarships annually** to Nepali citizens — a very

important tool. These strong ties are a tool.

- **Identity and labels**: **Nepali** carries two meanings — a person from Nepal, and the Nepali language (the popular song Musu Musu Hasi Deu was cited). People from Nepal are very concerned about their identity, like the **Gorkhaland** separate-state demand; **Tharu** and **Bhotia** are also Nepali connections, but they do not call themselves Gorkha. In Nepal, Madhesi and Pahadi can be ethnically distinguished on the ground, while outside we use regional labels such as Bihari and Punjabi as a matter of common sense — these are historical socio-economic layers [as stated in lecture].
- **The Himalayas are India's northern flange**; beyond them the culturally different **cold desert of Tibet** begins. India's physiography was also its cultural and international map, before the British came [as stated in lecture].

22.5.3 Geoeconomic Importance

There is a **structural connection with India**, and the two economies are interconnected in both directions.

India's share of Nepal's total trade	**63%** — India is the largest trade partner of Nepal
Nepal's exports that go to India	**68%**
Nepalese working in India	**80 lakh**
Indians working in Nepal	About **6 lakh** [the lecture also said almost 1 crore — as stated in lecture]
Remittances from Nepal to India	**$3 billion**
Remittances from India to Nepal	**$1 billion**

- **The remittance figures were clarified in class**: the Nepalese working in India send back about **$3 billion**, which is more than what Indians working in Nepal send back — about **$1 billion**. Every Nepali working in India and every Indian working in Nepal makes the two economies completely intertwined.
- **Energy security** comes from **HEP cooperation**. In **2022** the **MoU on the Joint Vision Statement on Power Sector Cooperation** was signed.
  - Exports have increased from **39 MW** to **1,300 MW** — almost a 1.3 gigawatt export. The **target is 10,000 MW** of export from Nepal to India in the next 10 years, that is, by **2032**.
  - **HEP helps in providing base load**, and it is important for the **clean energy transition**.
  - The energy trade is **both ways**: for a big chunk of the monsoon months Nepal sends power to India, and after the monsoon ends India sends power to Nepal.
- **Strategic regional connectivity** comes from the **tripartite agreement between India, Nepal and Bangladesh**, under which Nepal sells to Bangladesh **using India as transit**.
  - If Nepal has to export to Bangladesh it needs a transmission network; India's existing

network of transmission towers is being used to export electricity from Nepal to Bangladesh. The infrastructure is established — power only has to be generated and sent through those towers.

- **India's regional connectivity vision** rests on **HIT**: **petroleum pipelines**, **cross-border railways**, **ICPs — integrated checkposts** on the border (the exact names were to be written later), and **digital connectivity** through **UPI**.
  - India has been receiving **undersea cables at Bombay and Chennai**, and **Vizag** is emerging as a new port for receiving undersea cables. **UPI** involves financial technology — a kind of fiscal connectivity: Nepali traders can use it in India and Indians can use it in Nepal, which leads to engagement between the two nations.
- **Why India can provide energy security**: Bangladesh is an **energy-deficit country** importing about **90%** of its energy, and **80 to 85% of its oil comes through the Strait of Hormuz** — a 35% figure for its oil imports was also cited [as stated in lecture]. India has a thousand sources — **solar, HEP and tidal** — and last year **geothermal** energy came into the picture.

22.5.4 Geostrategic Importance

Geostrategic is the **most important** dimension, because it clearly discusses the dimension of **security** — and with security one has to be careful.

- Nepal is India's **Himalayan strategic buffer** — a **natural barrier between India and China**.
- **Internal security**: the **porous borders** have been used for **FICN — fake Indian currency notes**, **human trafficking**, **smuggling of liquor**, **smuggling of drugs**, the **diversion of essential inputs or goods like fertilizer** (Indian fertilizer can be sold through Nepal), and as an **entry route for terrorists**.
  - **Wildlife trade** is also very important — the lecture cited orangutans being found in Odisha [as stated in lecture].
- **China's military engagement is increasing**: Nepal has a **1,400 km border with China**, there are **proposed Nepal–China military drills**, and there is the history of the **Chinese arms deal of 1988 to 1990**, which makes Nepal's case a little more interesting than the others.
- **Human security** — in the lecture's view the most important: Nepal is important for India for ensuring human security, because of the recent increase in **climate-change-induced natural disasters** in Nepal that have an effect on India.
  - Example: the **flash floods of August 2026**, which had a downstream effect, along with the **increased number of glacial lakes**, leading to the possibility of **GLOFs — glacial lake outburst floods**.
  - Human security is a concern for both: Indians also work in Nepal, and deaths create security concerns for India. At least **1,500 to 2,000 deaths** were reported and about **5,000 people are missing, of whom 1,500 are Indians**; nearly **1,000 people died at once** — as many as would have died in a tsunami [figures as stated in lecture].
  - So India's **disaster-management architecture** has to take care of the security mechanism in Nepal; India has to get involved and cannot call it a violation of sovereignty — it has to cooperate with Nepal. Nepal resisted, saying it will not accept aid, so the answer is that **it is not aid, it is compensation** — you caused this much climate change, you have to pay

for it.

- **Gorkha military heritage**: Gurkha recruitment and military-to-military institutional relations — the exercise **Surya Kiran** — create a **defence relationship unparalleled**.
- Therefore **Nepal is increasingly important for regional security**, and thereby for **India's overall internal security matrix**.

QUICK REVISION

- Importance is written in four pieces: geopolitical, geoeconomic, geocultural and geostrategic.
- Geopolitical: land boundary and priority partner under Neighbourhood First; counterbalancing China (BRI, 2017); member of BIMSTEC, SAARC and BBIN; support for India's Global South leadership and UNSC membership; climate finance for loss and damage.
- Geocultural: roti-beti is the biggest advantage and a strategic lever; common culture — language, temples, educational mobility, and intermarriage as the key metric of social mobility.
- Geocultural circuits: Gurkha military tradition (34,000 recruits in 2025), the Hindu network (Janakpur–Ayodhya, Kashi–Pashupatinath), the Buddhist network (Kapilvastu, Kushinagar, Bodh Gaya, Lumbini), tourism (30% Indians) and 1,500 scholarships a year.
- Geoeconomic: India is Nepal's largest trade partner (63% of trade, 68% of exports); 80 lakh Nepalese work in India and about 6 lakh Indians in Nepal; remittances — Nepal to India $3 bn, India to Nepal $1 bn.
- Geoeconomic energy: 2022 power-sector MoU; 39 MW → 1,300 MW; 10,000 MW target by 2032; HEP base load and clean transition; tripartite India–Nepal–Bangladesh trade; HIT and UPI connectivity.
- Geostrategic: Himalayan strategic buffer; internal security threats (FICN, trafficking, drugs, liquor, fertilizer diversion, terrorists, wildlife trade); 1,400 km China border, proposed drills and the 1988–90 arms deal; human security and GLOFs; Gorkha heritage and the Surya Kiran exercise.

22.6 Concerns, Challenges and Way Forward

22.6.1 Challenges

- **Recent concerns** arise from the government: whenever a government changes, its domestic approach changes automatically, and so does its approach towards the neighbouring country — so the recent protests, the recent government and their implications have to be seen.
- The relationship has become **protocol driven**: earlier India's ambassador in Nepal could straight away meet the Prime Minister — the lecture names ambassador **Naveen Srivastava** — and now that access is not automatic.

CRITICAL POINT

Big brother syndrome — the traditional concern.

- Nepal has always said that India suffers from **big brother syndrome** — just as an elder brother or elder sister starts dictating and the younger one's freedom gets restricted. The

> younger one says: do not interfere in my personal life; I respect that you are my elder brother, but I have my own individual life.
>
> - **Nepal's attitude has undergone a seismic shift after the election of Balendra Shah**: Nepal now believes in **sovereign equality** — now we will talk as equals.
> - Earlier, Nepal consulted India first on any business decision, bilateral relationship or foreign-policy decision; now he is **protocol driven**.
> - The generational analogy: **Gen Z** is opinionated and does not want spoon-feeding; it wants its own individual opinions — the same shift from respecting a dominant elder sibling to asserting one's own opinion.

- **The boundary dispute**: the **Limpiyadhura–Lipulekh–Kalapani** controversy that emerged in **2019** after India **abrogated Article 370** and released a new map; and the two places flagged for later — the **Gandak river** and **Susta** (a part of the Gandak).
- **The Madhesi question**: the 2015 constitution gave limited federal rights to the Madhesis; India was blamed for the **unofficial blockade** of 2015–2016, and people-to-people ties deteriorated severely.
- **China's inroads**: Nepal signed the **BRI in 2017**; Chinese influence is increasing in **infrastructure, highways and railway networks**; Nepal shares a **1,400 km border with China**; there are **proposed Nepal–China military drills**; there is the history of the **Chinese arms deal of 1988–1990**; a Maoist faction has historical links to China; and **K. P. Oli's tilt towards China** in the last 10 years.
- **India's weak Achilles heel is China — that is, BRI — and Pakistan.**
- **The changing players**: there are always three players in Nepal, and every now and then one is emerging and another going, so every time India sets its game to engage the country, the players change — a structural challenge for India's foreign policy.

22.6.2 Way Forward

- Follow a policy of **partnership** under the new leadership in Nepal — **no big brother syndrome** — and work on the basis of **strategic equality (samanta)**, not strategic subversion or strategic operation.
- Practise **calibrated re-engagement**: strategic equality with India, but not dis-engagement.
- Build on the **strategic and institutional resilience** of the relationship; it stands on a sound footing that no individual leader can overturn.
- Use **disaster diplomacy** — India as the first responder (Operation Maitri and HADR) — and reframe climate support as **compensation**, not aid.
- Use the **strategic lever** of geocultural ties: roti-beti, common culture, education and the **1,500 annual scholarships**, and tourism (30% of Nepal's tourists are Indians).
- Use **energy and connectivity** — HIT, BBIN, the tripartite power trade and the 10,000 MW target — to complete the **structural shift** in the relationship.
- The overall suggestions and the way forward are the same for all bilateral countries: the Nepal-specific suggestions are given here, and the rest will be written as a **common way forward for all the neighbours** after the South Asia module.

QUICK REVISION

- Recent concerns come with a change of government; the relationship is now protocol driven, with no automatic ambassador-to-PM access.
- Traditional concern: **big brother syndrome** — Nepal says India dictates, and Nepal's attitude shifted after Balendra Shah's election towards **sovereign equality**.
- Boundary dispute: **Limpiyadhura–Lipulekh–Kalapani (2019)**, plus **Gandak** and **Susta** (part of the Gandak).
- The Madhesi question and the 2015–16 unofficial blockade, which badly hurt people-to-people ties.
- China's inroads: BRI 2017, increasing influence in infrastructure including highways and railways, the 1,400 km border, proposed Nepal–China drills, the 1988–90 arms deal and Oli's tilt.
- India's weak Achilles heel is China (BRI) and Pakistan; and the three players in Nepal keep changing.
- Way forward: partnership and no big brother syndrome, strategic equality (samanta), calibrated re-engagement, disaster diplomacy with the compensation framing, the geocultural lever, and energy and connectivity — plus a common way forward for all neighbours.

CHAPTER 23

India–Nepal Relations — Part 2

23.1 Recap: From South Asian Diplomacy to China's Role in Nepal

> **DATA & FACTS**
>
> **Source of remittances — the figure to carry.**
>
> - The World Bank releases the world investment / world remittance report; the source-of-remittances figure for India is **US$130 billion** (the figure was to be confirmed).

The discussion is India–Nepal relations as the framework of South Asian diplomacy: India is surrounded by these neighbours, so India and the other neighbours both need to be known. The importance of Nepal has been seen, the history has been seen, and it has been seen how the buffer of Nepal between India and China has always been there, and how Nepal has tried to diversify its foreign policy.

- The next step, in sequence, is to look at the other side — **China's role in Nepal** — and after China's role, the **recent elections**.
- There is an increase in the **Chinese footprint**, which has led to **structural geopolitical change** in India–Nepal relations.
- The trend would have started after **1988–1990**, before the first **Jan Andolan**, when the Chinese wanted to sell their weapons and the king in that particular part of the country wanted to import those weapons — that was one step.
  - Now China has become an **essential reality**.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - The discussion is India–Nepal relations within the framework of South Asian diplomacy.
> - The buffer of Nepal between India and China has always been there, and Nepal has tried to diversify its foreign policy.
> - The next subjects in sequence are China's role in Nepal, and then the recent elections.
> - The increase in the Chinese footprint has led to structural geopolitical change in India–Nepal relations.
> - The trend would have started after 1988–1990, before the first Jan Andolan, through Chinese arms sales to the king.
> - China has now become an essential reality; the World Bank remittance report figure for India is US$130 billion.

23.2 Why Nepal Is Important for China

The first question to write down is the fundamental one: **why is Nepal important for China?**

23.2.1 Immediate Neighbourhood and Tibetan Security

- **First reason — immediate neighbourhood**: any instability in Nepal shall directly affect the internal security of China, and it directly affects China's immediate neighbourhood.
  - Therefore China would want to have a **stable Nepal**.
- **Second reason — Tibetan security**: Nepal is important for Tibetan security, as Nepal shares a boundary with China's **Tibet Autonomous Region**.
  - Therefore there are concerns of **Tibetan refugee activity**, **anti-China political mobilisation**, **cross-border movement**, and **external support to Tibetan groups through Nepal**.

> **DATA & FACTS**
>
> **The Tibetan government in exile.**
>
> - The Tibetan government in exile is based in **McLeod Ganj, Dharamshala**, in Himachal.

The Tibet region is the point of maximum sensitivity for China, and the logic that follows is the same as India's own geopolitical logic.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Stable Nepal is a prerequisite for stable China.**
>
> - **Tibet is the Achilles heel of China** — and Tibet is precisely why Nepal matters so much.
> - China cannot afford Nepal to be a country where developments against the interests of China are taking place.
> - A stable Nepal is a **prerequisite for stable China** — exactly the same geopolitical importance that Nepal has for India.

23.2.2 The Routes into South Asia and the Buffer Logic

China wants to increase its access in the South Asian subcontinent — the **Indo-Gangetic subcontinent**. That access is possible by two routes: one by land, the other by sea.

By sea	Myanmar — **Kyaukphyu port** and **Sittwe port**	Parts of the **String of Pearls** strategy; the India–Myanmar relationship is to be studied separately
By sea	Bangladesh	A further point of access into the subcontinent; **Tariq Rahman** has already visited China [as stated in lecture]
By land	Pakistan — **CPEC as a part of BRI**	Access to the Indian Ocean region; the **biggest concern for India's sovereignty**
The remaining piece	**Nepal**	A buffer — but a buffer that can always be breached

- The moment China breaches the buffer of the country of Nepal, it crosses the Himalayas and straight away enters the **Terai** and the sacred **Indo-Gangetic plains**; it straight away gets access and is **perching on top of the entire Indian subcontinent**.
- Previous incursions have **not** happened through Nepal: they took place either along the **LAC** or along the **Sikkim border**, where India has direct borders with Tibet or China.
- That is why the Himalayas are a great buffer and Nepal is a great buffer; and thereby, if that buffer can be breached, China automatically makes inroads into the strategic subcontinent.
- The dependence runs both ways: **India is dependent on Nepal so that it remains a buffer; China is dependent on Nepal because it wants to breach the buffer.**
- China has been a **revisionist power** — it wants to revise the status quo; India has always been a believer in peace, on an **'as is where is' basis**.
  - India signed the **Land Boundary Agreement** with the amendment to the Constitution; India gave enclaves to Bangladesh; India agreed to a decision of the **Permanent Court of Arbitration**; certain islands were given to Myanmar or Bangladesh.
  - India is actually letting go of its territory if it is under the norms of international sovereignty — unlike what the Chinese have done in the South China Sea.

23.2.3 Geo-Economic Importance: BRI Membership and Connectivity Projects

- Nepal is of **geo-economic importance** because of BRI: Nepal agreed to and **joined BRI in 2017**.
  - Thereby there have been several **connectivity and infrastructure projects**.
- There are discussions regarding **Kerung** — Kerung is a place in China — and a **Kathmandu railway connection**.
- China has also built **border connectivity**, and it has built **tunnels**.

23.2.4 Concerns Against BRI

- BRI has concerns, and these concerns are **against** BRI — and thereby this is an **advantage for India**.
- **First concern — financing**: Nepal does not want additional debt.
- Because of financing concerns, there are **implementation delays**.
- And luckily there are the Himalayas: unlike the plains along the India–Nepal border, where as many porous borders as one wants can exist, the Himalayas mean basically **difficult geography**.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **Joining BRI and implementing BRI are two different things.**
>
> - Even if BRI is a project where the Chinese are making inroads and China is coming into countries, **formally joining it and actually implementing it are totally different**.
> - **No country wants to enter into debt with China; they want grants.** Grants mean there is no repayment obligation, whereas debt means you have to pay the interest rate.
> - Second, implementation delays: **clearance is not available**.
> - There is a **structural reason** that the Belt and Road Initiative will never be successful in this part of the world — the Himalayas themselves are a barrier. And how much construction can be done?
> - The construction is being built near the **Great Bend**; the road is going to be gone; a dam has been built there which is **three times more than the Three Gorges Dam** — that is the largest dam in the world.
> - So in a way the possibility is less: **BRI in the neighbourhood does not really emerge as a strong competition**.

- **Sovereignty concerns** can come here, but as such there is no threat; sovereignty concerns are with China and India.
- If the funding is **non-transparent and is imposed on the Nepalese government**, then it is a kind of threat to their **economic sovereignty**.
- **Sovereignty in the present times is no more understood only in terms of territory** — sovereignty itself has undergone a massive metamorphosis in the times of globalisation.

> **PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION**
>
> **Where these concerns are to be written.**
>
> - These are the concerns that will be written **next year in the Civil Services Mains**, when the question is studied of **whether BRI is a significant concern for India or not**.

23.2.5 Political Influence, the Maoist–RSP Question and China's Cautious Approach

- The most important thing is the **economic importance**: for India, Nepal is important because India wants to project its leadership as the **leadership of the Global South**; for China, Nepal is important for **political influence**.
  - China, being a **revisionist power**, seeks to expand its influence.

- Example to write down: the **Maoist party** in Nepal has supported the **CPI (Maoist)** along with the **CPI (Marxist–Leninist)**.
- That is the **RSP — the Rastriya Swatantra Party** [as stated in lecture: 'Rashtriya Tantra Party'] — basically a **party of the Madheshis**.
- This is a very significant matter: when the first Madheshi Prime Minister is made, he will have to bring his **Madheshi identity** into his own **eastern Terai (Purvanchal)** region; then it will be understood that he has to do something better, and time will tell.
  - Then **China will be even more worried than us**.
- India has anyway been engaging with the **Nepali Congress**; the **Maoists were a threat**, and **KP** [as stated in lecture] alone was a 100% threat.
- So more than India getting worried about the rise of the RSP — the Rastriya Swatantra Party, a Madheshi party — the question is how far it will go: it will come to our own neighbourhood, and his own roti-beti ties are here in India [as stated in lecture].
- **China's approach is cautious**: China is watching **Balendra Shah** cautiously and has adopted a **wait-and-watch approach** after the RSP's leader **Balen Shah** became the head of the government in Nepal.
- So this is a very interesting point: we are worried, but **more than us it is China that is worried** — both of you are worried, but the opponent is more worried than you.

23.2.6 *Geostrategic and Geocultural Importance*

- There is **geostrategic importance**, because of increased Chinese activities in the sphere of **military exchange, equipment support, training and joint training / joint exercises**.
- Such as **Surya Kiran** on our side, and **Sagarmatha Friendship**.
  - Sagarmatha Friendship was last held in **2025**; for the first time it was held in **2017**.
- On the cultural side, China's interaction is **almost nil**: there are no Hindus, and they practise **Confucian** and **Buddhism**.
- So there is **no geocultural importance per se**.

QUICK REVISION

- First reason Nepal matters to China: it is the immediate neighbourhood, so instability there affects China's internal security — China wants a stable Nepal, which is a prerequisite for a stable China.
- Second reason: Tibetan security — Nepal shares a boundary with the Tibet Autonomous Region, raising concerns of Tibetan refugee activity, anti-China mobilisation, cross-border movement and external support to Tibetan groups. Tibet is China's Achilles heel.
- The Tibetan government in exile is based in McLeod Ganj, Dharamshala, in Himachal.
- China's access into the Indo-Gangetic subcontinent runs by sea (Myanmar's Kyaukphyu and Sittwe ports, Bangladesh) and by land (CPEC as part of BRI); what is left is Nepal, a buffer that can always be breached.
- Breaching the buffer means crossing the Himalayas into the Terai and the Indo-Gangetic plains; India depends on Nepal to remain a buffer, China depends on Nepal to breach it; China

is a revisionist power while India works on an 'as is where is' basis.

- Geo-economic importance: Nepal joined BRI in 2017; projects include the Kerung–Kathmandu railway discussion, border connectivity and tunnels.
- Concerns against BRI: financing and debt aversion, implementation delays, difficult Himalayan geography — joining and implementing are different; sovereignty is no longer only about territory, and non-transparent funding threatens economic sovereignty.
- Political influence: India seeks Global South leadership while China seeks influence; the RSP is a Madheshi party and China is watching Balen Shah with a cautious wait-and-watch approach, more worried than India.
- Geostrategic importance comes from military exchange, equipment support, training and joint exercises such as Surya Kiran and Sagarmatha Friendship (first held 2017, last held 2025); there is no geocultural importance per se.

23.3 Implications of China's Growing Engagement for India

KEY CONCEPT

The frame.

- The **implications of Chinese growing engagement for India are the same as the implications of BRI**.
- That thought needs to be developed at the end of the day — in International Relations you need to **deep dive**.

- The questions to keep asking while writing this: What are the implications? What is the sovereignty issue? Why is China there in Nepal? What is the border incursion? What is the security issue? What is the threat to India's strategic primacy?
- **First implication — threat to India's strategic primacy**: China offers an opportunity for diversification to Nepal, and therefore more diplomatic or political choices, which hampers India's historical predominance.
  - There has been a shift: where there was **India's predominance**, it has now shifted to **competitive pluralism**.
- **Second implication — increased strategic presence close to the Indian / Indo-Gangetic subcontinent**: under BRI, Chinese infrastructure and connectivity in Nepal provides **improved logistical access to China of the Indo-Gangetic plains**.
  - **Chicken's Neck** is that part of the area lying between **India in the west, China in the middle and Bhutan in the east**; it is on the eastern side of the state of Sikkim.
  - To reach Chicken's Neck you need to come through the **Chumbi Valley**, which is adjacent to Bhutan, so it is more a concern with respect to the threat from Bhutan — the map will be shown in the classes on India–Bhutan relations.
- **Third implication — increased opportunity for diversification for Nepal**: as Chinese presence increases Nepal's diplomatic choices, Nepal may emerge as the **swing state**.
  - The analogy used in class: if there are more teachers teaching General Studies Paper 2, that

automatically affects the primacy of the main teacher; with more options one may emerge as a swing state, which has direct implications for the influence of the regional power in South Asia.
  - The phrase **Indo-Gangetic subcontinent** will take you towards South Asia; if there is a swing state, they will have more options and you will have **reduced stakes**.

- **Fourth implication — infra competition**: Chinese investments under BRI may threaten **India's centrality** plus India's ability to meet the infrastructure needs of Nepal, and threaten investments already made by India in **transmission lines, highways and information ways (information highways)**.
- **Fifth implication — the transmission and information route**: in HEP there is joint development, and the electricity produced in Nepal is brought into India through a transmission network; India itself lays transmission lines, and the transmission lines already laid act as a **transit for the flow of electricity from India to Bangladesh**.
  - So if a country like China comes offering increased opportunity for the creation of these transmission lines, and for the creation of information highways, along with construction along the Himalayas, that is a **clear threat**.
  - It is not only a security threat: India then becomes one of the players, one of the options, instead of being **the only option** for the country of Nepal.

EXAMPLE

The encirclement map.

- Nepal is a BRI signatory. In the west there is **Pakistan — Gwadar**; then **Sri Lanka — Hambantota**; in the east **Bangladesh — the port of Chattogram** (Chittagong in modern history); from the south-east **Myanmar — Kyaukphyu and Sittwe ports**.
- So from all sides, the only side that was left was the **northern side** — this is the **encirclement of India by China**.
- **Sixth implication (the security threat)**: infrastructure and logistics development by China in Nepal might lead to the encirclement of India from all sides, raising security concerns.

- **Further security threat — China–Pakistan access in Nepal** (numbered 'sixth' in the lecture): a deeper strategic presence of China in Nepal might enable **China–Pakistan cooperation in Nepal**, leading to the emergence of a **new, non-traditional security threat**.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Parliamentary Committee on External Affairs — the dual-use nature of Chinese infrastructure.

- The **Parliamentary Committee on External Affairs** has already pointed out the **dual-use nature of Chinese infrastructure**.
- It is said that these are only for infrastructure, which is a stupid thing to say — they all have **defence implications** also.
- Today these are ports built for commercial transportation; tomorrow, because China is in a **long-term lease agreement** with each of these particular areas, they might even end up

becoming a concern for India's territory.

- Chinese projects in the Himalayas affect river flows and ecology, impacting India's water security and disaster management — **not really**: there would not be a good amount of discharge coming from Chinese construction adjacent to Nepal.
- What can surely be said is that with increasing **climate change** effects and the **melting of glaciers**, the amount of water getting released into the rivers because of melting glaciers is a concern with respect to the emergence of **GLOFs — glacial lake outburst floods** — and also the concern of **flash floods**.
- **What is recommended with China** is a mechanism for **sharing of inter-country river data** — the need is sharing of data rather than a straight concern about the construction of a dam, because you cannot construct a dam there; there is not much hydropower available at that end.
- The dams which have been constructed are on the **Yarlung Tsangpo** — that is the **Brahmaputra** — further eastward, after it has started moving some **300–400 km** towards **Namcha Barwa**.

QUICK REVISION

- The implications of Chinese growing engagement for India are the same as the implications of BRI; in IR this thought has to be deep-dived.
- First: threat to India's strategic primacy — diversification for Nepal means more diplomatic choices, hampering India's historical predominance; predominance has shifted to competitive pluralism.
- Second: increased strategic presence close to the Indo-Gangetic subcontinent, giving China improved logistical access to the plains; Chicken's Neck (between India, China and Bhutan, east of Sikkim) and the Chumbi Valley belong to the India–Bhutan discussion.
- Third: Nepal gains diversification and may emerge as the swing state — the 'more teachers for GS Paper 2' analogy — which reduces India's stakes.
- Fourth: infra competition — Chinese BRI investment threatens India's centrality, India's ability to meet Nepal's infra needs, and Indian investments in transmission lines, highways and information highways.
- Fifth: the transmission and information route — Nepal's HEP power flows into India and onward to Bangladesh; Chinese-built lines and information highways would make India one option among many instead of the only option.
- Sixth: the security threat of encirclement — Gwadar in the west, Hambantota, Chattogram in the east, Kyaukphyu and Sittwe in the south-east, leaving only the northern side.
- The Parliamentary Committee on External Affairs flags the dual-use nature of Chinese infrastructure and long-term leases.
- Water: the real concern is glacier melt, GLOFs and flash floods, so the recommendation is inter-country sharing of river data; the constructed dams are on the Yarlung Tsangpo (Brahmaputra) some 300–400 km towards Namcha Barwa.
- China–Pakistan cooperation in Nepal could create a new, non-traditional security threat.

23.4 Challenges in India–Nepal Relations

After the Chinese developments, the challenges of India–Nepal relations are to be discussed. They can also be called **issues**, or written in the form of **concerns** that India–Nepal relations have; the recent events are taken up at the end.

23.4.1 Challenge 1 — Engaging with a New Government

- There has been a **decisive shift in Nepal's domestic politics**, which might require a shift in India's approach of engaging with Nepal.
- The new regime is **younger**, to some extent **anti-establishment**, **nationalist**, a **digitally mobilised leadership** — driven by social media — and **confrontational**.
- Thereby the regime seeks **dramatic changes** and believes in **sovereign equality**.
- **Anti-establishment** means that whatever the existing arrangement (vivaastha) was, they rebelled against it; now they themselves are an arrangement — they themselves form the establishment.
- For **75–80 years post-independence**, the Indian ruling elite dealt with Nepal on the premise of **three parties**: the **Communist Party of Nepal (Unified Marxist–Leninist)**, the **Communist Party of Nepal (Maoist)** and the **Nepali Congress**.
  - This has now been replaced by **one political party — the RSP, the Rastriya Swatantra Party**: one new political party, one new government.
- There is also **assertive nationalism**: the Prime Minister has criticized India's **big-brother approach**; therefore **diplomatic recalibration is required**.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **What anti-establishment really implies.**
>
> - Anti-establishment does not always imply that you are against the government; it also implies an **inherent desire in the new government to keep aside the archaic, age-old principles of engagement with India** and to engage with India on the principles which are determined by them.

- The rules of the game have changed — illustrated by the overhaul of teaching itself in the Civil Services exam: nothing is written on the board any more, everything is shown on the screen, so **teaching as an art and a science has itself undergone a recalibration**.
  - Instead of writing, deciphering the arguments and putting them down in an organized manner, it has become much easier to use certain help and read out a document, without any application of analysis or intellectual capability.
- This is a generation with **no experience in ruling politics** — like what happens whenever any new government comes to power: the **Aam Aadmi Party** came to power in **Punjab**, the Aam Aadmi Party came to power in **Delhi** (though they managed very well), or let us say the **Jan Swaraj Party** comes to power in **Bihar** after the Bankipur elections being won by the one you all know.
  - That state and its citizenry, used over the last so many years to engaging with a uniform political style, will see that political style totally metamorphosed.

23.4.2 Challenge 2 — The Treaty of Peace and Friendship

- Sections of the Nepali political establishment demand a **reform or an updation** of the **Treaty of Peace and Friendship**, because the treaty is perceived to be **outdated, unequal and asymmetric**.
  - **Asymmetric** means it is in India's favour and it compromises Nepal's sovereignty.
- Broadly, **India's special access under the treaty is seen by Nepal as excessive influence**.
- The Treaty of Peace and Friendship is based on **special access**, but that access does not guarantee that India can keep on interfering in the domestic affairs of Nepal.

KEY CONCEPT

Schism — the keyword for the treaty debate.

- **Schism** is a division: at one point India has got the access, and India has acted responsibly in some instances and might have become overbearing in others.
- But Nepal thinks that whatever has happened in the past 80 years is enough — **now we want strategic equality in negotiations**.

23.4.3 Challenge 3 — The Boundary Dispute: The Susta Region

DATA & FACTS

The India–Nepal boundary by numbers.

- Nearly **1,805 km** [as stated in lecture: '1805'] of boundary, running through the states of **Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, West Bengal and Sikkim**.
- **98% of the boundary has been demarcated**, and maps have been exchanged.

- **Demarcation** basically implies that maps have been exchanged and both sides have agreed to the **entry and exit points**.
  - It is like two neighbours who both have historical land records and clearly believe 'this is mine and this is his' — that is done for 98%.
- Two areas are still unsettled: first, **Kalapani–Limpiyadhura–Lipulekh (Lipu Lake)**; second, the **Susta region**.
- The **Susta region** is basically a very simple dispute — it is a **geographical dispute**; **Kalapani is totally different**, and the major problem is with respect to Kalapani.
- The problem in Susta is the **changing course of the Gandak river**, which has led to **varied boundary interpretation**. Broadly, it is **geographical in nature**.
- On the map (this is Nepal): the river is the **Gandak**, referred to in Bihar as the **Narayani river**; the Indian side is **West Champaran District in Bihar**, and the Nepal side is **West Nawalparasi District**.
  - The river comes growing from the **Valmiki National Park** and flows from the north-western part of Bihar into the river **Ganga**; in Nepal it is called **Narayani**.
  - West of the Gandak is Nepal and east is basically part of India — that is how it has been demarcated on the map.
- But when the river is flowing, its **river course is shifting**, so the whole region on the east —

the entire Susta region — is **difficult to demarcate**.

- All these rivers, which have origins in the Himalayas and flow in Bihar and enter the Ganges, have a **shifting river course** — that is why there are many **embankments** in Bihar, and even then floods happened this time.
  - So for this reason the map of the exact area itself is **undecided**.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **The inch-tape analogy.**
>
> - It is like saying that this is the entire Susta region, measured by the four walls, measured by inch tape — but this is the river Gandak.
> - Tomorrow, if the Gandak takes a rightward shift, then the entire area where the podium ends becomes Susta; if it shifts further eastward and reaches half of the glass, then the area of Susta reduces.
> - The question is how Susta is to be solved, because how much area it has is itself not decided.
> - **There is no mistake of history or of any treaty in this; the mistake here is of the river** — so it is not a very serious affair, because it keeps on shifting.

- Map instruction for the answer: first show the districts (**Champaran**, **Nawalparasi**) and, with an arrow, make a **zoomed-in map** showing the Susta region and the shifting of the Narayani/Gandak river, which makes demarcation tough on a map.

23.4.4 The Boundary Dispute: Kalapani, Limpiyadhura and Lipulekh

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **The major dispute is not Susta — it is Kalapani.**
>
> - The major dispute is **Kalapani–Limpiyadhura–Lipulekh (Lipu Lake)**.
> - The reason is not a shifting river: **the Kali river is not shifting — the reason is the origin of the river Kali**.

- India and Nepal have **varied interpretations of the origin of the river Kali** — the key word is **origin** — the river which was the **westward boundary of Nepal as per the Treaty of Sugauli**.
- The **Treaty of Sugauli** clearly says that the river Kali is the **westward limit of Nepal**.
- The disagreement is not that there is no disagreement; the disagreement is: **what is the river Kali?**
- If the origin is shifting, then automatically the region **west of the Kali — that is India — is shifting**, and accordingly the region **east of the river Kali — that is Nepal — is shifting**.
- **If you shift the origin to the west, Nepal gains; if you shift the origin to the east, India gains** — the region east of the Kali is Nepal, and west of the Kali is India.

Both interpretations now have to be set out — **first Nepal's perspective, then India's perspective** (a map follows).

Where the river Kali originates	At **Limpiyadhura** — Nepal says this is where the Kali originates	Roughly at **Kalapani**; India does not state the exact origin, but claims that the track runs like this
Evidence relied upon	**Early British maps** — Nepal is making **historical claims**	**Later / latest maps** available (maps available in the late 19th century) and **British administrative and revenue records**
Consequence for the disputed tract	The whole **eastward tract** (highlighted in pink) belongs to Nepal; India would then need Nepal's permission to reach **Kailash Mansarovar** through Lipulekh	The area **west of the Kali** is India; the tract has been **administered by British India and then India for about 150 years**, with no Nepal administration involved

- When the **Treaty of Sugauli** was signed in **1816**, the maps made then did not have that much clarity about the origin of the river.
- **After the Treaty of Sugauli was signed**, this particular part of the disputed area was administered as a part of **British India**, and India basically inherited British India from the British.
- India says that even if the earliest map of 1816 had some discrepancy that had gone in favour of Nepal, clearly after the Treaty of Sugauli Nepal and India got segregated; the **Kalapani–Limpiyadhura dispute is not a dispute** — it has been administered by the Indian administration (previously British Indian administration) over the past **150 years**, and no Nepal administration was involved.
- **Nepal's claim**: the origin of the Kali river is near **Kalapani and Panchgaun** [as stated in lecture]; the whole eastward tract highlighted in pink basically belongs to Nepal.
  - If it belongs to Nepal, then India **cannot organise the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra** — India penetrates from here into China for Kailash Mansarovar — so **Lipulekh is a very important road and a very important pass**.
- **India's claim**: the origin of the Kali/Kalapani is roughly somewhere here, although India does not state the exact origin; it says the track runs like this — and even if the earlier British maps might have shown this to be the origin, **this part was never administered by Nepal**; in all the revenue records of British India this was always Indian territory.
- In **2019**, when India published the **new map of Jammu and Kashmir** and the map of North India, that map invited a response from Nepal: they said this is my territory, because **Limpiyadhura is the place where the Kali originates**.
  - That is how, in the past **6–7 years**, it has remained perpetually in the news.

- If you shift the origin of the Kali from this part — the part of Kalapani — then automatically this region is India's; if you shift it to Limpiyadhura, then the area west of the Kali becomes India and this part goes to Nepal.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **Cartographic aggression.**
>
> - So it is called **cartographic aggression**: in brackets, write down that **India has been blamed by Nepal for cartographic aggression** — which China does against India, and India never does.

- On the merits: in the early British maps, when rivers were traced, there was not that much clarity of geography in 1816; when a treaty is being developed there is limited clarity about the rivers and about the origin — so claiming on that basis is **wrong**.
- Administratively, for the past **200 years** — more than 200 years — this has been India's territory; now suddenly evoking emotions is basically a **political gimmick** on the part of Nepal.
- The two areas to be shown in the boundary dispute: one is the **shifting Gandak**, and the other is the **interpretation of the origin of the river Kali**.

23.4.5 Lipulekh's Importance for India

For simple understanding, write down in brackets that **Lipulekh (Lipu Lake) has the following importance for India**.

1. **Strategic** — it is close to the China frontier and to the **India–Nepal–China triangle** (the triangle lies slightly south-east of Lipu Lake); it is important for **high-altitude access and surveillance**.
2. **Cultural** — it is on the route to **Kailash Mansarovar**.
3. **Economic** — not the entire district: the entire **Pithoragarh** district is comparatively very big in terms of area, and this part of Pithoragarh is claimed because of the differing opinion on the origin of the river Kali, not the entire district.

- The economic value: it has **historically been part of trans-Himalayan trade between India and Tibet**.
- That trade was very popular. When the **India–China war took place in 1962**, the trade was stopped; there have been instances in the past when trade along this border was stopped.
- Many sections and societies used to go to Tibet, and this **two-way trade** was very popular; whenever a war happened, it was stopped.
- **Historical communities used to earn a big chunk of money by transporting substances between India and Tibet**, and this is a **very harsh route — very important for the examination**.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **The one-line formulation.**

> • Therefore, **Lipulekh has geostrategic plus geo-economic plus geocultural significance**.

- Do not forget the topic while writing all of this: it is the **boundary dispute** — between **Susta** and **Kalapani**.

23.4.6 Challenge 4 — Big Brother Syndrome and Interference in Domestic Affairs

- **Big brother syndrome**, or the perception of India's role in Nepal's domestic affairs: India has been believed to be having a **role in political transitions in Nepal**.
- Second, **the 2015 Madheshi development**, along with **interference in constitutional developments, especially from 2008 to 2015** — the latest constitution was framed from 2008, when the elections to the Constituent Assembly happened.

23.4.7 Challenge 5 — The Challenge of Open Borders

- The challenge of **open borders** is a **challenge as well as an opportunity**.
- **Why it is a challenge** — it has led to **internal security concerns in India**:
  - **Drug trafficking** from Afghanistan and Pakistan; **human trafficking**.
  - **FICN — Fake Indian Counterfeit Notes**.
  - **Criminal movement**: when **Shudhu Musawala** was killed by the perpetrators, they had gone to Nepal; it is very common that they keep roaming in India, then go to Nepal and stay in a hotel for 7, 8, 10, 15 or 20 days.
  - **Illegal trade**.
- It is also a **conduit** — conduit means a route — **for organised crime**, and it has also led to **exploitation by terrorist networks**.

23.4.8 Challenge 6 — Expanding Chinese Presence and Trade Asymmetry

- **Expanding Chinese presence** under BRI and infrastructure investments — for example **Pokhara International Airport**, which China is developing — so Chinese presence is increasing (in brackets: the **dual-use nature of Chinese projects**).
- **Limited trade utilization** and the **trade deficit**: Indian exports to Nepal are approximately **$7 billion**, whereas Nepal's exports to India are just **$800 million**.
  - Therefore there is **trade asymmetry**.

23.4.9 Challenge 7 — Water Resources

- **Water resources**: there are disagreements on **benefit sharing, land acquisition, environmental impacts and dam design**.
- **2026 flash floods** reinforce the need for **treating transboundary rivers as international systems, requiring bilateral cooperation**.
- Nepal has a lot of **HEP potential**; right now Nepal's HEP utilisation is almost **less than 5 to 10 per cent**.
- If Nepal starts utilising HEP to the full scale, then automatically **India will have reduced runoff**.
  - Reduced runoff implies **less water for agriculture**; less water for agriculture implies

declining agricultural income.

  - It will also affect the **downstream flow of the river Ganga**, because all these rivers — **Kosi, Gandak, Ghaghra, Kali** — are either tributaries of the river Ganga or tributaries of tributaries of the river Ganga.

- Nepal is **yet to dam all of them**, but once it starts damming — with the increasing influence of the Belt and Road Initiative and the recent floods — there is **limited cooperation with respect to engaging in transboundary data sharing**.
- It is very important for **India, Nepal and China** to share the exact discharge of water available for sharing between these three countries.
  - This is even a concern with respect to **Bangladesh** as a country.
- We require the same inter-country agreements and **inter-country protocols of data sharing**: how much water there is, when the water reduces, when there is a lack of monsoons, what the peak season is, when the dam needs to be constructed, and what the downstream impact will be — all of it has to be conducted in a detailed manner.

QUICK REVISION

- Challenge 1 — engaging with a new government: a decisive shift in Nepal's domestic politics; the new regime is younger, anti-establishment, nationalist, digitally mobilised and confrontational, seeks dramatic changes, believes in sovereign equality, and has shown assertive nationalism against India's big-brother approach.
- The three-party premise (CPN-UML, CPN-Maoist, Nepali Congress) that lasted 75–80 years post-independence has been replaced by one party, the RSP (Rastriya Swatantra Party); anti-establishment also means a desire to set aside the archaic principles of engagement.
- Challenge 2 — the Treaty of Peace and Friendship is perceived as outdated, unequal and asymmetric; India's special access is seen as excessive influence; the keyword is schism, and Nepal wants strategic equality in negotiations.
- Challenge 3 — the boundary is nearly 1,805 km across Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, West Bengal and Sikkim, with 98% demarcated; two areas remain unsettled: Susta and Kalapani–Limpiyadhura–Lipulekh.
- Susta is a geographical dispute caused by the shifting course of the Gandak (Narayani) river: West Champaran in Bihar, West Nawalparasi in Nepal, Valmiki National Park as source, embankments and floods; the mistake is of the river, not of history or a treaty.
- Kalapani—Limpiyadhura—Lipulekh is the major dispute: the Kali is not shifting, its origin is disputed; the Treaty of Sugauli (1816) makes the Kali the westward limit of Nepal. Nepal uses early British maps, India uses later maps plus British administrative and revenue records and 150 years of administration; a westward origin shift favours Nepal, an eastward shift favours India; India is blamed for cartographic aggression.
- Lipulekh's importance for India: strategic (China frontier, India–Nepal–China triangle, high-altitude access and surveillance), cultural (Kailash Mansarovar route), economic (trans-Himalayan trade with Tibet, stopped in the 1962 war) — geostrategic plus geo-economic plus geocultural significance.

- Challenge 4 — big brother syndrome and the perception of interference: role in political transitions, the 2015 Madheshi development and constitutional developments from 2008 to 2015.
- Challenge 5 — open borders are a challenge and an opportunity: drug trafficking, human trafficking, FICN, criminal movement and illegal trade, a conduit for organised crime and exploitation by terrorist networks.
- Challenge 6 — expanding Chinese presence (Pokhara International Airport, dual-use projects) and limited trade utilization: exports to Nepal about $7 billion against Nepal's exports to India of $800 million, hence trade asymmetry.
- Challenge 7 — water resources: disagreements over benefit sharing, land acquisition, environmental impacts and dam design; 2026 flash floods; Nepal's HEP utilisation below 5–10%; damming would reduce runoff, cut irrigation water, lower agricultural income and affect the Ganga's downstream flow; inter-country data-sharing protocols are needed among India, Nepal and China, with Bangladesh also concerned.

23.5 Strengths of the India–Nepal Relationship

Apart from the weaknesses, the **strengths** of India — that is, of the India–Nepal relationship — are to be written down.

1. **Strong civilizational, historical and cultural people-to-people (P2P) ties.**
2. **Stable government** — because the government is not dependent on a coalition.
3. **Generational shift in leadership.**
4. **India's role as first responder** and its **capabilities in HADR**.
5. **India's developmental initiatives undertaken in Nepal.**

- Stable governments automatically provide **opportunities for collaboration**.
- The generational shift provides an **opportunity for recalibration**, because the leadership is (1) **educated in India and abroad**, (2) **technocratic**, focused on rapid development, and (3) **eager to work with India as a partner**.
- India's capabilities in HADR: during **2015**, **Operation Maitri**.

23.5.1 India's Developmental Footprint in Nepal

- **HEP cooperation**: the **Arun-III HEP project — 900 megawatts**.
- The **Seti river** project [as stated in lecture: 'Teti river'] — **1,200 megawatts**, under development, and important for western Nepal's HEP potential.
- The **Upper Karnali HEP project** — awarded to **GMR**, again **900 megawatts**.
- The **2022 Vision for HEP export**, seen earlier in the discussion.
- **Transmission lines**: the **Muzaffarpur–Dhalkebar 400 kV transmission line** is already built; other lines in the pipeline are **Gorakhpur–New Butwal**, **Bareilly–Dodhara** and **Inaruwa–Purnia**.
  - Remember the Muzaffarpur–Dhalkebar line as the example of HEP cooperation.

- **Pipelines**: the most important is the **Motihari–Amlekhgunj petroleum pipeline** (Motihari is in Bihar) — basically **South Asia's first cross-border petroleum products pipeline** — the biggest advantage being that petroleum products are being delivered to Nepal, which is **providing energy security to Nepal**.
  - It has been running since **2019**.
- **Railways**: the **Jainagar–Bijalpura–Bardibas railway** — a railway line coming from Bihar to Nepal, integrating Bihar with Nepal; it is a Bardibas extension, with the Jainagar–Bijalpura section running and to be extended to Bardibas — a good example of how inter-country connectivity is being promoted.
- **Jogbani–Biratnagar railway** — for freight: freight from Nepal (Biratnagar) is brought into India and, with the help of the railways, taken to the ports — basically **assisting Nepali freight to reach the ports**.
  - Jogbani is further connected to the Indian railway system, from where it can be diverted.
- **ICPs — Integrated Check Posts**: these are places where you can get **custom clearances**; they are **operational**.
  - At a check post, customs clearances surely have to be taken; whether a tax is there, and its exact rate, is not certain — but even if there is a tax, the **rate of customs should be comparatively lesser to allow easy entry of Nepalese goods**; there might be a **transit treaty** also.
- The **2023 Treaty of Transit**: under this treaty India allows **Nepalese merchandise to move through India's roads, plus rail, plus ports, plus inland waterways**.
- Overall: the **Amlekhgunj–Raxaul–Motihari pipeline**, railway connections, checkposts, Biratnagar connectivity, and the **Seti river and Arun river HEP projects** have been developed.
  - The **Satluj Vidyut (SJVN)** and the **NHPC (National Hydroelectric Power Corporation)** PSUs are involved — those PSUs do not have to be known, only the broad developments.

KEY CONCEPT

Why all of this counts as a strength.

- India's strength is the **development partnership**, and India's strength is **goodwill diplomacy** — these are the strengths of the bilateral relationship.
- When this development is taking place in these countries, it automatically creates strength for both nations: you are providing transit treaties, you are providing pipelines — it is beneficial for both.
- It can be written in both ways — as the **geoeconomic importance of Nepal**, because India has invested so much and it is an asset for India, and as a **strength**: it is a **win-win for both countries**.

23.5.2 Student Doubt — Why a Stable Government Is a Strength

- **Doubt raised in class**: the point about a stable government under strengths was not clear.
  - **Answer**: if there is a coalition government in a country, then that country is automatically entangled in its own disputes; it becomes very tough for that country to take initiatives for international cooperation with a neighbouring country.

- India is led by one party for the past so many years, and thereby India can implement its long-term vision of geopolitical cooperation with any country it wants, because the government is stable.
- Had there been a coalition government at the same point, there would have been **pulls and pressures**.
- Example: when the **UPA-1 and UPA-2** governments were ruling **from 2004 to 2014**, the **DMK, the Trinamool Congress and the RJD** — all of these parties played a very important role in creating pulls and pressures for the ruling dispensation.
  - So that was not possible. In **2013** an agreement had to be signed [as stated in lecture — the agreement is not named in the recording, and the reference to the government of Manmohan Singh is garbled].
- A further question raised: what is the problem if **Generation Z protests** once **Balen Shah** becomes the government — the government wants strong actions [as stated in lecture].

QUICK REVISION

- The five strengths: strong civilizational, historical and cultural P2P ties; a stable government not dependent on a coalition; a generational shift in leadership; India's role as first responder with HADR capabilities; and India's developmental initiatives in Nepal.
- Political stability gives opportunities for collaboration; the generational shift allows recalibration because the leadership is educated in India and abroad, technocratic and eager to work with India as a partner.
- India's first-responder role: capabilities in HADR, as in Operation Maitri during 2015.
- HEP cooperation: Arun-III (900 MW), the Seti river project (1,200 MW, western Nepal), Upper Karnali (900 MW, awarded to GMR) and the 2022 Vision for HEP export.
- Transmission lines: Muzaffarpur–Dhalkebar 400 kV is built; Gorakhpur–New Butwal, Bareilly–Dodhara and Inaruwa–Purnia are in the pipeline.
- Pipelines and railways: the Motihari–Amlekhgunj petroleum pipeline, South Asia's first cross-border petroleum products pipeline (running since 2019), the Jainagar–Bijalpura–Bardibas line and the Jogbani–Biratnagar freight line to the ports.
- Integrated Check Posts for customs clearances are operational, and the 2023 Treaty of Transit lets Nepalese merchandise move through India's roads, rail, ports and inland waterways.
- The whole set makes India's development partnership and goodwill diplomacy a win-win strength for both countries.
- On the doubt: coalition governments are entangled in their own disputes, so India's single-party stability lets it implement a long-term vision — the UPA-1/UPA-2 years (2004–2014) with the DMK, Trinamool and RJD show the pulls and pressures a coalition brings.

23.6 Implications of Recent Events

The next major point is the **implications of recent events** — the financial/digital connectivity, the floods, and the recent elections in Nepal.

23.6.1 UPI and Digital Connectivity

- India has a **UPI initiative** and has signed it; **UPI is accepted** in Nepal.
- **Merchant interoperability** basically began in **2024**, and **India's UPI and Nepal's NPI were launched in June 2026** [as stated in lecture].
- So it means that if I carry my own phone, it can automatically be used for transactions in Nepal also — **UPI connectivity is there**.
- UPI connectivity is basically **financial connectivity**, or it can be written as **digital connectivity**.

23.6.2 Impact of the Floods

Is a flood a geopolitical impact? There is infrastructure loss and there is human loss, and that is not denied — but from the international relations perspective there is a loss, and therefore the terms of diplomacy come first.

- **First implication** — it reinforced the need for **bilateral or trilateral or multilateral cooperation on transboundary rivers**.

1. **Data sharing.**
2. **Flood monitoring.**
3. **Disaster preparedness and mitigation.**
4. **Need for an early warning system** — in brackets, an **international network of sensors**.

- India is **not getting the data of the sensors that we have in Nepal**; you need to have a strong cooperation between both of the countries — it is tough.
- In the first lecture you have to understand **how to play with IR**: if it is clear, then there will be no concern.
- **Climate finance** is possible — as an implication for India.
- **Second implication — the need for HADR**: as a **developmental partner**, India provided a **strategic yet diplomatic cushion** against perceived interference in Nepal's domestic affairs.
  - The keywords here are **strategic cushion** and **diplomatic cushion**.
- India was able to **convert its geographic proximity into diplomatic capital** — India converted its proximity into a diplomatic advantage.
- **Need for border and connectivity security**: the recent disaster has **exposed the vulnerability of Himalayan connectivity** — highways, information highways and transmission lines — because HEP projects were destroyed.
  - A good chunk, almost **10 to 13**, were being constructed by India's assistance; **2 to 3 were completely destroyed**.
  - So connectivity is not only physical connectivity: it is physical, it is digital, and it is also transmission lines.
- Therefore a **shift is required from more connectivity to resilient connectivity**.

23.6.3 The Recent Elections in Nepal

- The recent elections in Nepal **represent / present a generational shift in the domestic political environment of Nepal**.

- The question to answer is: do you agree, and **discuss the implications on India**?

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

How to write it.

- **Implications mean positive and negative** — write this question in a **structured manner**, covering whatever discussion we have had.
- This was a heavy class — the framework class; in the framework you have to **open this entire discussion and think from all perspectives**.

QUICK REVISION

- UPI is accepted in Nepal: merchant interoperability began in 2024 and India's UPI with Nepal's NPI was launched in June 2026, so an Indian phone can be used for transactions in Nepal.
- UPI connectivity is financial connectivity, or digital connectivity.
- First implication of the floods: it reinforced the need for bilateral, trilateral or multilateral cooperation on transboundary rivers — data sharing, flood monitoring, disaster preparedness and mitigation, and an early warning system with an international network of sensors.
- India is not getting the sensor data from Nepal; climate finance is possible; in the first lecture one learns how to play with IR.
- Second implication: the need for HADR — as a developmental partner India provided a strategic yet diplomatic cushion against the perception of interference; the keywords are strategic cushion and diplomatic cushion.
- India converted geographic proximity into diplomatic capital.
- The disaster exposed the vulnerability of Himalayan connectivity (highways, information highways, transmission lines): of about 10–13 projects built with Indian assistance, 2–3 were completely destroyed — so the shift must be from more connectivity to resilient connectivity.
- The recent elections in Nepal present a generational shift in Nepal's domestic political environment, and the implications for India have to be discussed.
- Implications mean positive and negative; the question must be written in a structured manner, thinking from all perspectives.

23.7 Way Forward

Way forward means what steps need to be taken. The keywords will remain, and you have to **play with the keywords**, with a little content build. Answer writing should not be over-stressed — answer writing is very easy; it is keywords. In the exam, the way forward is to be written **within five minutes of writing**.

- **Reinforce the roti-beti relationship** — but you have to be slightly nuanced: roti-beti is already reinforced, unless we get all the betis from there to India or all the betis from here there, and vice versa.
- **Neighbourhood First** is to be written.

1. **Careful diplomatic recalibration** — required after the recent elections, as **old diplomatic assumptions need to be discarded**. First of all, change your thinking.
2. **Project yourself as the elder brother and not the big brother.**
3. **Focus on connectivity** — youth connectivity by creating joint economic opportunities, and skill development; **cooperate as partners but not patrons**.
4. **Engage the new actors** — youth leadership, provincial governments, municipalities, civil society and, very important, entrepreneurs.
5. **Resolve the border issue in a separate diplomatic track** — do not include the border in the main discussion; keep the border aside and talk cooperation; **do not muddy the waters which are already muddy**; do not engage on the border along with trade.
6. **Smart border management rather than hard border closure.**
7. **Cooperation in disaster management — disaster diplomacy.**
8. **Maintain strategic sensitivity** — you have to be sensitive to the interests of the Nepali population.

- On the 'which brother' question — half brother, full brother, helpful brother, twin brother, great brother were all the guesses offered in class; the answer is the **elder brother, not the big brother**.
- **'Big brother' should not be written in Hindi** unless your medium is Hindi.
- **Brothers are never responsible; sisters can be responsible** — a statement by **Sushma Swaraj**, Member of Parliament, whose daughter [as stated in lecture: 'Niyabas Pari Swaraj' — read as Bansuri Swaraj] is a Member of Parliament.

Disaster Diplomacy — as Set Out in an Article

1. **Information sharing under an automated real-time protocol.**
2. **Data from different stations — seismic sensors and automated water level gauges — should be fed into a shared regional data grid.**
3. **Joint ecological research and risk mapping.**
4. **Coordinated disaster response drills and cross-border environmental projects**, which lead to **building functional trust**.

- On the map: some stations are here and some there — the data of all of them should be integrated so that a **regional picture emerges about the possibility or probability of the occurrence of a disaster**.

- India needs to be careful about **reiterating the old mantras** of cultural, historical and religious ties and invoking **'Roti Beti ka Rishta'** — do not keep saying Roti-Beti; **Janakpur, Ayodhya, Lumbini** have had enough.
- The line to end on: **youth engagement, connectivity, HEP** — and thereby **maintain strategic sensitivity**.

KEY CONCEPT

The keyword to carry out of this topic.

- **From a controlling power you need to move to the closest partner.**
- Diplomats keep revolving around the same developments in their articles; this lingo will come to you slowly — it takes time, and you will not have that much time to read several articles at one place, which is where the course assists.

QUICK REVISION

- Way forward means the steps to be taken: play with the keywords and build a little content; answer writing is not to be over-stressed.
- Reinforce roti-beti with nuance (it is already reinforced), and write Neighbourhood First.
- The eight headline steps: careful diplomatic recalibration after the recent elections, discarding old diplomatic assumptions; project yourself as the elder brother and not the big brother; focus on connectivity, youth connectivity, skill development and cooperation as partners not patrons; engage the new actors — youth leadership, provincial governments, municipalities, civil society and entrepreneurs; resolve the border issue in a separate diplomatic track without muddying already muddy waters; smart border management rather than hard border closure; cooperation in disaster management (disaster diplomacy); and maintain strategic sensitivity.
- Disaster diplomacy (from an article by Shashi Tharoor): information sharing under an automated real-time protocol; data from seismic sensors and automated water level gauges fed into a shared regional data grid; joint ecological research and risk mapping; coordinated disaster response drills and cross-border environmental projects to build functional trust.
- Do not keep repeating Roti-Beti, Janakpur, Ayodhya and Lumbini — the old cultural mantras have been overused.
- Close with youth engagement, connectivity and HEP, and thereby maintain strategic sensitivity towards the interests of the Nepali population.
- The final keyword: move from a controlling power to the closest partner.

CHAPTER 24

India–Afghanistan Relations

24.1 Reading the Nepal Question: The Implications Framework

The session opened by reviewing an answer on the **implications of the election of Nepal's new Prime Minister**, Balendra Shah (Balen Shah). The question was decoded as having two parts, and that decoding is the skill that matters.

- Part one — the **generational shift**, to be written in **50–60 words**.
- Part two — the **implications**, which form the main body of the answer.
- Keep the introduction short; the intro must not be over-written.
- Draw the diagram showing how **three parties have now shifted to one**.

What the generational shift could be built from:

- **Youth awakening** and a change in the form of government, including the rise of a **Madheshi Prime Minister**.
- A **shift in foreign policy** and a new focus on economic issues such as **unemployment** and **connectivity**.
- A **shift in disaster management** and a **rights framework**, along with a **rise of nationalism**.
- Together this signals an **economic shift, a social shift and a political shift**; the same idea can be opened along **economic, social and political dimensions**.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **How to read "implications".**
>
> - A question on **implications** is asking for **effects (asar)**.
> - Write them as **positive and negative** — some gains, some losses — or simply show both sides; it is not compulsory to force both ways.
> - For International Relations, frame them as **geopolitical, geoeconomic, geocultural and geostrategic**; show the examiner this structure and the answer reads as nuanced knowledge.

- A negative reading: the emergence of the **RSP (Rashtriya Swatantra Party)** requires a **shift in India's foreign policy**, because India engaged historically with a **trio of political parties** (including the Nepali Congress) and must now deal with a new majority party.
- The new government is **protocol-driven**, so engagement may become administratively complicated and diplomatic access may be limited.
- On disaster management, the new leadership frames **climate compensation from other**

countries — for temperature rise, glacier melt and flash floods in Nepal — as something owed to Nepal.

QUICK REVISION

- The Nepal question had two parts: the generational shift (50–60 words) and the implications (the main body).
- Draw the diagram of three parties shifting to one.
- Implications = effects (asar); frame them as geopolitical, geoeconomic, geocultural and geostrategic.
- The generational shift can be opened along economic, social and political lines — youth awakening, shift in governance, foreign policy, disaster management, rights and nationalism.
- The RSP's rise forces a recalibration of India's foreign policy away from the older trio of parties.

24.2 Geopolitical Implications of Nepal's Leadership Change

Framed geopolitically, the implications were numbered:

1. Requires a **recalibration of India's foreign policy** — India historically engaged with the **Nepali Congress**, and must now interact with the **RSP, which has the majority**.
2. The new government's approach is **protocol-driven**, which might **limit diplomatic access**.
3. Its focus on **strategic equality with India and China** may reduce India's diplomatic options and strategic heft.

These read as concerns rather than pure losses. Positive geopolitical implications were then added:

- A **stable government**, matched with India's **outcome-driven, partnership-based engagement**, may lead to **significant improvement in bilateral relations** — a win–win effect.
- The new Prime Minister is the **first Madheshi Prime Minister**, and Madheshis have strong **social, cultural and ethnic linkages with India**, creating scope to improve strategic ties.
  - Caution: he has not asserted his Madheshi identity; he presents himself as working for all Nepalis — whichever caste, region or language one comes from, it makes no difference.

EXAMPLE

Diaspora roots are not leverage.

- Individual success does not automatically translate into bilateral influence — the examples given were Kamala Harris' Indian origin, Indian CEOs and politicians, and **Zohran Mamdani, the Mayor of New York**.
- Identity is asserted by individuals; it does not by itself resolve India–US ties or deliver State-level leverage.
- A significant number of Indians live in New York; in the US they concentrate in Texas (Dallas), California (West Coast) and the New England states, including New York.

A fourth, forward-looking implication:

- **Continued strategic balancing between India and China** — a nationalistic foreign policy leads to **cautious continuity** and maintaining a diplomatic balance, rather than a drastic rupture or shift.
- Nepal's policy of balancing has deep roots: **Prithvinath Shah**, who unified Nepal in **1768**, described Nepal as a **yam between two boulders**.

A fifth implication:

- **Better delivery of policies and objectives** because of the new government's outcome-driven approach.
  - The underlying idea: a demanding, outcome-focused counterpart is simultaneously an **opportunity and a challenge**, depending on how India engages.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - 1 — Recalibration of India's foreign policy: from the older trio (Nepali Congress) to the RSP majority.
> - 2 — A protocol-driven government may limit diplomatic access.
> - 3 — Focus on strategic equality with India and China may cut India's options and heft.
> - Positive side: a stable government plus India's outcome-driven approach may markedly improve ties.
> - First Madheshi PM offers social/cultural/ethnic linkage — though he does not assert caste identity.
> - Continued strategic balancing between India and China: cautious continuity, not rupture; Nepal as a yam between two boulders (Prithvinath Shah, 1768).
> - An outcome-driven government also means better delivery of policies and objectives.

24.3 Geoeconomic Implications of Nepal's Leadership Change

The geoeconomic head moved from energy and connectivity to trade, and closed with the digital opportunity.

- **Continued focus on HEP (hydropower)** cooperation.
- A push on **youth connectivity**, which the discussion diagrammed as a triangle.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Connectivity means HIT.**
>
> - **Connectivity** for Nepal means **HIT: Highways, Information ways and (electric) transmission ways**.
> - Connectivity is about how the **youth** are connected; the triangle promotes highways, information ways and power transmission together.

- On **trade**, the implication is the **continued centrality of India** in Nepal's trade.
- But the huge **trade deficit** creates two pressures:

  - The **imposition of taxes** recently levied by the Balen Shah government.
  - **Diversification of trade** — Nepal might focus on new trade partners, hampering India's market access.
- Example: if Indian **LEDs** are exported to Nepal, Nepal could switch to **Chinese LEDs** for import.

- **Opportunities for digital connectivity**: a youth-driven, outcome-oriented government needs **visible delivery** on jobs, startups, urban services, tourism, digital governance and anti-corruption.
- This is an opportunity for India to cooperate on these verticals because of its expertise in:
  - **Digital stack** — Aadhaar, UPI, DigiLocker, DigiYatra and the CoWIN platform.
  - **Artificial intelligence** — **Bhashini**, the AI-enabled tool that translates speech into different languages.
  - **Startups** — India has the **third largest startup ecosystem in the world**.
  - **Connectivity**, **skill development** and **cross-border tourism**.

EXAMPLE

Managed tourism as an opportunity.

- European nations manage tourist circuits well: at major public sites they hand out **headphones with recorded history**, unlike the typical Indian guide who may narrate without adequate information.
- This is not only about ancient history but about **preservation of cultural history**.
- India is now promoting **village tourism**; with work-from-home and the staycation trend, tourists want to explore local culture.
- Nepal offers a wonderful opportunity here — cross the **Darchula bridge** into Nepal, and youth there can learn from India's experience and gain employment.

QUICK REVISION

- Continued focus on HEP (hydropower) cooperation.
- Connectivity = HIT — highways, information ways and transmission ways.
- Huge trade deficit leads to new taxes by the Balen Shah government and to trade diversification that harms India's market access (LED example).
- Digital connectivity opportunity: jobs, startups, urban services, tourism, digital governance and anti-corruption.
- India's edge: digital stack (Aadhaar, UPI, DigiLocker, DigiYatra, CoWIN), AI (Bhashini), third-largest startup ecosystem, connectivity, skill development and cross-border tourism.
- Managed tourism (European models, village tourism) is another opening, with youth employment in Nepal.

24.4 Geocultural Implications of Nepal's Leadership Change

- **Continued civilizational, religious and historical ties** between India and Nepal.
- The **Madheshi identity of the Prime Minister** gives India–Nepal ties a **new social dimension**.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **A word of caution.**
>
> - India needs to go **beyond the geocultural framework of roti-beti and religious ties** and instead create new opportunities for a **new Nepal**.
> - In this new Nepal, the youth work on **outcomes** more than on religion, cultural ties or ethnicity.
> - The engagement must be on parameters that **benefit both sides** — a professional, outcome-based arrangement rather than an identity-based one.

Yet the cultural dimension cannot simply be wished away:

- The **Ayodhya Ramayan circuit** example: very few youth may wish to travel that circuit in Nepal, but the older generation sees Nepal as the land **Sita** came from.
- That cultural dimension **cannot be taken away** from the diplomatic circles of Nepal and India — it requires a **rejig**, a shaking up.
- The same framework travels across countries: the dimensions of the whole South Asia bilateral relationship structure are the same — only the country changes.
- With a country like **Afghanistan** there is **no cross-cultural relationship**, so this dimension is much weaker there.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Continued civilizational, religious and historical ties remain.
> - The Madheshi identity of the PM adds a new social dimension.
> - Caution: go beyond roti-beti and religious ties and build opportunities for a new Nepal whose youth value outcomes.
> - Cultural identity still matters — Sita's Nepal, the Ayodhya Ramayan circuit; the diplomatic circles cannot discard it, so a rejig is needed.
> - The same framework applies to three or four South Asian countries; only the country changes (Afghanistan lacks a cross-cultural dimension).

24.5 Geostrategic and Security Implications of Nepal's Leadership Change

Two security-related implications were drawn out — the border question and internal security — followed by human security.

- **Border question**: the youth-backed government has a **nationalistic overtone** and may use nationalism to preserve domestic legitimacy.
  - This reduces India's strategic options and diplomatic space to settle the border dispute.

  - Nepal will not simply succumb; it will make India go through repeated rounds of border interaction.
- **Internal security**: continued cooperation is expected, driven by the security-first, nationalist approach of the new government.
  - Such a government wants to preserve Nepal's identity, and that impulse adds a stabilising ripple effect on internal security for India and the region.
  - A government that is not nationalist-driven may let its approach to security get compromised.
- **Human security / disaster diplomacy**: cooperation on disaster risk management, triggered by recent flash floods.
  - Leads to **better information sharing**.
  - Leads to a **regional map or data grid** highlighting areas prone to natural disasters.
  - Leads to **transboundary cooperation in disaster risk reduction of Himalayan disasters — GLOF (glacial lake outburst floods), flash floods, earthquakes, landslides and avalanches**.

EXAMPLE

The 2015 Nepal earthquake.

- The 2015 Nepal earthquake opened areas of cooperation, but the leadership of the time (KP Oli) was not hell-bent on improving the relationship.
- Nepal then tilted towards China, but China did not cooperate — so Nepal's focus may shift away from China towards India.
- This raises the prospect of a **regional grid for cooperation on disaster risk management**.

On the framework itself:

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

From Hyogo to Sendai.

- Disaster management earlier sat under the **Hyogo Framework (2005–15)**.
- It now sits under the **Sendai Framework**, which reframes the subject as **disaster risk management**.

QUICK REVISION

- Border question: a nationalistic, youth-backed government uses nationalism for legitimacy, shrinking India's diplomatic space and forcing repeated rounds of interaction.
- Internal security: a security-first nationalist government is expected to continue cooperation.
- Human security / disaster diplomacy: flash floods open information sharing, a regional hazard map/data grid and transboundary DRR.
- Himalayan disasters to note: GLOF, flash floods, earthquakes, landslides and avalanches.
- The 2015 earthquake opened cooperation, but KP Oli's leadership did not pursue it; China's non-cooperation may nudge Nepal back to India.

- Framework shift: Hyogo (2005–15) to Sendai — disaster management to disaster risk management.

24.6 Afghanistan: Engagement Without Recognition — Introduction and Plan

The second South Asian country taken up was **Afghanistan**. Its defining feature for India is a paradox: full engagement, but no recognition.

KEY CONCEPT

Everything except recognition.

- India has **not recognized the Islamic Emirate of Afghanistan** under the Taliban, but its **engagement has significantly increased** — this is the **pragmatic, cautious engagement** that defines the relationship.
- The formula: **engagement does not mean recognition**.
- **On 15 August 2021** the Taliban came to power and Afghanistan became the Islamic Emirate of Afghanistan; India has not recognized it.

- India's approach was relatively slow, but set against **Myanmar on the east** and the **Taliban on the west**, India has made **strategic inroads** and read the game well.
- The foreign affairs ministry is playing its cards well through a framework of **engagement without recognition**.

EXAMPLE

The phoenix and the minion.

- The **Afghanistan–Pakistan rivalry** is arguably more interesting for a student of IR than India–Pakistan: the erstwhile 'minion' — **Taliban 1.0, dependent on Pakistan's ISI** — rose like a **phoenix** into a sovereign state.
- It now clearly segregates its foreign policy approach and **denies strategic dependence on Pakistan**.
- Afghanistan is also emerging as a good **Test-playing cricket nation**, taking that space away from Pakistan.

The discussion was structured as follows:

- Introduce Afghanistan.
- Its **importance**, under the geopolitical, geoeconomic, geocultural and geostrategic heads.
- The **challenges** of engaging with Taliban 2.0.
- India's **strengths** in the relationship.
- The **way forward** (kept deliberately limited).

CRITICAL POINT

Why we engage — the polygon.

- Why India engages the Taliban is the same question as the **implications of the Taliban's regional rise**; students were asked to draw a **polygon diagram** to answer it.
- **Terrorism** as a hotbed of insecurity is treated inside the **challenges and importance** heads, not separately.
- The **China factor** is taken into account throughout.

QUICK REVISION

- Second South Asian country studied: Afghanistan.
- India has not recognized the Islamic Emirate of Afghanistan but engages fully — 'everything except recognition'.
- The Taliban came to power on 15 August 2021.
- India was relatively slow but has made strategic inroads; contrast Myanmar (east) and the Taliban (west).
- Plan: introduction to importance (geopolitical, geoeconomic, geocultural, geostrategic), challenges, strengths, way forward.
- Draw a polygon to answer why India engages; terrorism and the China factor sit within these heads.

24.7 Afghanistan: Historical Background

The history was told in phases, across three distinct Afghan identities — the Afghanistan of 1947, of Taliban 1.0 and of Taliban 2.0.

KEY CONCEPT

Graveyard of civilizations.

- Afghanistan has been called the **graveyard of civilizations**: no dynasty or king ever ruled it completely, and it is an unruly land run on **tribal identity**.
- More than Islam, it is **tribal identity** that connects: the Taliban succeeded against the US by capitalising on **Pakhtun identity**, which is **40–50% of the Afghan population**.
- **No non-Afghan has ever ruled Afghanistan.** Even a Punjabi, Sindhi or Baloch based in Pakistan engages through the **Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP)** — an organisation run by **Pakhtuns** who are ethnically the same as Afghan Pashtuns and who want to erase the **Durand line**.
- Heads of state, kings or presidents, have been killed by their successors, often openly — there is no dynasty.

Pre-1947: The North-West Buffer

- During the British period, Afghanistan served as India's **strategic north-west buffer**.
- It was a buffer against the **USSR** — to stop Soviet entry into the subcontinent, since from the

Indian subcontinent the USSR could have reached India through this region.

1747–1947: Independent Afghanistan

- An independent Afghanistan emerged, and **Afghan–India contacts grew**.

1947–1973: Monarchy and the Durand Line Dispute

- India became independent; Afghanistan remained a **monarchy**.
- The **Pak–Afghan dispute over the Durand line** — Afghanistan rejected the line and spoke of **uniting the Pashtuns** — became a headache for Pakistan.
- This produced **strategic convergence with India**; Afghanistan aligned with India.
- In **1950** the two signed a **Treaty of Friendship**, which drove **economic and cultural diplomacy**.
- It was a **golden age of Bollywood and music** — the high point of cultural diplomacy between Afghanistan and India.

1973: The Daud Republic

- **Muhammad Daud Khan** overthrew King **Zahir Shah**, ending the monarchy and forming the **Daud Republic**.
- Afghanistan became a **republic** and continued its engagement with India.
- A caution: this Daud Khan is not to be confused with the underworld figure Dawood.

> **DATA & FACTS**
>
> **Afghanistan's religious map.**
>
> - Afghanistan is predominantly **Sunni**.
> - Only **four countries in the world are Shia-majority**: **Iran, Iraq, Azerbaijan and Lebanon**.

1978: Rise of the Communist Forces

- **1978** is the flagship year from which the story changes.
- **Communist forces** rose, killed Daud, and **implemented drastic reforms**.
- The communists were split into **several factions**, which drew the USSR into the equation.
- In **1978**, President **Zia-ul-Haq** — a hardline Islamist military general — exploited the situation.

December 1979: The Soviet Invasion

- Soviet forces **invaded Afghanistan** in **December 1979** — a year flagged as very important for Afghanistan.
- The USSR acted on the **Brezhnev doctrine** — the imperative to protect communist regimes wherever they existed.
- The **mujahideen** grew powerful, supported by the **US, routed through Pakistan and Saudi Arabia**.
- India stayed **cautious**: it had Russia on one side and Afghanistan's **territorial sovereignty** on the other.

- The mujahideen were the **origin of the school that became the Taliban**, rooted in **AfPak Pakhtun identity**.
- They were handed the latest missiles, and this was the **peak of the Cold War (1978–79)**.

1989: The Soviet Withdrawal

- After **10 years**, in **1989**, Soviet forces withdrew.
- The US would later stay in Afghanistan for **20 years** by comparison.

> **DATA & FACTS**
>
> **The wider 1970s backdrop.**
>
> - Global oil money mattered: **oil was found in Saudi Arabia around 1976**, and money was flowing.
> - The US had pulled back from **Vietnam** — **Richard Nixon was president in 1973** — and needed to preserve its standing in Afghanistan after the Vietnam defeat.
> - **24 June 1975**: the Emergency in India launched the careers of a generation of non-Congress leaders — **Nitish Kumar, Sharad Yadav, Lalu Prasad, Venkaiah Naidu, Arun Jaitley and George Fernandes**.

1989–1992: Najibullah and the Collapse

- A **communist government continued under Najibullah**, known as **'the bull'** — the last communist president, and a very important name.
- In **1991 the USSR collapsed**, cutting off Najibullah's fuel and supply.
- In **1992** Najibullah was tortured and killed.

1992–1996: Civil War and the Rise of the Mujahideen

- A **civil war** ran from **1992 to 1996** — complete mayhem — as the **mujahideen forces** rose and occupied the state.
- This was the start of the **worst times for India**.
- **19 January 1990**: Kashmiri Pandits were forcefully made to flee; about **two to three lakh families** were evicted.
  - Money pumped in by external players through Pakistan was diverted to Jammu and Kashmir to support Islamic fundamentalist forces; there was no genuine 'Azadi' movement.

1996–2001: Taliban 1.0

- **Taliban 1.0** ruled from **1996 to 2001** — the worst period for India.
- It was worse than the **1998 nuclear test** or the **1999 war**, and comparable in India's memory only to **Partition**.
- **1999**: the **IC-814 hijack** forced India to release **Masood Azhar**, founder of **Jaish-e-Mohammed**; the plane landed in **Kandahar**, and **three to four people on board** were killed.
  - Taliban 1.0 was following the directions of the **Pakistani ISI**.

2001–2021: India's Golden Period

- After the **9/11 attacks**, the US invaded in **December 2001** and **Hamid Karzai** was elected.
- For India this was the **golden period — soft power diplomacy** and sustained development work.
- Even then, the Taliban kept attacking Indian missions.
- **2011**: India became the **first country** with which Afghanistan signed a **Strategic Partnership Agreement** — not Pakistan, not the US, not the USSR.
- India backed the **Northern Alliance**, which operated from **Tajikistan**; northern Afghanistan was never under Taliban 1.0.
  - Analogy: India earlier backed Sheikh Hasina; when the opposing party came to power, India lost the game.
- A recurring pattern: when a foreign power intervenes in a neighbouring nation, India has ended up on the losing side.

15 August 2021: Taliban 2.0

- **15 August 2021 — Taliban 2.0** came to power, a **major setback for India**.
- Over the 20 years to 2021, India pumped in a good number of **billions of dollars** of developmental assistance — that is the **goodwill** India built.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Pre-1947: Afghanistan was India's north-west buffer against the USSR.
> - 1947–1973: monarchy and the Durand line dispute produced strategic convergence; 1950 Treaty of Friendship; a golden age of cultural diplomacy.
> - 1973: Daud Khan overthrows Zahir Shah (Daud Republic); 1978: communist rise; December 1979: Soviet invasion (Brezhnev doctrine) and the mujahideen (US via Pakistan and Saudi Arabia) — the origin of the Taliban.
> - 1989: Soviet withdrawal after 10 years; Najibullah 'the bull' till 1992; 1991 USSR collapse.
> - 1992–96 civil war and the rise of the mujahideen; 19 January 1990 Kashmiri Pandit eviction (two to three lakh families).
> - 1996–2001 Taliban 1.0 (IC-814, Masood Azhar); 2001–2021 golden period (Hamid Karzai, 2011 Strategic Partnership Agreement, Northern Alliance).
> - 15 August 2021: Taliban 2.0 comes to power — a major setback for India.

24.8 Taliban 1.0 and Taliban 2.0: A Structured Comparison

Taliban 1.0 ran from **1996 to 2001**; Taliban 2.0 runs from **2021 onwards**. The two are compared attribute by attribute below.

Nature	A civil-war militia that won the civil war	A victorious insurgency that inherited the state; a political movement with political objectives
Territorial control	Incomplete — areas held by the Northern Alliance	Nationwide control
Ideology and social policy	Radical Islam; application of Sharia law	Continuation of social and religious policies, alongside promises of reform
Administration	Weak administration	Institutionalised and bureaucratic
Technology	Restrictive — against social media and computers	Highly sophisticated use of social media; engages Al Jazeera, uses Telegram
Economy	Driven by drugs and narcotics — opium cultivation and illicit money	Pursues trade; focus on agriculture, investment and regional connectivity
Diplomacy	Isolated and Pakistan-dependent	Multi-vectored diplomatic engagement, grounded in Afghan/Pakhtun sovereignty
International recognition	Recognised by Pakistan, Iran, the UAE and Saudi Arabia	Russia is the first nation to recognise Taliban 2.0, with wide diplomatic engagement with China, India and Central Asian republics
Terrorism and Al-Qaeda	Hosted Al-Qaeda and Osama bin Laden	Fights the Islamic State of Khorasan Province (ISKP) itself, but per the UN other terrorist groups remain present
Gender	Permitted males	Permits males, not females — a clear gender difference

- The **Deoband school**: a Taliban representative (Muttaki) visited the **Darul Uloom Deoband in western Uttar Pradesh**.
- **US–Taliban negotiations began in 2018** and were hosted in **Qatar**, where the Taliban maintained a political office; they put out their positions through **Al Jazeera** and **Telegram**.
- On **terrorism**, the shift is from hosting Al-Qaeda to fighting **ISKP** — yet the UN still records the presence of other terrorist groups such as Al-Qaeda.

- On **diplomacy**, Taliban 2.0 says **Afghan soil will not be used by any terrorist organisation** to target any country, including India, and seeks an **Afghan-led, Afghan-owned peace process**.
- Taliban 2.0 stands completely against the earlier **Ashraf Ghani**-era dispensation.
- On diplomacy, 1.0 was **Pakistan-dependent**: the US delegated dealings to Pakistan — you engage with them — instead of talking to the Taliban directly.
- The characterisation offered: a barbaric, uncivilised lot living in ancient times, professing an **eye-for-an-eye logic of execution**.

QUICK REVISION

- 1.0 (1996–2001) was a civil-war militia with incomplete control; 2.0 (2021 onwards) is a victorious insurgency with nationwide control.
- Ideology continues (Sharia) but 2.0 promises reform; administration moved from weak to institutionalised/bureaucratic.
- Technology: from restrictive to sophisticated social-media use (Al Jazeera, Telegram); political office in Qatar; US–Taliban talks began 2018.
- Economy: from narcotics to trade, agriculture, investment and regional connectivity.
- Diplomacy: from Pakistan-dependent and isolated to multi-vectored; recognition — Russia is first for 2.0 (1.0 was recognised by Pakistan, Iran, the UAE and Saudi Arabia).
- Terrorism: hosted Al-Qaeda and Osama bin Laden in 1.0; fights ISKP in 2.0, but other groups (Al-Qaeda) persist per the UN.
- Gender: males permitted, females not — the clearest difference.

24.9 India's Response: From Isolation to Calibrated Engagement

- India's response to **Taliban 1.0** treated it as a **Pakistan-based, Pakistan-supported hostile non-state actor or regime**, and India **opposed** it.
- Its response to **Taliban 2.0** is **pragmatic, cautious engagement**, with a focus on **counter-terrorism** and the embassy operating.

India's view	A Pakistan-supported hostile non-state actor/regime	A problem, but also a strategic opportunity
India's approach	Opposition; isolation	Engagement; calibrated engagement
Diplomatic presence	No embassy	Embassy operational
Framing of Afghanistan	A normative view, focused on values	A realist view, focused on India's possibilities
Regional trigger	Taliban was a threat	Taliban–Pakistan rivalry makes engagement a strategic opportunity

- Overall, India has moved **from isolation to calibrated engagement**.
- Taliban is no longer only a threat for India; it is now **both a challenge and an opportunity**.

CRITICAL POINT

Interview favourite.

- The phrase **from isolationist to calibrated engagement** is very often asked in the interview.
- The answer is **not separate from Mains** — the same arguments serve both.
- Make such terms part of your **lingo** so they flow naturally rather than being memorised separately.

- **Recognition**: India has **not recognized the Islamic Emirate of Afghanistan**, and would recognize it only after other countries do; **Russia** is the only major country to have recognized the Taliban.
- Analogy: recognition is like the **IES/IPS name tag** — you may be selected, but until you are officially designated, the formal seal is missing; India's dealings are therefore **non-official, individual-capacity** engagement rather than state-to-state recognition.

QUICK REVISION

- Taliban 1.0: a hostile, Pakistan-supported actor — India opposed and isolated it.
- Taliban 2.0: pragmatic, cautious engagement focused on counter-terrorism; embassy operational.
- Framing shifted from a threat to a challenge-and-opportunity, and from a normative view to a realist view.
- Overall: from isolation to calibrated engagement.
- India has not recognised the Islamic Emirate; recognition would follow others; Russia is the first major recogniser.
- The Taliban–Pakistan rivalry is what makes engagement a strategic opportunity for India.

24.10 Recent Developments in India–Afghanistan Engagement

The recent engagement is best read as a timeline — a sequence of steps that aggregate to engagement without recognition.

1. **Post-2023**: a **diplomatic breakthrough** — a meeting with the **acting Foreign Minister** of the Taliban.
2. **October 2025**: India announced it would upgrade its **technical mission** to the status of an **embassy** — diplomatic normalisation, but not recognition.
3. **January 2026**: a **Taliban-appointed diplomat** took charge of the **Afghan embassy**.
4. **June 2026**: India backed **Afghan sovereignty at the UN** and criticised Pakistan's military action that caused **civilian casualties**; the position was also stated globally.
5. **15 August 2026**: **Victory Day celebrations** were held at the Afghan embassy.
6. **Recent**: formation of **Joint Working Groups (JWGs)** on **Agriculture, Trade, Commerce and Investment** — a signal of increasing economic partnership.

- The **Agriculture Minister, Shivraj Singh Chauhan**, met the **Taliban Agriculture Minister**, expanding the vistas of cooperation.
- Elsewhere, tie-ups have deepened: wholesalers report a significant **increase in the price of dry fruits**, importing either straight from West Asia or via Afghanistan.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Afghan culture as soft power.**
>
> - In Delhi's **Lajpat Nagar**, the restaurant **Mazar** serves Afghan cuisine — **bolani** (a roti stuffed with spinach, leek or potato), **chapli kebab**, **mutton chopan**, **Uzbeki pulao** and **shiri** (a condensed-milk dessert).
> - This is **not part of current affairs** — it was given as cultural flavour, to feel Afghanistan's distinct culture, different from Punjabi Pakistan and from Iran.

- On **Kashmir**, Taliban 1.0 never really cared about India's engagement there, although the issue was vibrant while it ruled.
- After **Taliban 2.0**, its statements on terrorism and on the sovereignty of Kashmir (post-abrogation of **Article 370**) have become more responsible; it will not say anything that harms India's interests, as India–Afghanistan relations are on the upswing.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Post-2023: diplomatic breakthrough with the Taliban's acting Foreign Minister.
> - October 2025: technical mission upgraded to embassy status — diplomatic normalisation, not recognition.
> - January 2026: a Taliban-appointed diplomat takes charge of the Afghan embassy.
> - June 2026: India backs Afghan sovereignty at the UN and criticises Pakistan's action causing civilian casualties.
> - 15 August 2026: Victory Day celebrations at the Afghan embassy.

- JWGs on Agriculture, Trade, Commerce and Investment; the Agriculture Minister met the Taliban Agriculture Minister; rising dry-fruit prices signal deeper trade.
- Taliban 2.0's statements on Kashmir and terrorism have grown more responsible post-abrogation of Article 370.

24.11 Importance of Afghanistan: Immediate Neighbourhood, Buffer and Strategic Theatre

- Afghanistan is India's **immediate neighbourhood** — and, acceptably, an **extended neighbourhood**.
  - The **Wakhan Corridor** abuts **Pakistan-occupied Kashmir**; since Kashmir is India's, the corridor lies adjacent.
- It sits at the **junction of South Asia, Central Asia and West Asia**, and is the **centre of Eurasia**.
- It is a **security buffer**: instability there flows through **Pakistan and the ISI** into India.
- It is the **gateway to Central Asia** — a gateway of connectivity.
- Instability in Afghanistan **directly affects India's internal security** — for example through **narcotics and drug trafficking**.

KEY CONCEPT

Theatre of the Great Game.

- Afghanistan is a **strategic theatre** where great powers have been present — the **USSR (1979–89)**, the **USA (2001–2021)**.
- **China** is increasing its engagement, along with **Pakistan, Iran, Saudi Arabia and the UAE**.
- The **Great Game** is the fight for control of **Eurasia** between the **US and the USSR**.
- It is also a **civilizational partner** for India.

- On **countering Pakistan's influence**: **Taliban 1.0 provided strategic depth to Pakistan**.
- The **deterioration of the Pakistan–Afghanistan relationship** opens a **strategic diplomatic opportunity** for India to cooperate.

EXAMPLE

Great-power misjudgment.

- The same pattern repeated: the West first **propelled the Taliban**, and now that the Taliban is a major headache, it wants the **Bagram airbase** back.
- The **2003 operation launched by the Bush administration** is cited as a complete failure of geopolitics; after **9/11**, the West destroyed its own regional players — **Saddam Hussein** was first supported against Iran and then removed, and **Gaddafi** was pursued — leaving the buffer destroyed.

QUICK REVISION

- Immediate (and, acceptably, extended) neighbourhood; the Wakhan Corridor abuts POK.
- Junction of South Asia, Central Asia and West Asia; centre of Eurasia.
- A security buffer — instability passes through Pakistan/ISI into India and directly hits internal security (narcotics).
- Gateway to Central Asia.
- A strategic theatre: USSR 1979–89, USA 2001–21, China now (with Pakistan, Iran, Saudi Arabia, UAE); the Great Game = US–USSR contest for Eurasia.
- Taliban 1.0 gave Pakistan strategic depth; the Pak–Afghan fissure is India's diplomatic opportunity.

24.12 Importance of Afghanistan: Geoeconomic

- Access to **critical minerals** and **energy security**: **lithium, copper, iron ore and gold**.
  - The **lithium triangle** is **Argentina, Bolivia and Chile**; the **largest producer is Australia**.
- These feed India's **Net Zero by 2070** target — turbines, batteries and motors all depend on them.
- **HEP (hydropower)** potential exists — the **Kabul river** and three to four other rivers — but they carry **low discharge**.
  - Their tributaries flow **westward into Pakistan** (the Indus system); the rest discharge into **inland lakes in the south-western part of Afghanistan bordering Iran**.
- **Connectivity gateway to Central Asia**: Pakistan blocks transit access, so India uses the **Chabahar port** and an **air traffic corridor** to reach Afghanistan and beyond.
  - Example: India sent **wheat and pulses** to Afghanistan via **Iran**.
- **Bilateral trade**: Afghanistan is an **export market** for India, and there is **complementarity** between the two economies.
  - Afghanistan supplies **dry fruits** and **hing (asafoetida)**.
  - India offers **digital public infrastructure, health and pharma, education, MSMEs, startups, skill development and telecom**.

DATA & FACTS

Trade figures.

- India's exports to Afghanistan were approximately **US$1 billion in 2019–20**, reduced to **US$328 million in 2024–25**.
- Imports have risen, creating the **first trade deficit with Afghanistan since 2000–2001** — flagged as **important for Prelims**.
- Related exam point: a Prelims/Essay question can ask with which countries India runs a trade deficit.

QUICK REVISION

- Critical minerals for energy security: lithium (largest producer Australia; lithium triangle Argentina, Bolivia, Chile), copper, iron ore and gold; these serve India's Net Zero by 2070.
- HEP on the Kabul river and three to four rivers, but low discharge; tributaries flow west to Pakistan, the rest drain into inland lakes near Iran.
- Connectivity gateway to Central Asia via Chabahar port and an air traffic corridor; India sent wheat and pulses via Iran.
- Complementarity: Afghanistan supplies dry fruits and hing; India offers DPI, health/pharma, education, MSMEs, startups, skills and telecom.
- Exports fell from about US$1 billion (2019–20) to US$328 million (2024–25); first trade deficit with Afghanistan since 2000–2001.

24.13 Importance of Afghanistan: Geocultural and Soft Power

- **Civilizational connection**, including **Gandhara Buddhist heritage**; the destroyed **Bamiyan Buddha statues** in Bamiyan province were majestic and are being rebuilt.
- **Indo-Persian links**, along with **Bollywood, cricket and education**.
- **Medical tourism**: India offers it to Afghan citizens, alongside **scholarships**.
- India's strength here is **popular goodwill**.

EXAMPLE

Cricket and culture.

- Afghan players train in India — **Rashid Khan, Azmatullah Omarzai and Rahmanullah Gurbaz** — and the **IPL** has given them the limelight.
- Songs such as **'Afghan Jalebi'** helped popularise Indian culture across Afghanistan.

- **Sikhism** also links the two, through the **Afghan Sikh** community.
- But **diaspora presence is limited**, so it is not a major geocultural pillar.

QUICK REVISION

- Civilizational link: Gandhara Buddhist heritage; the Bamiyan Buddhas destroyed and now being rebuilt.
- Indo-Persian links plus Bollywood, cricket and education.
- Medical tourism and scholarships for Afghan citizens; popular goodwill is India's strength.
- IPL and Afghan players (Rashid Khan, Omarzai, Gurbaz) build soft power; songs like 'Afghan Jalebi' spread Indian culture.
- Sikhism links via the Afghan Sikh community; diaspora presence is limited, so it is not a major pillar.

24.14 Importance of Afghanistan: Geostrategic, Counter-Terrorism and Internal Security

- **Counter-terrorism** is the sharpest strategic reason: Afghan territory must not be used by terrorist groups such as **Lashkar-e-Taiba, Jaish-e-Mohammed and ISKP (Islamic State of Khorasan Province)**.
- **Political instability** becomes a **breeding ground for non-state actors**, directly affecting **India's security architecture and overall regional security**.

DATA & FACTS

UNSC 1267 Sanctions Committee.

- The **UN Security Council's 1267 Sanctions Committee** recently stated that the **terrorist threat from Afghanistan remains unchanged** — an **enduring threat to Central Asia and neighbouring nations**.
- It specifically named **Al-Qaeda and ISIL-K** (Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant – Khorasan).
- It made **no mention of anti-India groups** such as **LeT and Jaish-e-Mohammed** — a point flagged in a **Hindu editorial of 10 August 2026**.

- **Narco-terror** and **drug trafficking** are internal-security concerns emanating from Afghanistan.
  - **Golden Crescent** — Afghanistan, Pakistan and Iran.
  - **Golden Triangle** — Thailand, Laos and Myanmar.
  - India's **precarious location** between the two makes it vulnerable to trafficking.
- **Human trafficking** emanating from Afghanistan is another concern.
- It is important to **prevent the Taliban from becoming an external arm of Pakistan**, and to prevent **Pakistan's strategic depth**.
- **India's security presence is limited**: India has **closed its airbase in Tajikistan (Ayni)**.
- **ISKP and ISIL-K mean the same thing** — Islamic State of Iraq and the Levant – Khorasan; there is no difference between the two.

QUICK REVISION

- Counter-terrorism: Afghan soil must not host LeT, JeM or ISKP; instability breeds non-state actors that hit India's security architecture and regional security.
- UNSC 1267 Sanctions Committee: the threat is unchanged and enduring for Central Asia; it names Al-Qaeda and ISIL-K and is silent on anti-India groups (Hindu editorial, 10 August 2026).
- Internal security: narco-terror, drug trafficking (Golden Crescent — Afghanistan, Pakistan, Iran; Golden Triangle — Thailand, Laos, Myanmar) and human trafficking.
- Prevent the Taliban from becoming Pakistan's external arm; deny Pakistan strategic depth.
- India has closed its Ayni airbase in Tajikistan — a limited security footprint.
- ISKP = ISIL-K (the same entity).

24.15 Why India Engages the Taliban: Challenges and Way Forward

Why India engages the Taliban is the same question as the implications of the Taliban's regional rise — which is why the polygon drawn earlier doubles as the answer.

24.15.1 Challenges

- **Engaging a rights violator**: the whole world will raise **human rights**; the Taliban are violators, and India is engaging them — resolving this is exactly what the polygon is for.
- **Reputational and human-security risk** in dealing with a government accused of barbarism.
- **Geopolitical challenge — increased strategic depth for Pakistan**.
- **Increased Pakistan–China access**: Afghanistan has recently indicated a **willingness to join the China–Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC)**.
- The full challenge frame uses the same lens as before — **geopolitical, geosecurity, geoeconomic, geostrategic and geocultural**.

24.15.2 Way Forward

- **The way forward is deliberately limited**: the standard **Neighbourhood First** approach will not fully apply here, and a more specific approach is required.
- Continue **pragmatic, cautious engagement**, keeping **counter-terrorism**, economic partnership and connectivity at its centre.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

PYQ signal.

- In the past **13 years**, **no Mains question** has been set directly on **Afghanistan or Nepal**; neighbourhood questions came on Sri Lanka (2), Maldives (1), Bangladesh (1–2) and Pakistan (1–2).
- **2013 PYQ**: 'The proposed withdrawal of international security assistance from Afghanistan is fraught with major security implications for countries of the region. Examine in the light of the fact that India is faced with a plethora of challenges and needs to safeguard its own strategic interests.'
- The setter's intent there was **internal security** — so internal-security challenges emanating from Afghanistan must be foregrounded.

QUICK REVISION

- Why India engages = the implications of the Taliban's regional rise.
- Challenges: engaging a rights violator; reputational/human-security risk; increased Pakistan strategic depth; Pakistan–China access (Afghanistan's possible CPEC entry).
- Challenges are framed geopolitical, geosecurity, geoeconomic, geostrategic and geocultural.
- Way forward is limited; Neighbourhood First will not fully apply.
- Engagement continues — pragmatic, cautious, focused on counter-terrorism, economic partnership and connectivity.

- PYQ: no Afghanistan/Nepal question in Mains in 13 years; the 2013 question was framed around internal-security implications of withdrawing international security assistance.

CHAPTER 25

India–Afghanistan Relations — Part 2

25.1 Why India Chose to Engage with the Taliban

The discussion begins with why India chose to engage with the Taliban, even though there are real challenges in engaging with the Taliban. Those challenges are taken up separately, immediately afterwards; the reasons for engaging are written first.

1. Secure **3 billion dollars** in developmental initiatives in Afghanistan.
2. The **deterioration of Afghanistan–Pakistan (AFPAK) relations** provided a strategic opportunity, or a strategic space, for engaging with the Taliban.
3. A **shift in Taliban 2.0's approach** — in brackets, refer to the table of comparison of Taliban 1.0 and Taliban 2.0 — which created the opportunity of cooperation.
4. **Bilateral ties** (the heading survives; its content was not recoverable from the recording).
5. **Increasing engagement by other nations.**
6. **Other factors** — the same as the importance of Afghanistan for India.

- **The shift in Taliban 2.0's approach (reason 3)** — it is more willing to engage with different stakeholders.
  - It is pursuing a **diversified foreign policy**.
  - It is also **embracing technology**.
  - Together, these shifts created the opportunity of cooperation.
- **Increasing engagement by other nations (reason 5)** — Russia became the first to recognise [the Taliban].
  - China, Pakistan, Iran and the Central Asian Republics have all increased their diplomatic activity with the Taliban.
  - That activity has prompted India to engage and secure its interests.
- **Other factors (reason 6) — the same as the importance of Afghanistan for India**:
  - **Internal security concerns**, and counterbalancing Pakistan's influence.
  - **Economic reasons** — Afghanistan is a market for the products and services India can export.
  - **Medical tourism** is an opportunity India cannot let go of.
  - **Cultural reasons** — India has historical, civilizational and religious ties with Afghanistan.
  - **A people-to-people framework already exists** — Bollywood and the IPL have already created a framework of cooperation with the Taliban: IPL matches are going on, Afghan players are participating, and they are in the same country under the same regime.

- **Staying out has a cost** — if India does not engage with the Taliban, it is out of the developments taking place in Afghanistan, which can have direct ramifications for India's internal security: counter-terrorism, drug trafficking, human trafficking and narco-terror.
- All of this has ensured that India **cannot choose not to engage** the Taliban at the diplomatic, political and strategic levels.

KEY CONCEPT

First mover advantage.

- Some nations have already intervened, and they are the **immediate or extended neighbourhood** of Afghanistan. Whichever country engages the Taliban earlier than the others wins the trust of the Taliban regime, because at this point the Taliban **wants diplomatic recognition**.
- India has not recognised the Taliban, but in the past one year — after **Amir Khan Muttaqi's** visit to India — India has spoken about the AFPAK issue at regional and global platforms and has indicated its willingness to engage. That by itself is a **first mover advantage**.
- If India does not do it, somebody else will do it, and will take that narrow diplomatic space — which **China has already occupied**.
- The ramifications of developments in Afghanistan will affect the whole region, left and right; the opportunity of talking to Afghanistan cannot be let go on a platter.

QUICK REVISION

- Six reasons for engaging the Taliban: 3 billion dollars of developmental initiatives; the deterioration of AFPAK relations; the shift in Taliban 2.0's approach; bilateral ties; increasing engagement by other nations; and other factors (the importance of Afghanistan for India).
- Taliban 2.0's shift — more willing to engage different stakeholders, a diversified foreign policy and the embracing of technology — together created the opportunity for cooperation.
- Reason 5: Russia became the first to recognise [the Taliban], and China, Pakistan, Iran and the Central Asian Republics are all more diplomatically active with the Taliban.
- Reason 6 bundles internal security, counterbalancing Pakistan, economic reasons and medical tourism, cultural and civilizational ties, the Bollywood–IPL people-to-people framework, and the cost of staying out — counter-terrorism, drug trafficking, human trafficking and narco-terror.
- **First mover advantage**: the earlier a country engages, the greater its trust with a regime desperate for recognition; India has signalled willingness without recognition, while China has already occupied that diplomatic space.
- India **cannot choose not to engage** the Taliban at the diplomatic, political and strategic levels.

25.2 Challenges of Recognition of Taliban 2.0

The discussion moves from the reasons for engaging to the challenges of recognition of Taliban 2.0. Four challenges were dictated in class.

1. **Normative challenge** — recognition will normalize a coercive takeover or coup, because Taliban 2.0 did not occupy power under, or through, any constitutional, legal or democratic regime.
2. **Interference in Afghanistan's internal affairs** — recognition of the Taliban government would amount to, or be construed as, interference in Afghanistan's domestic affairs.
3. **Loss of leverage** — leverage is deemed necessary for pressing the Taliban to undertake domestic political, social and economic reforms.
4. **Loss of India's credibility and moral authority** — recognition would mark a significant departure from India's historic, value-centric foreign policy.

- **Normative challenge (1)** — a military coup or a political takeover is exactly what recognition would be endorsing, and that harms India's image as the **mother of democracy**.
- **Interference (2)** — recognition would be construed as interference in Afghanistan's domestic affairs.
  - Analogy: who are you to recognise the government? Who is the US to recognise the Modi government? Who is Pakistan to recognise the Shahbaz Sharif government?
  - It is a government that has come to power — even if with the help of a military takeover — and that is an internal matter of Afghanistan.
  - India cannot grant the certificate; it has the challenge of addressing the apprehension of **perceived interference** in Afghan affairs.
- **Loss of leverage (3)** — leverage is needed to press the Taliban into **domestic political, social and economic reforms**.
  - It is also needed to force the Taliban to ensure **inclusive governance**, the **upholding of human rights**, and addressing and cooperating in **counter-terrorism**.
  - Analogy: a child is willing to engage on your terms — the same logic applies to difficult children; today the Taliban is willing to take an initiative in its regional, religious, social, political and economic ideology, and it is desperate to get the certificate from at least countries like India.
  - India is the leader of the **Global South** and the bridge between West and East, and between North and South; if India gives recognition, half the job for a country like Afghanistan led by Taliban 2.0 is almost achieved.
  - India would then pick up the banner and promote the support of the Taliban regime at international platforms — it is the **chair of BRICS**, and BRICS and SCO engage on issues like counter-terrorism and ensuring global peace.
  - So the leverage, the influence and the effect India has would be completely gone.
- The **diplomatic weapon of recognition** must instead be used to ensure that Afghanistan takes up the initiatives that eventually lead to the emergence of a **stable political, social and economic order** in Afghanistan — that is what India expects.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **The bait and the mouse — recognition is a bet.**
>
> - If the objective is fulfilled by engagement, do not take the step: give them the bait and let the

diplomatic endeavours be fulfilled.

- To catch a mouse, bread is first put out; the mouse eats it, and then the next bait is given. Likewise, **recognition is a bet that is being offered to the Taliban**.
- It is very important to ensure that the Taliban leading Afghanistan ends up fulfilling India's interests by undertaking reforms.

- **India would be the biggest beneficiary of a reformed Taliban** — if tomorrow the Taliban becomes inclusive and gives rights to women, Afghan soil will not be used to create any instability, which will automatically act as a lever in improving the India–Afghanistan bilateral relationship.
- The chain of benefits: stability in Afghanistan → stability in the region → further propelling of India's stature → decline in Pakistan's stature.

25.2.1 *Why Pakistan Gains from Instability in Afghanistan*

CRITICAL POINT

- Pakistan has thrived because of instability in Afghanistan: instability makes great powers like **China and the US dependent on Pakistan**.
- Whenever relations between Pakistan and India are stable, the **ISI** or the military takes a very important role, ensuring that a terrorist attack happens or a proxy-war-like situation is created, so that the peace-time equilibrium and the betterment of the relationship are stalled; **non-state actors** fulfil that role.
- The Pakistani military is itself passing through an **identity crisis** since independence — a diplomatic identity crisis — so, to stay relevant, it wants to create or propel instability.

- **It has backfired on Pakistan** — in the North-West Frontier Province and the erstwhile **FATA** (Federally Administered Tribal Areas), a terrorist movement has destroyed Pakistan, affected its stability, and brought great disrepute to the Pakistani military's capability to address civilian unrest in its own country.
- **India, by contrast, is a status quoist power** — in India, **Operation Sindoor** took place [as stated in lecture], the Indian Army was praised the world over, and yet the Indian Army always remains subservient to the civilian government.
  - Analogy: the guard's job is in the institute, and the guard's worth is felt only when there are thefts in the institute.
- **Pakistan's own birth explains this revisionist instinct** — a voice raised against the British for the rightful reason; no modern social science can justify colonialism, imperialism, the exploitation of resources, suppression and subjugation of subjects, and in the post-Second World War scenario, after the UN was formed, it is a slap at global norms and rules.
  - A country like Pakistan, or China, wants to **revise the global order** to stay relevant, and therefore deliberately creates opportunities so that India's stature [suffers].
  - If the **Pahalgam** terror attack had not happened, India and Pakistan would have de-hyphenated.

- **Normalising a terror attack gives stakes to the terrorist** — equating a terror attack with an attack by the state hands the terrorist legitimacy.
  - Analogy: if a student misbehaves and is engaged with, that student gets the guts to stand up and hold a candle to the one in authority; a **hathi (elephant) must walk like a hathi**, and the Government of India needs to walk like an elephant.
- This **new normal** — and the absence of a rebuttal of terror attacks — plays, to some extent, in favour of the terrorist groups.
- Pakistan can then tell the entire world that it is India, not Pakistan, that repeatedly attacks in the name of proxy terror: **where is the proof?** Where is the proof that the attack was organised by the ISI?
- **State-sponsored terror, proxy terror and cross-border terror are India's own words** — if the proof is not shown, India plays into the adversary's advantage.
  - Pakistan has signed an agreement with Saudi Arabia last year — the **Mecca Pact** — so it has nothing to lose.

QUICK REVISION

- Four challenges of recognition: the normative challenge (normalising a coup and damaging India's image as the mother of democracy); interference in Afghanistan's internal affairs; loss of leverage; and loss of India's credibility and moral authority as a departure from its value-centric foreign policy.
- Interference analogy: who is the US to recognise the Modi government, who is Pakistan to recognise the Shahbaz Sharif government — a government that came to power, even by a military takeover, is Afghanistan's internal matter.
- Leverage is needed to press the Taliban into domestic political, social and economic reform, inclusive governance, human rights and counter-terrorism cooperation; India's weight as leader of the Global South and chair of BRICS makes its recognition a certificate worth half the job for the Taliban.
- **Recognition is a bet**: if the objective is fulfilled by engagement, do not take the step — give them the bait; to catch a mouse, bread is first put out.
- If the Taliban becomes inclusive and gives rights to women, India is the biggest beneficiary — stability in Afghanistan → stability in the region → India's stature up → Pakistan's stature down.
- Pakistan thrives on instability in Afghanistan and its military faces an identity crisis; it has backfired in the North-West Frontier Province and FATA, while India remains a status quoist power with an army subservient to the civilian government.
- Normalising terror gives stakes to the terrorist; state-sponsored terror, proxy terror and cross-border terror are India's own words — without proof India plays into the adversary's advantage.

25.3 China's Engagement with Taliban-Ruled Afghanistan

After the challenges, China's engagement is taken up. It was not part of the structure drawn on the board, so it is written out separately — five points.

1. China became the **first country to appoint an ambassador** to Taliban-ruled Afghanistan.
2. It became the **first major power to accept a Taliban-appointed ambassador in Beijing**.
3. It signed a **25-year oil extraction contract** with the Taliban in **2023**, though this was cancelled or terminated by the Taliban in **2025** — but the start was made.
4. **Mes Aynak**, a copper mine, where the work began in **2024**.
5. **Trade access towards Afghanistan** — direct flights, cargo routes, visas for Afghan traders, and preferential access to Afghan products.

> **DATA & FACTS**
>
> **China–Afghanistan bilateral trade.**
>
> - **Almost 600 million dollars** in **2022**, increasing to **almost 1.3 billion dollars** in **2023** — the trade almost doubled.

- The oil is **Amu Darya** oil; the **Amu Darya and the Syr Darya** are the rivers studied on the Central Asia map.
- **Direct flights**, **cargo routes** and **visas for Afghan traders** are the instruments of this trade access.
- **Preferential access to Afghan products** — the example is **pine nuts**, the famous dry fruit; China has a very big economy and is trying to provide economic access.
- In **2023** [the mechanism] also became active [as stated in lecture].
- China has promoted the **Afghanistan–Pakistan–China trilateral mechanism**, or regional diplomacy.

25.3.1 China's Wider Design: Encircling India

- China is trying to **encircle India** by creating the **string of pearls** and the ports already seen.
- **Nepal** is India's **only strategic buffer**, and China is trying to increase its engagement there too; fortunately the **Himalayas** have acted as a barrier — they are a cultural, physical and security buffer for India.
  - **K.P. Sharma Oli** made Nepal sign the **BRI** agreement.
  - Analogy: had plate tectonics placed India on the other side of the Tethys, India would have been eaten and emasculated by the Chinese.
- **Triangles are being built** — China–Bangladesh–Afghanistan–Pakistan, with Pakistan trying to reach **Muhammad Yunus** and the government in Bangladesh after so many years.
- The other axis is China–Pakistan–Afghanistan along the **Wakhan Corridor**; add Nepal, Myanmar and Bangladesh, and beyond them the entire **Indian Ocean region**.
  - What is left in the encirclement of India is the **bait of infrastructure**, the **bait of development** and the **bait of the Belt and Road Initiative**.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

The **Belt and Road Initiative** question was asked: it is the topic that had to integrate all these facts of South Asian diplomacy, as one topic of at least four or five classes.

- **Implications** — China's trade is almost doubling: it will be exporting pharmaceutical ingredients and everything that India has been importing, along with areas India promoted at great cost to the Afghans, such as green energy and cooperation in hydroelectric power (HEP).
- The potential is limited, but the **rugged terrain** and the **rarefied atmosphere** can be used to generate **solar power** — there is so much to happen there.

QUICK REVISION

- China's five-point engagement: first country to appoint an ambassador to Taliban-ruled Afghanistan; first major power to accept a Taliban-appointed ambassador in Beijing; a 25-year oil extraction contract in 2023 (terminated by the Taliban in 2025); the Mes Aynak copper mine, where work began in 2024; and trade access.
- Trade access means direct flights, cargo routes, visas for Afghan traders and preferential access to Afghan products — the example is pine nuts.
- Bilateral trade rose from almost 600 million dollars in 2022 to almost 1.3 billion dollars in 2023 — almost doubled.
- The oil is Amu Darya oil; the Amu Darya and Syr Darya are on the Central Asia map; China also promoted the Afghanistan–Pakistan–China trilateral mechanism, or regional diplomacy.
- China's wider design is the encirclement of India through the string of pearls, Nepal in the north (only strategic buffer, BRI signed by K.P. Sharma Oli, Himalayas as the barrier), a China–Bangladesh–Afghanistan–Pakistan triangle and the China–Pakistan–Afghanistan axis along the Wakhan Corridor.
- The Belt and Road Initiative was the question that integrated all these facts of South Asian diplomacy — a topic of at least four or five classes.

25.4 Strengths of the India–Afghanistan Relationship under Taliban 2.0

A table of strengths and weaknesses is now to be prepared. India and Afghanistan under Taliban 2.0 have to be seen together — as one system, one unit.

KEY CONCEPT

What counts as a strength here.

- The **comparative advantages** India brings to the table are also counted as strengths of the India–Afghanistan relationship.
- The **importance** of Afghanistan is the same as the strength — but **not all importance is a strength**.
- **Countering Pakistan is not a strength**; the deterioration, or the **common threat of Pakistan**, is a strength of the relationship — a strategic opportunity.

1. **Diplomatic willingness to engage.**

2. **India's goodwill.**
3. **Developmental diplomacy and humanitarian assistance and disaster relief (HADR).**
4. **Complementarity — diplomatic complementarity.**
5. **Economic complementarity.**
6. **Diplomatic complementarity in the strategic sense** — Afghanistan sees India as a counter-balancing force.

- **Developmental diplomacy and HADR (3)** — India supplied **wheat**, **medicines** and **vaccines**, and provided **earthquake relief aid**, **winter clothing** and **hygiene kits**.
  - Do not forget which vaccine: the vaccine for the **pulse polio campaign**.
  - Afghanistan — along with Pakistan — is one of only one or two countries in the world where this is still the case [as stated in lecture].
- **Diplomatic complementarity (4)** — both sides' interests meet, which makes this an interdependence rather than a one-way dependence.
  - What **Afghanistan** wants: recognition. Second, the **common adversary is Pakistan**.
  - What **India** wants: secured development and regional security. Second, the **common adversary is Pakistan**.
  - So there is **diplomatic interdependence** — we want what they want, and they want what we want; India cannot be taken for granted, and the relationship is not "we feed you in the IPL — who are you to speak?"
  - **Afghanistan sees India as a strategic counterbalancing force against Pakistan–China**, and thereby reduces its dependence on Pakistan–China.
- **Economic complementarity (5)** — India needs **critical minerals** and **energy security**.
  - Afghanistan wants stability of **market access**, and it wants to **revive its economy**.

25.4.1 From Taliban 1.0 to Taliban 2.0: Why Engagement Is Now Possible

- **Taliban 1.0 was a civilian group that did not know how to run the government**; now they have come to run a government — gone are the days when they were firing guns and missiles.
  - Now they want to engage; they want to be prim and proper; they are no longer goons — they have **risen up the ladder**.
- **1.0's dependence on Pakistan** — in **1979** the Soviet invasion took place, and the **ISI** and Pakistani forces trained them; when they got power the Mujahideen forces rose, the Soviets left, and they celebrated that jihad had been successfully achieved.
  - After **Najibullah** was assassinated [as stated in lecture], between **1992 and 1996** there were multifarious tendencies — there was the **Northern Alliance** and there was the Taliban — and in **1996** they took command.
  - Just as there had been dependence on the Communists — on Najibullah and Communist politicians — the Taliban were completely dependent on Pakistan for **logistics**, **weapons** and **intelligence**.
  - The whole of Afghanistan was not in their hands; the northern territories were with the Northern Alliance, so they had to talk to Pakistan **with folded hands**.
- **2001 and after** — 9/11 came, guerrilla warfare followed, and they overhauled their mecha-

nisms to engage with the US; from **2018** onwards the US was made to leave Afghanistan after the talks in **Doha**, and that gave a push to the activities of the Taliban.

- **August 2021, when they assumed power** — Pakistan supported them but still believed Taliban 2.0 to be the same as Taliban 1.0; the Taliban, this time, was clear: it wanted to prevent **diplomatic isolation**, to engage as the **leader of the government** (it was now the state, no more a militia or terrorist organisation) and to **reduce its dependence on Pakistan**.
- **Pakistan's mistake** — because of the past of Taliban 1.0 and the hangover, Pakistan ended up interfering in the affairs of the Taliban and denying the **Durand Line**, which Afghanistan wanted denied, insisting that this side is Pakistan and that side Afghanistan even though **Pashtuns** live on both sides; that created the problem and the mistrust emerged.
  - Now the Taliban is wary of China: it will use **China as a balance against India**, and **India as a balance against the emerging access of China and Pakistan**.
- **Perpetual hedging** is the practice in South Asia — India hedges its interests by engaging with diverse players, and so do Nepal, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka and Maldives.
- **Taliban 2.0 is to be seen as a state**; in 1.0 it was a militia — those who let the aircraft land on Afghan soil and forced India to release **Mr. Masood Azhar**. How could India engage and trust such a partner?
  - Today the Taliban clearly says "we condemn the **Pahalgam** terror attack" — would one ever have thought the Taliban would do that?
  - **Stability is what they seek**, because they have caught hold of power and there is no insecurity of being thrown out by anyone else; they now want to **consolidate** — "more consolidated" is a **key word** — given the rise of the **TTP** and the emergence of a close nexus.
  - **Political recognition by nations** has given them diplomatic stature: ambassadors are being exchanged, and **China is sending an ambassador to the Taliban** — that itself tells a lot about the force that the Taliban is in 2.0.

The contrasts established above, set out together, are the comparison of Taliban 1.0 and Taliban 2.0 that the discussion keeps returning to:

Nature	A militia and a civilian group; did not know how to run a government	The state and the leader of the government; wants to prevent diplomatic isolation
Dependence on Pakistan	Completely dependent on Pakistan for logistics, weapons and intelligence; talked to Pakistan with folded hands	Wants to reduce its dependence on Pakistan; uses China as a balance against India and India as a balance against the emerging China–Pakistan access
Behaviour	Firing guns and missiles; no experience of governing	Wants to engage and to be prim and proper; no longer goons — they have risen up the ladder
Trust deficit for India	Let the aircraft land on Afghan soil; India had to release Mr. Masood Azhar	Publicly condemns terror attacks; seeks stability and consolidation

QUICK REVISION

- Strength means whatever India and Afghanistan under Taliban 2.0 offer each other as one unit; comparative advantages India brings count too, and not every importance is a strength — countering Pakistan is not a strength, but the common threat of Pakistan is.
- The six strengths: diplomatic willingness to engage; India's goodwill; developmental diplomacy and HADR; diplomatic complementarity; economic complementarity; and Afghanistan seeing India as a strategic counterbalancing force against Pakistan–China.
- India's HADR: wheat, medicines, vaccines (the pulse polio vaccine), earthquake relief aid, winter clothing and hygiene kits.
- Diplomatic interdependence: Afghanistan wants recognition and a counterweight against Pakistan; India wants secured development and regional security — with Pakistan as the common adversary.
- Economic complementarity: India needs critical minerals and energy security; Afghanistan wants market access and economic revival.
- Taliban 1.0 was completely dependent on Pakistan (trained by the ISI after the 1979 Soviet invasion; in command from 1996); after 2001, 9/11, the Doha talks and August 2021 it became Taliban 2.0 — a state that wants to end isolation and cut its dependence on Pakistan.
- Pakistan's denial of the Durand Line bred the mistrust; perpetual hedging is the rule in South Asia, and Taliban 2.0 — which condemns terror attacks, seeks stability and consolidates — is to be seen as a state.

25.5 Weaknesses of the India–Afghanistan Relationship under Taliban 2.0

The weaknesses follow the strengths. Six were dictated, and the section closes with the normative contradiction at the heart of India's position.

1. **Recognition dilemma** — several leaders of the Taliban are listed under the **UNSC's 1988 Taliban Sanctions Committee**, which is specifically meant for the Taliban only.
2. **Perpetual weakness / security uncertainty** — the Taliban keeps repeating that there will be no terrorists.
3. **Ideological continuity** — human rights violations, limited rights for women and the strict application of Sharia.
4. **Increasing China–Pakistan influence**, with the emergence of trilateral cooperation.
5. **Factionalism within tribal identities** — differences between the Kabul and the Kandahar leaderships.
6. **India's normative contradiction** — India's value-centric foreign policy goes against the policies of the Taliban.

- **The recognition dilemma (1) and the security uncertainty (2)** — the Taliban keeps repeating, over and over, that there will be no terrorist [as stated in lecture], yet several of its leaders stand listed under a committee meant specifically for the Taliban.
  - That is why the recognition dilemma is a **perpetual weakness** as well as a source of **security uncertainty**.

> GOVERNMENT & POLICY
>
> **The sanctions architecture cited.**
>
> - **UNSC 1988 Taliban Sanctions Committee** — meant specifically for the Taliban; several Taliban leaders are listed under it.
> - **1267 UNSC report** — released in **August 2026**.

- A student in the class pointed out where the real power lies: there are **many factions inside the Taliban**; the government runs from **Kabul**, but the real authority — the **Supreme Leader**, **Hibatullah Akhundzada** — sits in **Kandahar**.
- The **Haqqani network**, of the **Haqqani brothers**, is the most powerful network in Afghanistan — it holds the **Home Ministry** itself, it is a part of the government, and it has **deep relations with Al-Qaeda**.
  - The interior ministry, the home ministry, is basically with the Haqqani, and the entire internal setting of Afghanistan is watched by them.
  - Analogy: "I become a terrorist and you are Haqqani — will you ever leave me? I taught you; you will never leave me." How can somebody trust such a partner?
- **Ideological continuity (3)** — there are human rights violations, limited rights for women and the strict application of Sharia.
  - So how is such a group to be recognised? One-point-O was one thing, two-point-O is another.

- **Increasing China–Pakistan influence (4)** and the emergence of **trilateral cooperation — Xi Jinping** and **Mr. Sharif** are very slowly getting their act together and calling Afghanistan [to the table].
  - Pakistan keeps its relationships **deliberately ambiguous**: bombardment on one side, and **Ishaq Dar** going to a foreign ministers' trilateral meeting on the other.
- **Factionalism within tribal identities (5)** — leadership is based on community, and no one will accept a person sitting on top of them; in **Mahajanapada** history, out of the **16** mahajanapadas there were certain **republics** as well.
  - There is factionalism within the Taliban, and the leaderships in **Kabul** and **Kandahar** have differences.
  - **Kandahar** represents the traditional wing — the wing reflected in Taliban 1.0; **Kabul** represents the latest trend of ministers who have been educated abroad, speaking English and fond of Rolex watches.
  - **Amir Khan Muttaqi** was taught in **Darul Uloom** in India and is an Islamic scholar — those are scholars, but these others are not scholars, they are **butchers**.
  - When butchers and scholars meet, there will obviously be an **ideological crisis**; so **who do you engage with?** Even if they agree, tomorrow they might backfire and there will be instability within.

COMPARISON

The two wings of the Taliban.

- **Kandahar** — the traditional wing of the Taliban, the wing reflected in Taliban 1.0; the real authority, the Supreme Leader, sits there.
- **Kabul** — the latest trend of ministers educated abroad, speaking English and fond of Rolex watches; the government runs from here.

- **The Ghani–Karzai question — Ashraf Ghani** was the president when Afghanistan had a presidential form of government; the Taliban has lately been engaging with him and was also engaging with **Hamid Karzai**, but both are completely out of the picture.
  - Open question put in class: is Ashraf Ghani completely set aside? He is not in Afghanistan — he must have taken refuge in some country, probably in the Middle East.
- **India's normative contradiction (6)** — India's **value-centric foreign policy** goes against the policies of the Taliban.
  - Taliban policy — **strict segregation of men and women**; women are banned from workplaces.
  - **Contraction of the Afghan economy**, and almost **half of the population requires humanitarian assistance**.

KEY CONCEPT

The best metric of a society's progress.

- The best and the easiest metric to judge any society's progress is the **status of women** in that society.

- If women are relatively at par with men as compared with other societies, that is the **biggest fulcrum** and the biggest indicator of that section's happiness — the section being a village, a caste, a region or anything else.
- Such a section will automatically be striving much further ahead of others if women are given their space — political, social, educational or cultural. **Women's representation is very important, and in Afghanistan it is zero.**

- **The matrilineal example** — in the North, the matrilineal communities, the part least integrated with the mainland, are actually socially much ahead of the general perception Indians have of themselves.
  - There are tribes unfortunately called **primitive** whose behaviour towards the other gender is completely at par — the metric holds regardless.

QUICK REVISION

- Six weaknesses: the recognition dilemma (UNSC 1988 Taliban Sanctions Committee); perpetual weakness and security uncertainty; ideological continuity; increasing China–Pakistan influence; factionalism within tribal identities; and India's normative contradiction.
- The 1267 UNSC report was released in August 2026; several Taliban leaders stand listed under the 1988 Taliban Sanctions Committee, which is meant specifically for the Taliban.
- Power inside the Taliban runs from Kabul, but the Supreme Leader, Hibatullah Akhundzada, sits in Kandahar; the Haqqani network holds the Home Ministry, is part of the government and has deep relations with Al-Qaeda.
- Kandahar is the traditional wing of Taliban 1.0; Kabul is the wing of ministers educated abroad — an ideological crisis between scholars and butchers, so who do you engage with?
- Xi Jinping and Mr. Sharif are building trilateral cooperation, while Pakistan bombards on one side and sends Ishaq Dar to a foreign ministers' meeting on the other — relationships kept deliberately ambiguous.
- India's normative contradiction: the Taliban enforces strict segregation, bans women from workplaces, and the Afghan economy is contracting, with almost half the population needing humanitarian assistance.
- **The status of women is the best metric of a society's progress** — and in Afghanistan that metric is zero.

25.6 Way Forward: Engagement Without Recognition

The steps already taken by the Government of India towards the Taliban have been discussed; what remains is to write the further steps and the way forward, as suggestions for engaging with the Taliban.

1. Maintain a policy of **cautious, pragmatic engagement**.
2. Promote **developmental diplomacy** (in brackets: through the **Chabahar port**) — engage with Afghanistan not as an "enemy's enemy" but as a **strategic partner**, and simultaneously leverage or press the Taliban to undertake domestic economic and social and political reforms.

3. **Micro-level engagement** — engage with the Taliban at all levels and with all the **power centres**, from **Kabul and Kandahar**, and thoroughly assess the **alignment of the Haqqani network with Al-Qaeda** before granting recognition.
4. **Develop international consensus** on engagement with the Taliban, if the requisite reforms are undertaken by Taliban 2.0.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> At the **SCO summit**, the PM spoke for an **inclusive government in Afghanistan** — the model of pressing for reform while engaging.

- The **interior ministry, the home ministry, is basically with the Haqqani**, and the whole internal setting of Afghanistan is watched by them.
  - So if the level of Al-Qaeda's activity is to be assessed, **100 per cent of that knowledge is with the Haqqani**.
- The terrain is **rugged**, with so many mountains, and it is **inhospitable** — removing the Soviets took **15 years**, even **20–25 years** — so what does India achieve by recognition?
  - India has **no stakes** there; India cannot go in.
  - The **Haqqani network is spread out** across this terrain, and they are the home minister.
  - That is India's headache — but it is India's **neighbourhood**, and it has to be handled.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - The four suggestions: cautious, pragmatic engagement; developmental diplomacy through the Chabahar port; micro-level engagement with all power centres, from Kabul and Kandahar; and international consensus on engagement if the requisite reforms are undertaken.
> - Engage with Afghanistan not as an enemy's enemy but as a strategic partner — and simultaneously press the Taliban into domestic economic, social and political reforms.
> - Example of that pressure: at the SCO summit, the PM spoke for an inclusive government in Afghanistan.
> - Before granting recognition, thoroughly assess the Haqqani network's alignment with Al-Qaeda — the interior ministry is with the Haqqani, and 100 per cent of the knowledge of Al-Qaeda's activity lies with them.
> - India has no stakes on the ground: the terrain is inhospitable, removing the Soviets took 15 years (even 20–25), and the Haqqani network is spread out — a headache, but it is India's neighbourhood.

25.7 Overall Assessment: Recognition Is Not an Option

The discussion closes with the overall assessment: the Taliban is the reality, and it cannot be denied.

- Factionalism exists in every political leadership — there is factionalism within the **BJP**, within the **Labour Party**, within any party of the world — which is why the Taliban cannot be dismissed as a fact of life.

- But that factionalism **cannot be compared** with the factionalism witnessed in the Taliban, because this is an organisation having a **neck-and-neck network with Al-Qaeda**.
  - Therefore **recognition is not an option**.

KEY CONCEPT

How to hold the line.

- India has taken the good lead — it is a good example of India exercising **pragmatism**.
- The **leverage and influence** India has must be used **strategically**; till that point, **developmental needs, capacity building and improvement of people-to-people relations** are the key.
- A **perfect silence cannot be maintained** — India has to be engaged with the Taliban, or with whatever regime there is in Afghanistan.

- India has also exercised pragmatism in **Myanmar**, where he chose India as the first country [as stated in lecture] — that itself tells you that even your neighbours are willing to engage with you on your terms.
- That is why **SCO is also an important platform**: it is another place where developments in Afghanistan can be engaged with and discussed from a world view, and where developments in that country can be learnt — which helps strategise the relationship with Afghanistan.

QUICK REVISION

- The Taliban is the reality; factionalism exists in every party, but the Taliban's factionalism cannot be compared with ordinary party factionalism because of its neck-and-neck network with Al-Qaeda.
- Therefore recognition is not an option.
- India has taken the good lead and has exercised pragmatism — including in Myanmar, where the other side chose India first.
- Leverage and influence must be used strategically; developmental needs, capacity building and people-to-people relations are the key.
- A perfect silence cannot be maintained — India has to stay engaged, and SCO is an important platform for that engagement.

CHAPTER 26

The National Human Rights Commission (NHRC)

26.1 NHRC in the Examination: Placement and PYQ Trends

Polity is taken up for the first time with this topic. **NHRC** stands for the **National Human Rights Commission** — a key term which is also referred to by a very common shorthand.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **The common shorthand for the NHRC.**
>
> - NHRC is commonly referred to as a **toothless tiger**.

26.1.1 Where It Sits in General Studies Paper 2

- NHRC is part of **GS2**, whose main subject is **polity**.
  - GS2 has four broad heads: **polity, governance, social justice and international relations (IR)**.
- Polity is the **first theme** within GS2, and within polity the NHRC is the **last sub-theme — regulatory bodies**.

26.1.2 The PYQ Record of the Regulatory Bodies

- Questions have been asked on the **national commissions**, and all of them share one common problem.
- **NCSC, NCST, NCBC, NCW and NCPCR** — these five have been asked thoroughly in the examination.
- One question was asked on the **CBI**, based on current affairs; the CBI [as stated in lecture] is a very low-probability topic.
- One question was asked on **Lokpal** in **2013**, in the very first year of the examination, when Lokpal was itself a current affair.
  - Lokpal needs no separate class discussion — notes will be provided for it.
- The **Central Information Commission** is not in the news; the CIC, the CVC and similar bodies form a list of about **20 bodies**, and all of them cannot be compared.
- The **Competition Commission** has also been asked, but it is discussed under a separate head.
- The **Finance Commission** is a separate topic.
- The **Election Commission** belongs to the separate vertical of elections, election reform and the **RPA 1951 (Representation of the People Act)**; it is not taken up here.
- Whatever has been asked in the PYQs will be 100% covered in this module; if the CIC comes

into the news before the last day of this module, it will be incorporated.

> **DATA & FACTS**
>
> **How much has been asked.**
>
> - Regulatory bodies: almost **10–15 questions** — in the lecture's account all of them on the NHRC [as stated in lecture].
> - National commissions: **four or five questions**.
> - CBI: **one question**.
> - Lokpal: **one question**, in 2013.

A question **100% will come** either from the NHRC or from the different national commissions. All the PYQs on these bodies will be taken up in class, and content and framing will be done for all of them.

26.1.3 The Kinds of Questions Asked

- Ask for the **limitations of the NHRC — structural and practical**.
  - And then ask you to suggest **remedial measures** — 'what steps do you recommend'.
- Ask the **pros and cons of merging all these commissions into one place**: the National Commission for Women is important and so is the NHRC, so should there be only one body?
- Ask the **role of the NHRC in upholding human rights** — what work has the NHRC actually done?
- Ask about **constitutional status**: a commission was recently given constitutional status, so what role remains — what are the benefits of giving constitutional status to an institution? [as stated in lecture] This will be discussed separately.
- Ask the core gist question: **'NHRC is a toothless tiger — do you agree? Say yes or no.'**

26.1.4 The Merger Question: Positives and Negatives

A **SEBI and IRDA question was asked in 2013–14** (SEBI in 2013 or 2014), framed on a current topic: the **product diversification of financial institutions and insurance companies** resulting in overlapping of products and services, and the **ULIP (unit linked insurance product)** that was being introduced or contemplated. That question strengthened the case of merger of two regulatory agencies — the same logic will be asked for any other body, with only the example changing.

> **COMPARISON**
>
> **Merging the commissions into one body.**
>
> - **Positive — economies of scale**: no separate staff, separate salary, separate workforce, separate website or separate digital governance mechanism is required for each of them.
> - **Negative — specialised regulation is compromised**: the specialised regulation required for different products is lost, and the specialised needs of certain sections such as **women and children** get missed out.

QUICK REVISION

- **NHRC = National Human Rights Commission**; it sits in GS2, in the last sub-theme of polity — **regulatory bodies**.
- Its common shorthand in the examination is **toothless tiger**.
- PYQ record: almost **10–15 questions** from regulatory bodies, **four or five** on the national commissions, **one** on the CBI and **one** on Lokpal (2013).
- The five commissions asked thoroughly: **NCSC, NCST, NCBC, NCW, NCPCR**.
- A question **100% will come** either from the NHRC or from the different national commissions.
- Merger question: weigh **economies of scale** against the loss of **specialised regulation** and the special needs of women and children.

26.2 How the Discussion Is Structured

The structure of this topic is very important, and it is easy because this is a polity topic: you have to read exactly what is told, memorise it as it is, and use the **answer lingo**.

- This subject yields **12–13 questions**, but you have to use the subject's **lingo (technical vocabulary)**.
- Unlike **IR**, which is a **khichdi** (a mixture) that you must prepare in your own head, this topic is not spread out and is not tough to strike.
  - In this topic, nothing beyond what is taught will come in the examination.
- The target of the module: every PYQ asked between **2013 and 2026** should be attemptable.
- The discussion is **PYQ-based** — all the issues around the PYQ are covered.

26.2.1 The Four-Part Structure

1. **Constitutional and statutory provisions** — it is a non-constitutional body, but there is still something to look at.
2. **Importance or role of the NHRC in upholding human rights** — examples have to be given here.
3. **Issues, concerns or challenges** — the NHRC's incapability to uphold human rights, including the **merger**: the positives and the negatives of merging all the commissions.
4. **Way forward or suggestions**.

The order inside the class is reversed for the middle two: **issues are taken first**, and the importance is to be written by the students themselves and discussed later — otherwise it remains only an exercise.

EXAMPLE

An example of the NHRC upholding human rights (for the 'role with examples' question).

- The NHRC demanded a **report from the Chief Secretary of Delhi** regarding the construction happening in Delhi [as stated in lecture] — that is how the Commission upheld human rights.

- The underlying problem: very few colleges of **Delhi University** have a hostel, and even to get one there is a **criteria of merit**; apart from the technical, management and premier institutions, colleges of humanities, universities and social sciences in Delhi do not have hostel facilities.
- **Malkaganj** is an area of certified criminals who keep repeating criminal acts, and students stay there because there is no hostel.
- **Satya Niketan** was built in the **1970s** to rehabilitate people; it has good colleges along the road — **Venkateshwar College, Motilal Nehru College, PGDAV College, Atma Ram Sanatan Dharma College** — and is also a hub of coaching; students live there.
- Other such areas are **JNU** (actually Munirka village) and **IIT Delhi**, with **Ber Sarai, Katwaria Sarai and Neb Sarai**; waterlogging in these areas has been addressed [as stated in lecture].
- One regularly reads in the newspaper that the NHRC is demanding a report — that is the material for the examples.

QUICK REVISION

- Structure the topic in four parts: **provisions** → **role with examples** → **issues (including the merger)** → **way forward**.
- Issues are taken first in class; the importance of the NHRC is to be written by the student.
- This is a **polity** topic: read as taught, memorise as it is, and use the **answer lingo**; nothing beyond the material will be asked.
- **IR is a khichdi**; polity is bounded — **12–13 questions** come from it.
- Target: attempt every PYQ from **2013 to 2026** from this module.
- Example to remember for the role question: the NHRC seeking a report from the **Chief Secretary of Delhi**.

26.3 Introduction: Legal Mandate and Constitutional Roots

In the main structure, this part is written as the **introduction** of every answer on the NHRC.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

The law behind the NHRC.

- The relevant law is the **Protection of Human Rights Act (PHRA), 1993**.
- It is a **statutory body**: it derives its powers from a law, and **no article of the Constitution** speaks about its functions, term, appointment or removal — unlike the **CAG, the Election Commission, NCSC, NCST and NCBC**.

26.3.1 Why the Law Was Amended

- Earlier, only a **Chief Justice of India** could become the Chairperson, so the field was limited to persons who had been and retired as CJI — a very limited **sample size**.
- The law was changed so that a **serving or retired Supreme Court Judge** can also be made the Chairperson; the amendment was made only to **enhance the sample size** of persons who

could be made NHRC Chairperson.

- The last Chairperson was appointed in **December 2024** — **Justice Ramakrishnan** [name as stated in lecture], a Judge of the Supreme Court; a member's term is **five years**.

The mandate of the NHRC is the **protection of human rights** — that is the keyword. The mandate is enjoyed by the law, but the body is **rooted in the Constitution**.

26.3.2 *Rooted in the Constitution: The Letter and the Spirit*

- Several articles of the Constitution — **especially the Fundamental Rights** — are human rights.
  - **Article 14** — the right to equality.
  - **Article 15** — protection against discrimination.
  - **Article 21** — right to life and personal liberty.
  - Articles 14, 15, 16; freedom of speech and expression; Articles 20, 21 and 25 — the list is never-ending.
- The **Directive Principles of State Policy** speak of **bonded labour, the rights of the child, the right to public health and nutrition (mid-day meal), livelihood and humane working conditions**.
  - The mid-day meal is definitely a human right: when there is a problem, the Commission issues notices to the state government.
- The **Fundamental Duties** also bear on human rights — **Article 51A(c)**: to foster respect for international law and treaty obligations.
- Several **international covenants** and international provisions speak about respecting human rights.
- Therefore, even though this is not a constitutional body but a statutory one, it upholds the principles of human rights which are strewn across different parts of the Constitution.
- So the mandate may not be in the Constitution **by the letter**, but it is there **by the spirit** — the NHRC is doing nothing but upholding the constitutional values reflected in Fundamental Rights, Fundamental Duties and the DPSPs, rooted in **constitutional morality**.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **How to write the introduction.**
>
> - A **non-constitutional body** in prelims terms, but **rooted in the principles and the spirit reflected in constitutional morality** — it is nothing but an agency upholding human rights and the values of the Constitution.
> - **Do not write 'it is a statutory body, full stop.'** Write that it is a statutory body **but rooted in the constitutional articles and the constitutional values of human rights**.
> - The mandate is enjoyed by the law, but the body adheres to these principles — and these principles are **not complied with** by the NHRC. That is the issue, the concern, and the reason it has not been able to fulfil its role as a statutory body upholding fundamental rights.

QUICK REVISION

- The governing law is the **Protection of Human Rights Act (PHRA), 1993**.
- It is a **statutory body**; no article of the Constitution covers its functions, term, appointment or removal.
- Its mandate — the **protection of human rights** — is rooted in the Constitution through Fundamental Rights, DPSPs and Fundamental Duties.
- The law was amended so that a **serving or retired Supreme Court Judge** can be Chairperson (earlier only a CJI); the last Chairperson was appointed in **December 2024**.
- Key articles: **14, 15 and 21**, besides 16, freedom of speech and expression, 20 and 25; **Article 51A(c)** covers respect for international law and treaty obligations.
- Never write only 'it is a statutory body' — add that it is **rooted in constitutional values**.

26.4 The Paris Principles and the Six-Point Test

The Commission adheres to a set of principles — and these principles are not complied with by the NHRC. That is the issue, the concern, and the reason why the NHRC has not been able to fulfil its role as a statutory body upholding fundamental rights.

KEY CONCEPT

Paris Principles.

- The **Paris Principles** were set in **1993 by the UN**.
- They have to be met by the **national human rights institutions of the world** — in the lingo, **NHRI (National Human Rights Institutions)**.
- There are **five principles**; in any question on the NHRC these principles must be shown to the examiner — they are the **analysis**, and all of them are compromised in the NHRC's case.

Instead of five, **six principles** are to be written down and remembered. All six of them are problematic with respect to the working of the National Human Rights Commission, and together they give the plinth to argue why the NHRC is a **toothless tiger**.

26.4.1 The Six Principles

1. **Mandate and competence** — does the law give the body a mandate, and with it the competence? What can it actually do?
2. **Autonomy from government** — the government should not have stakes in the appointment of the NHRC members.
3. **Pluralism** — besides judges and ex-officers, there must be genuine **experts in human rights**.
4. **Independence** — guaranteed by law [as stated in lecture]; and is the NHRC independent in fact?
5. **Adequate resources** — the body should not have to depend on the government for money.
6. **Adequate powers of investigation** — does it have an independent power of investigation?

26.4.2 Challenges

- On **pluralism**: who is a human rights expert? **IPS officers, officers of the Indian Forest Service and the Director of the Intelligence Bureau** have been appointed to various positions of the NHRC, and this is presented as pluralism.
  - When members are appointed, ask to see the **profile**: all of them are bureaucrats, except the members whom the law mandates to represent the judiciary.
- The genuine experts to invite are the persons who actually uphold human rights — members of **civil society organisations** or **NGOs**, someone who has worked on the ground for the rights of children, **Mother Teresa** (who received the **Nobel Prize**), and **Bezwada Wilson**, who worked efficiently for the welfare of **manual scavengers**.
  - These are persons with **practical experience** of upholding the equality, dignity, liberty and right to life of a manual scavenger — and they are not finding a place here.
- An IPS officer may have **knowledge** of human rights, but **practical experience** is what really matters; retired bureaucrats are becoming the expert members.
- On **autonomy**: the three non-judicial members are officers, retired bureaucrats and persons who served the Government of India in the past in an all-encompassing capacity — they are appointed by the government, and anyone who fulfils the criteria can become a member, but who that anyone is, is decided by the government.
- On **resources**: a mandate without resources cannot be discharged (the analogy of being asked to run a class with no resources) [as stated in lecture].
- On **investigation**: the Commission must have adequate and independent powers of investigation.
- **All six principles are problematic** with respect to the working of the National Human Rights Commission.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **Why the Commission is called a toothless tiger.**
>
> - The six principles supply the complete analysis for the role of the Human Rights Commission.
> - In any question on the NHRC, these principles must be shown to the examiner — all of them are compromised.
> - Reverse the six principles and the answer is ready.

26.4.3 Way Forward

- **Mandate and competence must match**: the Commission must actually be able to do what its mandate claims.
- **Autonomy**: the government must not have stakes in appointments; **genuine upholders of human rights** — civil society members, NGO members and persons with practical experience on the ground — must be appointed instead of retired bureaucrats.
- **Pluralism must be real**, not a formality.
- **Independence** must be guaranteed in law and practised.
- **Adequate resources** must be provided so that the mandate is not defeated by financial

dependence on the government.

- **Independent powers of investigation** must be available.
- Reversing these six principles is itself the answer to any question that asks for the steps or recommendations.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - **Paris Principles**, set in **1993 by the UN**, apply to all **national human rights institutions (NHRIs)**.
> - Use them as the **analysis** in every NHRC answer.
> - The lecture expands five principles into **six**: mandate and competence, autonomy, pluralism, independence, resources and powers of investigation.
> - All six are **compromised** — this is the basis of the 'toothless tiger' charge.
> - **Pluralism** fails because retired bureaucrats, not ground-level human rights workers, are appointed as experts.
> - Invert the six principles to write the **way forward**.

26.5 Definition of Human Rights under the PHRA, 1993

The NHRC upholds human rights — so what are human rights? The **exact definition** has to be given as per the **Protection of Human Rights Act, 1993**.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Definition (as per PHRA, 1993).**
>
> - Human rights are **rights relating to the life, liberty, equality and dignity of the individual** — rights that relate to my life as a human.
> - They are **guaranteed by the Constitution** or **embodied in the international covenants**.
> - And they are **enforceable by the courts in India**.

Mnemonic for the four elements: **DELL** — recall **Michael Dell, the founder of Dell laptops**.

26.5.1 The Four Pillars, Explained

- **Life** — if I do not have a clean environment or clean sanitation facilities, or if there is manual scavenging, my life is getting compromised.
- **Liberty** — if you do not give me the freedom to think and to express my opinions on social media or on any other platform, you are compromising my liberty.
- **Equality** — if there is division in society, where I am the oppressed and there is an oppressor, or if I want to sit for a job of a service commission and hindrances prevent my application, equality is at stake.
- **Dignity** — if on a social media platform there is trolling and bullying, and people harm my dignity despite my work, it is not my life, liberty or equality that is compromised, but my **dignity**.
- When I am human, I need a life, a **dignified** life, equality and liberty — these are the **four**

pillars.

The list of rights is only **seemingly open-ended** — the definition cannot go on defining life. Forty years ago no one thought the AQI in Delhi would be 500 on paper (1,000 by European standards), which is why there is a demand for a **right to a pollution-free environment**. But the statutory definition is bounded: rights relating to these four things, guaranteed by the Constitution or embodied in international covenants, and enforceable by the courts in India.

26.5.2 The Three-Part Test of a Human Right

1. Does the right relate to **DELL** — life, liberty, equality and dignity?
2. Is it **enshrined or guaranteed by the Constitution**, or by an **international covenant**?
3. Is it **enforceable in a court of law**?

If all three answer a yes, then all those rights are human rights which enjoy the protection of the NHRC — a statutory organisation deriving its power from the PHRA 1993, but actually upholding the values enshrined in the Constitution. The rights upheld by the NHRC are rooted in the Indian Constitution.

QUICK REVISION

- Statutory definition: rights relating to **life, liberty, equality and dignity of the individual**, guaranteed by the Constitution or embodied in the international covenants, and **enforceable by the courts in India**.
- Mnemonic: **DELL** ('Michael Dell').
- The four pillars illustrated: clean environment and sanitation (life), freedom to think and express (liberty), no hindrance in an application (equality), no trolling or bullying (dignity).
- The three-part test: relates to DELL? guaranteed by the Constitution or a covenant? enforceable in court?
- The list is only **seemingly** open-ended — e.g. a right to a pollution-free environment.
- All three tests must answer yes for a right to enjoy the protection of the NHRC.

26.6 International Covenants: The Normative Base

Which are the international covenants? The two to write down are the **ICCPR** and the **ICESCR** — there may be many more.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

The Two Covenants.

- **ICCPR — International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights.**
- **ICESCR — International Covenant on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights.**
- **Both were adopted in 1966 by the UNGA** (United Nations General Assembly).

Therefore the NHRC has a **broad normative base** for upholding human rights — but with a limitation: **the right has to be enforceable within the Indian courts**.

QUICK REVISION

- The two covenants to remember are the **ICCPR** and the **ICESCR**.
- ICCPR — civil and political rights; ICESCR — economic, social and cultural rights.
- Both were **adopted in 1966 by the UNGA**.
- They give the NHRC a **broad normative base** for upholding human rights.
- The limitation: the right must be **enforceable within the Indian courts**.

26.7 Composition of the Commission

The composition is one of the most important parts of the topic, because it is here that the **excessive judicialisation** of the Commission becomes visible.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Composition at a glance.

- One **Chairperson** representing the judiciary — a **retired Chief Justice of India or a Judge of the Supreme Court**; this was added by the **2009 Amendment** [year as stated in lecture].
- **Two members representing the judiciary** — a serving or retired **Judge of the Supreme Court**, and a serving or retired **Chief Justice of a High Court**.
- **Three members representing human rights** — persons having **knowledge or practical experience in human rights**; among these three, at least one member [the clause was left incomplete in the lecture].
- **Seven chairpersons** of other bodies, who are **ex-officio** members of the Commission.

Representing the judiciary	3	Chairperson (retired CJI or a Judge of the Supreme Court) and two members — a serving or retired Supreme Court Judge and a serving or retired Chief Justice of a High Court
Representing human rights	3	Members having knowledge or practical experience in human rights; among them at least one member [clause incomplete in the lecture]
Ex-officio chairpersons	7	Chairpersons of NCSC, NCST, NCBC, NCW, NCPCR, NCM and the Chief Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities

26.7.1 The Judicial Members

- One member representing the judiciary is a **serving or retired Judge of the Supreme Court**.
  - If a **serving** Judge is appointed, the **consent of the Chief Justice of India** is required — a prelims point, but worth noting.
- The second member representing the judiciary is a **serving or retired Chief Justice of a High Court**.
  - So apart from the Chairperson there are **two** members who represent the judiciary.

26.7.2 The Ex-Officio Chairpersons

- The **Chairpersons of the national commissions** are ex-officio members: **NCSC, NCST, NCBC, NCW, NCPCR, NCM (National Commission for Minorities)**, and the **Chief Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities (PWD)**.
- If I am the Chairman of the NCSC, NCST, NCBC or NCPCR, I **automatically become a part of the NHRC**.

26.7.3 The Arithmetic: Three versus Three

- **Three** represent the judiciary — the Chairperson plus the two judicial members — against **three** who represent human rights. That is a 3:3 balance.
- Add the **seven chairpersons** of the other bodies.
- This 3:3 balance is described as **excessive judicialisation** for a body whose subject is human rights.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **Criticism of the composition.**
>
> - Making a **retired CJI or a Supreme Court Judge** the Chairperson is enough; excessive judicialisation is not desirable — what is a Judge of the Supreme Court doing in the composition of the NHRC?
> - In **tribunals** there are judicial members and expert members; a tribunal is a **quasi-judicial body** that acts like a court but is not a court, and there the judiciary should have a stake — but that logic does not carry into a human rights body.
> - When expert members are appointed, **the government tends to appoint its favourites**.
> - These are **political posts**: chairpersons of the other commissions are politicians who do not have a ministry (mantra), and the posts are **offices of profit** — an **MP** who is such a chairperson holds no executive office and is exempted from disqualification.
> - The offices are **exempted under the Office of Profit (Prevention of Disqualification) Act, 1959**, in which they are listed as exempt.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Composition: **three judicial posts + three human rights members + seven ex-officio chairpersons**.

- Chairperson: a **retired CJI or a Judge of the Supreme Court**; the two judicial members are a **serving or retired Supreme Court Judge** (CJI's consent needed if serving) and a **serving or retired Chief Justice of a High Court**.
- Ex-officio members: chairpersons of **NCSC, NCST, NCBC, NCW, NCPCR, NCM** and the **Chief Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities**.
- Their offices are exempt from disqualification under the **Office of Profit (Prevention of Disqualification) Act, 1959**.
- Criticism: **excessive judicialisation**, and the appointment of **bureaucrats** as human rights experts.
- The 3:3 balance plus seven chairpersons is the composition to reproduce in the examination.

26.8 Appointment and the Selection Committee

Appointment is by the **President**, on the recommendation of a **selection committee**.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

The six-member selection committee.

- **Prime Minister** — the chairperson of the committee.
- **Speaker of the Lok Sabha** — Mr. Om Birla, as named in the lecture.
- **Union Home Minister**.
- **Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha** — Mr. Rahul Gandhi, as named in the lecture.
- **Leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha** — Mr. Kharge, as named in the lecture.
- **Deputy Chairman of the Rajya Sabha** — Dr. Harivansh, as named in the lecture.

- **Out of six, three are the ruling party's own people** — the Prime Minister, the Speaker and the Home Minister.
- The **Vice-President**, who is the Chairman of the Rajya Sabha, was propelled by the ruling party; **Dr. Harivansh**, the Deputy Chairman of the Rajya Sabha, is also from the ruling party — so the Chair is 'one of our own'.

CRITICAL POINT

Appointment is decided by majority.

- Whenever this six-member committee meets, the person supported by the ruling party ends up becoming the member or the Chairperson of the NHRC.
- The appointment is by **majority** — whoever has the numbers, that person becomes the member.
- In a recent meeting the leaders of the Opposition (Mr. Rahul Gandhi and Mr. Kharge) criticised the process — that their voice is not heard and that they are only served tea and coffee [as stated in lecture].
- **Tenure, removal** and such details are prelims points and are not needed for this discussion.

QUICK REVISION

- Appointment is by the **President**, on the recommendation of a **selection committee**.
- The committee has **six members**: PM (chairperson), Speaker of the Lok Sabha, Home Minister, Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha, Deputy Chairman of the Rajya Sabha.
- **Three of the six** belong to the ruling party, so the ruling party's choice prevails.
- Appointment is ultimately by **majority**.
- Opposition members of the committee have criticised that their voice is not heard.
- **Tenure and removal** are prelims points and are not discussed in this topic.

26.9 Statutory Functions of the Commission

These are **statutory functions** — they are provided in the law, and the section numbers are not important. They are analysed when the **role** of the NHRC is analysed: how well the NHRC is able to perform them.

1. **Inquiry of human rights — the protective function.** It can inquire **suo motu** (on its own), on a **victim's petition** (filed by the victim or through a representative), or on the **direction of a court**. The inquiry can be for violation of human rights, for **abetment** of such a violation, or for **negligence by a public servant** in preventing the violation.
2. **Intervention in court proceedings.** It can intervene in court proceedings in concerns or matters of human rights violation.
3. **Prison monitoring.** It visits **jails and detention centres** and makes recommendations — therefore it is a **preventive or reformative** role, because it can stop a violation before it happens, and not only after the offence is committed (the analogy given: it can evaluate a classroom and see the rights of the students).
4. **Legislative review.** It reviews the **constitutional and statutory safeguards** for the protection of human rights and **recommends measures** in different areas. For example, after the **Transgenders Amendment** was passed in Parliament (which also came up in the examination), the NHRC **recommended** — not directed — the government that the requisite provisions need to be incorporated.
5. **International human rights-related obligations.** It analyses and studies **treaties and other international instruments** and **recommends measures for implementation**. International covenants are broad-based and all the rights and covenants cannot be implemented in India; keeping societal changes in mind, it has to recommend — for example, the right to choose a partner for marriage.
6. **Research and promotion of human rights.** It undertakes and promotes research on human rights and promotes **human rights literacy and awareness generation** through **publications, media, seminars and educational mechanisms**; programmes are organised and the NHRC website should be active.
7. **Civil society partnership.** It encourages **NGOs and institutions** working in human rights.
8. **Other functions.** It may review the **factors or structural causes** that inhibit the enjoyment of

human rights.

26.9.1 What the Transgender Example Shows

- Now that there is a law for the welfare of transgenders, the same logic must be taken forward: transgenders should be allowed to **choose their partner for marriage**.
- Their **sexual rights have been upheld**, but their **right to enter into marriage is not upheld**; the Supreme Court [as stated in lecture] clearly says it is a matter for **Parliament** — and someone has to tell Parliament.
  - This is the gap that the recommendation of the National Human Rights Commission can fill.
- The **right to choose a dignified partner** is an essential part of my life.
- **Marriage does not always mean procreation**; it also implies a **social contract of companionship**.
- That is the kind of change that can be upheld by the **recommendation** of the National Human Rights Commission.

QUICK REVISION

- The functions are **statutory** — provided in the PHRA 1993; the section numbers are not important.
- The eight functions: inquiry (protective), intervention in court proceedings, prison monitoring, legislative review, international obligations, research and awareness, civil society partnership, and other/structural causes.
- Inquiry may be **suo motu**, on a petition, or on court direction; the grounds are violation, abetment and negligence of a public servant.
- The Commission **recommends**, it does not direct — as with the transgender provisions.
- Prison and detention-centre visits make it a **preventive or reformative** body.
- Its legislative review covers **constitutional and statutory safeguards**.
- International covenants cannot all be implemented — societal change guides the recommendation.

26.10 Role of the NHRC: Watchdog, Monitor, Adviser, Educator, Collaborator

KEY CONCEPT

In a word, what is the NHRC?.

- It is an **investigator** — it investigates human rights violations in the country.
- It is a **watchdog** — it monitors.
- It is an **adviser**.
- It is an **educator / awareness generator**.
- It is a **collaborator with NGOs and civil society organisations**.

If you file a complaint, it investigates human rights violations in the country; it monitors the law; it advises changes after seeing the **international covenants and international human rights mechanisms**; it generates awareness; and it collaborates — thereby promoting **networked governance** and **integrated governance** by involving NGOs.

- As a **watchdog**, it watches for human rights violations and investigates them: every few days the newspapers carry that the NHRC sent a notice to an authority, a Police Commissioner, a Chief Secretary or the head of a body, and they act.
- There is a catch: the **investigators are IPS officers only** — but that is the practice; here the functions **as per the law** are what is being discussed.
  - One thing is to complain, another is to **monitor** whether everything is fine or not.
- As a **monitor**, it monitors **prisons** and the **implementation of laws**.
- As an **adviser**, it advises the **government** and **Parliament**, after studying the international covenants and understanding the latest developments.
- It also generates **awareness**.
- As a **collaborator**, it works with **NGOs and civil society**, because in **integrated governance** all the possible players in citizen delivery must be involved, including private players.
  - Example: **Sankalp IS**, run by the **RSS** at **RK Ashram**, provides coaching services at very nominal rates.
  - Example: government institutions in **Maharashtra** and **Gujarat** promote students from depressed backgrounds to come up and enjoy coaching free of cost.

EXAMPLE

How an inquiry actually runs.

- A complaint is filed with the NHRC — by the victim himself or herself, or through a representative.
- The NHRC formally starts the inquiry: it calls the persons involved, obtains the recording, looks at the CCTV footage, and investigates whether the allegation of violation is true or not.
- If the allegation is true, the NHRC **cannot do anything itself** — it can only **recommend** the Delhi police to take action.
- A violation has **three dimensions**: the violation itself; **abetment** — someone supporting the violation without coming forward to stop it; and **negligence** — for example, filing a complaint with the police and the FIR not being accepted.
- It can also be **suo motu**: seeing a lecture on a platform like Telegram, the NHRC may itself think that rights are being violated and act on its own.

In some areas it is **protecting**, in some areas it is **advising**, and in some areas it is **monitoring** — different adjectives are used for the same body because different roles have been guaranteed to it by the **Protection of Human Rights Act**.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

The question to prepare.

- Write the **role of the NHRC with examples** — the **positive role** of the NHRC has to be written with examples.
- Reversing the six principles supplies the negative side; the examples above supply the positive side.

QUICK REVISION

- The NHRC is an **investigator, watchdog, monitor, adviser, educator and collaborator**.
- It monitors prisons and the implementation of laws, and it advises the government and Parliament.
- Its investigators are **IPS officers** — a practical catch, though the law's functions are as described.
- It collaborates with NGOs and civil society, promoting **networked and integrated governance**.
- It cannot punish: in the illustration it could only **recommend** action to the Delhi police.
- A violation has three dimensions — violation, abetment and negligence — and the Commission can also act **suo motu**.
- Assignment: write the **positive role of the NHRC with examples**.

CHAPTER 27

Central Asian Republics — Part 2

27.1 Geocultural Importance of Central Asia

Recap: Central Asian Republics mean **connectivity**, they mean **security**, and they sit at the centre of the **Great Game**; recent meetings have been held in Uzbekistan and Kyrgyzstan. The geopolitical and geo-economic dimensions have already been covered, so the discussion now turns to the **geo-cultural** dimension.

> KEY CONCEPT
>
> **Heads of Geocultural Importance (to be remembered).**
>
> - **Civilization**
> - **History**
> - **Diaspora**
> - **Education**
> - **Health**
> - **Tourism**

The geo-cultural dimension is the main advantage India holds over other powers — over the US and, as the lecture corrected itself, over **China and other Western powers**, not over Russia.

27.1.1 Civilizational and Silk Road Linkages

- **Civilization**: the ancient Silk Road linked India and Central Asia and facilitated the movement of traders, scholars, monks, artisans and languages, and — very importantly — religion, along with food.
- The Silk Road is a bond of common history that India shares with Central Asia — a facilitation of ideas.
- India's **Central Asia Policy (2012)** describes these ties as "silken bonds of centuries of common history".

27.1.2 Buddhism and Soft Power Diplomacy

- **Buddhism**: Buddhist monks and intellectual traditions travelled between India and Central Asia. Remains of Buddhism survive in **Uzbekistan**.
- This makes Central Asia important for **soft power diplomacy**.

India can always claim its links with Central Asia and present itself as a leader of the world because of its strong soft power. The world had favoured hard power after the losses seen in West Asia; it

is now moving towards peace — this is a time of peace, not of war. In such a time India can tell Mr. Putin: look at my soft-power relationship, look at the projection of soft power I make through Buddhism — without Central Asia the close India-Central Asia relationship would not have existed. The region gives India the space to project its soft power. The Russian translation [of a Buddhist text] has been gifted by the PM to Mr. Putin — India is using its history to say that, historically and culturally, it never believed in war.

27.1.3 Sufism and the Islamic Connection

- **Sufism and the Islamic connection** are again important for **soft power projection**; India can speak of its Sufi cultural links with Central Asia.
- Elements: Sufi orders, architecture, literature, scholars and callers, and a Persian culture that influenced India's Islam.
- The **Mughal** connection came from **Khorasan**; Indian history — Delhi, North India and the Deccan — is full of this connection.
- **Babur** originated from the **Fargana (Fergana) Valley** — to be located on the Uzbekistan map.
- India's medieval history — the part most students skip — is connected with Central Asia; it is interesting, but it is written in Farsi and the names are hard to remember.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Uzbekistan Anchors.**
>
> - **Samarkand** is in Uzbekistan.
> - A popular blue mosque is also located in Uzbekistan.
> - Anecdote: a Mughal king, possibly Akbar, was short in height and a prolific eater who ate at night — the lecture noted that identifying the exact king was not important.

27.1.4 Cinema, Culture and Goodwill

- **Cinema, then music, then Bollywood personalities** are a major vehicle: Bollywood and Raj Kapoor's films played a phenomenal role in building ties between India and the Soviet Union, which is now Central Asia.
- **Mithun Chakraborty** ("Mithun Da") is very famous in Central Asia, thanks to Disco Dancer; a friend who completed a PhD there confirmed his popularity.
- At a summit, Anwar Ibrahim was heard humming a Kishore Kumar song in his hotel.
- **Yoga, cuisine, education and traditional medicine** are the other shared cultural heads; Central Asia and Tibet share these.
- Writing tip: such cultural references add colour to an answer.

US	Movies, serials and sitcoms (Star Movies, Star Trek), Hollywood actors such as Sylvester Stallone, and the space race (astronauts vs cosmonauts)	"The US is the biggest country"
Russia	Its films	"Russia is the best" — a subtle projection of power
India	Bollywood films (Raj Kapoor), personalities (Mithun Chakraborty), music, yoga, cuisine, education and traditional medicine	Goodwill, without the fear of political domination or economic dependence

This soft power **creates goodwill** and — very importantly — does **not** create the fear of **political domination** or **economic dependence**.

That fear of political domination and economic dependence is exactly what creates a problem for Central Asia with respect to China, because China uses the **Belt and Road Initiative (BRI)** as its card. India does not believe in the BRI but believes in connectivity — and connectivity does not mean only the BRI.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Geocultural heads: Civilization, History, Diaspora, Education, Health, Tourism.
> - Geo-cultural importance is India's biggest advantage over the US, China and other Western powers.
> - Silk Road = "silken bonds of centuries of common history" (Central Asia Policy, 2012).
> - Buddhism in Uzbekistan → soft power diplomacy.
> - Sufism, Persian culture and the Mughal-Khorasan link → religious/cultural soft power.
> - Soft power creates goodwill without the fear of political domination or economic dependence — unlike China's BRI.

27.2 Geostrategic Importance of Central Asia

Geostrategic importance means security. Central Asia is India's extended neighbourhood, but the geo-strategic lens focuses only on security; the extended-neighbourhood point belongs to the geopolitical dimension.

1. **Proximity and the Afghanistan factor**: Central Asia shares borders/proximity with Afghanistan. Instability in Afghanistan — driven by Taliban rule, **ISIS-Khorasan (IS-K)** and **narco-terror** —

can affect the stability of both Central Asia and India. Since both the Central Asian states and India border Afghanistan, cooperating with both can ensure the stability of the whole region, creating opportunities for **regional cooperation and regional stability**. This makes Central Asia an important territory for geo-security.

2. **Counter-terrorism**: the common concern of terrorism creates an opportunity for **security convergence** with the Central Asian Republics. India always highlights terrorism separately at the global level — even within the SCO — because cross-border terrorism is India's biggest loss.
3. **Defence cooperation**: India-Kazakhstan military exercise **KazInd**; India-Kyrgyzstan joint special-forces exercise **Khanjar**; India-Uzbekistan exercise **Dostlik**.
4. **Strategic presence in China's periphery**: Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan lie adjacent to China's western periphery — the province of **Xinjiang** — giving India strategic outreach and understanding in China's periphery.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

MEA Standing Committee on China's Approach.

- As per the Ministry of External Affairs Standing Committee's report, China's policy is to create a presence around India — a **dual-use** presence (Gwadar, Bangladesh, Chittagong) — and to fold in Afghanistan.
- China's objective is to halt India's rise: China is a **revisionist power**, while India is a **status-quo power** that will never disrupt the prevailing peace or spoil Central Asia's peace environment.
- India's presence in Central Asia is only to stay involved in developments relating to that part of the world — strategic presence and awareness of developments, not the encouragement of aggression against China.

Pakistan is a separate case: for Pakistan, Afghanistan's strategic importance is much greater. Pakistan is an adversary and an outright enemy — there is no ambiguity there. With China the relationship is layered, and it cannot be described in the same terms.

CRITICAL POINT

Write this framing into your answer: India is **not only an economic partner but also a security partner** of Central Asia.

QUICK REVISION

- Geo-strategic importance = security.
- Proximity to Afghanistan: Taliban rule, IS-K and narco-terror affect both Central Asia and India.
- Counter-terrorism → security convergence with the CARs.
- Defence exercises: KazInd (Kazakhstan), Khanjar (Kyrgyzstan), Dostlik (Uzbekistan).
- Strategic presence in China's periphery (Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan, adjacent to Xinjiang).

- MEA Standing Committee: China's dual-use presence; China is a revisionist power, India a status-quo power.

27.3 Major Powers Active in Central Asia

Central Asia is an arena of great-power rivalry. The leading players are **Russia, China, the European Union, the United States and Turkey**.

27.3.1 *Student Doubt: The Withdrawal of the Ayni Base*

- **Doubt**: if India has withdrawn from the Ayni (I&E) base, does that not undo its strategic edge in the region?
- **Answer**: even the Central Asian economies are trying to exercise **strategic autonomy**, so they do not create space for the military presence of any country — China or Russia. With the Taliban's existence now 100% a reality, the Ayni airbase is not needed.
- **Tajikistan** has the worst relationship with Afghanistan among the five CARs (compared with Turkmenistan or Uzbekistan), because the **Northern Alliance** was supported through Tajikistan.
- Russia and China also have a presence there, so the need was not felt. Central Asian countries can take a strategic advantage, but whether that converts into a security advantage against China is **a tough nut to crack**.

27.3.2 *Russia*

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Traditional security provider**: a power that supplies hard security guarantees to a region — for Central Asia, Russia, through the CSTO and its military bases.

- Russia is the **traditional security provider** in Central Asia — a **military + cultural + economic** power (the three parameters important in Central Asia).
- It is a member of the **EAEU (Eurasian Economic Union)** — memory hook **RuB KAK**: Russia, Belarus, Kazakhstan, Armenia, Kyrgyzstan.
- Security is delivered through the **CSTO (Collective Security Treaty Organisation)**, described as the opposite of NATO — a treaty under which Russia provides security.
- Military presence: the **Kant base** in Kyrgyzstan, and a base in **Tajikistan**.
- On India, Russia does not get engaged against Indian interests in Central Asia — a **tested understanding**.

Digression — **negotiated bipolarity**: it is now clear that the world has come into a negotiated bipolarity of two and a half powers — the US, China, and a China-pulled Russia. Deep down even China does not care much for Russia, but constraints keep Russia's security partnership alive.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **India's Diplomatic Heft.**

- The secretary concerned — a 1993-batch IFS officer — was given complete directions by Mr. Jaishankar to get the negotiations done; the entire BRICS collaboration spent more than 30-35 hours getting consensus between the UAE and Iran.
- The two countries were given an ultimatum and were reminded of India's geopolitical advantage; the secretary is 58 years old and slept only 3-4 hours over the past 15 days.
- Outcome: the message reached the front page of the Indian Express.
- Related note: the India-Africa summit was to be the 4th (the 3rd was in 2015 and the 1st in 2008); it was called off because of diseases such as Ebola. Botswana has "won"; its AIDS-affected population is very high.

27.3.3 China

- China is an **economic and infrastructure partner**.
- It is building railway lines in Kyrgyzstan and Uzbekistan, and is involved in **mining, energy and digital infrastructure**.
- Its presence at **Gwadar** links into this wider network.
- Central Asian states take pride in their historical memory and civilizational strength, and remain clear about engaging with all players, including India.

27.3.4 European Union

- The EU views Eurasia as a land border and asks why it should not connect with Central Asia — especially for **critical minerals**.
- Russia is seen as the big obstacle; the EU is worried about its limited space and wants to enter Russia's backyard through strategic presence and trade/other connectivity.
- Context: Mr. Trump met Mr. Putin in **Alaska**, and Mr. Trump met Mr. Jinping in **May** this year. When the big powers fight, it is the weak that get crushed.
- The EU held its **first EU-Central Asia summit** and is building the **Trans-Caspian Corridor**.
- The EU's relation with Central Asia is one of **trade, finance and connectivity**.
- From India's perspective this is **both competition and opportunity for cooperation**.

27.3.5 United States

- The US is trying to explore the **C5+1 mechanism**.
- There is **renewed diplomatic engagement post the Russia-Ukraine war**; after Russia launched its special operations it created worry in the US, which also creates opportunities for cooperation.

27.3.6 Turkey

- Turkey supplied [arms] to Pakistan and gave covert support in war — that is the historical problem in the relationship.
- Today Turkey promotes **Islam** and cultural-linguistic linkages; there are many **Turkish words** in Central Asia, along with an educational and cultural network.
- Turkey's body is the **Organisation of Turkish States**; the region is also called **Asia Minor**.

- There is no animosity as such: India and Turkey are of similar stature (both middle powers), but India is a much bigger economy and bigger in innovation; Turkey is located at the centre of Asia, with strong historical-cultural connections to the region.
- Earlier there was animosity with the US over the Syrian crisis and the **Kurds** (designated a terrorist organisation by Turkey), whom US forces had worked with to end the influence of the Islamic State. That issue has now died down: the **Syrian Democratic Forces** (led by Kurds) have assimilated into the Syrian army, and the main flag-bearer of the Kurd movement, **Abdullah Ocalan**, is in jail and has told the Kurds to lay down arms and assimilate with the government.
- Turkey is a member of **NATO** and an important buffer.

QUICK REVISION

- Russia: traditional security provider; EAEU (RuB KAK — Russia, Belarus, Kazakhstan, Armenia, Kyrgyzstan); CSTO; Kant base in Kyrgyzstan and a base in Tajikistan.
- China: economic and infrastructure partner — railways in Kyrgyzstan/Uzbekistan, mining, energy, digital infrastructure, Gwadar.
- EU: first EU-Central Asia summit, Trans-Caspian Corridor, critical minerals; both competition and opportunity for India.
- US: C5+1 mechanism; renewed engagement post the Russia-Ukraine war.
- Turkey: Organisation of Turkish States, cultural-linguistic links, NATO member, middle power of India's stature.
- Ayni base doubt: CARs exercise strategic autonomy, so no space for any country's military presence; Tajikistan has the worst Afghanistan relationship.

27.4 Implications of Great Power Competition for India

In international relations nothing is 100% certain: every development carries both **negative implications** and **positive implications** for India.

27.4.1 Negative Implications

1. **Limiting India's strategic reach** — because of competition for strategic influence. Russia has **strategic depth**; China has **capital/the BRI**; the EU has **financial resources**; Turkey has **cultural linkage/soft power**. India must therefore go "10 miles more" to compete.
2. **Increasing influence of China / China's strategic encirclement** — the BRI's infrastructure (pipelines, railways, digital systems and mining investments) is transforming China's economic presence into **strategic advantage**. As long as a road or a port is built, the aim is long-term geopolitical influence, which India cannot match.
3. **Competition for access to natural resources** — every country (Turkey, China, India) wants them, so India faces compromises in buying minds.
4. **Competition for connectivity** — India promotes the **INSTC (International North-South Transport Corridor)**; the EU promotes the **Trans-Caspian Corridor**; Russia has its traditional networks; China brings the BRI.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Standing Committee Finding (quote this).

- The **Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs** has pointed to the **dual-use nature of Chinese infrastructure investment in South Asia**.

27.4.2 *Positive Implications*

- **Diversification by the CARs**: great-power involvement has led them to follow a **multi-vectored foreign policy**, creating scope for India's increasing engagement.
- **Opportunities for cooperation**: broadly, except the BRI, other infrastructure investments do not affect India's interests, creating opportunities for **bilateral and trilateral connectivity**.
- **India's own openings**: India can cooperate with the EU over critical minerals and with the Gulf over financing, giving strategic depth to India as far as financing of projects is concerned, and thereby target the increasing influence of the Chinese.
- **Great-power engagement as a neutralizing force**: if several strategic powers are present, they end up reducing one another, so that no single country can dominate the region. This is the **policy of equal distance** — the analogy of not making any "gunda" (local strongman) a friend, but keeping information about him so that he is neutralized.

KEY CONCEPT

Keywords to Show the Examiner.

- **strategic competition**
- **limiting strategic influence**
- **strategic depth**
- **strategic influence**
- **strategic connectivity**

QUICK REVISION

- IR yields both negative and positive implications.
- Negative: limited strategic reach; China's strategic encirclement (BRI = dual use); competition for natural resources; competition for connectivity (INSTC vs Trans-Caspian Corridor vs BRI).
- Quote: Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs on the dual-use nature of Chinese infrastructure investment in South Asia.
- Positive: CAR diversification/multi-vectored foreign policy; cooperation except the BRI; opportunities with the EU (critical minerals) and the Gulf (finance).
- Great-power engagement acts as a neutralizing force — the policy of equal distance.
- Keywords: strategic competition, strategic depth, strategic influence, strategic connectivity.

27.5 India's Strengths in Central Asia

The advantages India enjoys in Central Asia, as dictated in class.

1. **Civilizational connect**, and energy (an agreement has been signed).
2. **Goodwill** because of India's soft-power projection and religious links.
3. **Absence of hegemonic baggage**: China carries the baggage of capturing the economy, Russia of being the leader, and the US of being a great power. The EU does not carry that baggage despite its Second World War involvement; India does not carry it either — India is **not viewed as seeking political, territorial or economic domination of the Central Asian Republics**.
4. **Culture** — the strongest asset, already discussed under geo-cultural importance.
5. **Security convergence**: a shared security agenda — counter-terrorism, limiting the influence of terrorists in Afghanistan, narco and cyber threats, and stability in Afghanistan.
6. **Strategic partnerships** with the Central Asian Republics, with the recent upgradation of India-Uzbekistan ties to a **Comprehensive Strategic Partnership (CSP)**. A strategic partnership means both countries are ready to engage, with a shared stance.
7. **Economic complementarity**: Central Asia has minerals and energy resources; India has healthcare, pharma, **DPI**, IT, skill development and space. DPI includes CoWIN, Aadhaar, UPI and DigiLocker; DigiLocker also supports security cooperation in airport security. (Note: the UPI threat environment is a security weak link.)
8. **Strengthening institutional engagement**: the SCO (both India and Central Asia meet there, except Turkmenistan), the India-Central Asia Summit and the Foreign Ministers' dialogue.
9. **Strong defence ties**: the Philippines is ready to buy **BrahMos**, and Malaysia has also shown interest.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **A Major Irritant.**
>
> - **Kashmir and the OIC (Organization of Islamic Cooperation)** is a major irritant in India-Turkey relations; Turkey has been an ardent supporter of Pakistan's claim over the area (POK). The civilizational connect, however, transcends into people-to-people relations.

27.5.1 Writing Tip: Strengths in Four Folds

- When writing strengths, organise them as **geo-political, geo-economic, geo-cultural and geo-strategic strengths** — this is an unstructured topic that must be forced into a structure.
- Geo-strategic strengths → **security congruence**; geo-security strengths → Afghanistan and counter-terrorism cooperation; geo-political strengths → **institutional density** (India is part of the SCO).

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Key strengths: civilizational connect, energy, goodwill, absence of hegemonic baggage, culture, security convergence.
> - India is not viewed as seeking political, territorial or economic domination of the CARs.
> - India-Uzbekistan ties upgraded to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership (CSP).
> - Economic complementarity: CARs have minerals/energy; India has healthcare, pharma, DPI, IT, skills and space.

- Institutional engagement: SCO (except Turkmenistan), India-Central Asia Summit, Foreign Ministers' dialogue.
- Irritant: Kashmir and the OIC (Turkey's support for Pakistan's claim on POK).
- Write strengths in four folds: geopolitical, geo-economic, geo-cultural and geo-strategic.

27.6 Weaknesses and Issues in India–Central Asia Relations

The biggest weakness is **connectivity**, and the biggest structural constraint is **Pakistan** — connectivity is the weakest **Achilles heel** of India's relationship with Central Asia.

- Form the IR keywords before writing: **strategic congruence**, **strategic shift**, **counter-balance**. These must be caught and carried into the answer.

1. **Connectivity deficit** — lack of direct connectivity, as there is no land access; denial of access by Pakistan and instability in Afghanistan limit cooperation. There is no way out except alternatives such as Chabahar.
2. **Limited trade / trade deficit** — its meaning is simply limited trade; and **diplomatic capital has not led to better trade relations**.
3. **Stiff competition from Chinese investment and state-backed companies** (state-backed = government-funded), along with **limited investment by the private sector** — because Central Asia is perceived as geographically and logistically remote, is a smaller market, and carries financial/banking constraints such as payment-mechanism issues, currency-conversion issues and limited trade finance.
4. **Trade asymmetry with China** — India cannot compete with Chinese investments, BRI infrastructure, China's geographic proximity and merchandise trade, and therefore has a **structural disadvantage**.
5. **Corridor constraints** — the **TAPI** pipeline (Turkmenistan-Afghanistan-Pakistan-India) is limited by limited cooperation between the members; **Chabahar**-linked Central Asian connectivity is limited by war sanctions and tensions with the USA/EU. Iran is the only way out to Central Asia — via Turkmenistan or the Caspian Sea — because the Afghanistan route is a completely unstable territory where anything can happen at any time.
6. **Great power involvement/complexity** — India must manage **rivalry with China, partnership with Russia, sanctions by the US, connectivity through Iran and instability in Afghanistan**, which requires **strategic multi-alignment or balancing**. Russia is an all-weather ally, but too much engagement in Russia's backyard could upset it; excessive engagement with the US could lead to a Russia-China axis.
7. **Pakistan as a structural hindrance** — Pakistan is located to India's west (had it been to the east, the situation might have been different); its very existence is connected to India's, and it stalls every project — connectivity, trade and human movement. Beyond connectivity, **Pakistan tries to limit India's civilizational links and usurp the historical lineage of India with the CARs by projecting religious affinity**.

DATA & FACTS

Two Numbers to Remember.

- India's total trade with the 5 CARs: only **US$2 billion**.
- Iran's currency strain: about **1 US dollar ≈ 2 million Iranian rial** [as stated in lecture].

27.6.1 *Divergences Among the Five CARs*

- The 5 Central Asian Republics may share similarities, but there are **more dissimilarities than similarities**; this, however, does not reflect in India's engagement, which follows a **policy of unified vision** for the region.
- Example: the ruler of Turkmenistan is described as a "crazy president" who has built many empty marbled buildings in the capital; Turkmenistan is called the "North Korea of Central Asia".
- Such divergences are not a major diplomatic concern for India.

QUICK REVISION

- Achilles heel = connectivity; biggest structural constraint = Pakistan.
- Connectivity deficit: no land access, denial by Pakistan and instability in Afghanistan.
- Limited trade: only US$2 billion with the 5 CARs; diplomatic capital has not produced better trade.
- Trade asymmetry with China → structural disadvantage; limited private-sector investment.
- Corridor constraints: TAPI and Chabahar (Iran sanctions).
- Great-power complexity → strategic multi-alignment/balancing.
- Pakistan stalls every project and tries to usurp India's civilizational lineage by projecting religious affinity; the CARs have more dissimilarities than similarities.

27.7 Steps Taken by India

Steps are written separately because Central Asia is a specific region — the approach differs from that for the SCO, for South Asia or for other groupings.

1. **Connect Central Asia Policy (2012)** — the policy framework; the stated approach is one of **partnership** ("we believe in partnership and in combined development").
2. **First PM to visit all five Central Asian Republics in a single tour (2015)** — the PM became the first to do so. Context: after his election in 2014 he had visited neighbouring Nepal.
3. **Ashgabat Agreement (2018)** — a connectivity project signed by India in 2018 that connects Central Asia with the Persian Gulf / Indian Ocean region through **multimodal transport corridors**.
4. **SCO membership (2017)** — the plinth was laid in 2015; membership led to **regular summit-level interaction**, ending the "out of sight, out of mind" problem and stabilising/institutionalising diplomatic engagement.
5. **Institutional architecture**: (1) India-Central Asia Summit (first held in **2022**); (2) India-

Central Asia Dialogue (a regular foreign-ministers' mechanism); (3) India-Central Asia Business Council.

6. **Connectivity projects** — the INSTC has been signed.
7. **Security cooperation** — already discussed under geo-strategic importance; recent visits of the PM to Uzbekistan and the Kyrgyz Republic.
8. **Recent Uzbekistan visit outcomes**: (1) upgradation of strategic partnership (SP → **CSP**, comprehensive strategic partnership); (2) an annual target of **US$5 billion trade by 2030**; (3) a framework for the long-term supply of **uranium** to India; (4) a commercial pact between India and Uzbekistan's payment-processing mechanism, enabling UPI apps of India to scan Uzbekistan's national QR.

- Note on timing: at the time of the 2015 visit, Chinese aggression was not at the present scale; the **abrogation of Article 370 (2019)** misfired with respect to China, which asserted itself on **Aksai Chin** — the LAC also passes through the region.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

PYQ Link.

- The **Ashgabat Agreement** was asked in the **2018 civil services mains** because of a current development.

QUICK REVISION

- Connect Central Asia Policy, 2012 — an approach of partnership.
- 2015: first PM to visit all five CARs in a single tour.
- 2018: Ashgabat Agreement (multimodal connectivity to the Persian Gulf/Indian Ocean).
- 2017: SCO membership → regular summit-level interaction.
- Institutional architecture: India-Central Asia Summit (2022), India-Central Asia Dialogue, India-Central Asia Business Council.
- Uzbekistan visit: SP → CSP, US$5 billion trade by 2030, uranium supply framework, UPI-QR payment pact.

27.8 Way Forward

The way forward must revolve around the issues identified — the trade deficit and connectivity — and around increasing engagement.

1. **Address the connectivity deficit** — by energizing the **International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC)** and greater use of **Chabahar Port**.
2. **Develop multiple corridors/routes** — via Iran and then the **Caspian Sea** to Kazakhstan; or via Iran to Turkmenistan and then Uzbekistan/Kazakhstan; or link connectivity to Central Asia with the **Trans-Caspian Corridor** (which connects Europe to Central Asia); and establish **air corridors** for high-value goods such as pharma, perishables and electronics. The alternative route — Chennai → Vladivostok → Arctic → southward bend to Central Asia — is a much longer pathway and is to be avoided.

3. **Strengthen people-to-people (P2P) relations** and improve trade relations — by developing a payment mechanism, trade in local currencies and export credit.
4. **Focus on India's comparative advantages**, not imitation of or competition with China's BRI — for example **DPI** (UPI, Aadhaar, CoWIN, DigiLocker, Digi Yatra), counter-terrorism expertise (India is an expert, having seen Pakistan's invasions), healthcare, education, IT and fintech, and **space and start-ups**.
5. **Project soft power** — entertainment and culture.
6. **Develop resource partnership** — joint partnership across exploration, mining, processing, refining and manufacturing, especially for **critical minerals**. **KABIL (Khanij India Bidesh Limited)** is a PSU formed in **2019**.
7. **Promote security partnership** — because of common security concerns and **minilateral partnerships** such as **India-EU-Central Asia**, **India-Japan-Central Asia** and **India-Gulf-Central Asia**.

- On space: **Agnikul** launched its rocket (Agnibaan) successfully — during the launch it looked like a celebration of Diwali on the beach, yet the mission succeeded.
- The privatisation of space and the **space policy (2023)** are live issues; ISRO was caught off guard because its people are government employees.

EXAMPLE

Resource Partnership: The DRC 'Pit to Port' Model.

- In the DRC, Chinese companies invested in development and mined metal straight from the pit to the port, without adding value locally.
- Now Zambia, Zimbabwe and the DRC demand local processing, local employment and taxes.
- Lesson: India should pursue a resource partnership — not present itself as a resource burden (uranium and hydrocarbon imports).

QUICK REVISION

- Address the connectivity deficit: energize INSTC and use Chabahar Port more.
- Develop multiple routes: Iran-Caspian-Kazakhstan, Iran-Turkmenistan-Uzbekistan/Kazakhstan, the Trans-Caspian Corridor, and air corridors for high-value goods.
- Strengthen P2P ties; improve trade via payment mechanisms, local-currency trade and export credit.
- Focus on India's comparative advantages (DPI, counter-terrorism, healthcare, education, IT, fintech, space) rather than competing with the BRI.
- Develop resource partnership (KABIL, 2019); avoid being seen as a resource burden.
- Promote security partnership through minilaterals: India-EU-Central Asia, India-Japan-Central Asia, India-Gulf-Central Asia.

27.9 Answer-Writing Framework: 2024 PYQ on India–Central Asia

The 2024 question on India-Central Asia was a 10-marker, but should be written as a 15-marker (about 200 words).

> **PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION**
>
> Critically analyze India's evolving diplomatic, economic and strategic relations with the CARs, highlighting their significance in regional and global geopolitics.

27.9.1 Deconstructing the Question

- "**Critically**" means presenting **both the positive and the negative**.
- Structure the answer as **introduction, body and conclusion**.
- The question is not merely asking for importance — it is asking for the **evolution** of the relationship across the diplomatic, economic and strategic dimensions.

27.9.2 Model Structure

- **Introduction**: "The recent visits of India's PM to Uzbekistan and Kyrgyzstan have highlighted the importance of, and the need to, reconnect with Central Asia."
- **Body — evolution**: India's approach has **evolved from a post-USSR hangover to a multi-pronged relationship** with Central Asia.
  - Diplomatic: (1) signing of strategic partnership agreements; (2) Connect Central Asia Policy; (3) Central Asia Dialogue.
  - Economic: (1) increasing trade partnership (US$2 billion); (2) focus on energy cooperation/energy security; (3) connectivity — the INSTC (2002), the Ashgabat Agreement, and now a focus on critical minerals.
  - Strategic: (1) defence cooperation; (2) counter-terrorism cooperation; (3) multilateral cooperation under the SCO and RATS.
- **Body — concerns**: connectivity deficit, increasing structural imbalance/asymmetry with China, limited trade, great power involvement.
- **Body — highlighting significance** (the significance of the region, not just of India):
  - Geopolitical: located at the centre of **Eurasia**, historically part of the Great Game; proximity to Afghanistan and China; membership of the SCO and the EAEU indicating the rising strategic heft of the region; increasing engagement by great powers.
  - Geo-economic: centre of **critical minerals**; centre of **energy security**; a bridge between Europe and Asia, and between South Asia and Russia.
  - Geo-strategic: located north of Afghanistan; addressing regional instability, terrorism and narco-terror requires increased cooperation with these countries.
- **Conclusion**: the upgradation of the strategic partnership, and India's importance for the region.

27.9.3 Practice Questions (frame them, do not write answers)

1. Discuss the implications of great power involvement in Central Asia on India, and discuss the steps taken by India.
2. Do you think India's Central Asia policy requires reform? Discuss, highlighting the changed geopolitical scenario post the Russia-Ukraine war.
3. More than Central Asia's importance for India, it is India's importance for Central Asia that holds significance. Do you agree?

QUICK REVISION

- 2024 PYQ: critically analyze India's evolving diplomatic, economic and strategic relations with the CARs (10-marker, write as a 15-marker, 200 words).
- "Critically" = both positives and negatives; structure = introduction + body + conclusion.
- Body: evolution (diplomatic, economic, strategic) + concerns + significance.
- Significance to be written under geopolitical, geo-economic and geo-strategic heads.
- Conclusion: the upgradation of the strategic partnership.
- Practice questions: great-power implications + steps; policy reform post Russia-Ukraine war; India's importance for Central Asia.

CHAPTER 28

The National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) — Part 2

28.1 Recap and Framing: The Role of the NHRC

This session analyses the **role** of the NHRC. The Commission's framework is created by law, but the body itself is rooted in constitutional principles, and the **Paris Principles** lay the plinth for the issues discussed here.

The functions of the Commission were studied earlier and mapped as a diagram. That diagram is very important and must be reproduced in the examination.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **How to read a question on 'importance'.**
>
> - When the question asks for the **importance** of the NHRC, expand the functions already known — the six or seven points such as: it is a watchdog, it investigates, it inquires, and it ensures that human rights are upheld.
> - Functions are the importance; add two or three more points, each immediately anchored to an example.
> - If the function of any body is known, that is the same as knowing its importance.

The role analysis therefore has two legs: first the functions plus the **other important aspects** of the Commission (its importance), and second the **issues**, which is where the body is called a **toothless tiger**.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Examples proposed for the importance question.**
>
> - **R.G. Kar case** — a rape case in which the NHRC played an important role in protecting women's rights.
> - **Manipur case** — ethnic violence.
> - **Custodial violence** — the best example of the Commission's importance.

- A retired Chief Justice of India (referred to in the lecture as Venkatachaliah) was made chairman of the NHRC, and the 1990s is regarded as the best period for the Commission.
- The Commission's landmark guideline: any custodial death in a jail or lock-up — whether in judicial or police custody — must be intimated to the NHRC within **24 hours**.
- A recent case involved a person who live-streamed the entire discussion and described himself

as a follower of Bhagat Singh.

QUICK REVISION

- The NHRC's framework is created by law, but the body is rooted in constitutional principles and rests on the Paris Principles.
- The functions diagram must be reproduced; when 'importance' is asked, expand the functions and add two or three points with examples.
- Knowing the function of a body is the same as knowing its importance.
- Role analysis = functions + other important aspects (importance) + issues (the 'toothless tiger').
- Standard examples: R.G. Kar (women's protection), the Manipur case, and custodial violence.

28.2 Institutionalisation of Human Rights

The first of the **other important aspects** is that the NHRC created a separate institution for human rights.

KEY CONCEPT

Institutionalisation of human rights.

- The NHRC led to the **institutionalisation of human rights** — a dedicated institution, rather than sole dependence on the courts and the executive.
- It gave human rights a **structural framework**, and it upheld **human rights accountability outside the courts**.

The contrast is simple: compare the position before the NHRC with the position after it.

Forum for grievance	The courts or the executive authorities — for example, the police	A specialised, accessible, dedicated forum of grievance redressal
Powers	The police would act on their own only when a complaint was filed	**Suo motu** powers and **suo motu** cognizance
Access	Limited	An automatic benefit to the citizen, who is no longer dependent on the judiciary alone

- Earlier, a citizen whose human rights were violated had to seek a grievance either in the courts or before the executive authorities such as the police.
- The Commission institutionalised a standing mechanism of **accountability outside the courts**,

and that is its key contribution.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - First other important aspect: the institutionalisation of human rights.
> - It gave human rights a structural framework and accountability outside the courts.
> - Before the NHRC, the courts or the executive (for example, the police) were the only recourse, and access was limited.
> - After the NHRC, a specialised, accessible and dedicated forum exists, armed with suo motu powers and cognizance.
> - The police would earlier act suo motu only when a complaint was filed.

28.3 Role in Prevention: Custodial Violence and the 24-Hour Reporting Rule

The lecture called the NHRC's **role in prevention** its most important contribution.

> **GOVERNMENT & POLICY**
>
> **Guidelines issued in the 1990s.**
>
> - Guidelines issued by the NHRC in the 1990s held the state accountable for the death of an accused or a convict in **police or judicial custody**.

Custodial custody in India works in two settings that must be clearly distinguished before the guideline can be appreciated.

> **COMPARISON**
>
> **Police custody versus judicial custody.**
>
> - **Police custody:** an arrested person is kept with the police for up to 24 hours in a **police lock-up** (the lock-up at the thana).
> - **Judicial custody:** the person is produced before a magistrate and then kept in the district's **central jail**, where the police come to investigate and where jail rivalries and mafia-type clashes also cause deaths.

1. Within **24 hours**, every death in police or judicial custody must be reported to the NHRC.
2. A follow-up **post-mortem report** must be furnished.
3. Judicial, magisterial and other records must also be provided.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Post-mortem and the model autopsy form.**
>
> - A **post-mortem** is a medical evaluation conducted by doctors to determine the cause of death; it guards against a death being mis-attributed — for example, a killing passed off as a suicide.
> - The NHRC developed a **model autopsy form** so that this information is supplied in a proper, standardised format.

- The older practice in a thana was to detain and beat a person for one to three days without

any report — picked up on Friday, beaten through Saturday and Sunday, and produced before a magistrate only on Monday.

- The move was described as a mixed step that changed this culture of unreported custody.
- The NHRC was formed in **1993**, and the custodial-death guideline belongs to the mid-1990s, around **1996**.

DATA & FACTS

Custodial deaths on record (2023–24).

- As per the NHRC annual report for **2023–2024**, there were **2,346** intimations relating to deaths in judicial custody.
- There were roughly **107** deaths in police custody.

- Custodial violence is a pressure point for officers: the lecture noted a Haryana IPS officer who committed suicide, followed by another Havaldar, and a caste matrix involving the IG of Haryana whose wife is an Indian Service officer.

QUICK REVISION

- Role in prevention is the Commission's most important contribution.
- 1990s guidelines held the state accountable for custodial deaths in police or judicial custody.
- Within 24 hours, every custodial death must be reported to the NHRC, along with a post-mortem report and judicial, magisterial and other records.
- The NHRC developed a model autopsy form for standardised reporting.
- Police lock-up (up to 24 hours with the police) and central-jail judicial custody are the two settings of custodial death.
- 2023–24: 2,346 intimations of judicial-custody deaths and about 107 police-custody deaths.
- The NHRC was formed in 1993; a retired CJI (Venkatachaliah) drove the mid-1990s guideline.

28.4 Compensatory Justice

A further contribution of the Commission is **compensatory justice**.

KEY CONCEPT

Compensatory justice.

- The NHRC provides relief in the form of **monetary compensation**, thereby assisting in upholding victims' rights.
- It recommends monetary compensation to the victims of human rights violations.

- **Satya Niketan case** — the NHRC provided compensation to the victims of an unfortunate incident in which poor students died in a building collapse.
  - Delhi University has only a limited number of hostels and colleges, so students are pushed into PG accommodation across Kamla Nagar and Malka Ganj.
  - Security gates and watchmen are everywhere in these areas, and the safety situation was

described as 'like hell'.

- The example shows the Commission converting a violation into a monetary remedy that reaches the victim.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Compensatory justice = monetary relief recommended by the NHRC.
> - It assists in upholding victims' rights through recommended monetary compensation.
> - Satya Niketan case: compensation was provided after poor students died in a building collapse.
> - Context: very few DU hostels, so students live in PGs across Kamla Nagar and Malka Ganj.

28.5 Upholding Fundamental Rights and Social Justice

The fourth contribution is the upholding of **fundamental rights and social justice**.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **What social justice means.**
>
> - **Social justice** means the rights of the socially deprived.
> - The sections covered are SC, ST, OBC, divyangjan (persons with disabilities), transgenders, the elderly, PVTGs (particularly vulnerable tribal groups), bonded labourers and manual scavengers.
> - Those who are economically backward are also brought within the ambit of social justice.

28.5.1 Bonded Labour

Among the best examples of this role is the upholding of the rights of bonded labourers, where the Commission continued the judicial legacy of the Bandhua Mukti Morcha jurisprudence.

> **GOVERNMENT & POLICY**
>
> **Bandhua Mukti Morcha.**
>
> - **Bandhua Mukti Morcha** was an important case in which the Supreme Court, acting under PIL, upheld the rights of bonded labourers.
> - The NHRC has continued this judicial legacy and has had a large hand in the removal of bonded labour.

- Bonded labour is typically found in **brick kilns** (*eet ka bhatta*).
  - Sales are good, the labour is entirely unskilled, and the contractor earns well, so the kiln must keep running at all times.
  - The worker is not allowed to leave and is denied freedom of expression and freedom of movement.
- Socialisation plays a large role in sustaining the practice — it is very common in Haryana, and allegations have arisen in Uttar Pradesh as well.

EXAMPLE

July 2026 — online hearing on bonded labour.

- In July 2026 the NHRC conducted an **online hearing** into the alleged violation of the human rights of bonded labourers in **Haryana**.

- In such hearings the NHRC summons the top officers: it calls the **Labour Commissioner** of the Labour Department and makes the **State Chief Secretary** a party.
- For an incident in Delhi — such as the Satya Niketan incident — it calls the **Delhi Police Commissioner**, makes him a party, and he must be present.
- It also calls the **District Magistrate**; the chain of command is used to make officers appear and answer.
- The NHRC chairman used to be a retired Chief Justice of India and is now a Supreme Court judge, so the Commission knows the protocol and how to keep bureaucrats in order — its judicial knowledge is a major help.

28.5.2 *Manual Scavengers and Sanitation Workers*

The NHRC has also upheld the rights of manual scavengers and sanitation workers.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Manual Scavenging Act, 2013.

- As per the **Manual Scavenging Act, 2013**, there is no manual scavenging in India on government records.

- Yet a worker dies in a septic tank almost every second or third day.
  - The deaths are caused by suffocation and the release of methane and other harmful gases.
  - The gap between the statute and the ground reality is the core contradiction.
- The documentary recommended on sanitation workers features Bezwada Wilson.

EXAMPLE

August 2026 — suo motu cognizance of a manhole death.

- In August 2026 the NHRC took **suo motu cognizance** of the death of a worker while cleaning a manhole in **Faridabad** — the industrial city of the agricultural state of Haryana, in the NCR, along with Mewat [as stated in lecture].

QUICK REVISION

- Fourth contribution: upholding fundamental rights and social justice.
- Social justice = the rights of the socially deprived (SC, ST, OBC, divyangjan, transgenders, elderly, PVTGs, bonded labourers, manual scavengers, and the economically backward).
- Bonded labour: the Commission continued the Bandhua Mukti Morcha legacy; brick kilns are the typical site.
- July 2026: an online hearing on bonded labour in Haryana.

- In such cases the NHRC summons the Labour Commissioner, the Chief Secretary, the Delhi Police Commissioner and the District Magistrate.
- Manual scavengers: the 2013 Act records no manual scavenging, yet deaths in septic tanks continue due to suffocation and gas release.
- August 2026: suo motu cognizance of a manhole death in Faridabad.

28.6 Enlarging the Ambit of Human Rights: Health Rights

The NHRC has also upheld **health rights**, interpreting human rights **beyond the traditional framework**.

KEY CONCEPT

Beyond the traditional framework of civil liberties.

- The traditional framework treated human rights largely as **civil liberties** — for example, bonded labour as a human rights issue.
- The NHRC expanded the ambit to cover health rights and rights of identity, such as the rights of a transgender person, which were not previously treated as part of human rights.
- The Commission, rather than the citizen, effectively determines what counts as a human right.

- The Supreme Court has consistently expanded the framework of Article 21, but here the expansion of the very ambit of human rights is being done by the NHRC.
- An example concerning the LGBT community was flagged in the lecture but deferred to a later session.

EXAMPLE

Recent suo motu interventions on health rights (August 2026).

- **Malda Hospital** — the NHRC took suo motu cognizance of **60 newborn deaths** at Malda Hospital in Malda district, where the Ganga enters Bangladesh (near Farakka), and issued notice to the **Chief Secretary**.
- **Ambala** — the NHRC acted on the death of a child from drinking **contaminated water** in Ambala, Haryana, a major railway junction established by the British on the Delhi–Northern Railways route.

QUICK REVISION

- Health rights: human rights interpreted beyond the traditional civil-liberties framework.
- The ambit now covers health rights and rights of identity (for example, of a transgender person).
- The NHRC, not the citizen, effectively defines what a human right is.
- August 2026: suo motu cognizance of 60 newborn deaths at Malda Hospital and notice to the Chief Secretary.
- August 2026: action on a child's death from contaminated water in Ambala, Haryana.

28.7 Upholding Women's and Children's Rights

The lecture then turned to what it called the most important area — the rights of **women and children**.

- The NHRC takes **suo motu cognizance** in cases of rape and sexual assault, upholding the **dignity of women**.
- Its role here rests on two pillars — **police accountability** and **victim compensation**.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Case examples on women's rights.**
>
> - **R.G. Kar case** — the mother of the victim fought and won an election, from the BJP.
> - **Hyderabad nurse case** (about four to five years ago) — the accused truck drivers were taken by the police at 4 a.m. to the place of the offence to 'recreate' it and were shot; the public was aggravated, and the government had to respond.

- **Custodial violence is a major problem in Tamil Nadu.**
  - The Dravidian movement played an important role in upholding the rights of the backward classes, but to some extent more so than the Scheduled Castes.
  - The caste conflict in Tamil Nadu is largely a fight within the Dravidian fold — between the Scheduled Castes and the Other Backward Classes.
  - This produces repeated incidents of custodial violence.
- A COVID-era Tamil Nadu case: a Christian father and son were arrested, kept in custody for two to three years, and killed by the police.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Recent suo motu case — a 16-year-old girl.**
>
> - A 16-year-old girl was raped during heavy rains in Delhi after she accepted a lift; she was taken to western Uttar Pradesh and dropped at Ring Road, and the NHRC took **suo motu cognizance**.

On gender inclusivity, the Commission asked the Union to review the law.

> **GOVERNMENT & POLICY**
>
> **Transgender Persons (Amendment) Act.**
>
> - The NHRC asked the Union government to **review the laws** relating to the Transgender Persons (Amendment) Act so as to ensure **gender inclusivity**.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Women and children: suo motu cognizance in rape and sexual assault, and the upholding of the dignity of women.
> - Two pillars: police accountability and victim compensation.
> - Examples: the R.G. Kar case and the Hyderabad nurse encounter.

- Custodial violence is a major problem in Tamil Nadu; the conflict lies within the Dravidian fold.
- A COVID-era Tamil Nadu case: a father and son were killed in police custody.
- Recent: suo motu cognizance of a 16-year-old raped in Delhi after taking a lift.
- Transgender Persons (Amendment) Act: the NHRC asked the Union to review the laws for gender inclusivity.

28.8 Upholding Migrant Rights

Another strand is the upholding of **migrant rights**.

KEY CONCEPT

Why migrants are vulnerable.

- Migrants have left their social ties behind, face economic hardships, and have limited social capital.
- In every state there is a large chunk of migrants whose rights are subjugated.

- In Delhi the issue is less visible because Delhi is no one's — everyone in Delhi has been a migrant, and the actual descendants have been restricted to the villages of Delhi.
- Yet migrant rights require great care, precisely because the migrant arrives without community support.

EXAMPLE

NHRC notices on the North East.

- The NHRC has commonly issued notices regarding assault on people from the **North East**, including on the death of a popular singer from Manipur.

- The North East incidents in Delhi have involved delivery boys and groups of young men shaped by social media — millions of YouTube followers, stunts and pranks — leading to juvenile delinquency and a knife culture.
  - Seven or eight lean young men beat a delivery boy to death late at night.
  - They do not engage in road rage; they kill with a knife and run away, and the group drifts towards organised crime.
- **Nido Tania** of Arunachal Pradesh was killed in Delhi, after which the government formed the **Bezbaruah Committee**.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Bezbaruah Committee.

- The **Bezbaruah Committee** was formed by the government after the killing of Nido Tania to inquire into the rights of the people of the North Eastern states.

- A cultural accommodation has emerged in these areas: two opposite cultural societies live in the same place.

  - The North Eastern society's dress, speech, movement and interaction between men and women are entirely different.
  - In the surrounding societies the *ghunghat* (veil) practice is common, yet an accommodation has developed, and the police — largely drawn from the same society — stay active.
  - The issue remains highly sensitive, and IPS officers in Delhi must give clear instructions to their ACPs about such activities.
- Delhi has the advantage of diversity: unlike Maharashtra, where the 'Maratha Manus' narrative runs, Delhi is a mix of Purvanchali, Punjabi and many other castes and regions.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **A sensitive governance problem.**
>
> - Because Delhi belongs to no one, its social fabric is comparatively less fractious than Maharashtra's, but the North East issue remains one of the most sensitive matters for the government.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Migrant rights: migrants leave social ties, face economic hardship and have limited social capital.
> - Delhi is no one's — everyone is a migrant, and the descendants are confined to the villages of Delhi.
> - The NHRC has issued notices on assault on North Eastern people and on the death of a Manipuri singer.
> - Nido Tania's killing led to the Bezbaruah Committee.
> - Social-media-driven youth groups and a knife culture mark the North East incidents.
> - Two opposite cultural societies coexist, yet a cultural accommodation ('samanyay') has emerged.

28.9 Addressing the Emerging Framework of Human Rights

The NHRC also plays an important role in addressing the **emerging framework of human rights**.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Upholding digital rights.**
>
> - In **2026** the NHRC conducted an **open house discussion** on **'DIGI arrest' scams**.
> - It treated cyber-enabled coercion, privacy violation, personal data exploitation and economic vulnerability as **human rights concerns**.

- **Cyber bullying** and **cyber stalking** are human rights violations.
- Actors and influencers routinely receive threats, and there is now a generation of **deep fakes**.
- A person's private chat or personal data, if consensual, cannot be policed by others; moral policing in society is not permissible.

- The Supreme Court has also pointed to the emergence of **data rights** in its jurisprudence.

EXAMPLE

Child sexual exploitative material on social media.

- Meta was running advertisements for **child sexual exploitative abuse material (CSEM)** on Instagram, and **NCPCR** issued a notice to Meta asking what protocols it has to prevent this — the answer was found to be non-existent.

- Moral framing that treats a woman only as 'my sister' or 'my wife' is described as the poorest thinking — a woman may occupy many other roles.
- Such framing **commodifies** a person's privacy, which is why the emergence of data rights matters.

CRITICAL POINT

Commodifying privacy.

- Treating a woman only as a sister or a wife is the poorest thinking and commodities her identity; privacy cannot be commodified in this way.

- **Environment and climate rights:** the NHRC expressed concerns and established deliberative mechanisms concerning **heat wave mitigation**, thereby linking climate governance to the **right to life**.
- **Right to food and nutrition:** the NHRC examined cases of food and upheld access to **safe food** as part of healthy and dignified living; food adulteration is the obvious testing ground.

KEY CONCEPT

Who decides what a human right is?.

- What counts as a human right is effectively determined by the NHRC — what is a human right for one person may not be for another.
- This enlarging of the content of human rights is the Commission's most distinctive contribution.

The praise of this expanding role must be qualified.

CRITICAL POINT

Decline after 2019.

- The Commission's **institutional graph has declined**, specifically after **2019** — its institutional role has weakened even as its formal mandate has widened.

QUICK REVISION

- Emerging framework: digital rights, environment and climate rights, and the right to food and nutrition.
- 2026: an open house discussion on 'DIGI arrest' scams, treating cyber coercion, privacy and data exploitation as human rights concerns.
- Cyber bullying, cyber stalking and deep fakes are human rights violations.

- NCPCR issued a notice to Meta over CSEM advertisements on Instagram.
- Heat wave mitigation was linked to the right to life; safe food to healthy and dignified living.
- The Commission's institutional graph has declined after 2019.

28.10 Improved Access

The fifth major point is that the NHRC has led to **improved access**.

KEY CONCEPT

Open hearings and camp settings.

- The NHRC has held **open hearings** and **camp settings**, and it has thereby improved access.
- This has improved **direct engagement** with the state, with civil society, and with victims.

- Most organisations are accused of **armchair policies** — sitting in Delhi and claiming to uphold human rights without knowing the ground reality.
  - The NHRC in Delhi cannot know what is happening in Hyderabad, Chennai or Gujarat.
  - It therefore conducts observations and field visits, engages with victims and the state government, and summons the District Magistrate or other authorities.
  - Through these visits it is itself improving access and direct engagement.
- The Commission does not merely issue orders from the capital; it physically reaches the ground.

CRITICAL POINT

Awareness is still low.

- Very few people know that a grievance for a human rights violation can be redressed at the NHRC.
- The institution is doing its part to improve access, but the citizen must actually use it.

QUICK REVISION

- Fifth major point: improved access.
- Open hearings and camp settings have improved access.
- Improved direct engagement with the state, civil society and victims.
- Armchair policies are countered by observations and field visits.
- Few people know that the NHRC is a grievance-redressal forum.

28.11 Issues and Challenges: Why the NHRC is Called a 'Toothless Tiger'

With the functions and the positive role covered, the lecture turned to the **issues, concerns and challenges**.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **The framing question.**
>
> - **Why is the NHRC a toothless tiger?**
> - This is the question that the issues section answers.

The issues are approached in two equivalent ways — both use the same points under different heads.

1. Legal issues, plus institutional issues, plus functional issues, plus federal issues — all of which culminate in **international issues**.
2. Structural issues, plus functional issues — which likewise culminate in international issues.

- **Structural issues** are problems for which the NHRC is not responsible — the appointment process, the powers granted by Parliament, and the inherent problems of the legal-institutional mechanism.
- **Functional issues** are the functions given to the NHRC by law that it is itself incapable of performing — not releasing the annual report, not using suo motu powers, heavy pendency of cases, and not doing public advocacy.
- Analogy: a planned course whose classes get cancelled is a **functional** problem, whereas the structural problem with learners — wanting to watch a lecture in two hours and take a PDF without making notes — is not of the planner's making.

28.11.1 Legal Issues and Constraints

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **Recommendations are not binding.**
>
> - Under the **Protection of Human Rights Act, 1993**, the NHRC's recommendations are **non-binding**.
> - Where governments delay or do not implement them, it leads to an **implementation deficit**.
> - However good the institution, if the state does not follow its recommendations, it is of no use.

- **One-year limitation:** a human rights violation beyond one year cannot be inquired into or investigated by the NHRC.
  - This is the keyword **temporal limitation**.
  - It makes the Commission unsuitable for cases of trafficking and bonded labour, where the victim is in trauma and may lack awareness, resources or even freedom.
- The **Me Too movement** (2018), in the aftermath of the Harvey Weinstein sexual harassment case, illustrates why survivors cannot always come forward within a year.
- The limitation is especially harsh for institutional or continuing violations, and for child and mother victims.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **No power over the armed forces.**

- The NHRC **cannot investigate** the armed forces; it can largely only seek a report from the central government and issue recommendations.
- This leaves it with a limited capacity to investigate allegations against one of the most coercive organs of the state.
- The armed forces have historically been accused of offences against civilians and against certain ethnicities, and the Ministry of Defence would not write a report against its own officer.

- **Public servant-focused approach:** the law is strongly structured around human rights violations by **public servants**, leaving lesser legal focus on non-state actors.
  - The gap covers large multinational corporations, contractors, private hospitals, and employers who make people work 24 hours.
  - A private hospital may refuse treatment for want of an advance or a Rs. 3,000 consultation fee, leaving the patient with no remedy.
- The reason is historical: the law was brought in **1993, right after LPG (liberalisation)**, when the private sector's role in rights violations was not yet in focus.

28.11.2 Institutional Concerns

CRITICAL POINT

Lack of independence.

- As per **Section 11**, the Secretary General, police and investigative staff of the NHRC are provided by the **central government**.
- This compromises institutional independence and is a clear violation of the **Paris Principles**.

- The NHRC's head is the **Secretary General**, of the rank of Secretary to the Government of India; above the Secretary sits the Cabinet Secretary, the highest civil servant.
  - After retirement, favoured officers are appointed to positions such as Private Secretary in the PMO — for example P.K. Mishra, Tarun Kapoor and Govind Mohan, in the line of Nripendra Misra.
  - The Indian Economic Service reaches the Secretary rank after about 35 years of service, whereas officers of the IPS, Indian Revenue Service and Audit and Accounts rarely reach it because their empanelment happens later.
  - Empanelment means entering the central pool of officers eligible for a post, and it depends on a clean, first-class ACR record.
- Because officers are **deputed** by the central government, there is no **permanent independent investigative cadre** — 'cadre' meaning a standing body of officers.
  - The Commission does conduct its own investigations, but with borrowed officers.

CRITICAL POINT

Delay in appointments.

- There is an average delay of about **one year** in appointing the chairman and members of the

NHRC.

- The present chairman, Justice **V. Ramasubramanian**, was appointed after a delay of six months — making it a **headless organisation** for that period.

- A flagged case: a judge referred to in the lecture as Megha Rupam was directed by the Allahabad High Court to pay **Rs. 5 lakh from her own salary**, and she has appealed to the Supreme Court.

CRITICAL POINT

Excessive judicialization.

- There is excessive judicialization: judicial experience matters, but the present human rights framework requires **HR experts** from sociology, gender studies, child protection, child psychology, tribal rights, digital technology, environment activism and civil society.
- Non-judicial members are usually retired bureaucrats, which means there is a **lack of adequate pluralism**.

- The lecture referred to Gloria Steinem's work and article in a magazine section, making the point that a broad reading habit — the Sunday magazine section, The Hindu, Frontline — builds the fine taste and personality needed for this subject.

The selection mechanism itself is **opaque**.

- Even though the selection committee has **statutory backing** (a collegium of six members), opacity persists because:
  - Vacancies are not always advertised through an open public process, and are sometimes deliberately under-publicised.
  - The shortlisting criteria are not fully transparent.
  - Civil society participation is limited.

28.11.3 Functional Problems

CRITICAL POINT

Complaint burden.

- In **2023–24** there were almost **77,000 fresh cases**, which has led to **pendency of cases**.
- The Commission is **reactive rather than preventive**.

- **Limited use of suo motu powers:** comparing 2012 with 2016, the number of suo motu cases had actually **halved**.
  - The Commission works on a **report-and-notice model** — an incident is reported, a notice is served, and the matter ends.
  - The better approach would be an **institutional model** that addresses the root cause and structural issues.
  - Manual scavenging is the clearest instance of this gap.
- **Satya Niketan revisited:** a building collapsed and poor students died. The NHRC took suo

motu cognizance, reported the matter, sent notice to the Delhi Police Commissioner and made him a party — and closed the file.

- There was no long-term structural analysis of why buildings keep collapsing in Delhi.
- After three years the case ended, and with it the institutional memory.
- The correct response was to summon the DDA chairman (the Lieutenant Governor), the PWD and the Delhi government's housing authorities, and to find land for hostels — a step recently approved by the Chief Minister.

CRITICAL POINT

Failed to arrest human rights violations.

- The NHRC has failed to arrest human rights violations — in cases of rape, sexual abuse, murder, manual scavenging, ethnic violence in Manipur, and in its review of laws (for example the Transgender Amendment of 2019).
- Measures are taken, but the **root cause** is not addressed.
- It has also followed a **lackadaisical approach** — a critique drawn from an article on LiveLaw — under which **annual reports are not released on time**, making it difficult to review the Commission's performance.

- **Rampant in limine dismissal** — approximately **50%** of cases filed are disposed of *in limine*, that is, rejection of the application at the threshold, at the very first stage.
  - Under the **NHRC Regulations, 1997**, an application may be dismissed in limine if the matter is sub judice before a commission, a court or a tribunal, and such cases are disposed of without a preliminary hearing.
  - The NHRC is meant to be an **addendum platform** for violations not pending before a court — the regulation was framed with that spirit in 1993, when overlap was inevitable.
  - The problem is that applications are wide and broad, and deciding whether the matter is sub judice demands knowledge of the law and of the provisions.
- Once a case is dismissed in limine, the individual has only one remedy — to file the case in a court of law and make the NHRC a party.
  - This adds another layer of burden and delays access to grievance redressal for human rights violations.
  - Incorrect applications and incorrect interpretation of the law are among the reasons for such dismissal.
- **Dependence on government reports:** the NHRC can call for reports from government authorities, but over-reliance on the reports of the same administrative system against which the allegations arise leads to a **lack of independent fact finding**.
  - It is like asking the accused to supply the information needed to investigate his own offence.

28.11.4 Federal Issues

CRITICAL POINT

Weak State Human Rights Commissions.

- The **SHRCs** are weak — they face vacancies and staff shortage, and their implementation is weak.
- This limits access to human rights in the states and overloads the NHRC.

- **Jurisdiction comparison:** the SHRC investigates offences in the State and Concurrent Lists, while the NHRC can inquire into offences in **any of the three lists** — no subject is specially reserved for it, so the restriction lies on the SHRC.
  - If an SHRC does not function well on a State List subject, the NHRC can still inquire, which ends up increasing the NHRC's burden.
- There are **limited dedicated human rights courts and special public prosecutors**.
- **Overlapping jurisdictions:** a woman belonging to SC/ST who faces a human rights violation as a bonded labourer involves the NCW (women), the NCSC or NCST (constitutional bodies) and the NHRC simultaneously.
  - This creates a problem of **forum selection** and **forum shopping**.
  - It also creates **administrative duplication**, since three bodies will address the same grievance.
  - And it leads to **institutional fragmentation**.

28.11.5 International Issues and GANHRI Accreditation

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

GANHRI and the SCA.

- **GANHRI** — the Global Alliance of National Human Rights Institutions — is a **UN-recognised** body that evaluates the working of National Human Rights Institutions across countries (India's NHRC, Pakistan's, the US's, Denmark's, and others).
- The evaluation is done by its **SCA — Sub-Committee on Accreditation**, which classifies NHRIs into **A and B categories**.

- India is in **Category A**, but concerns remain — GANHRI has said that India does not adhere to the **six Paris Principles**, which are the very issues used in the answer.
  - In **2023 and 2024** GANHRI **deferred India's A rating** — the first time in the NHRC's history, and India is the only country to be deferred continuously for two years.
- The deferment works like a promotion withheld: you have first rank, you sit a test and come tenth, yet you are given first rank again and one more chance to meet the Paris Principles; if you still fail, you drop to B.
  - Category A status is valuable — it gives a **voice in discussing global human rights issues**.

DATA & FACTS

The NHRC's accreditation record.

- The NHRC has continuously held an **A rating since 1999**, awarded by the UN-recognised **Global Alliance of National Human Rights Institutions**, which unites **120 national human rights institutions** globally.
- The review for GANHRI is conducted by the **SCA (Sub-Committee on Accreditation)**; **re-accreditation happens every five years**, evaluating the NHRI's performance.
- In the past, the NHRC's accreditation has been **deferred (2023 and 2024)** — the first time in the history of the NHRC.

- The **UN Human Rights Council has 40 seats**, and India has been a member for the last seven to eight years.
- Membership of these platforms matters: the loss of the A rating carries direct consequences.

Voting position	India loses its voting position with GANHRI
Representation	India must forgo its position as India's designated representative at the UN Human Rights Council and other subsidiary bodies
Credibility	Upholding of human rights is affected because of damaged institutional credibility

28.11.6 Way Forward

- Move from the **report-and-notice model** to an **institutional model** that addresses the root cause and structural issues rather than closing individual files.
- Address structural concerns so that the same incident need not recur — for example, by summoning the DDA chairman (the Lieutenant Governor), the PWD and the Delhi government's housing authorities, and by creating hostel capacity.
- A fuller Way Forward and the topic of **Merger of Commissions** were announced for the following session.

QUICK REVISION

- Issues are organised as legal, institutional, functional and federal, all culminating in international issues; the alternative framing is structural plus functional leading to international issues.
- Structural issues are not of the NHRC's making; functional issues are its own failures.
- Legal constraints: non-binding recommendations, the one-year (temporal) limitation, no power over the armed forces, and a public-servant-focused approach.
- Institutional concerns: lack of independence (Section 11), delayed appointments (a headless

organisation), excessive judicialization, and an opaque selection mechanism.

- Functional problems: complaint burden (about 77,000 fresh cases in 2023–24), limited suo motu use, the report-and-notice model, failure to arrest violations, late annual reports, and rampant in limine dismissal (about 50%).
- Federal issues: weak SHRCs, few human rights courts, and overlapping jurisdictions that cause forum shopping, duplication and fragmentation.
- International: GANHRI/SCA accreditation, A category since 1999, deferment in 2023 and 2024, and the costs of losing the A rating.

CHAPTER 29

The National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) — Part 3

29.1 PYQ-Based Approach to the Merger Debate

The examination frames questions on the NHRC primarily around **issues**. The discussion that follows is issue-centred, and it adopts a **PYQ-based approach**: PYQs matter not only as practice but to analyse how a question has been framed. The task set here is to write the **pros and cons of the merger** of the other commissions into the NHRC.

Six commissions are implicated in the debate, each currently running its own machinery.

> **GOVERNMENT & POLICY**
>
> **Commissions proposed for merger into the NHRC.**
>
> - **NCSC** — National Commission for Scheduled Castes
> - **NCST** — National Commission for Scheduled Tribes
> - **NCPCR** — National Commission for Protection of Child Rights
> - **NCW** — National Commission for Women
> - A commission for **minorities** (as stated in lecture)

- The merger question is essentially a **debate** — it has to be argued both ways.
  - A PYQ around **2015** raised this merger debate.
  - Only about one question has so far come on it.

> **PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION**
>
> **How this merger debate is examined.**
>
> - Expect an issue-centred question rather than a descriptive one on the NHRC.
> - The pros and cons of merger form the core of such an answer.
> - A single PYQ (around 2015) has tested this debate.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Questions on the NHRC are framed around **issues**, not descriptions.
> - Commissions in the merger debate: **NCSC, NCST, NCPCR, NCW** and a minorities commission — six in all.
> - The merger question is a **debate**, tested by a PYQ around 2015.

- PYQs must be analysed for framing, not merely practised.

29.2 Benefits of Merging the Commissions into the NHRC

Human rights are all-encompassing: **women's rights cannot be separated from human rights**, because human rights are themselves all-encompassing. A violation of the rights of any person or any section therefore automatically becomes the concern of the Human Rights Commission.

- **Intersectional approach** — an indivisible body of human rights is handled together, whereas fragmented commissions might artificially divide an interlinked and interconnected set of rights.
  - Every violation is then read through overlapping identities rather than a single category.
- **Eliminates duplication and overlapping jurisdiction** — a unified institution gives a **single grievance-redressal platform**.
  - It reduces **forum shopping** — the citizen having to choose which forum to file before.
  - These bodies enjoy their powers by statute or by the Constitution, so there must be "some method in the madness"; **forum selection** has to be rationalised.
  - In the lecture's words, forum shopping is like going from shop to shop: "should I file here or there?"
- **Administrative economies of scale** — merger prevents maintenance of separate staff, office, IT system, research division and grievance portal for each commission.
  - Six commissions mean six separate mechanisms, six separate staff requirements, six separate secretariats and six portals — a substantial added cost.
- **Better data integration** — an integrated database provides a broader perspective than isolated, commission-wise data.
- **Specialized investigating capacity**, **greater bargaining power with the government** and **greater public visibility** for one umbrella body.
- **Institutional weight** — one big umbrella organisation carries weight, like the Supreme Court and the High Courts, or Indian Railways.
  - Indian Railways draws on engineering services as well as civil services and is among the most coveted organisations.
  - Its staff enjoy accommodation and infrastructure advantages that revenue services, corporate-law services and trade services generally do not — except IAS and IPS.
- **Fulfils the international model of human rights institutions** — a National Human Rights Institution, per the **Paris Principles**, should possess a broad mandate covering civil, political, social, cultural and economic rights.

EXAMPLE

A Dalit woman in manual scavenging.

- She is **Dalit**, engaging the rights of the depressed classes.
- She is a **woman**, engaging women's rights.

- She is a **manual scavenger**, engaging the right to dignified living.
- All three identities and rights intersect to violate her human rights — which is exactly why an **intersectional approach** is desired.

The Paris Principles argument cuts further. Separate commissions for women, backward classes and minorities would still be dealing with humans; their rights-frameworks differ, but the violation itself calls for a unified approach. If the National Commission for Women takes women's rights and every non-women matter goes to the NHRC, that framework is of no use against the Paris Principles.

KEY CONCEPT

Human rights — definition.

- **Human rights** are those rights which exist as a prerequisite for the existence of a person as a human.
- Because they are a prerequisite of existence, they cut across gender, caste, region and minority status — the premise of the entire merger argument.

QUICK REVISION

- Human rights are **all-encompassing**; women's rights cannot be separated from them.
- **Intersectional approach** — indivisible rights versus artificially fragmented commissions.
- A **single grievance-redressal platform** removes duplication, overlapping jurisdiction and **forum shopping**.
- **Administrative economies of scale** — six commissions mean six staff, offices, IT systems, research divisions and portals.
- Institutional weight, bargaining power and public visibility follow from one umbrella body (like the Supreme Court/High Courts or Indian Railways).
- The **Paris Principles** require a broad civil, political, social, cultural and economic rights mandate.

29.3 Drawbacks of Merging the Commissions into the NHRC

The case against merger starts from identity. The problems of women, of Scheduled Tribes and of Scheduled Castes are all different, and India carries a separate identity built on caste, region and gender. Such unification might work in the United States or in a homogenised European society, but not in Indian society, where for every identity there is a distinct institutional problem.

EXAMPLE

The Konda Reddi tribals and the forest.

- The **Konda Reddi** tribals of Andhra Pradesh live around **Papikonda National Park** (east of Rajahmundry, north of Vizag).
- Their problem is not discrimination of the caste type; it is **Jal, Jangal, Zameen** — access to

water, forest and land.

- Forest land is their land: they have historically administered forests in accordance with their community rights, and they seek stakes in governance.

NCSC	Scheduled Castes	Untouchability, caste-based discrimination, difficulty staying in urban areas, confinement to class 3/class 4 jobs
NCST	Scheduled Tribes	Jal, Jangal, Zameen — forest land, access to water, and forests administered under community rights
NCW	Women	Gender violence and women-specific violations
NCPCR	Children	Child rights, including child sexual exploitative and abusive material

- **Dedicated institutions are needed for specialized discriminations** — child rights and tribal rights, child sexual exploitative and abusive material, alienation and forest governance, caste atrocities and gender violence each require **domain expertise**.
- **Domain expertise has a scholarly basis** — one school of sociology holds that atrocities against the subordinate castes can be researched and studied only by that deprived caste, because the upper caste will always write of lower-caste problems with an inherent bias.
  - **Counter-perspective:** if only the Dalit reproduces Dalit experience, the third-person perspective required in research methods — for instance an anthropologist studying a society for 30, 35 or 40 years — is lost.
  - Domain expertise and these social-science currents and counter-currents must therefore be argued together.
- **Institutional memory** matters — the Election Commission and the RBI have built strong institutional memory since independence.
  - NCSC and NCST have repeatedly focused on the interests of their vulnerable sections and developed the expertise and the framework to read those problems.
  - The NHRC cannot develop that framework; it might develop one for custodial violence, but not for these distinct categories.
- **Loss of voice and visibility** — specialized bodies project the specific concerns of vulnerable groups at the national and regional levels.

  - An umbrella NHRC leads to the **invisibilisation of specific concerns**.
- **Constitutional limitations** — merger or abolition of these commissions requires statutory or constitutional enactment, i.e. amendment of the law, which in turn requires **parliamentary consensus**.
- **A mega institution with mega bureaucracy** — one body handling everything becomes "too big to fail", creating administrative delay in grievance redressal, delayed inquiry or investigation, and pendency of applications.
- **Dilution of accountability** — a single, oversized body weakens the line of responsibility.
- **Loss of the non-grievance functions** — apart from grievance redressal, the separate commissions also monitor constitutional safeguards, suggest measures, and promote safeguards and socio-economic development; all of this is compromised in a merger.
  - They are not merely grievance-handling bodies: they build awareness, advocate policies, and recommend to the legislature that laws and policies be changed.

DATA & FACTS

Pendency is already visible.

- **77,000** cases were filed in the NHRC in **2023-24**.
- Earlier the figure was around **80,000** cases — pendency in the NHRC is already a concern.

Grievance redressal is only one — though the major — function. Each of the other roles is a specific constitutional function performed by a dedicated commission, and the whole set is a **paraphernalia**: one cannot pull out a single part and claim that the NHRC will perform everything.

CRITICAL POINT

Why a single umbrella is a false economy.

- India's human rights concept is international, but Indian society is organised by caste, region and gender — one unified umbrella cannot serve identities whose institutional problems differ.
- Even where a unified body meets 99% of needs, the **1% extra perspective** of the dedicated body is lost.
- Invisibilisation of specific concerns, loss of institutional memory and dilution of accountability together outweigh the administrative savings.

QUICK REVISION

- Each group's problems are **distinct** — women, Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes cannot be handled by one umbrella.
- SC problems: untouchability and caste discrimination; ST problems: **Jal, Jangal, Zameen** (example: **Konda Reddi** tribals and **Papikonda National Park**).
- Dedicated commissions supply **domain expertise** and **institutional memory** (Election Commission, RBI, NCSC, NCST).
- Merger would cause **invisibilisation of specific concerns**, loss of voice and visibility, and

dilution of accountability.

- Merger needs statutory/constitutional amendment and **parliamentary consensus**, and builds a mega bureaucracy that delays redressal.
- Pendency is already high: **77,000** cases filed in the NHRC in **2023-24**, against about **80,000** earlier.
- Separate commissions also monitor safeguards, advise and promote socio-economic development — a **paraphernalia** that merger would spoil.

29.4 The Common Public-Administration Logic Behind Merger Debates

The pros and cons rehearsed for the NHRC are generic: the same arguments recur whichever body is merged or split. This reasoning is the core of **public administration**, and once learned it transfers to other questions.

COMPARISON

The standard two-sided argument.

- **For merger:** economies of scale, reduced duplication, an overarching framework, an intersectional approach, and lower cost and staff requirements.
- **For separate bodies:** dedicated focus, a dedicated team, a framework tailored to a distinct category of rights, and the prevention of a mega bureaucracy — which in turn promotes accountability.

- The same reasoning applies to merging any ministry, to breaking a state into four parts, or to creating new districts in a state.
- The contrast lies in the domain: taxation (for example GST) is driven by an economic, business-formation logic, whereas here we are dealing with bodies, commissions and verticals — a public-administration topic, not an economic one.

QUICK REVISION

- Merger arguments are **generic** to any institution, ministry, state reorganisation or district creation.
- For merger: economies, reduced duplication, overarching framework, intersectional approach, lower cost and staff.
- For separation: dedicated focus and team, a tailored rights-framework, no mega bureaucracy, hence **accountability**.
- Detect the domain: bodies and verticals = public administration; taxation/GST = economy.

29.5 Second ARC's Stand and Its Recommendations

Against a wholesale merger, the **Second ARC** took a middle path: it did not favour merging the commissions outright, because that would fail to address the special problems of disadvantaged groups.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Second ARC on merger.

- **Did not favour a wholesale merger** of the commissions into the NHRC.
- Reason: it would **fail to address the special problems of disadvantaged groups**.

Instead it recommended a set of coordination reforms:

1. A **common complaint format**.
2. **Networked integrated governance** — a networked electronic database.
3. **Norms to determine the most appropriate commission**, so as to avoid **forum shopping**.
4. An **internal mechanism for handling overlapping cases**.

On the third recommendation, the norms must lay down clear-cut criteria. If, for example, the complainant is a woman Dalit bonded labourer, the norms must tell her which is the proper commission to approach.

QUICK REVISION

- Second ARC rejected a **wholesale merger**.
- Reason: it would fail to address the **special problems of disadvantaged groups**.
- Recommendation 1: a **common complaint format**.
- Recommendation 2: **networked integrated governance / networked electronic database**.
- Recommendation 3: **norms to identify the most appropriate commission** (to avoid forum shopping).
- Recommendation 4: an **internal mechanism for overlapping cases**.
- Norms must give clear-cut criteria (illustration: a woman Dalit bonded labourer).

29.6 2021 PYQ: Structural and Practical Limitations of Human Rights Commissions

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

PYQ 2021.

- "Human Rights Commissions have contributed immensely to protection of human rights in India, yet they have failed to assert themselves against the mighty and powerful. Analysing their structural and practical limitations, suggest remedial measures."

The first step is keyword analysis. The opening clause carries the **positive role** of the human rights institutions; the second clause carries their failure to assert themselves against the mighty and powerful, and attributes that failure to **structural and practical limitations**.

- "**Mighty and powerful**" means people who are powerful and have been more successful in violating human rights; their victims could not obtain remedies.
  - The answer must therefore explain *why* the institutions failed to act against the mighty

and powerful before it moves to remedies.

- The limitations must be split into **structural** and **functional/practical** heads.
  - **Structural** — lack of independence, the point the class identified, traceable to the composition and appointment process.
  - **Practical/functional** — the failure to act against the powerful and to secure remedies for victims.
- The introduction should establish the body: the NHRC is a **statutory body** formed under the **Protection of Human Rights Act, 1993**, adhering to the **Paris Principles**, and it has upheld the constitutional framework of human rights.
- The functions should be shown **in a diagram** rather than as prose.
- A **connecting line** is needed between the keyword analysis and the limitations — for example, "it has failed to assert itself against the mighty and powerful / to address the concerns of ... because of the following limitations".

QUICK REVISION

- PYQ 2021: the contribution of human rights commissions weighed against their failure to assert themselves against the **mighty and powerful**; analyse **structural and practical limitations** and suggest remedies.
- "Mighty and powerful" = the powerful, who succeeded in violating rights while victims went remediless.
- Split limitations into **structural** (lack of independence) and **practical/functional** (failure to act and to secure remedies).
- Introduction: NHRC = statutory body under the **Protection of Human Rights Act, 1993**, adhering to the **Paris Principles**.
- Show the functions in a **diagram** and add a **connecting line** to the limitations.

29.7 Remedial Measures Suggested for the NHRC

The second half of the answer is built as a set of remedial measures, each carrying its own reasoning so that it reads as reform rather than a wish-list.

1. **Amend the PHRA** (Protection of Human Rights Act) to adhere to the **Paris Principles**.
2. **Reform the appointment process and promote pluralism** — vacancies are not advertised, bureaucrats are appointed as members, and there is excessive judicialisation; a wider composition is required.
3. **Diversify the composition** so that pluralism is built into the membership.
4. **Create a separate investigative cadre** for the NHRC.
5. **Amend the temporal limitation of one year** so that the NHRC can accept applications beyond one year (a) in cases of **continuing violation**, and (b) in cases of **trafficking or bondage**, **sexual abuse or sexual violence**, **child abuse**, and where **grave public interest** exists.
6. **Strengthen the recommendations** — governments should be statutorily required to submit an **Action Taken Report (ATR)** and to accept the recommendations; in case of rejection, the

rejection must be **supported by reasons**.

7. **Strengthen parliamentary oversight** — parliamentary committees should examine pending NHRC recommendations, any delay in the ATR, and any repeated violation by departments or states.
8. **Strengthen the State Human Rights Commissions**, so as to prevent the increase in the number of cases filed with the NHRC.
9. **Use technology such as AI** to understand the patterns of human rights violations, shifting from **case-by-case disposal** to a **systemic audit** and **outcome governance**.
10. **Operationalise human rights courts** and follow the **Second ARC coordination approach**.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Why outcome governance, not case-by-case disposal.**
>
> - If ten manual-scavenging cases are each individually answered, the outcome — eliminating manual scavenging as a problem — is still unaddressed.
> - A "Bandicoot" robot exists to prevent manual scavenging, but it is a **knee-jerk reaction**.
> - The same ten scavengers may share structural root causes: lack of skill and being shunted from a parent job, trapping them in a perpetual vicious cycle of caste-based employment.
> - Address the **root**, not the case: identify the structural factors and treat the pattern as a socio-economic phenomenon.

Parliamentary oversight works as a chain: the NHRC recommends to the government; the government must follow; if it does not follow, it must give a reason; those reasons are evaluated by Parliament; and the whole action should be performed within a **time limit**, so that recommendations do not simply stay pending. The **Finance Commission** precedent shows that recommendations can be followed by convention.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **The endpoint of reform.**
>
> - The NHRC should **not** become an individual grievance-redressal body, nor an adjudicatory platform — it must pursue **systemic reform** for the rights of the socially deprived.
> - Human rights violations can occur anywhere, even to the caste-wise powerful.
> - The role of the NHRC in upholding human rights has to be **complemented by the State Human Rights Commissions**.

The same answer can be extended by discussing the **difference in the statutory framework of the NHRC and the SHRC**.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Amend the **PHRA** to align with the **Paris Principles**.
> - Reform appointment and diversify composition — advertise vacancies, avoid bureaucrat-members and excessive judicialisation.
> - Create a **separate investigative cadre**.

- Amend the one-year **temporal limitation** for continuing violation, trafficking/bondage, sexual and child abuse, and grave public interest.
- Strengthen recommendations through a mandatory **ATR** with reasons for rejection, and **parliamentary oversight** of delays and repeated violations (Finance Commission convention as precedent).
- Strengthen **SHRCs**; use **AI** for a **systemic audit** and **outcome governance**; operationalise **human rights courts** per the Second ARC coordination approach.
- NHRC must pursue **systemic reform**, not become an adjudicatory or individual-grievance body; its role is complemented by the SHRCs.

29.8 PYQ: NHRC as an Effective Complement to the Judiciary and Other Institutions

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

PYQ.

- "NHRC in India can be most effective when its tasks are supported by other mechanisms that ensure accountability of the government. In the light of the above observation, assess the role of NHRC as an effective complement to the judiciary and other institutions in promoting and protecting human rights standards."

This question boils down to governance: the government or executive must be made accountable, and the NHRC is only one of the mechanisms that can do so. It intertwines the NHRC with **separation of powers**.

Under separation of powers there are three — in effect four — pillars, and the NHRC is interlinked with them because it draws its information from them. The mechanisms that hold the government accountable therefore form the first half of the answer, and the role of the NHRC the second.

Judiciary	Enforces decisions and gives judgments; it can take suo motu notice when the NHRC reports a violation and bring the matter to a court of law
Legislature / Parliament	Enacts strong laws and amends the Protection of Human Rights Act; also enables the role of other commissions such as NCSC and NCST
Media — the fourth pillar	Reports and publicises violations, including through social media, making them real before the public
Civil society and NGOs	Mobilise opinion and advocate on rights issues
Other commissions (NCSC, NCST)	Work alongside the NHRC for persons from deprived sections and reinforce the protection of human rights

- The NHRC **institutionalised human rights** — earlier only the Supreme Court used to expand the human rights framework.
- It has **upheld a wide variety of human rights**, adhering to Supreme Court rulings — for example the **Bandhua Mazdoor Morcha** case.
- Its **custodial-torture guidelines** fulfil the **D.K. Basu** Supreme Court judgment (year around **1990** — the class was asked to verify the year).
- It has **complemented the roles of the NCW and the NCPCR** in upholding women's and child rights.
- By upholding the interests of **manual scavengers**, it upholds the interests of the **National Commission for Scheduled Castes**.
- By organising **advocacy campaigns on digital rights and cyberbullying**, it complements the role of the **media**.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Which mechanism does what.**
>
> - **Legislature illustration:** an employer who violates a teacher's rights, for example by not paying salary on time, points to a gap that only a law can close — a separate law for the regulation of coaching institutions is currently coming up in Delhi.
> - **Legislature illustration:** an amendment to the Transgender Persons Act passed by Parliament is itself a legislative mechanism of accountability [as stated in lecture].
> - **Judiciary illustration:** the NHRC reports a violation, the Supreme Court takes suo motu notice, and the matter reaches a court of law.

Only one sentence on the role of the judiciary needs to be added to the discussion — the Supreme Court points are simply folded into the same answer. The question then closes on its second half:

the role of the NHRC as a complementary authority to the judiciary and to other institutions.

QUICK REVISION

- The question is about **governance** — making the government/executive accountable.
- Mechanisms: **judiciary**, **legislature**, **media (fourth pillar)**, **civil society/NGOs** and **other commissions (NCSC, NCST)**.
- The NHRC is intertwined with **separation of powers** (three, in effect four, pillars) and draws information from them.
- The NHRC **institutionalised human rights**; earlier only the Supreme Court expanded the framework.
- Examples of adherence to Supreme Court rulings: the **Bandhua Mazdoor Morcha** case; **custodial-torture guidelines** fulfilling the **D.K. Basu** judgment (year around 1990, to verify).
- The NHRC complements the **NCW** and **NCPCR** (women's and child rights), the **NCSC** (manual scavengers) and the **media** (digital rights, cyberbullying).
- Add just one sentence on the role of the judiciary and fold in the Supreme Court points.

29.9 NHRC vs SHRC: Statutory Framework to Compare

NHRC and SHRC must be compared on their **statutory framework**, and this comparison belongs within the same answer — the complementarity of the two is the closing theme of the discussion.

- Prepare a comparative table of the NHRC and the SHRC on their statutory framework.
  - The table is to be shown the next day.
  - It can be searched on ChatGPT or Claude, or prepared by reading the provisions directly — either way, writing the table out aids recall.
  - A screenshot of the table may be sent if it is prepared digitally.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Prelims relevance.

- A **Prelims** question on the NHRC came about **two years ago**.
- GS2 topics also reappear in Prelims, so preparing the table serves both stages.

QUICK REVISION

- Compare the **statutory framework** of the NHRC and the SHRC.
- Prepare it as a **table** — searching or hand-making both work; writing aids recall.
- The complementarity of NHRC and SHRC closes the PYQ answer.
- **Prelims** has already asked on the NHRC (about two years ago); GS2 material doubles as Prelims preparation.

29.10 Preparation and Study Approach

- **Newspaper reading** improves comprehension, communication and the analysis of information; it also builds reading speed, which allows many topics to be covered in a week.
- Comfort with reasoning and mathematics helps in **CSAT**, even without MBA or GMAT coaching.
- Read **counter-current** perspectives: a weekly magazine carrying core leftist arguments is useful precisely because present-day newspapers write in support of the government, and that counter-current sharpens argument (The Hindu leans slightly left; the Express a little left).
- Do not restrict thought to a three-to-five-page PDF or pager — the nuances of civil society and of civil-services knowledge are the real value, and they keep the subject interesting.
- **AI tools** such as ChatGPT and Claude are an added skill: they help judge what is right and what is wrong and help upgrade skills.
- **FOMO** is a theoretical premise that has to be broken logically; the hours have to be put in.

QUICK REVISION

- Newspaper reading builds comprehension, communication, analysis and reading speed.
- Comfort with reasoning and mathematics helps in **CSAT**.
- Read **counter-current** publications to balance pro-government reportage.
- Do not confine study to short PDFs — the nuances matter.
- Use **AI tools** as a skill aid, not a crutch.
- Break **FOMO** logically; put in the hours.

CHAPTER 30

Various Commissions

30.1 Topic Overview, PYQs and Answer Framework

- This topic is a continuation of the **National Human Rights Commission (NHRC)**.
- The subject theme is **GS Paper 2**, in the segment dealing with **regulatory bodies**.
- The topic covers the various commissions — NCSC, NCST, NCBC, NCPCR and NCW.
  - **NCSC** — National Commission for Scheduled Castes.
  - **NCST** — National Commission for Scheduled Tribes.
  - **NCBC** — National Commission for Backward Classes.
  - **NCPCR** — National Commission for Protection of Child Rights.
  - **NCW** — National Commission for Women.

> **PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION**
>
> **PYQs asked on these commissions.**
>
> - What is the importance of independence and autonomy of regulatory bodies? — a broad question; it is to be written at the end.
> - Issues in the working of these commissions.
> - Measures that you suggest for the betterment of the working of these commissions.
> - Role of each commission.
> - A current question: the role of the **NCBC** in the wake of its transformation into a **constitutional body** — asked in the 2021-22 Mains cycle, in the pre-ChatGPT era (ChatGPT was released on 23 November 2022).

- Framework that will be followed: (1) the **details** of the various commissions — draw a table here; (2) the **functions** of each commission and its **role** — first the positives, that is the **merits**, and then the negatives, that is the **issues, challenges and concerns**; (3) the **steps suggested** at the end.
- The steps taken by the Government of India will **not** be asked here; they are asked under the framework of **social justice**.
- The steps taken by the commissions themselves are written under the **merits**.
- There will be one **common framework** for all the commissions — separate answers for each of them are not needed.

QUICK REVISION

- This topic continues from the NHRC and belongs to the regulatory-bodies segment of GS Paper 2.
- The five commissions: NCSC, NCST, NCBC, NCPCR and NCW.
- PYQs: importance of independence and autonomy of regulatory bodies; issues in working; measures suggested; role of each commission.
- A current question asked about the role of the NCBC after its transformation into a constitutional body (2021-22 Mains).
- Answer framework: details in a table, then functions and role (merits first, then issues, challenges and concerns), then steps suggested.
- Steps taken by the Government of India are not written here — they belong to the social justice framework; the commissions' own steps go under merits.
- One common framework serves all five commissions.

30.2 Introduction — Details of the Commissions

The first theme is the **Introduction**. On a new page, draw one **horizontal table** and write the details of each commission separately in it.

NCSC	Constitutional body	Article **338**	Made a separate body by the **89th Constitutional Amendment Act, 2003**
NCST	Constitutional body	Article **338** (as stated in the lecture)	A separate NCST was created by the **89th Constitutional Amendment Act, 2003**
NCBC	Constitutional body; earlier a statutory body	Article **338B**; made constitutional by the **102nd Constitutional Amendment Act, 2018** (2019)	Earlier statutory, under the NCBC Act, 1993
NCPCR	Statutory body	Enabling Act of Parliament — the lecture says the name of the law need not be written	Established in **2005**; Commission for Protection of Child Rights
NCW	Statutory body	Enabling Act of Parliament	Year **1990** [as stated in lecture]

30.2.1 Composition

- At least one member has to be a **woman**.
- At least one member has to be from the **Scheduled Castes**.
- At least one member has to be from the **Scheduled Tribes**.
- The **NCBC** has five members — the Chairperson, the Vice-Chairperson and three members.
- The **NCPCR** has no such category-based criteria.

Is the chairperson necessarily from the community served?

- In practice, the chairperson is from the community concerned.
  - **Kishor Makwana** is the Chairman of the NCSC.
  - The NCST also has its own chairman (the name was not recalled in the lecture).
  - The Chairman of the National Commission for Minorities is from the **Sikh** community.
  - The Chairperson of the National Commission for Women is a **lady from Maharashtra**.
- Composition-wise, however, there is **no criterion** that the chairman has to come from that section only.

  - As per the law and the provisions of the Constitution, you do not have to be from that section to be the chairman.
  - The reason is that it is a **political appointment**.
- So the position is: **in reality, yes** — the chairperson is usually from that community; **constitutionally, no**.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **Late creation of the women's and children's commissions.**
>
> - The National Commission for Women and the children's commission were formed at a **very late stage** in the working of policy.

- The introduction has broadly covered the base: the appointment is made by the **President** under his warrant, under hand and seal.
- The concerns of removal are too specific and will not be written.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - NCSC and NCST are constitutional bodies under Article 338, created as separate bodies by the 89th Constitutional Amendment Act, 2003.
> - NCBC is a constitutional body under Article 338B, made constitutional by the 102nd Constitutional Amendment Act, 2018 (brought into force in 2019); earlier it was a statutory body under the NCBC Act, 1993.
> - NCPCR (2005) and NCW are statutory bodies; for the NCPCR the name of the law need not be written.
> - Composition: at least one member must be a woman, at least one from the SCs and at least one from the STs; the NCBC has five members (Chairperson, Vice-Chairperson and three members); the NCPCR has no such criteria.
> - Constitutionally there is no requirement that the chairperson belong to the section served — it is a political appointment — but in reality the chairperson generally does come from that community.
> - The women's and children's commissions were created at a very late stage in the working of policy.
> - Appointment is by the President under his warrant, under hand and seal; removal concerns are too specific to be written.

30.3 Functions of the Commissions

- Functions are taken first for the **constitutional bodies** (NCSC, NCST and NCBC) and then for the **statutory bodies**.
- These commissions are essentially **social justice bodies**.
  - They monitor **discrimination** and they monitor **atrocities**.
  - They monitor **welfare schemes** — whether the benefit of a welfare scheme is reaching the people or not.

  - They check **access to education and employment**.

30.3.1 Function 1 — Investigation and Monitoring of Safeguards

The first function is **investigation and monitoring of safeguards**.

- **Monitoring means checking, not inquiring.**
  - It is like a monitor who only checks that the classroom AC is running, the seats are comfortable, the place is clean and the washroom is clean — the business is only that much, nothing more.

NCSC

- NCSC, 2024-25 — evaluated the **reservation policy and SC welfare schemes** in the **Bank of Baroda** and the **Bank of India**.
- NCSC, 2025-26 — a review was conducted at **IIT Delhi** on whether the reservation policy is being followed in teaching and whether the **backward cells** are functioning properly, plus **SBI** and other PSUs.
- NCSC took **suo motu cognizance**, in the investigation part, of the death of an **IPS officer of the Haryana cadre in Chandigarh**.
- NCSC ordered an inquiry into the **Punjab lecturer recruitment, 2026**, for violating reservation for SCs — the recruitment was conducted by the Punjab Government but it did not uphold the rights of the Scheduled Castes and reservation was not followed.
  - This is the active role played by the NCSC.

NCST

- NCST monitors the **Forest Rights Act, 2006** and the **Panchayats (Extension to Scheduled Areas) Act (PESA)**.
- It examines **tribal land alienation** — whether the tribals' rights are being displaced — in the case of national parks, tiger reserves and wildlife sanctuaries.
- It then evaluates atrocities, reservation and development projects in tribal areas.
  - Example: the **Great Nicobar Project**.
- NCST, 2025 — constituted **district-level committees in Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan** to expedite individual and community forest rights under the **FRA, 2006**.
- NCST — the **patta case** (already discussed earlier): it upheld the rights of tribes living inside tiger reserves.

NCW

- NCW reviews and monitors **constitutional and legal safeguards** and recommends **legislative measures**.
- NCW constituted a **five-member committee** to examine the practice of **paro or molki** marriage in the Mewat region.
- NCW conducted an inquiry under the **Prevention of Sexual Harassment Act**, following individual complaints (at TCS, in Nashik [as stated in lecture]).

NCPCR

- NCPCR ran a **child labour campaign in 2006** to rescue child labourers.
- The **NCSC and NCST** play an active role; the **NCPCR** is not very prominent, though the NCPCR and the **NCW** act to uphold the rights of the vulnerable groups that they are protecting.

EXAMPLE

Case study: paro / molki marriage and the NCW.

- **Paro or molki** is a type of marriage practised in the **Mewat** region — the Alwar area of Rajasthan and the Nuh district of Haryana.
- The cause is that the men in the Nuh district, and the men in the Mewat region generally, struggle to find a female to get married to.
- Women are brought for marriage from other States of India through intermediaries — specifically Bengal, specifically Odisha.
- The woman belongs to a highly oppressed class; these females are basically economically deprived.
- The intermediary communicates to the parents: we want your child, we will pay you some amount, and we will give her a **guaranteed future**.
- The female has got no agency — she is taken to a totally separate area of Mewat, married to the males there, and these males may also end up selling that female to another man in the future.
- This is a repercussion of an **extremely low child sex ratio in Haryana**, where the child sex ratio is almost in the **early 800s**; the child sex ratio of the Nuh district is comparatively much poorer.
- The practice was brought into perspective by the **National Commission for Women**.

30.3.2 Function 2 — Inquiry into Specific Complaints

The second function — the most important role of these commissions — is **inquiry into specific complaints** regarding deprivation of rights and standards. The NCSC runs a portal for this: the **E-Grievance Management Portal (E-GMP)**, which allows 24x7 complaint filing and tracking.

DATA & FACTS

Complaint and inquiry loads.

- NCSC **E-GMP**: almost **15,000** complaints in FY 25.
- For comparison, the **NHRC** recorded **77,000** complaints.
- **NCST**: **3,592 inquiries** in FY 25.
- Complaint volumes discussed: roughly **12,000-13,000**, with a variant figure of **12,000-15,000**; about **3,000** for one commission; and about **1,000** a year.

- The better term for these is **complaints**, not inquiries.

30.3.3 Function 3 — Participation and Advice in Socio-Economic Development

The third function is to **participate and advise in social and economic development**.

- This tells you that these are **not merely complaint or inquiry offices**.
- **NCSC** focuses on education, employment and entrepreneurship of Scheduled Castes.
- **NCST** will focus on livelihoods, PESA plus FRA implementation, and tribal development.
- They therefore assess and address **structural disadvantages**.
- Every commission of a vulnerable group — or of other groups — will have a different framework.

COMPARISON

Focus of the two constitutional commissions.

- **NCSC** — education, employment and entrepreneurship of Scheduled Castes.
- **NCST** — livelihoods, PESA plus FRA implementation and tribal development.

30.3.4 Function 4 — Evaluation of Progress

- The fourth function, **evaluation of progress**, was announced for the next session; in this session three functions were covered — investigation and monitoring, inquiry into specific complaints, and participation and advice in socio-economic development.

QUICK REVISION

- These commissions are social justice bodies that monitor discrimination, atrocities and welfare schemes, and check access to education and employment.
- Function 1 — investigation and monitoring of safeguards; monitoring means checking, not inquiring.
- Function 2 — inquiry into specific complaints regarding deprivation of rights and standards: NCSC's E-GMP with almost 15,000 complaints in FY 25 against the NHRC's 77,000, and NCST's 3,592 inquiries in FY 25.
- Function 3 — participate and advise in social and economic development; these are not merely complaint or inquiry offices. NCSC focuses on education, employment and entrepreneurship of SCs; NCST focuses on livelihoods, PESA plus FRA implementation and tribal development.
- The commissions address structural disadvantages, and each commission has its own framework.
- Examples to remember — NCSC: Bank of Baroda, Bank of India, IIT Delhi, SBI and other PSUs, suo motu cognizance of an IPS officer's death in Chandigarh, Punjab lecturer recruitment 2026; NCST: FRA 2006, PESA, Great Nicobar Project, patta case, 2025 district-level committees; NCW: five-member committee on paro/molki, POSH inquiry after individual complaints; NCPCR: 2006 child labour campaign.
- Function 4, evaluation of progress, is yet to be taken.

30.4 Exam Relevance and the Social Justice Linkage

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Where the questions come from.

- Only **one or two** questions have come from the **CCI**, and **one** has come from the **CAG** [as stated in lecture].
- Primarily **80% of the questions** have come from this area — the commissions.

- Bodies such as **TRIFED** are very much marketing things and will **not** be asked; the examiner will primarily ask the **broad functions**.
- If you have known the **structural-functional problems** of your NHRC, that same logic will also apply to the **issues** of these commissions.
- These **five or six heads** need to be known **broadly, with examples**, for the examination.
- The social justice part is more of a **societal part** — when we write it, we comment on the **governance challenges**.
- When a particular scheme has been devised for a welfare group and it is not adhering to the targets, that is again a problem of **formulation, implementation and feedback** — a different aspect from the role of a commission, which is basically the **designing of a scheme**.
- Questions may be about a **specific section**, a **specific scheme**, or the implementation of a particular scheme and why it is not successful.
- There are basically two parts to this: the **development industry** and the **development processes**.
- **Development processes** deal with scheme formulation loopholes, lack of integrated governance and civil society activism — the core governance area, keeping development in mind.
  - The analysis of all schemes for vulnerable groups and other sectors — for example **Gati Shakti** — will be asked from this perspective.
- The other perspective is that of **development players** — NGOs, SHGs and trusts — which will be taken separately next month.

QUICK REVISION

- Primarily 80% of the questions in this area have come from the commissions; only one or two from the CCI and one from the CAG.
- Marketing bodies such as TRIFED will not be asked; the broad functions will be.
- The structural-functional problems of the NHRC supply the same logic for the issues of these commissions.
- Five or six heads must be known broadly, with examples.
- In the social justice part we comment on governance challenges — scheme formulation loopholes, lack of integrated governance and civil society activism.
- Questions may concern a specific section, a specific scheme, or the failure of a scheme's

implementation.

- The two lenses are the development industry and the development processes; development players (NGOs, SHGs, trusts) come separately.

CHAPTER 31

Health — Governance, Universal Health Coverage and Challenges

31.1 Health in the Syllabus and the Underlying Thought

The topic is **health**, and the first thing is to see where it lies in the syllabus.

> KEY CONCEPT
>
> **Where health sits.**
>
> - Health lies in **GS2**, and within GS2 it lies under **social justice**.
> - Whenever social justice is said, one has to change one's thought — understand how the questions will come and how the keywords have to be used.
> - The social justice topics are **poverty, hunger, education, human resources and health**.

- After health comes **education**, and along with education, **skill development**; the third thing is **nutrition**.
- Together they contribute to **human capital formation**, known as **HCF** — that is the keyword.
- Once there is human capital formation, the result is automatically seen as the **demographic dividend**; the question that came this year in the civil services examination was the **18th/19th question of Paper 1 (May)** [as stated in lecture].
- These four topics are together a part of social justice; removing health, education, skill development and nutrition automatically addresses poverty and hunger, so poverty and hunger are not written separately.
- The strand of education, skill development and nutrition focuses on the **demographic dividend**, but the PYQs of health are slightly different in nature.
- Nutrition's role in human capital formation is the same as health's role, but their PYQs are slightly different.

> DATA & FACTS
>
> **One fact to anchor the shift.**
>
> - Civil services in the last **13 years** has not asked health in connection with the demographic dividend — which is why the health questions have to be prepared on their own footing.

QUICK REVISION

- Health lies in **GS2**, under **social justice** — the topics being poverty, hunger, education, human resources and health.
- Health with education, skill development and nutrition together make **human capital formation (HCF)** — the keyword — which automatically gives the demographic dividend.
- Removing health, education, skill and nutrition automatically addresses poverty and hunger, so they are not written separately.
- The education-skill-nutrition strand focuses on the demographic dividend; health's PYQs are slightly different in nature.
- Civil services in the last 13 years has not asked health in connection with the demographic dividend, though nutrition's role in HCF is the same as health's.

31.2 PYQs and the Exam Relevance of Health

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

The strands of health PYQs.

- The first question asked the **role of market forces** — which means the role of the **private sector**; the keywords used in Paper 2 were **private sector, market forces and minimum public investment**.
- **Minimum public investment** — if the state backtracks there is no primary health centre, no government school, no mohalla clinic, no AIIMS, no Safdarjung and no district hospital under the CMO.
- The second strand is the **primary health centre** — have you visited a PHC?
- **Issues in public health** are the issues in **UHC — universal health coverage**, in brackets health for all.
- **Old age care** and **maternal health** were also asked; old age care will be taken with the demographic dividend in Paper 1, and maternal health with women's issues.
- In total about **6-7 questions** have come — it is an easy topic, nothing heavy.

- PYQs are very important — UPSC's questions and its content are limited, so one has to understand exactly what it has asked.
- The points of the **role of market forces are the same as those of privatisation**; the points of privatisation are the same whether the question is on market forces, privatisation or **PPP in health**.
- **PPP in health** — civil services once asked what the next way forward is, whether PPP in health should be promoted; the pros and cons of PPP are the same as the pros and cons of the role of market forces.
- A full answer on these pros and cons was to be written and then given as class notes.
- Every issue discussed for health is **100% applicable to primary health**; the importance of primary health is the same as the importance of health.

- Two questions were asked, plus **measures**; measures will not finish even if one goes through a whole year of current affairs — measures matter for the prelims too and need new anecdotes.
- Arguments have to be seen and written as much as possible; current affairs and newspaper articles will all be incorporated.

EXAMPLE

Examples from the field.

- The **Malda district hospital** fire killed **40 children** in the ICU [as stated in lecture]; such news relates to district hospitals, headed by a **chief medical officer** who reports to the officer (IES).
- During COVID a platform was set up: private hospitals charged money with long queues, while at the **primary health centre** vaccination was **free** with easily available slots (the class's own example).
- A primary health centre near the class's home was visited for vaccination — an example of **preventive health**.
- The government's latest initiative: all **district hospitals in India will provide cancer/trauma care**.

- In cities there is an **urban primary health centre (UPHC)**, earlier called **HWC (Health and Welfare Center)** and now renamed — the new name matters most [as stated in lecture].
- Primary care is the route to **health for all** and **universal health care**.
- Two steps for **AI in health** were taken in February this year — **SATHI (S-A-T-H-I)** and **BODH (B-O-D-H)** [as stated in lecture].

QUICK REVISION

- PYQs are very important; the questions have asked the role of market forces (the private sector), minimum public investment, the primary health centre, issues in public health/UHC, and old age care with maternal health — about 6-7 questions in all, an easy topic.
- The role of market forces = privatisation = PPP in health; the pros and cons are the same, and a full answer was to be written and given as class notes.
- Minimum public investment means that if the state backtracks there is no PHC, no government school, no mohalla clinic, no AIIMS, no Safdarjung and no district hospital under the CMO.
- The Malda district hospital fire killed 40 children in the ICU [as stated]; district hospitals are headed by a chief medical officer and the officer (IES) is reported to.
- During COVID private hospitals charged money with long queues, while the primary health centre gave free vaccination with easily available slots — primary care is the route to health for all and universal health care.
- Urban PHCs were earlier called HWC (Health and Welfare Center) and are now renamed; two AI steps were taken in February — SATHI and BODH; measures matter for the prelims too and need new anecdotes.

31.3 The Structure of the Topic and the Approach to Answers

Structure is very important to decide the dimensions of any topic. When preparing a topic on one's own, see the PYQs first, then prepare the structure and, accordingly, the content of that topic.

1. **Introduce** the topic — a definition of health plus some statistics.
2. **Constitutional basis** — the articles which talk about health, because these articles must be on one's tips (the judgments on women, environment and children will be added next year after the prelims, with a health layer).
3. **Issues, concerns or challenges** of the health sector — health or public health, both are the same — which are the same as primary health issues, or why we do not have universal health coverage.
4. **Consequences and why health is important** — economic, social, political, international and governance consequences; this can be done as homework, as education was already discussed.
5. **Privatisation of health or the increasing role of market forces** — the advantages and losses if the role of market forces is increased.
6. **Steps taken by the Government of India** — the latest steps (to be added when the budget 26-27 comes) plus the traditional schemes; the schemes also help in the prelims.
7. At the end, the **way forward** — write all the issues, or expand the steps, and add the latest newspaper articles.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **The price of private healthcare.**
>
> - Big private hospitals — **Max Healthcare, BLK, Holy Family, Medanta** — charge for a separate bed more than a three-star hotel; at **Ganga Ram** the OPD is **Rs. 1,500 to Rs. 2,000**; the best doctors of the country and the world sit at **AIIMS Safdarjung** [as stated in lecture].
> - **OPD means outpatient department** — in any hospital, if one sees the doctor and comes back it is outpatient; if one is admitted and stays a night it is not OPD (it is inpatient); at AIIMS the charge is about **Rs. 10** with a four-day wait [as stated in lecture].
> - Even officers do not easily get appointments, but the best doctors are there.

- In the **Indian Express** an article on this subject appears about once in six months; a woman officer writes — a retired chief secretary of Delhi who was also the union health secretary, **Shailja Chandra**; she has written **2-3 articles in the last 3-4 months**.
- Her articles: one on how the **Delhi master plan** has certain problems and yet addresses urbanisation, and one on the **privatisation of health**; search Shailja Chandra in the Indian Express and read the article.
- This is **also essay material**; to ensure the effective implementation of policies addressing **WASH**, the identification of beneficiary segments is to be synchronised with the anticipated outcomes.
- The **WASH question** (examine statements in the context of WASH) is related to development processes in GS2 and to how schemes are poorly designed; it is not a promised part of the current-affairs syllabus — refer to it on one's own [as stated in lecture].

QUICK REVISION

- Structure is very important to decide the dimensions of a topic; see the PYQs, then build the structure and the content.
- The structure: introduce (definition plus stats); constitutional basis (articles on the tips); the issues/concerns/challenges (health = public health = primary health); the consequences and why health is important; privatisation/market forces; steps taken by the Government of India; and the way forward.
- The way forward means writing all the issues or expanding the steps, and adding the latest newspaper articles.
- Private hospitals (Max, BLK, Holy Family, Medanta) charge more than a three-star hotel; Ganga Ram's OPD is Rs. 1,500-2,000; OPD means outpatient department and at AIIMS the charge is about Rs. 10 with a four-day wait [as stated].
- Shailja Chandra, a retired chief secretary of Delhi and former union health secretary, writes in the Indian Express — one article on the Delhi master plan and urbanisation, one on the privatisation of health.
- This material is also for the essay: to ensure effective implementation of policies addressing WASH, beneficiary-segment identification is to be synchronised with the anticipated outcomes.
- The WASH question relates to development processes in GS2 and to poorly designed schemes; it is not a promised part of the current-affairs syllabus — refer to it on one's own.

31.4 Defining Health — A State of Complete Well-Being

KEY CONCEPT

The WHO definition.

- As per the **WHO**, health is a **state of complete physical, mental and social well-being**, and **not merely the absence of disease or infirmity**.
- Not having a disease does not mean one is healthy — it is a **state of being** that includes the physical, the mental and the social.

- The definition has to be expanded: **health in my opinion is a broader concept** which also includes **emotional well-being, intellectual well-being, spiritual well-being, occupational or financial well-being and environmental well-being**.
- Therefore, whenever a definition of health is written, health is a state of being which includes physical, mental, social, emotional, environmental, intellectual and occupational well-being.

EXAMPLE

Why environmental well-being is part of health.

- **Delhi pollution** — a person who is physically fit, goes to the gym and is mentally and financially stable, but survives in an environment with a very high air quality index, lacks environmental well-being; this affects his health and other dimensions: it causes disease, affects his social dimension (he cannot meet friends or go to the park) and restricts him to the

windows.

- **Climate-change-induced disasters** — the Himalayan **flash floods**; in **Shimla** in the mountains people are happy, physically and mentally fit, usually not poor and with a high level of satisfaction, but because climate change is increasing disasters their environmental well-being is compromised, which affects their health.

QUICK REVISION

- As per the WHO, health is a state of complete physical, mental and social well-being, and not merely the absence of disease or infirmity.
- Not having a disease does not mean one is healthy; health is a state of being that includes the physical, the mental and the social.
- Health is a broader concept — it also includes emotional, intellectual, spiritual, occupational/financial and environmental well-being.
- Environmental well-being explained — Delhi's very high air quality index harms a fit person's health and social life; the Himalayan flash floods in Shimla compromise environmental well-being through climate-change-induced disasters.
- The definition to write: health is a state of being which includes physical, mental, social, emotional, environmental, intellectual and occupational well-being.

31.5 Constitutional Dimensions of Health

Primarily there are **fundamental rights**, mainly **Article 21**, because the **right to health is a part of the right to life**, and the right to a clean environment is also a part of the right to life. Then come the **DPSPs**; the main DPSP on health is **Article 47**.

Article 21	Right to health and the right to a clean environment are parts of the right to life.
Article 47	Duty of the state to raise the level of nutrition and the standard of living and to improve public health; prohibition of intoxicating drugs and drinks injurious to health.
Article 48A	Seeks to protect and improve the environment and to safeguard forests and wildlife — environmental well-being.
Article 46	Interests of the scheduled castes, scheduled tribes and other weaker sections against social injustice and all forms of exploitation — manual scavenging and health equity.
Article 45	Early childhood care and education for children of 0 to 6 years — child nutrition plus health and the health of the infant.
Article 43	Living wage and conditions of work which ensure a decent standard of living — occupational health and the social determinants of health.
Article 42	Just and humane conditions of work — occupational and physical health (coal miners, manual scavengers).
Article 41	Public assistance (state assistance) in the case of old age, sickness and disablement — geriatric, occupational and general physical health.
Article 39(f)	Facilities for children to develop in a healthy manner and protection against moral and material abandonment.
Article 39(e)	Health and strength of workers, men and women, and the tender age of children is not abused.
Article 51A(g)	Fundamental duty of citizens to protect and improve the environment — forests, lakes and rivers.

- On **Article 42 and 45 and maternal health**: **maternal health is a part of RCH / RMCH —**

reproductive and maternal child health; the health of the child and the health of the mother both have to be seen.

- **Article 42 and manual scavenging** — the safai karamchari sweeps in the big market amid heavy dust and usually never wears a mask, straightaway inhaling particulate matter; an **N95 mask** costs **Rs. 100-200-500** [as stated in lecture].
- **Article 39(f)** — if a child is abandoned, with no material or economic support (no fees, no clothes, no food, no tuition), it affects the child's well-being; this was asked in **prelims 2012** — which of the following articles have a bearing on health.
- **Article 39(e)** — health and strength of workers, men and women; the constitution speaks not only of health but also of strength, with protein diet and the importance of protein — "an egg a day keeps the doctors away" [as stated in lecture; the aside on Ambedkar ji is garbled].

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Fundamental duties and Article 51A(g).

- **Article 51A(g)** — the fundamental duty of citizens to **protect and improve the environment**; protection of the environment is also in the DPSP, but the protection of the environment is in the fundamental duties.
- This environment includes three things — **forests, lakes and rivers** — that is, the natural environment.
- There are **11 fundamental duties**, amended **once**, brought by **Indira Gandhi**; the committee chairman was **Swaran Singh**, who said they should be binding, but the constitutional amendment did not make them binding.

QUICK REVISION

- Primarily the fundamental rights — Article 21, because the right to health and the right to a clean environment are parts of the right to life.
- DPSPs — Article 47 (nutrition, standard of living, public health, prohibition of intoxicating drugs and drinks), Article 48A (environment, forests, wildlife), Article 46 (SC/ST and weaker sections against exploitation — manual scavenging, health equity), Article 45 (early childhood care, 0-6 years).
- Article 43 (living wage, conditions of work — occupational health and social determinants) and Article 42 (just and humane conditions of work — coal miners, manual scavengers; N95 masks Rs. 100-200-500).
- Article 41 (old age, sickness, disablement) and Article 39(f) (children develop in a healthy manner, protection against moral and material abandonment — prelims 2012).
- Article 39(e) — health and strength of workers, men and women, and the tender age of children is not abused; protein diet, an egg a day keeps the doctors away.
- Maternal health is a part of RCH/RMCH — reproductive and maternal child health.
- Article 51A(g) — fundamental duty to protect and improve the environment (forests, lakes and rivers); there are 11 fundamental duties, amended once, brought by Indira Gandhi, the committee chairman being Swaran Singh, and they were not made binding.

31.6 Administrative Perspective — Health in the Three Lists and the Schedules

Now the **administrative perspective**: the **union list**, the **state list** and the **concurrent list** are seen together, because at the end of the day what is wanted is an **integrated, decentralised, whole-of-government and whole-of-society** approach, with coordination at all tiers.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **WHO and the international layer.**
>
> - **WHO** and the **World Health Assembly** meeting happen; the WHO definition has already been written.
> - The WHO framework is not so relevant in the health discussion unless **IR** asks the role of WHO (asked once) and because of current affairs.
> - The **global tobacco treaty** was the first global treaty of the WHO, and the **global pandemic treaty** is the second; the IR dimensions are not very necessary — write that **international cooperation is a must to improve health**.

Union List	Port quarantine; interstate quarantine; international health regulations; regulation of labour and safety in mines and oil fields; regulation of opium.
State List	Intoxicating liquor (excise duty on liquor is levied by the state); agriculture including plant disease; animal disease and veterinary health; water supply; public health and sanitation.
Concurrent List	Adulteration; population control and family planning; education including medical education; vital statistics; social security; labour welfare.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **Zoonotic disease and the One Health approach.**
>
> - **Why the regulation of slaughterhouses matters**: **zoonotic** diseases; the framework is **One Health** — health for all means the health of poultry and animals too, not only of you and me.
> - **Kerala**: **KFD (Kyasanur forest disease)** and the **Nipah virus**; the tropical climate, heavy rain and **deforestation** cause a strong spread of diseases from the forest towards humans; where there is no deforestation there is no transfer of zoonotic diseases to humans.

- **Health in the three lists** — the **7th schedule**, and the **11th and 12th schedules**; the three main lists are **List 1 (union), List 2 (state) and List 3 (concurrent)**.

- Health is a **never-ending governance challenge**; integrating the lists for universal health requires coordination not in three but in **five** — because the 11th and 12th schedules are also there.
- The **11th and 12th schedules** contain the specifics of the state list which has to be devolved to the **third tier**; they have **29 and 18 subjects**; a separate list for local self-government was made.
- If a **4th list** is added it becomes binding on the state to implement those areas, though simultaneous constitutional amendments would be required, because the 11th and 12th schedules say (as in Part 9) that state governments must take the lead.
  - A statement made during this discussion was later retracted by the speaker [as stated in lecture]; the substantive content is kept.
- The basic facts must be remembered — for instance whether **maternal health** is in the concurrent or the union list; one has to love the exam and look at PYQs every now and then.
- **Vital statistics** means the **registration of birth and death**; **Bihar** has a very poor registration mechanism of birth and death; it is needed for the census, the total fertility rate and the birth and death rates; it came into the light after the **COVID second wave**, when registered deaths were far fewer than actual deaths.
- **Social security** — the best example is the **4 labour codes**.
- The **11th and 12th schedules** include **women and child development; family welfare; health and sanitation (hospitals, primary health centres, dispensaries); drinking water; social welfare; and PDS**.
- This is the **envisioned framework of decentralisation**; primary health centres are the base or foundation of universal healthcare and must be outsourced completely to the third tier.
- In **Delhi** the urban areas include water supply (the **Delhi Jalboard**, headed by an IAS officer deputed to the Delhi government, and the **NDMC** and **MCD**), public health and sanitation, municipal solid waste management, Sanjeevan, Nehru Park, urban forestry, occupational health, vital statistics, public convenience (public toilets, Sulabh) and the regulation of slaughterhouses.
- **Centrally sponsored schemes — Jan Aushadhi Yojana, Amrit pharmacy, Rs. 5 lakh insurance, PM-Kisan giving Rs. 6,000**; usually **60% of the money comes from the centre** and the state spends the rest; eventually the approach has to be **cooperative and competitive federalism**.
- **Delhi slums — DUSIB**, the land of the **Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs** and of the **Ministry of Railways**, and the slum redevelopment board of the Delhi government; the **Supreme Court** decision on the slums along the railway line near the **NDLS** station; the **Vasant Vihar** slum cordoned off for a recent summit [as stated in lecture] — slum redevelopment is an **institutional maze**.
- The **slum entry is in the 12th schedule**; whether it has been devolved to the third tier is yet to be seen.
- In one's own cities the responsibility is of the **state government**; if devolved, it goes to the development authority (**JDA, JAPORKE**) or the **municipal corporation**; states usually do not give slum redevelopment to the municipal corporation — the powers rest with the state

government.

- **One diagram per question, every question**, has to be drawn to show coordination (union, state, RLB, ULB); it need not be the main diagram.

QUICK REVISION

- The administrative perspective — union, state and concurrent lists — aims at an integrated, decentralised, whole-of-government and whole-of-society approach; health is a never-ending governance challenge.
- Health is taken up under the 7th schedule and the 11th and 12th schedules (29 and 18 subjects); a 4th list would make devolution binding but would need simultaneous constitutional amendments.
- Union List — port quarantine, interstate quarantine, international health regulations, labour and safety in mines and oil fields, opium; State List — intoxicating liquor (state excise), agriculture/plant disease, animal disease/veterinary health, water supply, public health and sanitation; Concurrent List — adulteration, population control and family planning, education including medical education, vital statistics, social security (4 labour codes), labour welfare.
- Vital statistics means registration of birth and death; Bihar's mechanism is very poor; it came into the light after the COVID second wave; the 11th and 12th schedules include women and child development, family welfare, health and sanitation, drinking water, social welfare and PDS.
- Delhi's urban maze (Delhi Jalboard, NDMC, MCD, municipal solid waste management, Sanjeevan, slaughterhouses, One Health) and the slum institutional maze (DUSIB, Housing and Urban Affairs, Railways, NDLS, Vasant Vihar) show how hard integrated governance is.
- Centrally sponsored schemes (Jan Aushadhi, Amrit pharmacy, Rs. 5 lakh insurance, PM-Kisan Rs. 6,000; 60% from the centre) reflect cooperative and competitive federalism; one diagram per question is a must.
- Public health centres as the base of universal healthcare must be devolved to the third tier; and the Kerala zoonotic-disease example (KFD, Nipah; deforestation; One Health) explains why slaughterhouses are regulated.

31.7 Health for All and Universal Health Coverage

KEY CONCEPT

NHP 2017 — the goal of health governance.

- **NHP 2017 = National Health Policy 2017**; it prescribes the goal as the **highest possible level of health and well-being for all**, through **preventive and promotive care** and **universal access** to **good quality healthcare services, without any financial hardship**.
- Whenever writing on universal health or on health as a topic, write this definition — India's goal for health for all.
- **Preventive** means steps like vaccination; **promotive** health means generating awareness — washing hands before eating, flushing the toilet after use, not using the western commode as

a urinal [as stated in lecture].

- **UHC — universal health coverage** means the highest quality of health services for all, including preventive and promotive, without any financial hardship, **guaranteeing universal access**.
- Health for all is broader than any specific treatment or care — it means the **availability of all options**, their accessibility and affordability; it should be a state of being.
- The components to draw in the **health-for-all diagram**: primary health, old age health, child health, mental health, environmental health, sanitation, vaccination and preventive health, MCH, geriatric care, early childhood care, reproductive health, maternal health, health equity, animal health, WASH (the keyword), access and portability, affordability, equity, quality, promotive health and universal access.
- **Access is the keyword** — the keywords have to be used.

EXAMPLE

Availability, accessibility, affordability — and what comes after.

- **Availability** — first there should be doctors, hospitals and facilities; **accessibility** — there should be a road; the best doctors are at **Ganga Ram**, but water logging or a disaster can block access; **affordability** — money in the pocket is not enough if health is unaffordable.
- **Information asymmetry** is the keyword for private hospitals: doctors order tests for a **commission from the lab**; a small illness leads to a thousand tests; a good doctor diagnoses by **feeling the pulse (nabs)**, though now radiologists use AI-assisted CT, MRI and X-ray.
- The **equity dimension** is very important: the needs of **SCs, STs and transgenders** are different; for a transgender, sex reassignment is a matter of **identity and the right to life**, not humour; every region has different needs — more hospitals for the **tribals of Central India** and for sectors with occupational diseases — and with this comes **financial protection**, meaning insurance.
- In the end the most important is **continuity of care**, the keyword; and the **primary health centre** provides affordability, equity, access, quality and financial support — it is the **fulcrum of health** in the country.
- **Scandinavian countries** — fixed wages and social security deductions; one can go to any hospital for any health-related concern, including preventive.

QUICK REVISION

- NHP 2017 = National Health Policy 2017 — the goal is the highest possible level of health and well-being for all, through preventive and promotive care and universal access to good quality healthcare, without any financial hardship.
- Write this definition for India's goal for health for all in any question on health or universal health coverage.
- Preventive = vaccination; promotive = generating awareness (washing hands, flushing the toilet, not using the western commode as a urinal).

- UHC = highest quality of health services for all, including preventive and promotive, without financial hardship, guaranteeing universal access; health for all means the availability of all options.
- The health-for-all diagram components; access is the keyword; availability-accessibility-affordability plus quality, equity, continuity of care and financial protection (insurance).
- Information asymmetry in private hospitals, the equity dimension (SC/ST/transgenders, the tribals of Central India), continuity of care, the PHC as the fulcrum, and the Scandinavian example — all together make the answer.

31.8 India's Three-Tier Health Delivery Framework

Health framework — an individual falls ill and goes to a health centre or health facility; the public health structure is a **three-tier structure**.

Primary (first degree)	Sub-centres; primary health centres (PHCs)	The first layer; the sub-centre is actually the first layer.
Secondary	District hospitals; community health centres; taluka (block-level) hospitals	The district hospital is the main government hospital of secondary care in each district.
Tertiary	Apex hospitals; medical colleges	Specialised care.

- Every district has a government **district hospital** — the main government hospital of secondary care; the news of **60, 70, 400, 500 deaths** mostly concerns district hospitals.
- **Tertiary care means specialised care**, in apex hospitals and medical colleges — **AIIMS, Ram Manohar Lohia, Sucheta Kriplani**; in North India **PGI**; **JIPMER** is in Puducherry; **AFMC** is in Pune; **King George Medical College** in Lucknow; **PGI Rohtak, AIIMS Jodhpur, AIIMS Jammu and PGI Chandigarh**.
- In medical colleges, **MBBS doctors do internships** and are **junior residents (JR)** with a professor; the professor teaches and allows **live experiments**.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

From Health and Wellness Centres to Ayushman Arogya Mandir.

- **HWC — Health and Wellness Center** was introduced in the budget of **FY 2019** (the 2018 budget speech) — the first budget speech of Madam Sita Raman [Nirmala Sitharaman] or of Mr. Piyush Goyal, the interim finance minister [as stated in lecture].
- The HWC was the **primary fulcrum**; later the Health and Wellness Center was converted to the **Ayushman Arogya Mandir (AAM)**.
- The **AAM** includes **sub-centres, primary health centres and community health centres** —

that is, **upgraded health facilities for primary healthcare**.

- **About 1.8 lakh Ayushman Arogya Mandirs** — about **1.3 lakh sub-health centres, 24,000 PHCs, 5,500 UPHCs, 12.2 thousand AYUSH facilities, 10,000 urban health and wellness centres and 12,000 AYUSH facilities** [as stated in lecture].

Sub-centres	1.67 lakh
Primary health centres (PHCs)	26.6 thousand (about 27,000; another 5,000 urban PHCs)
Community health centres (CHCs)	About 6,000 (about 240 urban CHCs)
District hospitals	751
Ayushman Arogya Mandir (upgraded centres)	About 1.8 lakh; the recent number is about 1.87 lakh, till 13 September 2026

- Put the **Ayushman Arogya Mandir diagram and the health-for-all diagram** in the **primary health centre question**.
- **AYUSH** — ever since the government came to power (2014/2015), AYUSH has received a significant hike; the first **WHO Center for Traditional Medicine** is in **Jamnagar**, and a second is being opened in **Srinagar**.
- AYUSH as a topic has **little exam relevance**, except when giving the **availability of health options along with allopathic**.

QUICK REVISION

- The public health structure is a three-tier structure — primary (sub-centres, PHCs), secondary (district hospitals, community health centres, taluka hospitals) and tertiary (apex hospitals, medical colleges).
- Apex institutions: AIIMS, Ram Manohar Lohia, Sucheta Kriplani, PGI (North India), JIPMER Puducherry, AFMC Pune, King George Medical College Lucknow, PGI Rohtak, AIIMS Jodhpur, AIIMS Jammu, PGI Chandigarh.
- In medical colleges MBBS doctors do internships as junior residents with a professor; HWC (Health and Wellness Center) came in the FY 2019 budget (2018 speech) and is now the Ayushman Arogya Mandir (AAM).
- AAM includes sub-centres, PHCs and CHCs; about 1.8 lakh AAMs — about 1.3 lakh sub-health centres, 24,000 PHCs, 5,500 UPHCs, 12.2 thousand AYUSH and 10,000 urban HWCs.
- Numbers — sub-centres 1.67 lakh, PHCs 26.6 thousand (27,000 with 5,000 urban), CHCs about 6,000, district hospitals 751, urban CHCs about 240; the recent number is about 1.87 lakh AAM, till 13 September 2026.
- Put the AAM diagram and the health-for-all diagram in the primary health centre question.

- AYUSH has received a significant hike; the first WHO Center for Traditional Medicine is in Jamnagar and a second is coming in Srinagar; AYUSH has little exam relevance except for the availability of options along with allopathic.

31.9 Issues in Health — Building the Framework

KEY CONCEPT

One set of issues, many labels.

- **Issues in health** are the same as **issues in public health**, **issues in primary health** and the **challenges or concerns** — the answer is one and the same.
- The **issues framework** talks about **health insurance, availability, alternative medicine, accessibility, affordability and continuity of care**; **Ayurveda** treatment (a 5-day herbal and organic course) is very expensive; then **equity** and **quality** — and quality is the biggest issue.
- The framework heads: **focus of healthcare; infrastructure; number of doctors/human resources; governance; equity (access); affordability (insurance); technology; and financing**.

The diagram: an individual falls ill and goes to a health centre — first of all the **infrastructure** (a hospital) must be available; if there is a hospital there are **doctors**; if there are doctors there are **nurses and allied care**; if there is a hospital there is **affordability** and **insurance**; then comes **technology**; then **governance** and the **government's role**; and there is a broad focus on the **role of the private sector** — from the **demand of health to the supply of health**.

- This diagram is the **key to unravelling all the points** — keep a look at it; while writing, be aware and stay in the structure.
- The first concern is the **focus of healthcare**.

QUICK REVISION

- Issues in health = issues in public health = issues in primary health = challenges/concerns — the answer is one and the same.
- The issues framework talks about health insurance, availability, alternative medicine, accessibility, affordability, continuity of care, equity and quality (the biggest issue).
- The framework heads — focus of healthcare, infrastructure, human resources, governance, equity, affordability/insurance, technology and financing.
- The diagram — an individual falls ill and goes to a health centre; from the demand of health to the supply of health (infrastructure to doctors to nurses and allied care to affordability and insurance to technology to governance to the private sector); it is the key to unravelling all the points.

31.10 Focus of Healthcare — Curative Rather Than Preventive

CRITICAL POINT

The curative bias in the health system.

- The government's broad vision is towards **curative rather than preventive or promotive** — the approach is the **treatment of a disease rather than overall well-being**.
- This is seen **in the light of the emergence of non-communicable diseases**, like **obesity**.

- **NFHS Round 6** points to a rise in **obesity** among women and men, and also in **blood glucose**; the obesity number was **more than 30% of women** in India in the age bracket of **15 to 49**.
- This diagram was given in the **malnutrition discussion**; it has to be on one's tips — refer to the malnutrition discussion and update the notes; it will not be repeated.

QUICK REVISION

- The government's broad vision is curative rather than preventive or promotive — the treatment of a disease rather than overall well-being.
- This is seen in the light of the emergence of non-communicable diseases like obesity.
- NFHS Round 6 shows a rise in obesity among women and men and in blood glucose; more than 30% of women aged 15-49 were obese.
- Refer to the malnutrition discussion for the diagram and update the notes — it will not be repeated.

31.11 Poor Health Financing and High Out-of-Pocket Expenditure

DATA & FACTS

The numbers on health financing.

- **General government health expenditure** as a percentage of GDP is about **2.5% of GDP** (a figure of about **4% of GDP** was cited as per the **National Health Account 2022-23**) [as stated in lecture].
- The **WHO recommendation** is **5 to 6% of GDP**.
- If the expenditure is less, the benefits are also less.
- The most authentic health-expenditure data is **1.5%** (0.5% and 0.5%); writing **1.5 to 2%** also poses no problem — this is a **very important stat, an essay stat**.

- The second issue is **financing — poor health expenditure**.
- The third point — because the government itself does not spend, it has led to **high OOPE, out-of-pocket expenditure**.
- **OOPE explained** — the charges one pays at a hospital; first, **OPD charges**, which are not covered by any insurance policy.
- Health insurance policies say one must be hospitalised for a day or two; to claim the money people happily get admitted for two days so the full tests are done and the money is refunded.

- The costs: consultation in a metro like Delhi is at least **Rs. 1,000**, and **Rs. 2,000 the first time** (a discount from the next visit); medicines **Rs. 2,000-4,000**; tests **Rs. 5,000-10,000-20,000**.
- In a **government hospital treatment is free** — consultation charges are **zero**; the **free medicine scheme** started from the state of **Rajasthan**, 10-13 years ago [as stated in lecture].
- Doctors tell patients to buy a particular medicine from a particular shop and to mention the doctor's name (the commission); **stents** are also given free by the government.

EXAMPLE

The chain from illness to transient poverty.

- High out-of-pocket expenditure is the **most important problem in India**, because high OOPE leads to **transient poverty**.
- The household is just above the **poverty line** — that is, **MAPL (marginally above poverty line)**; **illness** strikes (for example the **occupational health** of **delivery workers**, or a **heat wave**), and high OOPE pushes it into **transient poverty**.
- The fuller chain: illness leads to **debt and informal borrowing**, which leads to **delayed treatment**, which hampers **productivity** and leads to **absenteeism** (frequent leave).
- In the examination hall one has to **innovate**; one diagram per question, and every diagram has to have a **box** showing high OOPE leading to transient poverty.

- **OOPE has declined** from **2013-14**, when it was almost **60%**, to **39%** now (2022-23) — a 40% difference; versus **8% in South Africa** [as stated in lecture].
- The **Parliamentary Standing Committee on Health**, in its latest report tabled in **August 2026** (referred to as a '170'/'PIB 176' report [as stated in lecture]), says **expensive diagnostic tests, medicines and specialised treatment** lead to high out-of-pocket expenditure.
- The point to pay attention to is that **out-of-pocket expenditure has to be reduced** — a very important point [the recording is garbled here].

QUICK REVISION

- Financing is the second issue — poor health expenditure; less expenditure means fewer benefits.
- General government health expenditure is about 2.5% of GDP (about 4% was cited from the National Health Account 2022-23); the WHO recommends 5-6%; the most authentic stat is 1.5% — an essay stat.
- Because the government does not spend, there is high OOPE (out-of-pocket expenditure), the most important problem in India.
- OOPE — OPD charges not covered by insurance; the costs of consultation (Rs. 1,000-2,000), medicines (Rs. 2,000-4,000) and tests (Rs. 5,000-20,000); free treatment in government hospitals and the free medicine scheme started from Rajasthan.
- High OOPE leads to transient poverty: the MAPL household, illness, debt and informal borrowing, delayed treatment, hampered productivity and absenteeism.
- OOPE declined from almost 60% in 2013-14 to 39% (2022-23), against 8% in South Africa;

the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Health report (tabled August 2026) says expensive tests, medicines and specialised treatment cause high OOPE.

- The point to pay attention to is that OOPE has to be reduced.

31.12 The Missing Middle in Health Insurance

KEY CONCEPT

Health insurance — a three-part pyramid.

- **At the top** are those who have opted for **private insurance** or **government-sponsored insurance** — **ESIC (Employee State Insurance Corporation)** and **CGHS-type** arrangements — that is, the **organised workforce** with good salaries.
- **At the bottom** are the **poor or vulnerable** — government coverage is very good: **state schemes** (run to win elections, after the success of cash transfers for women) and **Ayushman Bharat PMJAY — Rs. 5 lakh** per household; and for all people above **70-80 years** insurance is given (a step taken a year and a half back) [as stated in lecture].
- **In the middle is the missing middle** — the **gig workers, MSMEs, small shopkeepers** and **private employees working in informal organisations**.
- For example, content-development workers earning **Rs. 30-40K or 50K a month** have no PF deduction and the employer pays no insurance benefit [as stated in lecture].

- The grave problem is the **missing middle in health insurance** — the **middle class**.
- The **insurance premium is based on age** — entering insurance at a lesser age means a much lower premium; private insurers (a name heard as **SDFC/Bajaj Allianz/ICICI**) charge based on the number of remaining years [as stated in lecture].

DATA & FACTS

The NITI Aayog missing-middle numbers.

- As per **NITI Aayog's missing middle report 2021**, this chunk is **at least 30% of India's population — almost 40 crore people — without any health insurance**, because they do not fall in the criteria for **PMJAY** or for the schemes meant for the **downtrodden** [as stated in lecture].
- India's population is about **150 crore**; removing children and the elderly (the 19-60 group) leaves about **110-120 crore**; of that, **40 crore** do not have insurance [as stated in lecture].

- If a disaster strikes, the **whole household's financial security is down the drain**; hence the government should provide insurance and **innovative financial products** so that the common person can take insurance on his own.
- For health for all, **financial protection must first be given with the help of the insurance sector**.

QUICK REVISION

- The grave problem is the missing middle in health insurance — the middle class.
- The premium is based on age; entering at a lesser age means a much lower premium.
- The pyramid: at the top, private or government-sponsored insurance (ESIC, CGHS) for the organised workforce; at the bottom, the poor/vulnerable with state schemes and Ayushman Bharat PMJAY (Rs. 5 lakh; above 70-80 years).
- The missing middle — gig workers, MSMEs, small shopkeepers and private employees in informal organisations (for example content-development workers with no PF or insurance).
- As per NITI Aayog's missing middle report 2021, at least 30% of India's population — almost 40 crore people — have no health insurance; India's population is about 150 crore, leaving about 110-120 crore in the 19-60 group.
- A disaster can wipe out a household's financial security; the government should give insurance through innovative financial products — financial protection with the insurance sector comes first for health for all.

31.13 Limited Human Resources and Infrastructure

Next come the **resources — human resources and infrastructure**; the prominent problem is **limited human resources**.

- **Human resources** include **doctors, specialists, nurses, administration and auxiliary nurse midwives (ANMs)** — ANMs are a part of the women and child development framework; **beds come under infrastructure**, not human resources.
- The keyword is **allied healthcare workers — compounders, optometrists and the operators of radio/MRI machines**; an **ophthalmologist** is an eye doctor, a **pharmacist** gives medicines, and an **optometrist** (a diploma holder) is the "doctor" in small towns and conducts the eye tests before the doctor sees you.
- Allied healthcare matters because India is focusing more and more on **doctors**; **medical colleges have more than doubled in the last 10 years** (economic survey data), but allied healthcare lags behind.
- In the **2026-27 budget** the government spoke of training **1.5 lakh allied healthcare workers**, including **OT (operation theatre) technicians**; all the preparation before the doctor is done by the allied workers, and proper checks have to be maintained.
- **Out-migration of the workforce** takes place because of better opportunities and work conditions; many doctors have gone abroad; **Indian doctors in the US** earn millions of dollars and set up hospitals — it is a very respected profession there.

India	12-13	17
China and Brazil	17	40
High-income nations (US, Australia)	40	120 (40 × 3)

This table has to be **remembered** — it shows very clearly the **severe shortage of the human resources** in India; one arrow from this table gives the examiner several examples at once.

QUICK REVISION

- Prominent among the resource problems is limited human resources — doctors, specialists, nurses, administration and ANMs; beds come under infrastructure.
- The keyword is allied healthcare workers — compounders, optometrists and radio/MRI operators; an ophthalmologist is an eye doctor, a pharmacist gives medicines.
- Allied healthcare matters because India focuses on doctors; medical colleges have more than doubled in 10 years (economic survey), but allied healthcare lags; the 2026-27 budget spoke of training 1.5 lakh allied healthcare workers, including OT technicians.
- Workforce per 10,000 — India 12-13 doctors and 17 nurses/midwives; China and Brazil 17 and 40; high-income nations (US, Australia) 40 and 120.
- This table must be remembered — it shows the severe shortage of human resources.
- Out-migration of the workforce takes place because of better opportunities and work conditions; Indian doctors in the US earn millions and set up hospitals.

31.14 Equity Concerns

CRITICAL POINT

The equity divide.

- The equity concerns are the **urban versus rural divide**, the **backward versus forward state divide** and the **intra-state divide**.
- Equity also includes **poor versus rich, deprived versus non-deprived, high caste versus low, high income versus low, forward versus backward regions, rural versus urban and the digital divide**.

- **Urban versus rural** — rural India has about **70% of India's population** as per the **2011 census**, but only **35-40% of healthcare infrastructure** is located in rural areas; there is also a **shortage of doctors, nurses and allied health professionals**, and **electricity and limited digital connectivity** limit health access.
- **Forward versus backward** — the **north-eastern states**, the **Gangetic heartland (UP and Bihar)** and the **hilly states (Uttarakhand, HP, J&K)** are comparatively lagging, while the

south and west are comparatively forward.

- **Intra-state divide — Haryana** (Gurugram, Rohtak); **UP** (Lucknow, Noida, Banaras/Aditya hospital, Gorakhpur, Prayagraj, Agra — the region's footfall is in Agra); **Bihar** (Patna); **Karnataka** (Bangalore, Mysore); **Tamil Nadu**; erstwhile **Andhra** had Hyderabad, now Vizag/coastal Andhra (Amaravati); the **north-east** (Guwahati); **MP** (Indore, Bhopal); **Maharashtra** (Mumbai).
- Every region has different needs — more hospitals for the **tribals of Central India**, and specific attention where **occupational diseases** exist, along with **financial protection (insurance)**.
- **Substantiate with a state example and some other state example as much as possible** in the examination.

QUICK REVISION

- Equity concerns are the urban versus rural divide, the backward versus forward state divide and the intra-state divide.
- Equity also includes poor versus rich, deprived versus non-deprived, high caste versus low, high income versus low, forward versus backward regions, rural versus urban and the digital divide.
- Urban versus rural — rural India has about 70% of the population (2011 census) but only 35-40% of healthcare infrastructure, with shortages of doctors, nurses and allied professionals and limited electricity and digital connectivity.
- Forward versus backward — the north-east, the Gangetic heartland (UP and Bihar) and the hilly states lag, while the south and west are forward; intra-state, Haryana (Gurugram, Rohtak), UP (Lucknow, Noida, Banaras, Gorakhpur, Prayagraj, Agra), Bihar (Patna), Karnataka (Bangalore, Mysore), Tamil Nadu, Andhra (Vizag, Amaravati), the north-east (Guwahati), MP (Indore, Bhopal) and Maharashtra (Mumbai).
- Every region has different needs — more hospitals for Central India's tribals and for sectors with occupational diseases, plus financial protection; substantiate with state examples in the examination.

CHAPTER 32

Health — Part 2

32.1 Infrastructure Deficit in Health

The discussion continues with the issues in the health sector. After human resources, the next issue to be written down is infrastructure.

- **Infrastructure** in health means the physical delivery network of the health system, and what India has of it is limited:
  - limited primary health centres
  - district hospitals, along with tertiary care centres
  - medical colleges

The main indicator of the state of infrastructure is the bed-to-population ratio.

> **DATA & FACTS**
>
> **Bed-to-population ratio.**
>
> - Overall bed-to-population ratio: **1.5 beds per 1,000 population**.
> - Target under the **National Health Policy (NHP) 2017**: **2 beds per 1,000 population**.
> - Beds in the private sector: approximately **0.6 per 1,000 population** [as stated in lecture].

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Infrastructure = limited primary health centres, district hospitals, tertiary care centres and medical colleges.
> - The main infrastructure indicator is the bed-to-population ratio.
> - Present bed-to-population ratio: 1.5 beds per 1,000 population.
> - NHP 2017 target: 2 beds per 1,000 population.
> - Private-sector share cited: about 0.6 beds per 1,000 population.

32.2 Double Burden of Disease

Before moving on to governance and technology, the next issue to be written down is the double burden of disease.

KEY CONCEPT

Double burden of disease.

- A **unique health challenge** in which India has to address two opposite burdens at the same time.
- First burden: **malnutrition**.
- Second burden: the rise in **over-nutrition and non-communicable diseases (NCDs)**.

- **State of malnutrition — NFHS Round 6**: the wasting child population has remained the **same** as in NFHS Round 5, that is, there has been no improvement.
- **Rise of over-nutrition / NCDs** — the concerns to record are:
  - hypertension
  - cancer
  - metabolic disorders
  - high blood sugar
- Alternative framing that can also be written: **infectious diseases along with a rise in non-communicable diseases**.

EXAMPLE

Why the burden is called unique in India.

- Communicable diseases are usually not seen in Western countries; in India both communicable and non-communicable diseases are rising together.
- The infectious threat is live: if Ebola is present in the DRC it can spread across Africa and can come to India, even while NCDs are rising.

QUICK REVISION

- Double burden of disease = a unique health challenge of handling malnutrition and over-nutrition/NCDs together.
- NFHS Round 6 shows wasting among children unchanged from NFHS Round 5.
- NCD concerns: hypertension, cancer, metabolic disorders, high blood sugar.
- Alternative framing: infectious diseases alongside the rise in NCDs.
- Communicable diseases are rare in the West; India carries both burdens at once — Ebola in the DRC can reach India.

32.3 Climate Change-Related Health Concerns

The next concern after the double burden is climate change, whose health effects run along three routes.

32.3.1 Infrastructural Concern

- Climate change has led to disasters and extreme events such as floods, heat waves and cold waves.

- These events have affected cooling needs, electricity needs, and the durability of healthcare infrastructure.
- Hospitals are themselves infrastructure — and a more dangerous kind of infrastructure, because patients live inside them, which makes safety and security a concern as well.

EXAMPLE

Water logging in hospitals.

- In reported visuals from hospitals during floods, doctors and patients were wading through water while light equipment floated towards the patients [as stated in lecture].
- Standing water inside a hospital also creates the risk of electrical shock.

32.3.2 Increase in Extreme Weather Events

- Extreme weather events such as heat waves require dedicated infrastructure.
  - Example of dedicated infrastructure: **cooling rooms**.
  - Example of dedicated capacity: during Delhi's heat waves, the government starts dedicating a certain number of beds in government hospitals to patients suffering from heat-wave conditions.
- Consequence: the percentage of disease is rising — heat-stroke cases were earlier very few, and people had a basic resilience that is now being lost.
- Reason: urban living runs 24x7; labourers and street vendors have to work round the clock and cannot simply choose not to work during the day.

32.3.3 Rising Chance of Pandemics

- Climate change has increased the chances of a pandemic because the **resistance and survival capabilities of micro-organisms** are increasing.
- Micro-organisms survive in heat — many diseases occur in summer and not in winter.
- As the temperature range of their existence increases, their window of operation increases, which automatically keeps causing more chances of disease in individuals.
  - Examples: viruses and bacteria.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Global pandemic treaty.

- The **WHO** recently adopted the **global pandemic treaty** — cited to show that the pandemic risk from climate change is a live and recognised concern, not a forced point.

QUICK REVISION

- Route 1 — infrastructural: disasters and extreme events damage healthcare infrastructure, affect cooling and electricity needs, and cause water logging and electric-shock risk in hospitals.
- Route 2 — extreme weather: heat waves need dedicated infrastructure such as cooling rooms and dedicated beds in Delhi government hospitals.

- Extreme weather raises disease percentages and erodes the basic resilience people had; the 24x7 urban economy leaves labourers and vendors no option but to work in the heat.
- Route 3 — pandemics: micro-organisms' resistance and survival increase as the temperature range of their existence widens, enlarging their window of operation.
- WHO has recently adopted the global pandemic treaty.

32.4 Health Governance Issues

Health governance issues cover the integration of services, coordination between ministries and between levels of government, decentralisation, accountability, and the public-private divide.

32.4.1 Weak Integration of Health Services

- Primary, secondary and tertiary care work in **silos** — they are not integrated with one another.
- Alongside this there is a **weak referral system**.
- Consequence: crowding of district and tertiary health infrastructure, and bypass of primary health centres.

1. Envisaged chain: the patient first visits **primary care**.
2. From primary care the patient is referred to **secondary care**.
3. From secondary care the patient is referred to the **third tier**.
4. Emergency and trauma are handled differently: trauma is a separate case, handled at a trauma centre, and the ambulance takes the patient straight to the tertiary centre rather than following the referral chain.

This chain is the envisaged healthcare referral framework.

KEY CONCEPT

What a working referral chain delivers.

- **Less crowding** at the district and tertiary levels.
- A **healthcare continuum** — the envisaged healthcare referral.

In practice, however, the chain is broken.

CRITICAL POINT

What actually happens.

- People do not go to the primary centre at all; they go straight to a tertiary hospital such as AIIMS, saying that they will consult the AIIMS doctor.
- If a hundred such patients arrive at the tertiary level, the referral problem is created rather than solved, and there is no integration within health.

- **Exam relevance**: a question came in the Mains examination this year, and the first thing to examine inside health itself is the **first degree, second degree and third degree** structure of care.

32.4.2 Weak Horizontal Coordination Between Ministries

Coordination between ministries is horizontal coordination, and it has to be shown as a diagram listing each ministry with its health-linked function.

Ministry of Health and Family Welfare	Implements the National Health Mission
Ministry of Women and Child Development	Nutrition; Reproductive, Maternal and Child Health (RMCH) programme; adolescent nutrition; supplementary feeding for lactating mothers; complementary feeding for the child after six months
Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs and Ministry of Rural Development	Infrastructure
Ministry of Jal Shakti	WASH
Ministry of Agriculture	Food and nutrition
Ministry of Mines	Mines safety

KEY CONCEPT

Keywords to write.

- **Fragmented governance**.
- **Lack of coordination** — the diagram has to show the lack of coordination.

32.4.3 Limited Vertical Coordination

- **Union government** functions: interstate coordination, quarantine, mines safety, and the IHR.
  - The keyword for the state's role in the same vertical chain is **public health** — the state looks after everything under public health.
- **Rural local body (RLB) / urban local body (ULB)**: solid waste management.
- Across all three levels there is a **lack of vertical coordination**, and that produces a fragmented framework.

IHR stands for the **International Health Regulations** — regulations India adheres to because it is a signatory to the World Health Organization.

EXAMPLE

Observed during the pandemic.

- **Several states did not implement centrally sponsored schemes.**
- **West Bengal** did not implement **PM-JAY (Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana)** till 2026.
- **Odisha**, under the BJD government led by Mr. Patnaik, was not willing to adhere to the

schemes run by the central government.

- **Ayushman did not happen in Delhi**, even though central government health and family welfare hospitals exist in the city; Delhi residents could have availed free facilities worth Rs. 5 lakh under the scheme.
- **Punjab**: the state government is bringing its own model of **Mohalla Clinics** — existing primary health centres are being relabelled as Mohalla Clinics, so that the facility appears to have been started by the state even though centrally sponsored schemes are funded on a 60:40 sharing basis.
- **Delhi's Mohalla Clinics**: government doctors — who had cleared the examination and trained in good colleges — were made to sit free of cost and treatment was free; it was a marquee initiative of that party's health scheme, but after the party left it was kept in the dustbin, and nobody goes to the mohalla clinics now.

32.4.4 Lack of Decentralisation

- Centrally sponsored schemes such as **PM-JAN Arogya Yojana** are implemented in a **top-down manner**.
- They are implemented **without engagement of local communities**.
- Policy makers, health administrators and health providers perceive communities as **passive recipients** rather than **active participants**.
- Example of the ground reality: the pressure on one or two young doctors in the emergency ward of a government hospital such as AIIMS.

CRITICAL POINT

Critique of the governance framework itself.

- These governance concepts — coordination, integration, vertical and horizontal coordination, engagement of communities — are Western-imposed concepts; the West promoted privatisation and presented its own model as the right model of governance.
- They emerged in developed countries where doctor-to-population and bed-to-population ratios and other facilities were very different from India's.
- India is stuck in the middle: neither completely formalised like a developed society, nor completely informalised.
- A stakeholder approach may be ideal, but across a population of the scale cited in the lecture (500 crore) it becomes impossible for an administrator to carry out the actual task of administration [as stated in lecture].
- The theoretical premise for this debate was set by public administration scholars such as **Mohit Bhattacharya** and **Rajni Kothari**.

32.4.5 Focus on Outputs Rather Than Outcomes

- There is a focus on **outputs** rather than **outcomes**.
  - Example: under PM-JAY the number of beneficiaries is counted, but health outcomes are not measured.

32.4.6 Accountability and Quality Deficit

- There is an **accountability and standardisation deficit** — that is, a **quality deficit** in health governance.

32.4.7 The Dual Problem: Public versus Private Healthcare

Healthcare delivery faces a **dual problem** — the failures on the public side and the failures on the private side are of different kinds.

Principal failure	Overcrowding; shortage of human resources and infrastructure	Overpricing; lax regulation
Diagnostics and medicines	Shortage of diagnostics and medicines, for example TB medicines	Unnecessary diagnostics and interventions
Preventive and promotive care	Delivers vaccination, sanitation and disease surveillance	Absolute neglect of preventive care, because of limited commercial returns

On the private side the specific failures to write down are **overpricing**, **lax regulation**, **excessive commercialisation**, and **unnecessary diagnostics and intervention**. The regulation that applies to the private sector has a name.

> **GOVERNMENT & POLICY**
>
> **Clinical Establishments Act, 2010.**
>
> - This is the legal framework that looks at the concerns and the regulation of the private sector, and it decides the licence to perform your role as a medical practitioner or as a clinical establishment.
> - It is **not uniformly applied** in the entire country.
> - Because of this, many fake hospitals run without a licence.

On the public side, TB is the standing example of what a shortage of medicines means for patients.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> **TB as a public-sector test case.**
>
> - TB is a big and dangerous disease: if a person coughs repeatedly with a dry cough, be immediately alert, because TB spreads and is a communicable disease.
> - Pulmonary TB — the form in the lungs — spreads, so closed, crowded spaces are a big problem.
> - Poor nutrition makes a person susceptible.
> - In government facilities TB patients do receive medicines, but they also face shortages.

32.4.8 Parliamentary Standing Committee, 176th Report

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

176th Report.

- Released in **August 2026** [as stated in lecture], this is the latest trend on the private sector.
- It pointed out **unnecessary diagnostics and interventions** in the private sector.
- It flagged **over-commercialisation** and **dual pricing**.

- **Exam relevance**: parliamentary committees are a fixed question in the topic of Parliament; the sub-theme is **parliamentary committees**, and two to three questions have been asked in the civil services examination.
- Do not take an AI-generated summary of the report; take the report's excerpts and insert them into your own structure.
- The health topic is a puzzle — what we are doing here is writing the examples.

DATA & FACTS

Cost of hospitalisation — 176th Report findings.

- Average cost of hospitalisation in a **government hospital**: about **Rs. 6,000** (Rs. 6.5 thousand).
- Average cost of hospitalisation in a **private facility**: about **Rs. 50,000**.
- Average **out-of-pocket expenditure** in a government hospital: about **Rs. 2,300**.
- Average **out-of-pocket expenditure** in a private facility: about **Rs. 37,000**.
- For a student this is a very big amount, and for an ordinary household the gap is the whole issue.

QUICK REVISION

- Weak integration: primary, secondary and tertiary care work in silos with a weak referral system, causing crowding at district/tertiary levels and bypass of primary health centres; the envisaged chain is primary → secondary → tertiary, with trauma handled separately.
- Horizontal coordination: ministries work in silos — Health and Family Welfare (National Health Mission), Women and Child Development (nutrition, RMCH), Housing and Urban Affairs and Rural Development (infrastructure), Jal Shakti (WASH), Agriculture (food and nutrition), Mines (mines safety) — producing fragmented governance and lack of coordination.
- Vertical coordination: Union (interstate coordination, quarantine, mines safety, IHR), State (public health), RLB/ULB (solid waste management) do not coordinate, producing a fragmented framework; IHR = International Health Regulations, India being a WHO signatory.
- Example of the break: states did not implement centrally sponsored schemes — West Bengal (PM-JAY till 2026), Odisha under the BJD government, Delhi (Ayushman), and Punjab's relabelled Mohalla Clinics.
- Decentralisation deficit: PM-JAN Arogya Yojana is implemented top-down, communities are seen as passive recipients rather than active participants; the concepts themselves are Western-imposed, developed-country ideas.

- Outputs over outcomes (PM-JAY counts beneficiaries, not health outcomes) and an accountability, standardisation and quality deficit.
- Dual problem: public sector — overcrowding, HR and infrastructure shortage, diagnostics and medicine shortage; private sector — overpricing, lax regulation under the Clinical Establishments Act 2010, commercialisation, unnecessary diagnostics and interventions; the 176th Report of the Parliamentary Standing Committee (August 2026) puts average hospitalisation cost at Rs. 6,000 (government) versus Rs. 50,000 (private) and out-of-pocket expenditure at Rs. 2,300 versus Rs. 37,000.

32.5 Technology-Related Health Challenges

At the end of the governance issues come **technology-related challenges**.

1. **Digital divide** — access to the internet and to electricity is limited in rural areas.
2. **Gender divide** — NFHS Round 6 records women's internet use at **64%**, which is less than men's.
3. **Linguistic divide** — government websites and dashboards are available either in English or in Hindi; example: **e-Sanjeevani**.

- **Fragmentation of data systems** — the data collected by government for different health purposes sits in separate silos.
  - Data is collected for Ayushman Bharat, for vaccination, and from primary health centres.
  - All of it appears on separate dashboards, whereas it should all be at one place.

32.5.1 Concerns Related to AI

- AI, which is trained on data, might not reflect **linguistic, cultural and digital diversity**.
- AI models give answers in Hindi or English, but there are many people in India who know neither Hindi nor English, and they cannot use these systems.
- There is a strong **cultural divide**: every person comes from a different culture and there is a great deal of ethnic variation.
  - The general body structure and anthropometric parameters of people from Punjab, Haryana or western UP are different from those of the north-eastern states, which are a different race altogether.
  - If an AI system is to diagnose a disease such as malnutrition, stunting or wasting, judge the height of a child against age, or suggest the right dietary practices, it has to keep in mind the cultural preference of that individual.
  - One cannot tell a Bengali to drink a lot of milk, nor tell a Haryanvi to eat fish three times a day to fulfil protein intake.
- AI eventually requires data, and data cannot be provided for the entire territory of India — whatever training is done must incorporate linguistic, cultural and digital diversity.
- There is also a **digital diversity** problem: people using artificial intelligence in a backward state will not be familiar with its operation and usage.

32.5.2 Gender Bias in AI

- There is a clear **gender bias** in AI, because AI systems are trained on **male-centric or urban-centric databases**.
- A village lifestyle is completely different from an urban one, and that changes the body's response to non-communicable diseases.
  - In a village you get up early, do household activity, go to the fields; you eat fresh food that is locally available, and processed food is hardly available — to buy it you have to travel to a city.
- So when an AI or large language model is trained on data that is mostly of males or of urban areas, it cannot be applied to females or to rural areas.
- Example: undernutrition in a female cannot be detected by using data of males, because general body weight and bone density differ between males and females.

> **DATA & FACTS**
>
> ****2024 McKinsey** finding [as stated in lecture].**
>
> - AI-based detection performs differently for females **as compared to males**, because the data the model is trained on is male-centric.
> - There are a lot of studies which say that AI has to be used very carefully.

The answer therefore has to balance AI's vast applications against these challenges.

> **PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION**
>
> **Practice question.**
>
> - **Though AI has vast applications in healthcare in India, however there are certain challenges. Discuss.**

- **All the issues of data, and of data protection, in this country are the issues of AI** — that is the simple way to open this topic.
- The issues of AI in health are the same as the issues of AI as a technology; only the examples change — for health, the examples come from current affairs.

Also write down that AI is vulnerable to:

1. errors
2. data limitations
3. hallucination

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> ****Hallucination**.**
>
> - Hallucination means the AI ends up giving faulty arguments for the question you are trying to ask — it gives a wrong answer but attributes it as if it were correct.
> - Example: asked where the sun rises, it says the west; when asked why, it starts justifying the answer instead of correcting itself and saying that it rises in the east.

- It is said that at higher levels AI starts to hallucinate.

QUICK REVISION

- Digital divide: limited internet and electricity in rural areas; gender divide: NFHS Round 6 shows women's internet use at 64%, less than men's; linguistic divide: websites and dashboards only in English or Hindi, example e-Sanjeevani.
- Fragmentation of data systems: Ayushman Bharat, vaccination and primary health centre data sit on separate dashboards instead of one place.
- AI concerns: it may not reflect linguistic, cultural and digital diversity; cultural divide means anthropometric differences (Punjab/Haryana/western UP versus the north-east) must be respected — you cannot tell a Bengali to drink milk or a Haryanvi to eat fish thrice a day; digital diversity means unfamiliar users make more errors.
- Gender bias in AI: models trained on male-centric or urban-centric data cannot be applied to females or rural areas; undernutrition in a female cannot be detected with male data because of bone density and body weight; 2024 McKinsey cited on different performance for females as compared to males.
- Framing to open the topic: all data and data-protection issues in the country are AI issues; AI issues in health are the same as AI issues in science and technology, only the examples change.
- AI is vulnerable to errors, data limitations and hallucination — hallucination being a wrong answer defended as correct, for example saying the sun rises in the west.

32.6 Role of the Private Sector, Market Forces and PPP

This section answers the question of the role of the private sector — that is, of market forces — in health.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Questions to write for.

- **GS Paper 2, this year**: welfare-based constitutional provision can be provided with a non-integrated approach and minimum public investment — can market forces fulfil the objectives of the Constitution?
- **PYQ 2015**: Public Health Systems has limitations in providing Universal Health Coverage. Do you think that the private sector could help in bridging the gap?

The role of market forces is the same as the role of **PPP (public-private partnership)**.

32.6.1 Merits of Private Sector Participation

- **Capacity augmentation** — the private sector adds to the supply of health care and supplements public healthcare.
  - It builds beds and hospitals and provides diagnostics.
  - It provides tertiary care.

- **Mobilisation of capital and finances** — the private sector can raise money from banks, NBFCs, venture capital and foreign private equity investors.
  - That money is used to put up beds.
  - It thereby reduces pressure on public healthcare.
- **Innovation and managerial capacity** — the private sector gets new technologies and better management practices.
  - New technologies: **proton therapy** for the treatment of cancer, the latest **MRI machines**, and **LASIK** eye-surgery machines.
  - Managerial capacity: hospital management expertise (running a hospital is itself a big MBA-level function), procurement, and proper utilisation of manpower.
  - Example of manpower utilisation: **maximum utilisation of the operation theatre**.
  - Analogy given: an operation theatre is like an Uber car — the driver extracts full value from a depreciating asset, running it for 12 hours; in a government hospital, an empty bed simply stays empty.
  - Doctors who cannot build their own hospital end up using the operation theatre of another hospital, just as talented teachers who want to use their skills teach across several coaching institutes.
- **Geographical reach and scale** — almost **60% of hospital admissions** in the country take place in the private sector.
  - The private sector's geographical reach has no competition.
  - It also attracts talent.
- **Medical tourism** — the private sector generates employment, investment, services exports and foreign exchange, and boosts India's soft power.
  - Example: a person who wants a hair transplant travels to Turkey.
- **Specialised tertiary care and centres of excellence** — the private sector provides specialised care through developed centres of excellence.
  - Cardiology: **Medanta, Gurugram**, owned by **Naresh Trehan** and several partners, a legendary and popular cardiologist.
  - Oncology: the treatment of cancer — the best of the best research happens in the United States, and specialists trained there return to India.
  - Organ transplantation and replacement surgery: knee replacement, liver replacement and cornea replacement.
  - Ophthalmology: **Narayana Health**, **Fortis**, **Max** (Max Saket, New Delhi), **Apollo** (the first private hospital of its kind), **American Continental**, **Global Health City**, **Tata Memorial** (for cancer) and **Lilavati**.
  - Eye-care chains: **Shroff** and **Shroff Eye Care** in Delhi, **Shankar Nethralaya** in South India, and **Arvind Eye Care**.
- **Expansion of consumer choice** — the private sector expands the options available to the patient.
- **Promotion of the use of technology** — AI, robotics, nanomedicine and telemedicine.
  - Example: **Apollo** (owned by the Reddy's) and **ISRO** opened India's first rural telemedicine

centre at **Aragonda village** in Andhra Pradesh.
  - Aragonda was the first village in India to have rural telemedicine, achieved through the efforts of private health care — so private health care cannot always be blamed for malpractices.
- **Handling of complex, time-critical care** — only the private sector can execute tough transplantation cases.
  - Example: when a heart has to be transplanted, an air corridor is created and the police coordinate to move the organ from the airport to the hospital.
- **Corporate social initiatives** — example: in Lucknow, **Max Hospital** collaborates with the Traffic Police to control accident fatalities, distributing helmets and campaigning.

32.6.2 Challenges

- **Limited access and limited affordability** — private care is priced beyond the reach of many patients.
  - The **176th Report of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Health** gives the average cost of hospitalisation in the private sector against the cost in a government hospital.
  - Affordability is only the entry barrier; the continuum of care continues after admission.
- **High out-of-pocket expenditure** — the patient has to buy medicines, and the most expensive ones at that, and diagnostic tests keep being ordered until they are perfect.
  - The doctor's own test may be imperfect, yet the patient keeps being asked to repeat it.
  - Transport to and from the hospital also counts — in Delhi, even the ride to the hospital is part of out-of-pocket expenditure.
- **Equity problem** — private health care increases the health divide between those who can access it and those who cannot.
  - Health then becomes a **market commodity** — this is the commodification of health.
  - Health means social welfare; it is not something to be bought and sold.
- **Constitutional failure** — health is a constitutional right, and the constitutional preference is that public health is a **DPSP for the state**.
  - If a person has to go to a private hospital, that is the failure of the state.
- **Malpractices and poor governance** — private hospitals are often associated with malpractices.
  - Governance does not mean that only the government governs; anyone can govern, and poor governance is the charge here.
  - The standing committee report pointed to **over-commercialisation**.
  - There is **excessive billing** — coffee at Rs. 400 or a burger or sandwich at Rs. 300 inside the hospital.
  - There is **unwarranted medical intervention** — a very important point.
- **Information asymmetry** — patients cannot assess in advance whether the treatment is necessary or not, what the outcomes of the treatment will be, or whether surgical procedures are required at all.
- **Absolute neglect of preventive care** — the private sector focuses on disease, not on prevention and promotion.

  - Reason: preventive care gives **limited commercial returns**.
  - Consequently the private sector has a limited role in **WASH (sanitation)**, in the surveillance of diseases, and a limited focus on **vaccination**.
  - Therefore private health care cannot replace public health.
  - Nuance: private hospitals do organise **health camps** — a very popular idea, with doctors available on Saturdays and Sundays and refreshments such as bananas and juice in villages — but this is a marketing exercise; there is nothing called a free lunch.

Other Concerns

- **Regulatory dilemma — excessive price regulation can discourage investment in the private sector**.
  - If a regulatory bill is very stringent, a hospital that wants to expand and needs capital from a venture capitalist — a Rs. 100 crore expansion, for instance — will not go ahead, and the ripple effect will be felt across the whole sector.
  - The analogy given was the coaching industry: a very stringent bill discourages expansion.
  - Governance is about the least government and the maximum other players [as stated in lecture] — regulation must not become interference.
- **Regulatory multiplicity** — a single building needs clearances from several authorities and officers, such as the MCD, engineers, AEN and JEN, which delays and deters capacity creation [as stated in lecture].
- **Risk of withdrawal from social obligations by the state** — excessive dependence on the private sector can make the state withdraw from its social obligations.
  - That leads to non-fulfilment of constitutional values.
- **Increases every kind of divide** — the income divide, the regional divide and the gender divide.
  - Example: women find it easier to go to anganwadi centres, because their friends, the anganwadi workers, are there; women's socialisation is intertwined with the maze of health services delivered by the government.
  - Even if the state made a 100% cash transfer to women's accounts, they may not use a private facility, because socio-cultural undercurrents run through these places.

> **GOVERNMENT & POLICY**
>
> **Article 47 — public health.**
>
> - **Article 47** places public health among the **Directive Principles of State Policy** for the state.
> - The Constitution is the biggest document of social justice, and articles must be **quoted in GS2 answers and in essays**.

The conclusion that follows is that **privatisation cannot be a solution**.

> **COMPARISON**
>
> **Private healthcare — complement, not substitute.**

- **Supplement or complement**: private healthcare can supplement or complement public healthcare — this is its legitimate role.
- **Substitute**: private healthcare cannot substitute public healthcare.

32.6.3 Way Forward

1. **PPP in health** — for example, in **Madhya Pradesh** medical colleges are being established in **PPP mode**, and PPP hospitals have also been started in **Andhra Pradesh**.
2. **Cooperatives** — hospitals can be run through the cooperative route.

The pros and cons of PPP in health are dealt with in the separate lecture on PPP; PPP is a Paper 3 topic, so for GS2 it has to be looked at separately.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Question to write for.

- **Do you think that public-private partnership in health is a viable alternative to public health care? Give examples while substantiating.**

QUICK REVISION

- The role of market forces is the same as the role of PPP; the GS2 question on market forces and the 2015 PYQ on the private sector bridging the gap are answered by the same material.
- Merits: capacity augmentation (beds, hospitals, diagnostics, tertiary care); mobilisation of capital (banks, NBFCs, venture capital, foreign private equity); innovation and managerial capacity (proton therapy, MRI, LASIK, hospital management, procurement, OT utilisation like an Uber car); geographical reach, with almost 60% of hospital admissions in the private sector; medical tourism (employment, investment, services exports, forex, soft power, the Turkey hair-transplant example); specialised centres of excellence (Medanta, Max Saket, Apollo, Tata Memorial, Lilavati, Narayana Health, Shroff Eye Care, Shankar Nethralaya, Arvind Eye Care); expansion of consumer choice; technology promotion (Apollo and ISRO's first rural telemedicine centre at Aragonda village); complex transplant logistics; and corporate social initiatives such as Max Hospital, Lucknow with the Traffic Police.
- Challenges: limited access and affordability; high out-of-pocket expenditure on medicines, diagnostics and transport; equity problem and commodification of health; constitutional failure, since public health is a DPSP; malpractices, over-commercialisation, excessive billing and unwarranted medical intervention; information asymmetry; absolute neglect of preventive care, so private cannot replace public health; the regulatory dilemma of discouraging investment; regulatory multiplicity; the risk of the state withdrawing from social obligations; and widening income, regional and gender divides.
- Article 47 places public health among the Directive Principles, and articles must be quoted in GS2 and in essays.
- Conclusion: privatisation cannot be a solution — private healthcare can supplement or complement public healthcare, but not substitute it.

- Way forward: PPP in health (medical colleges in PPP mode in Madhya Pradesh, PPP hospitals in Andhra Pradesh) and cooperatives.

32.7 Steps (Schemes)

After the issues, the next section of the structure is **steps**, and 'steps' means **schemes**.

The schemes were to be taken up in the next session — dictated in class or given as a one-page note — because they are the same health schemes that are followed in everyday current affairs and in the Budget.

QUICK REVISION

- 'Steps' in the health structure means schemes.
- The schemes section follows the issues section in the order of the topic.
- The health schemes are the same ones read in everyday current affairs and in the Budget.
- This section was carried forward to the next session, either dictated in class or issued as a one-page note.

32.8 Consequences in Health

The consequences of health were assigned to be written for the next session; the framework is to analyse them at several levels.

1. **Economic consequences** — analysed at the **individual level**, the **national level** and the **sectoral level**.
2. **Social consequences**.
3. **Political consequences**.
4. **Governance consequences**.
5. **International consequences** — a healthy workforce means India can project soft power, medical tourism and the demographic dividend.

QUICK REVISION

- Consequences are analysed in five baskets: economic, social, political, governance and international.
- Economic consequences are examined at the individual, national and sectoral levels.
- International consequences rest on a healthy workforce: soft power, medical tourism and the demographic dividend.

32.9 Importance of Local-Level Community Healthcare in Universal Health Coverage

> **PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION**
>
> **Question.**
>
> - Write the answer to: **importance of local-level community healthcare in universal health coverage**.
> - This is a PYQ.

The framework is the referral pyramid, which begins with the individual and the first point of contact.

Primary — first point of contact	Primary health centre, sub-centre, community health centre
Secondary	District hospital or taluka hospital
Tertiary	AIIMS, medical colleges

- India has 700 to 800 districts but only about 700 district hospitals [as stated in lecture]; the remaining hospitals will be built by the government gradually.
- A district is built up step by step: first the SP, DM and DFO sit there and the revenue department goes in first; everything else follows afterwards.
- In reality, patients go straight to the tertiary level and treat themselves, even consulting ChatGPT for their treatment.

1. It is the **first point of contact** between the population and the health care system, and therefore important for health access for people in rural and remote areas.
2. It **reduces out-of-pocket expenditure and transient poverty** — there is no spending on medicines, no spending on diagnostic tests, and no spending on transport.
3. It ensures **affordability** of care.
4. It enables **early detection** and uses **local knowledge**: the local community health infrastructure and human resource are suited or customised to local needs and understand local disease patterns, leading to better disease prevention and treatment.
5. It delivers **preventive and promotive health** — vaccination, sanitation drives, WASH, nutritional counselling and lifestyle modification — with the Ayushman Arogya Mandir designed as a full-fledged package.
6. It provides **continuity of care**: the Ayushman Arogya Mandir integrates maternal, child, communicable and non-communicable disease services, ensuring comprehensive care.
7. It **strengthens disease surveillance** through early detection and rapid response during a pandemic, as in COVID-19 in 2020, which leads to resilience and promotes universal health coverage.

8. It gives **support to higher levels of health care** by reducing the patient load and resolving health issues at the local level, thereby allowing higher institutions to focus on specialised health care.
9. It leads to **decentralised, participatory, community-based health governance**, because most health workers are women from the local community and PRIs and village committees are involved in health planning, making governance more participatory and inclusive and empowering women.

- Elaboration of local knowledge: in a village, the doctor knows that the ten or twenty people who fall ill with the same illness every year or two need nothing expensive — a cheap or free course is enough.
  - A doctor in a city such as Delhi or Gurugram sits with cross-cultural cases and varied pressures, whereas the local doctor's specialised local knowledge lets resources be optimised and diseases be prevented.
  - Local community knowledge can also be wrong — during COVID-19 there was a belief that the virus could not affect them, and that was incorrect.
- Elaboration of preventive and promotive care: on paper community health care is based on vaccination, sanitation drives, WASH, nutritional counselling and lifestyle modification, and the Ayushman Arogya Mandir was conceived as a full-fledged package.
  - In practice this is not always so — the same doctor and patient may be seen together outside, and regional practices continue.
- Example for the governance benefit: **ASHA (Accredited Social Health Activist)** — a bridge between the individual, society and the health system.
  - ASHAs create awareness on health, nutrition, WASH, immunisation and health education, and distribute basic medicines.
  - They motivate families: eat properly and take nutritious food so that your health is protected and anaemia does not set in; take care of your child; go for breastfeeding; get immunisation done at home.
  - ASHAs have three to four rounds of training, and they play a very important role in health education, along with anganwadi workers, who are also women.

32.9.1 Challenges

- ASHAs are **not classified as workers or government employees** — they are activists, and their framework sits under the **National Health Mission**.
- Their remuneration is an **honorarium**, not a salary; it has recently been increased in Himachal [as stated in lecture].
- ASHAs receive only three to four rounds of training, and the comprehensive primary-care package is not fully realised in practice.

QUICK REVISION

- The referral pyramid: primary (PHC, sub-centre, community health centre) → secondary (district or taluka hospital) → tertiary (AIIMS, medical colleges); India has 700 to 800 districts

but only about 700 district hospitals, and in practice patients bypass the chain and go straight to the tertiary level.

- Benefit 1: the first point of contact between the population and the health system — health access for rural and remote areas; it also reduces out-of-pocket expenditure and transient poverty (medicines, diagnostics, transport) and ensures affordability.
- Benefit 4: early detection and local knowledge customised to local needs and local disease patterns, though local knowledge can also be wrong.
- Benefits 5 and 6: preventive and promotive health (vaccination, sanitation, WASH, nutritional counselling, lifestyle modification) and continuity of care through integrated maternal, child, communicable and non-communicable services.
- Benefits 7 and 8: strengthens disease surveillance and rapid pandemic response (COVID-19, 2020) and supports higher levels of care by reducing patient load so that tertiary institutions focus on specialised care.
- Benefit 9: decentralised, participatory, community-based health governance through women health workers, PRIs and village committees — example ASHA, the bridge between society and the health system.
- Challenges: ASHAs are not classified as workers or government employees, are paid an honorarium and get only three to four rounds of training.

CHAPTER 33

Various Commissions — Part 2

33.1 Functions of the Commissions

The commissions share a common set of functions. NCPCR is used here as the running illustration because the violation of children's rights — especially in the age of AI and deepfakes — is especially acute, and **NCW** carries out the same functions focused on women.

- **Evaluation of progress** for the targeted (relative) groups across defined areas:
  - **Representation in public employment**.
  - **Implementation of reservation**.
  - **Welfare schemes** — whether their results are actually coming, whether they are properly implemented, and whether the benefits reach the beneficiaries.
  - **Scholarships** run by ministries — e.g., the **Maulana Azad** scholarship for minorities, and **SC/ST fellowships** (and **GRF** [as stated in lecture]).
  - A person from these sections who qualifies an examination also receives the same amount under other schemes run by the government.
  - The ministry does not always release the money — e.g., in merit scholarships at the BA and Master's levels the government holds the funds; the respective commissions monitor this.
- **Study of institutional discrimination**.
- **Preparation of annual reports and special reports**, with recommendations made to the Union and the State governments on implementation of safeguards.
- **Recommendation of remedial measures** — for protection, welfare, development, implementation of safeguards, and institutional reforms.

1. The commission submits its **annual report** to the **President**.
2. The President causes the report to be laid before the **legislature**.
3. The government must then place an **Action Taken Report (ATR)**.
4. This reporting chain applies to **NCSC, NCBC and NCST**.

> GOVERNMENT & POLICY
>
> **Not civil courts — but armed with civil-court powers.**
>
> - These commissions are **not civil courts** — they have **no jail and no adjudicatory (judgment-passing) power**.
> - However, when they **investigate or inquire**, they possess powers **equivalent to those of a civil court**: summoning and examining persons **on oath**; receiving evidence **on affidavit**;

and **requisitioning public records**.

- Investigation also depends on the production of documents — e.g., to evaluate performance the commission directs the person to provide answer scripts and test performance, and then recommends measures to the authority, not to the individual.

- **Case example — Satya Niketan:** a clear-cut violation against a particular section of people from a locality; NCSC or NCST takes information from the **MCD** and from the department, and can **summon** the people, the property dealers and the owners of Satya Niketan.
  - After the summon, the commission evaluates the material and issues a **recommendation** — it can do no more, and it **cannot pass a judgment** as a civil court would (e.g., in marital disputes or divorce).

33.1.1 Functions Specific to NCPCR

- Apart from the broad functions above, **NCPCR** also:
  - **undertakes child rights literacy**;
  - **examines problems of children requiring special care** (very important);
  - **inspects juvenile homes and other institutions where children are detained**;
  - **examines factors affecting children impacted by terrorism, communal violence, rights, pornography and domestic violence**, along with other vulnerabilities.

33.1.2 Why NCPCR Is Highlighted — and the Same Framework for NCW

- **Digital pornography / child sexual abuse material (CSEM)** is now easily available on Instagram and social media, promoting exploitative action against children; NCSC, NCST and NCBC are therefore also carrying out research on these new dimensions.
- **Juvenile justice case study:** in the **Nirbhaya case** one of the individuals was a juvenile.
  - A juvenile cannot be jailed — the **Juvenile Justice Board** awards punishment and there is a **separate mechanism of detention**.
  - Inside a juvenile home the child comes into contact with fellow children who have committed offences, which gives **reinforcement** ('you did the right thing, this is the right way'), so the rate of juvenile crime rises and they become **hardened criminals**.
  - Illustration (ages of gangsters cited: 16, 17, 21, 22): a 16-year-old fires a gun, kills someone and is caught on CCTV; he is told 'don't worry, you are a juvenile, nothing will happen'; sent to a juvenile justice home he meets ten more juveniles like himself and emerges a hardened adult criminal who keeps committing crime.
- **NCPCR** therefore plays a very important role in the **evaluation and examination of juvenile homes**, ensuring that they respond to the concerns of society — going there, inspecting, monitoring conduct and observing the environment.
  - Some gangsters never leave jail; the entire nexus is run from inside the jail. If they come out they face a threat to life.
  - Young offenders of 22, 23, 24 want to kill someone and earn a 'brownie point' to rise in the ranks of crime.

All commissions have the same functions; NCPCR is written specifically because of the child

commission and the concerns of violation of children's rights, particularly in the spread of AI and of deepfakes.

- **NCW** performs the same six functions:
  - submitting the **annual report**;
  - making **recommendations**;
  - **investigating**;
  - **inquiring**;
  - fighting **litigation**;
  - taking **suo moto** action.

QUICK REVISION

- Commissions **evaluate the progress** of targeted groups across public employment, implementation of reservation, welfare schemes and scholarships.
- They **study institutional discrimination** and prepare **annual and special reports** with recommendations on implementation of safeguards.
- Reporting chain: report → **President** → laid before the **legislature** → **Action Taken Report (ATR)**; applies to NCSC, NCBC and NCST.
- They are **not civil courts** — no jail and no adjudicatory power — but hold **civil-court powers** (oath, affidavit, requisition of public records).
- **NCPCR** additionally does child rights literacy, special-care children, juvenile-home inspection, and examines children affected by terrorism, communal violence, pornography and domestic violence.
- **NCW** performs the same six functions: annual report, recommendations, investigation, inquiry, litigation and suo moto action.

33.2 Role of the Commissions: Positive Contributions

To evaluate the role of these commissions, look at both their **positive role** and their **negative role (limitations)**. The commissions follow the same template — if you know the role of **NHRC**, the same arguments apply to all the others.

33.2.1 Positive Role

- **Institutionalization of targeted rights protection** — a **statutory or constitutional mechanism and framework** has been created for upholding the rights of the targeted group.
- **Improved access to the rights protection system** — earlier one could only file a complaint with the police (and, if the police failed, approach the constitutional courts); now one can directly access the commission and file a complaint, leading to **intervention** and reducing the **cost and time of access to justice**.
  - Illustration: a casteist remark in a classroom can be taken to **NCSC**; a grievance filed there leads to **immediate action** and a **summons notice** to the police authorities, forcing accountability — the **SHO's ACR** is affected by a summons for poor policing.

  - **Data point:** In **May 2026**, NCSC sought an **ATR** after a complaint was filed regarding **casteist terminology in Punjab's socio-economic (slash drug) survey forms**.
- **Rights ensured through exercise of suo moto powers** — suo moto action ensures mobilisation and a **swift response from the state**, leading to **enforcement of victim rights**.
  - **NCW** took **suo moto notice** in the case of an **NGO worker in Odisha** and a similar case in **Manipur (2023)**.
  - **NCST** took notice of the **Kishtwar tribal minor sexual assault case**.
- **Creation of administrative accountability** — through swift and prompt exercise of power, backed by **statutory powers of a civil court** in investigation and inquiry.
  - Illustration: if **UPSC** does not advertise or fill the seats reserved for backward sections, **NCSC/NCST** immediately issue a notice and UPSC must answer — even a constitutional body like UPSC is susceptible to the answers sought by these commissions.
  - Without these commissions there would be no such accountability; UPSC is otherwise answerable only to **Parliament**.
  - The **Parliamentary Standing Committee** has lambasted UPSC: fulfil the needs of students and create a platform for employment; highly skilled aspirants are appealing for interviews while nothing is being created; the exam cycle takes a whole year; and answer keys are not released while everyone who never appeared gives answer keys.
- **Conversion of individual grievances into systemic reform** — an individual complaint leads to inquiry, identification of a structural deficiency, and then **institutional and policy reform**.
  - **Example:** NCW's cognizance of the **TCS Nashik Office** in a **POSH** case.
  - **POSH** = the **Prevention of Sexual Harassment Act, 2013**, brought in the aftermath of the **Vishakha Guidelines, 1997**.
- **Adaptation to new forms of vulnerability** — commissions are increasingly focusing on violations in **technological, digital and corporate spaces**.
  - Social media trolling of women and mass foul-language comments; corporate exploitation — a young CA who succumbed to excessive work pressure at the behest of her company (long 10-to-7 working hours).
  - **Deepfakes** — one deep fake can be followed by very real deep fakes; the issue was covered in a newspaper's Explained section.
  - **Example:** NCPCR's **formal inquiry** into **Meta India's policy relating to CSEM** (child sexual exploitation/abuse material).
  - Also the vilification of an individual based on caste, and **Yashoda AI**, which develops AI literacy, cyber security and digital safety awareness among women in rural and semi-urban areas.
- **Evidence-based affirmative action** — NCSC, NCST and NCBC now demand data instead of accepting demands at face value.
  - **Example:** in **2025**, when **Bihar** wanted **18 communities** added to the OBC list / central OBC list, **NCBC sought socio-economic and educational backwardness data**.
  - Earlier, any demand for reservation simply led to protest — the **Patidar (Patel) agitation in Gujarat**, the **Jat protest in Haryana** (during the first term of the **Khattar** government)

and the **Maratha protest in Maharashtra** (led by **Jarange-Patil**).

- Now the commissions say: give me the data, form a state commission on backwardness; such a commission should be headed by a **retired High Court judge**, because judges believe in facts.

- **Punjab case study:** Punjab has the **highest proportion of SC population among states — 32%** — and this population is politically active.
  - Within SCs there is great **heterogeneity**: some are economically better than other sections, while others are extremely backward and lack access even to the usual **gurudwaras**, which explains the existence of **deras**.
  - This segment can be politically mobilised the way **Kanshiram and Mayawati** mobilised in **Uttar Pradesh**; the same pattern is possible in Punjab.
- Media attention has focused on a self-styled religious-political figure (**Gurmeet Ram Rahim Singh Insan**), described as a major political influence across **Punjab and Haryana** — in Sirsa, Bathinda, Barnala, Mansa and the entire **Malwa belt** (district names as stated in lecture).
- **Sensitivity note:** when you qualify the examination you must be very sensitive to these developments; when **Justice Chandrachud was CJI** he ensured there was a list of certain words, sections and phrases that an administrator should not use.

> **DATA & FACTS**
>
> **Key Figures.**
>
> - **32%** — the SC population share in **Punjab**, the highest among states.
> - **May 2026** — when NCSC sought an ATR over casteist terminology in Punjab's socio-economic drug survey forms.
> - **2025** — when NCBC sought backwardness data on Bihar's proposal for **18 communities** in the OBC list.
> - **1997 → 2013** — the **Vishakha Guidelines (1997)** preceding the **POSH Act (2013)**.
> - **0 to 18** — the age range that defines the child rights domain.

NCSC	Sought an ATR (May 2026) on casteist terminology in Punjab's socio-economic drug survey forms	Improved access and administrative accountability
NCW	Suo moto notice in the case of an NGO worker in Odisha and a case in Manipur (2023)	Exercise of suo moto powers
NCST	Took notice of the Kishtwar tribal minor sexual assault case	Exercise of suo moto powers
NCW	Cognizance of the TCS Nashik Office in a POSH case	Individual grievance to systemic reform
NCPCR	Formal inquiry into Meta India's policy relating to CSEM	Adapting to digital and corporate violations
NCBC	Sought backwardness data when Bihar proposed 18 communities for the OBC list (2025)	Evidence-based affirmative action

CRITICAL POINT

Relevance increasingly depends on capacity.

- The relevance of these commissions increasingly depends on their **capacity to apply older constitutional protections to new environments dominated by technology**.
- As digitization spreads, the old frameworks, laws and policies must be applied to new dimensions — **deepfakes, cyber security and the technological divide**.
- The technological divide is itself a form of deprivation: a woman who cannot access the internet or AI faces a divide perpetuated by technology.
- Society is changing simultaneously through **globalisation and acculturation**; forms of exploitation change — a woman in New York, a woman in New Delhi and a woman in a far-flung state face exploitation that differs in nature.

QUICK REVISION

- Positive contributions: **institutionalization of targeted rights protection** and **improved access to justice**.
- **Suo moto powers** produce a swift state response and enforcement of victim rights (NCW: Odisha, Manipur 2023; NCST: Kishtwar).
- Commissions create **administrative accountability** (e.g., UPSC on reserved seats).

- They convert individual grievances into **systemic reform** (NCW–TCS Nashik POSH case; POSH Act 2013, Vishakha 1997).
- They adapt to digital and corporate harms (deepfakes, CSEM — NCPCR vs Meta India; Yashoda AI).
- They push **evidence-based affirmative action** (NCBC sought backwardness data for Bihar's 18 communities, 2025).
- Their relevance depends on applying old constitutional protections to technology-dominated new environments.

33.3 Limitations of the Commissions — Challenges and Way Forward

The concerns, issues, challenges and negatives are written crudely as where these commissions have **not been successful in upholding their constitutional and statutory mandate**. They are analysed in two simple buckets — **structural limitations** and **functional limitations**.

COMPARISON

Two Buckets of Limitations.

- **Structural constraints** — about the design, powers and resourcing of the commissions: enforcement deficit, vacancy deficit, dependence on other authorities, limited finances, lack of independence, politicization of posts.
- **Functional constraints** — about how the commissions actually work day to day: lackadaisical reporting, pendency, weak field presence, weak research, poor coordination, delayed reporting.

33.3.1 Challenges

Structural Constraints

1. **Enforcement deficit** (the main structural constraint) — recommendations are **non-binding** and dependent on the **police, courts or governments** for enforcement.
2. **Vacancy deficit** — flagged by the **Parliamentary Standing Committee in 2025**.
3. **Dependence on other authorities** — state, police, organisations, employers, universities, ministries and PSUs — for implementation as well as for ensuring compliance.
4. **Limited financial capacity and dependence on the parent ministry** — the **2026 Parliamentary Standing Committee report** pointed out that the **Rs. 36 crore budget for FY27 for NCW** was limited, which also led to **limited professional capacity in investigating gender-based crimes**.
5. **Lack of independence** — no independent secretariat and no independent staff.
6. **Politicization of posts (chairman and members) / appointments** — members of Parliament who have not been given ministerial posts are made heads of these organisations.

Functional Constraints

1. **Lackadaisical approach** — annual reports are not compiled and released or updated on time.

2. **Pendency and follow-up deficit** — complaints are not resolved timely, leading to a pile-up of cases and **delay in the enforcement of rights**.
3. **Weak field presence** — commissions sit in Delhi, but violations occur in far-flung, forested, tribal regions: Central India, MP, Odisha, Jharkhand, Maharashtra and Chhattisgarh; the regional office exists but is in the city headquarters, so in the hotbed of Maoism there is weak field presence.
4. **Weak research and data infrastructure** — failure to identify institutions that frequently violate, whose recommendations are ignored, and the average time taken to implement recommendations; recommendations not rooted in ground realities (e.g., the time taken to implement the reservation policy or a hostel in a university).
5. **Lack of coordination between central and state commissions** (e.g., NCW and the Delhi Commission for Women) — a **fragmented approach** leading to **duplication**, **jurisdictional ambiguity** and **poor information sharing and repeated referral**.
6. **Delayed reporting** — delay in submission of annual reports makes the recommendations irrelevant, and there is also delay in the ATR.

- **Elaboration — weak field presence:** tribal rights violations do not happen in Delhi; they happen in the far-flung forested areas (Central India, MP, Odisha, Jharkhand, Maharashtra, Chhattisgarh).
  - Affected communities are far removed from New Delhi and live in **Scheduled Areas**, tribal areas, and border and inaccessible districts, so their problem is one of **limited access**.
  - Both **online complaint platforms and physical accessibility** are important for grievance redressal — this is especially problematic for **NCST**.
- **Elaboration — coordination:** during **Swati Maliwal's** tenure as head of the **Delhi Commission for Women**, she was an active enforcer of women's rights, yet her statements ran against those of the **NCW** led by someone from another party; with both coming from different ideologies, the interests of women's rights suffered.
  - A complaint with the DCW is repeatedly diverted to the NCW and back; instead of diverting, the two should coordinate — then the house will be in order.
  - Data on exploitation in Delhi cannot be used by NCW, and no cross-sectoral study can be done by both commissions, which may also lead to **forum shopping**.
- **Elaboration — delayed reporting chain:** a report for **FY 2026-27** submitted in **2029** is already 2 years late; once the government places it before Parliament after 2 years, 4 years have passed since the recommendation; the ATR then comes after another 2 years — a total of **6 years**.
  - **Example:** NCST's **2015-16 report** was laid in Parliament in **2019**, and its annual report for **FY 2017-18** was laid in Parliament in **2023**.
  - This reflects a **low-level equilibrium** (a public administration concept).

EXAMPLE

Illustration — the pamphlet complaint.

- A woman complained about coaching institutes forcing students to distribute pamphlets on

the roads.

- The practice creates a cleanliness concern, adds to waste and also creates a concern of **sexual harassment**, because the institute incentivises/forces students to distribute pamphlets from rickshaws.
- Instead of solving every individual complaint of harassment, the **structural constraint — the practice itself — must be addressed** (e.g., it should be banned, and the beat constable told to act).
- One cannot work only on one child's complaint of discrimination — as a scheduled caste, backward class, female, or whatever the **vulnerability matrix** — the response must be **systematised** and requires a **long-term approach**.

Other Limitations

- **Emerging and frequently changing nature of discrimination** — e.g., the role of **AI**.
- **Monitoring compliance across many institutions** — e.g., reservation for **SC, ST and OBC** in several universities and colleges.
  - One NCW cannot manage all violations of women's rights, and one **NCPCR** cannot manage all violations of child rights in the country (a child is **0 to 18**) when there is a new breaking-news story every other day.
  - Illustration: a frustrated teacher beats a child; the media reports it everywhere — how then is enforcement maintained?
- **The child cannot enforce its own rights** — the child is dependent on the **police, media, guardians, child welfare committees and NGOs**.
- **Emerging concern — CSEM** (child sexual exploitation/abuse material) and its associated security concerns:
  - **Children's privacy**.
  - **Cyber bullying**.
  - **Online grooming** — many networking websites tell children what to do, what is right and what is wrong; acceptable for adults, but online grooming of a child is wrong because it is a new platform and a new interface that depends on an authority which does not possess the requisite validation.
  - **Addictive platform algorithms** — algorithms framed to make the child addicted to the platform.
- **Example: Australia** has grappled with online grooming through the internet and networking websites.
- **Non-constitutional status** — the child rights body (NCPCR) has a **non-constitutional status**; the same concern applies to **NCW**.

33.3.2 Way Forward

At the end, the way forward:

1. An **independent selection panel**, similar to that of **NHRC**.

2. **Increase regional presence** to focus on **high-atrocity areas**.
3. A **statutory limit of 180 days** for complaint disposal.
4. Creation of a **National Judicial Data Grid type platform** to track **real-time pendency**.
5. **Financial autonomy** — expenditure should be charged to the **Consolidated Fund of India (CFI)**, so that the commissions are not dependent.
6. **Strengthening of follow-up** — of recommendations, delivery of compensation and **initiation of prosecution**.
7. A **permanent secretariat** to reduce dependence on government staff.
8. **Coordination** — the commissions should work in an **integrated manner**, ensuring an **intersectional approach** in grievance redressal and enforcement of rights.

- **Permanent secretariat — detail:** a completely separate wing of officials and staff; recruitment done by the commission itself; the central government will not send anyone on deputation; the commission will frame its own rules and recruit its own staff.
- **Pluralism — multi-disciplinary expertise:** the secretariat should include lawyers, sociologists, anthropologists, economists, statisticians, child psychologists, gender experts, feminists, data scientists, engineers, tribal experts and cyber specialists.
- **Coordination — detail:** the commissions should work in an integrated manner, ensuring an intersectional approach in grievance redressal and enforcement of rights.
- **Related illustration:** a **Special Commissioner for disabilities** promptly directed **UPSC** to act in a matter.
  - The question raised was whether disability needs a separate constitutional, multi-member framework — like the **Election Commission**, which is a multi-member commission — since the disability framework is growing.
  - The **Supreme Court has said** that victims will count on disability [as stated in lecture].

QUICK REVISION

- Limitations are grouped as **structural** and **functional**.
- **Structural:** enforcement deficit (non-binding recommendations), vacancy deficit (2025), dependence on other authorities, limited finances (Rs. 36 crore NCW FY27), lack of independent secretariat/staff, politicization of posts.
- **Functional:** lackadaisical annual reports, pendency/follow-up deficit, weak field presence (NCST in Maoist/forest belts), weak research and data, poor centre–state coordination (NCW vs DCW; forum shopping), delayed reporting (6-year chain; NCST 2015-16 laid 2019, 2017-18 laid 2023).
- **Other limitations:** changing nature of discrimination (AI), monitoring across many institutions, child dependent on others, CSEM and digital safety concerns, non-constitutional status.
- **CSEM security concerns:** children's privacy, cyber bullying, online grooming, addictive platform algorithms.
- **Way forward:** independent selection panel, greater regional presence, 180-day statutory

> disposal limit, NJDG-type real-time pendency tracker, financial autonomy via CFI, stronger follow-up, permanent secretariat with pluralism, integrated intersectional working.

CHAPTER 34

Health in India — Part 3: Government Steps, Way Forward and AI in Health

34.1 Framing: How Health Questions Are Asked

Health carries a different **strand of questions**. Around health the demographic-dividend type of question is not asked; the health question is on the **importance of primary health**, and **market forces** play an important role in it. Everything asked in this theme is ultimately meant to make you **suggest measures**.

> **PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION**
>
> **Where this topic is asked.**
>
> - The **steps taken by the Government of India** in health are asked in **prelims** as well.
> - From the budget, **4–5 questions** come, and a budget question comes **every alternate year** — for example, revenue versus capital budget.
> - Do not hate the budget: it is a **very important document for pre and mains** and it has to be felt, not merely watched.

Roadmap of this part: first write the **steps taken by the Government of India**, then the **way forward**, and then the answer to the question on the **role of AI in health**, for which a model answer is to be written.

The steps are to be **written by hand**. The lecture had considered giving them as a two-three page PDF table, but because these classes are being taken for the first time the trajectory is to be followed and written out.

The source behind this chapter is a compilation of **PIB backgrounders and ministry updates** — separate articles, for example the steps launched for TB, have been made into a booklet. It is an interesting source, and everything in it is to be worked into the notes.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **How the steps are organised.**
>
> - **Budget steps are written through a fixed framework.** The earlier class had used the **three-pillar framework** of the budget, and had remembered **KATO (K-A-T-O)**, the four states where the **rare earth corridor** was established, along with rare earth elements and **critical minerals**.
> - **Every step list in this theme is written as budget steps + traditional steps.**

- **This is also the structure for social justice topics**, because social justice is discussed mainly through education and skill development.

- Mentioned in passing: the **Transgender Amendment** has been passed.

DATA & FACTS

Why the numbers matter.

- The **Ministry of Health and Family Welfare**'s entire budgetary expenditure is **Rs. 1.1 lakh crore** (Rs. 1,10,000 crore).
- A flagship scheme such as **MGNREGA** — which the lecture says is now being taken forward as Viksit Bharat [as stated in lecture] — spends about **Rs. 90,000 crore** in a year, which shows how large a sum Rs. 1.1 lakh crore is.
- Be very familiar with such numbers: the bigger the budgetary spending of a ministry, the greater the stature of the officer who heads it.

QUICK REVISION

- Health's question is on the importance of primary health; market forces matter, and the ask is always to suggest measures.
- Steps taken by the Government of India are asked in prelims; 4–5 questions come from the budget, and a budget question comes every alternate year.
- Roadmap: steps → way forward → AI in health; the steps are to be written by hand.
- The health ministry's budget is Rs. 1.1 lakh crore and MGNREGA spends about Rs. 90,000 crore a year — know the numbers.
- Steps are written as budget steps + traditional steps, the same structure as for social justice topics.

34.2 Budget Steps Taken by the Government of India in Health

The **budget 2026-27** gives **ten steps** for health. This is the first classification of the steps taken by the Government of India, and they are to be written in the order below.

DATA & FACTS

The health budget.

- The health budget has a **10% hike over the revised estimates of 2026**.

34.2.1 1. Bio-Pharma Shakti: Indigenous Production of Biologics and Biosimilars

- **Bio-Pharma Shakti** — the scheme for the **indigenous production of pharmaceuticals**, that is, of biologics and biosimilars.
  - Medicines are chemistry: a medicine (davai) is a salt. **Biologics and biosimilars** are the class of medicines that are not chemistry-made medicines and have to be manufactured as biological molecules.

- **Biosimilars explained:** a generic medicine has the same salt as a branded medicine; in the same way, the body has certain **naturally available molecules**, and when they are manufactured with the same **therapeutic efficiency**, those biological molecules are called **biosimilars**.
  - The **United States is a leader** in the production of biologics and biosimilars, and the area has a very big scope.
- They are used for **rare conditions**, such as those that soldiers get — for example **colitis** [as stated in lecture], in which the stomach cannot digest food and allopathic medicines do not work.
- **BioE3 policy, 2023** — bio-pharma is one of its pillars. The whole subject is to be done with **biotechnology** in the science-and-technology portion for prelims, where one or two questions come every year.
- **Rs. 10,000 crore is to be spent over 5 years**; the scheme is important for **advanced therapies**.
- **Three new NIPERs** — National Institute of Pharmaceutical Educational Research [expansion as stated in lecture] — are to be established, and the existing ones upgraded.
- **Exam note:** this scheme cannot be handled with sketchy knowledge. Two-three hours of deep dive in a current-affairs magazine are needed, and a question can come from it in prelims.

34.2.2 2. Expansion of Allied Health Professionals

- The focus is on **ten allied health disciplines**, with a target of **one lakh allied health professionals over the next five years** — a scheme to train one lakh people.
  - The ten fields include **radiology**, **optometry** (very important), **anaesthesia**, **OT (operation theatre) technology** and **rehabilitative professionals**.
- Why this matters: the focus is always on doctors, but it is the **allied health professionals who assist the doctors** — the compounder, the radiologist and the optometrist have a very big role in a hospital; where there are two doctors, the rest of the work is theirs.
- **Rehabilitative professionals:** a person who has had surgery is not normal — the stomach or the arm has been cut — and needs rehabilitation to be brought back to normal.
- This expansion is the **government's response to increase the female labour force participation rate**.

34.2.3 3. Care Economy and Geriatric Care

- The budget **promotes the care economy** with **1.5 lakh caregivers**, and envisages a **separate ecosystem for geriatric and allied care**.
  - The elements to be written for the care economy: **skills**, **wellness** — healthy discussion on politics and on AI — and the **operation of medical assistive devices**, that is, how the device is to be brought to the person.
- Why a separate ecosystem: the person who looks after the aged, the children and the family is the woman, and no **demographic transition** becomes a dividend unless women start participating in the economy — so a separate ecosystem for the care of the aged is a step for women.
  - A question came this year on the **challenges of demographic transition**, and in the steps

taken by Government of India this step could be written: the transition is happening, and along with the workforce of the young, the workforce of the aged is also being prepared.

- **Old-age residential projects:** articles in The Hindu and the Indian Express describe residential systems built specifically to the needs of senior citizens — even the construction is designed for them — in metropolitan areas, and they are heavily priced.
  - Senior citizens are becoming independent: they have their own routine and do not require their children's help.
  - Retired people hold a corpus of **Rs. 25–30 lakh to Rs. 1 crore**, and it has to be utilised in the economy.
  - This makes senior housing a big **real-estate and construction driver**.
- **Japan's silver economy:** senior citizens are experts in their respective fields and constitute a huge economy.
- **Real-estate consultancy:** big European companies are into real-estate consultancy — buildings and malls taken on contract through organised contractors and project management — and they are big recruiters of civil engineers from the top institutes of the country [company names garbled in the transcript].
- **Cross-connection to write:** the old-age economy and geriatrics is one topic, and the **female labour force** is another; the point has to be inserted there, and the articles have to be connected in the mind.

34.2.4 4. Emergency and Trauma Care in District Hospitals

- The budget **upgrades emergency care capacity by 50%** and provides **24x7 emergency care** in district hospitals.
  - The **identified hospitals are 615 district hospitals** (the total number of district hospitals was given as 700 [as stated in lecture]).
- The logic of the step: a trauma patient is not to be taken to AIIMS, Safdarjung or BLK for everything — in an emergency the only concern is that the life is saved, and a life that is bleeding out will not survive the drive.
  - Hence the step focuses on **decentralised health care** and on the **three-tiered health-care** structure: emergency and trauma care must be available in the district hospital itself.

34.2.5 5. NIMHANS 2 in North India

- **NIMHANS 2** is proposed in **North India** for mental health; NIMHANS itself is at **Bengaluru** and was established in the **1960s–70s**.
- **NIMHANS** is a top premier institute for **neuropsychiatry, neuropsychology and neuro-surgery**.
- Why it is needed: mental health is a major concern and a **non-communicable disease** challenge for India; and the **primary health centre is a fully prepared mechanism** to address mental-health concerns, so a NIMHANS doctor's time should go to **research**, not to a cold that any normal doctor in a primary health centre can treat.

34.2.6 6. Five Regional Medical Hubs on a Hub-and-Spoke Model

- **Five regional medical hubs** are being established in **partnership with the private sector (PPP)**, on a **hub-and-spoke model**, as envisaged in the **budget 2026-27**.
  - Write it in brackets in the answer as the **alternative solution as asked in the PYQ** — the question written earlier, asked in 2018, on alternative models.
- A hub is **not a hospital but an integrated ecosystem** — just as there is an education hub or an education city, this is a health hub addressing a very large region.
  - It contains **medical treatment**, **research on diseases**, **medical education**, **research**, **rehabilitation and post-treatment care**, **AYUSH centres** (for someone who wants Ayurveda, a five-day fasting technique or an internal healing regimen) and **medical tourism**.
- **Rehabilitation and post-treatment care** are very important: when a person has had a major ailment or surgery, he requires rehabilitation.
- **Medical tourism:** this can earn a lot of money, and a **special facilitation centre** is required for such patients.
  - NCR example: **Max Vaishali** attracts customers by giving lower prices compared with hospitals like **Fortis** and **Medanta**, and **Medanta is at the top in medical tourism in the NCR**.

34.2.7 7. Cancer Care: Basic Customs Duty Exemption

- The budget gives **BCD exemption** — exemption from **basic customs duty** — on cancer medicines, because cancer medicines are extremely costly.
- The budget has **two parts**: **Part A is expenditure** and **Part B is the revenues** coming from various taxes; it states which taxes have been exempted and for which medicines.
- Cancer medicine names to remember: **trastuzumab**, **isatuximab** [as stated in lecture].
- Addition to the **dual burden** already written: there is an emergence of different types of diseases — **non-communicable diseases**, cancer and **blood sugar in 25–30-year-olds**; a person who went to the gym once had a heart attack and died; even athletes are affected; vaccine side effects feed the same anxiety; health has become a **new fad**.

Health as a Fad: Globalisation and Urbanisation Examples

- **The fad has changed:** when the lecture was of the age of the students, the gym was the fad; now the gym is boring and people go for **hybrid workouts**, running, **hot yoga**, **fast yoga** and **Pilates** — all new techniques.
- **5 a.m. and 6 a.m. running clubs** and **marathons** (New York, Berlin) are all Western concepts, and the focus on health has expanded significantly — these are **globalisation and urbanisation** examples.
- Top **Kenyan and Ethiopian athletes do not come to India**: the Delhi AQI is so high that running 40 km would damage the body, and the performance would take years to recover.
- A mass street event in the **inner circle of Connaught Place** (Delhi), organised by a media house with popular actors and involving the **Commissioner of Police and district officers**, was recalled as taken from a **South American city (possibly Curacao)**, and it has now been discontinued; its exact name was not recalled.

  - It was an example of **community governance and urban political culture** under globalisation and urbanisation.
  - Such an event is impossible in a village; this is the urban culture of meeting new people and forming groups, and it is also how **caste disappears** through intermingling and interaction.
- **Answer-writing:** everything said in the class is an example, not an essay — examples must be quoted in **Paper 1**, more and more of them.

34.2.8 8. Rare Diseases: Customs Duty Exemption

- **Seven additional rare diseases** have been added for **customs duty exemption**.
- **Rare diseases** are diseases that very few people have, and the government gives significant benefits for their treatment; the list has been expanded.

> **GOVERNMENT & POLICY**
>
> **National Policy for Rare Diseases.**
>
> - The policy was launched in **2021–22**.
> - Its name appears in the news and in current-affairs magazines every day, so it has to be known.

34.2.9 9. Strengthening Drug Regulation: CDSCO and the DCGI

- The **Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO)** is under the **Ministry of Health and Family Welfare**, and it is being strengthened — because of **drug regulation**.
- Its head is the **DCGI — Drug Controller General of India** — a very senior **IS officer**, placed by the lecture at the rank of **Additional Secretary** [service as stated in lecture].
  - The DCGI looks after the **licensing of all the drugs and all the factories** in India.
- Why strengthening is necessary: cough syrup sent to **Afghanistan and Central Asia** caused many deaths; the quality of medicines is poor; some salts have no effect at all and are cancelled.
  - Drugs that contained three or four salts have been discontinued — for example **Decol Total**, a combination used for cold and cough — because that drug combination has been **banned by CDSCO**.

34.2.10 10. Ayurveda: New Institutes and the WHO Traditional Medicine Centre

- **Three new All India Institutes of Ayurveda** are to be established.
- The **WHO Global Traditional Medicine Centre at Jamnagar** is to be **upgraded**.

These are the **ten steps given in the budget**. This is the first classification of the steps taken by the Government of India; the second classification is the **traditional steps**.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - The budget 2026-27 gives ten steps for health, with a 10% hike over the revised estimates of 2026.
> - Bio-Pharma Shakti: indigenous biologics and biosimilars, Rs. 10,000 crore over 5 years, three new NIPERs; the US leads in biologics; BioE3 2023 has bio-pharma as a pillar.

- Allied health: ten disciplines — radiology, optometry, anaesthesia, OT technology and rehabilitative professionals — one lakh professionals in five years; it is the answer to raising the female labour force participation rate.
- Care economy: 1.5 lakh caregivers and a separate geriatric ecosystem; old-age housing and Japan's silver economy; the retired hold a corpus of Rs. 25–30 lakh to Rs. 1 crore.
- Emergency and trauma care in district hospitals: a 50% upgrade of emergency capacity, 24x7 care, and 615 identified district hospitals.
- NIMHANS 2 in North India (NIMHANS is at Bengaluru, 1960s–70s, for neuropsychiatry, neuropsychology and neurosurgery) and five regional medical hubs on PPP and a hub-and-spoke model.
- Cancer care gets BCD exemption (Part A expenditure, Part B revenue); seven more rare diseases get customs duty exemption (National Policy for Rare Diseases, 2021–22); CDSCO is strengthened with the DCGI at its head; three new All India Institutes of Ayurveda and an upgraded WHO Global Traditional Medicine Centre at Jamnagar.

34.3 Traditional Steps Taken by the Government of India in Health

After the budget steps, write the **traditional steps**. The **National Health Policy** is the framework document for these steps and has already been written in the earlier class. The order in which they were given is the order below.

34.3.1 1. Ayushman Bharat: Arogya Mandir, PMJAY and Vay Vandana

- **Ayushman Bharat** establishes the **Ayushman Arogya Mandir** for **primary health care — 1.87 lakh** of them — providing **12 packages of comprehensive health care**, including **mental health care**, **elderly care** and **palliative care**.
- **Palliative care** is the soothing dimension of health: where extreme medication or surgery, or a dangerous disease such as cancer, or any extreme acute ailment, has been treated but the chances of recovery are low, the health care given is called palliative care — it soothes and reduces the pain.
  - Illustration: as in the film The Bucket List — the doctor advises proper palliative health care when the number of days, hours or months is limited.
  - It is the stage at which the disease significantly takes a toll on the human body and specialised care of that order is required.
- **PMJAY — PM Jan Arogya Yojana**, again a part of Ayushman Bharat: **Rs. 5 lakh per family per year** for **secondary and tertiary hospitalisation**.
- Coverage: **12 crore vulnerable families** — it is not meant for everyone; for families below 70 years the **socio-economic criteria** apply, while **all persons above 70 years are comprehensively included**, with no concern of any social or economic barrier.

CRITICAL POINT

PMJAY's biggest loophole and its implementation.

- It **does not cater to OPD** — the outpatient department. If a patient goes to a hospital such as Gangaram for OPD treatment, Rs. 3–4 thousand must be paid out of pocket, and Ayushman Bharat does not cover it.
- In theory PMJAY is a **100% cashless insurance scheme**: the requisite documents are presented at the dedicated counter and all the benefits follow.
- At the **implementation stage** there is no significant check on private hospitals, and they misuse their power even against fully deserving beneficiaries.
- **Over-billing:** a treatment of Rs. 2 lakh is shown as Rs. 4 lakh — the extra Rs. 2 lakh goes into the hospital's pocket while the government reimburses the bill; hospitals also charge more so that the patient comes back again and again.

- **Ayushman Vay Vandana** — the scheme for those **above 70 years**, announced by the Prime Minister last year.
  - There is no such concern of any social or economic barrier, and all those above 70 get the benefit.
- **Public versus private health care:** public health is definitely required; private health can only **add on** to public health, and it **cannot replace** public health in a welfare state like India.

EXAMPLE

The implementation gap: Indore and Gujarat.

- In **Indore** the big private hospitals belong to large groups and do not fulfil the details, so patients travel to **Gujarat**, where the implementation of the scheme is smoother and there are fewer hindrances.

34.3.2 2. National Health Mission

- The **National Health Mission (NHM)** is the second major scheme after Ayushman Bharat; it comprises the **National Rural Health Mission (NRHM)** and the **National Urban Health Mission (NUHM)**.
- NHM **finances primary and secondary health infrastructure**, plus **ASHA**, plus other health initiatives.
- **NHM's budgetary spending is Rs. 40,000 crore** — about **40% of the ministry's budget** of roughly **Rs. 1 lakh crore**; all the broad schemes of the ministry sit under NHM.
- Under NHM: **free drugs at public health facilities** and the **free diagnostic service initiative** — some tests are made free, not all.
- The benefit of free drugs and free diagnostics is a reduction in **out-of-pocket expenditure (OOP)**: going to hospital is one thing and PMJAY is another, but **medicines and diagnostics are a different cost altogether**.

34.3.3 3. Maternal Health

- **Janani Suraksha Yojana** — for **institutional deliveries**, so that the maximum number of women deliver in hospitals.
- **PMSMA — Pradhan Mantri Surakshit Matritva Abhiyan** — a **specialist antenatal examina-**

tion on the **9th of every month**; antenatal means before the delivery.

- It covers **pregnant mothers and lactating mothers**: for the first **six months** the child is exclusively breastfed, and after six months **complementary and supplementary food** of the khichdi type is started.
- **SUMAN** — ensuring **assured, respectful and dignified maternal and newborn care with zero denial**.
- **SUMAN Road Map 2030**, launched in **June 2023** — it focuses on the **life cycle and continuum-of-care approach** to maternal and neonatal survival.
- **LaQshya** — ensures **quality improvement in labour rooms and maternity operation theatres (OT)**.
- The **Janani platform** — a digital **longitudinal maternal and child health record**: the weight, the condition and whether a vaccination was given or not.

34.3.4 4. Preventive Health Care: Immunisation

- **UIP — Universal Immunization Programme** — free vaccination. Whenever preventive health care is written, **vaccination must always come to mind**.
- **Mission Indradhanush** — a **catch-up strategy** for children and pregnant women who missed vaccination; it is a **subset of the UIP**, meant for those who could not be covered.
  - COVID-19 is the example: a separate mission was run to promote the **booster dose** among those who had not taken it.
- The **U-WIN portal** — the **digital vaccination platform**: it allows **tracking of due doses** and is integrated with the **Poshan Tracker** and the **Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission**.
- **Example of good integration of data sets:** an **Anganwadi worker** — paid under the **Ministry of Women and Child Development** — gives **take-home ration (THR)** through the **Poshan Tracker**, and because she has access to **U-WIN** she can tell a mother that a **vaccination dose is still pending** and that another vaccine will be needed as the child grows.
  - The vaccination belongs to the **Ministry of Health and Family Welfare** and nutrition to the **Ministry of Women and Child Development**; the integration of the two data sets ensures **coordination**, and that coordination produces **convergence**.
  - **Swiggy analogy:** Swiggy integrated its services — Instamart along with food orders, and it could start an ambulance or a class-notes service tomorrow — and an integrated platform has the data of who uses which service. Integration likewise has a very big role in health and welfare.

> **DATA & FACTS**
>
> **HPV vaccination campaign.**
>
> - A **nationwide HPV vaccination campaign** was launched on **28 February 2026**, with the target of reaching **1.2 crore girls aged 14**.

- India faces a **dual disease burden**, and these vaccination steps are the government's answer to the concern of **non-communicable diseases**.

34.3.5 5. Non-Communicable Diseases: National Programme for Prevention and Control

- The **National Programme for Prevention and Control of Non-Communicable Diseases** focuses on **diabetes**, **hypertension** (high blood pressure), **oral cancer** (from chewing tobacco), **breast cancer**, **cervical cancer**, **heart attack and heart stroke** and other NCDs.
- The approach of the programme is **promotional health**.

34.3.6 6. PM National Dialysis Programme

- The **PM National Dialysis Programme** — the sixth step — gives **free or subsidised dialysis** through **public facilities**.

34.3.7 7. The Cancer Care Spectrum

- Cancer care is a **complete spectrum**: prevention, screening, district care and tertiary care.
- **Prevention: tobacco control**, following a healthy lifestyle, the disclaimer before films that smoking is injurious to health, and the warning that chewing tobacco can cause cancer.
- **Screening:** the earlier cancer is detected, the better. For **breast cancer** a basic regular self-test around the breasts for any **protrusion**, and immediately thereafter a **mammography** test; screening is done for **oral** and **cervical** cancer as well.
- **District care: day-care cancer centres** in district hospitals (announced in the budget). A patient such as one with **leukaemia** needs a blood transfusion, and repeated travel costs a lot of money; the district headquarters is within **40 km** for anyone living in that village.
- **Tertiary care** is available as well, and **PMJAY benefits are given for cancer**.

34.3.8 8. Other Disease Programmes

- **National Tuberculosis Elimination Program**, with an **AI-enabled chatbot** named **Khushi** [as stated in lecture], built to take the push of the programme further.
  - **Mnemonic from the class:** TB is associated with **khansi** (cough), but the chatbot's name is **khushi** (happiness) — the second letter of the consonant series.
- **National AIDS and STD Control Program**.
- **National Mental Health Programme — Tele-MANAS**, which operates **nationally through 53 cells** in **20 languages**; a person can call it and get assistance.
- **Substance use disorder** is one of the packages, and it is very important: the **Nasha Mukti Abhiyan** has been launched and the drug issue is a major concern.
  - The drug issue will be discussed with **internal security** using the **Narcotics Control Bureau's annual report** — the trend of drugs, how they are imported, and a map of it.

34.3.9 9. PM-ABHIM: PM Ayushman Bharat Health Infrastructure Mission

- **PM-ABHIM** — the ninth step — provides for the establishment of **laboratories** and **critical care hospital blocks**.

34.3.10 10. Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission: Digital Health

- **ABDM — Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission** — the tenth step: the aim is to create **DPIs (digital public infrastructures) for health**.

- **ABHA — Ayushman Bharat Health Account** — the health ID.
- The **health facility registry** — where a health facility is.
- The **health care professional registry**.
- **e-Sanjeevani** — India's **national telemedicine system**, connecting **provider-to-provider** and **patient-to-provider** services.

34.3.11 Medicines: Amrit Pharmacy and Jan Aushadhi Kendras

COMPARISON

Two schemes for medicines.

- **Amrit Pharmacy** provides **high-cost medicines plus implants at discounted prices** in tertiary hospitals and some major hospitals.
- **PM Jan Aushadhi Kendra** provides **generic medicines**.
- Both address **high out-of-pocket expenditure**, which has come down by almost **20 basis points in the last 10 years**.

Aushadhi	A concoction made from the commonly available spices, plants and their products in nature	Primarily connected with **Ayurveda**, and with the other Indian systems that follow it
Davai (medicine)	Produced chemically	Modern medicine
Homoeopathy	Has its own medication; it is a science not based in India and was started by a German	One of the systems of medicine under **AYUSH**

34.3.12 National Ayush Mission

- The **National Ayush Mission** [as stated in lecture] is a scheme on which the Government of India has great focus; with this the list of traditional steps ends.

QUICK REVISION

- Ayushman Bharat: 1.87 lakh Ayushman Arogya Mandir with 12 packages including mental health, elderly and palliative care; PMJAY gives Rs. 5 lakh per family per year for secondary and tertiary hospitalisation and covers 12 crore vulnerable families, with all above 70 included (Vay Vandana) — but PMJAY does not cover OPD.
- NHM = NRHM + NUHM, Rs. 40,000 crore, about 40% of the ministry's budget; free drugs and free diagnostics reduce out-of-pocket expenditure.
- Maternal health: Janani Suraksha Yojana, PMSMA on the 9th of every month, SUMAN with its Road Map 2030 (June 2023), LaQshya for labour rooms and maternity OTs, and the Janani

platform.

- Preventive health: UIP, Mission Indradhanush as the catch-up strategy, the U-WIN portal integrated with the Poshan Tracker and ABDM, and the nationwide HPV campaign of 28 February 2026 for 1.2 crore girls aged 14.
- Other programmes: National TB Elimination Program with the Khushi chatbot, National AIDS and STD Control Program, Tele-MANAS (53 cells, 20 languages), the PM National Dialysis Programme, and the full cancer care spectrum.
- Infrastructure and digital health: PM-ABHIM (laboratories and critical care hospital blocks) and ABDM (ABHA health ID, health facility registry, professional registry, e-Sanjeevani telemedicine).
- Medicines: Amrit Pharmacy for high-cost medicines and implants at discounted prices, PM Jan Aushadhi Kendra for generics — OOP is down about 20 basis points in ten years; the National Ayush Mission ends the list.

34.4 Way Forward: Steps Recommended to Fulfil Health for All

Write the way forward as **significant steps recommended to fulfil the vision of health for all**, which is provided in **NHP 2017** — these policies have to be quoted again and again.

1. Increase the fiscal expenditure to **2.5% of GDP** and further increase it to **5% of GDP** — this is **government health expenditure (GHE)**, which includes union, state and local expenditure.
2. Shift from **curative to preventive care** through screenings, school-based programmes and public health campaigns.
3. Address the concern of **equity and the missing middle** and deepen PMJAY by increasing the **Rs. 5 lakh ceiling**, as recommended by the **Parliamentary Standing Committee** in its **170th report**.
4. Regulate private health care by amending the **Clinical Establishment Act 2010**, introducing **transparent price bands** for essential procedures and diagnostics, and rationalising the **price of beds**.
5. Promote **PPP in health** — the example is the PPP mode for the establishment of hospitals in **MP**; and provide support to **health-based startups** for AI-based applications such as risk prediction for high-burden diseases and early cancer detection.
6. Develop **data-based health governance** by integrating data systems: integrated data systems, the creation of **digital data banks connecting public and private data** with adequate **data protection** and a **consent-oriented framework**, leading to a data-driven clinical approach and the creation of a **digital health stack**.
7. Promote **medical tourism** in India — heal by India.
8. Use technology: promote emerging technologies such as **wearables** (watches that measure BP and glucose) and **AI-based remote monitoring**, where the doctor is alerted the moment the BP shoots up and then gives the medicine.
9. Follow the **best practices** of other health-governance models — Kerala, Japan and Thailand (see the table).

10. **Reverse the issues**: efficient drug regulation, proper regulation of private-sector clinical establishments, strengthening of the **CDSCO**, an increase in **medical colleges**, and focus on health infrastructure and on **tertiary care centres**.
11. Promote **efficient primary health care** — the examples of **Thailand and Singapore** can be quoted; primary care acts as a **gateway to a broader continuum of services**.

Kerala	Decentralisation of health governance through efficient **financial devolution**, ensuring efficiency, effectiveness and economy in the implementation of schemes for water supply, schools and Anganwadi centres	The Indian case study of best practice
Japan	**Standardised and mandatory pricing** with **mandatory insurance**	Cited as an international model of best practice
Thailand	**Tax-financed comprehensive coverage**	Cited as an international model of best practice, and with Singapore for primary care acting as a gateway

- **Data-based health governance explained:** if a patient consents and is willing to share his data with the public and private hospitals, data integration can lead to **better clinical history and diagnosis**.
  - There must be a **health card** kind of mechanism — like a university card with a roll number, a photograph and the entire health record of every visit, the facilities used and the medicines given.
  - **Privacy and consent** are the concerns; if there is a **strong legal framework**, this will help better clinical diagnosis and better treatment, and the data can be fed into an **AI-based data system** to develop **AI models for clinical diagnosis**.
- **The recommendation and its status:** the integration was recommended by **R.S. Sharma** in the Indian Express; he was also the **chairman of the CEA** and played a very important role in one of the **DPI projects**.
  - The concerns that emerged because of **data sharing** are known, so this remains a recommendation that has not happened [as stated in lecture].
  - At present the patient's history is not integrated — the basic details are integrated in the ABHA card, but the health record itself is not.
- **A caution raised in class:** whether AI-based models generate **false positives** — the concern was discussed with respect to the application of AI-based models.

Consequences of good health are very simple, and they are the same as the **consequences of education** — the lecture said they would be written later.

QUICK REVISION

- Way forward is written as significant steps to fulfil the vision of health for all given in NHP 2017, which must be quoted again and again.
- GHE is to go to 2.5% of GDP and then 5% of GDP, covering union, state and local expenditure.
- Shift from curative to preventive care; address equity and the missing middle; deepen PMJAY to a Rs. 5 lakh ceiling as recommended by the Parliamentary Standing Committee in its 170th report.
- Regulate private health care through the Clinical Establishment Act 2010, transparent price bands and rationalised bed prices; promote PPP (hospitals in MP) and health-based startups.
- Data-based health governance: digital data banks connecting public and private data, data protection, consent-oriented framework, digital health stack — the R.S. Sharma recommendation, based on the health-card idea.
- Best practices: Kerala (financial devolution and decentralisation), Japan (standardised mandatory pricing and mandatory insurance) and Thailand (tax-financed comprehensive coverage).
- Reverse the issues (drug regulation, CDSCO, private establishments, medical colleges, tertiary care) and promote efficient primary health care, with Thailand and Singapore as examples.

34.5 AI in Health

Write down this question: **Artificial intelligence has great applications in the health sector. Do you agree? Give examples, and provide a list of challenges/issues concerning AI in health.** The answer has **two parts of about 120 words each**, and it is to be written in **12 minutes**.

Structure of the answer: write the **applications first** and then the **list of challenges**. Introduce with the NHP focus on **health for all**, in which AI has a significant role to contribute; the **diagram of health for all** can be drawn; the idea has to be **demystified for the examiner** with diagrams.

34.5.1 Applications of AI in Health

- **1. Disease surveillance:** AI can scan **disease-related and epidemiological data**, data **from the media** and **health system data** for **unusual disease patterns and early warning**.
  - It helps in **preventive health planning**, identifies **hotspots**, and helps in better **direction or diversion of resources**.
  - Example: **vulnerability mapping for TB** by combining data from socio-economic groups.
- **2. Disease detection:** AI can detect with the help of **cough-analysis data and X-ray data for TB** — the example is **cough-against-TB**, which has helped in improving the **target yield** and in better targeting.
- **3. Detection from images:** AI can analyse **CT scan and retinal images and other images** to detect abnormalities — the example is **diabetic retinopathy**, where AI is helping **non-specialist workers** detect it.
  - High sugar in diabetes causes blindness, so a retina scan is essential; detection from the

images is not something very tough to do.

- **4. Telemedicine — the lecture's fourth point: AI and telemedicine** can compensate for the **shortage and uneven distribution of specialists**.
  - There may be several villages and one main hospital; with an AI system the medical concerns of the villages can be addressed simultaneously — a primary health centre can put its scans into the AI system, the easy ones are handled by AI and the tough ones are analysed by the doctor.
  - **Automation illustration:** an AI chatbot can handle routine queries — about the magazine, or back-end course queries — and route only the nuanced ones to the mentor, freeing an hour that can be used to plan the syllabus or automate other areas; the same logic applies to monitoring news sources so that anything new is flagged immediately.
- **5. Cancer treatment:** AI can analyse medical data for the treatment of **cervical and breast cancer**; the example was recently showcased at the **BRICS Bharat Innovates platform**.
- **6. Risk prediction:** AI can identify the patients who are likely to **deteriorate or suffer adverse outcomes**, and therefore helps in **early targeting**.
  - Example: the **Ministry of Health and Family Welfare** has deployed AI prediction of **adverse TB outcomes**.
- **7. Patient referral:** AI can **separate low-risk from high-risk patients**; this is done by **Madhunetra AI**, which recommends the **ophthalmologist**.
  - This ensures a **continuum of care** and reduces the burden on **tertiary health centres** — the biggest problem is that all patients go to tertiary care, and with AI the low-risk patients can be segregated at the primary level itself.
- **8. Drug discovery:** AI can **screen molecules and data** and thereby accelerate drug discovery, leading to a **shortening of the research timeline** and **lower costs**, which lowers drug prices and **reduces OOP**.
- **9. Precision or targeted medication:** AI enables the analysis of **large data sets** — medical data, genomic data, drug clinical-trial data and patient data — and helps suggest **the best drug suited to the patient**.
  - **Precision or targeted treatment** gives a person a specific medicine based on his **genetic makeup, history, genomics and proteomics**. This is different from what is done today, where medicines are simply prescribed on the basis of the medical ailment; precision treatment is based on the genomic data, and for that the entire DNA sequence has to be analysed — AI does it at a very easy pace.
  - Example: the **Nobel Prize 2024 in Chemistry** for the discovery of the protein structure of **200 million proteins** with the help of AI — the work was done under **Google DeepMind** by two or three scientists whose names the lecture could not recall.
  - Proteins are the **building block of life**; if the **structure** of a protein is known, its **function** is automatically known — so to understand life, to develop **biologics** and to develop medicines, the knowledge of the structure is needed.
  - With AI they also **created artificial proteins** in the lab based on the function that the protein was required to perform.
  - **Geoffrey Hinton** is named as the father of AI and machine learning (physics Nobel); he

wrote a **2010 paper** analysing how the **neural networks in the brain** work — the **synaptic connections** that develop between neurons. **Alan Turing** is the mathematician on whom a film was made.

  - **Genomic data:** ethnicity, parental history, genome and diet differ from person to person — lactose intolerance, genetic predisposition to cancer or diabetes. **Whole-genome mapping** costs **Rs. 15,000–20,000** (a student last year quoted Rs. 24,000), and the DNA carries **3.2 × 10 to the power 8 billion base pairs**; from the genome the **propensity to disease** can be known in advance.
  - **The ethical and personal debate:** if the genome data is leaked, an insurer may refuse cover after seeing that the person's time is nearly up — the example given was of an insurance company.

- **10. Administrative efficiency:** improving **hospital workflow — documentation automation**, **voice-to-text** converting a doctor's speech into a **prescription** (a study by the **Ministry of Health and Family Welfare**), **scheduling of appointments** and analysing **patient flow**.
  - A data set from one ministry's website can be integrated with another ministry's with the help of an AI tool by designing a **simple API**.
- **11. Medical education and workforce support: simulation**, **decision support** (as ChatGPT is a decision support system) and **adaptive learning**; care must be taken that **AI augments rather than replaces doctors**.
  - **Job displacement:** many low-skilled jobs will be replaced; in the civil services the **content-development vertical will be totally eliminated** and **test series** will also be replaced, with **mentors** — people who have taken the examination — sharing their own individual insights; the task now is to **map the content** that is important for the examination, which is somewhere AI is not very nuanced.
- **12. One Health approach:** AI can analyse **animal disease patterns** and identify **zoonotic diseases**.
  - With a large data set of the pockets that have a past history of the **Nipah virus** or **canine distemper**, AI can predict the future risk of a **viral outflow** from that particular area to another.

34.5.2 Challenges Concerning AI in Health

- **Data exploitation:** the integrated data system and AI can be **exploited** — the doubt raised in class was whether they can exploit the data, and the answer was: **yes, they can absolutely exploit the data**.
  - Because of this, **data protection** and a **consent-oriented framework** are the conditions on which AI in health can be used.
- **Bias across groups:** there must be a proper **evaluation of the application across gender and demographic groups**.
- **Diversity in data sets:** the data sets used for AI must be **diverse**.
- **Transparency:** there must be **transparency regarding the recommendations** given by AI platforms.
- **Monitoring and audit:** there must be **rigorous post-deployment monitoring and audit** of

AI systems.

34.5.3 The Thought Framework for the Answer

Think like this: for **each and every head — individual, hospital, doctors, nurses, allied health care, governance, technology and equity** — you will have the applications of AI.

- **Individual:** disease detection, disease screening and disease surveillance.
- **Doctors:** telemedicine — AI works as an **assisting tool** — and adaptive learning.
- **Nurses and healthcare staff:** they will devote their time to **upskilling**, because the basic trends can be analysed by them, and AI can help them **brief the doctor**.
- **Hospital:** hospital workload, hospital **patient management**, hospital **financial management**, overall working efficiency, and **scheduling of patients and appointments**.
  - In **equity**: AI can help **underserved areas** where, instead of ten doctors, only one is required; the data analysis can be upskilled by **training the frontline workers**, and **remote sensing** can be integrated with AI.
- **Governance:** AI can help in improving the **government data set**, in **integration**, and in addressing **which schemes are required for a particular area or a section** — all of this with examples.

QUICK REVISION

- AI in health answer: two parts of about 120 words each — applications with examples, then a list of challenges — written in 12 minutes, with health for all and its diagram in the introduction.
- Applications: disease surveillance (unusual patterns, early warning, TB vulnerability mapping), disease detection (cough-analysis and X-ray data; cough-against-TB improved the target yield), detection from CT and retinal images (diabetic retinopathy), telemedicine (shortage of specialists), cancer treatment (BRICS Bharat Innovates), risk prediction (adverse TB outcomes), patient referral (Madhunetra AI), drug discovery, precision medicine, administrative efficiency and medical education.
- Precision medicine rests on data sets — genomic, medical, clinical-trial and patient data; the Nobel Prize 2024 in Chemistry was for the protein structure of 200 million proteins; genome mapping costs Rs. 15,000–20,000 and the genome is 3.2×10 to the power 8 billion base pairs.
- Administrative efficiency: documentation automation, voice-to-text into prescriptions, appointment scheduling and patient-flow analysis, with simple APIs joining ministry data sets.
- One Health: AI analyses animal disease patterns and identifies zoonotic diseases, predicting viral outflows from Nipah virus or canine distemper pockets.
- Challenges: data exploitation, bias across gender and demographic groups, diversity of data sets, transparency of recommendations, and rigorous post-deployment monitoring and audit.
- The thought framework: individual, hospital, doctors, nurses, allied health care, governance, technology and equity — with examples for each.

CHAPTER 35

Health — Part 4

35.1 AI in Health: Framework of Challenges

The challenges of applying AI in health are the same as the challenges of AI in general; AI is treated here as a topic in its own right.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Initial framing.**
>
> - **Data-related concerns** — the first challenge.
> - **Privacy** — an emerging concern.
> - **Technological constraints** — India's AI systems' dependence on Western technologies.

Technical	Clinical accuracy, patient safety and model reliability
Ethical	Consent, autonomy and the human dimension of care
Data governance	Privacy, cybersecurity and data ownership (DPDP Act)
Legal	Liability for harm and regulatory gaps
Equity	Digital divide between urban and backward regions
Other	Upskilling, de-skilling, dependence and absorption capacity

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **Who builds the AI.**
>
> - Most AI work is done by **private players** — ChatGPT, Anthropic — with whom one must sign a contract.
> - Indian alternatives exist: **Bhashini** (built by the Indian government), **Sarvam AI**, **Hanuman AI**, and many other Indian companies working in AI and taking funding.

QUICK REVISION

- AI challenges in health = AI challenges in general.
- Initial trio: data-related concerns, privacy, and dependence on Western technology.
- Six categories: technical, ethical, data governance, legal, equity, other.
- AI is dominated by private players (ChatGPT, Anthropic); Indian options include Bhashini, Sarvam AI and Hanuman AI.
- The categories are then taken up one by one.

35.2 Technical Challenges

Technical challenges are the first category, and its issues are taken up one by one.

35.2.1 Clinical Accuracy and Patient Safety

The first issue is **clinical accuracy and patient safety** — AI can generate false positives, false negatives or incorrect clinical recommendations.

COMPARISON

False positive vs false negative.

- **False positive**: AI reports a disease the patient does not have — e.g., a chest scan flagged for TB in a person who has no TB.
- **False negative**: AI misses a disease the patient actually has.

- AI can also make an **incorrect clinical recommendation**.

EXAMPLE

An error in detection can delay treatment — for example, in cancer or TB.

35.2.2 Data Diversity and Generalisability

- The AI model's algorithm may not factor in **genetic, regional, gender and cultural diversity**.
- A model trained on one dataset **may not perform elsewhere**.
- Models are trained on **limited data** — ChatGPT is the best example; it was historically trained on a limited set of people and does not fit India's many languages, ways of communication and cultural responses.

EXAMPLE

India's diversity requires diverse datasets. Even this single classroom has people from so many states; a disease-detection model would need to incorporate that in-built diversity. If the data is not there, the model gives generalised results and **AI becomes of no use**.

35.2.3 Algorithmic Bias

- AI models are already seen to be **urban- and male-centric**.
- They may **underperform** for the rural, the poor, tribal communities and women, and **repro-**

duce existing inequalities as **algorithmic inequality**.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> - Take a person from a deprived tribe in Jharkhand against urban mainland users: the model was trained on urban private-hospital data and is now applied to the tribal patient. The patient already lacks healthcare access; when the urban-trained model returns false positives and negatives for them, it perpetuates the existing inequality and creates algorithmic inequality.
> - AI should have addressed this health inequality and helped doctors use AI to set up clinics in such areas. Instead, the model is applied for urban patients and not for the tribal patient, so the benefit stays with those on whom the model was trained.

35.2.4 The Black Box Problem

The **black box problem** implies that doctors or patients would know the AI's recommendation without understanding how it reached the conclusion.

- There is no sound explanation behind the recommendation; when the model is asked for the reason, it starts **hallucinating** in order to justify its output.
- A doctor reading such a diagnosis for a patient cannot establish why a particular suggestion was made.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Technical issue #1 — clinical accuracy and patient safety: false positives, false negatives, incorrect clinical recommendations.
> - Detection errors delay treatment (cancer, TB).
> - Technical issue #2 — data diversity: models do not factor genetic, regional, gender and cultural diversity and may not perform elsewhere.
> - Technical issue #3 — algorithmic bias: urban/male-centric models underperform for rural, poor, tribal and women users and create algorithmic inequality.
> - Black box problem: recommendations come without an understandable reasoning, and the model hallucinates to justify them.

35.3 Data Challenges: Poor and Fragmented Data

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Without data, there is no AI.**

- India suffers from **poor and fragmented data**.
  - Fragmented across hospitals.
  - Fragmented across ministries.
  - Most importantly, fragmented across states.
- States ruled by different political parties do not share data with one another — a state ruled by one party will not give its data to a state ruled by another party.

  - For example, a state governed by one party would not share data with a state governed by its rival party.
- **Data is oil** — a highly valuable resource.
- The data sits unintegrated across states, laboratories and government schemes.
- The consequence is **limited high-quality data and therefore limited application of AI**. If high-quality data does not exist in India, foreign models must be brought in at a hefty cost, and they will not reflect India's reality.

EXAMPLE

- Data integration is missing: integrating a child's school attendance data, Poshan Tracker nutrition data and National Health Mission health data would let one understand the child's performance.
- With such integration one could check on the child's UIN whether the vaccine was taken or not, trace the child's nutritional standard from age 4–5, and explain why the child tops the school in class 10 — perhaps through a diet element present from early childhood.
- This integration of data is what is missing today.

QUICK REVISION

- Without data there is no AI.
- India's data is poor and fragmented — across hospitals, ministries and, most of all, states.
- Political rivalry between states blocks data sharing.
- Data is oil; it stays unintegrated across states, laboratories and government schemes.
- Consequence: limited high-quality data → limited application of AI and dependence on costly foreign models.

35.4 Ethical Challenges

There are certain ethical constraints on AI in health.

35.4.1 Informed Consent

- **Informed consent** of the data is required.
- The patient would not know the use of the data, the data sharing, or the **secondary use** of the data — which itself leads to ethical challenges.

35.4.2 Patient Autonomy

KEY CONCEPT

Doctors might be **replaced by machines**, leading to **compromised patient autonomy** to accept or deny treatment.

- If an AI model dictates the treatment (as already happens in private hospitals), autonomous health systems put the patient in the hands of a few multinational corporations that build

these AI models.
  - Today a patient can seek a second opinion and can talk to the doctor; under an AI-driven framework the patient cannot refuse a treatment that the model has prescribed.
- **Patient autonomy** also includes the right to **die with dignity** — the right to deny treatment.
  - One cannot be forced to take injections and medicines if one wishes to die peacefully or to practise **Sallekhana**.
  - If AI increasingly creates autonomous systems, the patient's right to deny treatment gets compromised.

35.4.3 Doctor–Patient Relationship

- AI can lead to the **weakening of the doctor–patient relationship**.
- **Empathy and contextual judgment** are necessary, because healthcare involves psychological and ethical considerations.
- AI excludes the human interface and the humanistic influence of the doctor, thereby evading the human–doctor–patient relationship and the human aspect of treatment.

QUICK REVISION

- Ethical constraint 1 — informed consent: required for data; the patient does not know the use, sharing or secondary use of data.
- Ethical constraint 2 — autonomy: doctors replaced by machines compromise the patient's right to accept or deny treatment.
- Patient autonomy includes the right to die with dignity and to practise Sallekhana.
- Ethical constraint 3 — the human dimension: weakening of the doctor–patient relationship, empathy and contextual judgment.

35.5 Data Governance Challenges

35.5.1 Privacy

- AI models require access to **high-quality but sensitive health information** — genomic data, reproductive data and mental health data.
- This exposes risks of **hacking, unauthorized sharing, commercial exploitation and dangerous profiling**.

EXAMPLE

- Several **paternity suits** have been filed — secrets hidden inside families for generations have been revealed by genomic mapping.
- People who called someone dad or mom discovered that their father or mother was not their biological parent; this was reported in the press last year.

- Data can be **misused**: app downloads and data-based services collect data, and the student data of a coaching institute is oil for others.
  - Hence the risk of **commercial exploitation, hacking and unauthorized sharing**, as

happens in coaching institutes.
  - Whatever apps you keep on your phone share your data.

> **GOVERNMENT & POLICY**
>
> **DPDP Act as a shield.**
>
> - One can tell an unauthorised caller that one has read the **DPDP Act** — section 19, clause 4, sub-clause C — and will sue them; the caller then stops calling.

35.5.2 Cybersecurity

- AI systems are **digitally interconnected** and so increase the **attack surface** of hospitals and national health infrastructure.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> The **AIIMS ransomware attack** is the example — such an attack can disrupt **critical health services**.

35.5.3 Data Ownership

- A key question is **who owns patient data** that is used to train an AI model.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Privacy: AI needs sensitive data (genomic, reproductive, mental health) → hacking, unauthorized sharing, commercial exploitation and profiling.
> - Genomic mapping has triggered paternity suits that exposed long-hidden family secrets.
> - Data misuse: app downloads and coaching-institute student data carry commercial-exploitation and sharing risks.
> - Under the DPDP Act one can invoke section 19, clause 4, sub-clause C against unauthorised callers.
> - Cybersecurity: interconnected AI systems widen the attack surface of hospitals and national health infrastructure (AIIMS ransomware attack).
> - Data ownership: who owns the patient data used to train the model remains unresolved.

35.6 Legal and Regulatory Challenges

35.6.1 Medical Liability

- Where **AI caused harm or a wrong treatment**, responsibility is unclear.
  - It can involve the doctor who read the output, the hospital, the developer, the software updater, or the device manufacturer.

35.6.2 Regulatory Gaps

- Health regulations are designed for **traditional health systems**, which were static, whereas **AI-enabled systems are evolving rapidly**.

DATA & FACTS

There is **no separate law** regulating AI in health, and even the rules of the **DPDP Act, 2023** were notified only recently (in 2026).

35.6.3 *Post-Deployment Monitoring*

- There is **no statutory or administrative mechanism** to evaluate post-deployment monitoring.

EXAMPLE

Emerging industry trend.

- New companies train AI models and hire people by skill, paying rates based on their engagement, to improve data.
- Such a company uses the hired person's skill to improvise on already-available data and then sells it to **Anthropic/Claude** (and similarly to OpenAI, X and Google).
- Instead of training and paying every person for a better model, the big firms have **outsourced model improvement to individuals**.

QUICK REVISION

- Medical liability: when AI causes harm or wrong treatment, who is responsible — doctor, hospital, developer, software updater or device manufacturer?
- Regulatory gap: static traditional-health regulations cannot govern rapidly evolving AI-enabled systems.
- No separate law regulates AI in health; DPDP Act 2023 rules were notified only recently (2026).
- No statutory or administrative mechanism for post-deployment monitoring.
- Big AI firms now outsource data-improvement work to individuals and buy the refined data.

35.7 Equity Challenges

CRITICAL POINT

The equity challenge creates a **digital divide**: urban regions, doctors and hospitals benefit faster than remote, backward regions and primary health centres, so the divide widens.

- AI needs **digital records, connectivity, electricity, devices and trained personnel** — the very things lagging regions lack.
  - Hence AI benefits those already better connected and leaves the rest further behind.

QUICK REVISION

- Equity challenge = digital divide.
- Urban regions, doctors and hospitals gain faster than remote/backward regions and primary health centres.

- Cause: AI depends on digital records, connectivity, electricity, devices and trained personnel.
- Effect: the gap between the connected and the lagging widens.

35.8 Other Challenges

- **Upskilling** is required: as a student and as an aspirant one has to be very smart, because everything is moving very fast.
- **Dependence on app/product developers** → uncertainty in the ownership of health data, **opaque algorithms**, and difficulty in analysing the rapidly changing pace of AI products.
- **De-skilling** caused by too much dependence on AI models.
- **Cognitive decline**: heavy AI dependence has been felt to weaken general skills and reduce reading speed over time.
- **Limited absorption capacity**: AI might identify a disease, but this becomes fruitful only if India simultaneously has (1) specialists, (2) a referral system, and (3) medicines and treatment capacity.
- **AI-based automation is skill-dependent**, which limits its application at the regional or national level.

EXAMPLE

De-skilling illustration.

- Earlier one used a basic sense of direction and analysis to get out of an unfamiliar area onto the main road; today, even the route home is driven by Google Maps, used at least for the ETA.
- Likewise, replying to every mail through ChatGPT erodes basic communication and grammatical skills.
- The sense of human connection and the ingenuity that people once possessed is being lost.

QUICK REVISION

- Upskilling is essential because the field moves very fast.
- Dependence on app/product developers brings uncertainty over health-data ownership and opaque algorithms.
- De-skilling and cognitive decline follow from over-reliance on AI (navigation, email, grammar).
- Limited absorption capacity: AI diagnosis is fruitful only with specialists, a referral system, and medicines/treatment capacity.
- AI-based automation is skill-dependent and thus limited at the regional/national level.

35.9 Way Forward and Government Steps

- The Government of India **banned GPT (ChatGPT)** through a released order; industry consultants reported that they used to use ChatGPT frequently. The ban came a few months

ago.

- Such a ban is a **knee-jerk reaction** and is not the right approach.
- Where AI is to be used, hospitals should adopt it for **billing, cashier, payment and scheduling**.
- For the **steps taken by the Government of India**, refer to the **addendum notes** (extra material given separately).

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

All the PYQs on this topic can now be attempted.

QUICK REVISION

- The Government of India ordered a ban on GPT (ChatGPT) a few months ago.
- The ban is a knee-jerk reaction and not the right approach.
- Hospitals can adopt AI for billing, cashier, payment and scheduling.
- Government steps are given in the addendum notes.
- All PYQs on this topic can now be attempted.

CHAPTER 36

Regulatory Bodies

36.1 Regulatory Bodies: Syllabus Placement, Context and PYQ Trends

The commissions have already been done. This topic is taken up today because it is also part of the syllabus, and two or three questions have come from it.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **What kind of topic this is.**
>
> - It is primarily a **conceptual topic** — a **core governance concept**. The idea is to absorb the concept, take the write-up and be prepared if any question comes from this area in the examination.
> - Heading to write down: **Regulatory Bodies**.

36.1.1 Where It Sits

- **Regulatory Bodies** lies in **General Studies Paper 2**, and within GS2 in **Polity**.
- Within Polity the course has covered **Regulatory Bodies**, **Constitutional Bodies** and the **Commissions**.
- Under the constitutional-bodies head: the **CAG**, the **Attorney General** and the **Finance Commission**; then a discussion of the **NHRC** and various commissions; then the **CBI** (a current affair) and the **Lokpal**.
- The **CBI** was in the news in **2018**; the **Lokpal** needs no separate class — the material will be provided.
- Today's subject is the **theoretical aspect** of regulatory bodies. The Attorney General is a separate class and will be taken with the other areas of Polity; **tribunals** will be discussed later.
- Interesting areas are being taken first. This is a **theoretical topic** which is usually **not taught**, so a **theoretical approach** is needed — the same theoretical approach applies to governance.
- There are **various regulatory bodies — RBI, PFRDA, IRDA, TRAI** and the **Central Electricity Regulatory Commission** — a **plethora of bodies**; studying every one of them is **next to impossible**.
- Hence the attempt is only to understand the **theoretical framework**, which is not available anywhere else and will not be taught elsewhere; it is still taken up so that a framework can be given.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

PYQs on regulatory bodies.

- **What is the need for regulatory bodies to be independent and autonomous?**
- The **Rail Tariff Authority** — asked as a **12.5-marker in 2014**, framed on **reforms in railways**.
- The **merger of SEBI and IRDA** — asked in **2013**, the first year [the lecture first said SBI and IRDA], arising out of **overlapping products**.

- The core of the topic: **why regulators should be independent and autonomous**, and **what their role is**.
- The **independence of regulatory bodies** is one question that has come in the **Mains** examination so far.

QUICK REVISION

- **Regulatory Bodies** sits in **GS2, in Polity**, alongside the constitutional bodies and the commissions.
- It is a **conceptual, core-governance** topic; the material is not available anywhere else and gives the theoretical framework.
- There is a **plethora of regulators** — RBI, PFRDA, IRDA, TRAI, Central Electricity Regulatory Commission — so studying each one is impossible.
- PYQs: the **need for regulatory bodies to be independent and autonomous**; the **Rail Tariff Authority** in **2014 (12.5 marks)**; the **SEBI–IRDA merger** in **2013**.
- The independence of regulatory bodies is a question that has come in **Mains** so far.

36.2 Structure of the Discussion

The structure of this topic is simple and is laid out in **four to five points**.

1. **Define what regulators are** — for example, the coaching industry also needs a separate regulator, because the practices of the coaching industry and of the coaching institutes need to be regulated.
2. **Why they are required.**
3. **The PYQ — the reasons for their independence and autonomy**; the meaning of both words must also be understood here.
4. **The issues or challenges faced.**
5. **Way forward.**

- The concept will be taught first, along with a **basic analogy**.
- After the concept, students must say from their own basic understanding what the **various issues, challenges or concerns faced by regulators** are.
- Hint for that assignment: the **issues and challenges faced by the NHRC** have already been discussed, and so have the **structural and functional issues of the commissions** — the same **structural-functional approach** has to be attempted and shown in class.

  - Take two days; write it and show it by this week. The write-up will be done in the next GS2 class — write it yourself first.
- Writing the **issues and the functions** will itself give you the question, because a question will come from it; the hints are given here — collate both and write the answer.
- You must start **writing on your own**, seeing the question paper.

QUICK REVISION

- Structure the topic in **four to five heads**: definition, why they are required, the PYQ on independence and autonomy, the issues or challenges, and the way forward.
- A **basic analogy** precedes the student task on issues and challenges.
- Students must write the **issues and functions** of regulators themselves, using the **structural-functional approach** already applied to the NHRC and the commissions.
- Writing those issues generates the question — collate the hints and write the answer.
- Timeline: two days, written and shown by this week, with the write-up in the next GS2 class.

36.3 What Is a Regulator? Definition and Examples

The first thing to settle is **what a regulator is** — or, better, **who a regulator is**.

KEY CONCEPT

Definition of a regulator.

- A regulator is a **public authority**.
- It is **entrusted with laying down, supervising and enforcing rules**.
- The rules **govern a particular market, sector, profession or activity**.
- The object is **to uphold the public interest**.

A parallel mechanism is created **away from the state**: it **represents the state** but is **different from the state** — different from the government or the central government. It is a separate institution that will regulate that particular sector.

36.3.1 The Coaching-Institute Illustration

- Different coaching institutes provide services — they perform the function of providing coaching for a particular examination — and they run under a **policy framework**; a policy framework is required if coaching institutes are to work willfully.
- Within that policy framework the **Government of Delhi** or the **Government of India** can make a **National Coaching Institute Regulation Act**.
- The **Ministry of Education** can make a broad **National Coaching Institute Policy** — on the lines of the **NEP (New Education Policy)**.
- Because there are so many coaching institutes — and the government may itself establish its own — a **third-party regulator** is needed so that the government can give the policy framework and provide the **space to flourish**.
- People are using the services of those institutes, so an authority is needed that can **draw**

regulations, **write down rules** and ensure the **fulfilment of public activity in the public interest**.

36.3.2 The Regulators: The Illustrative List

RBI	Banking
IRDA (Insurance Regulatory Development Authority)	Insurance products
PFRDA (Pension Fund Regulatory Development Authority)	Pension products
SEBI	Stock markets, that is, securities
TRAI	The telecom sector — tariffs, quality of service, consumer protection
CCI (Competition Commission of India)	Market competition, across sectors
PNGRB (Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board)	Pipelines and city gas distribution
Airports Economic Regulatory Authority (AERA)	Air tariffs
FSSAI	Food safety
IBBI (Insolvency and Bankruptcy Board of India)	Insolvency professionals, insolvency agencies and information utilities
NMC (National Medical Commission)	The medical profession — doctors
BCI (Bar Council of India)	The legal profession — lawyers
ICAI (Institute of Chartered Accountants of India)	Chartered accountants

- **RBI** represents the state — it is not a private institution — and it regulates banks.
- The insurance market has **LIC** and **HDFC**; if there were no regulator, people would say the government makes the policies and itself gives insurance, so how would it protect the public interest, having no regulatory separation — hence **IRDA for insurance products**.
- **TRAI**: if pesky calls and unnecessary marketing messages come, TRAI's rules and regulations cover them — and since those messages are given by **BSNL, Jio, Vodafone and Airtel**, a **separate tier** is required.
- **CCI** promotes healthy competition: in e-commerce there are **Blinkit, Zepto and Swiggy Instamart**, so there is no monopolisation by one agency; in **UPI** there are **PhonePe, Paytm and Google Pay** — so many apps.
- **Airports Economic Regulatory Authority** is often in the news asking that development

charges be reduced, because tariffs shot up during **COVID** — that is when AERA came into the picture to regulate tariffs.

- **FSSAI** also **prevents adulteration** and **generates awareness**.
- **IBBI**: if any company becomes bankrupt, specific individuals — a **CA**, a **CS** or a **CFA** — carry out the task of the resolution of that company; they are called **insolvency professionals**.
  - The other two are the **insolvency agencies** and the **information utilities**; all three are connected with implementation of the **Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC)**.
  - Their details need not be known — IBBI regulates them.
- **UGC** is also a regulatory authority.
- **Professional regulators** regulate the professions: **NMC (National Medical Commission)** for the medical profession — it regulates doctors; **BCI (Bar Council of India)** regulates lawyers; **ICAI (Institute of Chartered Accountants of India)** regulates chartered accountants.
  - BCI has been in the news: its Chairman said he would take the names of **NALSAR** students, and it was replied that this is completely wrong as he has no such rights [as stated in lecture].

QUICK REVISION

- Definition: a **public authority** entrusted with **laying down, supervising and enforcing rules** governing a **market, sector, profession or activity**, to uphold the **public interest**.
- It is a **parallel mechanism away from the state** — it represents the state but is different from it.
- Illustration: a **National Coaching Institute Regulation Act** and a **National Coaching Institute Policy** on the lines of the **NEP**.
- Sectoral regulators: **RBI** (banks), **IRDA** (insurance), **PFRDA** (pension), **SEBI** (securities), **TRAI** (telecom), **CCI** (competition), **PNGRB** (pipelines and city gas), **AERA** (air tariffs), **FSSAI** (food safety), **IBBI** (insolvency).
- **UGC** is also a regulatory authority.
- Professional regulators: **NMC** (doctors), **BCI** (lawyers), **ICAI** (chartered accountants).

36.4 The Framework: State, Service Providers and the Regulator

Broadly the framework has three standing parts: the **state or government**, the **service providers** and the **regulator**.

- **The government sets the overall policy framework** and provides an **enabling environment**.
- The government wants coaching institutes to work, and wants different telecom companies to perform their role — so the government is **one player** in the sector.
- **Service providers** may be **public** or **private**.
- In telecom, the public players are **BSNL** and **MTNL**; the private players are **Jio**, **Airtel** and **Vodafone**, which became **Vi**.
- The basic policy environment in telecom is the **National Telecommunication Policy**.

- The government was providing the policy parameters and a law; meanwhile the service providers kept increasing and the telecom sector kept growing — and now comes the **need for a regulator**.
- The same is happening with coaching institutes: job opportunities increased in India and there are coaching institutes for every examination, so their regulation has now become a question.
  - You do not regulate the sector first so that it settles. You **first promote** the sector — with both public and private players — and **once it is promoted**, you have a **regulator**.
- The regulator then stands **away from both**: it has to be **independent of the government** and **cannot have any influence of the government**.

EXAMPLE

Why the regulator must stand away from the government.

- Otherwise the government would say that **BSNL** alone should be promoted and that in **Karol Bagh** internet can be provided only by BSNL — that **distorts consumer interest**.
- The government must therefore ensure that there is **no interference in the regulator**.
- The regulator is a **sarkari body** — think of **RBI** — but that does not mean the government puts its own people into it: **RBI has a board of six people**.

QUICK REVISION

- Three tiers: **government (policy framework and enabling environment)** → **service providers (public and private)** → **regulator**.
- You **promote first and regulate later**; once created, the regulator stands **away from both** the government and the private players.
- Telecom example: **BSNL and MTNL** (public) against **Jio, Airtel and Vodafone/Vi** (private), under the **National Telecommunication Policy**.
- The regulator is a **sarkari body**, yet the government does not put its own people into it — **RBI has a board of six people**.
- Without that distance from the government, promotions such as BSNL-only internet in **Karol Bagh** distort consumer interest.

36.5 The Three Functions of a Regulator

A regulator broadly performs **three functions** — it regulates through a **quasi-legislative**, a **quasi-executive** and a **quasi-judicial** function.

KEY CONCEPT

What 'quasi' means.

- **Quasi** means **like** — the analogy: he looks like Salman Khan, but he is not Salman Khan (a double role cannot happen in real life).
- So regulators are **not** legislative bodies, **not** judicial bodies and **not** executive bodies, but they perform functions which are **quasi-legislative, quasi-executive and quasi-judicial**.

36.5.1 1. The Quasi-Legislative Function

- Regulators **issue rules and issue regulations** — rules and regulations are made by regulators — and that is exactly what a **law passed by Parliament** does.
- Laws or statutory enactments — a **constitutional amendment**, a **law** — can be passed **only by the legislature**; but regulators make rules and regulations. That is the **quasi-legislative function**, that is, **delegated legislation**.
- **Delegated legislation** means the legislature gives responsibility to the executive: when any statutory body is created, power is usually given by a law, and in that law it is said that the body may make **rules and regulations for its own functioning**.

36.5.2 2. The Quasi-Executive Function

- They **ensure implementation**.
- If there is no proper function performed, they **carry out investigation** and they also perform the task of **monitoring** and **inspection** — as the **NHRC** and all the commissions investigate and inquire.
- Investigation is conducted by **IPS officers**, who conduct proceedings over **inspections, investigations and inquiries**.

36.5.3 3. The Quasi-Judicial Function

- They **pass orders** — they **adjudicate on violations** and **impose penalty**.
- A regulator is **different from a tribunal**: a **tribunal** is a specific body meant to adjudicate on a particular matter — it is **like a court but is not a court**.
  - A tribunal **will not make regulations or rules**: the job of the **National Green Tribunal** is not to make rules, but to **adjudicate when rules are violated**.
  - Regulators, by contrast, perform **all three functions**.

> **DATA & FACTS**
>
> **Penalties in practice.**
>
> - **TRAI** imposes a penalty on **Jio** and on **Vodafone**.
> - Many companies involved in **insider trading** are penalised; if you launch an **IPO** and do not fulfil the details in the **prospectus**, you are penalised.
> - **RBI** levies a penalty on banks — **one crore, two crore, three crore rupees** — if that bank is not fulfilling its functions.

Penalty is basically a quasi-judicial act. You are punishing a person, so the person is given an opportunity, presents the evidence, the counterparty is also heard, and then a decision is given. That is how the three functions together make a regulator what it is.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - A regulator is **quasi-legislative, quasi-executive and quasi-judicial** — not a legislature, an executive or a judiciary, but like them.

- **Quasi-legislative** = rules and regulations, that is **delegated legislation**; **quasi-executive** = implementation, investigation, monitoring and inspection; **quasi-judicial** = orders and **penalty**.
- A **tribunal** adjudicates a particular matter and makes no rules — the **National Green Tribunal** only adjudicates violations — while a regulator does all three.
- Penalties in practice: **TRAI** on Jio and Vodafone, **RBI** on banks (one, two, three crore rupees), **SEBI** for insider trading and prospectus violations.
- Penalty is a **quasi-judicial act** — opportunity, evidence, hearing the other side, then a decision.

36.6 How Independence Is Established

Regulators **need to be independent**. How is that independence established? Four things.

1. **Backed by a legislation or a statute.** The **RBI Act 1934**, the **SEBI Act**, the **PFRDA Act** and the **IRDA Act** — all of them are backed by laws. When you make a law you are **separating and segregating yourself from the executive**: these are **statutory powers**.
2. **Organizationally separated from the government department.** **TRAI** shall be separated from the **Department of Telecom**; **SEBI** is separated from the **Ministry of Finance** and is a completely separate body to regulate the securities market; **IRDA** and **PFRDA** are also separated from the Ministry of Finance. They are all **separate autonomous agencies** — SEBI has its office in **Bombay** and a completely separate mechanism of **recruitment**.
3. **Entrusted with regulatory authority.**
4. **Headed by officials who are not part of the elected political executive.** A **minister** can be neither the head of **TRAI** or **FSSAI** nor the chairman of **SEBI** or **PFRDA** — there can be absolutely **no political-executive involvement**.

KEY CONCEPT

But are they not accountable?.

- They **are accountable** — to the **government**, the **judiciary**, the **legislature** and other mechanisms — and they uphold **constitutional values**.
- It is not that **SEBI, PFRDA or RBI** answers to nobody; they do answer. But they must stay **away from the government** — the difficulty is with the government.
- Organisation of the polity: the **executive** (karyapalika) implements policies, the **legislature** (vidhayika) legislates and the **judiciary** adjudicates. This means the regulator is **not subordinate** to the government and the government **will not interfere** in the regulator.
- Terminology to keep straight: a regulator is **niyamak**, not **niyantrak** (controller) — this is commonly forgotten.

QUICK REVISION

- Independence is established by (1) a **statute** — RBI Act 1934, SEBI Act, PFRDA Act, IRDA Act; (2) **organisational separation** from the government department; (3) **entrustment with**

regulatory authority; and (4) heads who are **not part of the elected political executive**.

- **TRAI** is separated from the Department of Telecom; **SEBI, IRDA and PFRDA** are separated from the Ministry of Finance.
- No minister can head TRAI or FSSAI, or chair SEBI or PFRDA.
- They **are accountable** — to the government, the judiciary and the legislature — but they must stay away from the government.
- Terminology: **niyamak** is a regulator, not **niyantrak** (controller).

36.7 Evolution of Regulators: Pre-1991 to Post-LPG Reforms

The natural next thought is the **evolution of regulators**: their growth has been seen **post-1991**.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

What 1991 brought.

- **Liberalization** — the easing of rules, regulations and tariffs.
- **Privatization** — which led to the **entry of the private sector**.
- **Globalization** — entry of **foreign capital**, **foreign MNCs** and **foreign firms**.

Role of the state	**Service provider or producer, policy maker and regulator** — the state performed all the functions together	**Facilitator** — providing the right **policy environment** and creating the right **framework**
Who provides the services	Only the state's own arms — the **Department of Telecommunication**, **BSNL**, **MTNL**	Public-sector service providers **and** private players who entered because of liberalization, globalization and privatization
Why regulators emerged	No separate regulator needed — the state regulated itself	A **third party** separated from the private players and from the **government of the day**

- Earlier, in telecom, there was only the **Department of Telecommunication** — **BSNL** and **MTNL**, all of it under the state.
- Then came liberalization: the **Department of Telecom** said it would just **make rules and create a framework**, private players entered, companies invested in telecom, and **BSNL**, being a public entity, was left **competing against the private sector**.
- Thereby the **need for regulators was automatically created** — agencies separated from the private players **and** separated from the government of the day.

- As the government facilitates **both** the private and the public players and provides services to both, a **third party is needed to watch the entire sector** — hence the emergence of regulators.
- Had 1991 not happened, **equities, mutual funds, insurance products, pension products**, a plethora of food articles and the entry of **foreign brands such as chips and Pepsi** would not have been a reality.
- When so many players entered the market, a **level playing field** had to be created for the citizens and **consumer interest** upheld — that is why the framework of regulators was created, which gave **RBI the powers to regulate the banking sector**. RBI is simply **facilitating** now.
- In this framework there is **competition**, there are so many companies including in the public sector, and the government is just facilitating.
- The state is **evolving** — this cannot be called a **quid pro quo**; as discussed in health, the state has to remain in certain **strategic sectors**, has to facilitate and also needs to regulate.
- The state's job is to create **open competition**, to uphold **fairness** and to uphold **service delivery** to the citizens; whichever organisation or tier upholds our welfare best must do it — therefore **regulators are very necessary**.
  - This ensures that the **state itself cannot harm the consumer**; the same is the case with the private sector; and that is possible only when a regulator **creates regulations, creates norms and promotes competition**.

QUICK REVISION

- Regulators grew **post-1991** — **liberalization** (easing of rules, regulations and tariffs), **privatization** (entry of the private sector) and **globalization** (foreign capital, MNCs and firms).
- Pre-1991 the state was service provider, producer, policy maker and regulator together; post-1991 it became a **facilitator**.
- Telecom: from a single **Department of Telecommunication** with BSNL and MTNL, to a rule-making department plus private players — which created the **need for a regulator**.
- Had 1991 not happened, **equities, mutual funds, insurance and pension products** and foreign brands such as **chips and Pepsi** would not exist here.
- A **level playing field** and consumer interest required the framework of regulators, and **RBI** received the power to regulate banking — it only facilitates now.
- The state is evolving, not a quid pro quo: it must create **open competition, fairness and service delivery**, so that neither the state nor the private sector harms the consumer.

36.8 Why Regulators Are Needed (The Need for Regulators)

This is the **second part of the debate**: why are regulators needed in India? The lecture numbers the needs as follows.

1. **1. To prevent monopoly or abuse of dominance.** Monopolists may **exclude competitors** or **harm consumer interest** — the example is the role of the **CCI (Competition Commission of India)**.

2. **2. To correct market failures.** Free markets or the private sector do not automatically produce **socially optimal outcomes** — [self-corrected in the lecture] write **citizen-centric outcomes** — because they are **profit driven**.
3. **3. To maintain systemic stability.** The failure of **one institution or entity** might generate **sector-wide or system-wide consequences**.
4. **4. To establish standards.** Complex sectors — **food safety, telecom regulation, the securities and derivatives markets**, and **pollution regulation (done by the Central Pollution Control Board)** — require **specialised technical knowledge or technical know-how**, creating the need for regulators.
5. **5. To attract private investment or unlock foreign capital.** Efficient regulators create **predictable regulations, entry rules, tariffs** etc., leading to **business clarity** and **investment clarity** — and, because of their long-term perspective, they also provide **continuity**.
6. **6. To adapt to or deal with technological transformation.** The **specialised knowledge or expertise** possessed by regulators leads to **better regulation despite a technological shift**.
7. **7. To avoid conflict of interest.** The government is itself the **service provider or producer in several sectors**, so there is no separate regulator — the ministry or department itself regulates that sector — and a regulator paid by the regulated cannot uphold the interest of the sector.

36.8.1 *The Illustrations, Point by Point*

- **On monopoly**: no coaching institute can be so big as to control the entire sector — and, similarly, **Meta / Facebook / Instagram** control the entire scope of **digital advertisements**.
  - If you want to give an advertisement for your institute, there is only **one platform**; there is **no counter platform** to stop the monopoly.
- **On market failure**: the **Airports Economic Regulatory Authority** must regulate the **tariffs and other taxes or charges** levied by airlines — **IndiGo, SpiceJet and Air India** compete for you and me as travellers, but tomorrow they might also **form a cartel**.
- As airports are being **privatised**, the **Airports Authority of India** is trying to auction an airport to **GMR**, **Tata** or **Adani** — but at the end of the day they too might form a cartel.
  - Three companies together can bring **consumer welfare to a decline** — this is called **market failure**.
- **Market failure means** that market forces, that is the **private sector**, will always look for **profit**; no private sector will provide you a **free lunch**.
  - If they indulge in practices like **monopoly**, **information asymmetry** or **forming cartels**, it will automatically lead to the decline of that particular sector in the country — as happened with **Kingfisher Airlines**.
- **On systemic stability**: if **Jio** is incapable of recovering its revenues from the people, banks feel that in the telecom sector there is a lot of **noise and information asymmetry**, so they will not lend to **Airtel** at all, nor to **Vi** — if they will not give to Jio, they will not give to Airtel either.
  - The companies say their numbers are fine: give them money for a year, or a loan for **two, five or ten years**, since they are putting up **towers** and need investment for that.
- Because there is a **threat to financial stability**, the entire system might get affected — that is why regulators ensure that **one does not fail in the first place**, through **imposition**

of penalties, regulation, investigation and inquiry; and **even if it fails, it does not fail system-wise**.

- **On standards**: **SEBI** has to ensure that **India's financialisation of the economy** takes place; a mutual fund or fintech company may come with a very innovative financial product — we will take **Rs. 10,000** from you, put **Rs. 3,000** in a mutual fund, give you **Rs. 2,000** of insurance, keep **Rs. 3,000** of your money for your pension and buy **gold** with the remaining **Rs. 3,000** — and you wonder whether to invest or not.
  - There is so much **financialisation of the economy** happening, just like in the West — do you think the state or the central government is capable enough to regulate these products?
- Airlines and airports can **levy different types of charges**; **Zomato** charges sometimes a **platform charge** and sometimes another charge, trying to find new ways of recovering revenue.
  - Zomato is planning that if you order a particular item and pay by **COD (cash on delivery)**, it will levy some charges from you — is this not complex?
- In telecom, the **spectrum-allocation policy** is made by the **Department of Telecom** and different companies bid for it — but they bid in such a way that a **monopoly does not arise**.
- **On clarity and continuity**: the investor's problem is **clarity** — for instance, about the **regulations that will govern the next four years** in India.
  - Suppose I want to come up with a new **protein product** that has a high amount of **sugar** but is **rich in protein**: any protein bar gives **25 grams** of protein and I will give **50 grams**, but with slightly higher sugar.
  - If the regulator comes up with a **star rating of foods high in fat, salt and sugar**, I will also worry that, having entered with so much **marketing cost**, I may not be able to **regain the invested cost** of that protein bar.
- If there is no regulator in the economy, the state — primarily the **executive government** — will always run in a very **narrow, short-term perspective**.
- The government is there only to **win the elections for five years**, so it has to live in five years and cannot think beyond that.
  - But the **administrators stay intact**: as an administrator one has to give a **long-term reading**, and **regulators provide long-term vision and long-term clarity**.
  - Regulators also provide **continuity**, because of their long-term perspective, as compared with the government's **short-term approach**.
- **Governance perspective**: one is looking at the **citizen** and at the **state**, and within the state there is a separate **leg of the regulator**.
  - The regulator is trying to create, with the help of regulations, an opportunity for that sector to **prosper**; it gives the **long-term vision** the government cannot give, and **ensures continuity** if the regulations are strong.
- **Example — the FDA**: a particular food item in **US supermarkets** is regulated by the **FDA (Food and Drugs Administration)**, which has a very strong regulatory mechanism.
  - That regulation upholds **consumer interest**, but it also gives me **clarity** that whether a **Trump regime** comes to power or the **Democrats** come to power, the food sector will be

independently regulated by the FDA.

- **On technological transformation**: the example is the rise of **digital platforms, AI, fintech** and telecom technology **5G and 6G**, evolving **faster than the legislation**.
  - The legislature's job is to **make laws**, and laws cannot be made at the rate at which **AI** is evolving — so for these sectors a **separate regulator** is needed.
- **On conflict of interest**: it is like saying I am taking the class and the separate regulator is also **being paid by me** to regulate the environment of this coaching institute.
  - How will that individual, who is working under my salary and within my ambit, discharge his function of ensuring a **proper delivery of classes**, or of regulating classes between **students and teacher**?

36.8.2 What to Write at the End: Consumer Interest and Information Asymmetry

- At the end write: **upholds consumer interest**, and **information asymmetry vis-à-vis large manufacturing corporations**. The example is knowledge about **food safety**, or about **foods high in HFSS (high in fat, salt and sugar)**.
- The consumer today does not have the information: everyone says **diet coke is zero calorie**, but that does not mean that consuming diet coke is **100% healthy**.
- Consumption of diet coke beyond a certain number of **cans a day**, or over a **month**, might cause a **spike of blood sugar** or lead to a **pre-diabetic situation**.
- Several people of your age regularly consume diet coke because they think it is **healthy** and because it gives them a **kick** of having something like a coke — but that is not at all healthy. And **I do not know this either**.
- So the information is **asymmetric**, because the **multinational corporations** try to create a mechanism to **overpower the thoughts of a consumer**.
- You therefore require **independent regulators** — you require **FSSAI** — to bring in regulations and norms, **not only for competition**, **not only for the transformation of food items**, **not only for the rise of processed food**, but finally **to uphold the interest of me as the final consumer**.
- You can also write **malpractice, against law, against rules** and **conflict of interest**.
- So **information asymmetry**, along with the points on **prevention of monopoly** and **prevention of conflict of interest**, finally **promotes consumer interest** — and this is the **need for regulators**.

> **DATA & FACTS**
>
> **The figures used in these illustrations.**
>
> - The innovative financial product: **Rs. 10,000** split into **Rs. 3,000** mutual fund, **Rs. 2,000** insurance, **Rs. 3,000** pension and **Rs. 3,000** gold.
> - The protein bar: **25 grams** of protein is what any protein bar gives, and **50 grams** is what the new product would give — with slightly higher sugar.
> - The government's horizon: **five years**, because that is the election cycle.

QUICK REVISION

- Seven needs: (1) prevent monopoly or abuse of dominance, (2) correct market failures, (3) maintain systemic stability, (4) establish standards, (5) attract private investment or unlock foreign capital, (6) adapt to technological transformation, (7) avoid conflict of interest.
- **Market failure**: profit-driven private players may form **cartels** and bring consumer welfare down — the **Kingfisher Airlines** example.
- **Systemic stability**: the failure of one entity (for example **Jio**) can stop banks from lending to the whole sector (**Airtel**, **Vi**).
- **Standards**: sectors such as food safety, telecom, the securities and derivatives markets, and pollution (**CPCB**) need specialised technical knowledge.
- **Clarity and continuity**: predictable regulations and tariffs draw private and foreign capital; the government's horizon is only **five years**, while administrators and regulators give the long-term view — the **FDA** example.
- **Conflict of interest and information asymmetry**: the government is itself a provider, and consumers (**diet coke**, **HFSS foods**) are misled by MNCs — hence **FSSAI**.

36.9 Independence and Autonomy: Meaning and the PYQ

The **third thing** to write down is the **need for independent regulators**. The framing used is: **do you think regulators need to be independent and autonomous?** Two things follow — the meaning of **independence** and the meaning of **autonomy**.

- The **Quality Council of India** is not thought to be a regulatory body [as stated in lecture]; if it is one, it can be written.
- It is better to write the **examples that have been asked in the examination**: **SEBI**, **PFRDA**, and the recent assurance given by **FSSAI in the Supreme Court** regarding the **labelling of foods high in HFSS**.

36.9.1 Independence and Autonomy: The Two Words

COMPARISON

Independence versus autonomy.

- **Independence** means **statutory existence**, where **tenure, terms and conditions and salary** are **separated from political interference**.
- **Autonomy** — the regulator is created with the help of a **law**; that law provides for **statutory existence**, an **independent term**, the **terms and conditions** and the **salary**, so all those details are provided in the law and there is no compromise of independence.

- To study whether a regulator is **autonomous**, you have to understand the **details of the law** and the **working or functioning of the regulator**.
- **Administrative autonomy** — can it **recruit its own staff**? Can it appoint its own **specialised expert staff**?
- **Financial autonomy** — will it be dependent on the **government for the budget**? Is the

expenditure charged or made? All of this is financial autonomy.

- **Personal autonomy** and **decisional autonomy** — the regulator can independently take decisions on its own; it should **not require any consent or agreement from the government**.

> **PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION**
>
> **The PYQ on the board.**
>
> - **For achieving the desired objectives, it is necessary to ensure that regulatory institutions remain independent and autonomous. Discuss.**

36.9.2 How to Structure This Answer

- The question is comparatively easier and comes from the **theoretical framework**. The **keywords** are **desired objectives**, **independent** and **autonomous** — and with them, **regulatory institutions** and the **need for independence and autonomy**.
- **Structure**: an **introduction of 20 to 30 words**; a **body** that is the **need for independence and autonomy**; and a **conclusion**.
  - The main question is what the need for independence and autonomy is, and the answer has to be of about **200 words**.
- **The answer is the same as the need for regulators** — to prevent politicisation, to ensure a level playing field, to prevent monopoly, to uphold consumer interest.
- **Introduction to write**: the role of regulators, which are public entities framing rules and regulations for a sector, has **significantly enlarged post 1991**, creating the need for independence and autonomy.
  - There is **no need to define regulators**; two or three sentences can be clubbed into the introduction instead of writing only one.
- **The diagram**: on one side **independence** — statutory existence, stability in tenure, terms and conditions, salary, and **appointment and removal as per the statute and non-politicised**; on the other side **autonomy** — **decisional, functional and personal autonomy** plus **financial and administrative autonomy**.
  - That diagram, however, was **not better and not relevant enough**; in a question you have to show the best, and a diagram showing **evolution** was not needed at all — writing the definition was enough.
- The **body** is then written as **numbered points**.

36.9.3 The Body: The Numbered Points

1. **1. To prevent politicisation of regulators** — example: **TRAI** is independent and autonomous **vis-à-vis the Department of Telecom**.
2. **2. To create a level playing field** between various private players, and between private and public players.
3. **3. To ensure specialisation and technical expertise** — example: **SEBI regulations** for **derivatives**, **insider trading** and **market manipulation**.
4. **4. To protect regulation from short-term political considerations**, as the government focuses

on **short-term gains**, but regulators focus on **financial stability, long-term investment and consumer welfare** — example: the role of **RBI in the regulation of the banking sector**.

5. **5. To enable punitive action against powerful economic actors**, as institutional independence and autonomy is a must to act upon entities which have **greater financial resources** — example: **SEBI regulating MNCs and big companies like HDFC** (when the HDFC merger happened, it was not regulated). The analogy: independence is needed **to take action** — if I come under you, I will not be able to say anything; students will sit upon me and extract their welfare **against the interests of the teaching methodology** being adopted.
6. **6. To prevent regulatory capture** — capture **from the state**, that is **political capture**, or **from industry**, that is **industry capture**.
7. **7. To protect consumer or public interest.**
8. **8. To provide regulatory certainty and predictability**, which **unlocks industrial, private and foreign capital**, as independence and autonomy lead to **legal certainty**.
9. **9. It allows the regulator to take unpopular but necessary decisions** — examples: **RBI's prudential requirements for banks**, **CCI's levy of penalties for anti-competitive conduct**, and **FSSAI's proposed regulation for foods high in HFSS**.

Conclusion: therefore, **independence and accountability are prerequisites** for ensuring the accountability of the regulatory institutions [as stated in lecture].

QUICK REVISION

- **Independence** = statutory existence, with tenure, terms, conditions and salary separated from **political interference**; **autonomy** = the law-given ability to function on its own.
- Autonomy is tested through **administrative, financial, personal and decisional** autonomy.
- PYQ: for achieving the desired objectives, it is necessary to ensure that regulatory institutions remain independent and autonomous — **Discuss**.
- Intro of **20 to 30 words**, body, conclusion; about **200 words**; do not define regulators; the answer is the same as the need for regulators.
- Nine body points: prevention of politicisation, level playing field, specialisation, insulation from short-term politics, punitive action, prevention of regulatory capture, consumer interest, certainty and predictability, and unpopular but necessary decisions.
- Conclusion: **independence and accountability are prerequisites** — and all the points are relevant, so none can be skipped.

36.10 The Second PYQ: Post-LPG Sectoral Regulators and Their Concerns

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

The question.

- **Do you think that post-LPG reforms the need for sectoral regulators has arisen? Give examples. Also discuss the various concerns or limitations affecting the working of regulators in India.**

- The sentence may be rephrased — post liberalization, do you think the regulators are required — but the point remains the same.
- The **answer to the first part is the same as the need for regulators**.
- You have to take the **examiner back to the 1991 framework, again and again and again, with examples**.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - PYQ: do you think that post-LPG reforms the need for sectoral regulators has arisen? Give examples, and discuss the concerns or limitations affecting the working of regulators in India.
> - The first part is answered exactly as the **need for regulators**.
> - Take the examiner back to the **1991** framework repeatedly, with examples.

36.11 Student Doubt: Are Commissions Such as the NHRC Regulatory Bodies?

A doubt was raised: is the **NHRC** not an **all-encompassing body**, and would the NHRC be called a **regulatory body**?

> **COMPARISON**
>
> **Commissions versus regulatory bodies.**
>
> - **Commissions such as the NHRC, NCSC and NCST** — the NHRC will **not** be called a regulatory body; the NHRC, NCSC and NCST are **not regulating anything**. They are only **monitoring** and **investigating the violation of rights** as far as humans as an entity are concerned; they are basically upholding **welfare**, the constitutional principle of welfare.
> - **Regulatory bodies** — these are **sector-specific bodies** which are meant to address the **problems in a sector**, or where a couple of entities are working in something and therefore need to be regulated.

Eventually that also **traces to the Constitution**, but the **linkage is indirect** in the case of the commissions.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - The doubt: is the all-encompassing **NHRC** a regulatory body?
> - No — the **NHRC, NCSC and NCST regulate nothing**; they monitor and investigate violations of human rights and uphold the constitutional principle of **welfare**.
> - Regulatory bodies are **sector-specific** bodies meant to address the problems of a sector.
> - Both trace back to the Constitution, but for the commissions the **linkage is indirect**.

36.12 What Remains and How the Topic Connects

With this, the discussion of **regulators is done**; the **commissions**, including the **NHRC**, have also been discussed and are finished.

- The **Attorney General** and other authorities will be taught in main polity.
- Only the **Lokpal** remains, and its issues are the same as all these issues; handwritten notes will be given, the probability of a question is **almost nil**, and any question that comes can be done from those notes.
- These notes are to be kept aside — the continuation of the discussion of **IR** comes next.
- In the **commission answer**, the regulatory bodies can be **mentioned as examples — TRAI**, **PFRDA** and **IRDA** can be mentioned; the examples of the **different types of products** have to be given.
- **Challenges and way forward** have to be written by the students; they will be discussed in the next class — attempt an answer.
- Students are to **use ChatGPT** for practice; this is only to familiarise them with the use of **AI**.

QUICK REVISION

- Regulators and the commissions, including the **NHRC**, are done; the **Attorney General** and other authorities come in main polity.
- **Lokpal** remains: its issues are the same as these, notes will be given, and a question from it is almost impossible.
- The **IR** discussion continues next.
- In commission answers, use the regulators as examples — **TRAI, PFRDA, IRDA**.
- **Challenges and way forward** for regulators are to be written by the students and discussed in the next class; practise with **ChatGPT**.

CHAPTER 37

India–Bangladesh Relations

37.1 Leftover from the Previous Topic: Nepal and Overflight Rights

- Two airports have been built in Nepal — one of them is **Pokhara**, and there is another one.
- The Government of India has **not given the powers of overflight** for them.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Overflight — what it means.**
>
> - Overflight means you **cannot access the Indian airspace to reach that area**.
> - So when overflight is not granted, Indian airspace cannot be used as the route to reach the area in which the airport lies.

- The detailed discussion is deferred to the point when **Balen Shah** comes to India, in **November**; the module will be running by then and the latest changes and material will be given, to be added to the main notes.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Two airports were built in Nepal; one of them is Pokhara (the second was not named).
> - India has not given the overflight powers for them.
> - Overflight = access to Indian airspace to reach an area; denial blocks that route.
> - The full Nepal discussion is deferred to November, when Balen Shah visits India.
> - Updated material will then be added to the main notes so that the notes are current before the module ends.

37.2 Roadmap Ahead

- The neighbourhood series has so far covered **Nepal** and **Bangladesh**.
- After Bangladesh, the series moves to **Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Maldives**, and concludes the neighbourhood with the country of **Pakistan**.
- Then the three big powers: the **US, Russia and China**.
- Then **India–EU**, and India's relationship with the recent countries visited — **Japan, Israel, Australia and Indonesia**; Indonesia is also connected with India's relationship with **ASEAN**.
- Under the regional framework: **BRICS** (a class on it has already been taken; it is to be taken tomorrow), and then **ASEAN and the Quad** — their relevance.

QUICK REVISION

- Covered so far in the neighbourhood series: Nepal and Bangladesh.
- After Bangladesh: Myanmar, Sri Lanka, Maldives — closing the neighbourhood with Pakistan.
- Then the big powers: US, Russia, China.
- Then India–EU, plus Japan, Israel, Australia, Indonesia.
- Indonesia also links India to ASEAN.
- Regional framework: BRICS, then ASEAN and the Quad and their relevance.

37.3 PYQ Pattern and Exam Framing

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

PYQ on this topic.

- **2013**: the question asked the **significance for India** of the **Shahbagh Square** protest that took place in Dhaka.
- Only **one** question has come on this topic till now.

- Pattern: whenever any topic from South Asia comes in the examination, the question asks either the **broad relationship** or the **implications**.
- Example from the **2026** paper: the **strategic and security implications of BRI on India** — that is, implications for India's **regional influence**, which is geopolitical, geostrategic and geocultural, and implications for India's **security**, which is geostrategic.
- A **recent event** can be asked — a recent protest, or the most recent event of all, the **election of a new government in March 2026**.
- Whatever changes in the content in the meantime, the framework of the answer stays the same [as stated in lecture].

QUICK REVISION

- Only PYQ till now: 2013 — significance for India of the Shahbagh Square protest in Dhaka.
- South Asia topics are asked either as the broad relationship or as the implications.
- 2026 paper example: strategic and security implications of BRI on India.
- Geopolitical, geostrategic, geocultural = regional influence; security = geostrategic.
- Recent events — a recent protest, or the March 2026 election — can be asked.

37.4 The March 2026 Turning Point and the Framework of the Discussion

KEY CONCEPT

Model relationship.

- The India–Bangladesh relationship under **Mrs Sheikh Hasina** as Prime Minister, from **2009 till August 2024**.

- It is the benchmark against which every other phase of this topic is judged.

- **Mr Tariq Rahman** has got elected as the **Prime Minister of Bangladesh** in **March 2026**.
- This is a very important **turning point**, because India historically has been used to dealing with a regime that was very friendly.
- It was a **model relationship** that India had with Bangladesh when Mrs Sheikh Hasina was the Prime Minister from 2009 till August 2024.
- After she left, the relationship had the **worst of the worst times** ever since Bangladesh got independent.
- Now the relationship is on the **upswing**, but it is not that wonderful as it was with Sheikh Hasina as the Prime Minister.

DATA & FACTS

Dates that anchor the discussion.

- **4th–5th August 2024**: Sheikh Hasina fled Bangladesh and came to India.
- **August 2024 – March 2026**: interim government under Muhammad Yunus.
- **March 2026**: Tariq Rahman elected Prime Minister — the relationship enters the present phase.

QUICK REVISION

- March 2026: Tariq Rahman elected Prime Minister of Bangladesh.
- It is a turning point because India was used to a very friendly regime.
- The model relationship ran from 2009 till August 2024 under Sheikh Hasina.
- After she left, the worst of the worst times since Bangladesh's independence.
- Today: on the upswing, but not as wonderful as under Sheikh Hasina.

37.5 Structure of the Topic

The topic is to be written in this order:

1. **History** — a little history.
2. **Importance** — with **China's role** to be inserted here, before the weaknesses are taken up.
3. **Weaknesses**.
4. **Way Forward** — one common way forward with respect to India's neighbourhood, which will also carry India's foreign policy in the present times.

- History is **not very important** — it is only to understand the present; history in IR was handled very selectively, but since this is a module, the coverage goes only about **5% higher**.
- Analogy: as with Nepal's history — **Janandolan I**, **Janandolan II**, the **panchayat system**, and how India was engaging multiple political parties at that time — a little history is needed to understand the present. Nepal was harder to read because of its multi-party politics and several coalitions.

QUICK REVISION

- Order: History → Importance (China's role inserted after importance) → Weaknesses → Way Forward.
- History is not very important; it is only to understand the present.
- Because this is a module, history coverage goes about 5% higher than usual.
- Nepal comparison: Janandolan I and II, the panchayat system, India engaging multiple parties.
- The Way Forward is common for India's neighbourhood and carries India's foreign policy in the present times.

37.6 The Relationship Diagram: India's Stakes in Bangladesh

The diagram of the Indo-Bangladesh relationship has to be drawn on these heads, and the words used on it — such as **geo-strategic** — have to be defined.

1. **India's immediate neighbourhood**.
2. **North East security and stability**.
3. **Cultural and civilizational ties** — ties rooted in **blood**.
4. **Regional stability** — a part of this relationship.
5. **Access to Southeast**.
6. **Indian Ocean maritime security** — or access to the **IOR**.
7. **Connectivity** — rail-based, air-based, road-based, pipeline-based and digital connectivity; access to the North East is achieved through connectivity.

EXAMPLE

Ties rooted in blood — why the sacrifice matters.

- India too gave its sacrifices: Indian soldiers were also lost in the liberation of Bangladesh in 1971.
- **General G.D. Bakshi** recounts a batchmate of his armed-forces days — a very handsome young man of **21–22 years**, sent to Bangladesh, whose eyes were gouged out and whose body was so badly mutilated that one cannot even look at it.
- This is why the ties are said to be rooted in **blood**, and why this binding is important.

QUICK REVISION

- Heads: (1) India's immediate neighbourhood, (2) North East security and stability, (3) cultural and civilizational ties rooted in blood.
- (4) Regional stability, (5) access to Southeast, (6) Indian Ocean maritime security / access to the IOR, (7) connectivity.
- Connectivity gives access to the North East: rail, air, road, pipeline and digital.
- The ties are rooted in blood — India too sacrificed in 1971.

- General G.D. Bakshi's batchmate, 21–22 years old, was sent to Bangladesh and mutilated beyond recognition.
- Terms used on the diagram, such as geo-strategic, must be defined.

37.7 History of Indo-Bangladesh Relations

The history of this relationship is **intricate and layered**; in a way, it has weathered numerous storms or hindrances.

- The history is **topsy-turvy** — sometimes one way, sometimes the other; unlike India, where the present government has continued in office, so an entire youth and career passes under the same government and the same party.

37.7.1 Phase 1 (1971–1975): The Foundation Based on Blood and Sacrifice

- **1971 to 1975**: this was the phase of the **foundation of Indo-Bangladesh ties**, and the relation was based on **blood and sacrifice**.
- There were **strong bilateral ties between Indira Gandhi and Sheikh Mujibur Rahman**, who is the father of Sheikh Hasina.
- **1975**: Sheikh Mujibur Rahman was **assassinated** — the entire family was killed; the family was in **Germany** at the time.
- **Mrs Indira Gandhi called Sheikh Hasina to India** — which is why the policy of the first **4–5 years** was excellent; then came the rough phase.

37.7.2 Phase 2 (1975–1990): Military Rule, Islamization and Strategic Diversification

- The rough phase: **1975 to 1990**, which had **military rule plus the rule of Ziaur Rahman**.
- **Ziaur Rahman** was the father of **Khaleda Zia**, and Khaleda Zia is the mother of the present Prime Minister — so the present Prime Minister's **maternal grandfather** was a general.
- He had **overthrown Sheikh Mujibur Rahman** and became the **dictator**.
- This is important because Bangladesh now realised its own **locational advantage**, and in **1975 China recognised Bangladesh** [year garbled in the transcript; as stated in lecture] — an upshift at this point.
- Because Ziaur Rahman was a **military general** and Mujibur Rahman was a **liberal**, there was a policy of **gradual Islamization of the society**.
- The history of Bangladesh was rooted in the concept of **Bangla** — Bangladesh is the country of the ones who speak in Bangla; whether they are Islamist or Hindu does not make a difference.

KEY CONCEPT

Strategic diversification by Bangladesh.

- In the next **15 years** there was a **resurfacing of Islamic identity**.
- This was also the period of **strategic diversification** by Bangladesh.
- **Strategic diversification** = deliberately broadening partnerships beyond one partner:

> Bangladesh increased cooperation with (1) **China**, (2) **Pakistan**, and (3) the **Islamic world**.

37.7.3 Phase 3 (1991–1996): BNP Rule and Bilateral Mistrust

- **1991 to 1996**: the government was that of the **BNP — the Bangladesh Nationalist Party**.
- This was the period of **bilateral mistrust**.
- This phase also shows the parentage of Tariq Rahman — his father and mother — and therefore the **historical affiliation that cannot be hidden**.

> **COMPARISON**
>
> **BNP phases versus Awami League phases.**
>
> - **BNP phases** — 1991–1996, 2001–2006 and the present phase: bilateral mistrust and **strategic diversification** away from India.
> - **Awami League phases** — 1996–2001 and 2009–2024: reconciliation with India, a major reset, and expansion of bilateral cooperation.

- One point on the **familial ties** that run through this relationship: **Mr Anwar Ibrahim** specifically met **Mr Rahul Gandhi** and **Mrs Priyanka Vadra**, since there was a time when he was in jail or was detained, and his two children were with the Gandhi family [as stated in lecture; the reference is ambiguous].
- **Sheikh Hasina** is extremely close to **Pranab Mukherjee's** family and also very close to the Congress.
- Consider that the **entire family had been assassinated** and **Indira Gandhi assisted the family**, with Sheikh Hasina coming and staying in India — so they have got **familial ties** which, no matter what happens, cannot be broken.

37.7.4 Phase 4 (1996–2001): Awami League, Major Reset and the Ganga Water Treaty

- **1996 to 2001**: the party in power was the **Awami League**, and **Sheikh Hasina** became the Prime Minister.
- This was the phase of **major reset** — or, as it may be called, the phase of **major reconciliation**: she had now shifted towards India and wanted to reconcile with India.

> **GOVERNMENT & POLICY**
>
> **Ganga Water Sharing Treaty, 1996.**
>
> - A **landmark treaty** was signed in **December 1996**.
> - This was the **Ganga (Ganges) Water Sharing Treaty**, signed on **12 December 1996**.
> - It was signed **for 30 years**.
> - It is the shining example of **water diplomacy**.

- This was the **best period** of the relationship; unfortunately history is topsy-turvy — sometimes one way, sometimes the other.

37.7.5 Phase 5 (2001–2006): BNP, the Four-Party Alliance and the Chittagong Arms Haul

- **2001 to 2006**: the Prime Minister was **Khaleda Zia**, heading a **four-party alliance**.
- One party in that four-party alliance was absolutely **rogue — proper terrorists — and should be banned**: it played a major role in the **exodus of the Kashmiri Pandits from 1986 to 89**.
- That is the political party of **Jamaat — Jamaat-e-Islami**; in Pakistan, Jamaat-e-Islami has the **biggest hardliners**.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Chittagong Arms Haul Case, 2004.

- In **2004** came the **Chittagong Arms Haul Case** — a truck found in **Chittagong**, loaded with a huge quantity of weapons.
- This was the period when **ULFA — the United Liberation Front of Assam** — was very strong.
- It is a big shame for a country that has borders with India, and on which North Eastern stability depends.

- Our **worst fears turned into reality**: the **Bangladeshi soil was used by insurgents** to create **instability in the Northeast**.

CRITICAL POINT

Is this the worst phase?.

- In the assessment recorded here, **2001–2006 was supposedly the worst phase** — an opinion drawn from the reading of this topic and from the views of different experts, such as **Mr Panaki Ranjan Chakrabarti**, who gave an interview a few days ago in **The Indian Express** to **Mr Shubhajit**, the author of **The Explained**.
- But this judgement is **not to be written**: what belongs in the answer is what the phase actually contained.

- **2005**: **Mr Manmohan Singh** said that India **will work with any government that is chosen by the people of Bangladesh** — a very wise step.

37.7.6 Phase 6 (2009–August 2024): The Era of Model Relationship

- **2009 till August 2024**: the Prime Minister was **Sheikh Hasina** — this is the era of the **model relationship**; model is an understatement.
- It was an era of **expansion of bilateral cooperation**.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Land Boundary Agreement and the 100th Constitutional Amendment.

- The **Land Boundary Agreement** regarding the **exchange of enclaves** was settled in **2014**.
- There were some Indian territories in Bangladesh and some Bangladeshi territories in India — such pockets of one country's territory lying inside the other are the **enclaves**.
- India very well adhered to the agreement: the arrangement gave those people the option to come to India or to stay in Bangladesh.

- India even passed a **constitutional amendment — the 100th Constitutional Amendment** — to implement the Land Boundary Agreement.
- It was a perfect, peaceful and stable bilateral resolution of a land dispute — not really a dispute, but a concern regarding the territories.

- Analogy: just as the **Indus Waters Treaty** is a wonderful example of a treaty that survived for so many years despite wars — till the Pulwama episode happened [as stated in lecture] — this too was an example of wonderful cooperation.

COMPARISON

The PCA: the maritime case versus the Indus Waters Treaty.

- **PCA** is the **Permanent Court of Arbitration** at The Hague, Netherlands — a form of **alternative dispute resolution mechanism**.
- **Maritime dispute**: a dispute over a maritime area was settled through **arbitration by the PCA** — against the interests of India — and India **willfully submitted to the decision**, created no problem and simply agreed, setting an **international precedent of a responsible neighbour or power**.
- **Indus Waters Treaty**: unlike that, in the recent decision of the Permanent Court of Arbitration, India has clearly said that the **PCA does not enjoy any jurisdiction** — to be discussed with India–Pakistan relations.

37.7.7 Phase 7 (August 2024–March 2026): Interim Government under Muhammad Yunus

- **August 2024 to March 2026**: the phase of the **interim government under Muhammad Yunus**, marked by a **decline in political trust**.
- **Mr Yunus was supported by the US** to counter the increasing Chinese influence in the region; this also **increased great-power involvement** in Bangladesh.
- It also led to **increased engagement with Pakistan**, which included the **sale of JF-17 fighter aircraft**.
- Correction on the nature of that government: he was **just the interim Prime Minister** — it is now said that he was actually **supported by Jamaatis**, that the actual government was **run by Jamaatis**, and that he was just there to hold power and run the show.
- He had **gone to China** and gave a statement about **cutting off the neck of the Siliguri Corridor**, and thereby completely cutting off the Northeast.
- This was **one of the worst periods** that India saw in recent modern times.
- Hindu minorities were **attacked**.
- There was **disruption in trade**, as India had stopped the **transshipment of goods using Indian ports**.
- There was a **demand of extradition** for **war-crime related trials**: she has been blamed for the instability in Bangladesh and for the death of several students, before she fled to India on **4th or 5th August 2024**.

37.7.8 Phase 8 (March 2026 onwards): The Present Phase

- The present phase is **BNP-led**, with **Tariq Rahman** as Prime Minister, who has **continued with strategic diversification**.
- The implications of this election will be studied; this phase is best called a **reset phase of bilateral relations** — an **opportunity for reset**.

37.7.9 Timeline for the Diagram and the Phases That Matter

- The relationship has to be located on the diagram on this timeline: **1991–1996**, **1996–2001**, **2001–2006**, **2009–2024**, **2024–2026**, and now.
- **1996–2001** was the improved relationship; **2001–2006** was the bad phase; **2009–2024** was the phase of model relationship; then came **one of the worst phases**; and now there is an **opportunity for reset**.
- The brief **military rule of 2–3 years is not significant**. The timelines that matter are **1991–1996, 1996–2001, 2001–2006 and 2009–2024**.
- During the military period Bangladesh was **diversified** — it is not that meetings did not take place, but comparatively the relationship of **1975–1990** was the worst.
- **Mr Rajiv Gandhi visited** when **General Ershad** was in power; but these are **insignificant phases** of modern history.
- **The parliamentary form of government is where we need to understand the evolution** — whenever there has been **BNP** in power it is the BNP phase, and so on.
- The **historical baggage tells you where the direction is headed**; this **party-wise graph** is what should be shown in the template.
- In **IR mains**, history is not discussed much; in Nepal the complexity is very high because of multi-party politics and several coalitions, which would confuse a candidate — there **different diagrams (a triangle)** were used, while here a **single line** is shown.

1971–1975	Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, with Indira Gandhi	Foundation of the ties, based on blood and sacrifice
1975–1990	Military rule: Ziaur Rahman, later General Ershad	Gradual Islamization, strategic diversification; comparatively the worst relationship
1991–1996	BNP — Khaleda Zia	Bilateral mistrust
1996–2001	Awami League — Sheikh Hasina	Major reset / major reconciliation; the best period
2001–2006	BNP — Khaleda Zia, with a four-party alliance	Supposedly the worst phase: Chittagong Arms Haul, Bangladeshi soil used by insurgents
2009–August 2024	Awami League — Sheikh Hasina	Model relationship; expansion of bilateral cooperation
August 2024–March 2026	Interim government — Muhammad Yunus	One of the worst periods: decline in political trust
March 2026 onwards	BNP — Tariq Rahman	Opportunity for reset, with continued strategic diversification

QUICK REVISION

- 1971–75: foundation on blood and sacrifice (Indira Gandhi–Sheikh Mujibur Rahman); 1975 assassination; family in Germany; Hasina called to India.
- 1975–90: military rule and Ziaur Rahman — Islamization, resurfacing of Islamic identity, strategic diversification (China, Pakistan, Islamic world).
- 1991–96 BNP mistrust; 1996–2001 Awami League reset with the Ganga Water Sharing Treaty of 12 December 1996, signed for 30 years (water diplomacy).
- 2001–06 BNP four-party alliance: Jamaat-e-Islami, the 1986–89 Kashmiri Pandit exodus, the 2004 Chittagong Arms Haul Case, ULFA, instability in the Northeast; the 2005 Manmohan Singh statement.
- 2009–Aug 2024 model relationship: LBA 2014 (enclaves, 100th Constitutional Amendment), PCA maritime arbitration and the international precedent of a responsible power.
- Aug 2024–Mar 2026 Yunus interim government: decline in political trust, US backing, JF-17 sale by Pakistan, Siliguri Corridor statement, Hindu minorities attacked, transshipment stopped, extradition demand.
- Timelines that matter: 1991–96, 1996–2001, 2001–06, 2009–24; the 2–3 year military rule

> is insignificant; party-wise map: BNP → Awami League → BNP → Awami League → interim government → BNP.

37.8 Student Doubt Answered: Was the Sheikh Hasina Regime Dictatorial?

The doubt raised in class was whether the answer should also record that their regime was a **dictatorial regime**.

- Their regime was **considered a dictatorial regime** — the West portrayed it that way; whether that portrayal was right is not known, but it was a dictatorial regime.
- What they had done was to **mess with the reservation process**.

1. **Reservation** was given to the **descendants of the freedom fighters** of the 1971 liberation.
2. Over time, the reservation began to be **misused**.
3. **Students started protesting** that the freedom fighters and their children should not be given reservation.
4. The protest was **struck down with force**; and once she struck down with force, the students responded — **human rights violations** had taken place.
5. She **took back the reservation policy**, but then there was **action against those students**, so the students protested against that.
6. It was **started in Dhaka University** — Dhaka University has **10 times** the political activism of **JNU and DU together**, in Bangladesh.
7. That **resurgence of student protests led to action**: they had **reclaimed the public places** and were **about to enter the palace of the Prime Minister** — and then she left, and she came to India.

- So the movement began over **reservation for the children of those who had protested in the 1971 liberation** — that is supposedly true, and untrue also.
- There was **100% involvement of the US in the rise of Muhammad Yunus** — that is clearly documented — but yes, it is something very tough to comment on like this.

> **QUICK REVISION**
>
> - Doubt: should the answer say the regime was a dictatorial regime?
> - Answer: it was considered a dictatorial regime — portrayed so by the West; whether that was right is not known.
> - Trigger of the 2024 upheaval: reservation for the descendants of the 1971 freedom fighters, its misuse, and the students' demand to end it.
> - Sequence: force used → human rights violations → reservation policy withdrawn → action against the students → larger protest.
> - It started at Dhaka University — 10 times the political activism of JNU and DU together.
> - Students reclaimed public places and were about to enter the PM's palace; then she left and came to India on 4th–5th August 2024.

- 100% US involvement in the rise of Muhammad Yunus is clearly documented — comment cautiously.

Answer-Writing Toolkit

Policies of the Developed World and Their Impact on India

- **Always write steps, or a way forward**, in an answer on this topic; there is no need to label the way forward with the geopolitical and geoeconomic heads.
- **Always mention the year** in an example — the year adds weight to the observation.
- **Never write two examples back to back**; pair each example with analysis.
- **Avoid abbreviations**: write the full form first and then the abbreviation, or simply the full form — for instance write **Indian Semiconductor Mission 2.0**, because the schemes are technical and the evaluator is from political science.
- Frame the answer on the four heads — **geopolitical, geostrategic, geocultural, geoeconomic** — and, for a question on recent elections in a neighbouring state, structure it as **geopolitical opportunity, geoeconomic opportunity and geocultural opportunity**.
  - That kind of argument has to be framed and reframed.
- The **effect of the developments** and the **challenges thrown by the developments** imply the same thing and can be answered together.
- Use the **3 A's diagram — Autonomy, Alignment, Ambition** — and draw diagrams with clarity; they have to be appealing.
- Make notes like a **sponge**: in IR, any aspect can be asked, so the notes must be flexible enough that every point can be used in a **200-word answer**.
- Use **templates**, so that every candidate's answer turns out different; add or drop heads according to the word limit and one's own handwriting.
- Keep a separate **box of all official MEA keywords** for the examination.
- The same content works in **IR and in GS4** — for example the point on transactional foreign policy.

Various Diplomacies in India's Foreign Policy

The lecture gave a full method for answering diplomacy questions; the same structure applies to any of them.

1. **Break the question into its parts.** For the 2025 energy-security question, Part 1 is the statement (dominant kingpin + overarching influence) and Part 2 is how to integrate energy security with foreign policy.
2. **Allocate words to the parts** — about 125 words for the substantive part and 60 words each for the sub-parts, instead of a flat 70-70-70 split.

3. **Open with a hook** — give the role of energy security in any economy, or use the line that the recent West Asian conflict has exposed the vulnerabilities of nations with respect to energy security.
4. **Substantiate, do not restate** — every claim needs a stat, a diagram or an example.
5. **Write 4-5 main points with 2-4 lines each plus examples**, and list the remaining 5-6 points as **'other steps'**; this gives depth and a sense of priority.
6. **Show the way forward** with an arrow or diagram in about 20 words even when it is not asked, so the examiner sees three steps ahead.
7. **Keep a counterpoint** for domestic points.

- Use **boxes, underlines and diagrams** as presentation tools; enlarge a box to increase the focus on it.
- **Facts are accessories** that substantiate your points, not the point itself.
- A **250-word** answer runs to about **1.3 pages**; a 4-line question leaves roughly one-third of the page to be filled.
- Pick up **reading speed** and read rigorously; unlike prelims, this needs **repeated revision** for marks to build gradually.
- Practise on **pen and paper** — the style clicks with about a day's practice.
- In foreign-policy answers, mention institutional mechanisms such as a **separate energy security division in the Ministry of External Affairs**.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **The exam mindset.**
>
> - Take the examiner from **both sides** — present the debate and then resolve it.
> - Once the framework is internalised the points come on their own; the mind moves fast if a little manoeuvring has been done beforehand.

South Asian Diplomacy and India's Neighbourhood First Policy: Nepal

The lecture gave explicit answer-writing guidance for this topic.

- Write the impact under four dimensions: **geopolitical, geoeconomic, geostrategic and geocultural**.
- To predict the future impact, first establish the **present reality**.
- **Structure is the key in IR** — once the structure is in place, the points follow. The same structure used for Nepal can be used for Bangladesh.
- **Importance and challenges are correlated** — use one to build the other.
- Draw the **map of Nepal** (showing the northern part of India) to make the answer easier to follow.

KEY CONCEPT

Keywords to use.

- **3C — culture, commerce, connectivity**
- **Development partner, not donor hegemon**
- **Elder brother, not big brother**
- **Nepal for Nepalese** (and the frame: Bangladesh first, Nepal first)
- **Naya Nepal**
- **Closest power without becoming the controlling power**

The examiner wants analysis in a scenario that nobody knows: justify the argument through **structural interlinkage and dependence** rather than assertion.

Supreme Court on Child Rights, Abortion, Online Blocking and Bail

37.8.1 Dissecting the Question

- Absorb a lot of content first; then a bit of framing of the answers and structure will help give the examiner what he or she wants.
- The common content that everyone reads has low relevance in the examination — take the thought from it and go to the next level.
- Dissect every question and identify the key words to write down (for example, in the living-document question: **living document**, **social justice**, **in the light of Supreme Court case laws**).
- Train yourself daily to think in terms of selection; the improvement has to be incremental, and the game lies in the structure.

37.8.2 Structure and Presentation

- Use the **arrow technique** in the introduction and keep the Preamble compact — a box or two lines, not an expansion.
- Keep the introduction within about 200 words; the block covering the Preamble, Fundamental Rights, DPSPs, Articles 330 and 332 and the amendments can be finished within that limit.
- Insert a clean **table of comparison** wherever two provisions or concepts are compared; a table must be clear and uncluttered.
- Write only those differences that let the examiner understand what the provision is — do not write every difference.
- Draw proper diagrams and box important data (for example, the doubling of takedown orders).

37.8.3 Handwriting and Practice

- Handwriting has to be very good; leave space on the side and do not make the answer cluttered.
- Give two hours every day to handwriting and use a good pen — there is not so much time in the exam, so the notes and the answer must be legible.

37.8.4 Reading Habit

- The newspaper plays a very important role — anyone who says do not read the newspaper is advising the biggest foolishness; cases often appear first in the papers before the case law is available.

37.8.5 Paper-wise Spread

- The polity questions are somewhat spread apart (about 12–13 questions), quite opposite to internal security, which is narrowly restricted, and opposite to economy and agriculture, which are somewhat restricted; this paper (Paper 1) is completely open and this paper (Paper 2) sits in between.
- Paper 4 has not been analysed in the past one year, so no comment is offered on it.
- In this subject there is no need for a heavy International-Relations-style framing; in International Relations a bit more framing is required.

37.8.6 Writing for the Service

- Articulation of thought is very important for a future officer — one should be able to convey points in writing.
- Ideological thought and expression matter for a political party, but a bureaucrat must fit into the court of the political leadership; bureaucracy thrives under the cloak of ministerial responsibility.

37.8.7 Answer Strategy

- For a question such as whether the IT Act 2000 has outlived its purpose, do not directly disagree — say that there are concerns, but in your opinion it still serves the relevant purpose, and give points in support with the Supreme Court's own observations.
- Where two provisions are compared, show the objective, the grounds, the safeguards and the authority; that is enough for the examiner to see what each provision is.

Right to Bail, Abortion Jurisprudence and the Anti-Defection Law

- For bail, structure the answer as: write down the analysis first, and then the issues.
- For abortion, structure the answer in four parts: (1) introduction — what is the framework; (2) arguments in support of the MTP Act, 1971; (3) issues, or the case against the MTP Act, 1971 framework; (4) way forward.
- Close the abortion answer on the logic that the fault is not in the law but in the changed times — the law is not suited to them, so changes are required, because 1971 to 2026 is 55 years.
- The rights of the father is a relevant ethical dimension that can be quoted, but it need not be mentioned unless the answer is about ethics; the prime concern is choice versus life.
- You will not be asked which beneficiaries hold how many rights — simply write the position.
- For RPA 1951, direct questions come; the structure and framing approach needed for fundamental rights is not needed.

Local Self-Government: Democratic Decentralization, Devolution and Functionality (GS Paper 2 Current Affairs)

- **Structure first:** the most important part of any topic is the framework; absorb the issues into a framework before writing, and the answer will organize itself.
- **Use numbers to establish scale:** about 800 representatives at the centre, 4,000–5,000 in the states and 31.5 lakh in the third tier. The numbers are a weapon to justify to the examiner the scale of good governance, of the bottom-up approach and of participatory governance.
- **Diagrams:** the target is at least **10–15 diagrams in 20 questions**, always drawn in **pencil**. Ready-made titles: increasing importance of ULBs as compared to PRIs/RLBs; local bodies and women empowerment; local bodies as a bridge; local bodies as an interface between the state government and citizens.
- **Templates:** the multiple answer-writing templates given in the brochure have to be remembered and simply written — nothing new has to be thought for them, and there must be **no uniformity**: every candidate needs a different template.
- **Keywords must appear in the answer:** for example social justice (SJ), gender justice (GJ), democratic decentralization, F-cube.
- **Substantiation in the mains means data plus data sources** — the CAG audit report, the RBI report on municipal finances and Janaagraha's reports; for structural points, the Second ARC (with the caveat that it is of 2007). Even anecdotes from low-performing states belong in answers.
- **Way forward in polity:** commission (a commission ranks higher than a committee), committee, Supreme Court judgment, a law, a parliamentary standing committee, or important observations such as **Om Birla's on the working of the MCD**. Do not be innovative in core polity; for this topic, be innovative by adding the **RBI report on municipal government finances** and the **CAG audit 2024** to the Second ARC recommendations.
- **Weightage:** if asked whether, more than F-cube, the delay in elections is the most problematic feature, give almost **50% of the write-up** to delay.
- **Open without defining:** do not define local bodies; begin with 'local bodies constitute the third tier of governance' plus the numbers.
- **One answer, many questions:** 'role in good governance', 'how local bodies led to democratic decentralization', 'importance of local bodies', 'role of local bodies in local self-government' and 'do you agree that local bodies have upturned the framework of democracy by bringing democracy to the grassroots' are all answered with the same points.
- **A topic once prepared from PYQs plus current developments is done for next year's mains**, unless there is a major constitutional amendment or a major law for ULBs/RLBs; it then only needs revision and the pages turned before Paper 2.
- **Scope of this module:** it is a 100% Mains-oriented topic. The prelims content — the 73rd and 74th Amendment details, panchayats, municipal corporations, wards, the municipal councillor — must be known from prelims preparation and is not re-taught here.

Local Self-Government: Functions, Functionaries and Funds — Devolution Problems and the Way Forward

Structure the answer in the same sequence in which the problems have been taken: **elections** → **functions** → **functionaries** → **funds** → **the working of the local bodies**.

- Keep the examples ready so that either one or both can be used.
  - For own source revenue, the RBI and Ministry of Panchayati Raj figures and the Goa comparison: any one of them, or both, may be written.
  - For a diagram, the comparison of Finance Commission grants over the years should be drawn.
- Write the reasons for low own source revenue in a box — these reasons may be asked.
- Keep the data ready: 1% own source revenue of panchayats, 32% for ULBs, 15% in Jharkhand, Manipur, Tripura and Uttarakhand, Rs. 59 per capita against Rs. 1,640 in Goa, 56% property tax realisation, 63% of recommended grants released in the 15th FC period, 17 municipal bonds worth Rs. 2,800 crore since 2017.

> **PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION**
>
> **Answer framing.**
>
> - The F-cube cannot be blamed alone — the problem also lies in the local bodies' own functionality; this is the framing the examination asks for.
> - Do not treat this as an easy, usual topic: it demands institutional detail on the State Finance Commissions, Finance Commission grants and property tax.

GS Paper 2 Current Affairs: Local Self-Government and Malnutrition

- **Break the question into keywords first** — this is the first step of answer writing, and it is the same step that demystifies the question.
- **Simplify, do not complicate** — in Hindi the question is said to be khangalna, to be torn open; the examiner is not to be examined.
- **15-marker framework**: introduction 20–30 words, body about 200 words, conclusion 20–30 words — a 15-marker means about 250 words.
- Split the body when the question has two asks — for example **100 words on the role + 100 words on the pros and cons**.
- **Diagram is a must** — make it a rule; use the pentagon of good governance pillars, or the Union–States–ULBs triangle, or the graph given for the data.
- Draw the graph or diagram wherever it was given and **use it at different places** in the answer.
- When a **comparison** is asked, **answer in a table** — pros and cons, or a President-versus-Prime Minister comparison.
- Show **what is asked first** (role, pros, cons) and give the content after; **do not temper the pros and cons**.
- With a limited word count, **no substantiation is required** — two words can be written as two

lines.

- **No forced quotes, forced sentences or forced English** — keep things as basic as possible.
- **Highest form of preparation**: a table of the issues of a topic, the steps taken against each issue, and the way forward.
- If an issue is asked, write a remembered **step in brackets** next to the issue — the issue-plus-step template.
- Use the **specific keywords of the subject**; the content of one paper can be used in another, but with that subject's keywords (for urbanization, stress urbanism).
- **Structure is the most important part** of any topic, and many questions can be answered from the structure itself.
- In the examination hall, recall **where each point came from** and pick points as per the question — the knowledge base has to be a melting pot (the khichdi idea: vegetables are poverty, salt is inequality, rice in water is inclusive growth).
- Keep the **syllabus and the PYQs always with you**; a **PYQ compilation can never be prepared** by itself — it has to be inserted into the larger syllabus of the mains and the prelims.
- Even a professional or a good student can attempt only about **17–18 of the 20 questions** — plan for that benchmark instead of aiming at all twenty.
- Follow the **current debates and all the articles** on a theme; they have to get reflected in the answer.

Malnutrition in India — Part 1

- **Introduction:** it is not necessary to reproduce the exact definition of an organisation; even a definition you frame yourself will work. Use a definitional anchor (the WHO definition was used) and then move to your own framing.
  - The introduction of this theme must itself carry the idea that malnutrition is not merely a public health problem but a challenge of social equity, human development and effective welfare governance.
- **Diagram plus substantiation:** for questions on the vicious cycle or the intergenerational cycle, draw the diagram and then substantiate it.
  - The approach is like geography — show the diagram and substantiate; give up the typical point-wise Social Justice writing for such questions.
  - If the answer does not fill 200 words even then it is not a problem, provided the diagram has made the chain clear.
- **Structural dimension:** every theme has a structural dimension, and it must be reflected in the answer even if you do not know the answer — it shows the nuance in your knowledge compared with other aspirants.
  - For anything on governance, the governance diagram and the stakeholder triangle — government, industry, civil society or citizens — must automatically appear.
- **Sequence of the answer:** introduction, then data, then causes (which double as the challenges), then the steps taken and the way forward.

  - Welfare governance gives a ready frame: counting the affected, designing or planning the scheme, and ensuring delivery to the beneficiaries.
- **Practice the two evaluated skills:** identification of keywords and structuring of the answer; write down the PYQs of the topic before starting it.

Malnutrition in India — Part 2: Consequences, Government Steps and Way Forward

- **Diagrams are the differentiator** — draw the vicious circle of the poverty trap, the nutrition-as-bridge diagram and the intersectional-approach chart, and draw as many as the question allows.
- For **International Relations** questions, use the fixed structure: the importance of any organisation is examined through **geopolitical, geostrategic and geocultural** dimensions.
- **Read the newspaper every day** — even the day before prelims and even the day before the civil services essay; the newspaper is the first level of information and cannot be evaded.
- Use **contemporary keywords** — around 25 to 30 of them, such as **Generation Z** and **FOMO** — to signal nuanced understanding to the examiner.

Malnutrition in India — Part 3: Challenges of Malnutrition

- Open your notes with the heading **Challenges of Malnutrition**, and remember that challenges, issues and concerns are the same — they are written under one heading.
- Give a **framework first**: economic, social, agri–food system, political/institutional, WASH, maternal–intergenerational and cultural/behavioural.
- Draw the diagrams — the **poverty–malnutrition trap** and **malnutrition through generations** — as they carry the reasoning.
- Place the key approaches in brackets as you write: **therefore a life cycle approach is required**, **therefore an intersectional approach is required**, **therefore to address malnutrition, female empowerment must be addressed**.
- Keep stating that a **one-size-fits-all approach cannot be there**, because states, regions and individuals differ.
- Treat causes and challenges as interchangeable — the causes of malnutrition are nothing but its challenges (100% similar).

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

- The challenges of malnutrition are also the causes of malnutrition, so the same material can be deployed for questions on causes, issues, concerns or way forward.
- Regional disparity is written as a societal challenge, a governance challenge, an economic challenge and a fragmented challenge at once.
- Crop diversification is a part of agriculture and is taken up subsequently.

Obesity in India — Part 1

- **The final argument, repeated in every class**: it is very easy to qualify the exam, but you should know what the sources are, what the discourse is, and what will come and what will not come — that requires thorough deep diving, and reaching that level takes **1.5 to 2 years** of dedicated hard work.
- Once that level is reached, one is in a **perpetual equilibrium zone** where one might not clear the civil services but will 100% clear the **state civil services**, might clear **EPFO**, and might get an **interview call** — and with an interview call there are many opportunities: one might become a good content creator or a good teacher; professionally one will not struggle, and that insecurity of salary and work should not be there.
- Rote memorisation of **PDFs, PPTs and CPTs** will not clear the exam: the primary argument is that **100-500 topics** across current affairs remain active over a **4-5 year cohort**, so those topics must have prominence in one's daily lingo, daily conversations and daily understanding, so that when a question comes in the civil services mains, in GS 1-2-3, or in the essay, the facts come out automatically.
- Memorising facts released **before the prelims and before the mains** is a stupid strategy — it is garbage, it is bombardment; one has to justify where a fact is to be written and which theme has how much importance; that table is Greek for some and Raman for others because it shows many things at once.
- In the examination hall the first art is to **open the question and break it into the parts demanded**; a **structure diagram** has to be made first, because it makes things clear.
- Train the mind so that at the exam moment one does not have to think from scratch — the **dimensions open up and the points respond automatically** because it becomes a habit; questions have to be bifurcated into **reasons, consequences and impact**.
- **Handwriting** should be very good; handwriting improvement is the biggest challenge for new aspirants.
- For the interview: in the light of the recent NFHS facts which came last year, the focus should be drawn towards **malnutrition** — why not health, why not education — because these are the statistics from **Round 5 to Round 6, increased from 24 to 30 percent**; interviews ask about **arguments**, not about looks or clothes.
- **Health advice for preparation**: staying consistent means sitting **8 hours every day for 365 days**; if you fall ill your productivity goes down the drain; there should be no back pain, and many good students have been bedridden; nutrition knowledge is needed because the **brain plays a very important role**, and the best diet for a civil services aspirant matters.
- The **500-word, 10-minute answer** on "role of globalization in promoting over-nutrition and obesity in India and the world" was set as an in-class exercise; after the class, the products that are unhealthy are to be picked up and checked for how many are high in at least two parameters.
- Source and reading advice: the interviews of officers and secretaries are also interesting because they give the latest plans; the podcast-style current-affairs listening was recommended only for enjoyment, not as an added burden.

Obesity in India — Part 2

In the examination hall, when you look at the question, the first art is to open the question and break it into the parts demanded.

- If you are able to break the question into **two, three or four parts**, you are able to decide your **word limit**.
- If you can choose **4 parts in a 15-marker**, then **50 words each — 200 words** — is enough to write.
  - That will be written automatically, optimum and effective, because you will know every subject's keywords.
- Civil services demands are coming from the **main**; the answer-writing skill is what has to be built. In prelims the paper is cut by **content**; in the main paper the paper is cut by **answer writing**.
- Questions come from a time range — about **15-20 questions** come from such areas; some questions are 2-3 years old and, as recalled, **twelve years ago there were two questions on malnutrition**.
  - Prelims current affairs after the mains is redundant as a course; play around with a lot of facts.
- **Newspaper advice**: read one newspaper daily for **30-40 minutes** and write nothing down — read it enjoying it, not as a headache. Most of the facts you remember for prelims and mains will come from newspapers.
  - Finish in **40 minutes**; an hour is acceptable too, and with practice the reading becomes much easier.
- **Health advice for preparation**: take a cup of tea without added sugar, preferably a skimmed-milk tea (simple tea is fine), or black coffee, and sit down to study.
- **Memorise in class time** — the class time of three-four days should be kept active and excited for the day, telling yourself that something new will be learnt; train your brain, because it takes time to absorb content.
- The next **two-and-a-half months, specifically till December**, are the most crucial; if one pushes **10-12 hours**, the game is set.
- Before the prelims there is a bombardment of course and crash-course advertisements with 10-day timetables — they can disturb your stability; the cure is more hard work.
- After the class, **scribble or revise the whole lecture** — see it for two minutes and revise the notes, and then there will be time to write.

Framework of IR: India's Diaspora

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Five rules for every IR answer.**
>
> - Write in **keywords**; descriptive sentences about friendship, neighbourhood, trade, diaspora or military deals carry no weight.

- Attach the prefix **strategic** wherever it fits, and read every country through the inroads of the **US and China**.
- Quote the **Prime Minister**, never authors or ambassadors.
- Discuss every country as a **full profile**, the way Belgium was discussed.
- Each topic has one keyword that must appear — identify it first.

- For any organisation question use the four dimensions: **geo-political, geo-economic, geo-cultural, geo-strategic**.
- Fix the order of treatment — for the region it is **Quad, then SCO, then ASEAN**.
- Cover both sides: what the organisation does for India, and what it means for the region.

1. Strip the label of the question — it is usually not about the organisation named.
2. Identify the concept actually being tested (e.g., maritime domain awareness).
3. Define the concept with a plain, familiar analogy.
4. Link it to the outcome claimed (e.g., maritime security).
5. Close with India's stakes and the region involved (the IOR and the Indo-Pacific).

1. **Introduction** — open with the Prime Minister's statement (pride of India, rashtradoot, living bridge) and the MEA statistics.
2. **Keywords and terms** specific to the diaspora.
3. **Importance** — for India and for the host nation, written as two dimensions.
4. **Issues** — faced by the diaspora and caused by it.
5. **Steps taken by India** — Nehru's scepticism, Vajpayee, Pravasi Bharatiya Divas, the Modi phase.
6. **Way forward.**

- Write the bracketed line wherever the Indo-Pacific or the Quad comes up: '(... are a proof of India's civilizational and geocultural importance in the Indo-Pacific and Indian Ocean region, and thereby improve India's importance in regional platforms like the Quad.)'
- For the living bridge, **draw the two-way diagram** — Indian influence on the host and the host's influence on India.
- For importance, prepare the table of benefits for India against benefits for the host nation.
- Do not step back mentally from a difficult question — defence is fine, but the points come from the content supplied in class.

KEY CONCEPT

Keywords are the marks in this topic.

- **Rashtradoot**, **India's brand ambassador**, **living bridge**, **pride**, **brain circulation**, the **4C approach**, and **NRE/NRO/FCNR (B)** — these are the terms to show, underlined, to the examiner.
- Every subject has its keywords; they must be inserted in **Papers 1, 2 and 3** — without them the marks will not come.

- Open the engagement with the line: **India's engagement with the diaspora is based on** the 4C approach — care, connect, celebrate, contribute.
- Write the importance under separate heads: the importance **for India** and the advantage **for the host country**; a write-up will be given for the host country and only that is to be followed, with layers added on the economy axis [the passage is partly garbled in the recording].
- On the banking terms: **do not go into the difference between NRE and NRO** — it is enough to show **NRE** and **NRO**; that is very important.
- On the start-up question: the Budget schemes were studied, but the question came on **challenges** — domestic and international; **MSME's challenges are the same as those of start-ups**, so they can be used.
- Write in **English only** — Hindi words are for the class, not for the answer; if the medium is changed in the examination there will be a concern.
- On a question already discussed and analysed in class: do not take stress over it, do not sit down to write a full answer for it, and do not waste sectional-test time — **optimise** [the reference is partly garbled in the recording].
- For the **living bridge**, keep the two-way framing: the diaspora carries Indian values to the host, and the host's exposure changes India.

India's Diaspora — Part 2

> **PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION**
>
> **How the diaspora question is set.**
>
> - The question on the diaspora's **importance** is a repeat favourite — the past four questions have come on importance only.
> - If the question says discuss/elucidate/explain the importance, always give the **other side** — the issues faced by and caused by the diaspora.
> - Treat 'issues faced by them' and 'issues caused by them' separately in the answer format; use the West Asia and Southeast Asia examples.

- Frame the benefits with the keyword **strategic** — read them as geopolitical, geosecurity, geocultural and geoeconomic benefits.
- For the **India-US nuclear deal**, write **2008** (approved) sometimes; sign it as signed **2005**.
- In exams write only the **Khalistani terror network** — it is a well-accepted discourse; avoid naming the Lawrence Bishnoi gang/Goldie Brar, since the intelligence is already available.
- Keep the depth of one idea per point and give both sides of every comparison.

India's Diaspora — Part 4: Answer-Writing on the Diaspora as Living Bridge, Economic Factor and Knowledge Network

KEY CONCEPT

The three-step answer method.

- Underline the **keywords** in the question.
- Build the **structure** out of the question itself.
- Then pour in the **content** — the subject's keywords and facts — under the right heads; the way you write it is your art.

- Take every head straight from the question — show the examiner only what he asks.
- Show the structure first; write nothing before the structure is built.
- For every subject there are fixed keywords and facts that must appear.

CRITICAL POINT

Directive words and balance.

- critically examine, elucidate and discuss make little practical difference; for critically examine, add two paragraphs from the opposite side.
- If pros are asked, also give cons; if cons are asked, give 80% cons and 20% pros; if both are asked, 50-50.

- Conclusion options: a **4C** conclusion, the **soft power ambassador** role, the issues raised against the diaspora, or a recent development.
- Useful recent material: **e-Migrate** for diaspora welfare and the **two-pronged approach** — schemes for welfare and schemes for safety and security.
- Practise by underlining keywords and building structures on past questions; content then comes on its own, and the word limit must be respected.

India's Diaspora — Part 3

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

How the diaspora question is set.

- Any question that tries to know the **role of the diaspora** in any country will come from the same write-up — the points remain the same, only the **examples change**.
- The **role of the diaspora in the SCO** may not be asked, but the role of the diaspora is the same as the role of the diaspora in any country.
- The write-up prepared for the topic is enough content for your **next six attempts** (for your category).
- The writing task set for the session: **'Why is India a living bridge?'**

- Write the contribution under **three heads — economy, society and politics**; for the effect of the diaspora use **effect in the polity, effect in society and effect in the economy**.

- **Diagrams are very important in the exam** — they are what you remember; draw the protection-and-welfare steps diagram and the nation-building diagram.
- **Templates are very important for the examination** — at some point you must stop absorbing content and start applying the template; that confidence comes through hard work.
- For the **way forward**, first write the step already taken by the Government of India and then the step still to be taken; you can tell the examiner the steps taken and tell the government the steps that remain.
- Use the **4C approach** as the way-forward template.
- For the **evacuation operations**, make a **mnemonic** and write it **10,000 times** — the names can be asked in the examination.
- Every topic in the Civil Services Mains syllabus has a **theoretical premise**; for GS Paper 2 it is **development processes, welfare schemes, how a scheme is made and what its difficulties are** — read and know a bit of subject value, otherwise the answer is sketchy while **depth** is what the evaluator looks for.
- **IR is static** — arguments are static unless there is a development, so the same facts and the same arguments hold, which makes engaging easy.
- A chain worth writing: Indian exporters have played a very important role in negotiating **alternative payment systems** — somewhere the diaspora has a role when two countries transact.
- Sometimes you need to **bluff** — that is not your stage right now; how to attempt a question in the hall will be dealt with later.
- For the governance framing, keep in mind **top-down vs bottom-up**, all stakeholders and the concerns of a scheme (RTE, PTAs, PTMs, school WhatsApp groups) — that is what governance questions test.

The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO)

- Different templates can be used for the same framework — there is no fixed diagram. A triangle, square, pentagon, polygon or star will all work; any shape that looks good can be drawn, but the heads of the diagram must always be highlighted.
- Define each of the four dimensions — **geopolitical, geoeconomic, geocultural and geostrategic** — and substantiate each; the difference between the four has to be clear.
- In the Civil Services Mains examination 7-8 topics are set, so for IR the conceptual knowledge and the absorption of facts and keywords has to be very clear.
- IR requires broad knowledge and can be handled freehand — unlike internal security, which needs the nuances, facts, maps and borders.
- IR is the most dependent on newspapers; quality and economy also matter, but IR is completely newspaper-driven, with thought coming from individuals every now and then.
- Watch for the optics of diplomacy — not by taking a camera, but by watching events live and imbibing how things progress.

The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) — Part 2

- This is the write-up: the examiner wants to see these keywords. This is IR, and the social-science framework of political, social and psychological will not be used for IR. By showing only **strategic, tactical, long-term, leverage, influence and strategic gain**, all these words must be shown — it will come gradually as the topics are studied.
- Study technique: read the newspaper — it is very necessary; read it, do not merely write it; read and put it into the mind; keep a pen in hand and scribble.
- The advice is to read a **hard copy**, because the font is large and does not strain the eyes, whereas reading on large language models, techniques, iPad or laptop causes eye pain; after long hours of reading, look at a long stretch in the distance and then concentrate further — this keeps the eye muscles stronger, which is very important for the examination.
- Memory technique: write a fact five times — for example, to be good with the name of the Japanese Prime Minister, **Sanae Takaichi**; Sanae is a common Japanese name; building correlations is very necessary, specifically for tough, factual optionals such as geology, zoology and botany — the tough, classic sciences — where correlation greatly helps memorisation.
- Mnemonic: the name **Tharman Shanmugaratnam** is broken into Tharman, Shan, Muga and Ratnam — Tharman through a similar-sounding name, Shan from the Shan State, Muga from muga silk, and Ratnam from mani ratnam (gem); such things become very easy.
- Proper nouns are usually not got wrong because they are written then and there — once written they are never forgotten, and if not written they are always forgotten; so these are easy facts, while the mnemonic helps with tough facts.
- Keep a pen while reading the newspaper and scribble in it, but do not make notes — do not make anyone else's notes; the notes will be given.
- For the map a framework has to be set; at this stage the classes are take-it-easy and Mains preparation is the interesting part; for the prelims, when the strings are pulled, there will be a lot of facts, which is why this is being started early — at that time absorption is very necessary.
- Every point should be given its context in brackets — for example, in the light of **deglobalization, tariff-ification by the US and supply chain vulnerabilities** — so that the context is given to the examiner.
- Whether the context can be added depends on the word limit: in a 10-marker it cannot be written, but in a complete 15-marker written in 200–220 words the context of every point can be given, creating organic coordination between the point and the reason why it is important.
- Practice: take 10 minutes and write the points on India's importance for SCO — this shows how well they can be written.
- In the examination hall, write on a piece of paper, not in the notes, and increase your writing speed as well.
- This framework is the same for other topics: the diaspora framework has been seen, and the GS2 bilateral framework will be shown later; the structure does not change.
- In IR one has to zoom in and zoom out continuously: when writing about a country, then the region, then the world; one should be ready to discuss the regional implications of BRI — the framework of the points is the same, only the points will change.

- If independent nations are asked, the same points remain: India's leadership of the Global South; India's role as the one that allows strategic autonomy; India's civilizational depth; India's multiculturalism; India's role as a strong market; India's performance in terms of low-cost scalable technology; India's role in the upcoming green transition; and India's role as a security partner — India is the first security partner and the first responder.
- Give any IR question in any examination in the world: the brain has to pick up information from different subjects and make a **khichdi** — it has to be a collation, and then, as per the need of the question, it has to be taken out and given to the examiner; that has to be the thought.
- Right now the individual heads are being covered one by one; later it becomes a mix and match, then a khichdi: at present the best grains, the best amount of water, the best amount of ghee, the best amount of ajwain and the best amount of spices are being identified individually, to make a healthy concoction for the examination.
- These pages of IR need not be revised — absorb them; it is very easy, and then it will be in the head and the pages will not have to be flipped.

The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) — Part 3

- The issue-framework is a fixed set of 5–6 points; the picture becomes far clearer once 3–4 more bodies have been covered, for instance QUAD and then BRICS.
- Summits are examples of arguments: keep the arguments fixed and insert the latest summit as the example. The notes are 100 per cent theme — next year only the example changes.
- Write in a structure — do not be random; the way forward was to be attempted in five minutes of writing.
- Keywords to show in the answer: dismantling terror; no double standards; rejection of double standards; multipolarity within the SCO; minilateralism within the SCO; leverage India's strengths — DPI, UPI and tourism.

Central Asian Republics

37.8.8 How to Present the Answer

- Different General Studies papers — Paper 1, 2 and 3 — require a different framework of keywords and a different framework of presentation.
- When the topic is announced in the evening, read the PYQs and contemplate the topic first, so that you come curious to the class; the class itself is meant for revision.
- Write the importance of Central Asia under the five heads: extended neighbourhood, civilizational connection, energy security, critical minerals and security buffer.
- If time permits, straight away write the geoeconomic importance in the introduction; otherwise place these points in the body of the answer.
- Write **complementarity** as the keyword for the strength of the India–Central Asia economic relationship.
- Write **major powers**, not "great powers".

CRITICAL POINT

Diagram Discipline.

- 2 to 3 diagrams are enough for the answer.
- Do not write exports and imports, or "market", as separate heads.
- Do not write country names as heads — write the importance against each head.
- Acceptable heads include supply chain, trade resilience, security, energy security, connectivity, trade, civilizational connect, counterterrorism, critical mineral availability and C2C cultural exchange.
- Do not write multilateralism and multipolarity for Central Asia — it is not a pole; those belong to big organisations like BRICS, Quad and SCO.

India–Nepal Relations

Answer-writing guidance given for this topic:

- **Use the language of these notes as your civil-services language.** No other source is to be picked up — no material, no PDF, no book; reading ten or twenty pages of it is irrelevant. Listen to what is said and condense it.
- **Refer to the PYQs before the class starts** — the PYQs are very important. **Keep using ChatGPT**; talk to it every now and then, because it is very important for your understanding.
- **Feel IR, and write the keywords of the subject** — the keywords discussed in class are simplified in Hindi-English and written in the proper format; absorb them.
- **Draw the polygon for every country in IR** in the examination; for Nepal the vertices are roti-beti, neighbourhood first, civilizational ties, open borders, 1,800 km of border, Himalayan strategic buffer, energy, and trade and diaspora.
- **Whenever you write on any bilateral country, automatically insert what China's presence is** there; keep China's inroads and key projects ready as factual material.
- Write the importance **horizontally in four pieces** — geopolitical, geoeconomic, geocultural and geostrategic — because that is how you will remember it.
- Cover **both sides** in the answer: strengths and opportunities, and weaknesses or concerns, both recent and traditional. 'Nepal has always been a challenge' can be written in the answers.
- Do not expect a question asking what steps have been taken to improve our relationship with Nepal — that is not asked.
- Watch for the **structural shift** framing: in the examination they may ask about the shift in India–Nepal relations, such as the new energy vertex.
- Do not name Pakistan as the reference point, and do not adopt the BRI/China framing while writing [as stated in lecture].
- One question is written in class for every topic and four or five practice questions are given for each topic — practise them all, in class and at home.

India–Nepal Relations — Part 2

- **Revise after every class**: take the week's time on a Sunday, and for the 3–4 classes taken make very short, crisp notes of **only the keywords, along with examples**.
- Those 2–3 pages are the **'one-pager'**. One-pager notes cannot be given to you — they have to be made by you for absorption; that one-pager is your entire list of India–Nepal relations.
- In **30–35 pages** the entire discussion for International Relations is wound up for the Civil Services Mains.
- It is very important to **feel the topic**; let it sink in at this stage. Events will not change much — there might be 2–3 developments here and there, but the **conceptual part remains the same**.
- **Map-drawing earns marks**: drawing the map by your own hand always gets you some more seconds and minutes; once you have drawn it (it is a comparatively easier map), keep it ready to be pasted on the east. The examiner thinks no one can make it, but once started it becomes comparatively much easier to score well in other papers too — it took about 20 minutes to make it once.
- **Do not overstress answer writing** — answer writing is very easy; the keywords have to be played with and a little content built.
- **Implications mean positive and negative** — write the question in a structured manner, from all perspectives.
- Use **AI as an assistant** — for the subject and for the doubts you have; it will make your job easier — but AI also requires refinement. Your dependence on doubt-taking and mentoring will come down, but you still have to **train your brain to understand and remember things**, and that requires time.
- Make your **own mnemonic** — remember by heart; the mnemonic arranges the points and keeps them structured.
- **Absorption needs time**: a new thing requires a continuous stretch to click — two-and-a-half hours is just to give you a feel.
- Listen to the news as well as reading it — two newspapers, plus the radio, with two-minute news bulletins on All India Radio and 15–20 minute programmes: the lingo stays in you and helps you improvise.
- Sometimes you need to **zoom out** of the preparation and think about what can be asked; too much of a zoomed-in approach makes everything look important.

India–Afghanistan Relations

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Decode the question first.**
>
> - Two-part questions must be deciphered before writing: the body is answered first, and the introduction stays short.
> - For implication questions, display the **structure** — geopolitical, geoeconomic, geocultural, geostrategic — so the examiner reads nuanced knowledge.

- **Do not quote political-science experts or thinkers by name.** Instead cite what the **Prime Minister or the Foreign Affairs Minister** has said — for instance, the recent remarks at BRICS.
- Build a **10–15 keyword lingo for every subject** — for example **global governance, multilateralism, transparency, accountability and social justice**.
- **Draw the diagram** for every framework: the three-parties-to-one diagram for Nepal, and the **polygon** for why India engages the Taliban.
- Keep a note organised around **heads** — importance, challenges, strengths and way forward — with the development points added separately from current affairs.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **Interview reuses the same arguments.**
>
> - The calibrated-engagement question is **very often asked in the interview**, and the **answer is not separate from Mains** — the same arguments apply.
> - Prepare by **framing arguments and communicating them verbally**, one-to-one, rather than only writing them.
> - Terms such as **'from isolationist to calibrated engagement'** should become part of your lingo and flow naturally in your body language.

India–Afghanistan Relations — Part 2

- The writing sequence dictated for this topic: reasons for engaging → challenges of recognition → China's engagement → table of strengths and weaknesses → way forward.
- The implications of India's recognition are to be written as the same as the challenges of recognition — the two are identical in the answer.

The National Human Rights Commission (NHRC)

- **Structure every answer in four parts**: (1) constitutional and statutory provisions, (2) importance/role with examples, (3) issues and concerns including the merger debate, (4) way forward.
- **Open with the law and the mandate**: the PHRA 1993, a statutory body, whose mandate — protection of human rights — is rooted in the Constitution. Never stop at 'it is a statutory body, full stop.'
- **Use the six principles as the analysis** in any question on the NHRC — mandate and competence, autonomy from government, pluralism, independence, adequate resources, powers of investigation.
- **Reverse those six principles** whenever the question asks for remedial measures or 'the steps you recommend'.
- **Give examples for every claim** about the role of the NHRC — notices to authorities, the demand for a report from the Chief Secretary of Delhi, prison and detention-centre visits.
- **Use the lingo of the topic**: statutory body, mandate, Paris Principles, NHRI, suo motu,

abetment, protective function, preventive and reformative role, normative base.

- **Merger question**: the points stay the same for any body — economies of scale against specialised regulation — only the example changes.
- **Target**: attempt every PYQ asked between 2013 and 2026 from this module.

Central Asian Republics — Part 2

1. In every IR answer, give the advantages **vis-à-vis the chain and vis-à-vis the west**.
2. Use the two-point algorithm — **keywords and structure**: break the question down before writing.
3. Write notes by hand; writing itself fixes the content in memory. Prepare **one-pagers in keyword form** rather than depending on ready-made ones — a ready-made one-pager restricts the knowledge set and does not make the mind exert itself.
4. **Frame and reframe** as many questions as possible (about two minutes each); too much answer-writing alone does not help.
5. Write **10-15 full-length tests**, after which the hand responds automatically and you know your word count and writing style.
6. Use **AI/ChatGPT** as a tool — supply it a prompt describing what you have studied, and let it help with keywords and framing.
7. **Read the newspaper daily (30-40 minutes)**; it is the most important part of the day, it gives connections and understanding, and it improves personality. Radio (FM Gold 100.1, FM Rainbow 106) and **News on Air** are useful add-ons.
8. Best sources: the **MEA country-wise PDFs (25-35 pages each)**, **PIB briefs**, the think tanks **ICWA**, **IDSA (Manohar Parrikar Institute for Defence Studies and Analyses)** and **ORF**, and expert columns in The Indian Express (Amitabh Mattoo) and The Hindu.
9. Analogy for writing everything down: **Eileen Gu**, a top Chinese Winter Olympics athlete (freestyle/key jumping), says she writes everything down before sleeping — that is why she can comment on anything. The same discipline of writing everything applies to preparation.

The National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) — Part 2

The lecture set out how to use this material in the examination.

> **PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION**
>
> **How these questions are framed.**
>
> - PYQs on regulatory bodies: about 15–16 questions have been asked; one question was on the **CBI** (a current development) and one on the **Lokpal** (the 2013 question, asked when the Lokpal Act had just come).
> - The question on **TBI** (2013–14) was with respect to merger only.
> - UPSC has asked: 'Discuss the structural and practical limitations that TBI has with respect to investigation of an offence.'

- If the question asks for the **functions** of the NHRC directly ('as per the Human Rights Act'),

write the first part — the functions as given in the legal document.
  - The functions are those already listed.
- If the question asks for the **role**, write the functions first, then the recent positive case studies, and finally the issues.
  - Role = the functions studied and felt on the ground; examples are the key.
  - Write as many examples as possible — bonded labour, the Transgender Act, custodial violence, and policy advocacy against wrongful deaths in judicial and police custody.
- The same template applies elsewhere: for 'discuss the role of the CBI', first write the functions as per the DSP Act, then the recent positive case studies.
- For a 'critically analyse' question, write the functions, then the positive effects, then the concerns or issues at the end.
  - For example: 'Critically analyse the functions of a teacher for the GS2 module' — first the functions, then the positive effects for a student, then the concerns.
- For 'importance', mix and match: the functions, the anecdotes and examples, the upholding of fundamental rights, and the enlarged framework of human rights.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Writing discipline.**
>
> - Know how many words you write on a page, and let your hand know when to zoom in and when to zoom out — how much to write and how much to leave out.
> - This comes only by writing answers in the copy; the brain then signals when to stop.
> - Cover three or four points and stop — neither more nor less — because every question in the paper must be attempted.

The National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) — Part 3

These are the working rules the lecture laid down for writing NHRC answers.

- Questions on the NHRC come primarily around **issues**.
- If the issue is a **one-time** or sporadic issue, you can write the **way forward**.
- In polity, **way-forward committees** usually exist — but Second ARC has said nothing on this merger, so a reasoned way forward can be framed.
- Never invent your own way forward in polity. If the question says "write the recommendations", give the **recommendation of a committee**.
- Approach every answer in three steps: **keywords** → **structure** → **content**.
- Budget roughly **10–12 minutes** for a full answer of this kind.
- Show the **functions of the body in a diagram** rather than in prose.
- Add a **connecting line** between the keyword analysis and the limitations you list ("... because of the following limitations").
- Present **structural** and **functional/practical** limitations separately.
- Write **keywords and examples** properly, and write **slowly** — a good answer takes time.

- There is no need to believe in "daily answer writing"; absorb the content and apply the framework.
- PYQ preparation follows a **cycle**: content first, then framing, then scan current affairs and generate suggested questions. A one-pager or two-pager PDF alone will not work.
- **Incremental change takes time** — improvement is built up answer by answer.

Various Commissions

- Use one **common framework** for all the commissions — there is no need to write separate answers for each of them.
- Structure the answer as: (1) **Introduction** — the details of the commissions in a table; (2) **Functions and role** of each commission — first the **merits**, then the **issues, challenges and concerns**; (3) the **steps suggested** at the end.
- Steps taken by the Government of India are **not** to be written here — they are asked under the framework of **social justice**.
- Steps taken by the commissions themselves are written under **merits**.
- The examiner asks the **broad functions**, not peripheral marketing bodies (for example TRIFED).
- Know the **five or six heads** broadly, with examples — and carry the NHRC's structural-functional logic into the issues of these commissions.
- In the social justice part, comment on the governance challenges: scheme formulation loop-holes, lack of integrated governance and civil society activism.

Health — Governance, Universal Health Coverage and Challenges

- **Structure is the first step** — it decides the dimensions of a topic; see the PYQs first, then build the structure and the content accordingly.
- **One diagram per question, every question** — it need not be the main diagram but it must show the **coordination**; every diagram should have a **box** (for example, high OOPE leading to transient poverty).
- **Way forward** means either writing all the issues or further expanding the steps; here the **latest newspaper articles** are added.
- A **uniform framework cannot be given** for the issues because each subject's demand is different — health's dimensions and framework are different; 4-5 things have to be fixed subject-wise.
- **One-pager, two-pager, three-pager** — a one-pager can be made **only when all the content is already known**; one has to make one's own one-pager, and reading a one-pager without the content behind it is impossible; for a highly conceptual topic like centre-state relations a one-pager cannot be made.
- From the class one has to take away **familiarity and prioritisation** — knowing what is to be written, how the structure is to be presented, where the diagram is to be used and where each definition fits.

- For the **essay** — connect health for all with **any security** (food, water, energy); the more **dimensions** one opens, the higher the marks; there are about **12 dimensions** in the syllabus (Paper 1: ancient, medieval, modern, environment, geography, society; Paper 2: polity, IR, governance; Paper 3: economy, disaster, climate); whoever has good GS has a great essay, and **philosophical essays test broad structural capabilities and analysis** — essay FOMO is the worst FOMO.
- **Statistics are essay statistics** — the health-expenditure figure is to be written everywhere.

Health — Part 2

Every answer of this type follows one fixed skeleton: **keywords first, then structure, then writing**.

1. **Keywords** — read the question and list its keywords (for example universal health coverage, limitation of the public sector, the private sector).
2. **Structure** — fix the structure before writing; it must be the same for every question of this type, and once fixed it should not be changed.
3. **Introduction** — two or three points in about three lines.
4. **Body** — limitations of the public sector, then the role of the private sector, then the issues with the private sector, then the alternatives (which double as the way forward).
5. **Practice** — attempt every question in this format and get the answers evaluated.

- **Word budget**
  - The body runs as 5 points of 20 words each — about 100 words for the limitations of the public sector.
  - The role of the private sector takes 90 to 100 words.
  - Within that, 70 words go to the positives and 30 words to the negatives — overpricing, the 176th Report's findings on commercialisation, and dual pricing.
  - Alternatives take about 30 words; because the question itself asks for alternatives, a separate way forward is not required.
- **Fix the length in the mind**
  - Twenty words per point, five points — the hand should know exactly how much will be written on the sheet.
  - Muscle memory has to be developed; a 15-mark answer must also express your own thoughts, not only a diagram.

1. **Template 1** — define universal health coverage and argue that it is a task requiring joint efforts: the definition of UHC is itself so large that the public sector alone cannot be depended upon.
2. **Template 2** — use the National Health Policy 2017 framing: health for all should be affordable, equitable and accessible, along with promoting and preventive care, which would lead to universal health coverage; thereby joint efforts are required. Insert the health-for-all diagram, since the question has supplied the keyword universal health coverage.

3. **Template 3** — start from the fiscal fact: India's public health expenditure is 1.5% of GDP and has to be increased to 2.5%; thereby there is a role for the private sector.
4. **Template 4** — start from the National Health Policy 2017 itself; accepted as a good start.
5. **Template 5** — start with the statement that the right to health is a fundamental right; also accepted as a good start.
6. A table in the introduction is innovative, but it must be specific — diagrams and tables must carry the facts.

- **Diagrams that can be used**
  - Limitations of the public sector can be shown as a diagram — some toppers write their answers this way.
  - The universal health coverage cube can be drawn.
  - The health-for-all diagram can be inserted.
  - The PPP diagram and the role of cooperatives can be shown.
  - Tree diagrams and flow charts are equally acceptable, as many as you wish to draw.
  - Caution: the diagram must be specific and must carry the facts; for a 15-mark answer it cannot replace your own expression of the argument.
- **Heads to use**
  - Broad heads can be used, for example financing.
  - The limitations of the public sector can be organised as: financial limitation, equity-related limitation, human resource and infrastructure, the problem of the missing middle, governance (lack of integrated governance, shown through vertical, horizontal and local involvement), and technology (limited application, AI-related concerns and the digital divide).
- **Write by hand, on paper**
  - Write by hand rather than on an iPad, so that you get the examination-hall feel — how much friction writing produces, and which pen suits you best.
  - Buy the UPSC booklet-type answer sheets; they are bulky, but writing on them gives a sense of the length of an answer.
  - Practise answer writing regularly; what is written in class should be written again by hand.
- **Report material** — take the excerpts of a report such as the 176th Report and insert them into your own structure; never lift an AI-generated summary, and always verify the figure.
- **Article quoting** — quote articles in GS2 answers and in essays; **Article 47** on public health is the one to remember here.
- The health topic is a puzzle: the answer is built out of examples, so keep collecting current-affairs examples for every point.

Various Commissions — Part 2

KEY CONCEPT

Answer Framework — Role of the Commissions.

- Divide the answer into **positive role** and **negative (limitations) role**.
- **Positive role** = the functions + **institutionalization of targeted rights protection** + **improved access** to the rights protection system.
- **Negative role** = **structural limitations** + **functional limitations**.
- Use **NHRC** as the template — if you know the role of NHRC, the same arguments apply to all other commissions.

- Keep the **vulnerability matrix** in mind — child, scheduled caste, backward class, female, etc.
  - A single complaint cannot be solved in isolation; the response must be **systematic** and requires a **long-term approach**.
- Add the **functions** to the positive role — they are part of the role of these commissions.
- Be alert to **current developments** and frame the answer around current affairs, recent committees and reports.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

PYQ Framing.

- Go back to the **PYQs** already set on this topic and frame your answers from them.
- Answer the exact question asked; the framework for the answer is the one taught for these commissions.

Health in India — Part 3: Government Steps, Way Forward and AI in Health

- **Write the steps by hand.** The steps were to be given as a two-three page PDF table, but since these classes are being taken for the first time the trajectory is to be followed and written out yourself.
- **Numbers matter.** Be very familiar with the numbers: the bigger the budgetary spending of a ministry, the greater the stature of the officer who heads it. The budget is a very important document for pre and mains and it has to be **felt**, not merely watched.
- **Quote the policies again and again** — NHP 2017 provides the vision of health for all and has to be quoted repeatedly.
- **Bracket the exam signal.** Where a point answers a PYQ, write it in brackets in the answer: the regional medical hub is to be written as the alternative solution as asked in the PYQ, and the U-WIN and Poshan Tracker integration as an example of good integration of data sets.
- **Cross-connections.** The mind must connect articles with topics: old-age residential systems link geriatrics, the care economy and female labour force participation; and the impact of globalisation on a sector is the same as the impact of urbanisation on it, which is a Paper 1 theme.
- **Examples, more and more of them.** Everything said in the class is an example and not an

essay — the lifestyle and health culture of the cities (gym, hybrid workouts, hot yoga, fast yoga, Pilates, running clubs, marathons) are globalisation and urbanisation examples, and examples have to be quoted in Paper 1.

- **Demystify the answer for the examiner** with diagrams — for example the diagram of what exactly health for all means, and the diagrams the lecture asked to be drawn alongside the thematic points.

Health — Part 4

- AI cannot replace putting content into your own head — that needs **writing and by-hearting**, and it cannot be replaced in the Civil Services examination.
- Practise a **digital detox**: 30–40 minutes of writing/journaling every day keeps the brain intact.
- Before prompting an AI, first build your own **framework** of the topic in your head; then give the prompt.
- Content must be **precise and as per the exam**; knowing how to play with that content is the key.
- Use AI-based quizzes and test series for **self-evaluation**.

Regulatory Bodies

- **Structure the topic and the answer in four to five heads**: define the regulator, why regulators are required, the reasons for independence and autonomy, the issues or challenges, and the way forward.
- **The need for independence and autonomy is answered by the same points as the need for regulators** — prevention of politicisation, a level playing field, prevention of monopoly and upholding consumer interest.
- **Begin with the keywords of the question**: desired objectives, independent, autonomous, regulatory institutions.
- **Format**: an introduction of **20 to 30 words**, a body of numbered points and a conclusion; the answer runs to about **200 words**, and the need for independence and autonomy is the main question.
- **Model introduction**: the role of regulators, which are public entities framing rules and regulations for a sector, has significantly enlarged post **1991**, creating the need for independence and autonomy.
- **Do not define regulators** — club two or three sentences into the introduction rather than writing only one.
- **A diagram** of independence and autonomy may be drawn — statutory existence, tenure, terms, conditions and salary with appointment and removal by the statute on one side, and administrative, financial, personal and decisional autonomy on the other.
  - But the diagram was **not relevant enough**, and a diagram showing **evolution** was not needed at all; writing the definition was enough.
- **All the body points are relevant** — none of them can be skipped; if a small example is

forgotten it can be adjusted.

- **10-marker versus 15-marker**: the main body remains the same. In a **10-marker**, write one or two lines of introduction and put all the **150 words** straight as body points; in a **15-marker** there is the liberty of a proper introduction and a one-line conclusion.
- Whichever the marks, the **concept and the algorithm** of writing the answer stay the same; in class the answer was to be written in **11 minutes**.
- For the **post-LPG sectoral-regulator question**, take the examiner back to the **1991** framework again and again, with examples.
- In **commission answers**, mention the sectoral regulators — **TRAI, PFRDA, IRDA** — as examples of different types of products.
- **Challenges and way forward** for the regulators have to be written yourself and will be discussed in the next class; practise answers with **ChatGPT**.

India–Bangladesh Relations

- **India's foreign policy as a theme is not important** — no separate question will be asked on the theme; only a **broad observation** of India's foreign policy is required.
- India's foreign policy in the present times is to be written in the **Way Forward**, when the great powers are taken up.
- The **theoretical premise** of India's foreign policy need not be read separately — it is slightly non-required, and is anyway discussed in all the topics; read it **topic-wise**, which is more segmented and gives greater clarity than studying foreign policy together.
- Write the **keywords** in the **Importance** section.
- Show the **party-wise phase graph** — BNP, Awami League, interim government, BNP — in the template: the historical baggage tells you where the direction is headed.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **Precision, not speculation.**
>
> - Stick to the **requirement of the topic**.
> - Give **substantiation** for the involvement of China or Pakistan, so that the answer is precise.
> - We cannot be **speculative** in the class, but in the discussion the answer has to be written on that basis.